

Models *for* Writers

FOURTEENTH
EDITION

Short Essays for Composition

Alfred Rosa



Paul Eschholz



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Description

This is a sample content for Long ALT text



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- Built-in assignments support the book's approach.
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Be the writer you want to be.

A note about the cover

Models for Writers uses paper cranes as a symbol of the writing process, where analyzing models and applying the right strategies can produce successful—and stylish—results.

Description

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Models for Writers
Short Essays for Composition

FOURTEENTH EDITION

Alfred Rosa

Paul Eschholz

University of Vermont



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Preface

Models for Writers, now in its fourteenth edition, continues to offer students and instructors brief, accessible, high-interest models of rhetorical elements, principles, and patterns. As important as it is for students to read while they are learning to write college-level essays, *Models for Writers* offers more than a collection of essays. Through the abundant study materials that accompany each selection, students master the writing skills they will need for all their college classes. Writing activities and assignments give students the chance to stitch together the various rhetorical elements into coherent, forceful essays of their own. This approach, which has helped over five million students become better writers, remains at the heart of the book.

In this edition, we continue to emphasize the classic features of *Models for Writers* that have won praise from teachers and students alike. In addition, we have strengthened the book by introducing new selections and new perspectives, and we have emphasized the student voices that resound throughout the book. This edition is also available with Achieve, Bedford/St. Martin's new online course space with writing tools that support students through multiple

drafts as well as the full interactive e-book, LearningCurve adaptive quizzing, and reading comprehension quizzes.

FAVORITE FEATURES OF *MODELS FOR WRITERS*

- **Brief, lively readings that provide outstanding models.**
Most of the sixty-seven professional selections and all four of the sample student essays in *Models for Writers* are comparable in length (two to four pages) to the essays students will write themselves, and each clearly illustrates a basic rhetorical element, principle, or pattern. Just as important, the essays deal with subjects that we know from our own teaching experience will spark the interest of most college students. In addition, the range of voices, cultural perspectives, and styles represented in the essays will resonate with today's students. They will both enjoy and benefit from reading and writing about selections by many well-known authors, including Judith Ortiz Cofer, Stephen King, Amy Tan, Maya Angelou, David Sedaris, Langston Hughes, Bharati Mukherjee, Mary Sherry, and Martin Luther King Jr.
- **Introductory chapters on reading and writing.**
Throughout the chapters in [Part One](#), students review the writing process from fresh angles and learn how to use the essays they read to improve their own writing. [Chapter 1](#), "The Writing Process," details the steps in the writing process and illustrates them with a student essay in progress. A dedicated section on thesis statements, *Develop Your Thesis*, includes a clear five-step process to help students through the challenge of

arriving at an effective thesis statement from a broad topic. The chapter also includes a student essay that shows a student's writing process in action, from brainstorming a topic to the final essay. [Chapter 2](#),

"Reading Actively and Critically," shows students how to use the apparatus in the text and provides them with guidelines for critical reading, with expanded coverage of key topics like evaluating the strength of an author's evidence and identifying signs of bias. A contemporary essay by journalist Celeste Headlee serves as a model to guide students through a step-by-step process of reading actively and critically. Finally, a student essay shows how they can generate their own writing from reading.

- **An easy-to-follow rhetorical organization.** Each of the twenty rhetorically based chapters in *Models for Writers* is devoted to a particular element or pattern important to college writing. [Chapters 3](#) through [10](#) focus on the concepts of thesis, unity, organization, beginnings and endings, paragraphs, transitions, effective sentences, and writing with sources. A new [Chapter 11](#) introduces the concept of an author's voice, while [Chapter 12](#) illustrates the importance of controlling diction and tone, and [Chapter 13](#) explains the uses of figurative language. [Chapters 14](#) through [22](#) explore the types of writing most often required of college students: illustration, narration, description, process analysis,

definition, division and classification, comparison and contrast, cause and effect, and argument.

- **Flexible arrangement.** Each chapter is self-contained so that instructors can easily follow their own teaching sequences, omitting or emphasizing certain chapters according to the needs of their students or the requirements of the course.
- **Abundant study materials.** To help students use the readings to improve their writing, every essay is accompanied by ample study materials.

Reflecting on What You Know activities precede each reading and prompt students to explore their own ideas and experiences regarding the issues presented in the reading.

Questions for Study and Discussion focus on the selection's content, the author's purpose, and the particular strategy the author used to achieve that purpose. To remind students that good writing is never one-dimensional, at least one question in each series focuses on a writing concern other than the one highlighted in the chapter.

Questions for Critical Reading encourage students to go deeper in considering the writer's assumptions, making connections not readily apparent, and exploring the broader implications of the selection.

Classroom Activities provide brief exercises that enable students to work (often in groups) on rhetorical elements, techniques, or patterns. These activities range from developing thesis statements to using strong action verbs and building argumentative evidence, and they encourage students to apply concepts modeled in the readings to their own writing. Several activities throughout the book also provide students with examples of career-related writing to demonstrate that critical reading, writing, and thinking skills are crucial beyond the college classroom. Several new activities invite students to employ different learning strategies and understand a concept through movement, visuals, or other hands-on and collaborative practice.

Suggested Writing Assignments provide two writing assignments for each essay, encouraging students to use the reading selection as a direct model, asking them to respond to the content of the reading, or expanding the selection topic to include their personal experience or outside research.

- **Concise and interesting chapter introductions.** Writing instructors who use *Models for Writers* continue to be generous in their praise for the brief, clear, practical, and student-friendly chapter introductions that explain the various elements and patterns. In each introduction,

students will find illuminating examples — many written by students — of the feature or principle under discussion.

- **Practical instruction on working with sources.** One of the biggest challenges student writers face is incorporating supporting evidence from other writers into their essays. In [Chapter 1](#), “The Writing Process,” students find clear advice on developing strong thesis statements and marshaling evidence and support. [Chapter 10](#) models strategies for taking effective notes from sources; using signal phrases to integrate quotations, summaries, and paraphrases smoothly; synthesizing sources; and avoiding plagiarism. Further reviewing the steps and skills involved in research and synthesis, [Chapter 23](#), “A Brief Guide to Writing a Research Paper,” provides one full-length MLA-style model student research paper and the cover sheet, first page, and list of references for one APA-style model student research paper (the entire paper is offered online in Achieve). Thus, students become more confident in joining academic conversations and in writing the kinds of essays that they will be called on to write in their college courses.
- **Targeted instruction on sentence grammar.** [Chapter 24](#), “Editing for Grammar, Punctuation, and Sentence Style,” addresses editing concerns that instructors across the country have identified as the most problematic for their students, such as run-on sentences, verb tense shifts, comma splices, sentence fragments, and dangling and

misplaced modifiers. Brief explanations and hand-edited examples show students how to find and correct these common errors in their own writing. Also available in this new edition are a host of online tutorials and self-paced, adaptive activities for further practice with grammatical and mechanical concepts.

- **An alternative table of contents showing thematic clusters.** The alternative table of contents ([pp. xxix - xxxiv](#)) groups readings into twenty-four clusters, each with three to eight essays sharing a common theme. Students and instructors attracted to the theme of one essay in *Models for Writers* can consult this alternative table of contents to find other essays in the book that address the same theme.
- **Glossary of Useful Terms.** Cross-referenced in many of the questions and writing assignments throughout the book, this list of key terms defines rhetorical and literary terms that student writers need to know. Terms that are explained in the Glossary ([pp. 642 - 53](#)) are shown in boldface the first time they appear in a chapter.

NEW TO THE FOURTEENTH EDITION OF *MODELS FOR WRITERS*

- Engaging, informative, and diverse new readings.

Twenty-four of the book's sixty-seven professional readings are new to this edition of *Models for Writers* — ideal models by both new and established writers. We selected these essays for their brevity and clarity, for their effectiveness as models, and for their potential to develop critical thinking and writing on interesting and relevant topics. Among the new readings are Tara Westover's "Pygmalion," Sarah Smarsh's "Heartland," Farhad Manjoo's "It's Time for 'They,'" Brené Brown's "What Is Shame?," and Brooklyn White's "A Pleasure to Burn: One Family's Hot-Sauce Heirloom."

- More attention to critical reading. [Chapter 2](#),

"Reading Actively and Critically," has been extensively revised in response to feedback from instructors. The chapter now features a new contemporary essay by journalist Celeste Headlee, which provides the foundation for a discussion of critical reading topics like identifying an author's thesis and purpose, evaluating the strength of evidence, identifying tone, assumptions, and biases, and more. The chapter's new organization presents reading as a two-step process: first, students read actively to get a basic understanding of what an author is saying; then they read critically to draw deeper connections. Furthermore, the study questions that

follow each reading throughout the book have been reorganized so that five *Questions for Study and Discussion* are followed by three *Questions for Critical Reading* — a new study sequence that supports the way that instructors teach reading.

- **A new chapter on voice.** [Chapter 11](#) explains the significance and power of finding one's voice, which we define as the writer's personality as expressed on the written page. The chapter offers examples of compelling voices in professional writing, as well as helpful advice for student writers seeking to discover and express their own voices. The chapter includes three full reading selections, including two that are new to this edition.
- **Compelling new examples of argument.** [Chapter 22](#), "Argument," features two timely new thematic casebooks, each with three new full reading selections. The three authors in the first casebook, "Is College Worth the Cost?", examine the problem of rising higher education fees and debate whether college is still worth the financial investment. In the second casebook, "How Real Is the Automation Threat?", three authors consider the recent trend of jobs lost to automation and offer differing perspectives on the severity of the crisis and possible solutions.
- **Updated APA coverage.** The coverage of APA-style citation and documentation in [Chapter 23](#), "A Brief Guide to Writing a Research Paper," aligns formatting and

citation examples with the 2019 American Psychological Association guidelines.

- **Achieve with *Models for Writers*.** Achieve, Macmillan's customizable online course space, includes writing tools that keep writing and revision at the core of your course, facilitating instructor feedback and peer review through multiple drafts. In addition to writing tools, Achieve also includes the full interactive e-book version of the text, LearningCurve adaptive quizzing, and auto-scored reading comprehension quizzes.

BEDFORD/ST. MARTIN' S PUTS YOU FIRST

From day one, our goal has been simple: to provide inspiring resources that are grounded in best practices for teaching reading and writing. For more than 35 years, Bedford/St. Martin' s has partnered with the field, listening to teachers, scholars, and students about the support writers need. We are committed to helping every writing instructor make the most of our resources.

How can we help *you*?

- Our editors can align our resources to your outcomes through correlation and transition guides for your syllabus. Just ask us.
- Our sales representatives specialize in helping you find the right materials to support your course goals.
- Our learning solutions and product specialists help you make the most of the digital resources you choose for your course.
- Our *Bits* blog on the Bedford/St. Martin' s English Community (community.macmillan.com) publishes fresh teaching ideas weekly. You' ll also find easily downloadable professional resources and links to author webinars on our community site.

Contact your Bedford/St. Martin's sales representative or visit macmillanlearning.com to learn more.

Print and Digital Options for *Models for Writers*

Choose the format that works best for your course, and ask about our packaging options that offer savings for students.

PRINT

- *Paperback*. To order the paperback edition, use ISBN 978-1-319-21472-2. To order the paperback edition packaged with Achieve, use ISBN 978-1-319-37648-2.
- *Loose-leaf edition*. This format does not have a traditional binding; its pages are loose and hole punched to provide flexibility and a lower price to students. It can be packaged with Achieve for additional savings. To order the loose-leaf packaged with Achieve, use ISBN 978-1-319-37591-1.
- *Student's Companion for Models for Writers*. This guide offers additional support for students in ALP or co-requisite courses and helps beginning college writers develop on-level skills. Coverage includes time management, writing activities for each organizational pattern in [Part Three](#) of *Models for Writers*, sentence guides, and additional grammar help. To order the

Student's Companion packaged with the paperback edition of *Models for Writers*, use ISBN 978-1-319-37593-5.

DIGITAL

- *Achieve with Models for Writers*. Achieve puts student writing at the center of your course and keeps revision at the core, with a dedicated composition space that guides students through drafting, peer review, source check, reflection, and revision. Developed to support best practices in commenting on student drafts, Achieve is a flexible, integrated suite of tools for designing and facilitating writing assignments, paired with actionable insights that make students' progress towards outcomes clear and measurable. Fully editable pre-built assignments support the book's approach and an e-book is included. For details, visit macmillanlearning.com/college/us/englishdigital.
- *Popular e-book formats*. For details about our e-book partners, visit macmillanlearning.com/ebooks.
- *Inclusive Access*. Enable every student to receive their course materials through your LMS on the first day of class. Macmillan Learning's Inclusive Access program is the easiest, most affordable way to ensure all students have access to quality educational resources. Find out more at macmillanlearning.com/inclusiveaccess.

Your Course, Your Way

No two writing programs or classrooms are exactly alike. Our Curriculum Solutions team works with you to design custom options that provide the resources your students need.

(Options below require enrollment minimums.)

- *ForeWords for English*. Customize any print resource to fit the focus of your course or program by choosing from a range of prepared topics, such as Sentence Guides for Academic Writers.
- *Macmillan Author Program (MAP)*. Add excerpts or package acclaimed works from Macmillan's trade imprints to connect students with prominent authors and public conversations. A list of popular examples or academic themes is available upon request.
- *Mix and Match*. With our simplest solution, you can add up to 50 pages of curated content to your Bedford/St. Martin's text. Contact your sales representative for additional details.
- *Bedford Select*. Build your own print anthology from a database of more than 800 selections, or build a handbook, and add your own materials to create your ideal text. Package with any Bedford/St. Martin's text for additional savings. Visit macmillanlearning.com/bedfordselect.

Instructor Resources

You have a lot to do in your course. We want to make it easy for you to find the support you need — and to get it quickly.

The *Instructor's Edition of Models for Writers* (ISBN 978-1-319-30429-4) includes the *Instructor's Manual* printed in the back of the book. The *Instructor's Manual* is also available as a PDF that can be downloaded from macmillanlearning.com and from Achieve. In addition to teaching tips and overviews of each reading in *Models for Writers*, the *Instructor's Manual* includes sample syllabi, tips for using the Classroom Activities in the book, and example answers to all Questions for Study and Discussion and Questions for Critical Reading.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

In response to the many thoughtful reviews from instructors who use this book, we have maintained the solid foundation of the previous edition of *Models for Writers* while adding fresh readings and writing topics to stimulate today's student writers.

We are indebted to many people for their advice as we prepared this fourteenth edition. We are especially grateful to our reviewers: Cristina Axtell, Saddleback College; Lisa Bamber, Otero Junior College; Lesley Blake, Cerritos College; Deborah Bloom, Kirkwood Community College; Mike Bove, Southern Maine Community College; Ashlee Brand, Cuyahoga Community College; Roberta Brown, Western New Mexico University; Cheryl Cardoza, Truckee Meadows Community College; Joseph Castrogiovanni, Suffolk County Community College; Tammy Davis, Northern Oklahoma College; Stacey Frazier, Northern Oklahoma College; Sara Fuller, Cuyahoga Community College; Ashley Gipp, Glendale Community College; Jacqueline Gray, St. Charles Community College; Kent Harrelson, Dalton State College; Jason Horn, Gordon State College; Kimi Kelley, Otero Junior College; Denise Lagos, Union County College; Mary McGlone, Suffolk County Community College; Mark McGuire-Schwartz, Housatonic Community College; Nathan McQueen, American River College; Phillip Mitchell,

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It has been our good fortune to have the editorial guidance and good cheer of Will Stonefield, our development editor on this book; Samantha Storms, editorial assistant; and Paola García-Muñiz, assistant editor. We have also benefited from the great contributions to this edition by Elizabeth Catanese, Community College of Philadelphia; Amy Havel, Southern Maine Community College; Jean Mittelstaedt, Chemeketa Community College; Angelina Oberdan, Central Piedmont Community College; Jeff Ousborne; and Robert Vettese, Southern Maine Community College. We are grateful to the careful eye of Pamela Lawson, our content project manager, and the rest of the excellent team at Bedford/St. Martin's — Leasa Burton, Stacey Purviance, John Sullivan, and Joy Fisher Williams — as we planned, developed, and wrote this new edition. Our special thanks go to the late Tom Broadbent — our mentor and original editor at St. Martin's Press — who helped us breathe life and soul into *Models for Writers* in its earliest editions. The lessons that he shared

with us during our fifteen-year partnership have stayed with us throughout our careers.

Our greatest debt is, as always, to our students — especially Jake Jamieson and Zoe Ockenga, whose papers appear in this text — for all they have taught us over the years. Finally, we thank each other, partners in this writing and teaching venture for fifty years.

Alfred Rosa

Paul Eschholz

COUNCIL OF WRITING PROGRAM ADMINISTRATORS (WPA) OUTCOMES STATEMENT FOR FIRST-YEAR COMPOSITION

In 2014 the Council of Writing Program Administrators updated its desired outcomes for first-year composition courses. The following chart provides detailed information on how *Models for Writers* helps students build proficiency and achieve the learning outcomes that writing programs across the country use to assess their students' work: rhetorical knowledge; critical thinking, reading, and writing; writing processes; and knowledge of conventions.

WPA Outcomes Relevant Features of <i>Models for Writers</i> , 14th ed.	
RHETORICAL KNOWLEDGE	
Learn and use key rhetorical concepts through analyzing and composing a variety of texts	- The organization of <i>Models for Writers</i> supports students' understanding of rhetorical strategy. Part Two (Chs. 3 - 10) focuses on elements of the essay; Part Three (Chs. 11 - 13) highlights the language and style of the essay; Part Four (Chs. 14 - 22) explores the different writing strategies most often required of college students. Concise and practical chapter introductions explain how the elements and strategies suit authors' purposes. Chapter 1 shows students how to identify their audience (p. 18) and introduces them to purpose through an understanding of rhetorical methods of development (pp. 18 - 21).

	• In Chapter 2, students learn how to understand context through headnotes and how to read rhetorically and read as a writer, analyzing and evaluating texts according to their rhetorical purpose. • Dedicated boxes such as Audience Questions (p. 18) and Questions for Revising (p. 25) provide additional support for analyzing and composing texts. • Questions for Study and Discussion and Questions for Critical Reading following each reading focus on the author's purpose and the particular strategy used to achieve that purpose. • Suggested Writing Assignments following each reading prompt students to write using the rhetorical element or strategy focused on in that chapter. • A dedicated section in Chapter 22, Argument, asks students to Consider Ethos, Logos, and Pathos (pp. 522 - 24).
Gain experience reading and composing in several genres to understand how genre conventions shape and are shaped by readers' and writers' practices and purposes	• The sixty-seven professional readings in the book span a variety of topics, disciplines, and genres. Part Three is organized by rhetorical pattern, with three reading options per chapter to give students experience and practice. • Each reading selection features a robust apparatus that gives students practice analyzing and writing for a variety of purposes and in a range of styles. In addition to Questions for Study and Discussion, Questions for Critical Reading, and Suggested Writing Assignments (see above), Classroom Activities provide opportunities for applied learning with exercises that enable students to work (often in groups) on rhetorical elements, techniques, or patterns. Several activities connect rhetorical strategies to real-world genres such as application letters and memos.
Develop facility in responding to a variety of situations and contexts calling	• Chapter introductions explain how each rhetorical element and strategy is used to achieve an author's purpose. • Part Two (Chs. 3 - 10) emphasizes the Elements of the Essay, with dedicated chapters and model professional readings

for purposeful shifts in voice, tone, level of formality, design, medium, and/or structure	focused on organized writing: Thesis, Unity, Organization, Beginnings and Endings, Paragraphs, Transitions, Effective Sentences, and Writing with Sources. • Part Three (Chs. 11 - 13) emphasizes the Language of the Essay, with chapters dedicated to Voice, Diction/Tone, and Figurative Language. • While most essays and instruction highlight the writer's chosen organization, students are introduced to the importance of structure in the section Map Your Organization in Chapter 1 (p. 21). Chapter 5, Organization, focuses especially on essay structure.
Understand and use a variety of technologies to address a range of audiences	• Several of the Classroom Activities encourage students to engage other learning styles and use other technologies, from drawing on paper to creating storyboards. • The book's Achieve online platform invites students to interact with the readings in a digital environment with writing tools based on leading scholars' work on writer development. Online tutorials on important writing concepts help students learn through interaction. In addition, adaptive, game-like LearningCurve quizzing allows students to practice reading and writing skills.
Match the capacities of different environments (e.g., print and electronic) to varying rhetorical situations	• Research coverage in Chapter 10 and Chapter 23 gives instructions specific to research and project planning, from taking notes to finding and evaluating sources, in both print and online spaces. • See also the previous WPA Outcomes section, "Understand and use a variety of technologies to address a range of audiences."
CRITICAL THINKING, READING, AND COMPOSING	
Use composing and reading for inquiry,	• Chapter 1, The Writing Process, presents writing as inquiry, as a tool for gathering ideas and exploring topics.

learning, critical thinking, and communicating in various rhetorical contexts	• Chapter 2, Reading Actively and Critically, gives students tools to read critically and learn to read as a writer; students learn to understand the rhetorical context and the writer's choices in order to apply those tools to their own writing. • Questions for Study and Discussion, Questions for Critical Reading, and Suggested Writing Assignments encourage students to write to learn through small-stakes journal or homework writing or full essays appropriate to the rhetorical strategy of the chapter.
Read a diverse range of texts, attending especially to relationships between assertion and evidence, to patterns of organization, to the interplay between verbal and nonverbal elements, and to how these features function for different audiences and situations	• A lively collection of sixty-seven brief classic and contemporary essays provide outstanding models for students. Each selection has been carefully chosen to engage students and to clearly illustrate a basic rhetorical element or pattern at work in the chapter. • Thematic clusters (pp. xxix - xxxiv) offer flexibility, grouping readings by topic so students can use the selection in the book to collect and analyze information on their subject of choice. Themes include The American Dream, The Immigrant Experience, The Natural World, Social Issues and Activism, and Technology, among others. • The visual essay "On a Plate" by Toby Morris (pp. 472 - 76) encourages students to analyze the relationship between visual and verbal elements. • Chapter 22, Argument, provides thorough coverage of making and supporting claims.
Locate and evaluate (for credibility, sufficiency, accuracy, timeliness, bias, and so on) primary and secondary research materials, including	<i>Models for Writers</i> offers practical instruction on working with sources to guide students in one of their biggest writing challenges: incorporating supporting evidence from other writers into their essays. • Chapter 1, The Writing Process, offers students clear advice and steps for

journal articles and essays, books, scholarly and professionally established and maintained databases or archives, and informal electronic networks and internet sources	developing strong thesis statements and marshaling evidence and support. • Chapter 10, Writing with Sources, and Chapter 23, A Brief Guide to Writing a Research Paper, review the steps and skills involved in research and synthesis, with dedicated sections on Finding and Using Sources (p. 593), Evaluating Sources (p. 595), and Analyzing Sources for Position and Bias (p. 597). Chapter 23 includes model MLA- and APA-style research papers and models for citations. • Helpful charts in Chapter 23 make useful reference tools; see, for example, Refining Keyword Searches (p. 594) and Strategies for Evaluating Sources (p. 595).
Use strategies — such as interpretation, synthesis, response, critique, and design/redesign — to compose texts that integrate the writer’s ideas with those from appropriate sources	• The questions and prompts that accompany each reading ask students to interpret, respond, and critique the reading and the writer’s choices, engaging in academic conversation. • Chapter 10, Writing with Sources, models strategies for taking effective notes from sources; using signal phrases to integrate quotations, summaries, and paraphrases smoothly; synthesizing sources; and avoiding plagiarism. • The Checklist for Analyzing a Writer’s Position and Bias (p. 598) in Chapter 23 urges students to analyze writers’ purposes and assumptions as they incorporate outside sources into their own writing. • See also the previous WPA Outcomes section, “Locate and evaluate...”
PROCESSES	
Develop a writing project through multiple drafts	• Chapter 1, The Writing Process, leads students from Prewriting through Drafting, Revising, Editing, and Proofreading to present a final draft. See, especially, Choose a Subject Area and Focus on a Topic (p. 9), Get Ideas and Collect Information (p. 10), and the step-by-step process in Develop Your Thesis (p. 12).

	• Chapter 24, Editing for Grammar, Punctuation, and Sentence Style, provides sound advice, examples, and solutions for the editing problems that trouble students most. • Achieve with <i>Models for Writers</i> contains writing tools that support students and instructors through multiple drafts of revision.
Develop flexible strategies for reading, drafting, reviewing, collaborating, revising, rewriting, rereading, and editing	• In Chapter 1, a sample student essay by Mya Nunnally (pp. 27 - 36) illustrates one student's choices during the process for each stage of the writing process. • Most Classroom Activities that accompany each reading encourage students to work collaboratively to understand and apply rhetorical concepts and strategies in writing or other exploratory methods.
Use composing processes and tools as a means to discover and reconsider ideas	As part of the instruction on the writing process, Chapter 1 includes dedicated sections to help students brainstorm and prewrite with notes, clustering, and outlining: Choose a Subject Area and Focus on a Topic (p. 9) and Get Ideas and Collect Information (p. 10).
Experience the collaborative and social aspects of writing processes	• The Reflecting on What You Know prompts that immediately precede each reading selection, can be used for group discussion and writing. • The Classroom Activities that accompany each reading frequently ask students to share their writing and ideas with their classmates and discuss them, learning from each other.
Learn to give and to act on productive feedback to works in progress	• Dedicated boxes in Chapter 1, such as Questions for Revising (p. 25), guide students through the writing process and assist in peer revision workshops. • Achieve with <i>Models for Writers</i> offers robust peer review tools that empower

	students to seek and offer feedback to each other.
Adapt composing processes for a variety of technologies and modalities	• The book assumes that most students compose in digital spaces, and instructions in a number of Suggested Writing Assignments and other prompts reflect and encourage this use of the digital space. • Instructions for research and collecting notes on sources in Chapter 10 and Chapter 23 assume that students are working mostly online and with technology, so the advice offers strategies for collecting and managing data in digital formats. • Achieve with <i>Models for Writers</i> offers a digital course space with writing tools that support student writers across multiple drafts, as well as an interactive e-book, LearningCurve adaptive quizzing, integrated digital tutorials, and more.
Reflect on the development of composing practices and how those practices influence their work	• Reflecting on What You Know prompts before each reading ask students to discover and apply their prior knowledge to the reading selection. • Achieve with <i>Models for Writers</i> presents students with customizable reflection questions as they submit each draft of a writing assignment, encouraging them to consider their writing process.
KNOWLEDGE OF CONVENTIONS	
Develop knowledge of linguistic structures, including grammar, punctuation, and spelling, through practice in composing and revising	• A dedicated Part Three focuses particularly on the Language of the Essay, drawing students' attention to the rhetorical effectiveness of diction, tone, and figurative language. • Chapters in Part Two, The Elements of the Essay, emphasize the importance of linguistic structure at various levels of the essay, including Transitions (Ch. 8) and Effective Sentences (Ch. 9). • Chapter 24, Editing for Grammar, Punctuation, and Sentence Style, covers common grammar and mechanical errors and presents clear examples of corrections to help students write with minimal errors.

	Coverage includes run-ons and comma splices, sentence fragments, subject-verb agreement, pronoun-antecedent agreement, verb tense shifts, misplaced and dangling modifiers, faulty parallelism, weak nouns and verbs, and academic diction and tone. • In the Achieve, LearningCurve adaptive quizzing on common grammar, mechanics, and writing topics lead students to online self-guided practice that lets them learn at their own pace.
Understand why genre conventions for structure, paragraphing, tone, and mechanics vary	• Chapter introductions for each rhetorical element in Parts Two and Three and for each rhetorical pattern in Part Four explain how each strategy serves a writer's purpose. • Dedicated chapters on Paragraphs (Ch. 7), Tone (Ch. 12), and Mechanics (Ch. 24) further emphasize rhetorical importance and variation.
Gain experience negotiating variations in genre conventions	In addition to the support in chapter introductions mentioned above, the Classroom Activities and Suggested Writing Assignments following each reading selection encourage students to apply the rhetorical strategies to real-world genres and situations and to use them in their writing.
Learn common formats and/or design features for different kinds of texts	Model student essays in Chapters 1 and 2 are presented in MLA format. Chapter 23 features fully formatted examples of MLA- and APA-style student research papers, with annotations highlighting the genre design conventions.
Explore the concepts of intellectual property (such as fair use and copyright)	• Chapter 10, Writing with Sources, explains why outside sources are rhetorically useful and how doing so requires thoughtful documentation when

that motivate documentation conventions	integrating a quotation, paraphrase, or summary. • A dedicated section, Avoid Plagiarism (p. 235), further defines and explores these concepts.
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Introduction for Students

Students and teachers often agree that it is important to write well, and it is not hard to figure out why. Knowing how to write well is stressed at every rung of the educational ladder — from the early grades, through middle school, high school, and college. “You need to know how to write.” This idea, often a command, has become an educational cliché, a truth so often uttered and so seemingly apparent that few people feel the need to offer any explanation for it. As the authors of *Models for Writers*, however, we feel a special obligation to offer reasons for learning to write and for doing it well. It’s simple. We always learn better if we understand what and why we are learning.

No activity better develops your ability to think than writing does. Writing allows you to express what’s on your mind, to examine your thoughts, and to “see” objectively what you think. When you write thoughtfully and clearly, others can better understand you. Better yet, you can know yourself better. One way of thinking about writing, then, is to see it as holding a mirror up to yourself.

Writing, unlike speaking, is usually more deliberate and allows you to examine your ideas carefully and critically by reading what you have written as you compose sentences. It’s

not a one-way street but an interactive process. The process of reading what you have written and then revising and refocusing what you think gives you many opportunities to improve, clarify, and best express what you want to say. At some point in the process, when you are satisfied with your thinking, you can freeze the best expression of your thoughts, for that moment at least. And that moment can be an immensely satisfying one. When you can say about what you've written, "That's exactly what I mean," you will have brought order out of chaos and certainty where none seemed possible before. No other activity can do as much for developing your critical and intellectual abilities as writing.

It should not come as a surprise, then, that employers in every field are looking for people who can read and write well, for all these reasons. Simply put, employers want to hire and retain the best minds they can to reach their business objectives, and the ability to read and write well is a clear indication of a rigorous mind. In today's workplace, there is virtually no field that doesn't require clear, accurate, and direct expression in writing, whether it be writing cover letters and résumés, internal emails, self-appraisals, laboratory reports, contract bids, proposals, loan or grant applications, sales reports, market analyses, journal articles, books, or any other documents. Perhaps more than anything else, your ability to organize your thoughts

and present them clearly will affect your overall success not only on the job but in life itself.

Models for Writers is designed to help you learn to write by providing you with a collection of model essays — that is, essays that are examples of good writing. Good writing is direct and purposeful and communicates its message without confusing the reader. It doesn't wander from the topic, and it answers the reader's questions. Although good writing is well developed and detailed, it also accomplishes its task with the fewest possible words and with the simplest language appropriate to the writer's topic and thesis.

We know that one of the best ways to learn to write and to improve our writing is to read. By reading, we can see how other writers have communicated their experiences, ideas, thoughts, and feelings. We can study how they have used the various elements of the essay (words, sentences, paragraphs, organizational patterns, transitions, examples, evidence, and so forth) and thus learn how we might effectively do the same. When we see how a writer like James Lincoln Collier develops his essay [“Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name”](#) (p. 73) from a strong thesis statement, for example, we can better appreciate the importance of having a clear thesis statement in our own writing. When we see how Dan Shaughnessy uses transitions in [“Teammates Forever Have a Special Connection”](#) (p. 183) to link events and important ideas so

readers can recognize how the parts of his essay fit together, we have a better idea of how to write coherently.

But we do not learn only by reading. We also learn by doing — that is, by writing — and in the best of all situations, we engage in reading and writing in conjunction with each other. *Models for Writers* therefore encourages you to practice what you are learning and to move from reading to writing.

- Part One, On Reading and Writing Well ([Chapters 1 – 2](#)), introduces you to the important steps of the writing process, shows you how to use apparatus that accompanies each selection in this text, provides you with guidelines for critical reading, and demonstrates with an annotated student essay how you can generate your own writing from reading. You will soon see that an effective essay has a clear purpose, often provides useful information, has an effect on the reader's thoughts and feelings, and is usually a pleasure to read. The essays that you will read in *Models for Writers* were chosen because they are effective.

All well-written essays share a number of structural and stylistic features, and these are illustrated by the various essays in *Models for Writers*. One good way to learn what these features are and how you can incorporate them into your own writing is to look at each of them in isolation. For this

reason, twenty chapters of essays, each chapter with its own particular focus and emphasis, are spread over [Parts Two](#), [Three](#), and [Four](#).

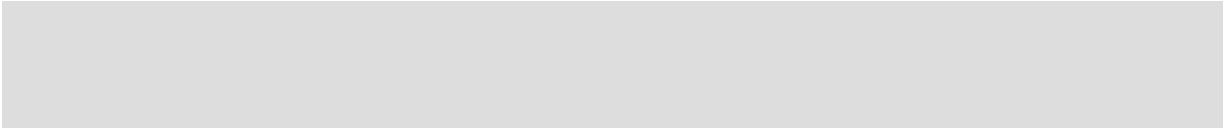
- Part Two, The Elements of the Essay ([Chapters 3 - 10](#)), includes eight chapters on the elements that are essential to a well-written essay. Because the concepts of thesis, unity, and organization underlie all the others, they come first in our sequence, followed closely by advice and models for strong beginnings and endings, well-developed paragraphs, clear transitions, and effective sentences. Finally, a chapter on writing with sources provides proven strategies for taking effective notes from sources; for using signal phrases to integrate quotations, summaries, and paraphrases smoothly into the text of an essay; and for avoiding plagiarism.
- Part Three, The Language of the Essay ([Chapters 11 - 13](#)), shows how writers carefully use language to convey meaning, to capture their own unique voice, to create a particular tone or relationship between writer and reader, and to add richness and depth to writing through figurative language.
- Part Four, Types of Essays ([Chapters 14 - 22](#)), focuses on the types of writing that are most often required of college writing students. These types of writing are often referred to as *organizational patterns* or *rhetorical modes*.

- Part Five, Guides to Research and Editing ([Chapters 23 – 24](#)), includes a useful [Chapter 23](#), A Brief Guide to Writing a Research Paper, with an annotated MLA-style student research paper. This chapter provides clear guidance on establishing a realistic schedule for a research project, conducting research on the internet using directory and keyword searches, evaluating sources, analyzing sources, developing a working bibliography, taking useful notes, and using MLA and APA citation styles to document your paper. [Chapter 24](#), Editing for Grammar, Punctuation, and Sentence Style, provides sound advice and solutions for the editing problems that trouble students most. This final section in *Models for Writers* helps you build confidence in your academic writing skills.

[Chapters 3](#) to [22](#) are each organized in approximately the same way. Each opens with an explanation of the element or principle under discussion. These introductions are brief, clear, and practical and usually provide one or more short examples of the feature or principle being studied, including examples from students such as yourself. Following the chapter introduction, each chapter presents three model essays ([Chapter 22](#), with twelve essays, is an exception). Each essay has its own brief introduction, which provides information about the author and directs your attention to the way the essay demonstrates the featured technique. A

Reflecting on What You Know prompt precedes each reading and invites you to explore your own ideas and experiences regarding some issue presented in the reading. Each essay is followed by four kinds of study materials — Questions for Study and Discussion, Questions for Critical Reading, a Classroom Activity, and Suggested Writing Assignments. Consult [Chapter 2](#), Reading Actively and Critically, for help on improving your writing by thinking critically using the materials that accompany the readings.

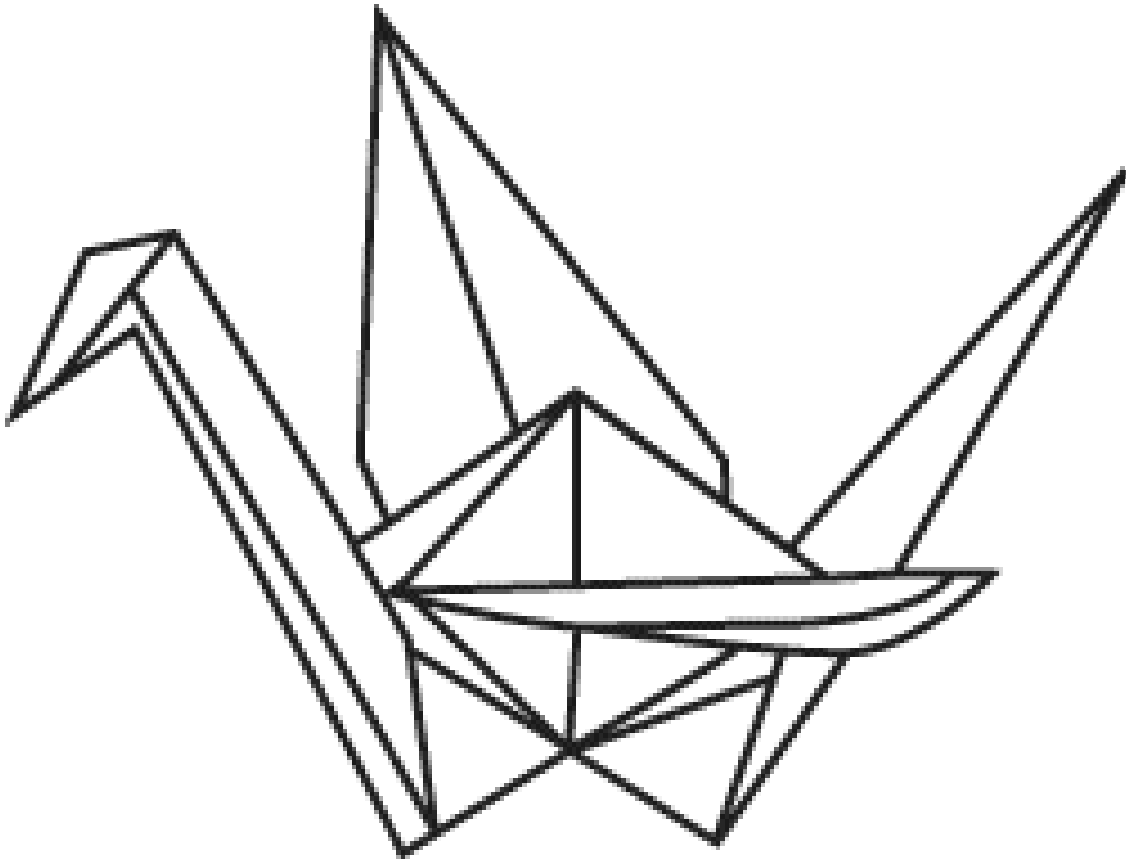
Models for Writers provides information, instruction, and practice in writing effective essays. By reading thoughtfully and critically and by applying the writing strategies and techniques you observe other writers using, you will learn to write more expressively and effectively.



PART ONE On Reading and Writing Well



CHAPTER 1 The Writing Process



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

The essays in this book will help you understand the elements of good writing and provide ample opportunity for you to practice writing in response to the model essays. As you write your essays, pay attention to your writing process. This chapter focuses on the stages of the writing process — prewriting, writing the first draft, revising, editing, and proofreading. It concludes with a sample of one student’s writing process that you can model your own writing after. The strategies suggested in this chapter for each stage of

the writing process will help you overcome many of the challenges you may face while writing essays.

Writers rarely rely on inspiration alone to produce an effective piece of writing. Good writers prewrite or plan, write the first draft, revise, edit, and proofread. It is worth remembering, however, that often the process is recursive, moving back and forth among the five stages. Moreover, writing is personal; no two people go about it exactly the same way. Still, it is possible to learn the steps in the process and thereby have a reliable method for undertaking a writing task.

PREWRITING

Reading can give you ideas and information and helps expand your knowledge of the organizational patterns available to you; consequently, it can help direct all your prewriting activities. During *prewriting*, you select your subject and topic, gather ideas and information, and determine the thesis and organizational pattern or patterns you will use. Once you have worked through the prewriting process, you will be ready to start on your first draft. Let's explore how this works.

Understand Your Assignment

When you first receive an assignment, read it over several times to make sure you understand what you are being asked to do. Try restating the assignment in your own words to make sure you understand it. For example, consider the following assignments:

1. Narrate an experience that taught you that every situation has at least two sides.
2. Explain what is meant by *theoretical modeling* in the social sciences.
3. Write a persuasive essay in which you support or refute the following proposition: "Violence in the media is in

large part responsible for an increase in violence in American society today.”

Each of these assignments asks you to write in different ways:

1. The first assignment asks you to tell the story of an event that showed you that every situation has more than one perspective. To complete the assignment, you might choose simply to narrate the event, or you might choose to analyze it in depth. In either case, you will need to explain to your reader how you came to this new understanding of multiple perspectives and why it was important to you.
2. The second assignment asks you to explain what theoretical modeling is and why it is used. To accomplish this assignment, you will first need to read about the concept to gain a thorough understanding of it, and then you’ ll need to define it in your own words and explain its purpose and usefulness to your readers. You will also want to demonstrate the abstract concept with concrete examples to help your readers understand it.
3. The third assignment asks you to take a position on a controversial issue for which there are many studies on both sides of the question. You will need to research the studies, consider the evidence they present, and then take a stand of your own. Your argument will necessarily have to draw on the sources and evidence you have

researched, and you will need to refute the arguments and evidence presented by those experts who take an opposing position.

If, after reading the assignment several times, you are still unsure about what is being asked of you or about any additional requirements of the assignment, such as length or format, be sure to consult with your instructor.

Choose a Subject Area and Focus on a Topic

Although you will usually be given specific assignments in your writing course, you may sometimes have the freedom to write on any subject that interests you. In such a case, you may already have a specific idea in mind. For example, if you are interested in sports, you might argue against athletes' use of performance-enhancing drugs. What happens, however, when you are free to choose your own subject and cannot think of anything to write about? If you find yourself in this situation, begin by determining a broad subject that you might enjoy writing about — a general subject such as medical ethics, amateur sports, or foreign travel. Also consider what you've recently read — essays in *Models for Writers*, for example — or your career ambitions when choosing a subject. Select several likely subjects and let

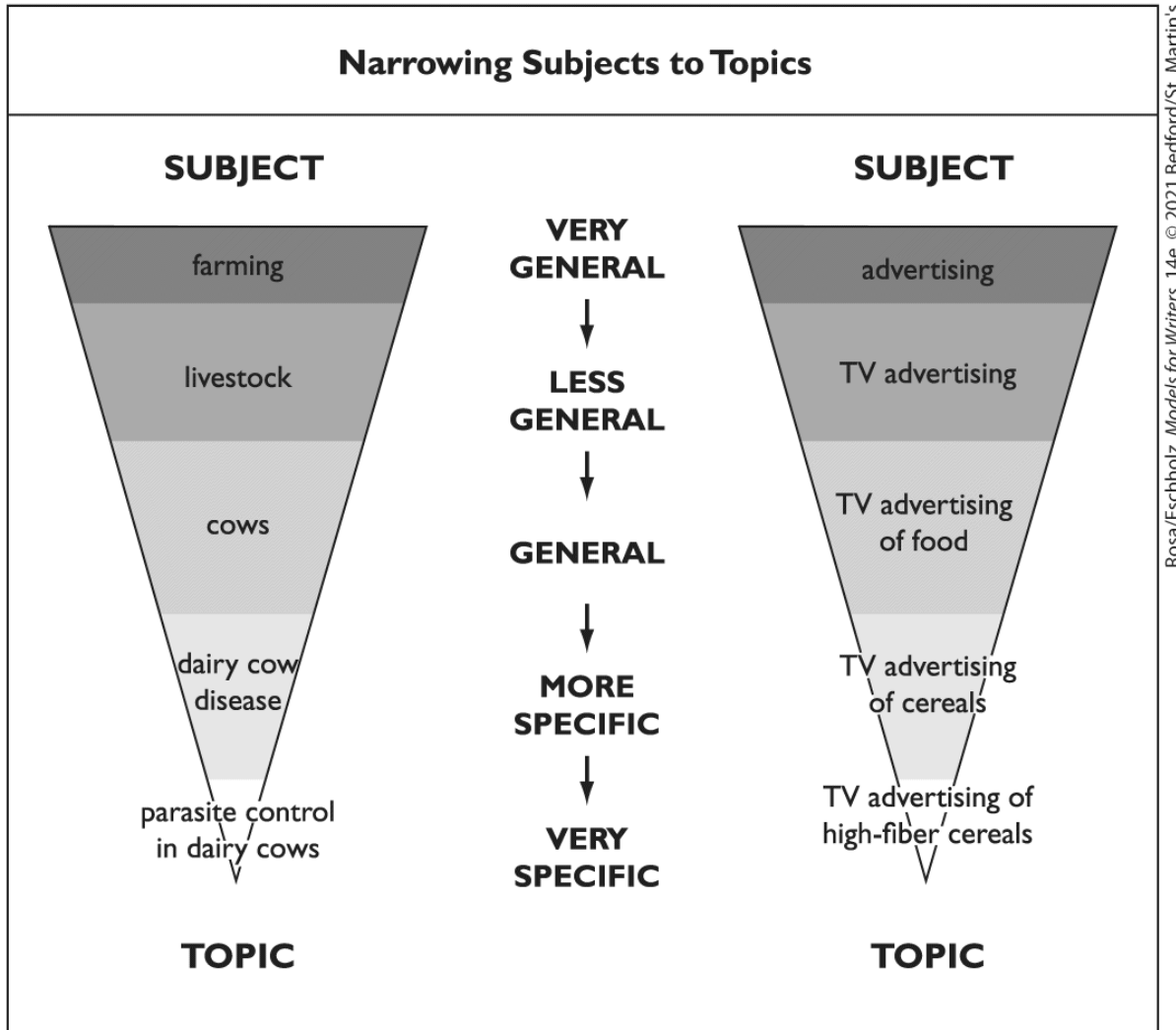
your mind explore their potential for interesting topics. Your goal is to arrive at an appropriately narrowed *topic*.

A *topic* is the specific part of a subject on which a writer focuses. Subjects such as the environment, literature, and sports are too broad to be dealt with adequately in a single essay. Entire books are written about these and other subjects. Start with your broad subject and make it more specific.

Suppose, for example, you select farming and advertising as possible subject areas. The examples in the Narrowing Subjects to Topics box that follows illustrate how to narrow these broad subjects into manageable topics. Notice how each successive topic is more narrowed than the one before it. Moving from the general to the specific, the topics become appropriate for essay-length writing.

When moving from a broad subject to a particular topic, you should take into account any assigned constraints on length or format. You will also want to consider the amount of time you have to write. These practical considerations will affect the scope of your topic.

✓ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Main Ideas



Rosa/Eschholz, *Models for Writers*, 14e, © 2021 Bedford/St. Martin's

Description

"A flow diagram in the middle depicts the general transition from subject to topic as follows: Very general leads to less general, which further heads to general, more specific, and very specific. An inverted pyramid on the left shows a transition from subject (agriculture) to topic as follows: Farming leads to livestock, cows, dairy cow disease, and parasite control in dairy cows. An inverted pyramid on the right shows a transition from subject (advertising) to topic as follows: Advertising leads to television advertising,

television advertising of food, television advertising of cereals, and television advertising of high-fiber cereals.”

Get Ideas and Collect Information

After you have found your topic, you will need to determine what you want to say about it. The best way to do this is to gather information. Your ideas about a topic must be supported by information, such as facts and examples. The information you gather about a topic will influence your ideas about the topic and what you want to say. Here are some of the ways you can gather information:

1. *Brainstorm.* Jot down the things you know about a topic, freely associating ideas and information as a way to explore the topic and its possibilities. (See [p. 28](#) for an example.) Try not to censor or edit your notes, and don't worry about spelling or punctuation. Don't write your notes in list form because such an organization will imply a hierarchy of ideas, which may hamper your creativity and the free flow of your thoughts. The objective of *brainstorming* is to free up your thinking before you start to write. You may want to set aside your notes and return to them over several days. Once you generate a substantial amount of brainstormed material,

you will want to study the items, attempt to see relationships among them, or sort and group the entries by using different colored highlighters.

2. *Cluster*. Another strategy for stimulating your thinking about a topic is *clustering*. Place your topic in a circle and draw lines from that circle to other circles in which you write related key words or phrases. Around each of these key words, generate more circles representing the various aspects of the key word that come to mind. (See [p. 29](#) for an example.) The value of clustering over brainstorming is that you are generating ideas and organizing them at the same time. Both techniques work very well, but you may prefer one over the other or find that one works better with one topic than another.
3. *Research*. You may want to add to what you already know about your topic with research. Research can take many forms beyond formal research carried out in your library. For example, firsthand observations and interviews with people knowledgeable about your topic can provide up-to-date information. Whatever your form of research, take careful notes so you can accurately paraphrase an author or quote an interviewee. [Chapters 10](#) and [23](#) will help with all aspects of researching a topic.

Understand What a Thesis Is

Once you have generated ideas and information about your topic, you are ready to begin the important task of

establishing a controlling idea, or *thesis*, for your essay. The thesis of an essay is its main idea, the point you are trying to make. It is important because everything in your essay, all the ideas and information you have gathered, should be connected to the thesis. It is the glue that holds your writing together.

In his essay [“The Ways of Meeting Oppression”](#) (pp. 447 – 50), Martin Luther King Jr. offers the following thesis statement: “Oppressed people deal with their oppression in three characteristic ways.” King supports his thesis by describing the three ways that oppressed people have traditionally dealt with oppression and explaining why two of those responses — acquiescing to their oppressors or violently resisting them — have not traditionally worked and are not responses he would recommend. He then works his way to the conclusion of his essay, recommending the path of nonviolent resistance as the best way to achieve social justice. His thesis statement carries with it the answer to several implied or built-in questions: What are the characteristic ways of meeting oppression, and which one is to be recommended? The structure of his essay, then, is also built into his thesis statement.

Remember that a weak thesis cannot produce a successful essay no matter how much effort you put into your writing. A strong

thesis, on the other hand, will succeed, but only if it is properly supported.

Develop Your Thesis

You might think that creating a thesis requires some kind of clever thinking or special skills on your part when, in fact, it's a fairly straightforward task. Rather than staring at a blank screen or sheet of paper hoping for a thesis to magically appear, you need to look at the ideas and information you have generated about your topic and ask questions about them in order to understand the topic completely.

STEP 1: ASK QUESTIONS

Let's say that you chose or were assigned the topic of internships, the practice of employing relatively inexperienced people, often students, so that they become familiar with particular work environments and business practices. Through your reading you have learned that internships are often mutually beneficial. Interns can gain useful work-related experience, and businesses get inexpensive temporary help (which sometimes leads to permanent positions).

Now you need to more deeply understand internships by asking questions about the information and ideas you have gathered. For example,

- Why did internships develop as an educational and business practice? Where and when are they now used?
- Are there internship programs at your school? If so, what informational materials are available to you?
- Who can help you find an internship? Can you get an internship on your own?
- Do any businesses in your area offer internships?
- What are the negative aspects of an internship for both parties?
- Do you have family or friends who have employed interns? Do you have family or friends who have had internships? What information have you been able to gain from those on both sides of the relationship?
- Are interns usually paid? How are internships funded?

When the questioning starts, one question will lead to another, and the answers to these questions — often found through more reading, interviews, and discussions — will inform you about the depth and breadth of your topic. If all this is done well, you will soon begin to think like an expert on your topic.

At this point, the likelihood of developing a thesis, or a number of theses, will greatly increase. A thesis will come

to mind from the facts and ideas that you have collected and the questions you ask of that material.

STEP 2: LIST SEVERAL POSSIBLE THESIS STATEMENTS

After you have asked all the questions you think necessary and have supplied answers to those questions, you are ready to list possible thesis statements. Trying to develop not just one thesis but several of them can be a very helpful strategy in refining your ideas and coming up with the best possible thesis. Also, keep in mind that a thesis can be considered a *working thesis* until you are sure it conveys exactly what you want to say, or until you revise it into its final form.

Here are some theses that might be developed as a result of a deeper investigation into the topic of internships:

- All effective internship programs have five key elements.
- Research is necessary before applying to an internship program.
- Employers must have a clearly defined set of expectations for internship programs.
- Record keeping and reporting are the keys to an effective internship program.
- There are no standard practices for funding internships.

- We need a federally funded internship program.

STEP 3: CHOOSE YOUR DIRECTION

The potential theses listed in Step 2 reflect different approaches to and aspects of the topic of internships. Let's take a closer look at how each one may have been arrived at and where each might lead the writer:

- *All effective internship programs have five key elements.*
This thesis is most likely the product of an examination of successful internship programs to learn their key elements. The supporting information might also serve to explain the establishment of an internship program or how to improve an existing one.

- *Research is necessary before applying to an internship program.*

This thesis might be the product of learning what can go right and wrong with an internship and might even suggest what individuals need to know about a program before entering it.

- *Employers must have a clearly defined set of expectations for internship programs.*

This thesis suggests that successful internships are the result of clear expectations for the intern and well-defined pathways for achieving success.

- *Record keeping and reporting are the keys to an effective internship program.*

This thesis suggests that communication is important in any internship relationship. It implies that all parties should document projects, goals, and steps toward achieving those goals, as well as any or all efforts in accomplishing them.

- *There are no standard practices for funding internships.*

This thesis suggests that the way internships are financed is not standardized and that arrangements vary greatly because each internship must be arranged for individually.

- *We need a federally funded internship program.*

This thesis suggests that internships are so worthwhile that they need to be made available nationally and be federally funded.

STEP 4: WRITE YOUR THESIS STATEMENT

A thesis statement should be

- the most important point you make about your topic,
- more general than the ideas and facts you use to support it, and
- focused enough to be covered in the space allotted for the essay.

A thesis statement is not a question, although it might be prompted by one or many, as we have seen with the topic of

internships.

An effective method for developing a thesis statement is to begin by writing, “What I want to say is that ...”

What I want to say is that unless employers offer paid internships, businesses will never recruit the most qualified interns, and interns will not be able to receive the full benefits of their internships.

Later, when you delete the formulaic opening and streamline the text, you will be left with a thesis statement:

Unless employers offer paid internships, businesses will never recruit the most qualified interns, and interns will not be able to receive the full benefits of their internships.

A good way to determine whether your thesis is too general or too specific is to consider how easy it will be to present information and examples to support it. If you stray too far in either direction, your task will become much more difficult. A thesis statement that is too general will leave you overwhelmed by the number of issues you must address. For example, the statement “Malls have ruined the fabric of American life” would lead to the question, “How?” To answer it, you would probably have to include information about traffic patterns, urban decay, environmental damage, economic studies, and so on. You would obviously have to take

shortcuts, and your essay would be ineffective. On the other hand, too specific a thesis statement will leave you with too little information to present. “The Big City Mall should not have been built because it reduced retail sales at the existing Big City stores by 21.4 percent” does not leave you with many options to develop an argument.

The thesis statement is usually set forth near the beginning of the essay, although writers sometimes begin with a few sentences that establish a context for the piece. One common strategy is to position the thesis as the final sentence of the first paragraph. In the opening paragraph of an essay on the harmful effects of quick-weight-loss diets, student Marcie Turple builds a context for her thesis statement, which she presents in her last sentence:

Americans are obsessed with thinness — even at the risk of dying. In the 1930s, people took dinitrophenol, an industrial poison, to lose weight. It boosted metabolism but caused blindness and some deaths. Since then dieters have used hormone injections, amphetamines, liquid protein diets, and, more recently, the controversial fen-phen. What most dieters need to realize is that there is no magic way to lose weight — no pill, no crash diet plan. The only way to permanent weight loss is through sensible eating and exercise.

Thesis

—Marcie Turple, student

Description

The thesis statement reads, “Americans are obsessed with thinness — even at the risk of dying. In the 1930s, people took dinitrophenol, an industrial poison, to lose weight. It boosted metabolism but caused blindness and some deaths. Since then dieters have used hormone injections, amphetamines, liquid protein diets, and, more recently, the controversial fen-phen. What most dieters need to realize is that there is no magic way to lose weight — no pill, no crash diet plan. The only way to permanent weight loss is through sensible eating and exercise.” The last sentence is highlighted. A corresponding annotation reads, Thesis. The writer’s name reads, Marcie Turple, student.

STEP 5: REVISE YOUR THESIS STATEMENT IF NECESSARY

Remember that you are not unalterably committed to the wording of your original thesis, what writers call a *working thesis*. Just as you provide evidence to support the thesis statement, you are free to revise the statement to fit the evidence. For example, let’s suppose you decide to use the following thesis statement for an essay on internships:

We need a federally funded internship program.

You discover as you draft your essay that your evidence is largely financial. You learn that schools and businesses,

especially in poorer parts of the country, refrain from establishing internships because there is little money for such efforts. You reason that if there were a federally funded program, students and businesses from any part of the country, regardless of local resources, would have an equal opportunity to participate. You then revise your working thesis to reflect this additional, more pertinent evidence:

We need a nationwide federally funded internship program that will provide equal opportunity for all students and businesses, regardless of their regional economic differences.

Models for Writers abounds in essays with excellent thesis statements, and we often ask you to identify them. Reading essays with strong thesis statements and locating the controlling idea in each is a great way to learn how to write your own strong thesis statements. Here are some more examples of thesis statements drawn from the essays in *Models for Writers*.

James Lincoln Collier states his thesis in paragraph 20 of [“Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name”](#) (p. 73):

The point is that the new, the different, is almost by definition scary. But each time you try something, you learn, and as the learning piles up, the world opens to you.

Collier's thesis appears near the end of his essay and consists of two sentences instead of a single statement.

Natalie Goldberg presents her thesis at the beginning of her essay in ["Be Specific"](#) (pp. 346 - 48):

Be specific. Don't say "fruit." Tell what kind of fruit —
"It is a pomegranate." Give things the dignity of their
names. Just as with human beings, it is rude to say, "Hey,
girl, get in line." That "girl" has a name.

Notice how she offers a strong opening sentence, really a command, and then moves on to elaborate on what she means by being specific in the rest of her paragraph. It is a message she will carry through the rest of her essay as well.

Finally, in an essay about finding appropriate punishment for minor crimes, Dan M. Kahan in ["Shame Is Worth a Try"](#) (p. 128) offers the following thesis statement in paragraph 3:

[W]hat the shame proponents seem to be getting, and the critics ignoring, is the potential of shame as an effective, cheap, and humane alternative to imprisonment.

With this thesis, Kahan expresses his argument and provides the reader with an outline of the three main points he'll expand on in his essay to support that argument.

As you read through the essays in this book, be on the lookout for thesis statements that you find especially effective. Note their placement within the essay and think about why they've caught your eye. These can serve, then, as models for you when you write your thesis statement. For more on the various ways of developing an effective thesis, see [Chapter 3](#).

Know Your Audience

Although it is not always possible to know who your readers are, you nevertheless need to consider your intended audience. Your attitude toward your topic, your tone, your sentence structure, and your choice of words are just some of the important considerations that rely on your awareness of audience. For a list of questions to help you determine your audience, see the following box.

Audience Questions

1. Who are my readers?
2. Is my audience specialized (for example, those in my geology lab) or more general (college students)?
3. What do I know about my audience's age, gender, education, religious affiliation, socioeconomic status, and political attitudes?
4. What do my readers need to know that I can tell them?

5. Will my audience be interested, open-minded, resistant, objective, or hostile to what I am saying?
6. Is there any specialized language that my audience must have to understand my subject? Is there language that I should avoid?
7. What do I want my audience to do as a result of reading my essay?

Determine Your Method of Development

[Part Four](#) of *Models for Writers* includes chapters on the various types of essays most often required of college students. These types of writing are referred to as *methods of development*, *modes*, *rhetorical patterns*, or *organizational patterns*.

In any effort to broaden your writing skills, it is important to study and practice organizational patterns. *Models for Writers* presents each pattern separately in order to introduce the pattern effectively and provide focus, but that does not necessarily mean that a well-written essay adheres exclusively and rigidly to a single pattern of development. Confining yourself exclusively to comparison and contrast throughout an entire essay, for instance, might prove impractical and result in a formulaic or stilted essay. As

you read the model essays in this text, you will find that many of them use a combination of patterns to support the dominant pattern. For a description of what each organizational pattern involves, see the following Organizational Patterns box.

✓ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Patterns of Organization

Organizational Patterns	
Illustration	Using examples to illustrate a point or an idea
Narration	Telling a story or giving an account of an event
Description	Presenting a picture with words
Process Analysis	Explaining how something is done or happens
Definition	Explaining what something is
Division and Classification	Dividing a subject into its parts and placing them in appropriate categories
Comparison and Contrast	Demonstrating likenesses and differences
Cause and Effect	Explaining the causes of an event or the effects of an

action	
Argument	Using reason and logic to persuade someone to your way of thinking

Combining organizational patterns is probably not something you want to plan or even think about when you first tackle a writing assignment. Instead, let these patterns develop naturally as you organize, draft, and revise your materials.

If you’ re still undecided or concerned about combining patterns, try the following steps:

1. Summarize the point you want to make in a single phrase or sentence.
2. Restate the point as a question (in effect, the question your essay will answer).
3. Look closely at both the summary and the question for key words or concepts that suggest a particular pattern.
4. Consider other strategies that could support your primary pattern.

EXAMPLES OF COMBINED ORGANIZATIONAL PATTERNS

Summary	Question	Pattern	Supporting Patterns
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Venus and Serena Williams are among the best tennis players in the history of the game.	How do Venus and Serena Williams compare with other tennis players?	<i>Comparison and contrast.</i> The writer must compare the Williams sisters with other players and provide evidence to support the claim that they are “among the best.”	<i>Illustration and description.</i> Good evidence includes examples of the Williams sisters’ superior ability and accomplishments as well as descriptions of their athletic feats.
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How to build a personal website.	How do you build a personal website?	<i>Process analysis.</i> The word <i>how</i> , especially in the phrase <i>how to</i> , implies a procedure that can be explained in steps or stages.	<i>Description.</i> The writer should describe the website, especially the look and design of the site, at various points in the process.
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Petroleum and natural gas prices should be federally controlled.	What should be done about petroleum and natural gas prices?	<i>Argument.</i> The word <i>should</i> signals a debatable claim and proposal, which calls for evidence and reasoning in support of the conclusion.	<i>Comparison and contrast and cause and effect.</i> The writer should present evidence from a comparison of federally controlled pricing with deregulated pricing, as well as from a discussion of the effects of deregulation.
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Map Your Organization

Once you settle on a topic and have some idea of what you want to say, your next task is to organize the main ideas for your essay in a way that seems both natural and logical to you. One way to map your ideas is to make an outline. In constructing this outline, if you discover that a particular organizational pattern will help you generate ideas, you might consider using that as your overall organizing principle.

Some writers make a detailed outline and fill it out point by point, whereas others follow a general plan and let the writing take them where it will, making any necessary adjustments to the plan when they revise.

Here are some major patterns of organization you may want to use for your outline:

- Chronological (oldest to newest, or the reverse)
- Spatial (top to bottom, left to right, inside to outside, and so forth)
- Least familiar to most familiar
- Easiest to most difficult to comprehend
- Easiest to most difficult to accept
- According to similarities or differences

Notice that some of these organizational patterns correspond to the rhetorical patterns in [Part Four](#) of this book. For example, a narrative essay generally follows a chronological organization. If you are having trouble developing or mapping an effective organization, refer to the introduction and readings in [Chapter 5](#), Organization. Once you have settled on an organizational pattern, you are ready to write a first draft.

WRITING THE FIRST DRAFT

Your goal in writing a first draft is to get your ideas down on paper. Write quickly and let the writing follow your thinking. Do not be overly concerned about spelling, word choice, or grammar because such concerns will break the flow of your ideas. After you have completed your first draft, you will go over your essay to revise and edit it.

As you write your draft, pay attention to your outline but do not be a slave to it. It is there to help you, not restrict you. Often, when writing, you discover something new about your subject; if so, follow that idea freely. Wherever you deviate from your plan, place an X in the margin, use a comment balloon, or highlight the shift to remind yourself of the change. When you revise, you can return to that part of your writing and reconsider the change you made, either developing it further or abandoning it.

It may happen that while writing your first draft, you run into a difficulty that prevents you from moving forward. Use your resources to work through the difficulty: talk about your writing with a friend or writing tutor, review your notes, or use the information in *Models for Writers*. For example, suppose you want to tell the story of something that

happened to you, but you aren' t certain whether you should be using the pronoun *I* so often. Turn to the essays in [Chapters 11](#) and [14](#) to see how the authors use diction and tone and how other narrative essays handle this problem. You will find that the frequent use of *I* isn' t necessarily a problem at all. For an account of a personal experience, it' s perfectly acceptable to use *I* as often as you need to. Or suppose that after writing several pages describing someone who you think is quite a character, you find that your draft seems flat and doesn' t express how lively and funny the person really is. If you read the introduction to [Chapter 15](#), you will learn that descriptions need lots of factual, concrete detail; the selections in that chapter give further proof of this. You can use those guidelines to add details that are missing from your draft.

If you run into difficulties writing your first draft, don' t be discouraged. Even experienced writers run into problems at the beginning. Just try to keep going and take the pressure off yourself. Think about your topic and consider your details and what you want to say. You may even want to go back and look over the ideas and information you' ve gathered.

Create a Title

What makes a good title? There are no hard-and-fast rules, but most writers would agree that an effective title hooks the reader into reading the essay, either because the title is unusual and intrigues the reader or because it asks a question and the reader is curious to know the answer. A good title announces your subject and prepares your reader for the approach you take. You can create a title while writing your first draft or after you have seen how your ideas develop. Either way, the important thing is to brainstorm for titles and not simply use the first one that comes to mind. With at least a half dozen to choose from, preferably more, you will have a much better sense of how to pick an effective title — one that is lively and inviting and does the important work of explaining your subject to the reader. Review the titles of the essays in *Models for Writers* in the [Table of Contents](#) on pp. xvii–xxviii. You’ll like some better than others, but reflecting on the effectiveness of each one will help you strengthen your own titles.

Focus on Beginnings and Endings

Beginnings and endings are important to the effectiveness of essays, but they can be difficult to write. Inexperienced writers often think that they must write their essays sequentially when, in fact, it is better to write both the beginning and the ending after most of the rest of an essay

is completed. Pay particular attention to both parts during revision.

Questions for Beginnings and Endings

1. Does my introduction grab the reader' s attention?
2. Is my introduction confusing in any way? How well does it relate to the rest of the essay?
3. If I state my thesis in the introduction, how effectively is it presented?
4. Does my essay come to a logical conclusion, or does it just stop short?
5. How well does the conclusion relate to the rest of the essay? Am I careful not to introduce new topics or issues that I did not address in the body of the essay?
6. Does the conclusion help underscore or illuminate important aspects of the body of the essay, or is it just another version of what I wrote earlier?

The beginning of your essay is vitally important to its success. Indeed, if your opening doesn' t attract and hold your readers' attention, readers may be less than enthusiastic about proceeding.

Your ending is almost always as important as your beginning. An effective conclusion does more than end your essay; it

wraps up your thoughts and leaves readers satisfied with the presentation of your ideas and information. Your ending should be a natural outgrowth of the development of your ideas. Avoid trick endings, mechanical summaries, and cutesy comments, and never introduce new concepts or information in the ending. Just as with the writing of titles, the writing of beginnings and endings is perhaps best done by generating several alternatives and then selecting from among them. Review the Questions for Beginnings and Endings box and see [Chapter 6](#) for more help developing your beginnings and endings.

REVISING

After you have completed a first draft, set it aside for a few hours or even until the next day. Removed from the process of drafting, you can approach the revision of your draft with a clear mind. When you revise, consider the most important elements of your draft first. You should focus on your thesis, purpose, content, organization, and paragraph structure. You will have a chance to look at grammar, punctuation, and mechanics after you revise. This way you will make sure that your essay is fundamentally solid and says what you want it to say before dealing with the task of editing.

It is helpful to have someone — a friend or a member of your writing class — listen to your essay as you read it aloud. The process of reading aloud allows you to determine if your writing sounds clear and natural. If you have to alter your voice to provide emphasis, try rephrasing the idea to make it clearer. Whether you revise your work on your own or have someone assist you, the questions in the Questions for Revising box will help you focus on the largest, most important elements of your essay early in the revision process.

✓ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Supporting Details

Questions for Revising

1. Have I focused on my topic?
2. Does my thesis make a clear statement about my topic?
3. Is the organizational pattern I have used the best one, given my purpose?
4. Does the topic sentence of each paragraph relate to my thesis? Does each paragraph support its topic sentence?
5. Do I have enough supporting details, and are my examples the best ones that I can develop?
6. How effective are my beginning and my ending? Can I improve them?
7. Do I have a good title? Does it indicate what my subject is and hint at my thesis?

EDITING

When you are sure you have communicated clearly what you want to say and you have done considerable work drafting and revising, you will want your work to be as accurate as possible. Editing is different from revising in that your focus is on correctness. It is also different from proofreading for careless errors in the final preparation of your essay, which we will discuss later in this chapter ([pp. 26 – 27](#)). During the editing stage, you check your writing for errors in grammar, punctuation, mechanics, spelling, usage, and sentence style. If your writing has editing errors, your readers may question the authority you are trying to establish as a writer — and perhaps then question your content.

You may have difficulty identifying editing errors because they are not easy to spot and take time to learn. After all, if they were easy to see, you would probably have identified and corrected them in the process of drafting and revising. For example, perhaps you forgot or were never made aware of the fact that the word *irregardless* is redundant, unacceptable usage and should be avoided. Or maybe you didn't notice that you created a nonparallel construction in one of your sentences:

INCORRECT The scientists' typical pattern of behavior was to
question, to probe, and research.

CORRECT The scientists' typical pattern of behavior was to
question, to probe, and to research.

Here the infinitive (or to + verb) verb form should be used to parallel other similar verb forms in the series.

It's often easier for others to spot errors in your writing than it is for you to see them, so it is a good idea to ask a classmate, roommate, or friend to edit your work in addition to the work you have done. It is not necessary to have immediate answers while editing, but it is important to raise questions and to double-check for accuracy. [Chapter 24](#) provides sound advice and solutions for the editing problems that trouble students most. For more guidance with these and other editing concerns, refer to a grammar handbook, make an appointment with a writing center tutor, or ask your instructor for advice.

PROOFREADING

Do not assume that because you used a spell-check or grammar-check function you've found and corrected every spelling and grammatical error. In fact, such checkers often allow incorrect or misspelled words to pass while flagging correct grammatical constructions as incorrect. Although spell-checkers and grammar-checkers are a good first line of defense against certain types of errors, there is no replacement for a human proofreader — you.

One way to proofread is to print out your essay and carefully proofread it manually. Distancing yourself from the screen and reading with a pen or pencil in hand makes it easier to avoid simply skimming the words you've written. Check to make sure you do not use *your* where you intend *you're*, *its* where you mean *it's*, or *to* where you want *too*. Spell-checkers often do not catch these types of errors. If you know you are prone to certain mistakes, go through your essay looking for those particular errors.

Be sure to refer to the Questions for Editing and Proofreading Essays box in this section. Check to be certain you have followed your instructor's formatting guidelines.

Above all, give your essay one final read-through before submitting it to your instructor.

Questions for Editing and Proofreading Essays

1. Have I checked my essay for common grammatical or style errors that I am prone to make?
2. Have I corrected my editing errors with the help of my handbook?
3. Have I printed a hard copy of my essay for proofreading?
4. Have I misspelled or incorrectly typed any words? Has my spell-checker inadvertently approved commonly confused words such as *its* and *it's* or *their*, *there*, and *they're*?
5. Do all my edits and corrections appear in my hard copy?
6. Have I formatted my essay according to my instructor's directions?
7. Have I given the hard copy of my final draft a thorough review before turning it in?

WRITING A NARRATIVE ESSAY: A STUDENT ESSAY IN PROGRESS

When she was a student in a writing class at Barnard College, Mya Nunnally was asked to write an essay about a personal experience using a suitable method of development. After considering her options, she chose to write about her experiences with her hair. She had always viewed her hair as an important part of her identity, so she figured she would have enough material for an essay.

First, she needed to focus on a specific topic related to her hair. She decided to write about her struggles with her hair and how, for much of her life, she had difficulty accepting it. She then established her tentative thesis.

Tentative Thesis

I have gone through a lot dealing with issues surrounding my hair.

Nunnally needed to develop a number of examples to support her thesis, so she brainstormed for ideas, examples, and anecdotes — anything that came to mind to help her develop her essay. These are her notes:

Brainstorming Notes

My salon visits: chemical “relaxation,” “creamy crack.”

Straightening my hair boosted my self-esteem, even though it hurt my hair.

“Black hair” (curly, kinky) vs. “white hair” (straight, smooth)

Our society presents white hair as beautiful/attractive: advertising, media, etc.

White hair viewed as normal, black hair abnormal.

I wanted to fit in w/classmates, peers.

Michelle Obama always straightened her hair while in White House.

Then: photo of Michelle with natural, curly hair on vacation

Similar to my experiences?

Hairdresser told me that my hair was almost dead; had to stop visits

Encounter with TSA agent at airport, when he searched my hair

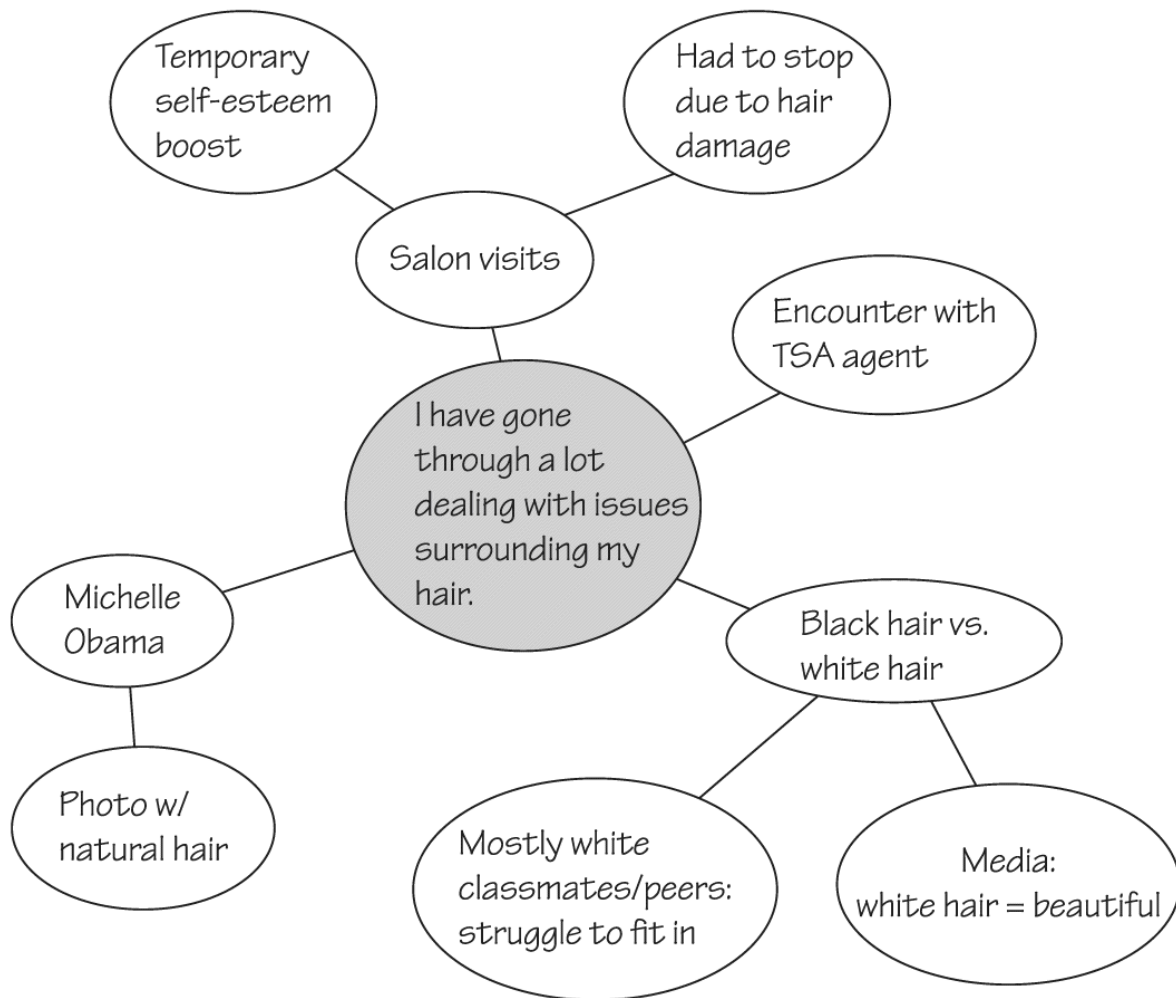
Eventually I accepted my curly hair in its natural state
Malcolm X speech inspired me

Instead of “different,” I saw myself as unique among classmates

When she thought that she had gathered enough material, she began to consider an organizational plan, a way to present her essay in a logical manner. She realized that her brainstorming notes clustered around some key subtopics. She decided to do some clustering, drawing circles that included her ideas: her salon visits, societal perceptions of black

and white hair, and the parallels to former first lady Michelle Obama. She then sorted out her related ideas and examples and added them, mapping their relationships in this diagram.

Clustering Diagram



Rosa/Eschholz, *Models for Writers*, 14e, © 2021 Bedford/St. Martin's

Description

The central circle reads, "I have gone through a lot dealing with issues surrounding my hair." The central circle connects to four secondary circles, "Salon visits",

“Encounter with T S A agent”, “Black hair versus white hair”, and “Michelle Obama.” Each secondary circle connects to several additional circles as follows: “Salon visits” connects to “Temporary self-esteem boost” and “Had to stop due to hair damage”; “Black hair versus white hair” connects to “Mostly white classmates/peers: struggle to fit in” and “Media: white hair equals beautiful”; “Michelle Obama” connects to “Photo w/ natural hair.”

Before beginning to write the first draft of her essay, Nunnally thought it would be a good idea to list in an informal outline the major points she wanted to make. Here is her informal outline:

Informal Outline

1. Introductory paragraph announcing the topic and including the thesis statement: I have gone through a lot dealing with issues surrounding my hair.
2. Background about perceptions of black hair vs. white hair in society
3. Personal narrative about my salon visits and why I had to stop going
4. Initial struggles with my “detox” from salon visits
5. Eventually, I began to enjoy my hair but still had doubts
6. Finally, full acceptance — Malcolm X speech
7. Michelle Obama — never wore her natural hair while in White House
8. Encounter with TSA agent who “searched” my hair

With her outline before her, Nunnally felt ready to try a rough draft of her essay. She wrote quickly, keeping her organizational plan in mind but striving to keep the writing going and get her thoughts down on paper. She knew that once she had a draft, she could determine how to improve it. Nunnally wrote some fairly solid paragraphs, but she sensed that they were on different aspects of her topic and that the logical order of the points she was making was not quite right. She needed a stronger organizational plan, some way to present her information that was not random but rather showed a logical progression.

Reviewing her outline, Nunnally could see that there was a natural progression in her personal narrative from her initial self-doubt about her hair to her eventual acceptance of it. Her narrative was primarily ordered by sequence and time. With this in mind, she decided to reverse the order of items 2 and 3, so that her essay would begin with a narrative of her salon visits before broadening the scope to the larger conversation about perceptions of black hair and white hair in society. Also, she had originally planned to conclude her essay with a personal story about an encounter with a TSA agent who “searched” her hair in an airport security line, running his gloved hands through her curls. Nunnally realized that, while this story was engaging, it did not fit neatly into the overall progression of the narrative, so she decided

to cut it and to instead use the discussion of Michelle Obama to lead into her conclusion. Here is her reordered outline:

Reordered Outline

1. Introductory paragraph announcing the topic and including the thesis statement: I have gone through a lot dealing with issues surrounding my hair.
2. Personal narrative about my salon visits
3. Larger discussion of perceptions about black hair vs. white hair in society
4. Initial struggles with my “detox” from salon visits
5. Eventually, I began to enjoy my hair but still had doubts
6. Finally, full acceptance — Malcolm X speech
7. Michelle Obama — never wore her natural hair while in White House
8. Concluding paragraph: Relate Michelle’s journey to my own, and to the struggles of other black girls and women

Nunnally was satisfied that her essay now had a natural and logical organization: it presented a clear narrative revealing her personal journey related to her hair. However, she now needed to revise her thesis to suit the new organization and narrative that she had established. She wanted her revised thesis to be focused and specific and to make it clear that the essay is about her journey from self-doubt to acceptance of her hair. Here is her revised thesis statement:

Revised Thesis Statement

I had to embark on a long journey of self-criticism and acceptance of my hair to get where I am today.

After revising the organization, she was now ready to edit her essay and to correct those smaller but equally important errors in word choice, wordiness, punctuation, and mechanics. She had put aside these errors to make sure her essay had the appropriate content. Now she needed to make sure it was grammatically correct. Here are several sample paragraphs showing the editing Nunnally did on her essay:

Edited paragraphs

Addition
of verb *was*
to create
a complete
sentence

I would calculate that at least weeks, probably whole months of my life have been lost to the art of dealing with hair. Before I learned to love my hair in its natural state, a salon visit for me could last anywhere from an hour to five. A lengthy braiding session^{was} made bearable only by the thick books I read while wincing through the pain. Sometimes I would get my hair chemically “relaxed,” a process that burns the scalp and makes your eyes water. (In most of these chemical

Elimination of
unessential
information

mixtures there is an ingredient called sodium hydroxide, whose chemical element is NaOH and which has some pesky side effects including blindness, third degree burns, and permanent

Description

The first paragraph reads, “I would calculate that at least weeks, probably whole months of my life have been lost to the art of dealing with hair. Before I learned to love my hair in its natural state, a salon visit for me could last anywhere from an hour to five. A lengthy braiding session (the text “was” is inserted after the word “session”) made bearable only by the thick books I read while wincing through the pain. A corresponding annotation reads, Addition of verb was to create a complete sentence. Sometimes I would get my hair chemically ‘relaxed,’ a process that burns the scalp and makes your eyes water. (In most of these chemical mixtures there is an ingredient called sodium hydroxide, whose chemical element is NaOH and (The text “whose chemical element is NaOH and” has a strikethrough) which has some pesky side effects including blindness, third degree burns, and permanent organ damage) A corresponding annotation reads, Elimination of unessential information. Greasing down the edges. Flattening down baby hairs. What’s your hair type? (the text “ - 4 A or 3 C” after the word “type”) There exists a secret world and a secret grammar for those with black hair in which we try all that we can to look perfect, no matter the cost.” A corresponding annotation reads, Specific hair types show the “secret grammar” that Nunnally mentions.

Specific hair types show the “secret grammar” that Nunnally mentions

organ damage.) Greasing down the edges. Flattening down baby hairs. What’s your hair type? ^{— 4A or 3C?} There exists a secret world and a secret grammar for those with black hair in which we try all that we can to look perfect, no matter the cost.

Elimination of run-on sentence

The “perfect” woman changes over time, but it has never been fashionable to be black, ^{to} steal aspects of our culture, yes, minus the actual black person. White girls tan in the sun

Elimination of wordiness

in order to get darker, ^{while skin-bleaching is} ~~and you can go get your skin bleached,~~ a multi-billion dollar industry worldwide. As of this writing,

Comma added to introduce appositive phrase

big lips and thick eyebrows are in, ^{the} the very things we were made fun of for having in middle school. But black hair has yet to become completely mainstream. The kind of hair that our culture wants us to aspire to is straight and smooth. Every day — in magazines, on billboards, in commercials — society ^{sends} ~~is sending us~~ messages that certain types of hair aren’t attractive, aren’t even professional. Every week there seems to be a new story about someone fired for their natural hair or forced to make it “acceptable” in order to continue working.

Unnecessary sentence removed

~~That is the problem with these messages that society sends us.~~ All of this culminated in deep discomfort with my hair, and ^{is}

Improved diction

why it took me so many years to reach a point where I could accept and even ^{cherish} love it.

Description

The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, “The ‘perfect’ woman changes over time, but it has never been fashionable to be black, (The comma is replaced with a period) to (the letter “T” is changed to upper case) steal aspects of our culture, yes, minus the actual black person. A corresponding annotation reads, Elimination of run-on sentence. White girls tan in the sun in order to get darker, and you can go get yours skin bleached, (the text “and you can go get yours skin bleached” has a strikethrough and replaced with the text “white skin-bleaching is) a multi-billion dollar industry worldwide. A corresponding annotation reads, Elimination of wordiness. As of this writing, big lips and thick eyebrows are in, (Comma added) the very things we were made fun of for having in middle school. A corresponding annotation reads, Comma added to introduce appositive phrase. But black hair has yet to become completely (the word “completely” has a strikethrough) mainstream. The kind of hair that our culture wants us to aspire to is straight and smooth. Every day — in magazines, on billboards, in commercials — society is sending us (the text “is sending us” has a strikethrough and is replaced with the word “sends.”) messages that certain types of hair aren’ t attractive, aren’ t even professional. Every week there seems to be a new story about someone fired for their natural hair or forced to make it “acceptable” in order to continue working. That is the problem with these message that society send us. (the sentence “That is the problem with these message that society send us” has a strikethrough) A corresponding annotation reads, Unnecessary sentence removed. All of this culminated in deep discomfort with my hair, and (the word

“is” is added after the word “and”) why it took me so many years to reach a point where I could accept and even love (the word “love” is replace with the word “cherish”) it.” A corresponding annotation reads, Improved diction.

After Nunnally edited her revised paper, she was left with the following final version of her essay. Note how her final essay uses a clear narrative organization. Note also how Mya’s voice — her personality as expressed on the written page — comes across strongly throughout the essay.

Final Essay

Mya Nunnally

Mixed Results

Beginning:
Effective
opening
paragraph
sets the
context for
the essay

I've never been good with hair. My hair is a physical combination of my heritage — a biracial tangle of curl and kink. It shapeshifts: when it's wet, it falls in long, loose tendrils. When it's dry, it shrinks and fros and not a comb on this Earth can get through it. I never learned how to braid, how to style, or do anything past a ponytail. I still prefer to cut my hair myself, leaving it choppy and uneven half of the time, and forget to shampoo on a regular basis. But I do *love* my hair, and this is a sought-after skill. For girls like me to love their hair is for our self-hatred to be reversed inch by inch. But it was not always this way for me. I had to embark on a long journey of self-criticism and acceptance of my hair to get where I am today.

Thesis state-
ment: Sets
clear expect-
ation in the
reader's mind

Transition
from intro-
duction to
specific
details

I would calculate that at least weeks, probably whole months of my life have been lost to the art of dealing with hair. Before I learned to love my hair in its natural state, a salon visit for me could last anywhere from an hour to five. A lengthy braiding session was made bearable only by the thick books I read while wincing through the pain. Sometimes I would get my hair chemically "relaxed," a process that burns the scalp and makes your eyes water. (In most of these chemical mixtures there is an ingredient called sodium hydroxide, which has some pesky side effects including blindness, third degree burns, and permanent organ damage.) Greasing down the edges. Flattening down baby hairs. What's your hair type — 4A or 3C? There exists a secret world and a secret grammar for those with black hair in which we try all that we can to look perfect, no matter the cost.

Nunnally
steps back
from personal
narrative to
give a broader
perspective

The "perfect" woman changes over time, but it has never been fashionable to be black. To steal aspects of our culture, yes, minus the actual black person. White girls tan in the sun in order to get darker, while skin-bleaching is a

Description

"A text reads, Final Essay; Mya Nunnally; Mixed Results. The first paragraph reads, "I've never been good with hair. My hair is a physical combination of my heritage - a biracial tangle of curl and kink. It shapeshifts: when it's wet, it falls in long, loose tendrils. When it's dry, it shrinks and fros and not a comb on this Earth can get through it. I never learned how to braid, how to style, or do anything past a ponytail. I still prefer to cut my hair myself, leaving it choppy and uneven half of the time, and forget to." A corresponding annotation reads, Beginning: Effective opening paragraph sets the context for the essay. "

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "shampoo on a regular basis. But I do love my hair, and this is a sought-after skill. For girls like me to love their hair is for our self-hatred to be reversed inch by inch. But it was not always this way for me. I had to embark on a long journey of selfcriticism and acceptance of my hair to get where I am today." A corresponding annotation reads, Thesis statement: Sets clear expectation in the reader's mind. The second paragraph reads, "I would calculate that at least weeks, probably whole months of my life have been lost to the art of dealing with hair. Before I learned to love my hair in its natural state, a salon visit for me could last anywhere from an hour to five. A lengthy braiding session was made bearable only by the thick books I read while wincing through the pain. Sometimes I would get my hair chemically 'relaxed,' a process that burns the scalp and makes your eyes water. (In most of these chemical mixtures there is an ingredient called sodium hydroxide, which has some pesky side effects including blindness, third

degree burns, and permanent organ damage) Greasing down the edges. Flattening down baby hairs. What's your hair type — 4A or 3C? There exists a secret world and a secret grammar for those with black hair in which we try all that we can to look perfect, no matter the cost." A corresponding annotation reads, Transition from introduction to specific details. The third paragraph reads, "The 'perfect' woman changes over time, but it has never been fashionable to be black. To steal aspects of our culture, yes, minus the actual black person. White girls tan in the sun in order to get darker, while skin-bleaching is a multi-billion-dollar industry worldwide. As of this writing, big lips and thick eyebrows are in, the very things we were made fun of for having in middle school. But black hair has yet to become mainstream. The kind of hair that our culture wants us to aspire to is straight and smooth. Every day — in magazines, on billboards, in commercials — society sends messages that certain types of hair aren't attractive, aren't even professional. Every week there seems to be a new story about someone fired for their natural hair or forced to make it 'acceptable' in order." A corresponding annotation reads, Nunnally steps back from personal narrative to give a broader perspective. "

Nunnally connects broader discussion to personal experiences

multi-billion-dollar industry worldwide. As of this writing, big lips and thick eyebrows are in, the very things we were made fun of for having in middle school. But black hair has yet to become mainstream. The kind of hair that our culture wants us to aspire to is straight and smooth. Every day — in magazines, on billboards, in commercials — society sends messages that certain types of hair aren't attractive, aren't even professional. Every week there seems to be a new story about someone fired for their natural hair or forced to make it "acceptable" in order to continue working. All of this culminated in deep discomfort with my hair, and is why it took me so many years to reach a point where I could accept and even cherish it.

Dialog gives a more specific sense of this scene

My journey toward loving my hair didn't begin voluntarily. It all started when the hairdresser told me "your hair is close to dead," and *tsked* as she brought the last strand through the straight iron. We were nearing my favorite part of the visit — when she would turn me around to face myself in the wide mirror. When I could see my long, silky, straight strands and smile and know that for a week or so I would be just like the other girls. Like the other *white* girls, really, but I was not self-conscious enough to understand that. I was fourteen and about to start high school.

Unity: Relates to the discussion in the previous paragraph

Each line of dialog begins a new paragraph

"What do you mean?" I asked.
She clucked again. I almost heard her frown. "Have you been straightening this every day?"
I flushed, my cheeks growing hot. "Yes," I admitted, like a confession.

"You're killing it," she told me. "If you keep doing that, eventually it might just fall out."

She swiveled me around in the chair to see myself. Beautiful, I thought. I looked white like a ghost.

Transition: Establishes passage of time

After that salon visit, I had to detox from straightening my hair while it grew back its strength. My unruly kinks sprouted from my head and, at first, I hid behind anything I could, wishing I could disappear completely. I broke the dress

Description

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "to continue working. All of this culminated in deep discomfort with my hair, and is why it took me so many years to reach a point where I could accept and even cherish it."

A corresponding annotation reads, Nunnally connects broader discussion to personal experiences. The second paragraph reads, "My journey toward loving my hair didn't begin voluntarily. It all started when the hairdresser told me

'your hair is close to dead,' and tsked as she brought the last strand through the straight iron. We were nearing my favorite part of the visit - when she would turn me around to face myself in the wide mirror. When I could see my long, silky, straight strands and smile and know that for a week or so I would be just like the other girls. Like the other white girls, really, but I was not self-conscious enough to understand that. I was fourteen and about to start high school."

A corresponding annotation reads, Dialog gives a more specific sense of this scene. A second corresponding annotation reads, Unity: Relates to the discussion in the previous paragraph. The above paragraph is followed by a set of dialogues. "What do you mean?" I asked. She clucked again. I almost heard her frown. "Have you been

straightening this every day?" I flushed, my cheeks growing hot. "Yes," I admitted, like a confession. "You're killing it," she told me. "If you keep doing that,

eventually it might just fall out." She swiveled me around in the chair to see myself. Beautiful, I thought. I looked white like a ghost. A corresponding annotation reads, Each line of dialog begins a new paragraph. The third paragraph reads, "After that salon visit, I had to detox from straightening my hair while it grew back its strength. A

corresponding annotation reads, Transition: Establishes passage of time. My unruly kinks sprouted from my head and, at first, I hid behind anything I could, wishing I could disappear completely. I broke the dress code and wore hats to school, even racking up a few detentions when I refused to take them off. I briefly contemplated converting to Islam in order to hide behind a flowing hijab. It hurt to stop pretending so completely. I was going through a kind of withdrawal, an addict aching for that easy fix.” A corresponding annotation reads, Metaphor helps convey Nunnally’ s feelings. The fourth paragraph reads, “There is a reason the slang term for relaxers is ‘creamy crack.’ But slowly, the cleanse began to work. I relished the extra hours I gained back from all the time straightening took. I began to enjoy the texture of my curls. And in the halls of.” A corresponding annotation reads, Organization continues to show Nunnally’ s changing attitude.”

Metaphor
helps convey
Nunnally's
feelings

Organization
continues
to show
Nunnally's
changing
attitude

Reference to
civil rights
leader Mal-
colm X adds
weight and
significance

Transition
relates
Nunnally's
experiences to
former first
lady Michelle
Obama

code and wore hats to school, even racking up a few detentions when I refused to take them off. I briefly contemplated converting to Islam in order to hide behind a flowing hijab. It hurt to stop pretending so completely. I was going through a kind of withdrawal, an addict aching for that easy fix. There is a reason the slang term for relaxers is “creamy crack.”

But slowly, the cleanse began to work. I relished the extra hours I gained back from all the time straightening took. I began to enjoy the texture of my curls. And in the halls of my high school, so many of the girls looked the same from far away. If I blurred my vision I could barely tell them apart. Blonde, thin, white, wearing the same clothes as everyone else. I cherished my difference and wore it with pride. This didn't stop me from bursting into panic attacks in the bathroom, sticking my head into the sink in an attempt to wet the curls and tone them down. It did not stop me from cutting my hair off to the nape of my neck in order to have less of it to deal with. But it was a start.

Eventually I shot to the other end of the spectrum, spurred by a particularly rousing Malcolm X speech about racial awakening and various internet articles about feminism. I threw out every bra I ever owned, let my underarm hair grow wild, and vowed never to burn any part of myself again. I told myself I was beautiful like it was a sacred mantra. To others, I looked self-obsessed. Vain and egotistical, they must have thought me. But I knew that I was balancing out a decade of self-hatred. I had so much lost time to make up for.

I know I'm not the only one to have this pressure to aspire towards “white hair.” Even Michelle Obama was not permitted to wear her natural hair once during eight years in office. It was simply not advised. During her time at Princeton, Michelle wrote about how her white classmates had transformed her hair into an object of exotic desire — often pulling and tugging without permission. She recalled how her roommate's mother, upon learning that Michelle was black, tried to move her child

Description

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "my high school, so many of the girls looked the same from far away. If I blurred my vision I could barely tell them apart. Blonde, thin, white, wearing the same clothes as everyone else. I cherished my difference and wore it with pride. This didn't stop me from bursting into panic attacks in the bathroom, sticking my head into the sink in an attempt to wet the curls and tone them down. It did not stop me from cutting my hair off to the nape of my neck in order to have less of it to deal with. But it was a start."

The second paragraph reads, "Eventually I shot to the other end of the spectrum, spurred by a particularly rousing Malcolm X speech about racial awakening and various internet articles about feminism. A corresponding annotation reads, Reference to civil rights leader Malcolm X adds weight and significance. I threw out every bra I ever owned, let my underarm hair grow wild, and vowed never to burn any part of myself again. I told myself I was beautiful like it was a sacred mantra. To others, I looked self-obsessed. Vain and egotistical, they must have thought me. But I knew that I was balancing out a decade of self-hatred. I had so much lost time to make up for." The third paragraph reads, "I know I'm not the only one to have this pressure to aspire towards 'white hair.' Even Michelle Obama was not permitted to wear her natural hair once during eight years in office. It was simply not advised. During her time at Princeton, Michelle wrote about how her white classmates had transformed her hair into an object of exotic desire - often pulling and tugging without permission. She recalled how her roommate's mother, upon learning that Michelle was black, tried to move her child into another dorm, or - if

that couldn't be done, remove her daughter from the college altogether. When she and Barack took office, Michelle was already being bombarded with racial rhetoric about her 'savagery' and 'monkey-like' appearance in political cartoons, professional media coverage, and the internet.

'An ape in heels,' she was called in 2016, by a mayor in West Virginia." A corresponding annotation reads, Transition relates Nunnally's experiences to former first lady Michelle Obama. The fourth paragraph reads, "After she left the White House, Michelle went on a getaway with the rest of the Obama family. From that vacation," "

into another dorm, or—if that couldn't be done, remove her daughter from the college altogether. When she and Barack took office, Michelle was already being bombarded with racial rhetoric about her "savagery" and "monkey-like" appearance in political cartoons, professional media coverage, and the internet. "An ape in heels," she was called in 2016, by a mayor in West Virginia.

Effective use
of example:
Connects to
Nunnally's
personal
narrative

After she left the White House, Michelle went on a getaway with the rest of the Obama family. From that vacation, black girls of America were blessed by a single candid photo: Michelle wearing her natural hair and a headband to hold it back. Like we had seen so many of our mothers do in the thick August heat. Like we had done ourselves before going to bed. At last, Michelle stepped out of the light and came back to us, is allowed to *be* like us again.

Transition into
conclusion
reinforces
parallels
with Michelle
Obama

Though different in many ways from Michelle Obama's journey, my own struggle also lasted for years. It took a significant amount of time and work for me to become someone who feels confident in her hair and her self. Looking back, however, if my story helps even one person with their own struggle, I know that it was definitely worth it.

Ending: An
appropriate
and optimistic
conclusion

Description

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "black girls of America were blessed by a single candid photo: Michelle wearing her natural hair and a headband to hold it back. Like we had seen so many of our mothers do in the thick August heat. Like we had done ourselves before going to bed. At last, Michelle stepped out of the light and came back to us, is allowed to be like us

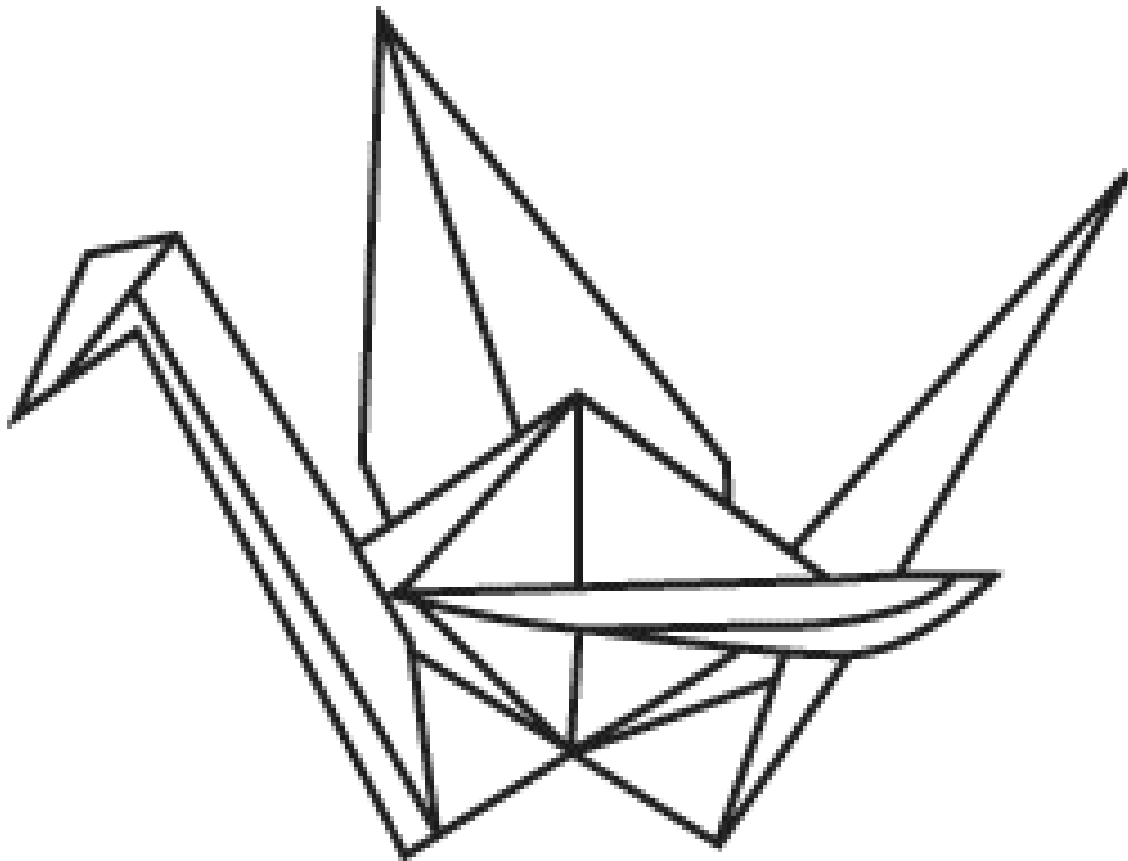
again.” A corresponding annotation reads, Effective use of example: Connects to Nunnally’s personal narrative.

The second paragraph reads, “Though different in many ways from Michelle Obama’s journey, my own struggle also lasted for years. A corresponding annotation reads, Transition into conclusion reinforces parallels with Michelle Obama. It took a significant amount of time and work for me to become someone who feels confident in her hair and her self.

Looking back, however, if my story helps even one person with their own struggle, I know that it was definitely worth it.” A corresponding annotation reads, Ending: An appropriate and optimistic conclusion. ”



CHAPTER 2 Reading Actively and Critically



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Reading is an integral part of most good writing courses. Reading and writing are two sides of the same coin. Many people think of writing as creating material that others will eventually read, but the connection does not end there. One of the best ways to improve our writing is to read. By reading, we begin to see how writers communicate their experiences, ideas, thoughts, and feelings in their writing. We can study how they use the various elements of the essay

(thesis, unity, organization, beginnings and endings, paragraphs, transitions, effective sentences, voice, diction and tone, and figurative language) to say what they want to say. By studying the style, technique, and rhetorical strategies of other writers, we learn how we might effectively do the same.

You also need to master the skills of reading actively and critically because you will be your own first reader and critic for everything you write. How well you are able to scrutinize your own drafts will powerfully affect how well you revise them, and revising well is crucial to writing well. So reading others' writing with a critical eye is a useful and important practice; the more you read, the more skilled you will become at seeing the rhetorical options available to you and the better you' ll be at making strategic choices in your own writing.

So, let' s get started. In this chapter we present reading as a two-step process: (1) active reading and (2) critical reading. We believe that you must first engage the reading actively with the purpose of coming to a basic understanding of what the writer has to say. With this basic understanding in mind, you can begin to analyze and evaluate the reading critically, taking your connection to the essay to a new level.

☑ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Critical Reading

READING ACTIVELY: GETTING A BASIC UNDERSTANDING OF THE ESSAY

Active reading requires, first of all, that you commit time and effort. Keep an open mind and take a positive interest in what you are reading, even if the subject matter is not immediately appealing. Remember that you are not reading just to fulfill an assignment or to be entertained. Your job is to thoughtfully engage the essay in order to come away with a basic understanding of what the author is saying.

To help you get the most out of your reading, follow these five steps of the active reading process:

1. Prepare yourself to read the selection.
2. Read the selection.
3. Use the Questions for Study and Discussion to direct your second reading of the selection.
4. Annotate the text with marginal notes.
5. Outline and summarize the selection to check your understanding of the selection.

Step 1: Prepare Yourself to Read the Selection

Before diving into any given selection, it's helpful to get a context for the reading: What's the essay about? What do you know about the writer's background and reputation? Where was the essay first published? Who was the intended audience for the essay? How much do you already know about the subject of the reading selection?

We encourage you, therefore, to review the materials that precede each selection in this book. Each selection begins with a title, a portrait of the writer, a headnote, and a writing prompt.

- From the *title*, you often discover the writer's position on an issue or attitude toward the topic. On occasion, the title provides clues about the intended audience and the writer's purpose in writing the piece.
- The *headnote* contains three essential elements: a biographical note about the author, publication information, and rhetorical highlights of the selection.
 - (1) The *biographical note* will tell you information on the person's life and work as well as something about his or her reputation and authority to write on the subject of the piece.
 - (2) The *publication information* tells you when the selection was published and in what

book or magazine it appeared. This information gives you insights about the intended audience and the historical context. (3) The *rhetorical highlights* direct your attention to one or more of the model features of the selection.

- Finally, the *writing prompt*, called Reflecting on What You Know, encourages you to collect your own thoughts and opinions about the topic or related subjects before you commence reading. This prompt makes it easy for you to keep a record of your own knowledge or thinking about a topic before you see what the writer has to offer in the essay.

To demonstrate how these context-building materials can work for you, carefully review the following materials that accompany Celeste Headlee's "Get Off the Soapbox." The essay itself appears later in this chapter ([pp. 42 - 44](#)).

Get Off the Soapbox

Title

■ ■ ■ Celeste Headlee

A classically trained soprano, Celeste Headlee was born in 1969 in Whittier, California. She is the granddaughter of African-American composer William Grant Still. She studied music at the Idyllwild Arts Academy in Riverside County, California, graduating in 1987. Headlee pursued her undergraduate degree in vocal performance at Northern Arizona University and later received her Master of Music from the University of Michigan in 1998.



Gary Gershoff/Getty Images

Headnote

I. Biographical note

Description

"A corresponding annotation reads, Title. A sub heading reads, Celeste Headlee. The first paragraph reads, "A classically trained soprano, Celeste Headlee was born in 1969 in Whittier, California. She is the granddaughter of African-American composer William Grant Still. She studied music at the Idyllwild Arts Academy in Riverside County, California, graduating in 1987. Headlee pursued her undergraduate degree in vocal performance at Northern Arizona University and later received her Master of Music from the University of Michigan in 1998." A corresponding annotation reads, Headnote 1. Biographical note. A photo on the right shows Celeste Headlee."

Although Headlee is a professional opera singer, news is her day job. She launched her journalism career with Arizona Public Radio in 1999 as an anchor and writer before moving on to Detroit Public Radio, where she hosted a weekly program, *Front Row Center*. In 2006, she joined National Public Radio, writing feature stories and breaking news reports. While at NPR she hosted *The Takeaway*, a morning news program, and filled in as host for such popular shows as *Tell Me More*, *Weekend Edition*, *Talk of the Nation*, and *Weekend All Things Considered*. In 2014, Headlee launched *On Second Thought*, a one-hour daily news talk show produced by Georgia Public Broadcasting. The show features her conversations with a wide variety of people about most anything relating to Georgia politics, wildlife, healthcare, education, guns, race, music, and poetry. Headlee's 2015 TED Talk "Ten Ways to Have Better Conversations" went viral and has been viewed by more than twenty million people. Headlee is the author of *Heard Mentality: An A-Z Guide to Take Your Podcast or Radio Show from Idea to Hit* (2016) and *We Need to Talk: How to Have Conversations that Matter* (2017).

In "Get Off the Soapbox," a selection from *We Need to Talk*, she details one of the strategies that she has used to become a better conversationalist. As you read this selection, notice how Headlee uses the example of the controversy surrounding the Confederate flag to help her make the case that we need to start talking to each other.

2. Publication information

3. Rhetorical highlight

Reflecting on What You Know

What are your thoughts when you hear the words "we need to talk"? Like most Americans, do you use texts, emails, and social media to communicate with family and friends? How do you handle controversial subjects? Describe the last time you had a difficult or challenging face-to-face conversation. How would you rate yourself as a conversationalist?

Writing prompt

Description

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "Although Headlee is a professional opera singer, news is her day job. She launched her journalism career with Arizona Public Radio in 1999 as an anchor and writer before moving on to Detroit Public Radio, where she hosted a weekly program, Front Row Center. In 2006, she joined National Public Radio, writing feature stories and breaking news reports. While at NPR she hosted The Takeaway, a morning news program, and filled in as host for such popular shows as Tell Me More, Weekend Edition, Talk of the Nation, and Weekend All Things Considered. In 2014, Headlee launched On Second Thought, a one-hour daily news talk show produced by Georgia Public Broadcasting. The show features her conversations with a wide variety of people about most anything relating to Georgia politics, wildlife, healthcare, education, guns, race, music, and poetry. Headlee's 2015 TED Talk 'Ten Ways to Have Better Conversations' went viral and has been viewed by more than twenty million people. Headlee is the author of *Heard Mentality: An A-Z Guide to Take Your Podcast or Radio Show from Idea to Hit* (2016) and *We Need to Talk: How to Have Conversations that Matter* (2017)." "In 'Get Off the Soapbox,' a selection from *We Need to Talk*, she details one of the strategies that she has used to become a better conversationalist. An annotation reads, 2. Publication information. As you read this selection, notice how Headlee uses the example of the controversy surrounding the Confederate flag to help her make the case that we need to start talking to each other." A corresponding annotation reads, 3. Rhetorical highlight. A subheading reads, Reflecting on What You Know "What are your thoughts when you hear the words 'we need to talk' ?

Like most Americans, do you use texts, emails and social media to communicate with family and friends? How do you handle controversial subjects? Describe the last time you had a difficult or challenging face-to-face conversation. How would you rate yourself as a conversationalist?" A corresponding annotation reads, Writing prompt."

From these preliminary materials, what expectations do you have for the selection? And how does this knowledge equip you to engage the selection before you read it?

- The essay's *title* is a command. A soapbox is a box or crate used as a makeshift platform for a speaker to give an impassioned speech about a current, possibly controversial, issue. Headlee is asking her readers to get off their soapboxes and to listen up instead of spouting off.
- (1) The *biographical note* reveals that Headlee is an accomplished opera singer and a well-respected journalist and talk show host with National Public Radio. She used her experience as a conversationalist and interviewer to develop a TED Talk and a book on how to have better conversations. (2) The *publication information* indicates that "Get Off the Soapbox" is a selection from her book *We Need to Talk: How to Have Conversations that Matter*. The sub-title of that book suggests that Headlee will be giving her readers advice about becoming better conversationalists. (3) The *rhetorical highlight* advises you to pay particular attention to how Headlee uses the

example of the Confederate flag controversy to illustrate what people need to do when talking about difficult subjects.

- The *writing prompt* asks you to reflect on how the words “we need to talk” impact you when you hear them. Do these words instill you with fear, or do you welcome a good conversation? Also, you’re asked to consider your communication habits. In your everyday life, do you tend to use texting and social media instead of picking up a phone to talk or sitting down for a face-to-face conversation? After reading Headlee’s essay, you can compare your thoughts about conversations — especially about controversial topics — with Headlee’s.

Step 2: Read the Selection

Always read the selection at least twice, no matter how long it is. The first reading gives you a chance to get acquainted with the essay and form your first impressions of it. With the first reading, you want to get an overall sense of what the writer is saying, keeping in mind the essay’s title and the facts that you know about the writer from the essay’s headnote. The essay will offer you information, ideas, and arguments — some you may have expected, some you may not have expected. As you read, you may find yourself modifying your sense of the writer’s message and purpose. If there are any words that you do not recognize, circle them so that you

can look them up later in a dictionary. Put question marks alongside any passages that are not immediately clear. You may, in fact, want to delay most of your annotating until a second reading so that your first reading can be fast and free.

Here is the text of Headlee’ s essay.

Stop pushing your cause.	Get Off the Soapbox	
Opens with story of her arrival in Georgia: a Northerner with Southern roots.	When I moved to Georgia in 2014, I became a Southerner for the first time in my life. I was raised in California and have lived in Arizona, Washington, Michigan, New Jersey, and Maryland, but I’d never put down stakes south of the Mason-Dixon Line. However, my family tree has its roots in the South. One of my ancestors was a slave on a Georgia plantation in Milledgeville, a small town northeast of Macon, less than a two-hour drive from Atlanta.	1
Ancestor was slave.	If you read the biography of my great-grandmother in <i>The Encyclopedia of Arkansas History and Culture</i> , you’ll see that her father’s name is “unknown.” That may be the truth according to the official record, but our family knows who he was. He was the Scotch-Irish man who owned Anne Fambro, my great-great-grandmother. Carrie Lena Fambro was his daughter, born in 1872. When the era of legal slavery came to an end with the Civil War, he provided all of his mixed-race children, I’m told, with a college education.	2
Why doesn’t she name slave owner?		
Slave owner is father of great-grandmother.		
Great-grandmother quite an activist.	Carrie got a degree from Atlanta University in 1886 and became a fierce advocate for the education of African Americans. She founded the first library for blacks in the Deep South, using funds raised by staging Shakespeare’s plays. She taught at Union School, the first school for black	3

Description

"The title reads, Get off the Soapbox. A corresponding annotation reads, Stop pushing your cause. The first paragraph reads, "When I moved to Georgia in 2014, I became a Southerner for the first time in my life. I was raised in California and have lived in Arizona, Washington, Michigan, New Jersey, and Maryland, but I'd never put down stakes south of the Mason-Dixon Line. A corresponding annotation reads, Opens with story of her arrival in Georgia: a Northerner with Southern roots. However, my family tree has its roots in the South. One of my ancestors was a slave on a Georgia plantation in Milledgeville, a small town northeast of Macon, less than a two-hour drive from Atlanta." A corresponding annotation reads, ancestor was slave. The second paragraph reads, "If you read the biography of my great-grandmother in The Encyclopedia of Arkansas History and Culture, you'll see that her father's name is 'unknown.' ¹ That may be the truth according to the official record, but our family knows who he was. An accompanying annotation reads, Why doesn't she name slave owner? He was the Scotch-Irish man who owned Anne Fambro, my great-great-grandmother. Carrie Lena Fambro was his daughter, born in 1872. When the era of legal slavery came to an end with the Civil War, he provided all of his mixed-race children, I'm told, with a college education." A corresponding annotation reads, Slave owner is father of great-grandmother. The third paragraph reads, "Carrie got a degree from Atlanta University in 1886 and became a fierce advocate for the education of African Americans. A corresponding text reads, Great-grandmother quite an activist. She founded the first library for blacks in the Deep South, using funds raised by staging Shakespeare's plays. She taught at Union School, the first school for black children in Little Rock, Arkansas. These stories are

part of my history; I' ve." A corresponding annotation reads, Ironic."

Why is she telling us these stories?

Is this William Grant Still? Look him up.

Shifts to personal experience. Wow, she punched the kid!

Had to feel angry, frustrated, disappointed to see Georgia's Confederate history celebrated.

children in Little Rock, Arkansas. These stories are part of my history; I've heard them retold many times and I've shared them with my own son.

I also grew up listening to stories about the ways my family has suffered because of racism. When my grandfather was to be awarded an honorary doctorate at Oberlin College, he decided to drive from Los Angeles to Ohio with his whole family. Unfortunately, they weren't allowed to stay at most hotels because he was black, and they couldn't stay at the black hotels because my grandmother was white. So, he drove nearly twenty-four hundred miles without stopping to get to Oberlin.

I'm quite light-skinned, yet I was the second-darkest kid in my elementary school in Southern California. In third grade, one of the other kids called me a "nigger" and I punched him in the eye, without hesitation. I was sent to the principal's office and I still remember how scared I was outside his office. I was a good student and I didn't get in trouble very often. I knew my mother's reaction would be harsh if she had to pick me up from school. But the principal told me that if anyone else called me that word, I should punch them, too. And then he sent me back to class.

Needless to say, moving to Georgia was an emotionally turbulent experience for me. You can imagine my feelings when I discovered that, as a state employee, I got a day off for Robert E. Lee's birthday and another for Confederate Memorial Day. (The latter has since been renamed simply "State Holiday.") And you might be able to understand my reaction as I drove down the highway and saw the Confederate battle flag flying over people's homes.

And yet, when the debate over the battle flag reignited in the wake of the horrific massacre of nine people in the Emanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church in Charleston, South Carolina, my duty as a journalist was to cover the issue. We devoted an entire hour of my radio show to a discussion of that flag, its history and significance. We invited guests to join the debate who believed that the Confederate flag is a symbol of Southern identity and pride and that it should fly freely on government property as a tribute to the heroism of the soldiers who died defending the Confederacy.

4

5

6

7

Description

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "heard them retold many times and I' ve shared them with my own son." A corresponding annotation reads, Why is she telling us these stories? The second paragraph reads,

"I also grew up listening to stories about the ways my family has suffered because of racism. A corresponding annotation reads, Is this William Grant Still? Look him up. When my grandfather was to be awarded an honorary doctorate at Oberlin College, he decided to drive from Los Angeles to Ohio with his whole family. Unfortunately, they weren' t allowed to stay at most hotels because he was black, and they couldn' t stay at the black hotels because my grandmother was white. So, he drove nearly twenty-four hundred miles without stopping to get to Oberlin." A corresponding annotation reads, Reminds me of movie Green Book. The third paragraph reads, "I' m quite light-skinned, yet I was the second-darkest kid in my elementary school in Southern California. In third grade, one of the other kids called me a 'nigger' and I punched him in the eye, without hesitation. I was sent to the principal' s office and I still remember how scared I was outside his office. I was a good student and I didn' t get in trouble very often. I knew my mother' s reaction would be harsh if she had to pick me up from school. But the principal told me that if anyone else called me that word, I should punch them, too. And then he sent me back to class." A corresponding annotation reads, Shifts to personal experience. Wow, she punched the kid! The fourth paragraph reads, "Needless to say, moving to Georgia was an emotionally turbulent experience for me. You can imagine my feelings when I discovered that, as a state employee, I got a day off for Robert E. Lee' s

birthday and another for Confederate Memorial Day. (The latter has since been renamed simply 'State Holiday.') And you might be able to understand my reaction as I drove down the highway and saw the Confederate battle flag flying over people' s homes." A corresponding annotation reads, Had to feel angry, frustrated, disappointed to see Georgia' s Confederate history celebrated. The fifth paragraph reads, "And yet, when the debate over the battle flag reignited in the wake of the horrific massacre of nine people in the Emanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church in Charleston, South Carolina, my duty as a journalist was to cover the issue. We devoted an entire hour of my radio show to a discussion of" "

Took inventory of own opinions and feelings. IMPORTANT!

Oh. Now clear why she shared family history.

Incredible — says a lot about Headlee as a person and as a journalist.

Stays cool — that's key.

Summary shares advice.

I spent some time examining my own thoughts before that show. I knew there was no way that defenders of the flag could possibly understand my emotional reaction to it. They couldn't know my family's history or understand my personal experience. In turn, I had to acknowledge that I couldn't know their history or understand their experience.

I also wanted to be fair to my audience; they deserved to know about any bias I brought to the table. So, at the beginning of that show, I read the following disclaimer:

In the interest of full disclosure, I want to be clear about my perspective on this issue. I'm a mixed-race woman whose ancestors were slaves on a Georgia plantation. I can't pretend that I'm unbiased on the Confederate battle flag, as the flag is a symbol of torture, oppression, and enslavement to me.

However, I'm also a professional journalist and I welcome an open, honest conversation from all sides on the issue. I don't make public policy. My job is to give you all the information and let you decide as objectively as possible. . . . As always, we don't just welcome your comments, we'd love you to enter the conversation with us.

Those interviews were among the hardest I've done in my long career. Some of the things people said were personally hurtful and painful to hear. I was often tempted to argue or interrupt, but I remained professional and curious, and it paid off. I have since had great conversations with members of the Sons of Confederate Veterans. I don't agree with them on this issue, but I understand them better.

Our differing opinions on this one issue of the battle flag didn't interfere with our ability to talk to one another or respect one another, and it doesn't necessarily follow that because we disagree on this, we disagree on everything. Furthermore, our disagreements didn't prevent us from listening to one another. In order to have important conversations, you will sometimes have to check your opinions at the door. There is no belief so strong that it cannot be set aside temporarily in order to learn from someone who disagrees. Don't worry; your beliefs will still be there when you're done.

Description

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "that flag, its history and significance. We invited guests to join the debate who believed that the Confederate flag is a symbol of Southern identity and pride and that it should fly freely on government property as a tribute to the heroism of the soldiers who died defending the Confederacy." The second paragraph reads, "I spent some time examining my own thoughts before that show. I knew there was no way that defenders of the flag could possibly understand my emotional reaction to it. They couldn't know my family's history or understand my personal experience. In turn, I had to acknowledge that I couldn't know their history or understand their experience." A corresponding annotation reads, Took inventory of own opinions and feelings. IMPORTANT! Oh. Now clear why she shared family history. The third paragraph reads, "I also wanted to be fair to my audience; they deserved to know about any bias I brought to the table. So, at the beginning of that show, I read the following disclaimer: In the interest of full disclosure, I want to be clear about my perspective on this issue. I'm a mixed-race woman whose ancestors were slaves on a Georgia plantation. I can't pretend that I'm unbiased on the Confederate battle flag, as the flag is a symbol of torture, oppression, and enslavement to me. However, I'm also a professional journalist and I welcome an open, honest conversation from all sides on the issue. I don't make public policy. My job is to give you all the information and let you decide as objectively as possible... As always, we don't just welcome your comments, we'd love you to enter the conversation with us." A corresponding annotation reads, Incredible — says a lot about Headlee as a person

and as a journalist. The fourth paragraph reads, “Those interviews were among the hardest I’ ve done in my long career. Some of the things people said were personally hurtful and painful to hear. I was often tempted to argue or interrupt, but I remained professional and curious, and it paid off. I have since had great conversations with members of the Sons of Confederate Veterans. I don’ t agree with them on this issue, but I understand them better.” A corresponding annotation reads, Stays cool- that’ s key. ”

The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, “Our differing opinions on this one issue of the battle flag didn’ t interfere with our ability to talk to one another or respect one another, and it doesn’ t necessarily follow that because we disagree on this, we disagree on everything. Furthermore, our disagreements didn’ t prevent us from listening to one another. In order to have important conversations, you will sometimes have to check your opinions at the door. There is no belief so strong that it cannot be set aside temporarily in order to learn from someone who disagrees. Don’ t worry; your beliefs will still be there when you’ re done.” A corresponding annotation reads, Summary Shares advice.

Step 3: Use the Study Questions to Direct Your Second Reading of the Selection

Your second reading should be quite different from the first. You will know what the essay is about, where it is going, and how it gets there. Now you can relate the parts of the essay to the whole. Use your second reading to test your first impressions against the words on the page, developing and deepening your basic understanding of the selection. To this end, we have provided you with a set of Questions for Study and Discussion after each essay in *Models for Writers* to help focus your attention both on the content of the essay and the writer's craft.

As you read Celeste Headlee's essay "Get Off the Soapbox" a second time, use the following set of questions to direct your reading.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Why do you think Headlee thought it was important to tell you about her family's history with slavery, her great grandmother's college education, and her grandfather's honorary degree from Oberlin College?
2. How did Headlee react when another student called her a "nigger" when she was a third grader in a Southern California elementary school (5)? Were you surprised by the principal's response to her? Why or why not?

3. What made Headlee's move to Georgia in 2014 "an emotionally turbulent experience" for her (6)? What do you think her feelings were when she learned what two of Georgia's state holidays celebrated and when she saw Confederate flags flying proudly in people's yards?
4. How did Headlee prepare to host her hour-long show about the Confederate flag in the aftermath of the "horrific massacre" of nine people in the Emanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church in South Carolina, on June 17, 2015 (7)? What guests did she invite to join her in talking about the legacy of the Confederate battle flag?
5. What advice does Headlee give you about having "important conversations" (13)? Do you find her advice helpful? Why or why not?

Step 4: Annotate the Text with Marginal Notes

When you annotate a text, you should do more than simply underline or highlight important points to remember. It is easy to highlight so much that the efforts of your highlighting can become almost meaningless because you forget why you highlighted the passages in the first place. Remember that active readers engage a text through writing. So as you

read, write down your thoughts in the margins or on a separate piece of paper. (See [pp. 42 - 44](#) for Headlee's "Get Off the Soapbox" with student annotations.) Mark the selection's main point when you find it stated directly. Look for the pattern or patterns of development the author uses to explore and support that point, and jot the information down. If you disagree with a statement or conclusion, object in the margin: "No!" If you feel skeptical, indicate that response: "Why?" or "Explain." If you are impressed by an argument or turn of phrase, compliment the writer: "Good point!" Place vertical lines or stars in the margin to indicate important points.

Jot down whatever marginal notes come to mind. Most readers combine brief responses written in the margins with underlining, circling, highlighting, stars, or question marks. Refer to the What to Annotate in a Text box for some suggestions of elements you may want to mark to help you record your responses as you read.

Remember that there are no hard-and-fast rules for which elements you should annotate. Choose a method of annotation that works best for you and that will make sense when you go back to recollect your thoughts and responses to the essay. When annotating a text, don't be timid. Mark up your book as much as you like, or jot down as many responses in your notebook as you think will be helpful. Don't let annotating

become burdensome. A word or phrase is usually as good as a sentence. One helpful way to focus your annotations is to ask yourself questions as you read the selection a second time.

What to Annotate in a Text

- Memorable statements of important points
- Key terms or concepts
- Central issues or themes
- Examples that support a main point
- Unfamiliar words
- Questions you have about a point or passage
- Your response to a specific point or passage

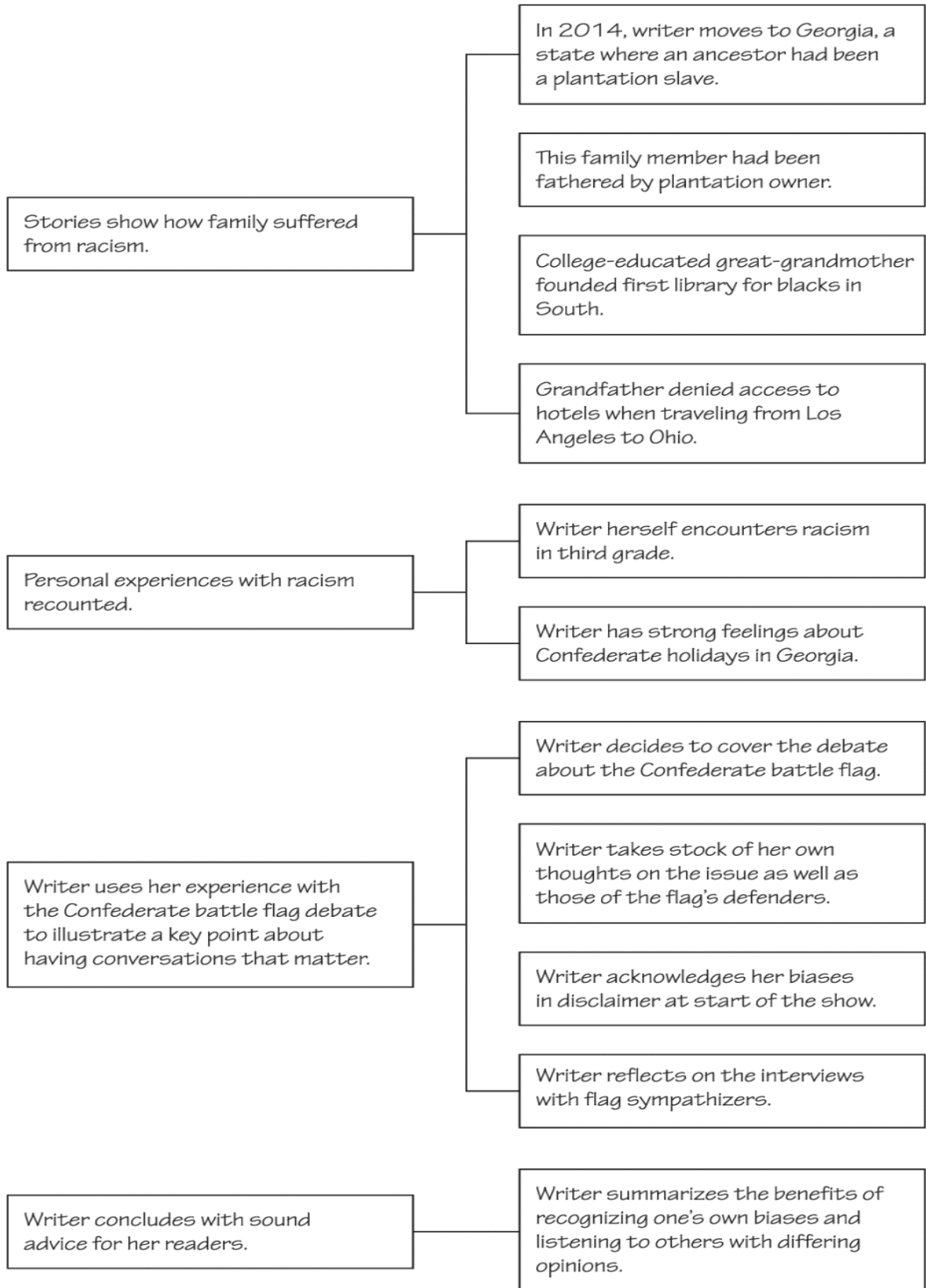
Step 5: Outline and Summarize the Selection to Check Your Understanding of It

One good way both to remember what you have read and to see how the writer's ideas are connected is to outline the selection. An outline helps you visualize the writer's organization and argument. Start by reviewing your annotations. One student's outline for Headlee's "Get Off the Soapbox" appears on [page 48](#).

Another good way to make sure that you have a solid understanding of what the writer has said is to paraphrase — that is, put into your own words — one of the more complicated paragraphs or to summarize the whole essay into a single paragraph. When you paraphrase material, your intent is to restate the information in your own words. Unlike a summary, which gives a brief overview of the essential information in the original, a paraphrase seeks to maintain the same level of detail as the original. Your paraphrase should closely parallel the presentation of ideas in the original, but it should not use the same words or sentence structure as the original. Being able to capture the writer's meaning in your own words demonstrates that you have internalized the material. Here's one student's paraphrase of Headlee's fifth paragraph:

Although Celeste Headlee was not particularly dark-skinned, she did stand out in her third grade class. That year a classmate called her the n-word. Instinctively, she hit him squarely in the eye. This incident landed Headlee in the principal's office. Terrified, she sat thinking about what her mother would say and do if she had to come after her. The principal surprised Headlee with his reaction. Without a second thought, he instructed her to do the same thing the next time a kid used that word. Then she was free to return to her classroom.

Get Off the Soapbox



Rosa Eschholz, Models for Writers, 14e, © 2021 Bedford/St. Martin's

Description

"The flow diagram has four levels which further branches into several sub-levels. The first level reads, Stories show how family suffered from racism. The respective sub-levels are as follows: In 2014, writer moves to Georgia, a state where an ancestor had been a plantation slave, This family member had been fathered by plantation owner, College-educated great-grandmother founded first library for blacks in South, and Grandfather denied access to hotels when traveling from Los Angeles to Ohio. The second level reads, Personal experiences with racism recounted. The respective sub-level is as follows: Writer herself encounters racism in third grade and Writer has strong feelings about Confederate holidays in Georgia. The third level reads, Writer uses her experience with the Confederate battle flag debate to illustrate a key point about having conversations that matter. The respective sub-levels are as follows: Writer decides to cover the debate about the Confederate battle flag, Writer takes stock of her own thoughts on the issue as well as those of the flag's defenders, Writer acknowledges her biases in disclaimer at start of the show, Writer reflects on the interviews with flag sympathizers. The fourth level reads, Writer concludes with sound advice for her readers. The respective sub-level reads, Writer summarizes the benefits of recognizing one's own biases and listening to others with differing opinions."

When you summarize an essay, your intent is to capture in condensed form the essential idea of the whole piece. A good place to start a summary is with a sentence that presents the

writer’ s thesis in your own words. Next, present the writer’ s important supporting ideas in the order in which they appear in the essay. Here is a summary of Headlee’ s whole essay written by the same student who wrote the paraphrase:

In “Get Off the Soapbox,” Celeste Headlee believes that in order have meaningful conversations with people with different views we all have to keep our beliefs and opinions in check so that we can truly listen to one another. Headlee establishes her family’ s history of living in a racist world by recounting the stories of her great-great-grandmother, her great-grandmother, and her grandfather. She continues this story to the present day with several racial experiences from her own life. Against this backdrop, Headlee relates her struggle with how to best report the controversial debate over the Confederate battle flag. In order to be true to herself, to her audience, and to the people whose views differed from hers, she had to acknowledge her own biases as a mixed-race woman living in Georgia. From this experience, Headlee learned that thoughtful listening had the power to bring people to understand one another better in spite of their differing opinions.

✓ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Active Reading

READING CRITICALLY: TAKING YOUR ANALYSIS TO THE NEXT LEVEL

Now that you have a basic knowledge of what the essay is about, you can begin to probe for a deeper understanding of what the writer has done. Focus your attention by asking some questions such as those in the Guidelines for Critical Reading box.

Guidelines for Critical Reading

1. What does the writer want to say? What is the writer's thesis?
2. Why does the writer want to make this point? What is the writer's purpose?
3. Does the writer take a position on the subject and adequately support it? Is the evidence sound, or is it vague or anecdotal? Does the writer take an opposing point of view into account?
4. What is the writer's tone? Is this tone appropriate for the subject?
5. Does the writer make any assumptions about the subject or audience? Are the writer's assumptions reasonable? Does the writer have a discernible bias?

6. How effective is the essay? Does the writer make his or her points clearly?

Each essay in *Models for Writers* is followed by a set of three Questions for Critical Reading that are specific to the essay. Here, for example, are the questions that accompany the Headlee reading:

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What is Headlee' s purpose in writing this essay? (Glossary: [Purpose](#)) Do you think that she accomplished her purpose? Explain.
2. In her “disclaimer,” Headlee says, “I can’ t pretend that I’ m unbiased on the Confederate battle flag, as the flag is a symbol of torture, oppression, and enslavement to me” (10). As a journalist, why was it important that Headlee read her “disclaimer” at the beginning of the show? How well did she prepare her readers for this disclosure?
3. What assumptions does Headlee make about the nature of a conversation? In what ways is a conversation different from a debate? An argument? A discussion?

As you review and reflect on the essay, look for details that will support your answers to these questions, and then answer

the questions as fully as you can.

Now let's take a closer look at each of the six critical reading questions listed previously and discuss the skills associated with each. We will continue to use Celeste Headlee's essay "Get Off the Soapbox" for this deeper analysis and evaluation.

Identifying the Thesis

The thesis is the main idea of the essay, and it is often expressed in a one- or two-sentence statement. The thesis statement literally controls the content of the essay. While most writers usually present the thesis in the opening paragraph or two of an essay, some writers will put off presenting the thesis statement to later in the essay on purpose. (For more information on thesis, see [Chapter 3](#).)

Celeste Headlee makes an unconventional choice: she waits until her final paragraph to dramatically present her two-sentence thesis statement. Speaking directly to her readers, she says, "In order to have important conversations, you will sometimes have to check your opinions at the door. There is no belief so strong that it cannot be set aside temporarily in order to learn from someone who disagrees." What a way to end an essay; her thesis statement really packs

a wallop! It is more common, however, for a writer to present his or her thesis statement early in an essay, because doing so can help signal to readers what the essay will be about.

Identifying the Purpose

Every writer writes with purpose. They all want to accomplish something in a piece of writing. While the thesis is a statement of what the writer wants to say, the purpose is the reason *why* the writer wants to make this point. Purposeful writers tell stories; describe people, places, or things; inform or explain processes, differences, meanings, and cause and effect relationships; and argue or persuade readers to adopt positions or to take courses of action.

Headlee's title, "Get Off the Soapbox," is a command, which suggests that her purpose is to persuade her readers to do something or change their behavior. Indeed, in the main body of her essay, Headlee first explains how she prepares to have important conversations about controversial issues. Then, having done so, she tries to persuade readers to change their behavior so that they, too, can have conversations that matter.

Evaluating Evidence

Writers use evidence to support their theses and other points that they make. Widely used types of evidence include personal experiences, anecdotes, facts, statistics and data, surveys, news reports, eyewitness reports, quotations from authorities, and illustrative examples. Writers use evidence to build arguments or establish proof. They also use evidence to counter opposing points of view.

Critical readers are careful to question evidence. They want to know its source, appropriateness, and verifiability. In order to determine whether a writer has supported a claim with sufficient evidence, you must recognize the difference between a fact and an opinion. Facts are things that are true, things that have occurred, and things that have been proven correct. They are objective information; facts can be checked in reliable books and online sources. Opinions, on the other hand, are subjective and are frequently based on the feelings or beliefs of individual people, which cannot be established as either true or false.

Fact: Driving while intoxicated causes many deaths annually.

Opinion: Consuming alcoholic beverages is a poor lifestyle choice.

For more information on evidence and examples, see [Chapter 14](#) and [Chapter 22](#).

Celeste Headlee uses a number of different types of evidence in her essay. To tell of her family's history with racism, she uses facts from *The Encyclopedia of Arkansas History and Culture*: that her great-great-grandmother, Anne Fambro, was a slave in Georgia and that her great-grandmother was fathered by the Scotch-Irish man who owned Fambro. The story about her grandfather's experience while driving from Los Angeles to Ohio is part family oral history and part fact. William Grant Still did, in fact, receive an honorary doctorate from Oberlin College. Headlee then uses personal experience to illustrate her own encounters with racism, first as a student in third grade and then as an employee of the state of Georgia. The two state holidays — Robert E. Lee's birthday and Confederate Memorial Day — that she found offensive are indeed real holidays.

Having established the fact that she and her family had suffered the indignities of racism, Headlee proceeds to use the example of the debate over the Confederate battle flag to show how people can have conversations that matter. It is public record that there was a "horrific massacre of nine people in the Emanuel African Methodist Episcopal Church in Charleston" (7) and that Headlee devoted her one-hour show, *On Second Thought*, to a discussion of the Confederate flag with ardent defenders of the flag. You can go to the archives of Georgia Public Broadcasting to listen to her read the disclaimer she quotes in her essay, as well as to the

“personally hurtful and painful” things she heard while maintaining her journalistic professionalism.

Instead of entering into a debate with the defenders of the flag, which could have ended up in a shouting match, Headlee chose to show them that it is possible to have a conversation and come to a better understanding of each other in spite of their differing views on the flag. At this point, Headlee makes an inductive leap from her evidence to her conclusion so eloquently stated in her final paragraph. (For additional information on inductive and deductive reasoning, see [p. 524 in Chapter 22.](#))

Identifying Tone

Tone is the manner in which a writer relates to an audience. A writer’s tone may be friendly, serious, detached, arrogant, humorous, frustrated, cheerful, bitter, cynical, enthusiastic, morbid, resentful, compassionate, warm, playful, or indignant, for example. A writer creates a particular tone by selecting words with appropriate connotations, using effective figures of speech, and employing appropriate sentence patterns. Tone is also influenced by the writer’s purpose and viewpoint or attitude toward the subject. For more information on diction and tone, see [Chapter 12.](#)

While Headlee's title suggests a no-nonsense, serious attitude toward her readers and her subject matter, that feeling doesn't last long. In her opening paragraph, she uses a conversational tone: you get the feeling that someone is talking to you. She's telling her story using the first-person pronoun *I*. Her easy, informal language and use of contractions — “I'd,” “put down stakes,” “family tree,” “roots,” and “two-hour drive” — prepare us for her warm, friendly tone even as she recounts her family's history with slavery and racial discrimination.

Headlee handles her own encounters with racism with a calm, matter-of-fact tone, which supports her argument that we all can have better conversations when we let go of the emotional energy that accompanies many controversial issues. Her handling of the Confederate flag controversy is a wonderful case in point. As she says, “I was often tempted to argue or interrupt, but I remained professional and curious, and it paid off” (12). Her low-key, conversational tone is perfect for her subject and audience; after all, Headlee wants to help people have “important conversations.”

Identifying Assumptions and Biases

In an effort to keep their writing concise and to the point, writers often make assumptions. They will present ideas, concepts, or principles as things that are accepted as true or as certain to happen without question or proof. While many assumptions are commonsense and reasonable, others are questionable. And it's your job as a critical reader to identify the writer's assumptions and to analyze whether or not they are fair. For example, most people would agree that it's reasonable to assume that people who go hiking like adventure and the great outdoors. However, it would not be reasonable to assume that hikers are millennials. More often than not, assumptions are presented implicitly, sometimes making detection difficult. When a writer bases his or her argument on an unreasonable, questionable, or misleading assumption, the writer's whole argument should be called to question.

After Tamara, a student, read Headlee's "Get Off the Soapbox," she identified three assumptions that Headlee makes:

1. The writer assumes that her readers will be sympathetic to the emotions and feelings surrounding the racial indignities that she and her family suffered.
2. The writer assumes that as a professional journalist, her "job is to give you [readers] all the information and let you decide as objectively as possible" (11).

3. The writer assumes that readers want to learn how to have conversations that matter.

Tamara thought that all three assumptions were reasonable and let Headlee get on with the main thrust of her essay.

When you analyze an essay to see what assumptions the writer has made, see if you can determine whether or not the writer has any discernable bias — perhaps a cultural, political, religious, or gender bias. In what ways, if any, does the writer's bias color his or her claims or evidence? Be careful not to become too absorbed in an essay that supports or aligns with your own beliefs. Check to see that the writer considers the merits of alternate points of view. Use the headnote that accompanies each article in *Models for Writers* to find out information about the author. Such information will help you determine the writer's authority on the issue. Is the writer associated with a special interest group, such as the American Medical Association, the National Organization for Women, The American Spectator, the Media Research Center, National Public Radio, the National Rifle Association, Amnesty International, Planned Parenthood, the NAACP, Black Lives Matter, or Project for the New American Century?

One student, Rishabh, was at first surprised about how open Celeste Headlee was about her biases — but then he realized

that openness was one of the central points of her essay. Headlee readily admits that she's a "mixed-race woman" who finds the Confederate battle flag "a symbol of torture, oppression, and enslavement" (10) in order to encourage her readers to similarly examine our own thoughts, beliefs, and biases before trying to have a meaningful conversation, especially with people who hold opposing views. Rishabh remembered reading in the headnote to this essay that Headlee had worked for National Public Radio and is currently working for NPR affiliate Georgia Public Broadcasting, two liberal-leaning organizations. He was impressed that even though Headlee's experiences and views differed from those of the folks who defended the Confederate flag, she was able not only to have "great conversations" with them but also to "understand them better" (12).

Evaluating the Overall Effectiveness of an Essay

When evaluating the overall effectiveness of an essay, you need to review everything that went into your critical analysis of the selection. Did the writer have a strong thesis — something worthwhile to say? Did the writer make his or her points clearly, and did he or she persuade the reader to accept them? That is, did the writer achieve his or her purpose? In the process of answering these questions, you

will need to consider whether or not the writer's tone and diction were appropriate given the writer's subject, audience, and purpose.

Headlee's essay serves her purpose extremely well. She prepares her readers with her family background so that they can understand and sympathize with the personal struggles she went through as a journalist reporting on the Confederate battle flag controversy. Headlee shares with her readers how she had to bite her tongue and not interrupt her guests in order to get the whole story out to her listening audience. In her concluding paragraph, she tells readers what she learned about facilitating the talks we all need to have. In her final three sentences, she brings her essay full circle. In challenging readers to get off their soapboxes and check their opinions and beliefs at the door, she reveals the secret ingredient in all good conversations. And she's careful to reassure us that "your beliefs will still be there when you're done" (13).

FROM READING TO WRITING

As we move from reading what other people have written to creating our own writing, we encourage you to think about your audience, your readers. Now that you've learned how to read as a writer, you can write with a reader's insights.

Reading as a Writer

What does it mean to read as a writer? As mentioned earlier, most of us have not been taught to read with a writer's eye, to ask why we like one piece of writing and not another. Similarly, most of us do not ask ourselves why one piece of writing is more convincing than another. When you learn to read with a writer's eye, you begin to answer these important questions. You read beyond the content to see how certain aspects of the writing itself affect you. You come to appreciate what is involved in selecting and focusing on a subject as well as the craftsmanship involved in writing: how a writer selects descriptive details, uses an unobtrusive organizational pattern, opts for fresh and lively language, chooses representative and persuasive examples, and emphasizes important points with sentence variety. You come to see writing as a series of decisions the writer makes.

On one level, reading stimulates your thinking by providing you with subjects to write about. For example, after reading Helen Keller' s "The Most Important Day," you might take up your pen to write about a turning point in your life. Or by reading Mia Schon' s "Look It Up!" and Thomas L. Friedman' s "My Favorite Teacher," you might see how each of these writers creates a dominant impression of an influential person in his or her life, leading you to write about an influential person in your own life.

On a second level, reading provides you with information, ideas, and perspectives for developing your own essay. In this way, you respond to what you read, using material from what you' ve read in your essay. For example, after reading Dan M. Kahan' s essay "Shame Is Worth a Try," you might want to elaborate on what he has written and either agree with his examples or generate some of your own. You could also qualify his argument or take issue with it. Similarly, if you want to write about the effects of new technologies and engineering on our health and well-being, you will find Julie Zhuo' s "Where Anonymity Breeds Contempt" and Markham Heid' s "We Need to Talk About Kids and Smartphones" invaluable resources.

On a third level, critical reading can increase your awareness of how others' writing affects you, thus making you more sensitive to how your own writing will affect your

readers. For example, if you have ever been impressed by an author who uses convincing evidence to support each of his or her claims, you might be more likely to back up your own claims carefully. If you have been impressed by an apt turn of phrase or absorbed by a writer's new idea, you may be less inclined to feed your readers dull, worn-out, and trite phrases.

More to the point, however, the critical reading that you are encouraged to do in *Models for Writers* will help you recognize and analyze the essential elements of the essay. When you see, for example, how a writer such as Julie Zhuo uses a strong thesis statement to control the parts of her essay calling for the elimination of anonymous comments on the internet, you can better appreciate what a clear thesis statement is and see the importance of having one in your essay. When you see the way Dan Shaughnessy uses transitions to link key phrases and important ideas so that readers can clearly recognize how the parts of her essay are meant to flow together, you have a better idea of how to achieve such coherence in your own writing. And when you see how Martin Luther King Jr. divides the ways in which people characteristically respond to oppression into three distinct categories, you witness a powerful way in which you, too, can organize an essay using division and classification.

Another important reason, then, to master the skills of critical reading is that for everything you write, you will be your own first reader and critic. How well you are able to scrutinize your own drafts will powerfully affect how well you revise them. Revising well is crucial to writing well. So reading others' writing with a critical eye is a useful and important practice; the more you read, the more skilled you will become at seeing the rhetorical options available to you and making conscious choices in your own writing.

To help you make the transition from reading to writing, we have included a Classroom Activity (a brief exercise that focuses on a rhetorical strategy or technique) and two Suggested Writing Assignments for each selection in *Models for Writers*.

COMPLETE THE CLASSROOM ACTIVITY TO LEARN RHETORICAL STRATEGIES AND TECHNIQUES

Each activity in this book enables you and your classmates to work on rhetorical strategies, elements, techniques, and patterns. The activities are intended to be done in class and should last no longer than fifteen or twenty minutes. Your instructor may want you to prepare a bit the night before class. These activities range from developing strong thesis

statements to using active verbs and building compelling argumentative evidence. In addition, the activities encourage you to apply writing concepts modeled in the readings to your own writing.

Here is the Classroom Activity for “Get Off the Soapbox” by Celeste Headlee.

Classroom Activity Using Argument

When writing an argument, it is important that we do not use faulty reasoning. Identify the fallacy in each of the following statements. (For more information on logical fallacies, see [the Logical Fallacies box](#) on pp. 527 – 28.)

- a. Oversimplification
 - b. Hasty generalization
 - c. Post hoc, ergo propter hoc
 - d. Begging the question
 - e. False analogy
 - f. Either/or thinking
 - g. Non sequitur
-
- 1. America: Love it, or leave it.
 - 2. Two of my best friends who are overweight don’ t exercise at all. Overweight people are simply not getting enough exercise.

3. If we use less gasoline, the price of gasoline will fall.
4. Life is precious because we want to protect it at all costs.
5. Randy is a good mechanic, so he' ll be a good racecar driver.
6. Susan drank hot lemonade and her cold went away.
7. Students do poorly in college because they do too much surfing on the internet.
8. If we can eliminate pollution, we can cure cancer.
9. Sexual harassment is wrong because people should always treat each other respectfully.
10. Every time I have something important to do on my computer, it crashes.
11. We should either raise taxes or cut social programs.
12. Education ought to be managed just as a good business is managed.

Discuss your answers with your classmates. Be prepared to explain the faulty reasoning underlying each statement.

Here are the answers, together with brief explanations, that one of our students came up with for this classroom activity:

1. either/or thinking (Certainly there are more than two alternatives.)

2. hasty generalization (A general conclusion cannot be based on the sole example of two friends.)
3. post hoc, ergo propter hoc (The fact that one thing follows another does not allow one to speculate causation.)
4. begging the question (One cannot assume in a premise what needs to be proven.)
5. non sequitur (Just because a person is a good mechanic does not mean that he will be good racecar driver.)
6. post hoc, ergo propter hoc (There' s no proof that the hot lemonade cured Susan' s cold.)
7. oversimplification (Surely the issue of poor student performance in college is more complicated than "surfing the internet.")
8. false analogy (The ability to eliminate pollution does not predict or serve as proof one' s ability to cure cancer.)
9. begging the question (Although most of us will agree with the conclusion here that sexual harassment is wrong, this conclusion is based on a premise that needs to be supported.)
10. post hoc, ergo propter hoc (No causal relationship exists between important work and computer crashes.)
11. either/or thinking (There have to be more than two options.)
12. false analogy (Writer assumes that education and business have much in common, but there are important dissimilarities.)

USE THE SUGGESTED WRITING ASSIGNMENTS TO CRAFT AN ESSAY OF YOUR OWN

The two writing assignments that accompany each selection in this text provide you with several starting points to begin developing your own piece of writing. Often these assignments are of two types: one type of assignment will ask you to use the reading selection as a direct rhetorical model, while the other type will encourage you to respond to the content of the reading or even to expand upon the topic to include personal experience or outside research. Here, for example, are the two assignments that accompany Headlee's essay "Get Off the Soapbox."

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. One of the latest buzzwords in the world of news, politics, and social media is "conversation." Newscasters, politicians, and educators tell us that we "need to have a conversation" about this or that hot-button issue. Yet we seem to be living in a culture where real conversations do not happen. Do you find it uncomfortable to have conversation about difficult issues or topics? Why do you think people find it difficult to talk with one another, so difficult that Celeste Headlee felt the need to write

a book entitled *We Need to Talk: How to Have Conversations That Matter*? Write an essay in which you explore why you think having meaningful conversations is so difficult. What solutions can you offer?

2. Identify a hot-button issue — for example, immigration, racism, taxes, abortion, or socialism — that you'd like to discuss. Where do you stand on this issue? What evidence do you have to support your position? Do you have any biases about the topic? What opposing arguments do you need to address? Following Celeste Headlee's example, write a balanced argument in which you present your position on the issue you selected and address the concerns of the opposition.

WRITING FROM READING: A SAMPLE STUDENT ESSAY

For an assignment following James Lincoln Collier's essay ["Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name"](#) (p. 73), student writer Zoe Ockenga tackled the topic of anxiety. In her first draft, she explored how anxious she felt the night before her first speech in a public speaking class and how in confronting that anxiety she benefited from the course. Ockenga read her essay aloud in class, and other students had an opportunity to ask her questions and to offer constructive criticism. Several students suggested that she might want to relate her experiences to those that Collier recounts in his essay. Another asked if she could include other examples to bolster the point she wanted to make. This question triggered Ockenga's memory of a phone conversation she had with her mother regarding her mother's indecision about accepting a new job. The thought of working outside the home for the first time in more than twenty years brought out her mother's worst fears and threatened to keep her from accepting the challenge. Armed with these valuable suggestions and ideas, Ockenga began revising. In subsequent drafts, she worked on the Collier connection, actually citing his essay on several occasions, and developed the example of the anxiety surrounding her mother's decision. What follows

is the final draft of her essay, which incorporates the changes she made based on the peer evaluation of her first draft.

Zoe Ockenga

Title: indicates main idea of the essay

The Excuse "Not To"

Beginning: captures readers' attention with personal experience most college students can relate to

I cannot imagine anything worse than the nervous, anxious feeling I got the night before my first speech in public speaking class last spring semester. The knots in my stomach were so fierce that I racked my brain for an excuse to give the teacher so that I would not have to go through with the dreaded assignment. Once in bed, I lay awake thinking of all the mistakes that I might make while standing alone in front of my classmates. I spent the rest of the night tossing and turning, frustrated that now, on top of my panic, I would have to give my speech with huge bags under my eyes.

Thesis

Anxiety is an intense emotion that can strike at any time or place, before a simple daily activity or a life-changing decision. For some people, anxiety is only a minor interference in the process of achieving a goal. For others, it can be a force that is impossible to overcome. In these instances, anxiety can prevent the accomplishment of lifelong hopes and dreams. Avoiding the causes of stress or fear can make us feel secure and safe. Avoiding anxiety, however, may mean forfeiting a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity. Confronting anxiety can make for a richer, more fulfilling existence.

Description

"The title reads, "The Excuse 'Not To' ." A corresponding annotation reads, Title: indicates main idea of the essay. The first paragraph reads, "I cannot imagine anything worse than the nervous, anxious feeling I got the night before my first speech in public speaking class last spring semester. The knots in my stomach were so fierce that I racked my brain for an excuse to give the teacher so that I would not have to go through with the dreaded assignment. Once in bed, I lay awake thinking of all the mistakes that I might make while standing alone in front of my classmates. I spent the rest of the night tossing and turning, frustrated that now, on top of my panic, I would have to give my speech with huge bags under my eyes." A corresponding annotation reads, Beginning: captures readers' attention with personal experience most college students can relate to. The second paragraph reads, "Anxiety is an intense emotion that can strike at any time or place, before a simple daily activity or a life-changing decision. For some people, anxiety is only a minor interference in the process of achieving a goal. For others, it can be a force that is impossible to overcome. In these instances, anxiety can prevent the accomplishment of lifelong hopes and dreams. Avoiding the causes of stress or fear can make us feel secure and safe. Avoiding anxiety, however, may mean forfeiting a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity. Confronting anxiety can make for a richer, more fulfilling existence." A corresponding annotation reads, Thesis."

First example:
continues
story intro-
duced in open-
ing paragraph
to support
thesis

The next day I trudged to class and sat on the edge of my seat until I could not stand the tension any longer. At this point, I forced myself to raise my hand to volunteer to go next simply to end my suffering. As I walked to the front of the room and assumed my position at the podium, the faces of the twenty-five classmates I had been sitting beside a minute ago suddenly seemed like fifty. I probably fumbled over a word or two as I discussed the harmful aspects of animal testing, but my mistakes were not nearly as severe as I had imagined the night before. Less than five minutes later the whole nightmare was over, and it had been much less painful than I had anticipated. As I sat down with a huge sigh of relief to listen to the next victim stumble repeatedly over how to milk dairy cows, I realized that I had not been half bad.

Although I still dreaded giving the next series of speeches, I eventually became more accustomed to speaking in front of my peers. I would still have to force myself to volunteer, secretly hoping the teacher would forget about me, but the audience that once seemed large and forbidding eventually became much more human. A speech class is something that I would never have taken if it had not been a requirement, but I can honestly say that I am better off because of it. I was forced to grapple with my anxiety and in the process became a stronger, more self-confident individual. Before this class I had been able to hide out in large lectures, never offering any comments or insights. For the first time at college I was forced to participate, and I realized that I could speak effectively in front of strangers and, more important, that I had something to say.

Second
example:
cites essay
from *Models
for Writers*
to support
thesis

The insomnia-inducing anticipation of giving a speech was a type of anxiety that I had to overcome to meet my distribution requirements for graduation. In the essay "Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name" by James Lincoln Collier, the author tells of his own struggles with anxiety. He tells of

Description

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "The next day I trudged to class and sat on the edge of my seat until I could not stand the tension any longer. At this point, I forced myself to raise my hand to volunteer to go next simply to end my suffering. As I walked to the front of the room and assumed my position at the podium, the faces of the twenty-five classmates I had been sitting beside a minute ago suddenly seemed like fifty. I probably fumbled over a word or two as I discussed the harmful aspects of animal testing, but my mistakes were not nearly as severe as I had imagined the night before. Less than five minutes later the whole nightmare was over, and it had been much less painful than I had anticipated. As I sat down with a huge sigh of relief to listen to the next victim stumble repeatedly over how to milk dairy cows, I realized that I had not been half bad." A corresponding annotation reads, First example: continues story introduced in opening paragraph to support thesis. The second paragraph reads,

"Although I still dreaded giving the next series of speeches, I eventually became more accustomed to speaking in front of my peers. I would still have to force myself to volunteer, secretly hoping the teacher would forget about me, but the audience that once seemed large and forbidding eventually became much more human. A speech class is something that I would never have taken if it had not been a requirement, but I can honestly say that I am better off because of it. I was forced to grapple with my anxiety and in the process became a stronger, more self-confident individual. Before this class I had been able to hide out in large lectures, never offering any comments or insights. For the first time at college I was forced to participate, and I

realized that I could speak effectively in front of strangers and, more important, that I had something to say.” The third paragraph reads, The insomnia-inducing anticipation of giving a speech was a type of anxiety that I had to overcome to meet my distribution requirements for graduation. In the essay ‘Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name’ by James Lincoln Collier, the author tells of his own struggles with anxiety. He tells of. A corresponding annotation reads, Second example: cites essay from Models for Writers to support thesis.”

one particular event that happened between his sophomore and junior years in college when he was asked to spend a summer in Argentina with a good friend. He writes about how he felt after he made his decision not to go:

Block quote in
MLA style

I had turned down something I wanted to do because I was scared, and had ended up feeling depressed. I stayed that way for a long time. And it didn't help when I went back to college in the fall to discover that Ted and his friend had had a terrific time. (74)

The proposition of going to Argentina was an extremely difficult choice for Collier, as it meant abandoning the comfortable routine of the past and venturing completely out of his element. Although the idea of the trip was exciting, the author could not bring himself to choose the summer in Argentina because of his uncertainties.

The summer abroad that Collier denied himself in his early twenties left him with such a feeling of regret that he vowed to change his approach to life. From then on, he faced challenges that made him uncomfortable and was able to accomplish feats he would never have dreamed possible — interviewing celebrities, traveling extensively throughout Europe, parachuting, and even learning to ski at age forty. Collier emphasizes that he was able to make his life fulfilling and exciting by adhering to his belief that anxiety cannot be stifled by avoidance; it can be stifled only by confrontation (76).

Third example:
introduces
mother's
dilemma

Anxiety prevents many individuals from accepting life's challenges and changes. My own mother is currently struggling with such a dilemma. At age fifty-three, having never had a career outside the home, my mother has been recommended to manage a new art gallery. The River Gallery, as it will be called, will be opening in our town of Ipswich, Massachusetts, this spring. An avid collector and art lover as well as a budding potter, my mother would, I believe, be exceptional at this job.

Description

The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, “one particular event that happened between his sophomore and junior years in college when he was asked to spend a summer in Argentina with a good friend. He writes about how he felt after he made his decision not to go:

I had turned down something I wanted to do because I was scared, and had ended up feeling depressed. I stayed that way for a long time. And it didn’ t help when I went back to college in the fall to discover that Ted and his friend had had a terrific time. (74)” A corresponding annotation reads, Block quote in M L A style.

The second paragraph reads, “The proposition of going to Argentina was an extremely difficult choice for Collier, as it meant abandoning the comfortable routine of the past and venturing completely out of his element. Although the idea of the trip was exciting, the author could not bring himself to choose the summer in Argentina because of his uncertainties.”

The third paragraph reads, “The summer abroad that Collier denied himself in his early twenties left him with such a feeling of regret that he vowed to change his approach to life. From then on, he faced challenges that made him uncomfortable and was able to accomplish feats he would never have dreamed possible — interviewing celebrities, traveling extensively throughout Europe, parachuting, and even learning to ski at age forty. Collier emphasizes that he was able to make his life fulfilling and exciting by adhering to his belief that anxiety cannot be stifled by avoidance; it can be stifled only by confrontation (76).”

The fourth paragraph reads, “Anxiety prevents many individuals from accepting life’s challenges and changes. My own mother is currently struggling with such a dilemma. At age fifty-three, having never had a career outside the home, my mother has been recommended to manage a new art gallery. The River Gallery, as it will be called, will be opening in our town of Ipswich, Massachusetts, this spring. An avid collector and art lover as well as a budding potter, my mother would, I believe, be exceptional at this job.” A corresponding annotation reads, Third example: introduces mother’s dilemma.

Anticipating this new opportunity and responsibility has caused my mother great anxiety. Reentering the workforce after over twenty years is as frightening for my mother as the trip to Argentina was for Collier. When I recently discussed the job prospect with my mother, she was negative and full of doubt. "There's no way I could ever handle such a responsibility," she commented. "I have no business experience. I would look like a fool if I actually tried to pull something like this off. Besides, I'm sure the artists would never take me seriously." Just as my mother focused on all the possible negative aspects of the opportunity in front of her, Collier questioned the value of his opportunity to spend a summer abroad. He describes having second thoughts about just how exciting the trip would be:

Quotation:
quotes Collier
to help explain
mother's
indecision

I had never been very far from New England, and I had been homesick my first few weeks at college. What would it be like in a strange country? What about the language? And besides, I had promised to teach my younger brother to sail that summer. (74)

Focusing on all the possible problems accompanying a new opportunity can arouse such a sense of fear that it can overpower the ability to take a risk. Both my mother and Collier found out that dwelling on possible negative outcomes allowed them to ignore the benefits of a new experience and thus maintain their safe current situations.

Currently my mother is using anxiety as an excuse "not to" act. To confront her anxiety and take an opportunity in which there is a possibility of failure as well as success is a true risk. Regardless of the outcome, to even contemplate a new challenge has changed her life. The summer forgone by Collier roused him to never again pass up an exciting opportunity and thus to live his life to the fullest. Just the thought of taking the gallery position has prompted my mother to contemplate taking evening classes so that if she refuses the offer she

Description

The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, “Anticipating this new opportunity and responsibility has caused my mother great anxiety. Reentering the workforce after over twenty years is as frightening for my mother as the trip to Argentina was for Collier. When I recently discussed the job prospect with my mother, she was negative and full of doubt. ‘There’ s no way I could ever handle such a responsibility,’ she commented. “I have no business experience. I would look like a fool if I actually tried to pull something like this off. Besides, I’ m sure the artists would never take me seriously.” Just as my mother focused on all the possible negative aspects of the opportunity in front of her, Collier questioned the value of his opportunity to spend a summer abroad. He describes having second thoughts about just how exciting the trip would be:

I had never been very far from New England, and I had been homesick my first few weeks at college. What would it be like in a strange country? What about the language? And besides, I had promised to teach my younger brother to sail that summer. (74) A corresponding annotation reads, Quotation: quotes Collier to help explain mother’ s indecision.

The second paragraph reads, “Focusing on all the possible problems accompanying a new opportunity can arouse such a sense of fear that it can overpower the ability to take a risk. Both my mother and Collier found out that dwelling on possible negative outcomes allowed them to ignore the benefits of a new experience and thus maintain their safe current situations.”

The third paragraph reads, “Currently my mother is using anxiety as an excuse ‘not to’ act. To confront her anxiety and take an opportunity in which there is a possibility of failure as well as success is a true risk. Regardless of the outcome, to even contemplate a new challenge has changed her life. The summer forgone by Collier roused him to never again pass up an exciting opportunity and thus to live his life to the fullest. Just the thought of taking the gallery position has prompted my mother to contemplate taking evening classes so that if she refuses the offer she”

may be better prepared for a similar challenge in the future. Although her decision is unresolved, her anxiety has made her realize the possibilities that may be opening for her, whether or not she chooses to take them. If in the end her answer is no, I believe that a lingering “What if?” feeling will cause her to reevaluate her expectations and goals for the future.

Conclusion:
includes
strong
statement
about anxiety
that echoes
optimism of
thesis

Anxiety can create confidence and optimism or depression, low self-esteem, and regret. The outcome of anxiety is entirely dependent on whether the individual runs from it or embraces it. Some forms of anxiety can be conquered merely by repeating the activity that causes them, such as giving speeches in a public speaking class. Anxiety brought on by unique opportunities or life-changing decisions, such as a summer in a foreign country or a new career, must be harnessed. Opportunities forgone due to anxiety and fear could be the chances of a lifetime. Although the unpleasant feelings that may accompany anxiety may make it initially easier to do nothing, the road not taken will never be forgotten. Anxiety is essentially a blessing in disguise. It is a physical and emotional trigger that tells us when and where there is an opportunity for us to grow and become stronger human beings.

MLA-style
works cited
list

Works Cited

Collier, James Lincoln. “Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name.” *Models for Writers*, edited by Alfred Rosa and Paul Eschholz, 14th ed., Bedford/St. Martin’s, 2021, pp. 73-76.

Description

The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, “may be better prepared for a similar challenge in

the future. Although her decision is unresolved, her anxiety has made her realize the possibilities that may be opening for her, whether or not she chooses to take them. If in the end her answer is no, I believe that a lingering ‘What if?’ feeling will cause her to reevaluate her expectations and goals for the future.”

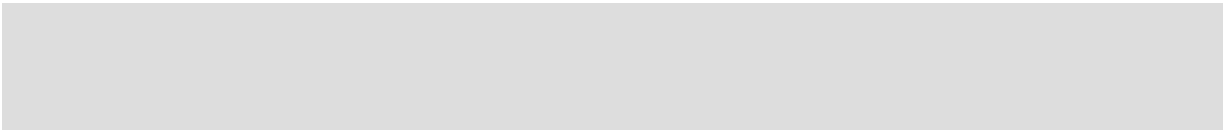
A corresponding text reads, Conclusion: includes strong statement about anxiety that echoes optimism of thesis. The second paragraph reads, “Anxiety can create confidence and optimism or depression, low self-esteem, and regret. The outcome of anxiety is entirely dependent on whether the individual runs from it or embraces it. Some forms of anxiety can be conquered merely by repeating the activity that causes them, such as giving speeches in a public speaking class. Anxiety brought on by unique opportunities or life-changing decisions, such as a summer in a foreign country or a new career, must be harnessed. Opportunities forgone due to anxiety and fear could be the chances of a lifetime. Although the unpleasant feelings that may accompany anxiety may make it initially easier to do nothing, the road not taken will never be forgotten. Anxiety is essentially a blessing in disguise. It is a physical and emotional trigger that tells us when and where there is an opportunity for us to grow and become stronger human beings.”

A sub-heading reads, Works cited.

Text below reads, Collier, James Lincoln. ‘Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name.’

Models for Writers, edited by Alfred Rosa and Paul Eschholz, Fourteenth ed., Bedford/St. Martin’ s, 2021, pages. 73 – 76.

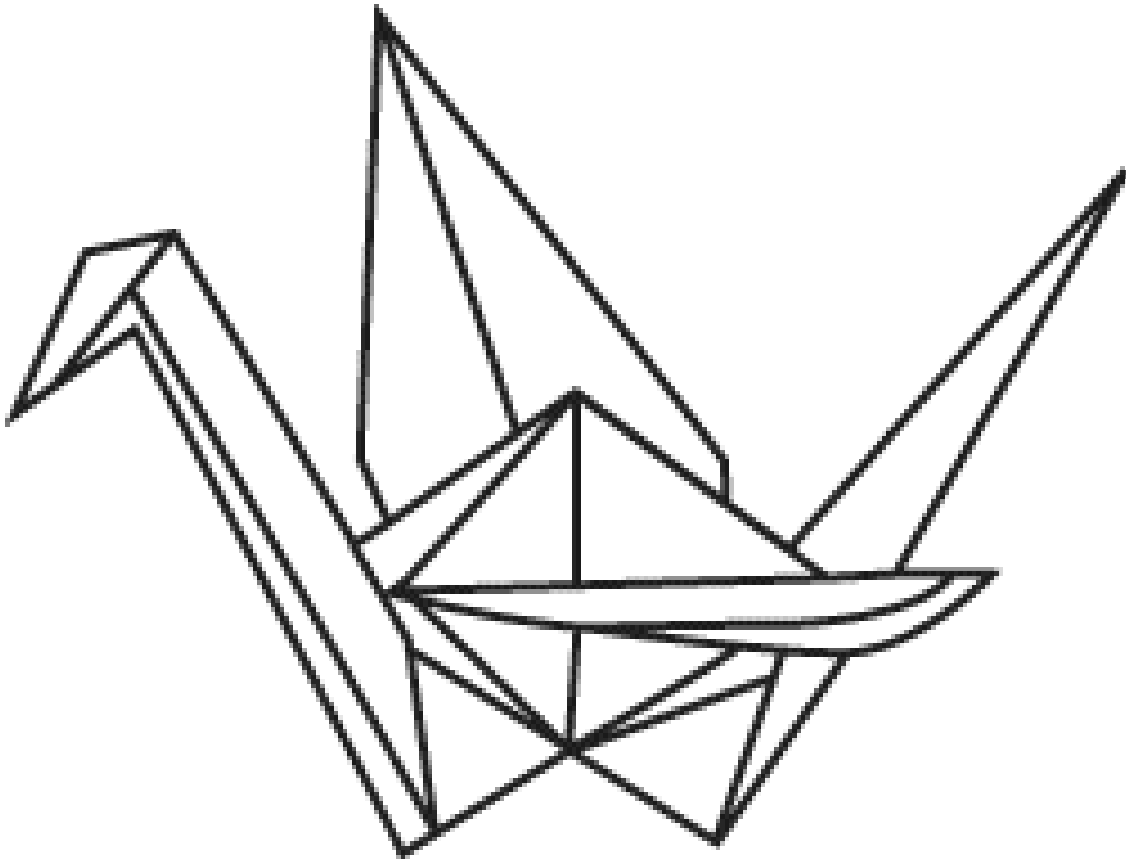
A corresponding annotation reads, M L A-style works cited list.



PART TWO The Elements of an Essay



CHAPTER 3 Thesis



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

The thesis of an essay is its main or controlling idea, the point the writer is trying to make. The thesis is often expressed in a one- or two-sentence statement, although sometimes it is implied or suggested rather than stated directly. The thesis statement determines the content of the essay developed in every paragraph.

Because everything you say in your composition must be logically related to your thesis, the thesis statement controls and directs the choices you make about the content

of your essay. This does not mean that your thesis statement is a straitjacket. As your essay develops, you may want to modify your thesis statement to accommodate your new thinking. This urge is not only acceptable but also normal.

A thesis statement should be

- the most important point you make about your topic;
- debatable, or open to an opposing argument;
- more general than the ideas and facts used to support it;
and
- appropriately focused for the length of your paper.

A thesis statement is not a question but an assertion — a claim made about a debatable issue that can be supported with evidence. The word “debatable” is important here. If your argument has no opposing argument, it is not itself an argument.

STRATEGIES FOR DEVELOPING A THESIS

Deciding on a direction for your essay and writing a thesis can be a daunting task, but below are some strategies that will help you brainstorm a working thesis. For more information on thesis statements, including steps to develop them, see [“Understand What a Thesis Is” in Chapter 1.](#)

Ask a Question

One way to develop a working thesis is to determine what question you are trying to answer in your essay. A one- or two-sentence answer to this question often produces a tentative thesis statement. For example, a student wanted to answer a question about gendered speaking styles, and after a working answer and two drafts, she modified her thesis statement:

QUESTION:	Do men and women have different conversational speaking styles?
-----------	---

PRELIMINARY ANSWER:	Men and women appear to have different objectives when they converse.
---------------------	---

MODIFIED	Very often, conversations between men and women become
----------	--

THESIS: situations in which the man gives a mini-lecture and the
 woman unwittingly turns into a captive audience.

Complete the Sentence

Another effective strategy for developing a thesis statement is to begin by writing “What I want to say is that ...”

What I want to say is that unless the university administration enforces a strong anti-hazing policy, the well-being of many of its student-athletes will be endangered.

Later, when you delete the formulaic opening, you will be left with a thesis statement:

Unless the university administration enforces a strong anti-hazing policy, the well-being of many of its student-athletes will be endangered.

LOCATION OF THE THESIS

Usually the thesis is presented early in the essay, sometimes in the first sentence. Here are some examples of strong thesis statements:

Mutual respect is the most important ingredient in a healthy marriage.

Mark Twain's great contribution to American literature is his use of vernacular English, and this is no more pronounced than in his novel *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*.

Professional sports organizations need to address the long-term effects of player concussions with rule changes and more technologically advanced equipment.

Many people believe that the American legal system is flooded with frivolous lawsuits, but there is little agreement on what is meant by "frivolous."

Each of these sentences does what a good thesis statement should do: it identifies the topic and makes an assertion about it.

Often writers prepare readers for the thesis statement with one or several sentences that establish a context. Notice in the following example how the author eases the reader into

his thesis about the stages of life instead of presenting it abruptly in the first sentence:

There used to be four common life phases: childhood, adolescence, adulthood and old age. Now, there are at least six: childhood, adolescence, odyssey, adulthood, active retirement, and old age. Of the new ones, the least understood is odyssey, the decade of wandering that frequently occurs between adolescence and adulthood.

—David Brooks, “The Odyssey Years”

On occasion a writer may even purposely delay the presentation of a thesis until the middle or the end of an essay. If the thesis is controversial or needs extended discussion and illustration, the writer might present it later to make it easier for the reader to understand and accept it. A thesis gains prominence when it appears near or at the end of an essay. For example, after an involved discussion about why various groups put pressure on school libraries to ban books, a student ended an essay with her thesis:

The effort to censor what our children are reading can turn into a potentially explosive situation and cause misunderstanding and hurt feelings within our schools and communities. If we can gain an understanding of why people have sought to censor children's books, we will be better prepared to respond in a sensitive and reasonable manner. More importantly, we will be able to provide the best educational opportunity for our children through a sensible approach, one that neither overly restricts the range of their reading nor allows them to read all books, no matter how inappropriate.

Thesis

—Tara Ketch, student

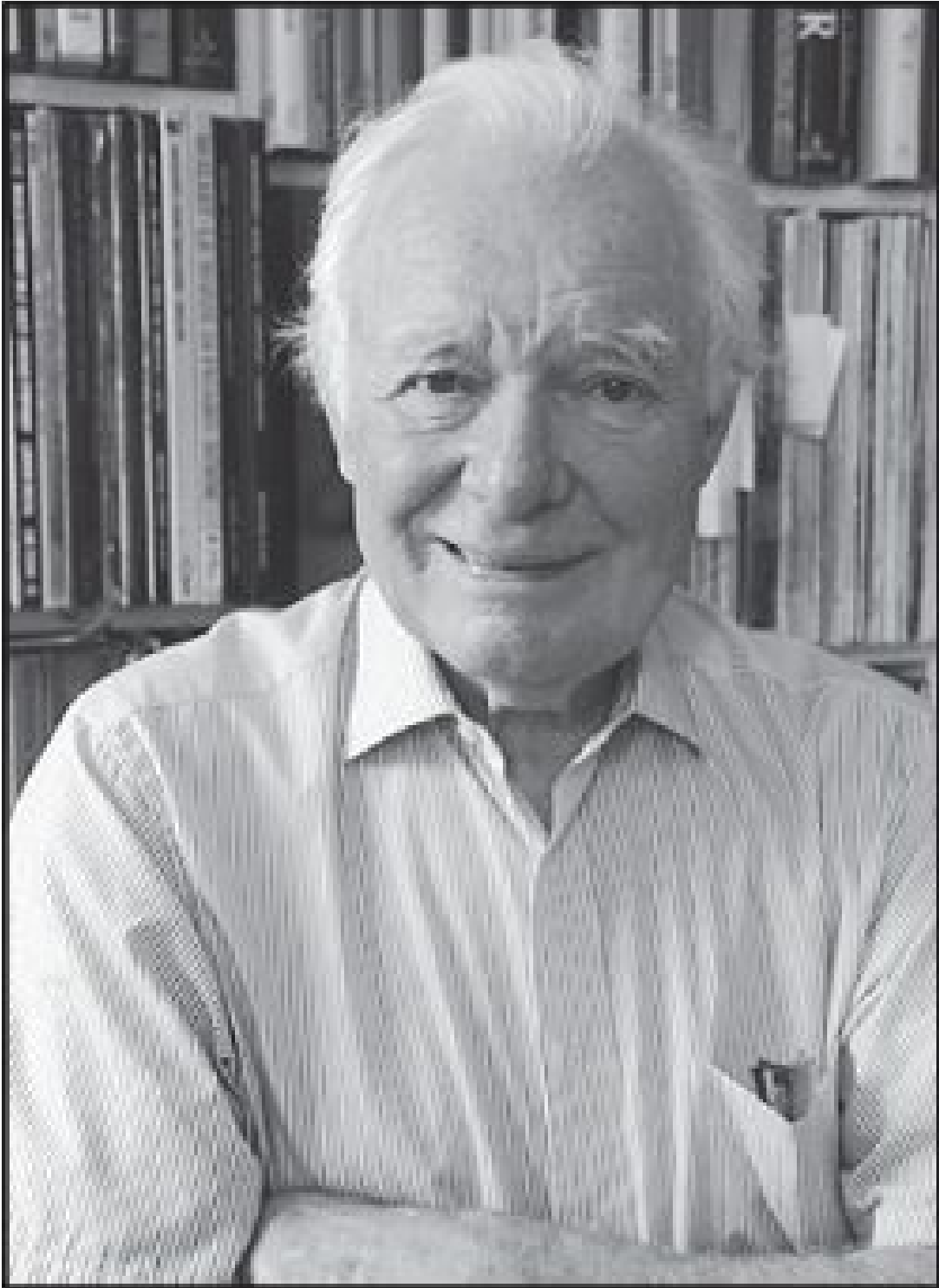
Description

The thesis statement reads, “The effort to censor what our children are reading can turn into a potentially explosive situation and cause misunderstanding and hurt feelings within our schools and communities. If we can gain an understanding of why people have sought to censor children's books, we will be better prepared to respond in a sensitive and reasonable manner. More importantly, we will be able to provide the best educational opportunity for our children through a sensible approach, one that neither overly restricts the range of their reading nor allows them to read all books, no matter how inappropriate.” A corresponding annotation reads, Thesis.

Some kinds of writing do not need thesis statements. These include descriptions, narratives, and personal writing such as letters and diaries. But any essay that seeks to explain or prove a point has a thesis that is usually set forth in a formal thesis statement.

Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name

James Lincoln Collier



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James Lincoln Collier is a freelance writer with more than six hundred articles to his credit. He was born in New York in 1928 and graduated from Hamilton College in 1950. An accomplished jazz musician, Collier has often focused his nonfiction writing on American music. His best-known book is *The Making of Jazz: A Comprehensive History* (1978). With his brother Christopher, he has written a number of history books, including *A Century of Immigration: 1820 - 1924* (2000), *The Civil War* (2000), *The Changing Face of American Society: 1945 - 2000* (2001), and a series of biographies for young readers covering major figures in American history. Collier has also written a number of children's books, one of which, *My Brother Sam Is Dead* (1974), received a Newbery Honor award and was named a Notable Children's Book.

As you read the following essay, which first appeared in *Reader's Digest* in 1986, pay attention to where Collier places his thesis. Note also how his thesis statement identifies the topic (anxiety) and makes an assertion about it (that it can have a positive effect on our lives).

Reflecting on What You Know

Many people associate anxiety with stress and think of it as a negative thing. Are there good kinds of anxiety, too? Provide an example of anxiety that has been beneficial to you or to someone you know.

Between my sophomore and junior years at college, a chance came up for me to spend the summer vacation working on a ranch in Argentina. My roommate's father was in the cattle business, and he wanted Ted to see something of it. Ted said he would go if he could take a friend, and he chose me.

The idea of spending two months on the fabled Argentine Pampas¹ was exciting. Then I began having second thoughts. I had never been very far from New England, and I had been homesick my first few weeks at college. What would it be like in a strange country? What about the language? And besides, I had promised to teach my younger brother to sail that summer. The more I thought about it, the more the prospect daunted² me. I began waking up nights in a sweat.

In the end I turned down the proposition. As soon as Ted asked somebody else to go, I began kicking myself. A couple of weeks later I went home to my old summer job, unpacking cartons at the local supermarket, feeling very low. I had turned down something I wanted to do because I was scared, and had ended up feeling depressed. I stayed that way for a long time. And it didn't help when I went back to college in the fall to discover that Ted and his friend had had a terrific time.

In the long run that unhappy summer taught me a valuable lesson out of which I developed a rule for myself: *do what*

makes you anxious; don' t do what makes you depressed.

I am not, of course, talking about severe states of anxiety or depression, which require medical attention. What I mean is that kind of anxiety we call stage fright, butterflies in the stomach, a case of nerves — the feelings we have at a job interview, when we' re giving a big party, when we have to make an important presentation at the office. And the kind of depression I am referring to is that downhearted feeling of the blues, when we don' t seem to be interested in anything, when we can' t get going and seem to have no energy.

I was confronted by this sort of situation toward the end of my senior year. As graduation approached, I began to think about taking a crack at making my living as a writer. But one of my professors was urging me to apply to graduate school and aim at a teaching career.

I wavered. The idea of trying to live by writing was scary — a lot more scary than spending a summer on the Pampas, I thought. Back and forth I went, making my decision, unmaking it. Suddenly, I realized that every time I gave up the idea of writing, that sinking feeling went through me; it gave me the blues.

The thought of graduate school wasn' t what depressed me. It was giving up on what deep in my gut I really wanted to do. Right then I learned another lesson. To avoid that kind of depression meant, inevitably, having to endure a certain amount of worry and concern.

The great Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard believed that anxiety always arises when we confront the possibility of our own development. It seems to be a rule of life that you can' t advance without getting that old, familiar, jittery feeling.

Even as children we discover this when we try to expand ourselves by, say, learning to ride a bike or going out for the school play. Later in life we get butterflies when we think about having that first child, or uprooting the family from the old hometown to find a better opportunity halfway across the country. Any time, it seems, that we set out aggressively to get something we want, we meet up with anxiety. And it' s going to be our traveling companion, at least part of the way, into any new venture.

When I first began writing magazine articles, I was frequently required to interview big names — people like Richard Burton,³ Joan Rivers,⁴ sex authority William Masters, baseball-great Dizzy Dean. Before each interview I would get butterflies and my hands would shake.

At the time, I was doing some writing about music. And one person I particularly admired was the great composer Duke Ellington. Onstage and on television, he seemed the very model of the confident, sophisticated man of the world. Then I learned that Ellington still got stage fright. If the highly honored Duke Ellington, who had appeared on the bandstand some 10,000 times over thirty years, had anxiety attacks, who was I to think I could avoid them?

I went on doing those frightening interviews, and one day, as I was getting onto a plane for Washington to interview columnist Joseph Alsop, I suddenly realized to my astonishment that I was looking forward to the meeting. What had happened to those butterflies?

Well, in truth, they were still there, but there were fewer of them. I had benefited, I discovered, from a process psychologists call “extinction.” If you put an individual in an anxiety-provoking situation often enough, he will eventually learn that there isn’ t anything to be worried about.

Which brings us to a corollary⁵ to my basic rule: *you’ ll never eliminate anxiety by avoiding the things that caused it.* I remember how my son Jeff was when I first began to teach him to swim at the lake cottage where we spent our summer vacations. He resisted, and when I got him into the

water he sank and sputtered and wanted to quit. But I was insistent. And by summer's end he was splashing around like a puppy. He had "extinguished" his anxiety the only way he could — by confronting it.

The problem, of course, is that it is one thing to urge somebody else to take on those anxiety-producing challenges; it is quite another to get ourselves to do it.

Some years ago I was offered a writing assignment that would require three months of travel through Europe. I had been abroad a couple of times on the usual "If it's Tuesday this must be Belgium" trips, but I hardly could claim to know my way around the continent. Moreover, my knowledge of foreign languages was limited to a little college French.

I hesitated. How would I, unable to speak the language, totally unfamiliar with local geography or transportation systems, set up interviews and do research? It seemed impossible, and with considerable regret I sat down to write a letter begging off. Halfway through, a thought — which I subsequently made into another corollary to my basic rule — ran through my mind: *you can't learn if you don't try*. So I accepted the assignment.

There were some bad moments. But by the time I had finished the trip I was an experienced traveler. And ever since, I

have never hesitated to head for even the most exotic of places, without guides or even advanced bookings, confident that somehow I will manage.

The point is that the new, the different, is almost by definition scary. But each time you try something, you learn, and as the learning piles up, the world opens to you.

I' ve made parachute jumps, learned to ski at forty, flown up the Rhine⁶ in a balloon. And I know I' m going to go on doing such things. It' s not because I' m braver or more daring than others. I' m not. But I don' t let the butterflies stop me from doing what I want. Accept anxiety as another name for challenge and you can accomplish wonders.

¹*Pampas*: a vast plain in central Argentina.

²*daunted*: discouraged.

³*Richard Burton* (1925 - 1984): a well-known British stage and Hollywood movie actor.

⁴*Joan Rivers* (1933 - 2014): a stand-up comedian and talk-show host.

⁵*corollary*: a proposition that follows with little or no proof required.

⁶*Rhine*: a major river and waterway of western Europe.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is Collier' s thesis? Based on your own experiences, do you think Collier' s thesis is valid? Explain.
2. What is the psychological process known as “extinction” ?
3. What causes Collier to come up with his basic rule for himself: “Do what makes you anxious; don' t do what makes you depressed” (4)? (Glossary: [Cause and Effect](#)) How does he develop the two corollaries to his basic rule? How do the basic rule and the two corollaries prepare you for his thesis?
4. What is Collier' s purpose? (Glossary: [Purpose](#))
5. What function do [paragraphs 17 - 19](#) serve in Collier' s essay?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Collier writes that Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard “believed that anxiety always arises when we confront the possibility of our own development” (9). How do Collier' s own experiences and growth substantiate Kierkegaard' s belief in the value of anxiety?
2. In [paragraph 16](#), Collier writes “The problem, of course, is that it is one thing to urge somebody else to take on those anxiety-producing challenges: it is quite another to get ourselves to do it.” Have you

personally experienced anxiety recently? If so, do you think the advice in Collier's essay will help to reduce your own anxiety? Have you found any other solutions that work to reduce anxiety?

3. In the [Questions for Study and Discussion](#), there is a question about Collier's thesis and a question about his purpose. Thesis and purpose are not the same thing. Why, as a writer, is it important for you to distinguish between these two concepts?

Classroom Activity Using Thesis

A good thesis statement identifies the topic and makes an assertion about it. Evaluate the following sentences, and explain why each one either works or doesn't work as a thesis statement.

1. Americans are suffering from overwork.
2. Life is indeed precious, and I believe the death penalty helps to affirm this fact.
3. Birthday parties are loads of fun.
4. New York is a city of sounds: muted sounds and shrill sounds, shattering sounds and soothing sounds, urgent sounds and aimless sounds.
5. Everyone is talking about the level of violence in American society.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Building on your own experiences and the reading you have done, write an essay in which you use as your thesis either Collier's basic rule or one of his corollaries to that basic rule.
2. Write an essay using any one of the following as your thesis:

Good manners are a thing of the past.

We need rituals in our lives.

To tell a joke well is an art.

We are a drug-dependent society.

Travel broadens one's understanding of the world.

Stage fright is an important part of performance.

Making decisions by "gut" feelings is irresponsible.

The End of Passwords

David Pogue



Stephen Lovekin/Getty Images

David Pogue, born in 1963 in Shaker Heights, Ohio, graduated from Yale with a distinction in music; he has also been awarded an honorary doctorate in music by the Shenandoah Conservatory in Virginia. He is a tech critic for Yahoo! Finance, a monthly columnist for *Scientific American*, and a host for science shows on PBS' s *Nova*. He has over three million books in print, on topics ranging from technology to classical music; and he is also the winner of three Emmy awards, two Webby awards, and a Loeb award for journalism. Pogue has gained a reputation as a consumer advocate for his writing in *The New York Times*, where he especially focuses on technology products.

In this article, which appeared in *Scientific American* in 2016, Pogue addresses an issue all users of technology — virtually all of us — face: the use of passwords. He argues that truly effective passwords are at odds with how most people use them. As you read, pay attention to the evidence Pogue uses to support his thesis and suggest that new technology promises better, more efficient, and more dependable protection in the future.

Reflecting on What You Know

What is your approach to the use of passwords? Do you use simple, easy-to-remember passwords? Do you use multiple passwords for different websites and devices? Do you change

your passwords regularly? How do you keep track of your passwords?

Our tech lives are full of pain points, but at least the world's tech geniuses seem committed to solving them. Today who complains about the things that bugged us a decade ago, such as heavy laptops, slow cellular Internet, the inability to do e-mail in planes?

It was only a matter of time before those geniuses started tackling one of the longest-running pain points in history: passwords. We're supposed to create a long, complex, unguessable password — capital and lowercase letters, numbers and symbols, with a few Arabic letters thrown in if possible. *For each site*. Don't reuse a password. Oh, and change them all every month.

Sorry, security experts. Not possible. Not for an average person, not even for you. Nobody has that kind of memory.

To make matters worse, passwords aren't even especially secure. See any recent headline about stolen passwords or about some company's servers being hacked.

It's time to kill the password.

Surely, in the 50 years since we started typing passwords, somebody must have invented a better security system. The answer: yes and no. Apps such as 1Password and Dashlane memorize and enter long, complicated passwords *for* you. But most of them cost money, they don' t work on every Web account and the nontechie public doesn' t know they exist.

There' s also two-factor authentication, which makes you type a password *and* a code texted to your phone to log in. It' s an unbelievable hassle. The masses will never go for it.

Finally, biometric¹ approaches can be both secure and easy because they recognize *us*, not memorized strings of text. Here there' s hope. Fingerprint readers on smartphones, tablets and laptops are becoming common, cheap, convenient, and essentially impossible to hack on a large scale. So far they' re primarily useful for logging us into our *machines*. Shouldn' t the next step be letting us log into our Web accounts? Iris² scanning is another biometric technology, fast enough to work well at automated border-crossing systems and secure enough for national ID programs such as India' s (it' s enrolling 1.2 billion people).

At the moment, iris scanners are far too new and expensive to build into every phone and laptop — but almost every technology gets cheaper over time. Some scanners can be fooled by a photograph of your eye, but this problem, too,

can be overcome (by tracking your pupil as you read something, for example). Bottom line: there's no insurmountable³ problem in iris reading's future.

Same with voice authentication, using the unique pitch, accent and frequencies of your speaking voice as your key. It's cheap enough for wide adoption — our phones and gadgets already have microphones. Worried about bad guys faking out the system with a recording of your voice? That can't happen if the phrase you're asked to speak changes every time you log in.

The only roadblocks here are background noise and laryngitis.⁴ And as with any biometric security solution, this approach really requires a backup system — like a password — just in case.

Then there's Windows Hello, a new feature of Windows 10 that lets you log in with fingerprint, iris, or facial recognition — whatever your laptop is equipped to handle. The face option is especially exciting. You just sit down at the computer, and it unlocks instantly. You can't fool it with a photograph or even a 3-D model of your head, because the Intel RealSense camera it requires includes infrared and 3-D sensors.

Of course, very few gadgets come with that camera preinstalled. But the RealSense concept is truly the Holy Grail:⁵ secure and convenient. If the hardware ever became as ubiquitous⁶ and cheap as, say, our phones' fingerprint readers, we could have a winner.

Clearly, the password concept is broken. Equally clearly, these new technologies can provide both the security and the convenience the world demands. Nothing's quite there yet, and we need to keep our eye on privacy concerns (who owns the databases of biometric scans, for example?).

But one thing is for sure: this is one pain point that's got everyone's attention.

¹*biometric*: relating to physical or behavioral characteristics, such as voices and fingerprints, often used to identify an individual.

²*iris*: the colored part of the eye that also adjusts the size of the pupil (the black center).

³*insurmountable*: incapable of being overcome; unbeatable.

⁴*laryngitis*: inflammation of the vocal chords that causes the voice to become hoarse or raspy.

⁵*Holy Grail*: the goal of a long or difficult quest.

⁶*ubiquitous*: common; widespread.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Is Pogue's thesis about a topic of importance and controversy? Why or why not? What question is Pogue trying to answer in his thesis?
2. What is the problem with passwords, as Pogue sees it? Do you share his concerns? Why or why not?
3. When Pogue presents the two-factor authentication (7), he states that the "masses will never go for it." Why is that? Do you agree?
4. What does Pogue mean by "biometric approaches" (8)? Examine each of the approaches that Pogue suggests and argue whether or not you see each one as a realistic alternative to replace passwords.
5. At the end of his essay, Pogue does raise the issue of privacy and information ownership. What are some of those concerns? How might they be resolved?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Have issues about personal security in the digital world reached the point where the resultant stress over security has become a health concern? Have you been personally affected in any way? Explain.
2. What new security features have your phone provider or internet provider been able to offer you? Do you

think these providers should be doing more to protect your privacy and data? Explain.

3. Facial recognition has become a common way of securing your data and privacy. What issues have been created by this technology? Does the technology present any potential dangers?

Classroom Activity Using Thesis

A strong thesis makes a claim rather than stating something obvious about the topic. One way to check whether your thesis makes a claim is to try stating its opposite as an alternative. If this new thesis seems absurd or wrong, your original thesis might benefit from greater specificity.

Imagine that you were going to write a response to Pogue's argument about passwords. Which of the following could be a thesis statement for a substantial counterargument? If you're not sure, test each one by stating its opposite. Note: Often a good thesis cannot be easily reversed because it does not frame the issues in black and white.

1. The password system for digital security needs to be replaced immediately.

2. Costs for hardware and software that provide the most up-to-date security should be subsidized by the federal government so that all Americans can afford to be secure online.
3. Hardware and software manufacturers are working hard to improve security.
4. People should be smarter about creating complex passwords that cannot be guessed by hackers and identity thieves.
5. Pogue is far too optimistic about the ability to lower costs for high-end computer security devices.
6. Trying to improve security is pointless because with every new advance, hackers will create new ways around them.

Now that you've eliminated some, how many potential theses are left? When writers like Pogue address complex issues, thoughtful readers can respond with an array of ideas, concerns, or questions. Look at the remaining thesis statements and discuss how each one takes a different approach to the problem.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write an essay in which you respond to Pogue's concern about the use of passwords on the internet today. Formulate a thesis statement in which you

argue whether or not his concerns are justified. Consider whether his proposed improvements are realistic. Can you envision a time when passwords will disappear completely? If so, what changes would have to occur for that to happen? If not, why not?

2. Do you currently use biometric security, such as fingerprint ID or facial recognition, on any of your devices? Investigate the problems associated with biometric approaches to security. What are some of the potential drawbacks and advantages? Formulate a thesis statement that presents an argument about the future of biometric computer security and then write an essay supporting your position.

Where Anonymity Breeds Contempt

Julie Zhuo



AP Photo/Jeff Chiu

Julie Zhuo was born in Shanghai, China, but her family moved to Texas when she was five. She attended Stanford University, where she completed both a bachelor's and a master's degree in computer science. Zhuo began working at Facebook in 2006 and is currently a vice president of product design. She also writes a weekly online series called "The Year of the Looking Glass" on Medium, featuring her thoughts on creative pursuits, management problems, and the business of social media. Her book *The Making of a Manager: What to Do When Everyone Looks at You* (2019) offers advice to help managers develop their skills, lead with confidence, and assist their reports in advancing their careers.

In the following essay, which appeared in the Opinion Pages of *The New York Times* in November 2010, Zhuo addresses the problem of online trolling and puts forth the thesis that we must lift the veil of anonymity to bring greater responsibility to online communications.

Reflecting on What You Know

Do you think people interact differently online than they do face to face? Why or why not? Think of an example that supports your answer.

There you are, peacefully reading an article or watching a video on the Internet. You finish, find it thought-provoking, and scroll down to the comments section to see what other

people thought. And there, lurking among dozens of well-intentioned opinions, is a troll.

“How much longer is the media going to milk this beyond tired story?” “These guys are frauds.” “Your idiocy is disturbing.” “We’ re just trying to make the world a better place one brainwashed, ignorant idiot at a time.” These are the trollish comments, all from anonymous sources, that you could have found after reading a CNN article on the rescue of the Chilean miners.

Trolling, defined as the act of posting inflammatory, derogatory or provocative messages in public forums, is a problem as old as the Internet itself, although its roots go much farther back. Even in the fourth century B.C., Plato touched upon the subject of anonymity and morality in his parable of the ring of Gyges.

That mythical ring gave its owner the power of invisibility, and Plato observed that even a habitually just man who possessed such a ring would become a thief, knowing that he couldn’ t be caught. Morality, Plato argues, comes from full disclosure; without accountability for our actions we would all behave unjustly.

This certainly seems to be true for the anonymous trolls today. After Alexis Pilkington, a 17-year-old Long Island

girl, committed suicide earlier this year, trolls descended on her online tribute page to post pictures of nooses, references to hangings and other hateful comments. A better-known example involves Nicole Catsouras, an 18-year-old who died in a car crash in California in 2006. Photographs of her badly disfigured body were posted on the Internet, where anonymous trolls set up fake tribute pages and in some cases e-mailed the photos to her parents with subject lines like “Hey, Daddy, I’ m still alive.”

Psychological research has proven again and again that anonymity increases unethical behavior. Road rage bubbles up in the relative anonymity of one’ s car. And in the online world, which can offer total anonymity, the effect is even more pronounced. People — even ordinary, good people — often change their behavior in radical ways. There’ s even a term for it: the online disinhibition effect.

Many forums and online communities are looking for ways to strike back. Back in February, Engadget, a popular technology review blog, shut down its commenting system for a few days after it received a barrage of trollish comments on its iPad coverage.

Many victims are turning to legislation. All 50 states now have stalking, bullying or harassment laws that explicitly include electronic forms of communication. Last year, Liskula

Cohen, a former model, persuaded a New York judge to require Google to reveal the identity of an anonymous blogger who she felt had defamed her, and she has now filed a suit against the blogger. Last month, another former model, Carla Franklin, persuaded a judge to force YouTube to reveal the identity of a troll who made a disparaging comment about her on the video-sharing site.

But the law by itself cannot do enough to disarm the Internet's trolls. Content providers, social networking platforms and community sites must also do their part by rethinking the systems they have in place for user commentary so as to discourage — or disallow — anonymity. Reuters, for example, announced that it would start to block anonymous comments and require users to register with their names and e-mail addresses in an effort to curb “uncivil behavior.”

Some may argue that denying Internet users the ability to post anonymously is a breach of their privacy and freedom of expression. But until the age of the Internet, anonymity was a rare thing. When someone spoke in public, his audience would naturally be able to see who was talking.

Others point out that there's no way to truly rid the Internet of anonymity. After all, names and e-mail addresses can be faked. And in any case many commenters write things that are rude or inflammatory under their real names.

But raising barriers to posting bad comments is still a smart first step. Well-designed commenting systems should also aim to highlight thoughtful and valuable opinions while letting trollish ones sink into oblivion.

The technology blog Gizmodo is trying an audition system for new commenters, under which their first few comments would be approved by a moderator or a trusted commenter to ensure quality before anybody else could see them. After a successful audition, commenters can freely post. If over time they impress other trusted commenters with their contributions, they'd be promoted to trusted commenters, too, and their comments would henceforth be featured.

Disqus, a comments platform for bloggers, has experimented with allowing users to rate one another's comments and feed those ratings into a global reputation system called Clout. Moderators can use a commenter's Clout score to "help separate top commenters from trolls."

At Facebook, where I've worked on the design of the public commenting widget, the approach is to try to replicate real-world social norms by emphasizing the human qualities of conversation. People's faces, real names and brief biographies ("John Doe from Lexington") are placed next to their public comments, to establish a baseline of responsibility.

Facebook also encourages you to share your comments with your friends. Though you're free to opt out, the knowledge that what you say may be seen by the people you know is a big deterrent to trollish behavior.

This kind of social pressure works because, at the end of the day, most trolls wouldn't have the gall to say to another person's face half the things they anonymously post on the Internet.

Instead of waiting around for human nature to change, let's start to rein in bad behavior by promoting accountability. Content providers, stop allowing anonymous comments. Moderate your comments and forums. Look into using comment services to improve the quality of engagement on your site. Ask your users to report trolls and call them out for polluting the conversation.

In slowly lifting the veil of anonymity, perhaps we can see the troll not as the frightening monster of lore, but as what we all really are: human.

Julie Zhuo, "Where Anonymity Breeds Contempt," *The New York Times*, November 29, 2010. Copyright © 2010 by The New York Times. All rights reserved. Used under license.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is Zhuo' s thesis, and where does she state it?
2. What problem does Zhuo address in this essay? How does her thesis offer an approach to this problem?
3. Why does Zhuo think Plato' s story about the ring of Gyges (4) is relevant to internet users?
4. How does Zhuo define the “online disinhibition effect” (6)? Which of Zhuo' s examples of this effect do you find most powerful? (Glossary: [Definition](#))
5. Zhuo identifies anonymity as a source of the problem. How does she think internet culture allows, or even encourages, users to remain anonymous?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. At the beginning of her essay, Zhou says a troll can lurk “among dozens of well-intentioned opinions” (1). What does this say about the balance of thoughtful and inflammatory comments online? How much of the latter do you think it takes to derail a discussion?
2. According to Zhou, Plato argues that “without accountability for our actions we would all behave unjustly.” Do you agree with that opinion? Why or why not?
3. Zhou expressed her concerns with trolls back in 2010. How successful has big tech been since then in

remedying its problems with trolls?

Classroom Activity Using Thesis

A good thesis is an arguable statement that presents an answer to a question. So, sometimes the best way to construct a thesis is to start first by constructing a question. Constructing the question can lead you to an answer, or perhaps several different possible answers that you will need to consider. Which answer you choose will depend on your own opinion about the matter and what evidence you have to support your statement.

Develop a list of five questions on the subject of “censorship on the internet.” To get you started, here is one possible question: “Should anyone be able to put any information or photographs online even if they could be considered untrue or fake?”

1. _____.
2. _____.
3. _____.
4. _____.
5. _____.

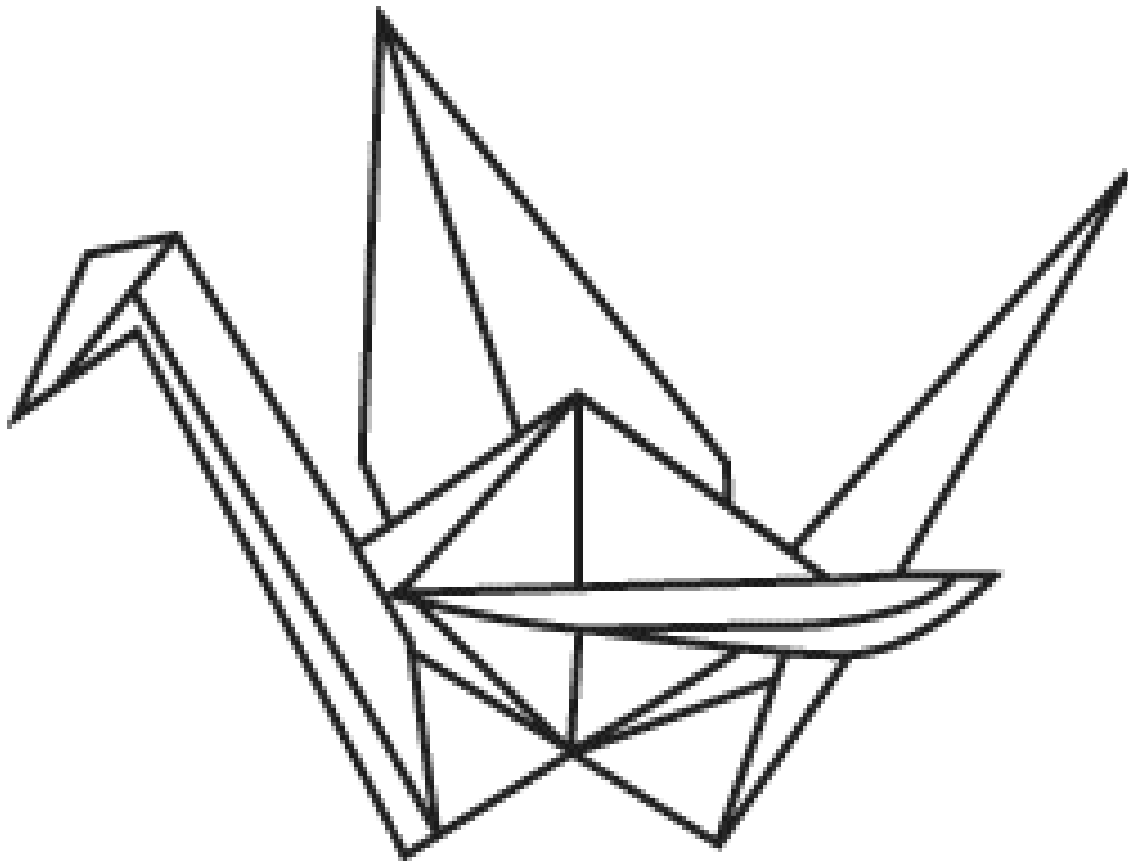
Now develop a preliminary thesis statement by answering one of your questions.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Find a newspaper article posted in the past weeks and survey the comments section. Do your findings support Zhuo's assertions about trolling? Write an essay that summarizes what you observe. Think carefully about how you want to organize your essay: in chronological order? by types of responses? by profiles of commentors? by frequency of comments on a point? Be sure to support your thesis about online commenting behavior.
2. Though Zhuo is optimistic in offering her solution to the problem, her thesis about how to curb trolling depends on a skeptical view of human moral behavior. Do you agree with her that we are far more likely to be moral when we're being watched? Is there a better way to assure moral behavior? Write an essay supporting Zhuo's call for "full disclosure" or arguing for an alternative way to encourage more responsible interactions. Be sure to offer supporting details in a way that most effectively defends your thesis.



CHAPTER 4 Unity



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Unity is an essential quality in a well-written essay. The principle of unity requires that every element in a piece of writing — whether a paragraph or an essay — be related to the main idea. Sentences that stray from the main idea, even though they might be related to it or provide additional information, can weaken an otherwise strong piece of writing. Notice how the *italicized segments* in the following paragraph undermine its unity and divert our attention from its main idea:

When I was growing up, one of the places I enjoyed most was the cherry tree in the backyard. *Behind the yard was an alley and then more houses.* Every summer when the cherries began to ripen, I used to spend hours high up in the tree, picking and eating the sweet, sun-warmed cherries. *My mother always worried about my falling out of the tree, but I never did.* But I had some competition for the cherries — flocks of birds that enjoyed them as much as I did would perch all over the tree, devouring the fruit whenever I wasn' t there. I used to wonder why the grown-ups never ate any of the cherries — *my father loved all kinds of fruit* — but actually, when the birds and I had finished, there weren' t many left.

—Betty Burns, student

When the italicized sentences are eliminated, the paragraph is unified and reads smoothly.

Now consider another paragraph, this one from an essay about family photographs and how they allow the author to learn about her past and to stay connected with her family in the present:

First sentence gives focus and direction to the paragraph. Subsequent sentences relate directly to the places and people mentioned in the first sentence.

Photographs have taken me to places I have never been and have shown me people alive before I was born. I can visit my grandmother's childhood home in Vienna, Austria, and walk down the high-ceilinged, iron staircase by looking through the small, white album my grandma treasures. I also know of the tomboy she once was, wearing lederhosen instead of the dirndls worn by her friends. And I have seen her as a beautiful young woman who traveled with the Red Cross during the war, uncertain of her future. The photograph that rests in a red leather frame on my grandma's nightstand has allowed me to meet the man she would later marry. He died before I was born. I have been told that I would have loved his calm manner, and I can see for myself his gentle smile and tranquil expression.

—Carrie White, student

Description

The first paragraph reads, "Photographs have taken me to places I have never been and have shown me people alive before I was born. I can visit my grandmother's childhood home in Vienna, Austria, and walk down the high-ceilinged, iron staircase by looking through." The phrase, my grandmother's childhood home is highlighted. A corresponding annotation reads, First sentence gives focus and direction to the paragraph.

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "the small, white album my grandma treasures. I also know of the tomboy she once was, wearing lederhosen instead of the dirndls worn by her friends. And I have seen her as a beautiful young woman who traveled with the Red Cross during the war, uncertain of her future. The photograph that rests in a red leather frame on my grandma's nightstand has allowed me to meet the man she would later marry. He died before I was born. I have been told that I would have loved his calm manner, and I can see for myself his gentle smile

and tranquil expression.” A corresponding annotation reads, Subsequent sentences relate directly to the places and people mentioned in the first sentence. The writer’s name reads, —Carrie White, student. ”

A well-written essay should be unified both within and between paragraphs; that is, everything in it should be related to its **thesis**, the main idea of the essay. There are two requirements for unity:

1. The thesis itself should be clear, either through a direct statement, called the *thesis statement*, or by implication. (See [Chapter 3](#) for more on thesis.)
2. There should be no digressions — no discussion or information that is not shown to be logically related to the thesis. A unified essay stays within the limits of its thesis.

Here, for example, is a short essay by Stuart Chase about the dangers of making generalizations. As you read, notice how carefully Chase sticks to his point.

Overgeneralizing

One swallow does not make a summer, nor can two or three cases often support a dependable generalization. Yet all of us, including the most polished eggheads, are constantly falling into this mental peopletrap. It is the most common, probably the most seductive, and potentially the most dangerous, of all the fallacies.

1 Thesis

You drive through a town and see a drunken man on the sidewalk. A few blocks further on you see another. You turn to your companion: “Nothing but drunks in this town!” Soon you are out in the country, bowling along at fifty. A car passes you as if you were parked. On a curve a second whizzes by. Your companion turns to you: “All the drivers in this state are crazy!” Two thumping

2 Paragraphs 2 and 3 document the thesis with examples.

Description

“Paragraph 1 reads, ‘One swallow does not make a summer, nor can two or three cases often support a dependable generalization. (The phrase, ‘nor can two or three cases often support a dependable generalization’ is highlighted) Yet all of us, including the most polished eggheads, are constantly falling into this mental peopletrap. It is the most common, probably the most seductive, and potentially the most dangerous, of all the fallacies.’ A corresponding annotation reads, 1 Thesis. Paragraph 2 reads, ‘You drive through a town and see a drunken man on the sidewalk. A few blocks further on you see another. You turn to your companion: ‘Nothing but drunks in this town!’ Soon you are out in the country, bowling along at fifty. A car passes you as if you were parked. On a curve a second whizzes by. Your companion turns to you: ‘All the drivers in this state are

crazy!’ Two thumping generalize- “A corresponding annotation reads, 2 Paragraphs 2 and 3 document the thesis with examples.”

generalizations, each built on two cases. If we stop to think, we usually recognize the exaggeration and the unfairness of such generalizations. Trouble comes when we do not stop to think—or when we build them on a prejudice.

This kind of reasoning has been around for a long time. Aristotle was aware of its dangers and called it “reasoning by example,” meaning too few examples. What it boils down to is failing to count your swallows before announcing that summer is here. Driving from my home to New Haven the other day, a distance of about forty miles, I caught myself saying: “Every time I look around I see a new ranch-type house going up.” So on the return trip I counted them; there were exactly five under construction. And how many times had I “looked around”? I suppose I had glanced to right and left—as one must at side roads and so forth in driving—several hundred times.

In this fallacy, we do not make the error of neglecting facts altogether and rushing immediately to the level of opinion. We start at the fact level properly enough, but *we do not stay there*. A case or two and up we go to a rousing oversimplification about drunks, speeders, ranch-style houses—or, more seriously, about foreigners, African Americans, labor leaders, teenagers.

Why do we overgeneralize so often and sometimes so disastrously? One reason is that the human mind is a generalizing machine. We would not be people without this power. The old academic crack: “All generalizations are false, including this one,” is only a play on words. We *must* generalize to communicate and to live. But we should beware of beating the gun; of not waiting until enough facts are in to say something useful. Meanwhile it is a plain waste of time to listen to arguments based on a few handpicked examples.

—Stuart Chase, *Guides to Straight Thinking*

3

4 Paragraph 4 explains how overgeneralizing occurs.

5 Paragraph 5 analyzes why people overgeneralize. For a conclusion, Chase restates his thesis in different words.

Description

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "tions, each built on two cases. If we stop to think, we usually recognize the exaggeration and the unfairness of such generalizations. Trouble comes when we do not stop to think — or when we build them on a prejudice." Paragraph 3 reads, "This kind of reasoning has been around for a long time. Aristotle was aware of its dangers and called it 'reasoning by example,' meaning too few examples. What it boils down to is failing to count your swallows before announcing that summer is here. Driving from my home to New Haven the other day, a distance of about forty miles, I caught myself saying: 'Every time I look around I see a new ranch-type house going up.' So on the return trip I counted them; there were exactly five under construction. And how many times had I 'looked around'? I suppose I had glanced to right and left — as one must at side roads and so forth in driving — several hundred times." A corresponding annotation reads, 3. Paragraph 4 reads, "In this fallacy, we do not make the error of neglecting facts altogether and rushing immediately to the level of opinion. We start at the fact level properly enough, but we do not stay there. A case or two and up we go to a rousing oversimplification about drunks, speeders, ranch-style houses — or, more seriously, about foreigners, African Americans, labor leaders, teenagers." A corresponding annotation reads, 4 Paragraph 4 explains how overgeneralizing occurs. Paragraph 5 reads, "Why do we overgeneralize so often and sometimes so disastrously? One reason is that the human mind is a generalizing machine. We would not be people without this power. The old academic crack: 'All generalizations are false, including this

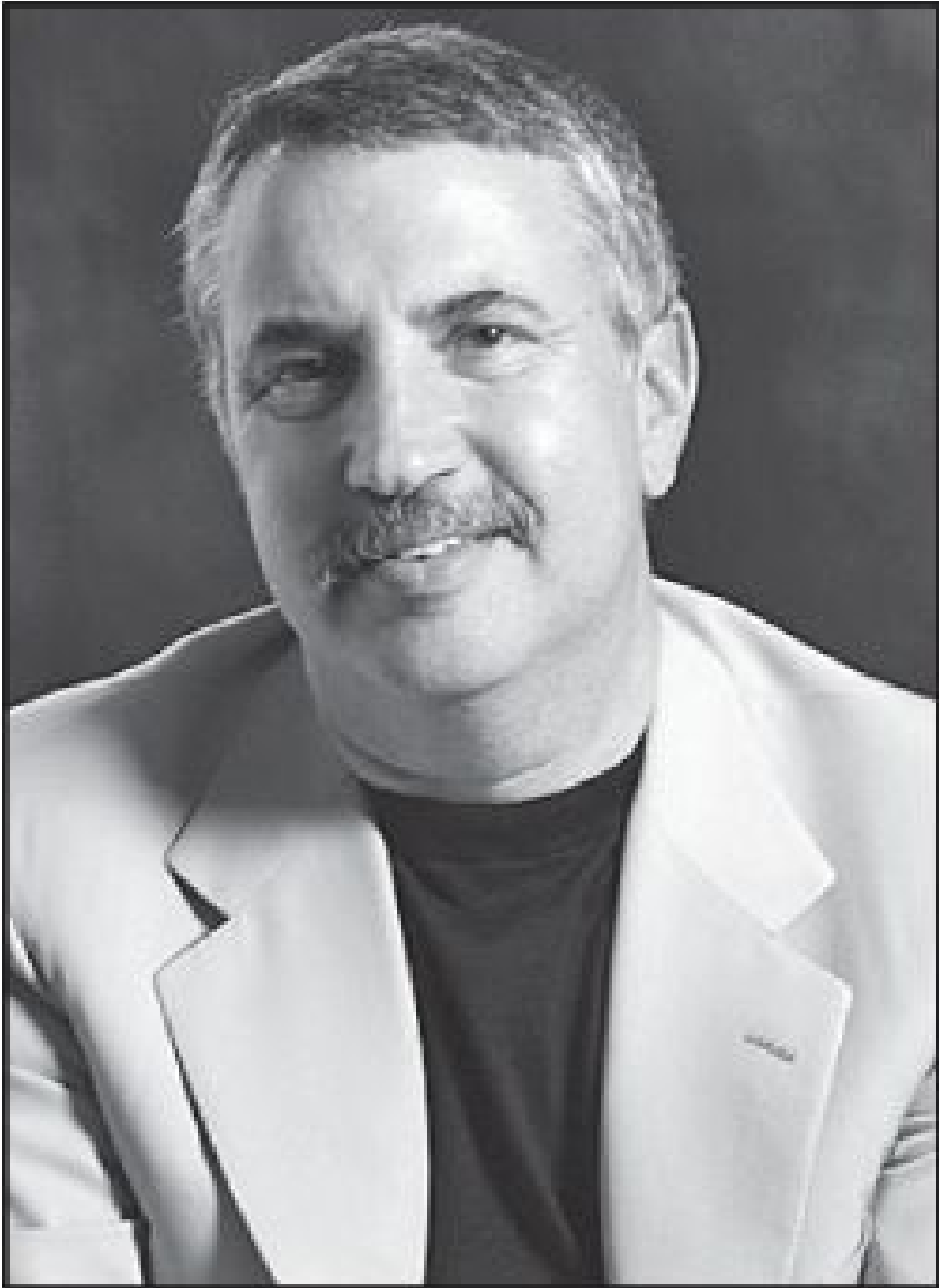
one,' is only a play on words. We must generalize to communicate and to live. But we should beware of beating the gun; of not waiting until enough facts are in to say something useful. Meanwhile it is a plain waste of time to listen to arguments based on a few handpicked examples." A corresponding annotation reads, 5 Paragraph 5 analyzes why people overgeneralize. For a conclusion, Chase restates his thesis in different words. The writer's name reads, — Stuart Chase, Guides to Straight Thinking"

An essay may be longer, more complex, and more wide-ranging than this one, but to be effective, it must also avoid digressions and remain close to the author's main idea.

A good way to check that your essay is indeed unified is to underline or highlight your thesis and then explain to yourself how each paragraph in your essay is related to the thesis. If you find a paragraph that does not appear to be logically connected, you can revise it so that the relationship is clear. Similarly, it is useful to make sure that each sentence in a paragraph is related to the topic sentence. (See [pp. 160 – 62](#) for a discussion of topic sentences.)

My Favorite Teacher

Thomas L. Friedman



Nancy Ostertag/Getty Images

Thomas L. Friedman, foreign affairs columnist for *The New York Times*, was born in Minneapolis, Minnesota, in 1953. He graduated from Brandeis University in 1975 and received a Marshall Scholarship to attend St. Antony's College, Oxford University, where he earned a master's degree in Middle East studies. He has worked for *The New York Times* since 1981, first in Lebanon, then in Israel, and since 1989 in Washington, D.C. He has won three Pulitzer Prizes. His 1989 best seller, *From Beirut to Jerusalem*, received the National Book Award for nonfiction. Friedman's most recent books include *The World Is Flat: A Brief History of the Twenty-First Century* (2005); *Hot, Flat, and Crowded: Why We Need a Green Revolution — and How It Can Renew America* (2008); *That Used to Be Us: How America Fell Behind in the World It Invented and How We Can Come Back* (2011), co-written with Michael Mandelbaum; and *Thank You for Being Late* (2016).

In the following essay, which first appeared in *The New York Times* in 2001, Friedman pays tribute to his tenth-grade journalism teacher. As you read Friedman's profile of Hattie M. Steinberg, note the descriptive detail he selects to create a unified, dominant impression of “a woman of clarity in an age of uncertainty.”

Reflecting on What You Know

If you had to name your three favorite teachers to date, who would be on your list? Why do you consider each of the

teachers a favorite? Which one, if any, are you likely to remember twenty-five years from now? Why?

Last Sunday's *New York Times Magazine* published its annual review of people who died last year who left a particular mark on the world. I am sure all readers have their own such list. I certainly do. Indeed, someone who made the most important difference in my life died last year — my high school journalism teacher, Hattie M. Steinberg.

I grew up in a small suburb of Minneapolis, and Hattie was the legendary journalism teacher at St. Louis Park High School, Room 313. I took her intro to journalism course in 10th grade, back in 1969, and have never needed, or taken, another course in journalism since. She was that good.

Hattie was a woman who believed that the secret for success in life was getting the fundamentals right. And boy, she pounded the fundamentals of journalism into her students — not simply how to write a lead or accurately transcribe a quote, but, more important, how to comport yourself in a professional way and to always do quality work. To this day, when I forget to wear a tie on assignment, I think of Hattie scolding me. I once interviewed an ad exec for our high school paper who used a four-letter word. We debated whether to run it. Hattie ruled yes. That ad man almost lost his job when it appeared. She wanted to teach us about consequences.

Hattie was the toughest teacher I ever had. After you took her journalism course in 10th grade, you tried out for the paper, *The Echo*, which she supervised. Competition was fierce. In 11th grade, I didn't quite come up to her writing standards, so she made me business manager, selling ads to the local pizza parlors. That year, though, she let me write one story. It was about an Israeli general who had been a hero in the Six-Day War,¹ who was giving a lecture at the University of Minnesota. I covered his lecture and interviewed him briefly. His name was Ariel Sharon.² First story I ever got published.

Those of us on the paper, and the yearbook that she also supervised, lived in Hattie's classroom. We hung out there before and after school. Now, you have to understand, Hattie was a single woman, nearing 60 at the time, and this was the 1960s. She was the polar opposite of "cool," but we hung around her classroom like it was a malt shop and she was Wolfman Jack.³ None of us could have articulated it then, but it was because we enjoyed being harangued⁴ by her, disciplined by her, and taught by her. She was a woman of clarity in an age of uncertainty.

We remained friends for 30 years, and she followed, bragged about, and critiqued every twist in my career. After she died, her friends sent me a pile of my stories that she had saved over the years. Indeed, her students were her family —

only closer. Judy Harrington, one of Hattie's former students, remarked about other friends who were on Hattie's newspapers and yearbooks: "We all graduated 41 years ago; and yet nearly each day in our lives something comes up — some mental image, some admonition⁵ that makes us think of Hattie."

Judy also told the story of one of Hattie's last birthday parties, when one man said he had to leave early to take his daughter somewhere. "Sit down," said Hattie. "You're not leaving yet. She can just be a little late."

That was my teacher! I sit up straight just thinkin' about her.

Among the fundamentals Hattie introduced me to was the *New York Times*. Every morning it was delivered to Room 313. I had never seen it before then. Real journalists, she taught us, start their day by reading the *Times* and columnists like Anthony Lewis and James Reston.

I have been thinking about Hattie a lot this year, not just because she died on July 31, but because the lessons she imparted seem so relevant now. We've just gone through this huge dot-com-Internet-globalization bubble — during which a lot of smart people got carried away and forgot the fundamentals of how you build a profitable company, a lasting

portfolio, a nation state, or a thriving student. It turns out that the real secret of success in the information age is what it always was: fundamentals — reading, writing, and arithmetic; church, synagogue, and mosque; the rule of law; and good governance.

The Internet can make you smarter, but it can't make you smart. It can extend your reach, but it will never tell you what to say at a P.T.A. meeting. These fundamentals cannot be downloaded. You can only upload them, the old-fashioned way, one by one, in places like Room 313 at St. Louis Park High. I only regret that I didn't write this column when the woman who taught me all that was still alive.

Thomas L. Friedman, "Foreign Affairs: My Favorite Teacher," *The New York Times*, January 9, 2001. Copyright © 2001 by The New York Times. All rights reserved. Used under license.

¹*Six-Day War*: the short but pivotal war in June 1967 between Israel and the allied countries of Egypt, Syria, and Jordan.

²*Ariel Sharon* (1928 – 2014): Israeli general and politician, elected prime minister of Israel in 2001.

³*Wolfman Jack*: pseudonym of Robert Weston Smith (1938 – 1995), a famous American rock-and-roll radio disc jockey.

⁴*harangued*: given a long, scolding lecture.

⁵*admonition*: a warning or cautionary advice.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Friedman claims that his high school journalism teacher, Hattie M. Steinberg, was “someone who made the most important difference in my life” (1). What details in Friedman’s portrait of his teacher stand out for you? Why do you suppose Friedman chose the details that he did? What dominant impression of Steinberg do they collectively create? (Glossary: [Dominant Impression](#))
2. Hattie M. Steinberg taught her students the fundamentals of journalism — “not simply how to write a lead or accurately transcribe a quote, but, more important, how to comport yourself in a professional way and to always do quality work” (3). According to Friedman, what other fundamentals did she introduce to her students? Why do you think he values these fundamentals so much?
3. Friedman punctuates his description of Steinberg’s teaching with short, pithy sentences. For example, he ends paragraph 2 with the sentence “She was that good” and paragraph 3 with “She wanted to teach us about consequences.” Identify several other short sentences Friedman uses. What do these sentences have in common? How do short sentences like these affect you as a reader? Explain.
4. Why do you think Friedman tells us three times that Steinberg’s classroom was number 313 at St. Louis Park High School?

5. According to Friedman, what went wrong when the “huge dot-com-Internet-globalization bubble” (10) of the late 1990s burst?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What do you think was Friedman’ s purpose in writing this essay? (Glossary: [Purpose](#))
2. What assumptions does Friedman make about the nature and value of education? In what ways does Hattie M. Steinberg reflect these assumptions? Explain.
3. What do you think Friedman means when he states, “The Internet can make you smarter, but it can’ t make you smart” (paragraph 11)? What role or roles does he see technology fulfilling in American classrooms?

Classroom Activity Using Unity

Mark Wanner, a student, wrote the following essay using this thesis statement:

In order to provide a good learning environment in school, the teachers and administrators need to be strong leaders.

Unfortunately, some of the sentences disrupt the unity of the essay. Find these sentences, eliminate them, and reread the essay.

Strong School Leaders

- 1 School administrators and teachers must do more than simply supply students with information and a school building. They must also provide students with an atmosphere that allows them to focus on learning within the walls of the school. Whether the walls are brick, steel, or cement, they are only walls, and they do not help to create an appropriate atmosphere. Strong leadership both inside and outside the classroom yields a school in which students are able to excel in their studies because they know how to conduct themselves in their relationships with their teachers and fellow students.
- 2 A recent change in the administration of Eastside High School demonstrated how important strong leadership is to learning. Under the previous administration, parents and students complained that not enough emphasis was placed on studies. Most of the students lived in an impoverished neighborhood that had only one park for several thousand residents. Students were allowed to leave school at any time of the day, and little was done to curb the growing substance abuse problem. “What’s the point of trying to teach algebra to students who are just going to get jobs as part-time sales clerks, anyway?” Vice Principal Iggy Norant said when questioned about his school’s poor academic standards. Mr. Norant was known to students as

Twiggy Iggy because of his tall, thin frame. Standardized test scores at the school lagged well behind the state average, and only 16 percent of the graduates attended college within two years.

- 3 Five years ago, the school board hired Mary Peña, former chair of the state educational standards committee, as principal. A cheerleader in college, Ms. Peña got her BA in recreation science before getting her master's in education. She immediately emphasized the importance of learning, replacing any faculty members who did not share her high expectations of the students. Among those she fired was Mr. Norant; she also replaced two social studies teachers, one math teacher, four English teachers, and a lab instructor who let students play Gameboy in lab. She also established a code of conduct, which clearly stated the rules all students had to follow. Students were allowed second chances, but those who continued to conduct themselves in a way that interfered with the other students' ability to learn were dealt with quickly and severely. "The attitude at Eastside has changed so much since Mary Peña arrived," said math teacher Jeremy Rifkin after Peña's second year. "Students come to class much more relaxed and ready to learn. I feel like I can teach again." Test scores at Eastside are now well above state averages, and 68% of the most recent graduating class went straight to college.

—Mark Wanner, student

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Friedman believes that “the real secret of success in the information age is what it always was: fundamentals — reading, writing, and arithmetic; church, synagogue, and mosque; the rule of law; and good governance” (10). Do you agree? What are the fundamentals that you value most? Write a unified essay in which you discuss what you believe to be the secret of success today.
2. Who are your favorite teachers? What important differences have these people made in your life? What characteristics do these teachers share with Hattie M. Steinberg in this essay or Anne Mansfield Sullivan in Helen Keller’s [“The Most Important Day”](#) (p. 99)? Using examples from your own school experience as well as from one or more of the essays noted above, write an essay in which you explore what makes a great teacher. Be sure to choose examples that clearly illustrate each of your points.

The Most Important Day

Helen Keller



Bradley Smith/CORBIS/Getty Images

Helen Keller (1880 – 1968) was born in Tuscumbia, Alabama. At the age of eighteen months, she was afflicted by a disease that left her blind and deaf. With the aid of her teacher, Anne Mansfield Sullivan, she was able to overcome her severe handicaps, to graduate from Radcliffe College, and to lead a productive and challenging adult life. In the following selection from her autobiography, *The Story of My Life* (1902), Keller tells of the day she first met Anne Sullivan, a day she regarded as the most important in her life.

As you read, note that Keller maintains unity within her narrative by emphasizing the importance of the day her teacher arrived, even though her story deals with the days and weeks following.

Reflecting on What You Know

Reflect on the events of what you consider “the most important day” of your life. Briefly describe what happened. Why was that particular day so significant?

The most important day I remember in all my life is the one on which my teacher, Anne Mansfield Sullivan, came to me. I am filled with wonder when I consider the immeasurable contrast between the two lives which it connects. It was the third of March, 1887, three months before I was seven years old.

On the afternoon of that eventful day, I stood on the porch, dumb,¹ expectant. I guessed vaguely from my mother's signs and from the hurrying to and fro in the house that something unusual was about to happen, so I went to the door and waited on the steps. The afternoon sun penetrated the mass of honeysuckle that covered the porch and fell on my upturned face. My fingers lingered almost unconsciously on the familiar leaves and blossoms which had just come forth to greet the sweet southern spring. I did not know what the future held of marvel or surprise for me. Anger and bitterness had preyed upon me continually for weeks and a deep languor² had succeeded this passionate struggle.

Have you ever been at sea in a dense fog, when it seemed as if a tangible white darkness shut you in, and the great ship, tense and anxious, groped her way toward the shore with plummet and sounding-line,³ and you waited with beating heart for something to happen? I was like that ship before my education began, only I was without compass or sounding-line, and had no way of knowing how near the harbor was. "Light! Give me light!" was the wordless cry of my soul, and the light of love shone on me in that very hour.

I felt approaching footsteps. I stretched out my hand as I supposed to my mother. Someone took it, and I was caught up and held close in the arms of her who had come to reveal all things to me, and, more than all things else, to love me.

The morning after my teacher came she led me into her room and gave me a doll. The little blind children at the Perkins Institution⁴ had sent it and Laura Bridgman⁵ had dressed it; but I did not know this until afterward. When I had played with it a little while, Miss Sullivan slowly spelled into my hand the word “d-o-l-l.” I was at once interested in this finger play and tried to imitate it. When I finally succeeded in making the letters correctly I was flushed with childish pleasure and pride. Running downstairs to my mother I held up my hand and made the letters for doll. I did not know that I was spelling a word or even that words existed; I was simply making my fingers go in monkeylike imitation. In the days that followed I learned to spell in this uncomprehending way a great many words, among them *pin*, *hat*, *cup* and a few verbs like *sit*, *stand*, and *walk*. But my teacher had been with me several weeks before I understood that everything has a name.

One day, while I was playing with my new doll, Miss Sullivan put my big rag doll into my lap also, spelled “d-o-l-l” and tried to make me understand that “d-o-l-l” applied to both. Earlier in the day we had had a tussle over the words “m-u-g” and “w-a-t-e-r.” Miss Sullivan had tried to impress it upon me that “m-u-g” is *mug* and that “w-a-t-e-r” is *water*, but I persisted in confounding the two. In despair she had dropped the subject for the time, only to renew it at the first opportunity. I became impatient at her repeated attempts and, seizing the new doll, I dashed it upon the

floor. I was keenly delighted when I felt the fragments of the broken doll at my feet. Neither sorrow nor regret followed my passionate outburst. I had not loved the doll. In the still, dark world in which I lived there was no strong sentiment or tenderness. I felt my teacher sweep the fragments to one side of the hearth, and I had a sense of satisfaction that the cause of my discomfort was removed. She brought me my hat, and I knew I was going out into the warm sunshine. This thought, if a wordless sensation may be called a thought, made me hop and skip with pleasure.

We walked down the path to the well-house, attracted by the fragrance of the honeysuckle with which it was covered. Someone was drawing water and my teacher placed my hand under the spout. As the cool stream gushed over one hand she spelled into the other the word *water*, first slowly, then rapidly. I stood still, my whole attention fixed upon the motions of her fingers. Suddenly I felt a misty consciousness as of something forgotten — a thrill of returning thought; and somehow the mystery of language was revealed to me. I knew then that “w-a-t-e-r” meant the wonderful cool something that was flowing over my hand. The living word awakened my soul, gave it light, hope, joy, set it free! There were barriers still, it is true, but barriers that could in time be swept away.

I left the well-house eager to learn. Everything had a name, and each name gave birth to a new thought. As we returned to the house every object which I touched seemed to quiver with life. That was because I saw everything with the strange, new sight that had come to me. On entering the door I remembered the doll I had broken. I felt my way to the hearth and picked up the pieces. I tried vainly to put them together. Then my eyes filled with tears; for I realized what I had done, and for the first time I felt repentance and sorrow.

I learned a great many new words that day. I do not remember what they all were; but I do know that *mother*, *father*, *sister*, *teacher* were among them — words that were to make the world blossom for me, “like Aaron’ s rod,⁶ with flowers.” It would have been difficult to find a happier child than I was as I lay in my crib at the close of that eventful day and lived over the joys it had brought me, and for the first time longed for a new day to come.

¹*dumb*: unable to speak; mute.

²*languor*: sluggishness.

³*plummet* ... *line*: a weight tied to a line that is used to measure ocean depth.

⁴*Perkins Institution*: the first school for blind children in the United States, opened in 1832 and located in South Boston during Keller’ s time there. The school moved to Watertown, Massachusetts, in 1912.

⁵*Laura Bridgman (1829–1889)*: a deaf-blind girl who was educated at the Perkins Institution in the 1840s.

⁶*Aaron's rod*: in Jewish and Christian traditions, a rod similar to Moses's staff that, in the high priest Aaron's hands, had miraculous power.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is Keller's thesis? (Glossary: [Thesis](#)) What question do you think Keller is trying to answer? Does her thesis answer her question?
2. What was Keller's state of mind before Anne Sullivan arrived to help her? To what does she compare herself? (Glossary: [Analogy](#)) How effective is this comparison? Explain.
3. Why was the realization that everything has a name important to Keller?
4. How was the "mystery of language" (8) revealed to Keller? What were the consequences for her of this new understanding of the nature of language?
5. Keller narrates the events of the day Sullivan arrived (2–4), the morning after she arrived (5), and one day several weeks after her arrival (6–9). (Glossary: [Narration](#)) Describe what happens on each day, and explain how these separate incidents support Keller's thesis.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What evidence does Keller supply to support her thesis that the most important day in her life was the one on which Anne Mansfield Sullivan arrived at her home? Would you describe this evidence as fact, opinion, or a little of both?
2. How would you describe Keller's tone in this selection? (Glossary: [Tone](#)) What about her diction, sentence structure, and attitude toward her subject led you to your conclusion?
3. Keller writes that “ ‘Light! Give me light!’ was the wordless cry of my soul” (paragraph 3). What was the “light” that Keller longed for? How does Keller, blind and deaf from the age of eighteen months, manage to explain her world to an audience that can both see and hear? Explain.

Classroom Activity Using Unity

Write a unified paragraph that makes a clear statement about the following list of items. Then compare your paragraph with another student's work. How did each of you establish relationships among the items on the list? How does your writing help your reader make these connections?

a coffee maker
a toaster oven
a stove
a cookbook
a frying pan

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Think about an important day in your own life. Using the thesis statement “The most important day of my life was _____,” write an essay in which you show the significance of that day by recounting and explaining the events that took place, as Keller does in her essay. Before you write, you might find it helpful to reflect on your response to the Reflecting on What You Know prompt for this reading. Review your list to be sure that there are no items that break the unity. In other words, are there any events that you have listed that do not belong because they are not part of that same day or fail to shed light on the events of that day?
2. For many people around the world, the life of Helen Keller symbolizes what a person can achieve despite seemingly insurmountable obstacles. Her achievements have inspired people with and without disabilities, leading them to believe they can accomplish more than they ever thought possible. Consider the role of

people with disabilities in our society, develop an appropriate thesis, and write an essay on the topic. If you have a disability, you may use your own experiences to support your thesis. Be sure that the specific details that you incorporate in the essay are unified; that is, details should relate directly to the thesis and topics that support the thesis.

Against Meat

Jonathan Safran Foer



Emily Berl/Getty Images

Jonathan Safran Foer was born in 1977 in Washington, D.C., and educated at Princeton University, where he took an introductory writing course from Joyce Carol Oates. He is the author of the award-winning and best-selling novels *Everything Is Illuminated* (2002) and *Extremely Loud and Incredibly Close* (2005), both of which have been made into motion pictures, as well as the book art piece *Tree of Codes* (2010). His most recent novel is *Here I Am* (2016). He currently teaches writing at New York University. Foer serves on the board of Farm Forward, a nonprofit organization dedicated to advancing healthy food choices, reducing livestock suffering, and promoting sustainable agriculture.

This selection is adapted from his third book, the nonfiction *Eating Animals* (2009), in which becoming a new father pushes him to confront the cultural importance and ethics of our eating habits. As you read, pay attention to Foer's sympathetic portrayal of food as a center of family life, despite his vegetarian convictions. Note how each of his arguments against eating meat is unified by his desire to lead what he sees as a moral life.

Reflecting on What You Know

Reflect on the meals that are part of your family history and tradition. What sorts of food were served, and who cooked it? What impact has food had on your experience of family?

Seconds after being born, my son was breast-feeding. I watched him with an awe that had no precedent¹ in my life. Without explanation or experience, he knew what to do. Millions of years of evolution had wound the knowledge into him, as it had encoded beating into his tiny heart and expansion and contraction into his newly dry lungs.

Almost four years later, he is a big brother and a remarkably sophisticated little conversationalist. Increasingly the food he eats is digested together with stories we tell. Feeding my children is not like feeding myself: it matters more. It matters because food matters (their physical health matters, the pleasure they take in eating matters), and because the stories that are served with food matter.

Some of my happiest childhood memories are of sushi “lunch dates” with my mom, and eating my dad’s turkey burgers with mustard and grilled onions at backyard celebrations, and of course my grandmother’s chicken with carrots. Those occasions simply wouldn’t have been the same without those foods — and that is important. To give up the taste of sushi, turkey or chicken is a loss that extends beyond giving up a pleasurable eating experience. Changing what we eat and letting tastes fade from memory create a kind of cultural loss, a forgetting. But perhaps this kind of forgetfulness is worth accepting — even worth cultivating (forgetting, too, can be cultivated). To remember my values, I need to lose

certain tastes and find other handles for the memories that they once helped me carry.

My wife and I have chosen to bring up our children as vegetarians. In another time or place, we might have made a different decision. But the realities of our present moment compelled us to make that choice. According to an analysis of U.S.D.A.² data by the advocacy group Farm Forward, factory farms now produce more than 99 percent of the animals eaten in this country. And despite labels that suggest otherwise, genuine alternatives — which do exist, and make many of the ethical questions about meat moot — are very difficult for even an educated eater to find. I don't have the ability to do so with regularity and confidence. (“Free range,” “cage free,” “natural” and “organic” are nearly meaningless when it comes to animal welfare.)

According to reports by the Food and Agriculture Organization of the U.N.³ and others, factory farming has made animal agriculture the No. 1 contributor to global warming (it is significantly more destructive than transportation alone), and one of the Top 2 or 3 causes of all of the most serious environmental problems, both global and local: air and water pollution, deforestation, loss of biodiversity... Eating factory-farmed animals — which is to say virtually every piece of meat sold in supermarkets and prepared in

restaurants — is almost certainly the single worst thing that humans do to the environment.

Every factory-farmed animal is, as a practice, treated in ways that would be illegal if it were a dog or a cat. Turkeys have been so genetically modified⁴ they are incapable of natural reproduction. To acknowledge that these things matter is not sentimental. It is a confrontation with the facts about animals and ourselves. We know these things matter.

Meat and seafood are in no way necessary for my family — unlike some in the world, we have easy access to a wide variety of other foods. And we are healthier without it. So our choices aren' t constrained.

While the cultural uses of meat can be replaced — my mother and I now eat Italian, my father grills veggie burgers, my grandmother invented her own “vegetarian chopped liver” — there is still the question of pleasure. A vegetarian diet can be rich and fully enjoyable, but I couldn' t honestly argue, as many vegetarians try to, that it is as rich as a diet that includes meat. (Those who eat chimpanzee look at the Western diet as sadly deficient of a great pleasure.) I love calamari, I love roasted chicken, I love a good steak. But I don' t love them without limit.

This isn' t animal experimentation, where you can imagine some proportionate good at the other end of the suffering. This is what we feel like eating. Yet taste, the crudest of our senses, has been exempted from the ethical rules that govern our other senses. Why? Why doesn' t a horny person have as strong a claim to raping an animal as a hungry one does to confining, killing and eating it? It' s easy to dismiss that question but hard to respond to it. Try to imagine any end other than taste for which it would be justifiable to do what we do to farmed animals.

Children confront us with our paradoxes⁵ and dishonesty, and we are exposed. You need to find an answer for every why — Why do we do this? Why don' t we do that? — and often there isn' t a good one. So you say, simply, because. Or you tell a story that you know isn' t true. And whether or not your face reddens, you blush. The shame of parenthood — which is a good shame — is that we want our children to be more whole than we are, to have satisfactory answers. My children not only inspired me to reconsider what kind of eating animal I would be, but also shamed me into reconsideration.

And then, one day, they will choose for themselves. I don' t know what my reaction will be if they decide to eat meat. (I don' t know what my reaction will be if they decide to renounce their Judaism, root for the Red Sox or register Republican.) I' m not as worried about what they will choose

as much as my ability to make them conscious of the choices before them. I won' t measure my success as a parent by whether my children share my values, but by whether they act according to their own.

In the meantime, my choice on their behalf means they will never eat their great-grandmother' s singular dish. They will never receive that unique and most direct expression of her love, will perhaps never think of her as the greatest chef who ever lived. Her primal story, our family' s primal story, will have to change.

Or will it? It wasn' t until I became a parent that I understood my grandmother' s cooking. The greatest chef who ever lived wasn' t preparing food, but humans. I' m thinking of those Saturday afternoons at her kitchen table, just the two of us — black bread in the glowing toaster, a humming refrigerator that couldn' t be seen through its veil of family photographs. Over pumpernickel ends and Coke, she would tell me about her escape from Europe, the foods she had to eat and those she wouldn' t. It was the story of her life — “Listen to me,” she would plead — and I knew a vital lesson was being transmitted, even if I didn' t know, as a child, what that lesson was.

1*precedent*: an example or model, usually set by an earlier occurrence or long practice.

²*U. S. D. A.* : United States Department of Agriculture; government branch overseeing food, farming, nutrition, and related public policies.

³*U. N.* : the United Nations, an international organization founded after World War II to confront global issues affecting humanity, such as human rights and climate change.

⁴*genetically modified*: containing a genetic structure that has been altered to produce desired results.

⁵*paradoxes*: contradictions.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Foer states that millions of years of evolution are behind his infant son's instinct to breastfeed (paragraph 1). How does this relate to his later argument about his decision to become a vegetarian? (Glossary: [Argumentation](#))
2. Foer argues that changing what people eat can create a “cultural forgetting” (3). What does he mean by this? How then can he justify becoming a vegetarian, which means no longer eating the foods he used to eat?
3. Foer names animal agriculture — and, specifically, factory farming — as the biggest contributor to global warming and the cause of other environmental problems (5). Why does this matter so much to him? Does he think the actions that he and his family are

taking will have any effect on these global problems? Explain.

4. Why does Foer state that his grandmother's "primal story, our family's primal story, will have to change" (12)? Is such a thing possible?
5. In his conclusion, Foer brings together the idea of food and family by reflecting on his own childhood memories with his grandmother (13). How does the ending unify Foer's essay? (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Foer states that "taste, the crudest of our senses, has been exempted from the ethical rules that govern our other senses" (9). What does he mean? Why do you think he considers taste cruder than our senses of touch, seeing, hearing, and smelling? Do you agree? Explain and support your opinion with examples.
2. Foer admits that a vegetarian diet is not as "rich" as a diet that includes meat (8). Does this admission weaken his overall argument, or does it make his decision to become a vegetarian more sympathetic and realistic? Why?
3. What underlying values are implicit in Foer's argument against eating meat, and why does he believe

that it's important for him to share these with his children?

Classroom Activity Using Unity

Make a list of foods that have had special relevance to you, whether because of the person who cooked the food, the occasion or place where it was eaten, the cultural or personal history behind the food, or any other significant reason. In a group, compare your lists of foods with your classmates' lists. Make a "map" of the foods, drawing connections between them based on why they're important. What does this say about your group's "society"? Does it reveal anything important about your shared values and ethics or your cultural practices? More broadly, how does food connect us?

Suggested Writing Assignments

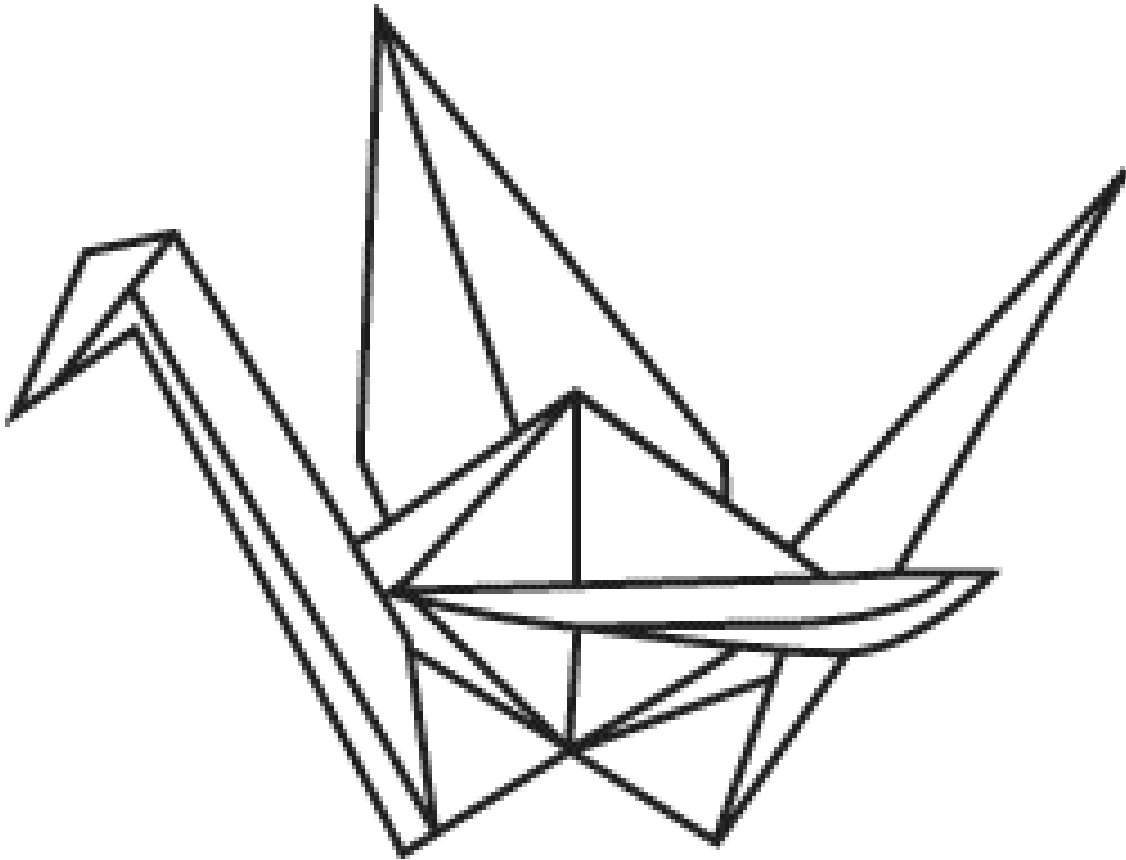
1. Foer makes a moral argument for vegetarianism based on the environmental harm done by factory farms and the suffering of the animals in those farms. Do you agree that his reasons are important, whether or not you're a vegetarian? Write a unified essay in which you argue whether you found his reasoning convincing

(or convicting). Be sure to include reasons to support your thesis; you may want to do some library or Internet research for more points for or against vegetarianism.

2. Write a unified essay about your own experiences with food and family. Include important details about the types of food associated with special family members and occasions and the emotional relevance and importance of the food to you. Be sure all of your paragraphs and examples support the thesis of your essay.



CHAPTER 5 Organization



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

In an essay, ideas and information cannot be presented all at once; they have to be arranged in some order. That order is the essay's **organization**.

The pattern of organization in an essay should be suited to the writer's subject and **purpose**. For example, if you are writing about your experience working in a fast-food restaurant and your purpose is to tell about the activities of a typical day, you might present those activities in chronological order. If, on the other hand, you wish to argue

that working in a bank is an ideal summer job, you might proceed from the least rewarding to the most rewarding aspect of this job; this is called *climactic order*.

Some common patterns of organization are chronological order, space order, and logical order.

CHRONOLOGICAL ORDER

Chronological order, or time order, is used to present a sequence of events in the order they occurred. A personal narrative, a report of a campus incident, or an account of a historical event can be most naturally and easily related in chronological order. In the following paragraphs, student writer Jeffrey Olesky uses chronological order to recount an important lesson he learned playing golf.

The lesson I learned that day appears rather simple now. It came on the putting green of the second hole. My father had finished putting out, and I was holding the flagstick off to the side of the green while the other players finished. Generally, my father would come stand next to me and give me a hand, but due to circumstances we ended up on opposite sides of the green. During the next player's putt, my father lowered his eyebrows at me and nodded his head to one side a few times. Curious as to what he wanted me to do, I almost let the question slip out of my mouth. But I knew better. I had already learned the rules of not talking or moving while other golfers were hitting. I quietly stood my ground until everyone was finished and then placed the flagstick back in the hole. While walking toward the next tee box, I neared my father. Regardless of what he had wanted me to do, I thought he would commend me for not talking or moving during the ordeal.

"You know better than that, Jeffrey," he said.

“What?” I asked curiously, disappointed that he had not praised me on a job well done.

“You never stand so that your shadow is in someone’ s line.”

How could I be so stupid? He had reminded me a thousand times before. You never allow your shadow to fall in the line of someone’ s putt because it is distracting to the person putting. I rationalized to my father that maybe the man hadn’ t noticed or that it didn’ t bother him. Unfortunately, my father wasn’ t going to take that as an excuse. After explaining to me what I had done wrong, he suggested that I go over and apologize to the gentleman. I was still a young boy, and the figure of the older man was somewhat intimidating. This task was no easy chore because I was obviously very scared, and this is perhaps what made the lesson sink in a little deeper. I remember slowly approaching my father’ s friend and sheepishly looking back to my father for help. Once I realized I was on my own, I bashfully gave him my apologies and assured him that it wouldn’ t happen again. As you can probably guess, the repercussions were not as dramatic as I had envisioned them to be. Once my father had pointed out my mistake, I begged him to reconcile with the gentleman for me. However, in apologizing for myself, I learned a valuable lesson. Golf is important because it has taught me many social values such as this, but it can also be a personal, internal tool.

Of course, the order of events can sometimes be rearranged for special effect. For example, an account of an auto accident may begin with the collision itself and then flash back in time to the events leading up to it. The description

of a process — such as framing a poster or serving a tennis ball — almost always calls for a chronological organization.

When analyzing a causally related series of events, writers often use a chronological organization to clarify for readers the exact sequence of events. In the following example, the writer examines sequentially the series of malfunctions that led to the near disaster at the Three Mile Island nuclear facility in Harrisburg, Pennsylvania, showing clearly how each one led to the next:

On March 28, 1979, at 3:53 A.M., a pump at the Harrisburg plant failed. Because the pump failed, the reactor's heat was not drawn off in the heat exchanger and the very hot water in the primary loop overheated. The pressure in the loop increased, opening a release valve that was supposed to counteract such an event. But the valve stuck open and the primary loop system lost so much water (which ended up as a highly radioactive pool, six feet deep, on the floor of the reactor building) that it was unable to carry off all the heat generated within the reactor core. Under these circumstances, the intense heat held within the reactor could, in theory, melt its fuel rods, and the resulting "meltdown" could then carry a hugely radioactive mass through the floor of the reactor. The reactor's emergency cooling system, which is designed to prevent this disaster, was then automatically activated, but when it was, apparently, turned off too soon, some of the fuel rods overheated.

— Barry Commoner, *The Politics of Energy*

SPACE ORDER

Space order is used when describing a person, place, or thing. This organizational pattern begins at a particular point and moves in some direction, such as left to right, top to bottom, east to west, outside to inside, front to back, near to far, around, or over. In describing a house, for example, a writer could move from top to bottom, from outside to inside, or in a circle around the outside.

In the following paragraph, the subject is a baseball, and the writer describes it from the inside out, moving from its “composition-cork nucleus” to the print on its stitched cowhide cover:

It weighs just over five ounces and measures between 2.86 and 2.94 inches in diameter. It is made of a composition-cork nucleus encased in two thin layers of rubber, one black and one red, surrounded by 121 yards of tightly wrapped blue-gray wool yarn, 45 yards of white wool yarn, 54 more yards of blue-gray wool yarn, 150 yards of fine cotton yarn, a coat of rubber cement, and a cowhide (formerly horsehide) exterior, which is held together with 216 slightly raised red cotton stitches. Printed certifications, endorsements, and outdoor advertising spherically attest to its authenticity.

— Roger Angell, *Five Seasons: A Baseball Companion*

LOGICAL ORDER

Logical order can take many forms, depending on the writer's purpose. Often-used patterns include general to specific, most familiar to least familiar, and smallest to biggest. Perhaps the most common type of logical order is order of importance. Notice how the writer uses this order in the following paragraph:

The Egyptians have taught us many things. They were excellent farmers. They knew all about irrigation. They built temples which were afterwards copied by the Greeks and which served as the earliest models for the churches in which we worship nowadays. They invented a calendar which proved such a useful instrument for the purpose of measuring time that it has survived with few changes until today. But most important of all, the Egyptians learned how to preserve speech for the benefit of future generations. They invented the art of writing.

— Hendrick Willem Van Loon, *The Story of Mankind*

By organizing the material according to the order of increasing importance, the writer places special emphasis on the final sentence.

A student essay on outdoor education provides another example of logical order. In the paragraph that follows, the writer

describes some of the special problems students have during the traditionally difficult high school years. She then explains the benefits of involving such students in an outdoor education curriculum as a possible remedy, offers a quotation from a noteworthy text on outdoor education to support her views, and presents her thesis statement at the end of the paragraph — all logical steps in her writing.

Statement
of the
problem

For many students, the normally difficult time of high school is especially troublesome. These students may have learning disabilities, emotional-behavioral disorders, or low self-esteem, or they may be labeled “at-risk” because of socioeconomic background, delinquency, or drug and alcohol abuse. Any combination of these factors contributes negatively to students’ success in school. Often the traditional public or private high school may not be the ideal environment in which these students can thrive and live up to their highest potential.

A possible
remedy is
offered and
explained

Outdoor education can benefit these high schoolers and provide them with the means necessary to overcome their personal issues and develop skills, knowledge, and self-esteem that will enable them to become successful, self-aware, emotionally stable, and functional adults. In their book *Outdoor Education*, authors Smith, Carlson, Donaldson, and Masters state poignantly that outdoor education “can be one of the most effective forces in the community to prevent human erosion as well as land erosion; it can be one of the means of saving youngsters from the education scrap heap” (49). Outdoor education builds a relationship between students and the natural environment that might not be formed otherwise and gives students a respect for the world in which they live. Aspects of outdoor education should be implemented in the curriculums of high schools in order to achieve these results in all students.

Authorities
are quoted to
support the
suggested
solution

The thesis
is given
after a
preliminary
discussion
to increase
its accept-
ability

—Jinsie Ward, student

Description

The first paragraph reads, "For many students, the normally difficult time of high school is especially troublesome. These students may have learning disabilities, emotional-behavioral disorders, or low self-esteem, or they may be labeled 'at-risk' because of socioeconomic background, delinquency, or drug and alcohol abuse. A corresponding annotation reads, Statement of the problem. Any combination of these factors contributes negatively to students' success in school. Often the traditional public or private high school may not be ideal environment in which these"

"The first paragraph, a continuation from the previous page reads, "students can thrive and live up to their highest potential. Outdoor education can benefit these high schoolers and provide them with the means necessary to overcome their personal issues and develop skills, knowledge, and self-esteem that will enable them to become successful, self-aware, emotionally stable, and functional adults. A corresponding annotation reads, A possible remedy is offered and explained. In their book Outdoor Education, authors Smith, Carlson, Donaldson, and Masters state poignantly that outdoor education 'can be one of the most effective forces in the community to prevent human erosion as well as land erosion; it can be one of the means of saving youngsters from the education scrap heap' (49). A corresponding annotation reads, Authorities are quoted to support the suggested solution. Outdoor education builds a relationship between students and the natural environment that might not be formed otherwise and gives students a respect for the world in which they live. Aspects of outdoor education should be implemented in the curriculums of high

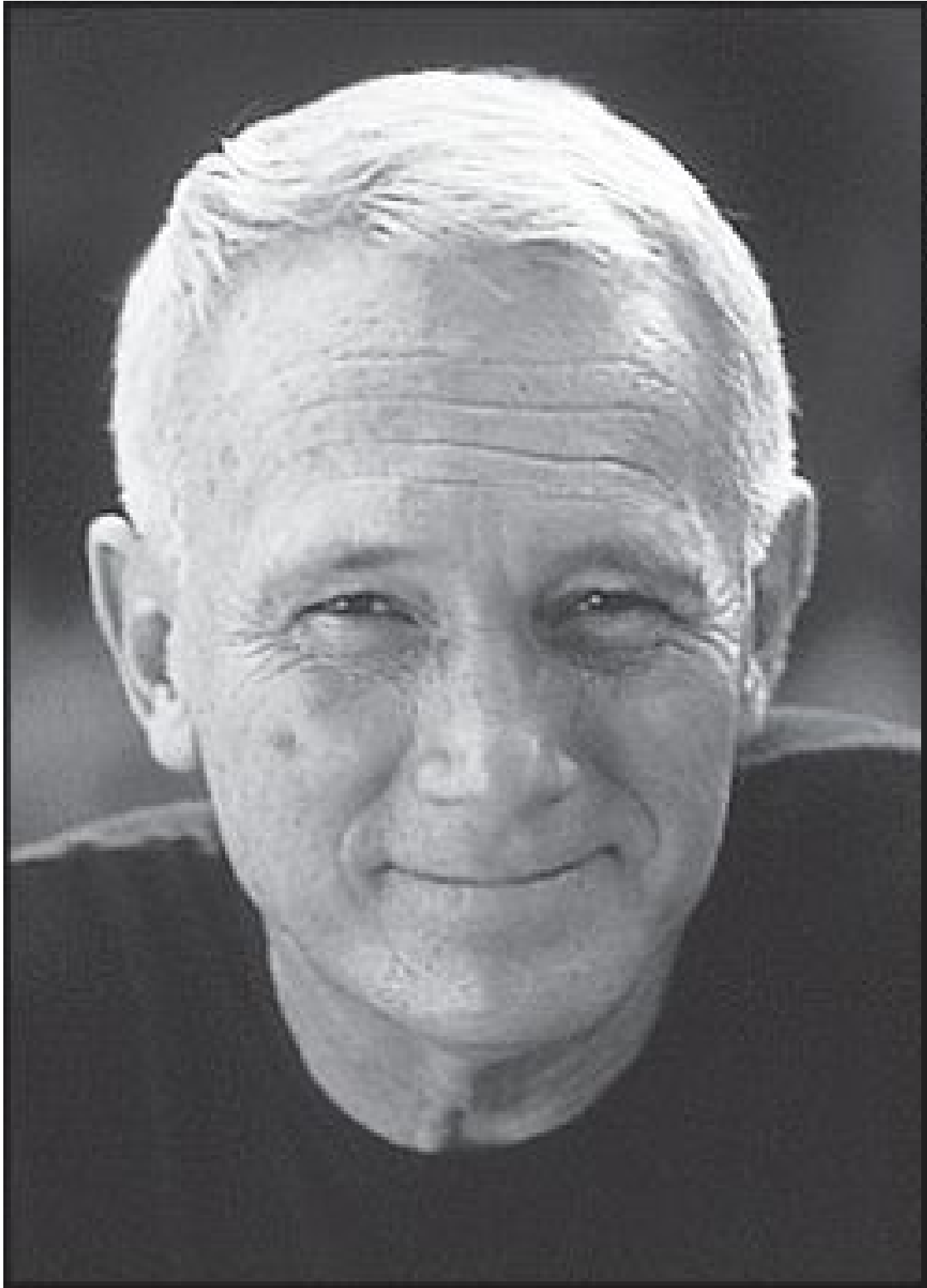
schools in order to achieve these results in all students.”
A corresponding annotation reads, The thesis is given after
a preliminary discussion to increase its acceptability. The
writer’s name reads, —Jinsie Ward, student.”

Although logical order can take many forms, the exact rationale always depends on the topic of the writing. For example, in writing a descriptive essay about a place you visited, you can move from the least striking to the most striking detail to keep your readers interested and involved in the description. In an essay explaining how to pick individual stocks for investment, you can start with the point that readers will find the least difficult to understand and move on to the most difficult-to-understand point. (That’s how many teachers organize their courses.) Or in writing an essay arguing for more internships and service learning courses, you can move from your least controversial to your most controversial point, preparing your reader gradually to accept your argument.

A simple way to check the organization of an essay is to outline it once you have a draft. Does the outline represent the organizational pattern — chronological, spatial, or logical — that you set out to use? Problems in outlining will naturally indicate sections that you need to revise.

A View from the Bridge

Cherokee Paul McDonald



Courtesy of Cherokee Paul McDonald

A fiction writer, memoirist, and journalist, Cherokee Paul McDonald was raised and schooled in Fort Lauderdale, Florida. In 1970, he returned home from a tour of duty in Vietnam and joined the Fort Lauderdale Police Department, where he rose to the rank of sergeant. In 1980, after receiving a degree in criminal science from Broward Community College, McDonald left the police department to become a writer. He worked a number of odd jobs before publishing his first book, *The Patch*, in 1986. In 1991, he published *Blue Truth*, a memoir. His novel *Summer's Reason* was released in 1994, and his memoir of the Vietnam War titled *Into the Green: A Reconnaissance by Fire*, was published in 2001.

“A View from the Bridge” was originally published in *Sunshine* magazine in 1990. As you read, notice how McDonald organizes his narrative. He tells us what the narrator and the boy are doing, but he also relies heavily on their dialogue to structure his story, which unfolds as the two talk. McDonald makes the story come alive by showing us, rather than by simply telling us, what happens.

Reflecting on What You Know

Make a list of your interests, focusing on those to which you devote a significant amount of time. Do you share any of these interests with people you know? What does a shared interest do for a relationship between two people?

I was coming up on the little bridge in the Rio Vista neighborhood of Fort Lauderdale, deepening my stride and my breathing to negotiate the slight incline without altering my pace. And then, as I neared the crest, I saw the kid.

He was a lumpy little guy with baggy shorts, a faded T-shirt and heavy sweat socks falling down over old sneakers.

Partially covering his shaggy blond hair was one of those blue baseball caps with gold braid on the bill and a sailfish patch sewn onto the peak. Covering his eyes and part of his face was a pair of those stupid-looking ' 50s-style wrap-around sunglasses.

He was fumbling with a beat-up rod and reel, and he had a little bait bucket by his feet. I puffed on by, glancing down into the empty bucket as I passed.

“Hey, mister! Would you help me, please?”

The shrill voice penetrated my jogger's concentration, and I was determined to ignore it. But for some reason, I stopped.

With my hands on my hips and the sweat dripping from my nose I asked, “What do you want, kid?”

“Would you please help me find my shrimp? It’ s my last one and I’ ve been getting bites and I know I can catch a fish if I can just find that shrimp. He jumped outta my hand as I was getting him from the bucket.”

Exasperated, I walked slowly back to the kid, and pointed.

“There’ s the damn shrimp by your left foot. You stopped me for *that*?”

As I said it, the kid reached down and trapped the shrimp.

“Thanks a lot, mister,” he said.

I watched as the kid dropped the baited hook down into the canal. Then I turned to start back down the bridge.

That’ s when the kid let out a “Hey! Hey!” and the prettiest tarpon¹ I’ d ever seen came almost six feet out of the water, twisting and turning as he fell through the air.

“I got one!” the kid yelled as the fish hit the water with a loud splash and took off down the canal.

I watched the line being burned off the reel at an alarming rate. The kid’ s left hand held the crank while the extended fingers felt for the drag setting.

“No, kid!” I shouted. “Leave the drag alone ... just keep that damn rod tip up!”

Then I glanced at the reel and saw there were just a few loops of line left on the spool.

“Why don’ t you get yourself some decent equipment?” I said, but before the kid could answer I saw the line go slack.

“Ohhh, I lost him,” the kid said. I saw the flash of silver as the fish turned.

“Crank, kid, crank! You didn’ t lose him. He’ s coming back toward you. Bring in the slack!”

The kid cranked like mad, and a beautiful grin spread across his face.

“He’ s heading in for the pilings,” 2 I said. “Keep him out of those pilings!”

The kid played it perfectly. When the fish made its play for the pilings, he kept just enough pressure on to force the fish out. When the water exploded and the silver missile hurled into the air, the kid kept the rod tip up and the line tight.

As the fish came to the surface and began a slow circle in the middle of the canal, I said, “Whooee, is that a nice fish or what?”

The kid didn’ t say anything, so I said, “Okay, move to the edge of the bridge and I’ ll climb down to the seawall and pull him out.”

When I reached the seawall I pulled in the leader, leaving the fish lying on its side in the water.

“How’ s that?” I said.

“Hey, mister, tell me what it looks like.”

“Look down here and check him out,” I said. “He’ s beautiful.”

But then I looked up into those stupid-looking sunglasses and it hit me. The kid was blind.

“Could you tell me what he looks like, mister?” he said again.

“Well, he’ s just under three, uh, he’ s about as long as one of your arms,” I said. “I’ d guess he goes about 15, 20 pounds. He’ s mostly silver, but the silver is somehow made

up of *all* the colors, if you know what I mean.” I stopped.

“Do you know what I mean by colors?”

The kid nodded.

“Okay. He has all these big scales, like armor all over his body. They’ re silver too, and when he moves they sparkle. He has a strong body and a large powerful tail. He has big round eyes, bigger than a quarter, and a lower jaw that sticks out past the upper one and is very tough. His belly is almost white and his back is a gunmetal gray. When he jumped he came out of the water about six feet, and his scales caught the sun and flashed it all over the place.”

By now the fish had righted itself, and I could see the bright-red gills as the gill plates opened and closed. I explained this to the kid, and then said, more to myself, “He’ s a beauty.”

“Can you get him off the hook?” the kid asked. “I don’ t want to kill him.”

I watched as the tarpon began to slowly swim away, tired but still alive.

By the time I got back up to the top of the bridge the kid had his line secured and his bait bucket in one hand.

He grinned and said, “Just in time. My mom drops me off here, and she’ ll be back to pick me up any minute.”

He used the back of one hand to wipe his nose.

“Thanks for helping me catch that tarpon,” he said, “and for helping me to see it.”

I looked at him, shook my head, and said, “No, my friend, thank you for letting *me* see that fish.”

I took off, but before I got far the kid yelled again.

“Hey, mister!”

I stopped.

“Someday I’ m gonna catch a sailfish and a blue marlin and a giant tuna and *all* those big sportfish!”

As I looked into those sunglasses I knew he probably would. I wished I could be there when it happened.

¹*tarpon*: a large, silvery fish.

²*pilings*: support columns driven vertically into the ground or ocean floor.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How does McDonald organize his essay? What period of time would you estimate is covered in this essay?
2. What clues lead up to the revelation that the boy is blind? Why does it take McDonald so long to realize it?
3. Notice the way McDonald chooses and adjusts some of the words he uses to describe the fish to the boy in [paragraphs 33 - 36](#). Why does he do this? How does he organize his description of the fish so that the boy can visualize it better?
4. By the end of the essay, we know much more about the boy beyond that he is blind, but after the initial description, McDonald characterizes him only indirectly. As the essay unfolds, what do we learn about the boy, and how does the author convey this knowledge?
5. What is the connotation of the word *view* in the title? (Glossary: [Connotation/Denotation](#)) Of the word *bridge*?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Near the end of the story, why does the narrator say to the boy, “No, my friend, thank you for letting *me* see that fish” (43)? What happens to the narrator’s

attitude as a result of his encounter with the boy? What lesson do you think the narrator learns? Did you come away from the story having learned anything? Explain.

2. McDonald tells much of his experience through dialogue (Glossary: [Dialogue](#)). What special organizational concerns do you think using dialogue requires of a writer?
3. Have you ever tried to make someone “see” something and come to a better understanding of it yourself in the process? Why do you think this happened?

Classroom Activity Using Organization

If you were to write an essay about the best ways to conserve energy in a home, you might organize that essay using a chronological order, a space order, or a logical order. Here are a few examples of possible organizations using each type of order:

1. From the basement to the attic (space order)
2. From the least expensive to the most expensive (logical order)
3. From the inside of the home to the outside (space order)
4. From the simplest to the most difficult (logical order)

5. From the quickest to the slowest (logical order)
6. From the longest payback to the quickest payback (logical order)
7. From the most general to the most specific (logical order)
8. From the first to the last (chronological order)
9. From what you can do to what you need help with (logical order)

Now, choose a topic from the following list. With a small group of two or three classmates, jot down some ways in which you can organize an essay on that topic using: (a) a chronological order, (b) a space order, and (c) a logical order.

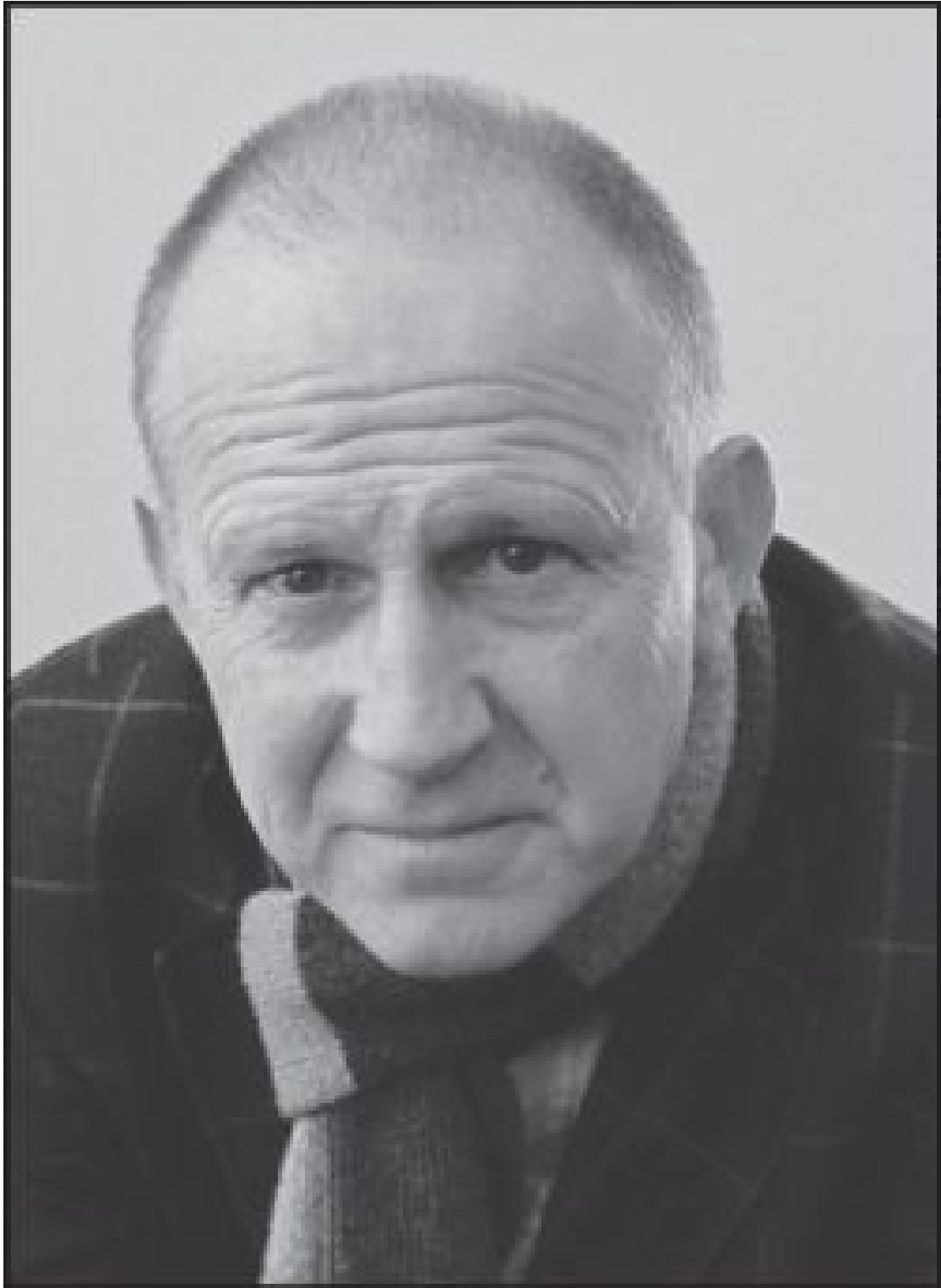
1. What to do when a tornado threatens
2. What we can do about the opioid crisis
3. What we mean by “freedom of speech”
4. A description of a painting
5. How a digital camera works
6. Why we need a flat income tax
7. What happened at your friend’s birthday party
8. How infectious diseases spread
9. Why we need the Electoral College
10. Consequences of climate change

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Recall a time when you and one other person held a conversation that helped you see something more clearly — visually, in terms of understanding, or both. Using McDonald’ s narrative as an organizational model, tell the story of that moment, re-creating the dialogue exactly as you remember it.
2. McDonald’ s “A View from the Bridge” is just one “fish story” in the long and rich tradition of that genre. In its own way, the story plays on the ironic notion that fishing is a quiet sport but one in which participants come to expect the unexpected.
(Glossary: [Irony](#)) For the narrator in the story, there is a lesson in not merely looking but truly seeing, in describing the fish so that the blind boy can “see” it. It is interesting that a sport in which “nothing happens” can be the source of so much storytelling. Write an essay in which you tell a “fish story” of your own, one that reveals a larger, significant truth or life lesson. Pay particular attention to the pattern of organization you choose, and be sure to revise your essay to tighten up your use of that pattern. If possible, incorporate some elements of surprise as well.

Do We Write Differently on a Screen?

Tim Parks



Schiffer-Fuchs/ullstein bild/Getty Images

Tim Parks, a novelist, essayist, and translator, was born in Manchester, England, in 1954 and grew up in London. He

studied at Cambridge University and Harvard University before moving to Italy. His first novel, *Tongues of Flame* (1986), won the Betty Trask Award and the Somerset Maugham Award. Parks has written seventeen novels, including *Europa* (1998), which was shortlisted for the Booker Prize. His published collections of essays include *Where I'm Reading From: The Changing World of Books* (2014) and *The Novel: A Survival Skill* (2015). Parks contributes regularly to *The New Yorker*, the *London Review of Books*, and the *New York Review of Books*. He is also a noted translator of Italian fiction, including various titles such as *Ka* (1998), *The Prince* (2009), and *Passions* (2014). His most recent nonfiction work, *Pen in Hand: Reading, Rereading and other Mysteries* (2019), details the positive and wonderful effects reading can have in a person's life. He currently lives in Verona, Italy, and teaches at the University of Verona.

The following essay, first published in 2019 in *The New Yorker*, compares and contrasts the different writing methods and devices that Parks has used throughout his prolific career. As you read, pay close attention to the way Parks organizes his essay, beginning with a discussion of the ballpoint pen and progressing all the way to modern laptop computers.

Reflecting on What You Know

Make a list of the different types of writing that you produce on any given day. Consider both the major (an essay for your English Composition class, an email to an employer or a professor) and the minor (signing a birthday card or a bill at the coffee shop). What are the differences in those experiences? Which types of writing do you find encourage the most creativity? In which contexts do you produce your best writing?

I wrote my first story in a university library, in Boston. It was 1978, and I was bored to death with structuralism and post-structuralism. I wrote with a cheap ballpoint pen in the exercise book that I used for lecture notes. I noticed at once that the time passed differently when writing a story. It wasn't quicker or slower, simply absent. You moved into a dream space. You didn't know whether it was early or late.

When I finished, I typed up the story on a small manual typewriter. I have to thank America for teaching me how to type fast, with all fingers and never looking at the keys. In England, you gave your weekly essay assignments to professors handwritten. In the States, they had to be typed. Walking back through the campus, late on spring evenings, you could hear a clatter of typewriters from open windows. I bought a book called "Teach Yourself Typewriting."

When a story was typed, you let it rest, then reread it and made handwritten corrections. Then reread it again. Then again. Then typed it up again, hopefully without mistakes. A lot of paper was thrown away. A lot of Wite-Out was used. You were a craftsman, producing pieces of paper with neat black signs. After making photocopies, you sent the story, by post, to a magazine, and it came back, months later, with a rejection and perhaps some suggestions how to improve it. You rewrote and retyped and re-sent.

It was many years before I had a story published. Meantime, I moved back to the U.K., then, with my Italian wife, to Verona, where I began to translate. Here, typing skills were invaluable. You rode your moped into town in the morning, picked up a piece of work — perhaps a description of a marble-quarrying machine — rode home and had to translate it onto camera-ready paper for evening delivery and immediate printing. There was no time for rough drafts. You read each sentence, thought it through, produced an English version in your head, and typed it out perfect the first time. It was a fantastic discipline. And hugely stressful.

In the early eighties, we bought an electric typewriter that could memorize about half a page before printing it out. To read the page, you had to scroll it from right to left, on a single line of display, between keyboard and print roller. It cost the equivalent of a thousand euros in today's money and

wasn't satisfactory. A year or two later, we spent double that for a machine that could memorize a fantastic four pages on an audiocassette and offered a yellowish monochrome¹ screen where you could read as many as fifteen lines at once. That was the machine on which I translated Roberto Calasso's "The Marriage of Cadmus and Harmony."² On more than one occasion, the audiocassette jammed and four pages of work were lost.

But, before that, I published my first short novel, "Tongues of Flame." I continued to write fiction by hand and then type it up. But, at least, once it was typed, you could edit on a screen. What a difference that was! What an invitation to obsession! Hitherto, there was a limit to how many corrections you could make by hand. There was only so much space on the paper. It was discouraging — typing something out time after time, to make more and more corrections. You learned to be satisfied with what you had. Now you could go on changing things forever. I learned how important it was to keep a copy of what I had written first, so as to remember what I had meant in the beginning. Sometimes it turned out to be better than the endlessly edited version.

Despite the introduction of this technology into the writing process, feedback on what you wrote was still slow. Long-distance and international phone calls were expensive, and editors and agents tended to communicate by letter. Post from

London took at least a week to arrive in Italy. When it came to reviews, English newspapers were hard to find and expensive if you did find them. You had to wait, sometimes months, for press cuttings from London. Every day, I listened for the postman, passing on his scooter, and rushed downstairs to check the mail when he passed. Nothing. Just when the price of fax machines fell to something affordable, we bought a flat³ in a new development on the edge of town. The phone company made us wait eighteen months for a line.

But this slowness was positive. You concentrated on the next piece of writing or the next translation. You learned not to worry too much what people were saying about you. What did it matter, so long as your publisher was more or less happy? We had personal computers at this point, but I still wrote fiction by hand. The mental space feels different when you work with paper. It is quieter. A momentum builds up, a spell between page and hand and eye. I like to use a nice pen and see the page slowly fill. But, for newspaper articles and translations, I now worked straight onto the computer. Which was more frenetic, nervy. The writing was definitely different. But more playful, too. You could move things around. You could experiment so easily. I am glad the computer wasn't available when I started writing. I might have been overwhelmed by the possibilities. But once you know what you're doing, the facility of the computer is wonderful.

Then e-mail arrived and changed everything. First, you would only hook the computer up through your landline phone a couple of times a day, as if there were a special moment to send and receive mail. Then came the permanent connection. Finally, the wireless, and, of course, the Internet. In the space of perhaps ten years, you passed from waiting literally months for a decision on something that you'd written, or simply for a reaction from a friend or an agent, to expecting a reaction immediately. Whereas in the past you checked your in-box once a day, now you checked every five minutes.

And now you could write an article for *The Guardian* or *The New York Times* as easily as you could write it for *L' Arena di Verona*.⁴ Write it and expect a response in hours. In minutes. You write the first chapter of a book and send it at once to four or five friends. Hoping they'd read it at once. It's impossible to exaggerate how exciting this was, at first, and how harmful to the spirit. You, everybody, are suddenly incredibly needy of immediate feedback. A few more years and you were publishing regularly online for the *New York Review of Books*. And, hours after publication, you could know how many people were reading the piece. Is it a success? Shall I follow up with something similar?

The mind becomes locked into an obsessive, manic back-and-forth. When immediate confirmation is not forthcoming, there is a sense of failure. Suddenly, the writer, very close to

his public, is tempted to work hard and fast to please immediately, superficially, in order to have immediate gratification for himself in return. Curiously, the apparent freedom of e-mail and the Internet makes us more and more conformist as we talk to each other unceasingly.

While you sit at your computer now, the world seethes behind the letters as they appear on the screen. You can toggle to a football match, a parliamentary debate, a tsunami. A beep tells you that an e-mail has arrived. WhatsApp flashes on the screen. Interruption is constant but also desired. Or at least you' re conflicted about it. You realize that the people reading what you have written will also be interrupted. They are also sitting at screens, with smartphones in their pockets. They won' t be able to deal with long sentences, extended metaphors. They won' t be drawn into the enchantment of the text. So should you change the way you write accordingly? Have you already changed, unwittingly?

Or should you step back? Time to leave your computer and phone in one room, perhaps, and go and work silently on paper in another. To turn off the Wi-Fi for eight hours. Just as you once learned not to drink everything in the hotel minibar, not to eat too much at free buffets, now you have to cut down on communication. You have learned how compulsive you are, how fragile your identity, how important it is to

cultivate a little distance. And your only hope is that others have learned the same lesson. Otherwise, your profession, as least as you thought of it, is finished.

¹*monochrome*: consisting of only one color.

²*Robert Calasso's "The Marriage of Cadmus and Harmony"*: an anthology, originally published in Italian in 1988, that retells stories from ancient Greek mythology for a modern audience.

³*flat* (British English): an apartment.

⁴*L' Arena di Verona*: a daily newspaper headquartered in Verona, Italy.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What method of organization does Parks use in this essay? (Glossary: [Organization](#)) What types of transitions does he use to help lead the reader through his ideas? List three specific transitions that he uses to support the overall organization.
2. What does Parks mean when he claims that editing on a screen is “an invitation to obsession” (5)? Do you agree with him?
3. Parks began his writing career with a ball-point pen and a blank page. For him, what are the positives of writing by hand? What does he mean when he states that this process creates “a spell between page and hand and eye” (7)?

4. In what specific ways does technological advancement change the way Parks approaches his writing?
5. Which type of ending strategy does Parks employ? (Glossary: [Endings](#)) What is his concluding message? Is it an effective way to end this essay? Why or why not?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. In this essay, Parks focuses on his personal experience with the writing methods he has used. What elements of the writing process has he neglected to discuss? (Glossary: [Writing Process](#)) Consider the following topics: prewriting, drafting, revising, and editing. Why do you think Parks has chosen not to mention or discuss certain aspects of the process?
2. In [paragraph 12](#), Parks makes an argument about the dangers of being closely connected. In his view, what hazards does this closeness create? Do you agree with his assessment? Why or why not?
3. Parks considers many different writing tools in this essay, including a ball-point pen, a manual typewriter, an electric typewriter, and a laptop. In your opinion, how effective is his essay at comparing and contrasting these writing devices? Does he present enough evidence to effectively evaluate the

similarities and differences between these tools? Why or why not? Point to specific examples.

Classroom Activity Using Organization

The following passage is taken from the late Stephen E. Ambrose' s book *Crazy Horse and Custer: The Parallel Lives of Two American Warriors* (1975). Carefully read and analyze the passage, in which Ambrose compares and contrasts Chief Crazy Horse and General George Armstrong Custer. Then answer the questions that follow.

It was bravery, above and beyond all other qualities, that Custer and Crazy Horse had in common. Each man was an outstanding warrior in war-mad societies. Thousands upon thousands of Custer' s fellow whites had as much opportunity as he did to demonstrate their courage, just as all of Crazy Horse' s associates had countless opportunities to show that they equaled him in bravery. But no white warrior, save his younger brother, Tom, could outdo Custer, just as no Indian warrior, save his younger brother, Little Hawk, could outdo Crazy Horse. And for both white and red societies, no masculine virtue was more admired than bravery. To survive, both societies felt they had to have men willing to put their lives on the line. For men who were willing to do so, no reward was too great, even though there were vast differences in the way each society honored its heroes.

Beyond their bravery, Custer and Crazy Horse were individualists, each standing out from the crowd in his separate way. Custer wore outlandish uniforms, let his hair fall in long, flowing golden locks across his shoulders, surrounded himself with pet animals and admirers, and in general did all he could to draw attention to himself. Crazy Horse's individualism pushed him in the opposite direction — he wore a single feather in his hair when going into battle, rather than a war bonnet. Custer's vast energy set him apart from most of his fellows; the Sioux distinguished Crazy Horse from other warriors because of Crazy Horse's quietness and introspection. Both men lived in societies in which drugs, especially alcohol, were widely used, but neither Custer nor Crazy Horse drank. Most of all, of course, each man stood out in battle as a great risk taker.

What is Ambrose's point in these two paragraphs? How does he use comparison and contrast to make this point? How has he organized his paragraphs? How else might he have organized them? Explain.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Throughout his essay, Parks compares and contrasts writing tools such as a ballpoint pen, a small manual typewriter, an electric typewriter, audiocassettes, fax machines, computers, and email. As time progresses in the essay, so does technology. Using

his essay as a model, think about the progression of technologies in another field, and consider how technological advancements have changed that field. Write a brief essay in which you explain these changes — including both positive and negative changes. Below are a few possible fields that you might write about:

- Photography
 - Maps
 - Music
 - Film/movies
 - Video games
2. Reflect on your own writing process and writing style. Have they changed over time? If so, how? What writing devices or technologies do you use, and how do those devices affect your writing process? Has the technology's effect on your writing been mostly positive, mostly negative, or mixed? Write a brief essay in which you answer these questions.

Shame Is Worth a Try

Dan M. Kahan



Courtesy of Dan M. Kahan

Dan M. Kahan was born in 1963 and graduated from Middlebury College in 1986 and Harvard Law School in 1989, where he served as president of the *Harvard Law Review*. He clerked for Judge Harry Edwards of the U.S. Court of Appeals for the District of Columbia circuit in 1989 – 1990 and for Justice Thurgood Marshall of the U.S. Supreme Court in 1990 – 1991. After practicing law for two years in Washington, D.C., Kahan launched his teaching career, first at the University of Chicago Law School and later at Yale Law School, where since 2003 he has been the Elizabeth K. Dollard Professor of Law. From 2005 to 2006, he served as deputy dean of Yale Law School, and in spring 2016 he served as a distinguished resident scholar at the Annenberg Public Policy Center at the University of Pennsylvania. His teaching and research interests include science communication, criminal law, risk perception, punishment, and evidence. Kahan is coauthor, with Tracey Meares, of *Urgent Times: Policing and Rights in Inner-City Communities* (1999).

In the following essay, first published in the *Boston Globe* on August 5, 2001, Kahan uses a pro-con organizational pattern to argue in favor of the use of shame as “an effective, cheap, and humane alternative to imprisonment.”

Reflecting on What You Know

Think about the times you were punished as a child. Who punished you — parents, teachers, or other authority

figures? What kinds of behavior were you punished for? What type of punishment, if any, worked best to deter you from behaving badly later on? Explain.

Is shame an appropriate criminal punishment? Many courts and legislators around the country think so. Steal from your employer in Wisconsin and you might be ordered to wear a sandwich board proclaiming your offense. Drive drunk in Florida or Texas and you might be required to place a conspicuous “DUI” bumper sticker on your car. Refuse to make your child-support payments in Virginia and you will find that your vehicle has been immobilized with an appropriately colored boot (pink if the abandoned child is a girl, blue if a boy).

Many experts, however, are skeptical of these new shaming punishments. Some question their effectiveness as a deterrent. Others worry that the new punishments are demeaning and cruel.

Who’s right? As is usually the case, both sides have their points. But what the shame proponents seem to be getting, and the critics ignoring, is the potential of shame as an effective, cheap, and humane alternative to imprisonment.

There’s obviously no alternative to imprisonment for murderers, rapists, and other violent criminals. But they

make up less than half the American prison population.

Liberal and conservative reformers alike have long believed that the remainder can be effectively punished with less severe “alternative sanctions,” like fines and community service. These sanctions are much cheaper than jail. They also allow the offender to continue earning an income so he can compensate his victim, meet his child-support obligations, and the like.

Nevertheless, courts and legislators have resisted alternative sanctions — not so much because they won’ t work, but because they fail to express appropriate moral condemnation of crime. Fines seem to say that offenders may buy the privilege of breaking the law; and we can’ t very well condemn someone for purchasing what we are willing to sell.

Nor do we condemn offenders to educate the retarded, install smoke detectors in nursing homes, restore dilapidated low income housing, and the like. Indeed, saying that such community service is punishment for criminals insults both those who perform such services voluntarily and those whom the services are supposed to benefit.

There’ s no confusion about the law’ s intent to condemn, however, when judges resort to public shaming. As a result,

judges, legislators, and the public at large generally do accept shame as a morally appropriate punishment for drunken driving, nonaggravated assaults, embezzlement,¹ small-scale drug distribution, larceny,² toxic waste dumping, perjury, and a host of other offenses that ordinarily would result in a short jail term.

The critics' anxieties about shame, moreover, seem overstated. Clearly, shame hurts. People value their reputations for both emotional and financial reasons. In fact, a series of studies by Harold Grasmick, a sociologist at the University of Oklahoma, suggests that the prospect of public disgrace exerts greater pressure to comply with the law than does the threat of imprisonment and other formal punishments.

There's every reason to believe, then, that shaming penalties will be an effective deterrent, at least for nonviolent crimes. Indeed, preliminary reports suggest that certain shaming punishments, including those directed at deadbeat dads, are extraordinarily effective.

At the same time, shame clearly doesn't hurt as much as imprisonment. Individuals who go to jail end up just as disgraced as those who are shamed, and lose their liberty to boot. Those who've served prison time are also a lot less likely to regain the respect and trust of their law-abiding

neighbors — essential ingredients of rehabilitation. Given all this, it's hard to see shame as cruel.

Consider the case of a Florida mother sentenced to take out a newspaper ad proclaiming “I purchased marijuana with my kids in the car.”

The prospect that her neighbors would see the ad surely caused her substantial embarrassment. But the alternative was a jail sentence, which would not only have humiliated her more but could also have caused her to lose custody of her children. Not surprisingly, the woman voluntarily accepted the shaming sanction in lieu of³ jail time, as nearly all offenders do.

Shame, like any other type of criminal punishment, can definitely be abused. Some forms of it, like the public floggings imposed by authoritarian states abroad, are pointlessly degrading.

In addition, using shame as a supplement rather than a substitute for imprisonment only makes punishment more expensive for society and destructive for the offender. Accordingly, requiring sex offenders to register with local authorities is harder to defend than are other types of shaming punishments, which are true substitutes for jail.

These legitimate points, however, are a reason to insist that shaming be carried out appropriately, not to oppose it across the board.

In short, shame is cheap and effective and frees up scarce prison space for the more serious offenses. Why not at least give it a try?

¹*embezzlement*: stealing money or goods entrusted to one's care.

²*larceny*: theft.

³*in lieu of*: in place of; instead of.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is Kahan's thesis? (Glossary: [Thesis](#)) Where does he state it most clearly? Is that the most effective place for his thesis?
2. What examples of shaming punishments does Kahan provide? Has he placed his examples in any particular order? If so, in what order?
3. How does Kahan handle the opposition argument that public shaming is cruel?
4. According to Kahan, why have courts and legislators resisted alternative punishments such as fines and community service?
5. What evidence does Kahan present to show that shaming punishments work? (Glossary: [Evidence](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What does Kahan mean when he states that “requiring sex offenders to register with local authorities is harder to defend than are other types of shaming punishments” (15)?
2. How convincing is Kahan’s argument? What is the strongest part of his argument? The weakest part? Explain.
3. Why do you suppose Kahan published his views on public shaming in *The Boston Globe* — a daily newspaper that is read by a general audience — rather than in a legal journal?

Classroom Activity Using Organization

Consider the ways in which you might organize a discussion of the seven states listed below. For each state, we have provided some basic information: the date it entered the Union, population (2010 census), land area, and number of electoral votes in a presidential election.

ALASKA
January 3, 1959

ARIZONA
February 14, 1912

710,231 people
570,374 square miles
3 electoral votes

6,392,017 people
113,642 square miles
11 electoral votes

FLORIDA

March 3, 1845
18,801,310 people
53,937 square miles
29 electoral votes

MONTANA

November 8, 1889
989,415 people
145,556 square miles
3 electoral votes

MISSOURI

August 10, 1821
5,988,927 people
69,709 square miles
10 electoral votes

OREGON

February 14, 1859
3,831,074 people
98,386 square miles
7 electoral votes

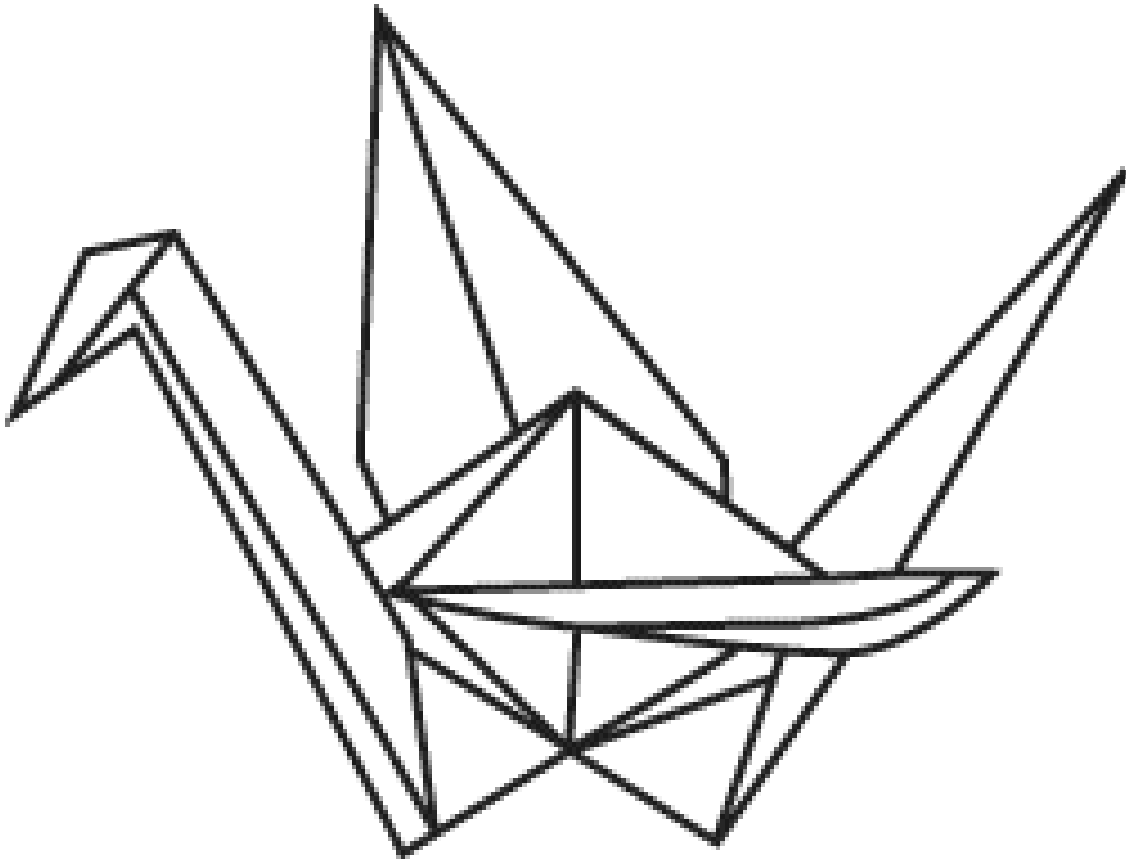
Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Identify several current problems at your college or university involving violations of campus rules for parking, cheating on exams, plagiarizing papers, recycling waste, using drugs or alcohol, defacing school property, and so on. Select one of these problems and write a proposal to treat violators with a shaming punishment of your own design. Address your proposal to your school's student government organization or administration office.
2. What is your position on the issue of whether convicted sex offenders should be required to register with local authorities? Should registration be required even though they have already served their sentences in prison? Should people have the

right to know the identity of any sex offenders living in their neighborhoods, or is this an invasion of privacy? Conduct library and internet research on the subject of sex offender registration, and write an essay arguing for or against the measure. Give special consideration to how you will organize your essay logically. Consider first drafting a simple outline of your main points to help you plan the structure of your essay.



CHAPTER 6 Beginnings and Endings



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

“Begin at the beginning and go on till you come to the end: then stop,” advised the King of Hearts in *Alice in Wonderland*. “Good advice, but more easily said than done,” you might be tempted to reply. Certainly, no part of writing essays can be more daunting than coming up with effective **beginnings and endings**. In fact, many writers believe that beginnings and endings are the most important parts of any piece of writing, regardless of its length. Even before coming to your introduction, your readers will usually know something about your intentions from your title. Titles such

as “The Case against Medical Marijuana,” “Laptop or Tablet: Which Should You Buy?” and “What Is a Migraine Headache?” indicate both your subject and your approach and prepare your readers for what follows.

BEGINNINGS

What makes for an effective beginning? Not unlike a personal greeting, a good beginning should catch a reader's interest and then hold it. The experienced writer realizes that many readers would rather do almost anything than make a commitment to read, so the opening — or *lede*, as journalists refer to it — requires a lot of thought and much revising to make it right and to keep the reader's attention from straying. The inexperienced writer, on the other hand, knows that the beginning is important but tries to write it first and to perfect it before moving on to the rest of the essay. Although there are no “rules” for writing introductions, we can offer one bit of general advice: wait until the writing process is well under way or almost completed before focusing on your opening. Following this advice will keep you from spending too much time on an introduction that you will undoubtedly revise. More important, once you actually see how your essay develops, you will know better how to introduce it to your reader.

In addition to capturing your reader's attention, a good beginning usually introduces your thesis and either suggests or actually reveals the structure of the composition. Keep in mind that the best beginning is not necessarily the most

catchy or the most shocking but the one most appropriate for the job you are trying to do.

There are many effective ways of beginning an essay. Here are a few of the most popular strategies.

Anecdote

Introducing your essay with an **anecdote** — a brief narrative drawn from current news events, history, or your personal experience — can be an effective way to capture your reader's interest. In the following example, the writer introduces an essay on choosing her career path by recounting the moment she first encountered her most inspiring teacher.

Picture this: it is my first day of AP European History, sophomore year of high school. I sit slumped over in my desk, listening to my teacher babbling on about some revolution or uprising somewhere in the world. I struggle to stay awake, wondering how I am ever going to get through this class today, let alone this year. All of a sudden a man enters our classroom, walks right up to my history teacher (who is sitting at a desk in the front of the classroom lecturing), whips out a hankie and a rubber band, and creates something like a keffiyeh (a traditional Middle Eastern head covering) on the head of my bald history teacher. My classmates and I wait in anxious anticipation for the outburst of angry words that are sure to follow. To our surprise and delight, Mr. C (our history teacher) cracks a smile, and we all burst into laughter. He introduces this strange man as our English teacher, Mr. R. This

mysterious Mr. R then proceeds to walk to the far end of the classroom, hoist himself up onto a desk, and walk across each student's desk to the other side of the room. This accomplished, he waves a final farewell and exits the classroom. This would be the English teacher I would never forget. He would be the one to inspire me to pursue a career in education.

— Karen Vaccaro, student

Analogy and Comparison

An [analogy](#), or comparison, can be useful in getting readers to think about a topic they might otherwise reject as uninteresting or unfamiliar. In the following multiparagraph example, William Zinsser introduces a subject few would consider engrossing — bloated, sloppy writing — with a comparison to disease. By pairing these two seemingly unrelated concepts, he both introduces and illustrates the idea he will develop in his essay: writing is a demanding craft, and to keep one's writing disease-free one must edit with a watchful eye.

Clutter is the disease of American writing. We are a society strangling in unnecessary words, circular constructions, pompous frills, and meaningless jargon.

Who can understand the clotted language of everyday American commerce: the memo, the corporation report, the business

letter, the notice from the bank explaining its latest “simplified” statement? What member of an insurance or medical plan can decipher the brochure explaining his costs and benefits? What father or mother can put together a child’s toy from the instructions on the box? Our national tendency is to inflate and thereby sound important. The airline pilot who announces that he is presently anticipating experiencing considerable precipitation wouldn’t think of saying it may rain. The sentence is too simple — there must be something wrong with it.

But the secret of good writing is to strip every sentence to its cleanest components. Every word that serves no function, every long word that could be a short word, every adverb that carries the same meaning that’s already in the verb, every passive construction that leaves the reader unsure of who is doing what — these are the thousand and one adulterants that weaken the strength of a sentence. And they usually occur in proportion to education and rank.

— William Zinsser, “Simplicity,” *On Writing Well*

Dialogue/Quotation

Although relying heavily on the ideas of others can weaken an effective introduction, opening your essay with a quotation or a brief **dialogue** can attract a reader’s attention and succinctly illustrate a particular attitude or point you want to discuss. In the following example, the writer introduces

an essay about the three main types of stress in our lives by recounting a brief dialogue with one of her roommates.

My roommate, Megan, pushes open the front door, throws her keys on the counter, and flops down on the couch.

“Hey, Megan, how are you?” I yell from the kitchen.

“I don’ t know what’ s wrong with me. I sleep all the time, but I’ m still tired. No matter what I do, I just don’ t feel well.”

“What did the doctor say?”

“She said it sounds like chronic fatigue syndrome.”

“Do you think it might be caused by stress?” I ask.

“Nah, stress doesn’ t affect me very much. I like keeping busy and running around. This must be something else.”

Like most Americans, Megan doesn’ t recognize the numerous factors in her life that cause her stress.

— Sarah Federman, “Identifying Stress”

Facts and Statistics

For the most part, you should use **facts** and statistics to support your argument rather than let them speak for you, but

presenting brief and startling facts or statistics can be an effective way to engage readers in your essay.

One out of every five new recruits in the United States military is female.

The Marines gave the Combat Action Ribbon for service in the Persian Gulf to twenty-three women.

Two female soldiers were killed in the bombing of the USS *Cole*.

The Selective Service registers for the draft all male citizens between the ages of eighteen and twenty-five.

What's wrong with this picture?

— Anna Quindlen, “Uncle Sam and Aunt Samantha”

Irony or Humor

It is often effective to introduce an essay with irony or humor. Humor signals to the reader that your essay will be entertaining to read, and **irony** can indicate an unexpected approach to a topic. Paul W. Merrill begins his ironic instructional essay on how to write poorly by establishing a wry tone, even poking fun at himself, stating that “the author ... can write poorly without half trying.”

Books and articles on good writing are numerous, but where can you find sound, practical advice on how to write poorly? Poor

writing is so common that every educated person ought to know something about it. Many scientists actually do write poorly, but they probably perform by ear without perceiving clearly how their results are achieved. An article on the principles of poor writing might help. The author considers himself well qualified to prepare such an article; he can write poorly without half trying.

The average student finds it surprisingly easy to acquire the usual tricks of poor writing. To do a consistently poor job, however, one must grasp a few essential principles:

1. Ignore the reader.
2. Be verbose, vague, and pompous.
3. Do not revise.

— Paul W. Merrill, [“The Principles of Poor Writing,”](#) p. 407

There are several other good ways to begin an essay; the following opening paragraphs illustrate each approach.

Short Generalization

Washington is a wonderful city. The scale seems right, more humane than other places. I like all the white marble and green trees, the ideals celebrated by the great monuments and memorials. I like the climate, the slow shift of the seasons here. Spring, so southern in feeling, comes early, and the long, sweet autumns can last into December. Summers are murder, equatorial — no question; the compensation is that Congress adjourns, the city empties out, eases off. Winter evenings in Georgetown with the snow falling and the lights just coming on are as beautiful as any I’ve known.

— David McCullough, *Brave Companions: Portraits in History*

Startling Claim

I’ ve finally figured out the difference between neat and sloppy people. The distinction is, as always, moral. Neat people are lazier and meaner than sloppy people.

— Suzanne Britt, “Neat People vs. Sloppy People”

Strong Proposition

For the ambulatory individual, access for the mobility-impaired on the University of Texas at Austin (UT) campus is easy to overlook. Automatic door entrances and bathrooms with the universal handicapped symbol make the campus seem sufficiently accessible. But for many students and faculty at UT, including me, maneuvering the UT campus in a wheelchair is a daily experience of stress and frustration. Although the university has made a concerted and continuing effort to improve access, students and faculty with physical disabilities still suffer from discriminatory hardship, unequal opportunity to succeed, and lack of independence.

The university must make campus accessibility a higher priority and take more seriously the hardship that the campus at present imposes on people with mobility impairments. Better accessibility would also benefit the numerous students and faculty with temporary disabilities and help the university recruit a more diverse body of students and faculty.

Rhetorical Questions

Where does the universe begin? Where does it end? The universe is so immense that it is difficult to wrap our minds around the sheer magnitude of it. Yet, despite the immensity of our universe, there is only one known planet that can support life as we know it. That planet, of course, is Earth — a unique and precious sphere teeming with life, beauty, mysteries, and wonder. Unfortunately, we tend to take our valuable home for granted, for it is easy to forget just how much our actions impact the environment. Why do we ignore those who point out the negative effects of our behaviors and ask us to change our ways, especially when it comes to the issue of global warming? Evidence shows that humans are largely responsible for causing this phenomenon, yet we continue to engage in old habits that only make it worse. Global warming is a serious issue affecting everyone, and so it is up to all of us to be more aware of our actions and change our harmful behaviors in order to protect our one and only home — and us.

— Kristen Sadowski, student

The “Beginnings to Avoid” box lists some examples of how *not* to begin an essay. You should always *avoid* using beginnings such as these in your writing.

Beginnings to Avoid

Apology

I am a college student and do not consider myself an expert on intellectual property, but I think file sharing and movie downloads should be legal.

Complaint

I'd rather write about a topic of my own choice than the one that is assigned, but here goes.

Dictionary

Webster's New Collegiate Dictionary defines the verb *to snore* as follows: "to breathe during sleep with a rough hoarse noise due to vibration of the soft palate."

Platitude/Cliché

America is the land of opportunity, and no one knows that better than Martha Stewart.

Reference to Title

As you can see from my title, this essay is about why we should continue to experiment with embryonic stem cells.

ENDINGS

An effective ending does more than simply indicate where the writer stopped writing. A strong conclusion may do the following:

- summarize
- inspire the reader to further thought or action
- return to the beginning by repeating key words, phrases, or ideas
- restate the thesis
- predict an outcome
- recommend a course of action or way of thinking
- surprise the reader by providing a particularly convincing example to support a thesis

Indeed, there are many ways to write a conclusion, but the effectiveness of any choice must be measured by how appropriately it fits what comes before it.

The following selections illustrate some approaches to conclusions.

Restatement of the Thesis

In an essay contrasting the traditional Hispanic understanding of the word *macho* with the meaning it has developed in mainstream American culture, Rose Del Castillo Guilbault begins her essay with a succinct, two-sentence paragraph offering her thesis:

What is *macho*? That depends which side of the border you come from.

She concludes her essay by restating her thesis, but in a manner that reflects the detailed examination she has given the concept of macho in her essay:

The impact of language in our society is undeniable. And the misuse of *macho* hints at a deeper cultural misunderstanding that extends beyond mere word definitions.

— Rose Del Castillo Guilbault, “Americanization Is Tough on ‘Macho’ ”

Figurative Language

In the following conclusion to her essay on global warming (you can read her introduction on [p. 138](#)), Kristen Sadowski summarizes the points she has made in her essay, ending with a clever use of figurative language to drive home her point. (See [the introduction to Chapter 13](#), pp. 320 – 321, for a detailed discussion of figurative language.)

Clearly, there are numerous ways for us to reduce our greenhouse gas emissions and prevent global warming from worsening. In fact, there are so many ways that it can be overwhelming. But we do not have to change our lifestyles entirely or implement every single solution. Instead, we can be more aware of our actions and make small changes here and there until we are comfortable with our newly formed habits. Often, changing our behaviors can be the hardest thing for us to do, especially if we are content with our current way of life. By making conscious efforts to become more environmentally responsible, however, we can all be successful in our attempts to make the world a better place. One person acting alone cannot impact global warming, but individuals acting together can make a huge difference. The Earth has a fever, and we have the medicine of our actions to keep that fever at bay.

— Kristen Sadowski, student

Overview of Argument

In the following conclusion to her essay “Title IX Just Makes Sense,” Jen Jarjosa offers an overview of her argument and concludes by predicting the outcome of the solution she advocates:

There have undeniably been major improvements in the treatment of female college athletes since the enactment of Title IX. But most colleges and universities still don’ t measure up to the actual regulation standards, and many have quite a ways to go. The Title IX fight for equality is not a radical feminist

movement, nor is it intended to take away the privileges of male athletes. It is, rather, a demand for fairness, for women to receive the same opportunities that men have always had. When colleges and universities stop viewing Title IX budget requirements as an inconvenience and start complying with the spirit and not merely the letter of the law, collegiate female athletes will finally reach the parity they deserve.

— Jen Jarjosa, student

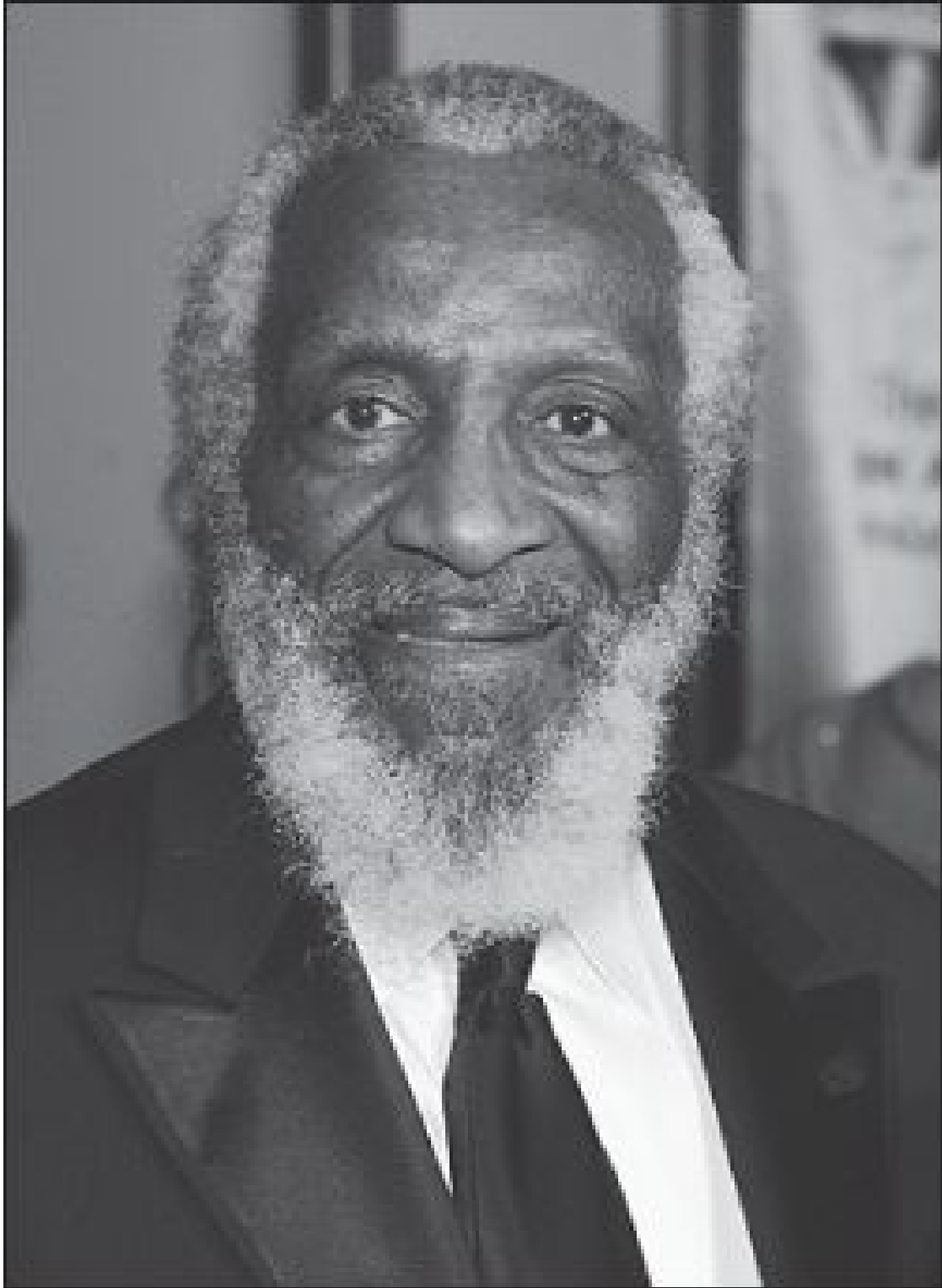
If you are having trouble with your conclusion — which is not an uncommon occurrence — it may be because of problems with your essay itself. Frequently, writers do not know when to end because they are not sure about their overall purpose. For example, if you are taking a trip and your purpose is to go to Chicago, you will know when you get there and will stop. But if you don' t really know where you are going, it' s very difficult to know when to stop.

It' s usually a good idea in your conclusion to avoid such overworked expressions as “In conclusion,” “In summary,” “I hope I have shown,” or “Finally.” Your conclusion should also do more than simply repeat what you' ve said in your opening paragraph. The most satisfying essays are those in which the conclusion provides an interesting way of wrapping up ideas introduced in the beginning and developed throughout, so that your reader has the feeling of coming full circle.

You might find it revealing as your course progresses to read with special attention the beginnings and endings of the essays throughout *Models for Writers*. Take special note of the varieties of beginnings and endings, the possible relationship between a beginning and an ending, and the general appropriateness of these elements to the writer's subject and purpose.

Shame

Dick Gregory



Ethan Miller/Getty Images

Dick Gregory (1932 - 2017) was born in St. Louis, Missouri. While attending Southern Illinois University on an athletic

scholarship, Gregory excelled in track, winning the university's Outstanding Athlete Award in 1953. In 1954, he was drafted into the army. After his discharge, he immediately became active in the civil rights movement led by Martin Luther King Jr. In the 1960s, Gregory was an outspoken critic of U.S. involvement in Vietnam, which in turn led to his run for the presidency in 1968 as a write-in candidate for the Freedom and Peace Party. Two of his books from this era are *No More Lies: The Myth and Reality of American History* (1971) and *Dick Gregory's Political Primer* (1972). Throughout his life he crusaded for economic reforms and minority rights and spoke out on antidrug issues. In 2000, he published *Callus on My Soul*, the second volume of his autobiography. His last book, *Defining Moments in Black History* (2017), examines 100 key events from the history of black America. In 2015, Gregory received a star on Hollywood's Walk of Fame, over fifty years after he first broke into the public spotlight as a stand-up comedian.

In the following episode from *Nigger* (1964), the first volume of his autobiography, Gregory narrates the story of a childhood experience that taught him the meaning of shame. Through his use of dialogue, he dramatically re-creates the experience for readers. Notice how he begins this essay in the shelter of home and ends with the feeling that his lesson in shame exposes him to the eyes of "the whole world."

Reflecting on What You Know

We all learn many things in school beyond the lessons we study formally. Some of the extracurricular truths we learn stay with us for the rest of our lives. Write about something you learned in school — something that has made life easier or more understandable for you — that you still find useful.

I never learned hate at home, or shame. I had to go to school for that. I was about seven years old when I got my first big lesson. I was in love with a little girl named Helene Tucker, a light-complexioned little girl with pigtails and nice manners. She was always clean and she was smart in school. I think I went to school then mostly to look at her. I brushed my hair and even got me a little old handkerchief. It was a lady's handkerchief, but I didn't want Helene to see me wipe my nose on my hand. The pipes were frozen again, there was no water in the house, but I washed my socks and shirt every night. I'd get a pot, and go over to Mister Ben's grocery store, and stick my pot down into his soda machine. Scoop out some chopped ice. By evening the ice melted to water for washing. I got sick a lot that winter because the fire would go out at night before the clothes were dry. In the morning I'd put them on, wet or dry, because they were the only clothes I had.

Everybody's got a Helene Tucker, a symbol of everything you want. I loved her for her goodness, her cleanness, her

popularity. She' d walk down my street and my brothers and sisters would yell, "Here comes Helene," and I' d rub my tennis sneakers on the back of my pants and wish my hair wasn' t so nappy¹ and the white folks' shirt fit me better. I' d run out on the street. If I knew my place and didn' t come too close, she' d wink at me and say hello. That was a good feeling. Sometimes I' d follow her all the way home, and shovel the snow off her walk and try to make friends with her Momma and her aunts. I' d drop money on her stoop late at night on my way back from shining shoes in the taverns. And she had a Daddy, and he had a good job. He was a paper hanger.

I guess I would have gotten over Helene by summertime, but something happened in that classroom that made her face hang in front of me for the next twenty-two years. When I played the drums in high school it was for Helene and when I broke track records in college it was for Helene and when I started standing behind microphones and heard applause I wished Helene could hear it, too. It wasn' t until I was twenty-nine years old and married and making money that I finally got her out of my system. Helene was sitting in that classroom when I learned to be ashamed of myself.

It was on a Thursday. I was sitting in the back of the room, in a seat with a chalk circle drawn around it. The idiot' s seat, the troublemaker' s seat.

The teacher thought I was stupid. Couldn' t spell, couldn' t read, couldn' t do arithmetic. Just stupid. Teachers were never interested in finding out that you couldn' t concentrate because you were so hungry, because you hadn' t had any breakfast. All you could think about was noontime, would it ever come? Maybe you could sneak into the cloak-room and steal a bite of some kid' s lunch out of a coat pocket. A bite of something. Paste. You can' t really make a meal of paste, or put it on bread for a sandwich, but sometimes I' d scoop a few spoonfuls out of the paste jar in the back of the room. Pregnant people get strange tastes. I was pregnant with poverty. Pregnant with dirt and pregnant with smells that made people turn away, pregnant with cold and pregnant with shoes that were never bought for me, pregnant with five other people in my bed and no Daddy in the next room, and pregnant with hunger. Paste doesn' t taste too bad when you' re hungry.

The teacher thought I was a troublemaker. All she saw from the front of the room was a little black boy who squirmed in his idiot' s seat and made noises and poked the kids around him. I guess she couldn' t see a kid who made noises because he wanted someone to know he was there.

It was on a Thursday, the day before the Negro payday. The eagle always flew on Friday. The teacher was asking each student how much his father would give to the Community

Chest. On Friday night, each kid would get the money from his father, and on Monday he would bring it to the school. I decided I was going to buy me a Daddy right then. I had money in my pocket from shining shoes and selling papers, and whatever Helene Tucker pledged for her Daddy I was going to top it. And I'd hand the money right in. I wasn't going to wait until Monday to buy me a Daddy.

I was shaking, scared to death. The teacher opened her book and started calling out names alphabetically.

"Helene Tucker?"

"My daddy said he'd give two dollars and fifty cents."

"That's very nice, Helene. Very, very nice indeed."

That made me feel pretty good. It wouldn't take too much to top that. I had almost three dollars in dimes and quarters in my pocket. I stuck my hand in my pocket and held onto the money, waiting for her to call my name. But the teacher closed her book after she called everybody else in the class.

I stood up and raised my hand.

"What is it now?"

“You forgot me.”

She turned toward the blackboard. “I don’ t have time to be playing with you, Richard.”

“My Daddy said he’ d …”

“Sit down, Richard, you’ re disturbing the class.”

“My Daddy said he’ d give … fifteen dollars.”

She turned around and looked mad. “We are collecting this money for you and your kind, Richard Gregory. If your Daddy can give fifteen dollars you have no business being on relief.”

“I got it right now, I got it right now, my Daddy gave it to me to turn in today, my Daddy said …”

“And furthermore,” she said, looking right at me, her nostrils getting big and her lips getting thin and her eyes opening wide, “we know you don’ t have a Daddy.”

Helene Tucker turned around, her eyes full of tears. She felt sorry for me. Then I couldn’ t see her too well because I was crying, too.

“Sit down, Richard.”

And I always thought the teacher kind of liked me. She always picked me to wash the blackboard on Friday, after school. That was a big thrill, it made me feel important. If I didn’ t wash it, come Monday the school might not function right.

“Where are you going, Richard?”

I walked out of school that day, and for a long time I didn’ t go back very often. There was shame there.

Now there was shame everywhere. It seemed like the whole world had been inside that classroom, everyone had heard what the teacher had said, everyone had turned around and felt sorry for me. There was shame in going to the Worthy Boys Annual Christmas Dinner for you and your kind, because everybody knew what a worthy boy was. Why couldn’ t they just call it the Boys Annual Dinner; why’ d they have to give it a name? There was shame in wearing the brown and orange and white plaid mackinaw² the welfare gave to three thousand boys. Why’ d it have to be the same for everybody so when you walked down the street the people could see you were on relief? It was a nice warm mackinaw and it had a hood, and my Momma beat me and called me a little rat when she found out I stuffed it in the bottom of a pail full of garbage way over

on Cottage Street. There was shame in running over to Mister Ben' s at the end of the day and asking for his rotten peaches, there was shame in asking Mrs. Simmons for a spoonful of sugar, there was shame in running out to meet the relief truck. I hated that truck, full of food for you and your kind. I ran into the house and hid when it came. And then I started to sneak through alleys, to take the long way home so the people going into White' s Eat Shop wouldn' t see me. Yeah, the whole world heard the teacher that day, we all know you don' t have a Daddy.

¹*nappy*: coarse, curly, and tightly coiled.

²*mackinaw*: a short, double-breasted wool coat.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How do the first three paragraphs of the essay help establish a context for the narrative that follows?
(Glossary: [Narration](#))
2. What does Gregory mean by “shame”? What precisely was he ashamed of, and what in particular did he learn from the incident?
3. What role does money play in Gregory' s experience?
How does money relate to his sense of shame?
4. Specific details can enhance the reader' s understanding and appreciation of a subject.
(Glossary: [Details](#)) Gregory' s description of Helene

Tucker's manners or the plaid of his mackinaw, for example, makes his account vivid and interesting. Cite several other specific details he gives, and consider how the essay would be different without them.

5. Reread this essay's first and last paragraphs and compare how much each one emphasizes shame.

(Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#)) Which emotion other than shame does Gregory reveal in the first paragraph, and does it play a role in the last one? Is the last paragraph an effective ending? Explain.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. In a word or phrase, how would you describe Gregory's tone? What specific words or phrases in his essay lead you to this conclusion? In light of his subject, did you find his tone appropriate? Explain.
2. What is the teacher's attitude toward Gregory? In arriving at your answer, consider the teacher's words and actions as well as Gregory's opinion.
3. Gregory states, "Now there was shame everywhere. It seemed like the whole world had been inside that classroom, everyone had heard what the teacher had said, everyone had turned around and felt sorry for me" (28). Why did his teacher's words hurt him so

deeply? Why do you think Gregory never names his teacher? What insights into the nature and power of shame did Gregory's story give you?

Classroom Activity Using Beginnings and Endings

Gregory begins his essay with a startling claim: "I never learned hate at home, or shame. I had to go to school for that." Pick two from among the eight other methods for beginning essays discussed in the introduction to this chapter (see [pp. 134 – 138](#)) and use them to write alternative openings for Gregory's essay. Share your beginnings with others in the class and discuss their effectiveness.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Using Gregory's essay as a model, write an essay narrating an experience that made you feel especially afraid, angry, surprised, embarrassed, or proud. Include details that allow your readers to know exactly what happened. Pay attention to how you use your first and last paragraphs to present the emotion your essay focuses on.

2. Most of us grow up with some sense of the socioeconomic class that our family belongs to, and often we are aware of how we are, or believe we are, different from people of other classes. Write an essay in which you describe a possession or an activity that you thought revealed your socioeconomic standing and made you self-conscious about how you were different from others. Using Gregory's essay as a model, let your first and last paragraphs dramatize this realization by showing how your self-consciousness changed as you understood how others viewed you.

The Case for Censoring Hate Speech

Sean McElwee



Courtesy Sean McElwee

Sean McElwee grew up in Connecticut and graduated from King’ s College. He writes about current events and economics for publications including *Politico*, *The Atlantic*, *The New Republic*, *Rolling Stone*, *Alternet*, *Salon*, and *Reason*. McElwee is currently based in New York City and is a co-founder of Data for Progress, a nonprofit organization that uses data analysis to advocate for a left-leaning policy agenda on a wide range of issues.

In “The Case for Censoring Hate Speech,” originally published online in the *Huffington Post* on September 23, 2013, McElwee answers the objections of free-speech advocates. According to McElwee, the idea for this essay came from “reading about the experiences of women, minorities and LGBT youth who had been harassed on websites like Twitter and Reddit.” His goal was to “show that by allowing racism, homophobia and misogyny, these websites don’ t make speech more free, but rather, more constrained.” McElwee did a lot of research in preparation for writing this essay, reading articles, conducting interviews, and gathering information on worldwide hate-speech laws. As you read, pay attention to how McElwee begins by setting the context for his argument, which leads to a strong claim.

Reflecting on What You Know

The First Amendment to the Constitution states that

“Congress shall make no law ... abridging the freedom of

speech.” Do you think we should, for the public good, place restrictions on this right? Why or why not?

For the past few years speech has moved online, leading to fierce debates about its regulation. Most recently, feminists have led the charge to purge Facebook of misogyny that clearly violates its hate speech code. Facebook took a small step two weeks ago, creating a feature that will remove ads from pages deemed “controversial.” But such a move is half-hearted; Facebook and other social networking websites should not tolerate hate speech and, in the absence of a government mandate, adopt a European model of expunging offensive material.

Stricter regulation of Internet speech will not be popular with the libertarian-minded citizens of the United States, but it’s necessary. A typical view of the case for expunging hate speech comes from Jeffrey Rosen, who argues in *The New Republic* that,

given their tremendous size and importance as platforms for free speech, companies like Facebook, Google, Yahoo, and Twitter shouldn’t try to be guardians of what Waldron calls a “well-ordered society”; instead, they should consider themselves the modern version of Oliver Wendell Holmes’ s fractious marketplace of ideas — democratic spaces where all values, including civility norms, are always open for debate.

This image is romantic and lovely but it's worth asking what this actually looks like. Rosen forwards one example:

Last year, after the French government objected to the hash tag “#unbonjuif” — intended to inspire hateful riffs on the theme “a good Jew ...” — Twitter blocked a handful of the resulting tweets in France, but only because they violated French law. Within days, the bulk of the tweets carrying the hash tag had turned from anti-Semitic to denunciations of anti-Semitism, confirming that the Twittersphere is perfectly capable of dealing with hate speech on its own, without heavy-handed intervention.

It's interesting to note how closely this idea resembles free market fundamentalism: simply get rid of any coercive rules and the “marketplace of ideas” will naturally produce the best result. Humboldt State University compiled a visual map that charts 150,000 hateful insults aggregated over the course of 11 months in the U.S. by pairing Google's Maps API with a series of the most homophobic, racist and otherwise prejudiced tweets. The map's existence draws into question the notion that the “Twittersphere” can organically combat hate speech; hate speech is not going to disappear from Twitter on its own.

The negative impacts of hate speech cannot be mitigated by the responses of third-party observers, as hate speech aims at two goals. First, it is an attempt to tell bigots that they are not alone. Frank Collins — the neo-Nazi prosecuted

in *National Socialist Party of America v. Skokie* (1977) — said, “We want to reach the good people, get the fierce anti-Semites who have to live among the Jews to come out of the woodwork and stand up for themselves.”

The second purpose of hate speech is to intimidate the targeted minority, leading them to question whether their dignity and social status is secure. In many cases, such intimidation is successful. Consider the number of rapes that go unreported. Could this trend possibly be impacted by Reddit threads like /r/rapingwomen or /r/mensrights? Could it be due to the harassment women face when they even suggest the possibility they were raped? The rape culture that permeates Facebook, Twitter and the public dialogue must be held at least partially responsible for our larger rape culture.

Reddit, for instance, has become a veritable potpourri of hate speech; consider Reddit threads like /r/nazi, /r/killawoman, /r/misogyny, /r/killingwomen. My argument is not that these should be taken down because they are offensive, but rather because they amount to the degradation of a class that has been historically oppressed. Imagine a Reddit thread for /r/lynchingblacks or /r/assassinatingthepresident. We would not argue that we should sit back and wait for this kind of speech to be

“outspoken” by positive speech, but that it should be entirely banned.

American free speech jurisprudence relies upon the assumption that speech is merely the extension of a thought, and not an action. If we consider it an action, then saying that we should combat hate speech with more positive speech is an absurd proposition; the speech has already done the harm, and no amount of support will defray the victim’s impression that they are not truly secure in this society. We don’t simply tell the victim of a robbery, “Hey, it’s okay, there are lots of other people who aren’t going to rob you.” Similarly, it isn’t incredibly useful to tell someone who has just had their race/gender/sexuality defamed, “There are a lot of other nice people out there.”

Those who claim to “defend free speech” when they defend the right to post hate speech online are in truth backwards. Free speech isn’t an absolute right; no right is weighed in a vacuum. The court has imposed numerous restrictions on speech. Fighting words, libel and child pornography are all banned. Other countries merely go one step further by banning speech intended to intimidate vulnerable groups. The truth is that such speech does not democratize speech, it monopolizes speech. Women, LGBTQ individuals and racial or religious minorities feel intimidated and are left out of the public sphere. On Reddit, for example, women have left or changed

their usernames to be more male-sounding lest they face harassment and intimidation for speaking on Reddit about even the most gender-neutral topics. Even outside of the intentionally offensive sub-reddits (i.e., /r/imgoingtohellforthis) misogyny is pervasive. I encountered this when browsing /r/funny.

Those who try to remove this hate speech have been criticized from left and right. At *Slate*, Jillian York writes, “While the campaigners on this issue are to be commended for raising awareness of such awful speech on Facebook’s platform, their proposed solution is ultimately futile and sets a dangerous precedent for special interest groups looking to bring their pet issue to the attention of Facebook’s censors.”

It hardly seems right to qualify a group fighting hate speech as an “interest group” trying to bring their “pet issue” to the attention of Facebook censors. The “special interest” groups she fears might apply for protection must meet Facebook’s strict community standards, which state:

While we encourage you to challenge ideas, institutions, events, and practices, we do not permit individuals or groups to attack others based on their race, ethnicity, national origin, religion, sex, gender, sexual orientation, disability or medical condition.

If anything, the groups to which York refers are nudging Facebook towards actually enforcing its own rules.

People who argue against such rules generally portray their opponents as standing on a slippery precipice, tugging at the question “what next?” We can answer that question: Canada, England, France, Germany, The Netherlands, South Africa, Australia and India all ban hate speech. Yet, none of these countries have slipped into totalitarianism. In many ways, such countries are more free when you weigh the negative liberty to express harmful thoughts against the positive liberty that is suppressed when you allow for the intimidation of minorities.

As Arthur Schopenhauer said, “the freedom of the press should be governed by a very strict prohibition of all and every anonymity.” However, with the Internet the public dialogue has moved online, where hate speech is easy and anonymous.

Jeffrey Rosen argues that norms of civility should be open to discussion, but, in today’s reality, this issue has already been decided; impugning someone because of their race, gender or orientation is not acceptable in a civil society. Banning hate speech is not a mechanism to further this debate because the debate is over.

As Jeremy Waldron argues, hate speech laws prevent bigots from “trying to create the impression that the equal position of members of vulnerable minorities in a rights-respecting society is less secure than implied by the society’ s actual foundational commitments.”

Some people argue that the purpose of laws that ban hate speech is merely to avoid offending prudes. No country, however, has mandated that anything be excised from the public square merely because it provokes offense, but rather because it attacks the dignity of a group — a practice the U.S. Supreme Court called in *Beauharnais v. Illinois* (1952) “group libel.” Such a standard could easily be applied to Twitter, Reddit and other social media websites. While Facebook’ s policy as written should be a model, its enforcement has been shoddy. Again, this isn’ t an argument for government intervention. The goal is for companies to adopt a European-model hate speech policy, one not aimed at expunging offense, but rather hate. Such a system would be subject to outside scrutiny by users. If this is the standard, the Internet will surely remain controversial, but it can also be free of hate and allow everyone to participate. A true marketplace of ideas must co-exist with a multi-racial society open to people of all genders, orientations and religions, and it can.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is the example that McElwee uses to begin his essay? What is effective about this example? Are there weaknesses to this approach?
2. Near the beginning of the essay, McElwee uses direct quotations from Rosen. Later, he summarizes Rosen's argument, using his own language. How do these different uses of the source serve different purposes?
3. Which websites does McElwee think have the worst problems with hate speech, and why? What does he suggest websites could do to improve the situation?
4. In this essay, McElwee responds to an argument by Jeffrey Rosen. Why does he object to Rosen's position on free speech? What, for example, does he think is wrong with the evidence Rosen cites about how Twitter reacted to the hashtag #unbonjuif?
5. McElwee closes his article by responding to the objection that banning hate speech is just a way to "avoid offending prudes." What is the advantage to ending his essay on this note? What are some drawbacks? How else might he have ended the same article more effectively?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What does McElwee mean by calling Americans “libertarian-minded” (2)? What assumptions does he make about Americans and about America by saying this? Does McElwee exhibit any discernable bias?
2. What does McElwee believe are the two goals of hate speech? Do you agree or disagree, and why? Do you think hate speech ought to be censored?
3. How does McElwee answer the concern that limiting hate speech is like “standing on a slippery precipice” (12)? How does he respond to the charge that restricting hate speech is just about avoiding giving offense to people who are overly sensitive? Do you agree with American jurisprudence that “speech is merely the extension of a thought, and not an action” ? Why or why not?

Classroom Activity Using Beginnings and Endings

Carefully read the following three possible beginnings for an essay about the famous practical joker, Hugh Troy. What are the advantages and disadvantages of each? Which one would you select as an opening paragraph? Why?

Whether questioning the values of American society or simply relieving the monotony of daily life, Hugh Troy always managed to put a little of himself into each of his stunts. One day he attached a plaster hand to his shirt sleeve and took a trip through the Holland Tunnel. As he

approached the tollbooth with his toll ticket between the fingers of the artificial hand, Troy left both ticket and hand in the grasp of the stunned tollbooth attendant and sped away.

Nothing seemed unusual. In fact, it was a rather common occurrence in New York City. Five men dressed in overalls roped off a section of busy Fifth Avenue in front of the old Rockefeller residence, hung out “men working” signs, and began ripping up the pavement. By the time they stopped for lunch, they had dug quite a hole in the street. This crew was different, however, from all the others that had descended upon the streets of the city. It was led by Hugh Troy — the world’s greatest practical joker.

Hugh Troy was born in Ithaca, New York, where his father was a professor at Cornell University. After graduating from Cornell, Troy left for New York City, where he became a successful illustrator of children’s books. When World War II broke out, he went into the army and eventually became a captain in the 21st Bomber Command, 20th Air Force, under General Curtis LeMay. After the war he made his home in Garrison, New York, for a short while before finally settling in Washington, D.C., where he lived until his death.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Although McElwee works with many sources, the disagreement between Jeffrey Rosen and Jeremy Waldron seems to be the catalyst of this essay. Choose a subject you would like to write about and find articles stating two opposing views. Write an essay summarizing the points these two authors make. Focus on creating a good, attention-getting beginning to your essay.
2. Look up the law banning hate speech in one of the countries McElwee mentions in paragraph 12. Write an essay analyzing the language of the law. How does it compare with the United States' First Amendment? (Glossary: [Comparison and Contrast](#)) Be sure to end your essay with an effective conclusion. You may wish to inspire the reader to combat hate speech, speculate about the long-term effects of hate speech, or propose another solution, among other options.

Can Music Bridge Cultures and Promote Peace?

Omar Akram



Tibrina Hobson/Getty Images

Omar Akram is a world-famous pianist, composer, recording artist, and cultural ambassador who has had a major influence in shaping New Age and World Music. Born in 1964 in New York City, he is the son of a United Nations diplomat and grew up in various places around the world, absorbing a variety of cultures and their musical traditions. Since he was a very active child, his parents gave him piano lessons, which both quieted him and allowed for social engagement as he grew. Akram's albums include *Opal Fire* (2002), *Free as a Bird* (2004), *Secret Journey* (2007), and *Daytime Dreamer* (2013). His *Echoes of Love* won a Grammy for Best New Age Album in 2013, the first Grammy awarded to someone of Afghan descent, and it catapulted him to international fame. His followers find peace and solace in the quietude of his melodies, rhythms, and harmonies, characteristics that he attributes to his multicultural exposure.

In the following essay, published in the *Huffington Post* on August 12, 2013, Akram explores the idea that music has the power not only to entertain but also to embrace and transcend cultures, to move across borders, and to open hearts. As you read, notice how Akram begins his essay with a brief personal narrative that both engages his readers and introduces his topic of music, culture, and world peace.

Reflecting on What You Know

Some of us are interested in only one or a limited number of musical styles and genres, such as blues or jazz. Others are more eclectic and wide-ranging in their tastes and will listen to almost any music. We may never know exactly what shapes our musical tastes, but where and when we grew up, our gender, age, personality, and moods are worth contemplating. What kind of music do you like, and why do you find it so satisfying? Where do you think your musical preferences originated? Have your musical tastes changed? Why?

I met Fidel Castro¹ when I was 14 years old. I was at one of my father's diplomatic functions, and I had the opportunity to strike up a conversation with Castro about music. He knew I played the piano and asked me if I'd been to any of the local African jazz clubs. I was too young to enter the clubs at the time, but to my surprise the dictator wielded his power to get me in. I entered some of Cuba's best jazz clubs by simply using his name, and no one questioned it. I would go on stage and play the piano between sets, and the musicians would improvise with me and encourage me to play. This is one of the most powerful ways I was able to absorb the culture, and bring it with me in my own art.

After I was thrust into the international spotlight as the first Afghan American to win a Grammy award this year, I learned some important lessons about the power of music. I was born in New York as the son of a UN diplomat. I've lived

all around the world, from the U.S. to the Czech Republic, Cuba, Switzerland and Afghanistan. Although my parents are from Afghanistan, I' ve never felt confined by the borders of just one culture, and I' ve learned to weave these many cultures into my compositions. One reason why I think my music in particular has been able to easily flow between international borders is because there is no singing or language. I receive letters from amazing fans all around the world who are able to create their own images and impressions about what my music means because they are not being directed by words or a certain language. It is the reason I started playing instrumental music.

The Grammy win brought me a lot of attention, both from the Afghan media and the people of Afghanistan. Afghanistan is a very divided country that is made up of many different ethnicities and social groups. After being on the radio and television I heard from everyone. The people there can hardly ever unite behind anything, and after I won the Grammy award there was a shared sense of accomplishment. It was a kind of unity I' ve never seen that I was very happy to be a part of.

I' ve received very touching letters and e-mails from people all around the world. I once received a letter from a man in Iraq who had just lost his family and his job. He was on the brink of committing suicide and someone gave him my CD. He told me that the music gave him the hope to move on. A woman

in Australia wrote to me about her father who had terminal cancer. She said that after playing my music for him his whole demeanor changed, and now he leaves it playing in the background 24/7. I' ve received letters ranging from an overworked father in the U.S. who is soothed by my music during his grueling commute to work, to an electricity-deprived family in Afghanistan who were mystified after hearing music unlike anything they are used to through the radio. I guess you could say music at its best could provide a sort of positive culture shock.

Music can positively affect people on many different levels. It can be a tool to communicate culture and a remedy for suffering just as much as it is a form of entertainment. I' ve learned to meld cultures and bring in instruments from around the world without hesitation. Embrace the culture you are from. It' s who you are and it is a part of what makes you unique. In some ways, you can promote diplomacy through music, but it' s important to understand that diplomacy does not always have to be political. Don' t be afraid of who you are and where you are from. When you keep an open mind and an open heart to the many cultures of the world, you can turn your musical instrument into an instrument of peace.

¹*Fidel Castro* (1926 – 2016): Cuban revolutionary leader who served as president of Cuba from 1976 to 2008.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How did you respond to Akram' s opening sentence? How does his opening paragraph as a whole introduce the subject of his essay?
2. Why does Akram believe that his music has been able to cross international borders and bridge cultures?
3. Akram claims to have learned “some important lessons about the power of music” (2) after winning a Grammy award. What exactly do you think he learned? Explain.
4. In [paragraph 4](#), Akram describes some of the letters and emails he has received from total strangers. What impact did these little stories have on you? What do they add to his essay as a whole? (Glossary: [Example](#))
5. Do you think the final paragraph closes Akram' s essay effectively? How is this ending related to his opening paragraph? (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What do you think Akram' s purpose is in this essay? Is he arguing a point, sharing a personal experience, or making an observation about music? What insight, if any, does his title give you into his purpose? Do

you believe that people “can promote diplomacy through music” (5)? Explain.

2. Akram believes in the power of instrumental music. What does he see as the dangers of vocal music? Do you believe that “singing or language” (2) makes it more difficult to cross international borders? Explain.
3. In an age when some people are criticized for cultural appropriation, why do you think Akram has been able “to weave ... many cultures into [his] compositions” (2) to acclaim and not censure? How has he been able to turn his “musical instrument into an instrument of peace” (5)?

Classroom Activity Using Beginnings and Endings

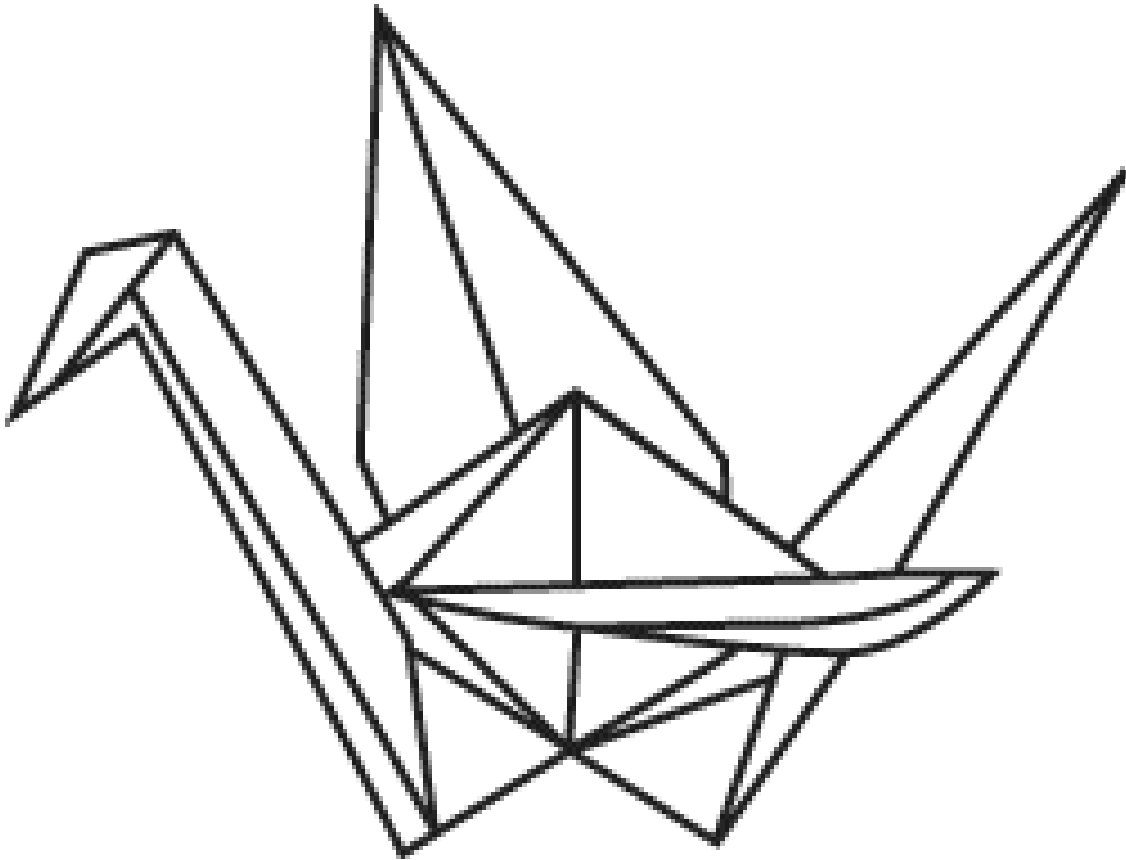
Read six to eight opening paragraphs for essays not in [Chapter 6](#), and try to choose selections you have not yet read. Which openings make you want to read the whole essay? What was it about these beginnings that “hooked” you? Share the paragraphs you chose and your observations about them with your classmates or a small group. What generalizations can you draw about successful beginnings?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Akram believes that “music can positively affect people on many different levels. It can be a tool to communicate culture and a remedy for suffering just as much as it is a form of entertainment” (5). In what ways has music been a part of your life? What impact does music have on you? Using Akram’s essay as a model, write an essay in which you explore the role that music plays in your life. Before beginning to write, you may find it helpful to review what you wrote in response to the Reflecting on What You Know prompt for this essay.
2. Write an essay in which you answer the question Akram asks in his title. Akram answers the question for himself by reflecting on his international experiences with music. Have you ever attended a concert (classical, jazz, rock, etc.) given by a group from another culture or country? What did you learn about the culture? Have you participated in or witnessed a community- or school-sponsored cultural exchange program that focused on music? How did the program affect the participants and the audiences?



CHAPTER 7 Paragraphs



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Within an essay, the **paragraph** is the most important unit of thought. Like the essay, it has its own main idea, often stated directly in a topic sentence. Like a good essay, a good paragraph is unified: it avoids digressions and develops its main idea. Paragraphs use many of the rhetorical strategies that essays use — strategies like classification, comparison and contrast, and cause and effect. As you read the following three paragraphs, notice how each writer develops his or her topic sentence with explanations,

concrete details and statistics, or vivid examples. The topic sentence in each paragraph is italicized.

Happiness is a slippery concept, a bundle of meanings with no precise, stable definition. Lots of thinkers have taken a shot at it. “Happiness is when what you think, what you say, and what you do are in harmony,” proposed Gandhi. Abraham Lincoln argued “most people are about as happy as they make up their minds to be.” Snoopy, the beagle-philosopher in *Peanuts*, took what was to my mind the most precise stab at the underlying epistemological problem. “My life has no purpose, no direction, no aim, no meaning, and yet I’ m happy. I can’ t figure it out. What am I doing right?”

— Eduardo Porter, [“What Happiness Is,”](#) p. 439

The problem of substance abuse is far more complex and far more pervasive than any of us really knows or is willing to admit. *Most stories of illegal drugs overshadow Americans’ struggles with alcohol, tobacco, food, and nonprescription drugs — our so-called legal addictions.* In 2000, for example, 17,000 deaths were attributed to cocaine and heroin. In that same year, 435,000 deaths were attributed to tobacco and 85,000 to alcohol. With the exception of a marked increase in heroin- and opioid-related deaths to about 47,000, in more recent years these figures have remained in about the same proportion. It’ s not surprising, then, that many sociologists believe we are a nation of substance abusers — drinkers, smokers, overeaters, and pill poppers. Although the statistics are alarming, they do not begin to suggest the heavy toll of substance abuse on Americans and their families. Loved ones die, relationships are fractured, children are abandoned, job productivity falters, and the dreams of young people are dashed.

— Alfred Rosa and Paul Eschholz

Photographs have let me know my parents before I was born, as the carefree college students they were, in love and awaiting the rest of their lives. I have seen the light blue Volkswagen van my dad used to take surfing down the coast of California and the silver dress my mom wore to her senior prom. Through pictures I was able to witness their wedding, which showed me that there is much in their relationship that goes beyond their children. I saw the look in their eyes as they held their first, newborn daughter, as well as the jealous expressions of my sister when I was born a few years later. There is something almost magical about viewing images of yourself and your family that you were too young to remember.

— Carrie White, student

Many writers find it helpful to think of the paragraph as a very small, compact essay. Here is a paragraph from Martin Luther King Jr.'s essay "The Ways of Meeting Oppression" (p. 449).

Violence as a way of achieving racial justice is both impractical and immoral. It is impractical because it is a descending spiral ending in destruction for all. The old law of an eye for an eye leaves everybody blind. It is immoral because it seeks to humiliate the opponent rather than win his understanding; it seeks to annihilate rather than to convert. Violence is immoral because it thrives on hatred rather than love. It destroys community and makes brotherhood impossible. It leaves society in monologue rather than dialogue. Violence ends by defeating itself. It creates bitterness in the

survivors and brutality in the destroyers. A voice echoes through time saying to every potential Peter, “Put up your sword.” History is cluttered with the wreckage of nations that failed to follow this command.

This paragraph, like all well-written paragraphs, has several distinguishing characteristics:

- It is *unified* in that every sentence and every idea relates to the main idea, stated in the italicized topic sentence.
- It is *coherent* in that the sentences and ideas are arranged logically, and the relationships among them are made clear by the use of effective transitions.
- Finally, it is *adequately developed* in that it presents a short but persuasive argument supporting its main idea.

How much development is “adequate” development? The answer depends on many things — how complicated or controversial the main idea is, what readers already know and believe, how much space the writer is permitted. Nearly everyone agrees that the Earth circles around the sun; a single sentence would be enough to make that point. A writer arguing that affirmative action has outlived its usefulness, however, would need many sentences — indeed, many paragraphs — to develop that idea convincingly.

PARAGRAPH LENGTH

How long should a paragraph be? In modern essays, most paragraphs range from 50 to 250 words, but some run a full printed page or more, and others may be only a few words long. The best answer is that a paragraph should be long enough to develop its main idea adequately. When some writers find a paragraph running very long, they break it into two or more paragraphs so that readers can pause and catch their breath. Other writers forge ahead, relying on the unity and coherence of their paragraph to keep their readers from getting lost.

Articles and essays that appear in magazines and newspapers (especially online versions) often have relatively short paragraphs, some of only one or two sentences. Short paragraphs are a convention in journalism because of the narrow columns, which make paragraphs of average length appear very long. But often you will find that these journalistic paragraphs could be joined together into a few longer paragraphs. Longer, adequately developed paragraphs are the kind you should use in all but journalistic writing.

My Rosetta

Judith Ortiz Cofer



Miriam Berkley

Judith Ortiz Cofer (1952 – 2016) was born in Hormigueros, Puerto Rico. As a young girl, she moved with her family to Paterson, New Jersey, and when she was fifteen, the family settled in Augusta, Georgia. Cofer earned a BA in English from Augusta College and an MA from Florida Atlantic University. She is the author of numerous books, including *The Cruel Country* (2015), a memoir; *If I Could Fly* (2011), a novel; *A Love Story Beginning in Spanish* (2005), a collection of poems; *The Meaning of Consuelo* (2003), a novel; *The Latin Deli: Prose and Poetry* (1993); and *Silent Dancing* (1990), a collection of poetry and essays. Cofer wrote in several genres and for audiences of varied ages, but her writing is unified by the influence of oral storytelling, commentary on how immigrants negotiate dual identities, and concern with gender issues and the empowerment of women. She taught at the University of Georgia for twenty-six years before her retirement in 2013.

In this essay from her book *Woman in Front of the Sun: On Becoming a Writer* (2000), Cofer remembers a woman who played a small but significant role in her life. As you read, pay attention to how her paragraphs have a strong topic sentence that describes Sister Rosetta, with specific details and humorous comparisons to support her description.

Reflecting on What You Know

What adults outside of your family have most influenced your life? What do you think made them so important you? How did they help you grow?

Sister Rosetta came into my life in 1966, at exactly the right moment. I was fourteen, beginning to stretch my bones after the long sleep of childhood, and the whole nation seemed to be waking up along with me. Each day the transistor radio¹ I took everywhere informed me that the streets were alive with rebellion. Rock and roll filled the airwaves with throbbing sounds like those the heart makes when you are young and still listening to it — sounds that made me want to dance, yell, break out of my parents' cocoon of an apartment, sprout wings, and fly away from my predictable life and (what I feared most) a predictable future as a good Catholic barrio woman. Instead I was signed up for classes leading to my confirmation in the Catholic Church, spiritual preparation for the bishop's symbolic slap in the face: turn the other cheek, girl, you are now one of us humble followers of Christ. But my teacher in the ways of Christian humility, Sister Rosetta, was anything but the docile bride of Jesus I had expected.

She was not an attractive woman. Her face, although bright with wit, belonged on an Irish guy with a tough job, perhaps a construction foreman or a cop. If a nun's coif had not framed those features — the slightly bulbous nose, plump

red-veined cheeks, and close-set eyes — this could have been the face of a heavy drinker or a laborer. She walked without grace but with a self-assured step we could hear approaching on the hardwood floors of the church basement where our lessons were held after school on cold winter afternoons in Paterson, New Jersey. Her rosary swinging from side to side on her habit's skirts, she strode in and slammed on the desktop whatever she was carrying that day. Then she'd lift herself onto the desk and face us, hands on hips as if to say, *What a shit job this is.*

And it was. Common knowledge had it that Sister Rosetta was assigned all the routine work of the convent by the Mother Superior to keep her busy and out of trouble. There was a rumor among us public school kids that Sister Rosetta had been arrested for taking part in a civil rights demonstration. And that she had been sent to our mainly Puerto Rican parish so that Father Jones, our saintly missionary pastor, could keep her under his wing. We found it funny to think of the shy, skinny man standing up to Sister Rosetta.

"OK, my little dumplings," Sister Rosetta would greet us, squinting like a coach about to motivate her team. "Today we are going to get in touch with our souls through music. Now listen carefully. You've never heard anything like this." Out of curiosity at first, then in near rapture, that day I

listened to the exotic music of Ravi Shankar emerge from the old turntable² Sister Rosetta had dragged in. The celestial notes of his sitar enveloped me in a gauzy veil of sound, stirring me in a new way. Sister had tacked the album cover on the corkboard, and as I looked deeply into Shankar' s onyx³ eyes he seemed to look back: in his gaze there were answers to questions I was almost ready to ask.

She must have noticed my enchantment, because Sister Rosetta handed me that record album as I was walking out of her overheated classroom. All she said was, ‘ ‘Bring it back without a scratch.’ ’ Much to my mother' s annoyance, I played Shankar' s music every day after school in my room while I did my homework. She called it *los gatos peleando*, the cat-fight album; but to me the high, lingering notes were an alarm clock bringing me out of myself, out of ignorance and into the realm of the senses. For my thirteenth birthday I had received my own turntable and a Felipe Rodriguez album of Puerto Rican *boleros*, the romantic ballads my parents danced to at parties. I played the record occasionally for their sake, but Rodriguez' s deep-throated laments about lost loves and weak women in tears did not appeal much to me. I liked the leaping, acrobatic images that Shankar' s music induced, replacing my childhood dreams of flight.

¹*transistor radio*: a portable radio popular in the 1960s and 1970s.

²*turntable*: a record player.

3*onyx*: black.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How are the topic sentences and the structure of the first two paragraphs similar? Why do you think Cofer organized the opening this way?
2. Why does Cofer fear being a “good Catholic barrio woman” ([paragraph 1](#))? Explain this vision of her future and why she rejects it.
3. In [paragraphs 4](#) and [5](#), Cofer’s style of paragraphs changes. What rhetorical strategy does she use in these paragraphs? Is it effective? Why or why not? (Glossary: [Rhetorical Modes](#))
4. Cofer sets up the first appearance of Sister Rosetta by telling us she is “anything but the docile bride of Jesus” (1). How does the description of her in [paragraph 2](#) contradict that stereotypical picture of a nun?
5. What is Sister Rosetta’s reputation among the public school students? Do you see any connections between her situation and Cofer’s?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. At the beginning of “My Rosetta,” Cofer claims that Sister Rosetta appeared in her life “at exactly the

right moment.” What was special about this time in her life? Find passages from the essay that show how Cofer was feeling at this moment in time.

2. Who was Ravi Shankar and what is a sitar? What characterized his music? If you are unfamiliar with him and his music and the sounds of a sitar, find some of his music on the internet. What in Shankar’s music represents all that Cofer is seeking and all that she wishes to leave behind at this stage of her life?
3. Consider the difference of opinion between Cofer and her mother over the Ravi Shankar album. How does the music Cofer’s parents prefer compare to it? Why does Cofer’s mother feel “annoyance” when Cofer listens to Shankar’s music?

Classroom Activity Using Paragraphs

Cofer uses only five paragraphs to paint the picture of Sister Rosetta and the effect she had on the young Cofer. Examine each of the paragraphs and determine what the topic sentence is for each, whether stated explicitly or implied. Highlight or underline it, and circle or make a list of the supporting details in each paragraph. Based on these descriptive paragraphs, draw a picture of what you think Sister Rosetta looks like. Don’t worry if

you' re not the best artist. If you' re working in a group, you can choose one artist and give feedback and direction or create a brief comic that depicts the actions Sister Rosetta might take based on your impression of her.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Choose someone close to you and write an essay describing him or her to a stranger. Using “My Rosetta” as a model, describe both physical appearance and characteristic gestures as a way to communicate personality. Focus on creating strong topic sentences to state the main idea of each paragraph and use only details that support that idea.
2. Write a personal essay about a time in your life when your view of the world was changing. First, create an outline of your essay. Organize your story into different stages, each of which will be developed into a paragraph. Write a topic sentence for each paragraph and then list what details you would include to support that topic sentence. When your outline is complete, write the essay using transitional words and phrases to give the paragraphs unity and coherence.

Independence

Donna Hicks



Donna Hicks

Donna Hicks is an associate at the Weatherhead Center for International Affairs at Harvard University and a speaker on topics of conflict resolution and human dignity. She holds a PhD in Educational Psychology from the University of Wisconsin and completed postdoctoral work in International Conflict Analysis. In 2006, Hicks was a cohost with Archbishop Desmond Tutu on *Facing the Truth*, a British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) series that established dialogue between both sides of the Northern Ireland conflict. In a 2013 TEDx talk entitled “Declare Dignity,” she lectured about an unspoken dialogue that occurs when people come together to resolve conflict — a dialogue that reveals the human need for dignity. Hicks’ s ideas about the role of dignity in conflict resolution have been featured on NPR, Fox News, and the BBC and in publications like *Psychology Today* and *Newsday*.

The following chapter was published in Hicks’ s best-selling book *Dignity: The Essential Role It Plays in Resolving Conflict* (2011). In this chapter, Hicks begins by writing that it is important to “encourage people to act on their own behalf so that they feel in control of their lives and experience a sense of hope and possibility.” As you read, consider how Hicks develops her paragraphs and the examples she uses to support her argument.

Reflecting on What You Know

What does *dignity* mean to you? Explain a situation when you felt that you lost a sense of personal dignity, and then explain a situation when you were able to maintain your dignity. What factors were at play in each situation? How did the circumstances differ?

War is the inevitable consequence of choosing to resolve differences by force. Domination and control are the goals of war. Prisoners may be taken, and we all know that torture is not uncommon when they are questioned, even though international law forbids it.

At the end of a conflict-resolution workshop between warring parties held at Harvard, I had an opportunity to speak privately with one of the participants, someone who played a leadership role in his community, about the time he had spent in prison as a political prisoner. I wasn't planning to have an intimate conversation. We were seated next to one another at dinner and made small talk for quite a while. He asked me questions in an effort to get to know me, which doesn't happen often with influential people — they are usually busy telling you all about themselves. At one point, he jokingly mentioned his time in prison.

I was surprised to hear that he had been a prisoner and asked him what it was like. For a few seconds he studied my face. I am not sure what he was looking for, but after a short pause,

he started to tell me stories about the day-to-day abuse by guards who were younger than his children and about being humiliated during interrogations.

One thing he told me will stay with me forever. I asked him how he reacted when he was being humiliated. He said: “From the time I was a little boy, my mother told me that I should never react when someone treats me badly. I should not lose my temper. She said it didn’ t matter whether someone hurt me with words or with a stick. Never let them know they are hurting you. And that wasn’ t all. She said I should always maintain a smile on my face because you never want to give the person the satisfaction of thinking he has injured you. *You are the one in control of your dignity, not the person hurting you.* ”

The last sentence struck home. I added the emphasis mentally. I realized that what he said was true: ultimately we are the ones in control of our own dignity, even if we are being held against our will. My dinner partner’ s words reminded me of a quotation of Eleanor Roosevelt’ s: “No one can make you feel inferior without your permission.”

At the end of our conversation, after listening to him intently for nearly an hour, I told him, “I don’ t know how you did it. I don’ t think I would have had the strength to endure what you did with such dignity.”

He looked at me and began to cry. It was only for a second, but he cried. He quickly composed himself, momentarily put his hand over mine, and then turned to his aide, sitting on the other side of him, who was tapping him on the shoulder.

“Mr. X-----, the waiter wants to know what you would like for dessert: crème brûlée or chocolate gâteau?”

This story is about the inhumanity of war and how it strips us of our freedom, but the impulse to control and dominate others is not confined to the battleground. The imperative of war — to use power to deprive others of power — is all too often the imperative in our everyday lives as well.

Minority groups often find their freedom restricted by the imposition of the norms of the dominant culture, and that restriction has been enough to incite serious political unrest. Members of the minority group want to express themselves and their unique identity freely. Without coercion¹, it is difficult to repress a group’s desire to speak their own language and practice their own religion — to choose how to live their lives in a way that gives them meaning.

We can see the impulse to restrict the freedom of others in most of our relationships, not just at the national level. Imagine the domineering husband who wants to control his wife, the overprotective mother who fails to see the

importance of letting her daughter experience herself as an independent being with her own dreams to fulfill, or the executive who refuses to hear the concerns of employees out of fear of losing authority.

The real problem with domination is that it takes away a person's independence, thereby violating one of the essential elements of dignity. Like any other dignity violation, taking away a person's independence creates resentment. Resentment contaminates relationships, setting the stage for the transformation of the other into an enemy. In contrast, using power to empower others not only guarantees them their freedom and protects our own but is a step toward fulfilling our primal longing to be connected with others.

¹ *coercion*: the act of compelling or forcing someone to act or choose, often with force or threat.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. After stating her thesis, Hicks provides a definition of war. (Glossary: [Thesis](#); [Definition](#)) Would you define war the same way? How does Hicks's definition of war relate to her overall argument?
2. Consider the quotations from the conflict-resolution participant (4), Eleanor Roosevelt (5), and the

participant' s aide (7). What is the function of each quotation in Hicks' s argument? How does the placement of these quotations contribute to her argument? (Glossary: [Organization](#))

3. In [paragraph 10](#), Hicks gives various examples of “the impulse to restrict the freedom of others.” Does this paragraph fall into the trap of any logical fallacies? (Glossary: [Logical Fallacy](#)) If so, explain. If you do not think the paragraph contains any logical fallacies, talk about why it is effective.
4. What does Hicks mean when she claims that “Resentment contaminates relationships, setting the stage for the transformation of the other into an enemy” (11)? How does this claim relate to her overall argument?
5. In the last paragraph of her essay, how does Hicks use deductive reasoning? How does the conclusion of this chapter relate to Hicks' s thesis?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Hicks' s *ethos* (Greek for “character”) is established by her impressive biography, which includes work in prestigious academic institutions and the international exposure of her ideas. In [paragraph 2](#), she also appeals to *ethos* when she

introduces one of the participants in a conflict-resolution workshop. How does she appeal to *ethos* in her description of this person? Does this appeal help her argument? If so, how? If not, why not?

2. Hicks writes, “The imperative of war — to use power to deprive others of power — is all too often the imperative in our everyday lives as well” (8). Do you think that war and personal conflict are an apt comparison? Do you feel that individuals try to take power away from other individuals too often in everyday life? Explain your opinions.
3. Hicks emphasizes the dialogue of a participant at one of her conflict-resolution workshops who says, “You are the one in control of your dignity, not the person hurting you” (4). Do you agree with the participant’s statement? Put another way, do you believe that each individual has the ability to *choose* to preserve their own dignity, even in extremely difficult or humiliating situations? Explain.

Classroom Activity Using Paragraphs

Carefully read the following set of related sentences and select one to use as a topic sentence. Then rearrange the

other sentences to create an effective paragraph. Be ready to explain why you chose the order that you did.

1. PGA golfer Fred Divot learned the hard way what overtraining could do.
2. Divot's case is typical, and most researchers believe that too much repetition makes it difficult for the athlete to reduce left-hemisphere brain activity.
3. Athletes who overtrain find it very difficult to get in the flow.
4. "Two weeks later, all I could think about was mechanics, and I couldn't hit a fairway to save my life!"
5. Athletes think about mechanics (left hemisphere) rather than feel (right hemisphere), and they lose the ability to achieve peak performance.
6. "I was playing well, so I thought with a little more practice, I could start winning on tour," Divot recalled.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. In your opinion, what is the most important element in conflict resolution? Write an essay that argues why this element is most important. Hicks writes about dignity, but you might write about an element

like cooperation, respect, loyalty, or another that strikes you as crucial. Develop your argument with a clear thesis, strong supporting evidence, and good organization.

2. Hicks writes that “minority groups often find their freedom restricted by the imposition of the norms of the dominant culture” (9). Consider whether these norms are imposed on minority groups through social media. Write an essay arguing that social media challenge the ability of minority groups (or a particular group) to maintain their cultural dignity, that social media give minority groups (or a particular group) new opportunities for maintaining cultural dignity, or some position in between.

Heartland

Sarah Smarsh



Simone Padovani/Awakening/Getty Images

Sarah Smarsh was born in Kansas in 1980. She comes from a family of farmers who faced significant socioeconomic challenges during the presidency of Ronald Reagan, as she describes in her writing. In addition to reporting for *The New York Times*, *The New Yorker*, *The Guardian*, and other news sources, her essays have been published widely, including in *Creative Nonfiction* and *McSweeney's*. Her writing has also been anthologized in *Tales of Two Americas: Stories of Inequality in a Divided Nation* (2017) and in *Scratch: Writers, Money and the Art of Making a Living* (2017). Smarsh holds undergraduate degrees in journalism and English from the University of Kansas. She earned her MFA in nonfiction writing from Columbia University, one of many universities where she has taught writing. She is on the board of the nonprofit initiative I'm First, which helps first-generation college students achieve their goals. Smarsh is also a speaker and a commentator who has appeared on CNN, CBS, and radio stations worldwide, where she has talked about socioeconomic class, the media, and the impact of political decisions on rural communities.

Her book *Heartland: A Memoir of Working Hard and Being Broke in the Richest Country on Earth* (2018) was a *New York Times* best seller and a finalist for the National Book Award. In the following selection from *Heartland*, Smarsh presents unified paragraphs with thoughtful explanations, concrete details, and vivid examples that point to the particularity

of Kansas farm life in relation to American life in other regions.

Reflecting on What You Know

What is your relationship to food production? Have you ever participated in farming, or do you buy food at a corner store or a grocery store without thinking too much about where it came from originally? Do you grow vegetables in a community garden, but purchase other food? Do you hunt or fish and eat what you catch?

We were country people in the middle of the country, living in a way that, I gather from things they' ve said to me over the years, some middle-class people in cities and suburbs on coasts thought had died long ago. For someone who never worked a farm, for whom the bread and meat in deli sandwiches seemed to magically materialize without agricultural labor, the center of the country was a place flown over but not touched.

“I haven’ t heard of anything like that since *The Grapes of Wrath*, ” ¹ people with different backgrounds would say to me in all seriousness when I described life on the farm. They thought we didn’ t exist anymore, when in fact we just existed in places they never went. It was an easy way to think, I guess. I rarely saw the place I called home described or tended to in political discourse, the news

media, or popular culture as anything but a stereotype or something that happened a hundred years ago.

We were so invisible as to be misrepresented even in caricature, lumped in with other sorts of poor whites, derogatory terms applied to us even if they didn' t make sense.

We lived on the open prairie, so we weren' t the "hillbillies" of the Smoky Mountains or the Ozarks. We weren' t "roughnecks" in oil fields; Kansas had a humble tap on oil thousands of feet below the prairie, but nothing like Oklahoma or Texas to the south.

"Redneck" and "cracker" didn' t quite translate, since their American usage was rooted in the slave South, against which Kansas had lit many of the fires that sparked the Civil War. After the Kansas-Nebraska Act of 1854 allowed those territories to decide for themselves whether to allow slavery, abolitionists fought border wars with slaveholders across the line in Missouri. "Bloody Kansas," historians call the period, and that blood ensured that Kansas would be established as a free state. Kansas and Missouri still have a cultural rivalry more than 150 years later. That' s not to say white abolitionists were morally righteous on the matter of race or that black and brown Kansans were treated well.

But it' s a different history to come out of, as a poor white.

Slang terms for my plains ancestors who built dwellings there from sod, the only available material for lack of trees, didn' t survive in common vernacular. We were so willfully forgotten in American culture that the most common slur toward us was one applied to poor whites anywhere: "white trash." Or, since we moved in and out of mobile homes, "trailer trash."

There' s an image in popular culture of the poor white female version: a smoke hanging out of her mouth, a baby on one hip, and the screen door to her trailer propped open with the other. You could say my mother was that woman and I was that baby, and that you would have been that baby, too. But as members of all sorts of stereotyped groups know, the popular image — selected or fixated upon by someone more powerful than you — doesn' t tell you much about the life.

For one thing, anyone who has lived it knows that what matters less than the trailer is where the trailer is parked. Ours was in the country by my father' s choice, on the land where he later built our house. The place was thought boring for being grassland — mountains and forests being the landscapes that more often inspire awe — but without hills and trees we had a bigger sky than Montana, an unobstructed

view of bright color between dark thunder clouds like nothing I' ve ever seen elsewhere. Those displays were so grand outside a single-wide metal dwelling on wheels that it felt less like us having a good view than like God having a view of us. I could feel how small we were.

I knew, so deeply that I wasn' t even conscious of it, that my family was on the outside of something considered normal. That normalized thing was the city, suburbs, even little burghs of three thousand people. We called them all "town," even the small ones seeming to lord over us when we wore dirty jeans to visit a bank teller wearing a suit from Dillard' s. Places with banks, schools, stores, and county courthouses — let alone skyscrapers — represented to us a sort of power we were removed from, a disenfranchisement not only by culture but by geographic distance.

This bred in us a distrust of just about anyone who held a power we didn' t — even those who tried to help.

"I never seen a dime of it," Grandpa Arnie would say about Farm Aid, the concert fund-raiser begun in 1985 to save dying family farms. The founders were white singers from humble places: Willie Nelson, who was born the son of an auto mechanic during the Great Depression and spent the summers of his youth picking cotton in the Texas heat. John Cougar Mellencamp, who was born in small-town Indiana and became a

grandfather at age thirty-seven. Neil Young — well, he was a middle-class hippie from Canada. Grandpa Arnie didn' t know or care about any of that. All he knew was that he' d never been to a big concert in his life, and he wouldn' t get to go to this one.

Whether or not famous singers in cowboy boots testified before Congress, public policy went on selling us right up the rivers of corporate monopolies and factory farming. It was hardly a new story but reached its sad climax under Reagan.² All around us, farm loans were underwater. Old farmers died and their kids sold everything off; many of them had already moved to cities, which their parents often encouraged for their survival.

That economic collapse deepened a consensus within society that a talented person from the country would endeavor to “get out.” Some did. They got scholarships to college, blew town, and — their politics and economic prospects having changed — never looked back. That “rural flight” made way for the idea that country people can' t “make it” in a bustling metropolis. But the ability to measure distances for planting alfalfa³ and smell the right moment to cut it isn' t so different from the ability to map out a subway trip and feel when a stop has been missed.

Like all industrialized countries, America started out country and turned city. My people didn' t turn with it. Instead of striving toward glowing economic meccas,⁴ they stayed on tractors in fields, or in small towns where life struck many of them as not just good enough but preferable to bigger places. Often, it' s not that country people can' t hack the city but that they choose not to — or life just played out differently regardless of their desires.

The Kentucky farmer and activist Wendell Berry wrote for *The Atlantic* in 1991, “The only sustainable city — and this, to me, is the indispensable ideal and goal — is a city in balance with its countryside,” one that would pay “all its ecological and human debts.” Those human debts might be to the indigenous people pushed off the land where a Western city would rise, or to black slaves who worked Southern fields so that cotton and tobacco would be cheap to city whites wanting clothes and cigars.

It is harder to imagine a debt owed to members of the race that committed those horrors. And indeed my countryside was an overwhelmingly white one. A few thousand freed slaves started African American farming settlements in Kansas, one of which still survives, but most went to urban centers farther north. Around the same time, the federal government was killing and forcibly driving indigenous tribes to “Indian Territory,” the border of which was fifty miles

south of my family' s land. A lot of Mexican American people settled throughout the state due to the cattle drives from Texas. But during the twentieth century, most of the state population was of European descent.

We thus benefited from our skin color in ways that are hard to perceive by three white people working a field together, no other human being, town, or structure in sight to the horizon — a complicated mix of privilege and disadvantage. I don' t know what, if anything, is owed to that version of the countryside. I do know that, mostly neglected by state and federal power centers, much of it is now economically dead and abandoned or under the thumb of seed corporations, natural gas corporations, and factory farms.

Government programs pop up to offer financial incentives for business and homeowners to stay in or move to rural America, but they can' t prevent infrastructure costs from rising when populations decline or home values from going down and, with them, local tax revenues and the schools they funded.

When I was a kid, the United States was a few decades away from reckoning with the reality that the next generation would be worse off, not better off, than the one before it. But my community had been facing dwindling odds for generations. They knew that children like me likely wouldn' t

and shouldn't aim for life on a farm. Few country kids were pressured to keep a farm going.

Well ahead of middle-class America, for all my family's emphasis on hard work, on some level we'd done away with the idea that it always paid off. Being as we got up before dawn to do chores and didn't quit until after dark, it was plain that the problem with our outcomes wasn't lack of hard work. The problem was with commodities markets, with big business, with Wall Street — things so far away and impenetrable to us that all we could do was shake our heads, hate the government, and get the combine into the shed before it started to hail.

¹*The Grapes of Wrath* (1939): novel by John Steinbeck about a poor family of farmers during the Great Depression.

²*Reagan*: Ronald Reagan (1911–2004), president of the United States from 1981 to 1989.

³*alfalfa*: crop grown for hay and food for grazing animals.

⁴*meccas*: centers of economic activity or culture.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. In her opening paragraph, Smarsh states that where she lives was “a place flown over but not touched.”

According to her, why was it easy for people to ignore the “center of the country” ?

2. Smarsh feels that her home was not adequately represented in the media and when it was, it was represented through stereotypes. Name one of the stereotypes she mentions to demonstrate the inaccuracy of media perceptions. Are you familiar with this stereotype? What, if anything, do you associate with the stereotype?
3. Presenting an accurate representation of place is essential to Smarsh’ s mission, and she reveals a clear sense of her home in the topic sentence of [paragraph 8](#). What techniques does Smarsh use to develop this paragraph (for example, does she use explanations, examples, descriptions, statistics)?
4. [Paragraph 13](#) uses the rhetorical strategy of comparison. (Glossary: [Comparison and Contrast](#)) What comparison does Smarsh make in this paragraph?
5. What is the topic sentence of the final paragraph? What type of organization does Smarsh use to develop this paragraph (for example, classification, comparison and contrast, or cause and effect)? Explain your answer.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What is Smarsh' s purpose in this selection? How can you tell? (Glossary: **Purpose**)
2. A key feature of successful paragraph development is unity (Glossary: [Unity](#)), which means paragraphs that are focused, relate to the author' s purpose, and avoid digressions. In several of her paragraphs, Smarsh includes cultural references without going into great detail about them. Some readers may find these references helpful, while others may find them confusing or digressive. For example, in [paragraph 2](#), Smarsh states that people found her experience to be similar to that of characters in *The Grapes of Wrath*, the 1939 novel by John Steinbeck about farmers during the Great Depression. Find another outside reference in Smarsh' s writing. Do you find that this reference strengthens the paragraph, or do you find that it takes you, as the reader, away from the main focus of the paragraph? Explain your answer.
3. In [paragraph 7](#), Smarsh addresses an unborn child with the second-person pronoun “you.” Does her switch to second person in this paragraph make sense to you? What effect does the second-person pronoun have? Why do you suppose Smarsh makes the rhetorical choice to use the second-person pronoun in this paragraph?

Classroom Activity Using Paragraphs

Smarsh studied journalism in college and has done a great deal of reporting. It is not surprising that some of her paragraphs might be considered *journalistic* — that is, similar to paragraphs you might find in a newspaper or magazine article. Some journalistic paragraphs do not include a topic sentence that clearly reveals the main idea. Instead, journalistic paragraphs may include one or more of the following features:

- They may be short (sometimes just one sentence).
- They may start with dialogue or with a quotation.
- They may begin with a specific example (instead of with a general main idea).

With a partner, identify one of Smarsh's journalistic paragraphs. Come up with a new topic sentence for the paragraph that more plainly states the overall main idea of the paragraph. Do you feel that this new topic sentence makes the paragraph more or less effective than Smarsh's original paragraph? Why?

Suggested Writing Assignments

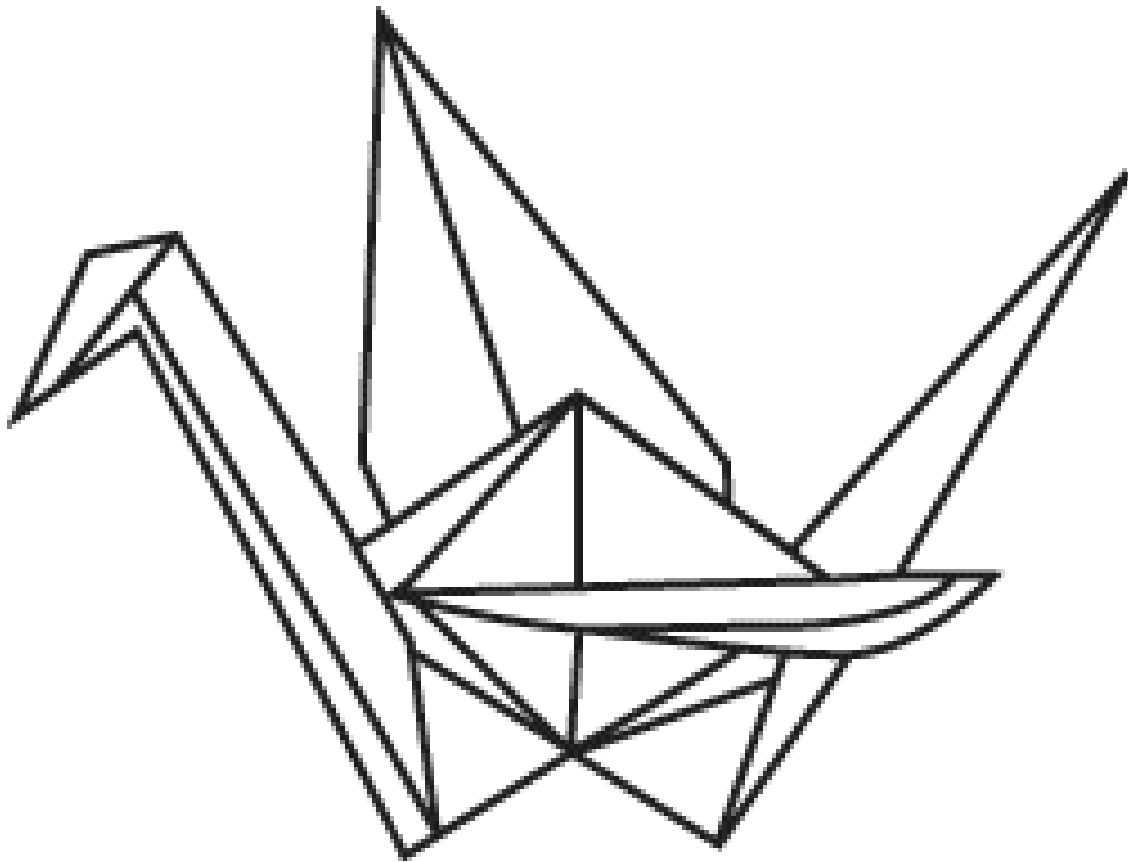
1. What, in your opinion, is the relationship between food and labor (work)? Write a paragraph with a strong topic sentence that explores this question.

For example, you might write the following topic sentence: “People would enjoy food more if they were a part of the food production process.” To explain your idea, you could contrast the experience a farmer might have when eating food to the experience you have had eating food from a cafeteria. Then develop your paragraph into a brief essay that further expands on your topic sentence.

2. One theme of Smarsh’ s writing is the concept of power. First write a definition of power and any associations you have with the concept. Then highlight any moments in the reading where Smarsh directly or indirectly speaks about power. Develop a thesis statement (Glossary: [Thesis](#)) that answers the question: What are the consequences of power? Finally, write a short essay that uses Smarsh’ s writing and your own personal experience to support your thesis statement about power.



CHAPTER 8 Transitions



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

A **transition** is a word or phrase used to signal the relationships among ideas in an essay and to join the various parts of an essay together. Writers use transitions to relate ideas within sentences, between sentences, and between paragraphs. The three major transitional strategies are

- transitional expressions
- repetition
- pronoun references

Perhaps the most common type of transition is the transitional expression. Following is a list of transitional expressions categorized according to their functions.

Transitional Expressions

Addition

and, again, too, also, in addition, further, furthermore, moreover, besides

Cause and Effect

therefore, consequently, thus, accordingly, as a result, hence, then, so

Comparison

similarly, likewise, by comparison

Concession

to be sure, granted, of course, it is true, to tell the truth, certainly, with the exception of, although this may be true, even though, naturally

Contrast

but, however, in contrast, on the contrary, on the other hand, yet, nevertheless, after all, in spite of

Example

for example, for instance

Place

elsewhere, here, above, below, farther on, there, beyond, nearby, opposite to, around

Restatement

that is, as I have said, in other words, in simpler terms, to put it differently, simply stated

Sequence

first, second, third, next, finally

Summary

in conclusion, to conclude, to summarize, in brief, in short

Time

afterward, later, earlier, subsequently, at the same time, simultaneously, immediately, this time, until now, before, meanwhile, shortly, soon, currently, when, lately, in the meantime, formerly

Besides transitional expressions, there are two other important ways to make transitions: by repeating key words and ideas and by using pronoun references. This paragraph begins with the phrase “Besides transitional expressions,” which contains the transitional word *besides* and also repeats wording from the last sentence of the previous paragraph. Thus, the reader knows that this discussion is moving toward a new but related idea. Repetition can also give a word or an idea emphasis: “Foreigners look to America as a land of freedom. Freedom, however, is not something all Americans enjoy.”

Pronoun references avoid monotonous repetition of nouns and phrases. Without pronouns, these two sentences are wordy and tiring to read: “Jim went to the concert, where he heard Beethoven’s Ninth Symphony. Afterward, Jim bought a recording of the Ninth Symphony.” A more graceful and readable passage results if two pronouns are substituted in the second sentence: “Afterward, he bought a recording of

it.” The second version has another advantage in that it is now more tightly related to the first sentence. The transition between the two sentences is smoother.

In the following example, notice how Rachel Carson uses transitional expressions, repetition of words and ideas, and pronoun references (transitions have been italicized):

Repeated key idea	Under primitive agricultural conditions the farmer had few insect problems. <i>These</i> arose with the intensification of agriculture—the devotion of immense acreages to a single crop. <i>Such a system</i> set the stage for explosive increases in specific insect populations. Single-crop farming does not take advantage of the principles by which nature works; <i>it</i> is agriculture as an engineer might conceive it to be. Nature has introduced great variety into the landscape, but man has displayed a passion for simplifying <i>it</i> . <i>Thus he</i> undoes the built-in checks and balances by which nature holds the species within bounds. One important natural <i>check</i> is a limit on the amount of suitable habitat for each species. <i>Obviously then</i> , an insect that lives on wheat can build up its population to much higher levels on a farm devoted to wheat than on one in which wheat is intermingled with other crops to which the insect is not adapted.	Pronoun reference
Pronoun reference		Pronoun reference
Repeated key word		Transitional expression; pronoun reference
		Transitional expression
Repeated key idea	<i>The same thing</i> happens in other situations. A generation or more ago, the towns of large areas of the United States lined their streets with the noble elm tree. <i>Now</i> the beauty <i>they</i> hopefully created is threatened with complete destruction as disease sweeps through the elms, carried by a beetle that would have only limited chance to build up large populations and to spread from tree to tree if the elms were only occasional trees in a richly diversified planting.	Transitional expression; pronoun reference

— Rachel Carson, *Silent Spring*

Description

"The first paragraph reads, "Under primitive agricultural conditions the farmer had few insect problems. These arose with the intensification of agriculture—the devotion of

immense acreages to a single crop. A corresponding annotation reads, Pronoun reference. Such a system set the stage for explosive increases in specific insect populations. A corresponding annotation reads, Repeated key Idea. Single-crop farming does not take advantage of the principles by which nature works; it is agriculture as an engineer might conceive it to be. A corresponding annotation reads, Pronoun reference. Nature has introduced great variety into the landscape, but man has displayed a passion for simplifying it. A corresponding annotation reads, Pronoun reference. Thus he undoes the built-in checks and balances by which nature holds the species within bounds. A corresponding annotation reads, Transitional reference expression. One important natural check is a limit on the amount of suitable habitat for each species. A corresponding annotation reads, Repeated key word. Obviously then, an insect that lives on wheat can build up its population to much higher levels on a farm devoted to wheat than on one in which wheat is intermingled with other crops to which the insect is not adapted.” A corresponding annotation reads, Transitional expression The second paragraph reads, “The same thing happens in other situations. A corresponding annotation reads, Repeated keyword. A generation or more ago, the towns of large areas of the United States lined their streets with the noble elm tree. Now the beauty they hopefully created is threatened with complete destruction as disease sweeps through the elms, carried by a beetle that would have only limited chance to build up large populations and to spread from tree to tree if the elms were only occasional trees in a richly diversified planting.” A corresponding annotation reads, Transitional expression; pronoun reference. The writer’s name reads, —Rachel Carson, *Silent Spring*”

Carson's transitions in this passage enhance its coherence — that quality of good writing that results when all sentences and paragraphs of an essay are effectively and naturally connected.

In the following four-paragraph sequence about a vegetarian's ordeal with her family at Thanksgiving each year, the writer uses transitions effectively to link one paragraph to another.

Reference
to key idea
in previous
paragraph

The holiday that I dread the most is fast approaching. The relatives will gather to gossip and bicker, the house will be filled with the smells of turkey, onions, giblets, and allspice, and I will be pursuing trivial conversations in the hope of avoiding any commentaries upon the state of my plate.

Do not misunderstand me: I am not a scrooge. I enjoy the idea of Thanksgiving — the giving of thanks for blessings received in the past year and the opportunity to share an unhurried day with family and friends. The problem for me is that I am one of those freaky, misunderstood people who — as my family jokingly reminds me — eats “rabbit food.” Because all traditional Western holidays revolve around food and more specifically around ham, turkey, lamb, or roast beef and their respective starchy accompaniments, it is no picnic for us vegetarians.

The mention of the word *vegetarian* has, at various family get-togethers, caused my Great-Aunt Bertha to rant and rave for what seems like hours about those “liberal conspirators.” Other relations cough or groan or simply stare, change the subject or reminisce about somebody they used to know who was “into that,” and some proceed either to demand that I defend my position or try to talk me out of it. That is why I try to avoid the subject, but especially during the holidays.

Repeated
key word

Transitional
time reference

In years past I have had about as many *successes as failures in steering comments about my food toward other topics*. Politics and religion are the easiest outs, guaranteed to immerse the family in a heated debate lasting until the loudest shouter has been abandoned amidst empty pie plates, wine corks, and rumpled linen napkins. I prefer, however, to use this tactic as a last resort. Holidays are supposed to be for relaxing.

Repeated
key idea

— Mundy Wilson-Libby, student

Description

"The first paragraph reads, "The holiday that I dread the most is fast approaching. The relatives will gather to gossip and bicker, the house will be filled with the smells of turkey, onions, giblets, and allspice, and I will be pursuing trivial conversations in the hope of avoiding any commentaries upon the state of my plate." The second paragraph reads, "Do not misunderstand me: I am not a scrooge. I enjoy the idea of Thanksgiving — the giving of thanks for blessings received in the past year and the opportunity to share an unhurried day with family and friends. The problem for me is that I am one of those freaky, misunderstood people who — as my family jokingly reminds me — eats 'rabbit food.' Because all traditional Western holidays revolve around food and more specifically around ham, turkey, lamb, or roast beef and their respective starchy accompaniments, it is no picnic for us vegetarians." A corresponding annotation reads, Reference to key idea in previous paragraph. The third paragraph reads, "The mention of the word vegetarian has, at various family get-togethers, caused my Great- Aunt Bertha to rant and rave for what seems like hours about those 'liberal conspirators.' A corresponding annotation reads, Repeated key word. Other relations cough or groan or simply stare, change the subject or reminisce about somebody they used to know who was 'into that,' and some proceed either to demand that I defend my position or try to talk me out of it. That is why I try to avoid the subject, but especially during the holidays." A corresponding annotation reads, Transitional time reference. The fourth paragraph reads, In years past I have had about as many successes as failures in steering comments about my food toward other topics. A

corresponding annotation reads, Repeated key idea. Politics and religion are the easiest outs, guaranteed to immerse the family in a heated debate lasting until the loudest shouter has been abandoned amidst empty pie plates, wine corks, and rumpled linen napkins. I prefer, however, to use this tactic as a last resort. Holidays are supposed to be for relaxing. The writer's name reads, —Mundy Wilson-Libby, student.”

Teammates Forever Have a Special Connection

Dan Shaughnessy



John Ioven/The Boston Globe/Getty Images

Born in 1953, Dan Shaughnessy is a native of Groton, Massachusetts. After graduating from the College of the Holy Cross in Worcester, Massachusetts, he began his career in 1977 as a sports writer covering the Baltimore Orioles for the *Baltimore Evening Sun*. He moved to the *Boston Globe* in 1981 and has been covering the Boston Red Sox in baseball and the Boston Celtics in basketball ever since. Shaughnessy has published ten books on sports, too, including *The Curse of the Bambino* (2004), which covered the heated Yankees - Red Sox rivalry, followed by *Reversing the Curse* (2006) after the Red Sox finally won the World Series in 2004. In 2007 he published *Senior Year: A Father, a Son, and High School Baseball*, the story of his relationship with his son Sam; and in 2013 *Francona: The Red Sox Years*, the biography of Terry Francona's time as manager of the Boston Red Sox. He was named the recipient of the 2016 J. G. Taylor Spink Award "for meritorious contributions to baseball writing" by the Baseball Writers' Association of America, the same group that votes on the induction of baseball players into the Hall of Fame.

In this article, originally published in *The Boston Globe* on June 24, 2016, Shaughnessy remembers his old baseball teammate, Stanley J. Kopec Jr. As you read, pay attention to how Shaughnessy uses transitions to move from remembering the past to discussing the present, from team sports to

individual sports, from teams to families, and back to his old teammate.

Reflecting on What You Know

With whom do you have special connections? It could be teammates, but it could also be other people who you have worked with on a common goal: fellow cast members in a play, people in a band, members of a club, employees at a job, or any other similar situation. What do these people mean to you now? What might they mean to you in the future?

Stanley J. Kopec Jr. died of brain cancer at his home in Pepperell at the age of 63 last week. He taught math, worked in high tech for three decades, and loved to play golf. By all accounts, he lived a quiet and happy life in Central Massachusetts. He leaves his wife, his sister, and extended family members. His obituary read, “As genuine as they come, there was not a bone of pretense in his body.”

I know that’s true. Fifty years ago, Stan was my baseball teammate. We always called him “Woody.”

I lost touch with Woody a long time ago. We connected a few times at reunions and funerals — and occasionally he’d send me an e-mail about something in the world of sports — but life and choices simply sent us in different directions.

When a friend sent me a text notifying me of Woody' s passing, I got to thinking about the bonds we form as teammates.

Woody played third base for the Groton Little League Braves in the mid-1960s. A chunky 10-year-old, he batted right, threw right, wore dark-rimmed glasses, and could really hit. I think he led the league in homers in his final year of Little League. We remained teammates through Babe Ruth summers and a couple of high school seasons. As a teenager, he was quiet, steady, and really good with the glove. We all knew he was better at math than the rest of us, but he wasn' t one to brag about anything. He didn' t slam his helmet when he struck out. He didn' t call attention to himself. Just like the obit said, "there was not a bone of pretense."

If you play team sports, you have dozens, maybe hundreds of folks like this in your life. Through the random elements of geography, age, and skill level, you are thrown together with people who share the same goals as yourself. They become your daily sports family. Just like with real family, you don' t get to choose who they are. And just like with real family, they can make you feel great, or they can make you miserable.

Boxers, golfers, gymnasts, skaters, and tennis players don' t have the same experience. They' re out there by themselves.

They alone control their success or failure. There is nobody with whom to share glory. Likewise, there is no one to blame. It's all on you. We all know some team players who would have been better off in individual sports.



Stanley J. Kopec Jr. (bottom row, second from the left) and Dan Shaughnessy (top row, second from the last on the right).

If you play team sports, you spend more time with your teammates than just about anyone else. You share things with them that no one else knows. You have your own language. You have inside jokes. A word to a teammate triggers a memory and a laugh. And only you and your teammates know what you are laughing about.

These bonds are forged through the sheer volume of time you spend with one another and the ways you learn to cope. A shortstop and second baseman develop their own signal system to tell one another who's covering second on the next pitch. Two guys who never get to play bond on the bench, sitting side by side, telling jokes and no doubt agreeing that they are getting screwed over by the coach. They are teammates.

Some teammates don't like each other. It's inevitable. Teammates do not ask to be put together, but the success of the team usually requires that they learn to live and work with one another. It's a life lesson. You learn that you don't have to like the other guy, but you're going to have to figure out how to work with him. Go back and listen to Denzel Washington's speech in *Remember the Titans*, when coach Herman Boone has his team visit the Gettysburg battleground and tells them, "I don't care if you like each other or not, but you will respect each other."

This dynamic never changes, not even at the highest levels of professional team sports. Pedro Martinez and Curt Schilling didn't particularly like one another, but for one season they put their personal stuff on the shelf and worked together to deliver a World Series championship to Boston.

When Larry Bird told us that Dennis Johnson was the best teammate he ever played with, Larry was not pretending that

DJ was a better player or in any way a better guy than Kevin McHale. He was simply paying DJ the highest compliment he could deliver. Larry was telling us that DJ would do anything it took to win. DJ did not need to feed his ego. He did not need “touches.” He would take the charge. He would wear himself out *guarding* Magic Johnson. And when Larry stole the ball on the inbounds pass against the Pistons, DJ would know that his job was to immediately cut to the basket.

The top of Mickey Mantle’s plaque in Yankee Stadium’s Monument Park says nothing about Mantle’s seven championship rings, three MVP awards, or 536 homers. It reads:

Mickey Mantle

“A Great Teammate”

A teammate is someone with whom you shared ... hits, runs, errors, and maybe coffee frappes after the games. Wins and losses. You had a common goal. You went through changes together. You grew up and probably grew apart. But wherever you go and whatever you do, your former teammates are part of your history. There was a time when the thing you were doing together felt like the thing that mattered most.

RIP, Stanley Kopec.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. In [paragraph 1](#), Shaughnessy cites a line from Kopec's obituary: "As genuine as they come, there was not a bone of pretense in his body." What does that mean? Why is that a desirable quality in a person?
2. Why do you suppose Shaughnessy makes the comment that Kopec did not slam his helmet when he struck out ([paragraph 5](#))? What does this comment suggest compared with the behavior of many of today's major leaguers?
3. Which paragraphs use pronouns to transition from one paragraph to the next? Is this the most effective transitional device in each case, or should Shaughnessy have used another means to make the transition?
4. Shaughnessy makes comparisons between team sports and individual sports, saying some teammates would have been better suited to individual sports (7). What qualities would make one not suited for team sports?
5. How does the word "teammate" work as a transitional device to connect [paragraphs 13](#) and [14](#)? (Glossary: [Transition](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What is Shaughnessy's thesis, and where is it stated? What is his purpose in writing this essay?
2. What metaphor does Shaughnessy use to describe team sports and teammates? How well does this metaphor work for you? Does it ring true? In what ways is calling someone your "best teammate ... the highest compliment" you could give a person? Explain.
3. What assumptions does Shaughnessy make about the value of team sports? Are his assumptions reasonable, or has your experience with team sports either as a spectator or participant been different?

Classroom Activity Using Transitions

The following sentences and clauses from the beginning of Lewis Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* have been rearranged. Place the pieces in what seems to you to be a coherent sequence by relying on language signals such as transitions, repeated words, pronouns, and temporal references. Be prepared to explain your reasons for the placement of each sentence.

1. but when the Rabbit actually took a watch out of its waistcoat-pocket, and looked at it, and then hurried on, Alice started to her feet,
2. In another moment down went Alice after it, never once considering how in the world she was to get out

again.

3. Alice was beginning to get very tired of sitting by her sister on the bank, and of having nothing to do:
4. There was nothing so very remarkable in that; nor did Alice think it so very much out of the way to hear the Rabbit say to itself, “Oh dear! Oh dear! I shall be late!” (when she thought it over afterwards, it occurred to her that she ought to have wondered at this, but at the time it all seemed quite natural);
5. So she was considering in her own mind (as well as she could, for the hot day made her feel very sleepy and stupid), whether the pleasure of making a daisy-chain would be worth the trouble of getting up and picking the daisies, when suddenly a White Rabbit with pink eyes ran close by her.
6. once or twice she had peeped into the book her sister was reading, but it had no pictures or conversations in it, “and what is the use of a book,” thought Alice “without pictures or conversations?”
7. and burning with curiosity, she ran across the field after it, and fortunately was just in time to see it pop down a large rabbit-hole under the hedge.
8. for it flashed across her mind that she had never before seen a rabbit with either a waistcoat-pocket, or a watch to take out of it,

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Shaughnessy's article is a remembrance of a childhood friend. Write an essay describing a good friend of yours, how you met, what you do together, and how you envision life as friends in the future. Make sure that you use effective transitions to help your readers follow the timeline of your relationship and the shifts in your discussion between your description, your past, your present, and your future as friends.
2. Write about the role of sports in the lives of young people today. Are sports still a positive influence, as Shaughnessy's article claims, or have sports today become a problem, with the promise of money and fame creating an allure that only a few can ever achieve? Consider also the influence of performance-enhancing drugs, the push toward professionalism at amateur levels, and the emphasis on winning rather than simply competing. Be sure to use effective transitional expressions and devices in your writing to help your readers follow your argument.

Let Children Get Bored Again

Pamela Paul



Marion Ettlinger/Getty images

Pamela Paul is an author and journalist who has written for *The Economist*, *The Atlantic*, *Time*, *Vogue*, and other magazines. Her books, which focus on such topics as marriage, children, reading, and the consequences of societal trends, include *The Starter Marriage and the Future of Matrimony* (2003), *Pornified* (2005), *Parenting, Inc.* (2008), *By the Book: Writers on Literature and the Literary Life from The New York Times Book Review* (2014), and *My Life with Bob: Flawed Heroine Keeps Book of Books, Plot Ensues* (2014). She also co-wrote *How to Raise a Reader* (2019). She joined *The New York Times* in 2011, and in 2013 she was named senior editor of *The New York Times Book Review*.

The following selection, “Let Children Get Bored Again,” was published in *The New York Times* on February 2, 2019. Paul believes that boredom is important for children because it can give rise to “flights of fancy, self-discipline” and “resourcefulness” (13). Notice how she uses a variety of transitional devices to enhance the flow of her argument from one paragraph to the next throughout the entire essay.

Reflecting on What You Know

Have you ever had an important idea when you were taking a shower, washing dishes, walking to the store, or otherwise engaged in a mundane activity? If so, do you think boredom played any part in the emergence of your idea? If you

haven' t had this experience, why do you think it hasn' t happened?

“I' m bored.” It' s a puny little phrase, yet it has the power to fill parents with a cascade of dread, annoyance and guilt. If someone around here is bored, someone else must have failed to enlighten or enrich or divert. And how can anyone — child or adult — claim boredom when there' s so much that can and should be done? Immediately.

But boredom is something to experience rather than hastily swipe away. And not as some kind of cruel Victorian conditioning, recommended because it' s awful and toughens you up. Despite the lesson most adults learned growing up — boredom is for boring people — boredom is useful. It' s good for you.

If kids don' t figure this out early on, they' re in for a nasty surprise. School, let' s face it, can be dull, and it isn' t actually the teacher' s job to entertain as well as educate. Life isn' t meant to be an endless parade of amusements. “That' s right,” a mother says to her daughter in Maria Semple' s 2012 novel, *Where' d You Go, Bernadette*.

“You are bored. And I' m going to let you in on a little secret about life. You think it' s boring now? Well, it only gets more boring. The sooner you learn it' s on you to make life interesting, the better off you' ll be.”

People used to accept that much of life was boring. Memoirs of pre-21st-century life are rife with tedium. When not idling in drawing rooms, members of the leisured class took long walks and stared at trees. They went motoring and stared at more trees. Those who had to work had it a lot harder. Agricultural and industrial jobs were often mind-numbing; few people were looking to be fulfilled by paid labor. Children could expect those kinds of futures and they got used to the idea from an early age, left unattended with nothing but bookshelves and tree branches, and later, bad afternoon television.

Only a few short decades ago, during the lost age of underparenting, grown-ups thought a certain amount of boredom was appropriate. And children came to appreciate their empty agendas. In an interview with *GQ* magazine, Lin-Manuel Miranda credited his unattended afternoons with fostering inspiration. “Because there is nothing better to spur creativity than a blank page or an empty bedroom,” he said.

Nowadays, subjecting a child to such inactivity is viewed as a dereliction of parental duty. In a much-read story in *The Times*, “The Relentlessness of Modern Parenting,” Claire Cain Miller cited a recent study that found that regardless of class, income or race, parents believed that “children who were bored after school should be enrolled in extracurricular activities, and that parents who were busy

should stop their task and draw with their children if asked. ”

Every spare moment is to be optimized, maximized, driven toward a goal.

When not being uberparented, kids today are left to their own devices — their own digital devices, that is. Parents preparing for a long car ride or airplane trip are like Army officers plotting a complicated land maneuver. Which movies to load onto the iPad? Should we start a new family-friendly podcast? Is this an O.K. time to let the kids play Fortnite until their brains melt into the back seat? What did parents in the ’ 70s do when kids were bored in the way-back? Nothing! They let them breathe in gas fumes. Torture their siblings. And since it wasn’ t actually for wearing, play with the broken seatbelt.

If you complained about being bored back then, you were really asking for it. “Go outside,” you might get, or worse, “Clean your room.” Was this fun? No. Was it helpful? Yes.

Because things happen when you’ re bored. Some of the most boring jobs I’ ve had were also the most creative. Working at an import factory after school, I pasted photos of ugly Peruvian sweaters onto sales sheets. My hands became

encrusted with glue as the sweaters blurred into a clumpy sameness. For some reason, everything smelled like molasses. My mind had no choice but to drift into an elaborate fantasy realm. It's when you are bored that stories set in. Checking out groceries at the supermarket, I invented narratives around people's purchases. The man buying eggplant and a six-pack of Bud at 9 p.m.: Which was the must-get item and which the impulse purchase? How did my former fifth-grade teacher feel about my observing her weekly purchase of Nutter Butters?

Once you've truly settled into the anesthetizing¹ effects of boredom, you find yourself en route to discovery. With monotony, small differences begin to emerge, between those trees, those sweaters. This is why so many useful ideas occur in the shower, when you're held captive to a mundane activity. You let your mind wander and follow it where it goes.

Of course, it's not really the boredom itself that's important; it's what we do with it. When you reach your breaking point, boredom teaches you to respond constructively, to make something happen for yourself. But unless we are faced with a steady diet of stultifying boredom, we never learn how.

The idea isn't that you suffer through crushing tedium indefinitely like Neville ("N is for Neville who died of ennui") of *The Gashlycrumb Tinies*.² It's that you learn how to vanquish it. This may come in several forms: You might turn inward and use the time to think. You might reach for a book. You might imagine your way to a better job. Boredom leads to flights of fancy. But ultimately, to self-discipline. To resourcefulness.

The ability to handle boredom, not surprisingly, is correlated with the ability to focus and to self-regulate. Research has shown that people with attention disorders are particularly prone to boredom. It makes sense that in a hyperstimulating world, what at first seems captivating now feels less so; what was once mildly diverting may now be flat-out dull.

It's especially important that kids get bored — and be allowed to stay bored — when they're young. That it not be considered "a problem" to be avoided or eradicated by the higher-ups, but instead something kids grapple with on their own.

We've stopped training children to do this. Rather than teach them to absorb material that is slower, duller and decidedly two-dimensional, like a lot of worthwhile information is, schools cave in to what they say children

expect: fun. Teachers spend more time concocting ways to “engage” students through visuals and “interactive learning” (read: screens, games) tailored to their Candy Crushed attention spans. Kids won’ t listen to long lectures, goes the argument, so it’ s on us to serve up learning in easier-to-swallow portions.

But surely teaching children to endure boredom rather than ratcheting up the entertainment will prepare them for a more realistic future, one that doesn’ t raise false expectations of what work or life itself actually entails. One day, even in a job they otherwise love, our kids may have to spend an entire day answering Friday’ s leftover email. They may have to check spreadsheets. Or assist robots at a vast internet-ready warehouse.

This sounds boring, you might conclude. It sounds like work, and it sounds like life. Perhaps we should get used to it again, and use it to our benefit. Perhaps in an incessant, up-the-ante world, we could do with a little less excitement.

Pamela Paul, “Let Children Get Bored Again,” *The New York Times*, February 2, 2019. Copyright © 2019 by The New York Times. All rights reserved. Used under license.

¹*anesthetizing*: numbing, desensitizing.

²*The Gashlycrumb Tinies*: first published in 1963, an illustrated children’ s book by Edward Gorey in which 26 characters meet

untimely and often humorous deaths, each representing a letter of the alphabet.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Paul writes that “boredom is something to experience rather than hastily swipe away” (2). What does she mean by this statement?
2. What evidence does Paul use to support her point that “People used to accept that much of life was boring” (4)?
3. In [paragraph 10](#), what does Paul say is the positive effect of boredom? What example does she use in this paragraph to support her point?
4. What contrast is set up by the transitional expressions “Only a few short decades ago” (5) and “Nowadays” (6)? What is the effect of this contrast on you as a reader?
5. Explain how Paul makes the transition between [paragraphs 9](#) and [10](#) and then between [10](#) and [11](#). Did you find the transitions effective and unobtrusive? Explain.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Paul writes, “School, let’s face it, can be dull, and it isn’t actually the teacher’s job to

entertain as well as educate. Life isn't meant to be an endless parade of amusements" (3). Do you agree with her that teachers do not need to be entertainers? Explain why or why not.

2. In her essay, Paul sometimes uses puns, or jokes that reveal multiple meanings of a word, to make transitions within sentences. Identify a pun in [paragraph 8](#) or [paragraph 16](#) and explain the way the pun is functioning as a transition. Do you think Paul's use of this pun as a transition is effective? Why or why not?
3. In her concluding paragraph, Paul states, "Perhaps we should get used to [boredom] again, and use it to our benefit" (18). In your opinion, would it be useful for those in power (such as parents, educators, and politicians) to help create a culture where boredom is societally valued? If so, how might they do so? If not, why not?

Classroom Activity Using Transitions

Instructions for constructing and hanging a tire swing appear here in scrambled order. First, read all nine sentences carefully. Next, arrange the sentences in what seems to you to be a logical sequence. Finally, identify places where transitional expressions, repetition of

words and ideas, and pronoun references give coherence to the instructions.

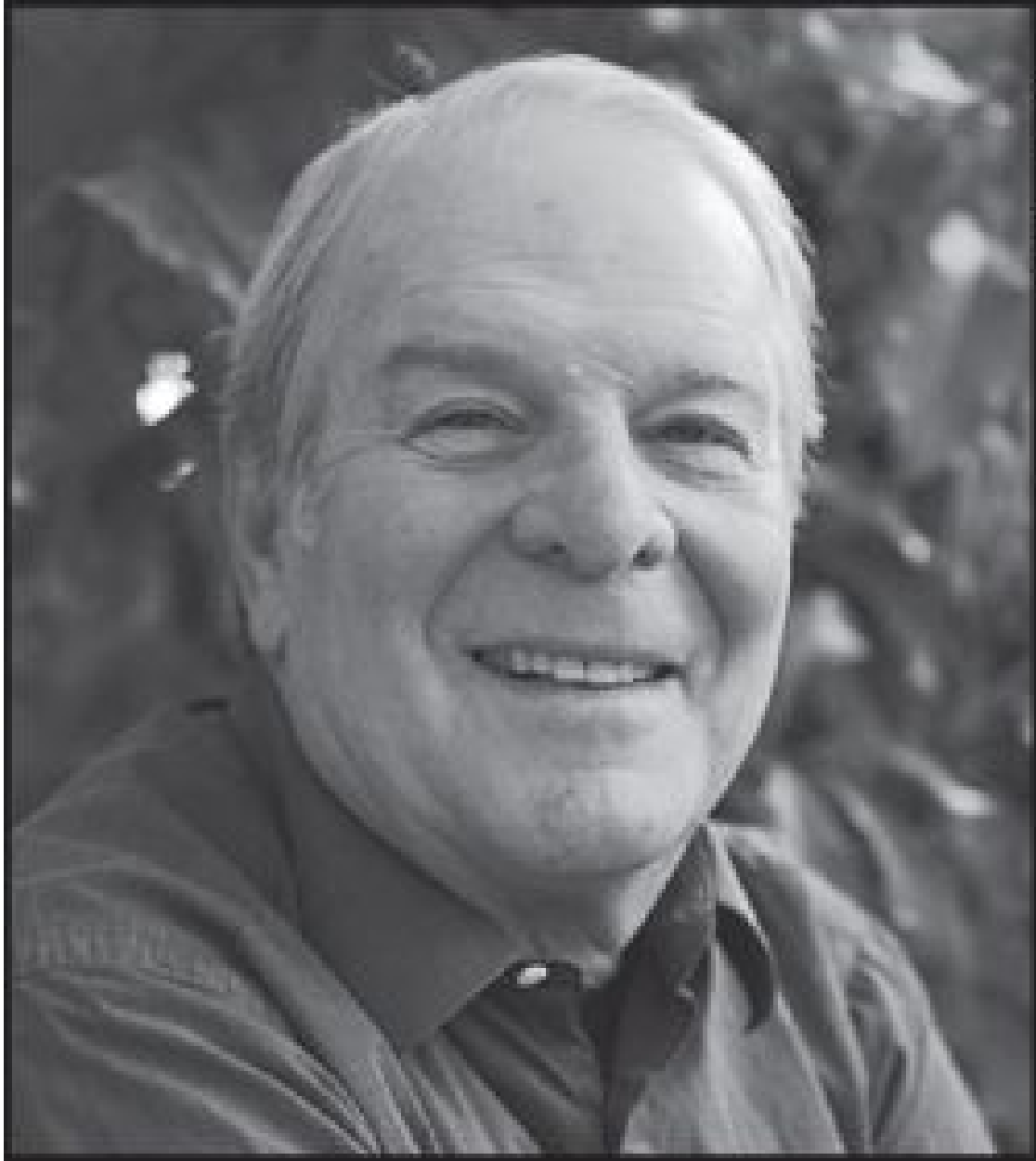
1. Attach your tire to the rope with another tight square knot. (Make sure your tire is hanging with the holes on the bottom.)
2. After it's clean, drill a few holes, evenly spaced, along the bottom half of the tire to act as a drain for rainwater.
3. Then, using a ladder, loop your protected rope over the branch, and secure the rope to the branch with a tight square knot.
4. First, pick a sturdy branch that is high enough to accommodate the length of your rope and strong enough to support your weight.
5. After it's secured, spread some mulch around the base of your tire swing to absorb any falls.
6. Then find a tire that is large enough to comfortably fit one person.
7. Now test your swing and have some fun!
8. Next, clean the tire thoroughly before getting to work.
9. When your tire is ready to be hung, get your rope and place rubber tubing over the section that will rest over the branch. (The tubing will help protect your rope from fraying.)

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write a brief essay in which you argue for or against boredom using examples from your own life to support your thesis. (Glossary: [Thesis](#)) In your essay, include one paragraph describing a moment when you felt extremely busy, followed by a paragraph where you felt very bored. Use at least one transitional expression between these two paragraphs (see [p. 179](#)). Highlight the transitional expression and label the type of transition you have created.
2. There have been many changes in society in your lifetime, often involving the loss of something that used to be widespread. Write a short essay in which you argue that something society has lost should be brought back. Your essay can be about an idea (like boredom or freedom) or an object (like CD music albums). Make sure that your essay includes at least one transitional expression, at least one moment of repetition, and at least one use of a pronoun to stand in for a noun. Be sure to use specific examples to support your argument. (Glossary: [Example](#)) When you have completed your essay, highlight all of your transitions and write one short reflection paragraph about how you chose your transitions and how the transitions work to strengthen the essay as a whole.

The Case for Short Words

Richard Lederer



Courtesy of Richard Lederer

Born in 1938, Richard Lederer holds degrees from Haverford College, Harvard University, and the University of New Hampshire. He has been a prolific and popular writer about language and is the author of more than forty books about language, history, and humor, including his best-selling *Anguished English* series. His latest book, *The Joy of Names*, was published in 2018. He's a frequent radio commentator on language, and his column, "Lederer on Language," appears in newspapers and magazines throughout the United States. Dr. Lederer has been named International Punster of the Year and is a Toastmasters International's Golden Gavel winner.

In the following essay, taken from *The Miracle of Language* (1999), pay attention to the structure of his argument. He begins with a strong proposition and returns at the end to this proposition, which he expects might contradict what readers have assumed or have been taught about what makes good writing. Also make note of how Lederer uses a variety of transitions to seamlessly move from one paragraph to the next.

Reflecting on What You Know

We all carry with us a vocabulary of short, simple-looking words that possess a special personal meaning. For example, to some the word *rose* represents not just a flower but a whole array of gardens, ceremonies, and romantic occasions.

What little words have special meaning for you? What images do they bring to mind?

When you speak and write, there is no law that says you have to use big words. Short words are as good as long ones, and short, old words — like *sun* and *grass* and *home* — are best of all. A lot of small words, more than you might think, can meet your needs with a strength, grace, and charm that large words do not have.

Big words can make the way dark for those who read what you write and hear what you say. Small words cast their clear light on big things — night and day, love and hate, war and peace, and life and death. Big words at times seem strange to the eye and the ear and the mind and the heart. Small words are the ones we seem to have known from the time we were born, like the hearth fire that warms the home.

Short words are bright like sparks that glow in the night, prompt like the dawn that greets the day, sharp like the blade of a knife, hot like salt tears that scald the cheek, quick like moths that flit from flame to flame, and terse like the dart and sting of a bee.

Here is a sound rule: Use small, old words where you can. If a long word says just what you want to say, do not fear to use it. But know that our tongue is rich in crisp, brisk,

swift, short words. Make them the spine and the heart of what you speak and write. Short words are like fast friends. They will not let you down.

The title of this [essay] and the four paragraphs that you have just read are wrought entirely of words of one syllable. In setting myself this task, I did not feel especially cabined, cribbed, or confined. In fact, the structure helped me to focus on the power of the message I was trying to put across.

One study shows that twenty words account for twenty-five percent of all spoken English words, and all twenty are monosyllabic. In order of frequency they are: *I, you, the, a, to, is, it, that, of, and, in, what, he, this, have, do, she, not, on, and they*. Other studies indicate that the fifty most common words in written English are each made of a single syllable.

For centuries our finest poets and orators have recognized and employed the power of small words to make a straight point between two minds. A great many of our proverbs punch home their points with pithy monosyllables: “Where there’ s a will, there’ s a way,” “A stitch in time saves nine,” “Spare the rod and spoil the child,” “A bird in the hand is worth two in the bush.”

Nobody used the short word more skillfully than William Shakespeare, whose dying King Lear laments:

And my poor fool is hang' d! No, no, no life!
Why should a dog, a horse, a rat have life,
And thou no breath at all? ...
Do you see this? Look on her, look, her lips.
Look there, look there!

Shakespeare's contemporaries made the King James Bible a centerpiece of short words — “And God said, Let there be light: and there was light. And God saw the light, that it was good.” The descendants of such mighty lines live on in the twentieth century. When asked to explain his policy to Parliament, Winston Churchill¹ responded with these ringing monosyllables: “I will say: it is to wage war, by sea, land, and air, with all our might and with all the strength that God can give us.” In his “Death of the Hired Man” Robert Frost² observes that “Home is the place where, when you have to go there, / They have to take you in.” And William H. Johnson³ uses ten two-letter words to explain his secret of success: “If it is to be, / It is up to me.”

You don't have to be a great author, statesman, or philosopher to tap the energy and eloquence of small words. Each winter I ask my ninth graders at St. Paul's School to write a composition composed entirely of one-syllable words.

My students greet my request with obligatory moans and groans, but, when they return to class with their essays, most feel that, with the pressure to produce high-sounding polysyllables relieved, they have created some of their most powerful and luminous prose. Here are submissions from two of my ninth graders:

What can you say to a boy who has left home? You can say that he has done wrong, but he does not care. He has left home so that he will not have to deal with what you say. He wants to go as far as he can. He will do what he wants to do.

This boy does not want to be forced to go to church, to comb his hair, or to be on time. A good time for this boy does not lie in your reach, for what you have he does not want. He dreams of ripped jeans, shorts with no starch, and old socks.

So now this boy is on a bus to a place he dreams of, a place with no rules. This boy now walks a strange street, his long hair blown back by the wind. He wears no coat or tie, just jeans and an old shirt. He hates your world, and he has left it.

— Charles Shaffer

For a long time we cruised by the coast and at last came to a wide bay past the curve of a hill, at the end of which lay a small town. Our long boat ride at an end, we all stretched and stood up to watch as the boat nosed its way in.

The town climbed up the hill that rose from the shore, a space in front of it left bare for the port. Each house was a clean

white with sky blue or gray trim; in front of each one was a small yard, edged by a white stone wall strewn with green vines.

As the town basked in the heat of noon, not a thing stirred in the streets or by the shore. The sun beat down on the sea, the land, and the back of our necks, so that, in spite of the breeze that made the vines sway, we all wished we could hide from the glare in a cool, white house. But, as there was no one to help dock the boat, we had to stand and wait.

At last the head of the crew leaped from the side and strode to a large house on the right. He shoved the door wide, poked his head through the gloom, and roared with a fierce voice. Five or six men came out, and soon the port was loud with the clank of chains and creak of planks as the men caught ropes thrown by the crew, pulled them taut, and tied them to posts. Then they set up a rough plank so we could cross from the deck to the shore. We all made for the large house while the crew watched, glad to be rid of us.

— Celia Wren

You too can tap into the vitality and vigor of compact expression. Take a suggestion from the highway department. At the boundaries of your speech and prose place a sign that reads “Caution: Small Words at Work.”

¹*Winston Churchill* (1874–1965): British orator, author, and statesman.

²*Robert Frost* (1874–1963): American poet.

³*William H. Johnson* (1771–1834): associate justice of the U.S. Supreme Court, 1804–1834.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How does Lederer support his argument? What types of evidence does he provide to support his claim that “short, old words ... are best of all” (1)? (Glossary: [Evidence](#))
2. How does Lederer make the transition from the first paragraph to the second? From the second to the third?
3. Identify several different transitional expressions in Lederer’s essay and explain how each works.
4. Lederer quotes a variety of passages to illustrate the effectiveness of short words. For example, he quotes from famous, universally familiar sources, such as Shakespeare and the King James Bible, as well as his own ninth-grade students. How does the variety of his illustrations serve to inform his readers? How does each example gain impact from the inclusion of the others and support his argument?
5. This essay has many striking sentences and passages consisting entirely of one-syllable words. Choose four of the single-sentence examples or a section of several sentences from one of the longer examples and rewrite them, using primarily words of two or more

syllables. Notice how each revision differs from the original.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. In his opening paragraph, Lederer states that “short, old words — like *sun* and *grass* and home — are best of all.” Does this claim surprise you by running counter to what we’ve always heard about “big words” and a large vocabulary? Explain.
2. In [paragraph 10](#), Lederer refers to the relief his students feel when released from “the pressure to produce high-sounding polysyllables.” Where do you think this pressure comes from? How is this anecdote related to Lederer’s central purpose in the essay? Explain.
3. To make clear to the reader why short words are effective, Lederer relies heavily on metaphors and similes, especially in the first four paragraphs. Identify these figures of speech, and explain the comparison explicit in each.

Classroom Activity Using Transitions

Read the following three paragraphs from a student's narrative essay. Provide transitions between sentences and paragraphs so that the narrative flows smoothly.

Last year, I got lost on a hike during an extended camping trip in Oregon. I lost the path where a storm had washed it out and could not find my way back. I walked in the rain all day, desperate to find a road that would lead me to some sign of humanity. I tried not to panic, but I was cold and exhausted, and I had no extra clothes or any gear with me to make camp for the night.

I picked a direction and hoped it would lead me before long to a gas station or a restaurant — anyplace where I could get something hot to drink. After about twenty minutes I came to a little diner, but I could tell from first sight that it was closed. The sign wasn't lit, and it looked like the lights were off inside, too.

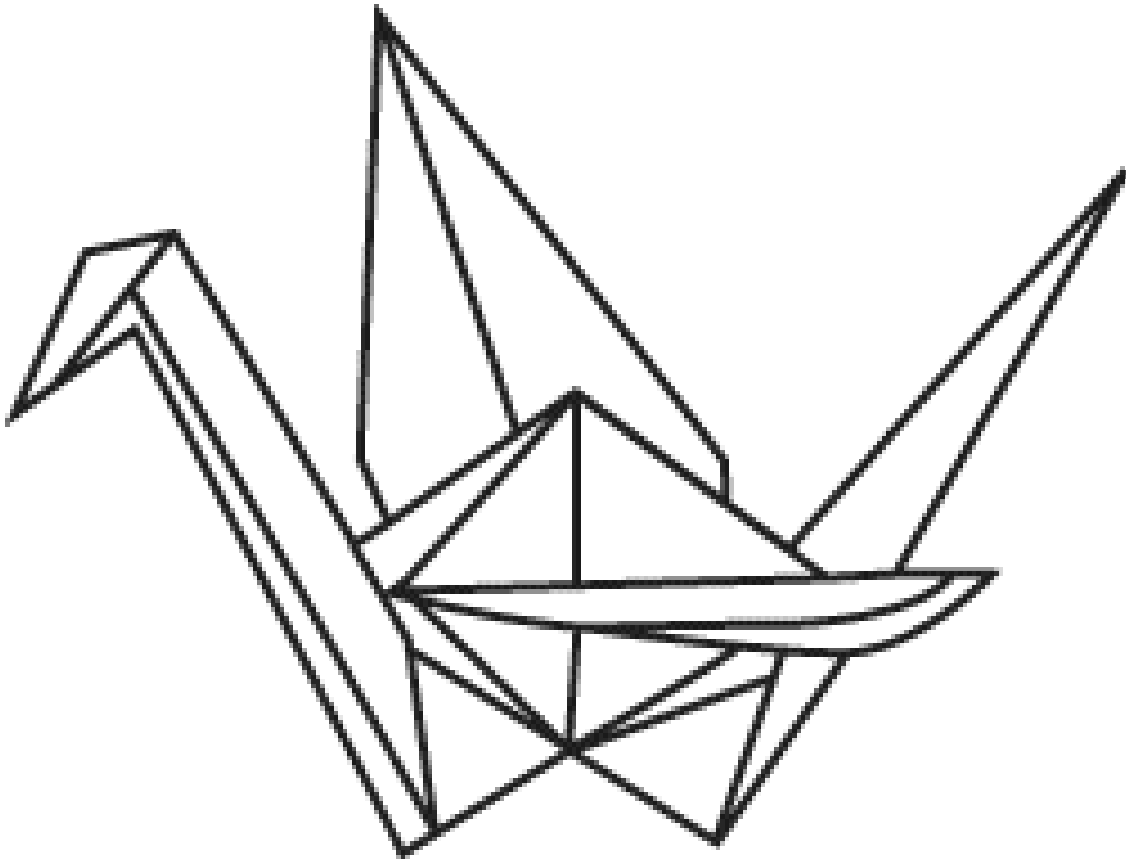
One of the workers let me in through the kitchen and gave me the last of a pot of coffee, which wasn't that hot anymore, but I was not feeling picky by that point. I had not had cell phone reception since the morning, but she let me use the diner's phone to call my friends. She had to lock up and leave before they arrived, but she sent me out to wait under the front awning with a piece of pie in a napkin and a wool scarf that she said had been sitting in the lost-and-found box for months.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Follow the assignment Lederer gives his own students, and write a composition using only of one-syllable words. Make your piece approximately the length of his student examples or of his own four-paragraph opening.
2. Write a persuasive essay attempting to convince readers to give up a widely held belief. Using Lederer' s essay as a model, state your argument directly in the first paragraph, and use the final paragraph to reiterate the value of your proposition.



CHAPTER 9 Effective Sentences



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Although it often takes an entire essay or book to convey an idea, it is important to pay attention to each individual sentence, too. The way ideas are crafted into sentences and the variety of sentences that we use can have a huge impact on readers' understanding and enjoyment of a text. Using different sentence patterns will not only keep readers interested in a text but can also make the ideas we are conveying more powerful.

Each of the following paragraphs describes the Canadian city of Vancouver, British Columbia. Although the content of both paragraphs is essentially the same, the first paragraph is written in sentences of nearly the same length and pattern, whereas the second paragraph uses sentences of varying length and pattern.

Unvaried Sentences

Water surrounds Vancouver on three sides. The snow-crowned Coast Mountains ring the city on the northeast. Vancouver has a floating quality of natural loveliness. There is a curved beach at English Bay. This beach is in the shape of a half moon. Residential high-rises stand behind the beach. They are in pale tones of beige, blue, and ice-cream pink. Turn-of-the-century houses of painted wood frown upward at the glitter of office towers. Any urban glare is softened by folds of green lawns, flowers, fountains, and trees. Such landscaping appears to be unplanned. It links Vancouver to her ultimate treasure of greenness. That treasure is thousand-acre Stanley Park. Surrounding stretches of water dominate. They have image-evoking names like False Creek and Lost Lagoon. Sailboats and pleasure craft skim blithely across Burrard Inlet. Foreign freighters are out in English Bay. They await their turn to take on cargoes of grain.

Varied Sentences

Surrounded by water on three sides and ringed to the northeast by the snow-crowned Coast Mountains, Vancouver has a floating quality of natural loveliness. At English Bay, the half-moon curve of beach is backed by high-rises in pale tones of beige,

blue, and ice-cream pink. Turn-of-the-century houses of painted wood frown upward at the glitter of office towers. Yet any urban glare is quickly softened by folds of green lawns, flowers, fountains, and trees that in a seemingly unplanned fashion link Vancouver to her ultimate treasure of greenness — thousand-acre Stanley Park. And always it is the surrounding stretches of water that dominate, with their image-evoking names like False Creek and Lost Lagoon. Sailboats and pleasure craft skim blithely across Burrard Inlet, while out in English Bay foreign freighters await their turn to take on cargoes of grain.

The difference between these two paragraphs is dramatic. The first is monotonous because of the sameness of the sentence structure and because the ideas are not related to one another in a meaningful way. The second paragraph is much more interesting and readable; its sentences vary in length and are structured to clarify the relationships among the ideas. Sentence variety, an important aspect of all good writing, should be used to express ideas precisely and to emphasize the most important ideas within each sentence. Sentence variety includes the use of *subordination*, *periodic and loose sentences*, *dramatically short sentences*, *active and passive voice*, *coordination*, and *parallelism*.

SUBORDINATION

Subordination, the process of giving one idea less emphasis than another in a sentence, is one of the most important characteristics of an effective sentence and a mature prose style. Writers subordinate ideas by introducing them either with subordinating conjunctions (*because, if, as though, while, when, after*) or with relative pronouns (*that, which, who, whomever, what*). Subordination not only deemphasizes some ideas but also highlights others that the writer believes are more important.

There is nothing about an idea — *any* idea — that automatically makes it primary or secondary in importance. The writer decides what to emphasize, and he or she may choose to emphasize the less profound or noteworthy of two ideas. Consider, for example, the following sentence:

“Melissa was reading a detective story while the national election results were being televised.” Everyone, including the author of the sentence, knows that the national election is a more noteworthy event than Melissa reading a detective story. But the sentence concerns Melissa, not the election, and so her reading is stated in the main clause, while the election news is subordinated in a dependent clause.

Generally, writers place the ideas they consider important in main clauses, and other ideas go into dependent clauses.

Consider the following examples:

When she was thirty years old, she made her first solo flight across the Atlantic.

When she made her first solo flight across the Atlantic, she was thirty years old.

The first sentence emphasizes the solo flight; in the second sentence, the emphasis is on the pilot's age.

✓ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Coordination and Subordination

PERIODIC AND LOOSE SENTENCES

Another way to achieve emphasis is to place the most important words, phrases, and clauses at the beginning or end of a sentence. The ending is the most emphatic part of the sentence, the beginning is less emphatic, and the middle is the least emphatic of all. The two preceding sentences about the thirty-year-old pilot put the main clause at the end, achieving special emphasis. The same thing occurs in a much longer kind of sentence, called a *periodic sentence*, in which the main idea is placed at the end, closest to the period. Here is an example from *The New Yorker's* "Talk of the Town" feature:

On the afternoon of the first day of spring, when the gutters were still heaped high with Monday's snow but the sky itself had been swept clean, we put on our galoshes and walked up the sunny side of Fifth Avenue to Central Park.

— John Updike

By holding the main clause back, Updike keeps his readers in suspense and so puts the most emphasis possible on his main idea.

A *loose sentence*, on the other hand, states its main idea at the beginning and then adds details in subsequent phrases and

clauses. Rewritten as a loose sentence, Updike's sentence might read like this:

We put on our galoshes and walked up the sunny side of Fifth Avenue to Central Park on the afternoon of the first day of spring, when the gutters were still heaped high with Monday's snow but the sky itself had been swept clean.

The main idea still gets plenty of emphasis, since it is contained in a main clause at the beginning of the sentence. A loose sentence resembles the way people talk: it flows naturally and is easy to understand.

DRAMATICALLY SHORT SENTENCES

Another way to create emphasis is to use a *dramatically short sentence*. Especially when following a long and involved sentence, a short declarative sentence helps drive a point home. Here are two examples:

The qualities that Barbie promotes (slimness, youth, and beauty) allow no tolerance of gray hair, wrinkles, sloping posture, or failing eyesight and hearing. Barbie's perfect body is eternal.

— Danielle Kuykendall, student

Be specific. Don't say "fruit." Tell what kind of fruit — "It is a pomegranate." Give things the dignity of their names. Just as with human beings, it is rude to say, "Hey, girl, get in line." That "girl" has a name. (As a matter of fact, if she's at least twenty years old, she's a woman, not a "girl" at all.) Things, too, have names. It is much better to say "the geranium in the window" than "the flower in the window." "Geranium" — that one word gives us a much more specific picture. It penetrates more deeply into the beingness of that flower. It immediately gives us the scene by the window — red petals, green circular leaves, all straining toward sunlight.

— Natalie Goldberg, ["Be Specific,"](#) pp. 346 – 47

ACTIVE AND PASSIVE VOICE

Since the subject of a sentence is automatically emphasized, writers may choose to use the *active voice* when they want to emphasize the doer of an action and the *passive voice* when they want to downplay or omit the doer completely. Here are two examples:

High winds pushed our sailboat onto the rocks, where the force of the waves tore it to pieces.

Our sailboat was pushed by high winds onto the rocks, where it was torn to pieces by the force of the waves.

— Liz Coughlan, student

The first sentence emphasizes the natural forces that destroyed the boat, whereas the second sentence focuses attention on the boat itself. The passive voice may be useful in placing emphasis, but it has important disadvantages. As the examples show, and as the terms suggest, active-voice verbs are more vigorous and vivid than the same verbs in the passive voice. Then, too, some writers use the passive voice to hide or evade responsibility. “It has been decided” conceals who did the deciding, whereas “I have decided”

makes it all clear. So the passive voice should be used only when necessary, as it is in this sentence.

☑ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Active and Passive Voice

COORDINATION

Often a writer wants to place equal emphasis on several facts or ideas. One way to do so is to give each its own sentence. For example, consider these three sentences about tennis player Serena Williams.

Serena Williams chose a racket. She walked to the baseline. She then began to serve.

But a long series of short, simple sentences quickly becomes tedious. Many writers would combine these three sentences by using **coordination**. The coordinating conjunctions *and*, *but*, *or*, *nor*, *for*, *so*, and *yet* connect words, phrases, and clauses of equal importance:

Serena Williams chose a racket, walked to the baseline, and began to serve.

— Will Briggs, student

By coordinating three sentences into one, the writer makes the same words easier to read and also shows that Williams' three actions are equally important parts of a single process.

PARALLELISM

When parts of a sentence are not only coordinated but also grammatically the same, they are parallel. Parallelism in a sentence is created by balancing a word with a word, a phrase with a phrase, or a clause with a clause. Here is a humorous example from the beginning of Mark Twain's *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*:

Persons attempting to find a motive in this narrative will be prosecuted; persons attempting to find a moral in it will be banished; persons attempting to find a plot in it will be shot.

— Mark Twain

Parallelism is often found in speeches. For example, in the last sentence of the Gettysburg Address, President Abraham Lincoln proclaims his hope that “government of the people, by the people, for the people, shall not perish from the earth.”

✓ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Parallelism

White Lies

Erin Murphy



Sarah Morgan

Erin Murphy was born in New Britain, Connecticut, in 1968 and grew up in Richmond, Virginia. She earned a BA in English from Washington College in 1990 and an MFA in English and poetry from the University of Massachusetts in 1993. Murphy is author of seven collections of poetry, including *Too Much of This World* (2008), winner of the Anthony Piccione Poetry Prize, and *Word Problems* (2011), winner of the Paterson Prize for Literary Excellence. She is also coeditor of a poetry anthology, *Making Poems: Forty Poems with Commentary by the Poets* (2010) and *Creating Nonfiction: Twenty Essays and Interviews with Writers* (2016). Other awards include a National Writers' Union Poetry Award; a Dorothy Sargent Rosenberg Poetry Prize; a Foley Poetry Award; and fellowships from the Pennsylvania Council on the Arts, the Maryland State Arts Council, and the Virginia Center for the Creative Arts. Her poems have appeared in dozens of journals and several anthologies, including *180 More: Extraordinary Poems for Every Day*, edited by Billy Collins. She is on the faculty at Pennsylvania State University's Altoona College, where she teaches English and creative writing; she has received several teaching awards, including the university-wide Alumni Award for Excellence in Teaching.

First published in 2010 in *Brevity*, the following essay has been nominated for a Pushcart Prize. Murphy comments on her writing of the narrative and how she feels about it now:

“This is a story that I carried with me for thirty years

before I wrote about it. Now that I am a mother, I have a heightened awareness of the kind of bullying that is all too common in schools. When my own children came home with stories about classmates being ostracized, I thought of Connie and her candy. For decades, I've felt sympathy for Connie; from my current perspective, I also feel tremendous sympathy for her mother." As you read, notice how Murphy captures the reader's attention by crafting effective sentences.

Reflecting on What You Know

At what point do repeated mocking comments directed at our classmates and school friends cross the line into bullying? Have you engaged in such mocking comments? Have you been bullied? Have you come to anyone's rescue who was being bullied? Explain.

Arpi, a Lebanese girl who pronounced *ask* as *ax* no matter how many times the teacher corrected her, must have been delighted by the arrival of Connie, the new girl in our fifth grade class. Connie was albino, exceptionally white even by the ultra-Caucasian standards of our southern suburb. Only her eyelids had color: mouse-nose pink, framed by moth-white lashes and brows.

We had been taught that there was no comparative or superlative for *different*. Things were either different or

the same, the teacher said. Likewise for *perfect* — something was either perfect or not. But surely Arpi thought of Connie as *more different* than herself. Arpi may have had a name that sounded all too close to Alpo, a brand of dog food, but at least she had a family whose skin and hair and eyes looked like hers. Connie, by comparison, was alone in her difference. She was, perhaps, *most different. Differentest.*

This was confirmed by the ridicule, which was immediate and unrelenting: *Casper, Chalk Face, Q-Tip*. Connie, whose shoulders hunched in a permanent parenthesis, pretended not to hear the names or the taunting questions: *What' d ya do, take a bath in bleach? Who' s your boyfriend — Frosty the Snowman?* She sat in the front of the classroom, and if she felt the boys plucking white hairs from her scalp, she didn' t react. The teacher, who was serving the last nine months of a thirty-year sentence in the public school system, spent the bulk of each day perusing magazines and L.L. Bean catalogs in the back of the room. As far as I know, she never intervened.

All of this changed in mid-October when Connie' s father got a job at a candy factory, news Connie announced tentatively one rainy day during indoor recess.

Can he get us candy?

Yes.

Any kind? As much as we want? For free?

Yes, yes, yes.

And so the daily ritual began. Kids placed orders for Reese' s Cups, Baby Ruth bars, Hubba-Bubba bubble gum. Connie kept a log of the requests in a pocket-sized notebook. The next day, she would tote a box full of candy into the classroom and distribute the promised sweets to eager hands. Overnight, Connie became the center of attention. Girls — even Marcia Miller, the first in our class to wear mascara — would beg to sit by Connie at lunch so they could update their orders.

And what about me? What was my role? Did I request my favorites — Three Musketeers and coconut-centered Mounds bars? Or did I, as I have told myself and others in the years since, refuse to contribute to such cruelty? Or, in a more likely scenario, did I dump out my loot triumphantly at home one afternoon, only to be scolded by my mother? I don' t remember, my memory obscured, I' m sure, by the wishful image of myself as a precocious champion of social justice. And I don' t remember if I actually witnessed — or just imagined — Connie and her mother at the 7-Eleven one day after school. They were in the candy aisle. Her mother was filling

a cardboard box. And Connie, bathed in unflinching fluorescence, was curved over her notebook making small, careful check marks.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Murphy' s first sentence contains a lot of detail and uses parallelism to introduce Arpi and Connie. What is the effect of this beginning? (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#))
2. Murphy' s story is brief, but how well does she satisfy the five essential features of good narration — a clear context; well-chosen details; a logical, often chronological organization; an appropriate and consistent point of view; and a meaningful point or purpose? Explain.
3. What point does Murphy make about the lack of comparative and superlative forms for some adjectives? Does reality support the grammatical rule? Explain.
4. [Paragraph 4](#) is a single long sentence, followed by a series of very brief paragraphs consisting of short sentences. What is the effect of this? Examine other parts of Murphy' s story. How does she vary her sentences and to what effect? (Glossary: [Sentence](#))
5. What is the point of Murphy' s story?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. In her essay, Murphy introduces an interesting technique for an essay writer. Murphy explains:

This essay hinges on the use of what the writer Lisa Knopp calls “perhapsing.” Sometimes when we’re writing, we can’t recall the exact details of our experiences. In this case, we can “perhaps” or speculate about what actually happened. In the final paragraph of “White Lies,” I speculate about whether I saw or dreamt about Connie and her mother in the convenience store. The result of this rhetorical strategy is two-fold: it establishes me as a reliable narrator and allows me to question my own motives in “re-membering” (as in the opposite of “dismembering”) the past.

How well does this strategy work for Murphy in her final paragraph? Explain.

2. In the story, is Connie’s mother a hero, or is she someone whose actions are ethically questionable, even wrong? Explain.
3. Assuming that the events in the convenience store actually took place, what motivates Connie’s mother’s actions? If you had been Connie’s mother, what would you have done in her situation?

Classroom Activity Using Effective Sentences

Repetition can be an effective writing device to emphasize important points and to enhance coherence. Unless it is handled correctly, however, it can often result in a tedious piece of writing. Rewrite the following paragraph, either eliminating repetition or reworking the repetitions to improve coherence and to emphasize important information.

Daycare centers should be available to all women who work and have no one to care for their children. Daycare centers should not be available only to women who are raising their children alone or to families whose income is below the poverty line. All women who work should have available to them care for their children that is reliable, responsible, convenient, and does not cost an exorbitant amount. Women who work need and must demand more daycare centers. No woman should be prevented from working because of the lack of convenient and reliable mother' s child care.

Suggested Writing Assignments

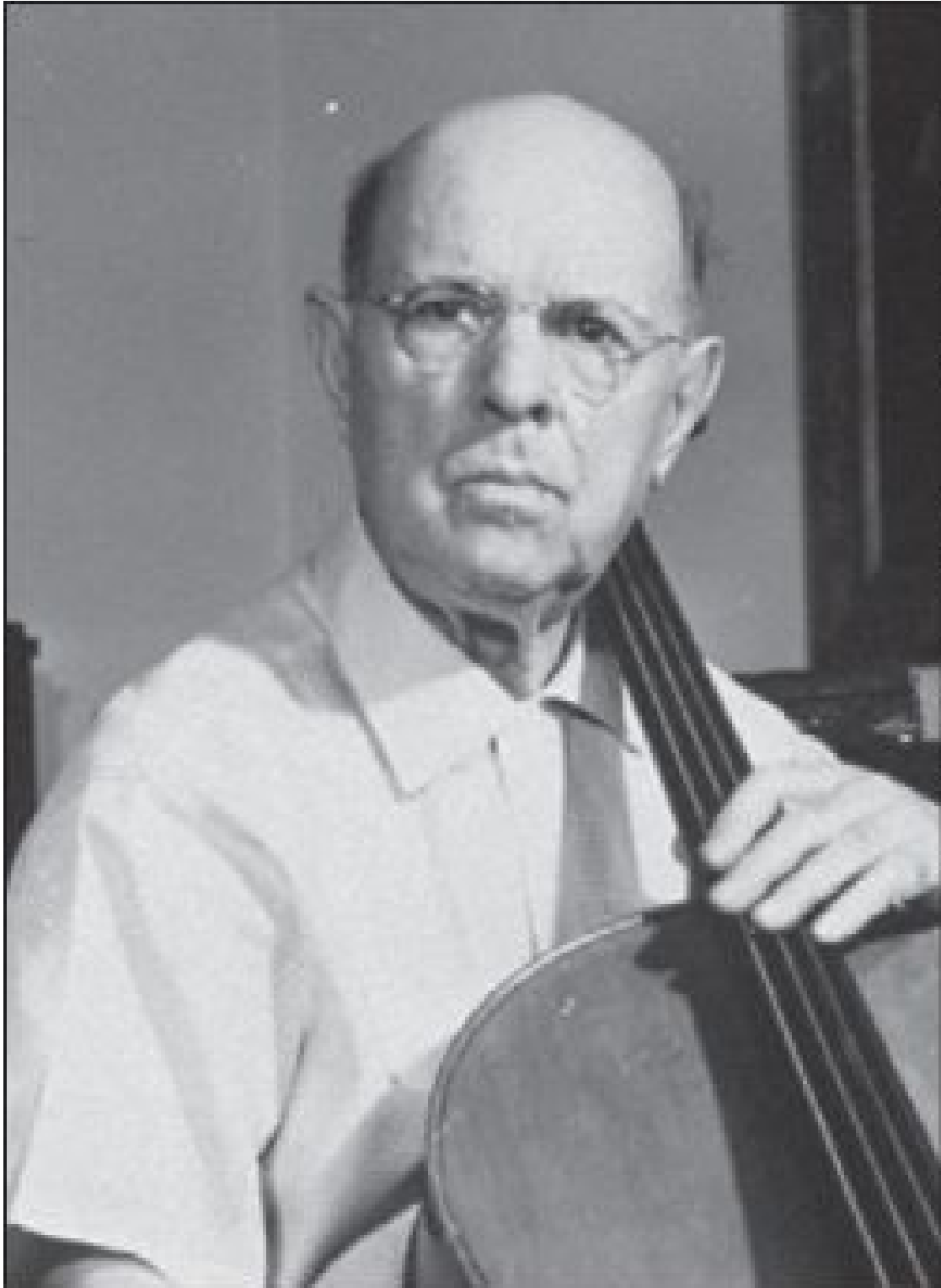
1. Retell the story of "White Lies" from either Connie' s or her mother' s point of view or tell of a similar situation drawn from your own experiences as a schoolchild. Where does your story begin? What information do you need to tell it? What information might you have to supply by using the "perhapsing"

strategy Murphy employs at the end of her essay? Murphy's theme is one of prejudice and marginalization, so if you are telling a story from your childhood you might want to base your narrative on a similar situation when you felt isolated and powerless or perhaps one in which you witnessed or were responsible for someone else feeling like an outsider. Make sure to vary your sentences, using short and long sentences; periodic and loose sentences; and, where appropriate, subordination, coordination, and parallelism.

2. Write a brief essay in which you tell of a time one or both of your parents came to your rescue when you thought yourself to be in a tight spot. Did they intervene in answer to your request for help, or did they simply see that you were in need? Were you thankful for your parents' help, or did their involvement make the situation worse? How did the "rescue" work out? Make sure to vary your sentences, using short and long sentences; periodic and loose sentences; and where appropriate, subordination, coordination, and parallelism.

San Salvador

Pablo Casals



Ellot Elisofo/The LIFE Picture Collection/Getty Images

Born in Catalonia, Spain, Pablo Casals (1876 – 1973) is widely regarded as one of the greatest cellists of all time. He was

also a prolific orchestra conductor, a role that afforded him the opportunity to travel throughout Europe and the Americas and to influence the music scene in many countries. He is best known for his performance of the work of Johann Sebastian Bach. In both practice and performance, and as both a musician and a conductor, Casals valued feeling and expression over rules and structure. In 1963 he received the Presidential Medal of Freedom from John F. Kennedy. Later, he dictated much of his life story to journalist Albert E. Kahn; this material was published in 1970 as his memoir, *Joys and Sorrows*.

This selection from *Joys and Sorrows* explores Casals' s travels to San Salvador, El Salvador, and his appreciation for the animals that were part of the experience. Casals' s love of animals is illuminated through varying sentence structures within his paragraphs. At the end of this selection, he states, "For me, animals have always been a special part of the wonder of nature — the smallest as well as the largest — with their amazing variety, their beautifully contrived shapes and fascinating habits."

Reflecting on What You Know

Do you have any particularly vivid memories involving animals — either pets or wild animals? If so, how has that memory shaped your feelings about animals in general?

When living abroad, I had always longed for my summer vacations at San Salvador. But after my return to Catalonia¹ the house there really became my home. Though I still spent many weeks each year on tour and much time in Barcelona with my orchestra, I not only passed the summers at San Salvador but visited it whenever I could. And what a joy it was to be there, with my mother and Luis and his family, and the beauty of the sea at my door!

As a boy, I had loved to ride horseback. Now I had a horse of my own. His name was Florian. He was a magnificent animal — an Andalusian Arab, large, jet-black, with excellent gaits.² In the early mornings I would ride him along the beach, galloping to the music of the wind and the surf. We had a splendid comradeship. It was about two hundred yards from the house to his stable, but the moment I came out of the house in the early morning he would hear me and whinny in excitement. I had him from a colt, and he lived to be twenty-four years old.

The other animals on our farm — geese, ducks, cows, burros, doves — were also a constant source of delight to me. Different personalities, all of them. There was one small burro³ of whom I was especially fond. He was so gentle, so friendly and intelligent — those who call burros stupid simply do not know these animals. I used to bring this burro into the house to bid good-morning to my young nieces and

nephews. I think he relished this ceremony no less than the children did!

I had canaries too — eight of them in separate cages along the hallway leading to the small music room containing the piano that had belonged to my father. Each dawn when I had arisen and was about to commence the day by playing Bach at my father's piano, I would be greeted by their song. They would start singing the moment they heard my footsteps on the stairs, and they would continue their chorus while I played. Sometimes it seemed to me that I was their accompanist.

Alas, not all the memories of my animal friends at San Salvador are such happy ones. I had a dog, a German shepherd named Follet, who was like my shadow. He slept outside, but he knew my schedule to the minute, and when I left the house for my morning ride, he would be waiting for me on the doorstep. Then a terrible thing happened. One morning I opened the door, and there lay Follet in a pool of blood. He was dead. A trail of blood led all the way from his body to the front gate. During the night somebody had tried to force the gate open, and when Follet had apparently tried to guard it, the prowler had stabbed him, wounding him horribly. He had crawled from the gate to the front door, and there he had waited for me to the end. Such was the faithfulness of my friend.

There are, I know, people who do not love animals, but I think this is because they do not understand them — or because, indeed, they do not really see them. For me, animals have always been a special part of the wonder of nature — the smallest as well as the largest — with their amazing variety, their beautifully contrived shapes and fascinating habits. And I am captivated by the spirit of them. I find in them a longing to communicate and a real capacity for love. If sometimes they do not trust but fear man, it is because he has treated them with arrogance and insensitivity.

¹*Catalonia*: region in northeast Spain. Its capital is Barcelona.

²*gaits*: the ways in which a horse moves, such as a walk, trot, canter, or gallop.

³*burro*: donkey.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Contrast the memory Casals has of his horse, Florian, in [paragraph 2](#) and the memory he has of his dog, Follet, in [paragraph 5](#). Then compare how Casals perceives the two pets feel about him. (Glossary: [Comparison and Contrast](#))
2. Casals' s sentences often employ subordination. (Glossary: [Subordination](#)) For example, in [paragraph 4](#), he states, “I had canaries too — eight of them in separate cages along the hallway leading to the

small music room containing the piano that belonged to my father.” Which part of this sentence is emphasized? How does the subordination in this sentence reinforce Casals’ s attitude toward animals in this selection? (Glossary: [Attitude](#))

3. Most of the sentences in this essay are written in the active voice, emphasizing the doer. However, there is a dramatically short sentence in [paragraph 5](#) that reveals what happened to Follet, which deliberately hides the doer. Identify that sentence. What is its function in the paragraph?
4. Casals says that some people do not love animals because “they do not understand them — or because, indeed, they do not really see them” (6). What does he mean by this?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. The journalist Albert E. Khan collaborated with Casals on the creation of this memoir. This may be the reason why some sentences in this selection seem musical in rhythm, variety, or structure, while other sentences seem journalistic in style. Identify one “musical” sentence and one “journalistic” sentence in the selection. What are the characteristics of each type of sentence?

2. The title of Casals' s memoir is *Joys and Sorrows*. Do you feel that this selection is balanced in its focus on joys and sorrows? Why or why not?
3. What biases does Casals reveal in this piece? What can we infer about his personality? Support your answer with specific examples from the reading.

Classroom Activity Using Effective Sentences

Select a favorite sentence of Casals' s to read aloud. In a small group with two or three classmates, read your sentence aloud without commenting on it. Then each of your group members will take turns reading their own sentences aloud. With your group, discuss how it felt to hear Casals' s sentences spoken out of the context of his essay. What was the effect of hearing them read aloud? Did anyone else in your group choose to read the same sentence as you? If so, why do you think you both chose that particular sentence?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Just as Casals collaborated with Albert E. Khan to create his memoir *Joys and Sorrows*, collaborate with a classmate to come up with a thesis statement about

animals. (Glossary: [Thesis](#)) It might take a while to come up with a thesis on which you can both agree. One example might be: “Animals often make travel more enjoyable.” Another example might be: “It is unethical to domesticate certain animals.” Then, write separate essays using the same thesis statement and whatever examples you come up with individually. (Glossary: [Example](#)) When you are done, share your essay with your partner and discuss how the essays are similar and different. In particular, pay attention to similarities and differences in sentence structure. For example, does one of the essays use more subordination or coordination, or does it use longer or shorter sentences than the other?

2. In this selection, Casals writes about San Salvador, but instead of talking about everything that he experienced there, he focuses his paragraphs by revealing different experiences with animals. Think about a place of importance to you. Then, write an essay about that place that focuses on one specific aspect of your experience in that place. (Glossary: [Focus](#)) For example, you might write about your birthday dinners at a favorite restaurant over the years but focus on the food. Alternatively, you could write paragraphs about the people that were there each time, or about the environment of the restaurant. When you revise your essay, make sure that you have included varied, descriptive sentences

that give your reader a vivid sense of the specific aspect on which you are focusing.

Salvation

Langston Hughes



Corbis Historical/Getty Images

Born in Joplin, Missouri, Langston Hughes (1902 – 1967) became an important figure in the African American cultural movement of the 1920s known as the Harlem Renaissance. He wrote poetry, fiction, and plays, and he contributed columns to the *New York Post* and an African American weekly, the *Chicago Defender*. He is best known for *The Weary Blues* (1926) and other books of poetry that express his racial pride, his familiarity with African American traditions, and his understanding of blues and jazz rhythms. In his memory, New York City designated his residence at 20 East 127th Street in Harlem as a landmark, and his street was renamed Langston Hughes Place.

In the following selection from his autobiography, *The Big Sea* (1940), notice how, for the sake of emphasis, Hughes varies the length and types of sentences he uses. The effect of the dramatically short sentence in [paragraph 12](#), for instance, derives from the variety of sentences preceding it.

Reflecting on What You Know

What role does religion play in your family? Do you consider yourself a religious person? Have you ever felt pressure from others to participate in religious activities? How did that make you feel?

I was saved from sin when I was going on thirteen. But not really saved. It happened like this. There was a big revival

at my Auntie Reed' s church. Every night for weeks there had been much preaching, singing, praying, and shouting, and some very hardened sinners had been brought to Christ, and the membership of the church had grown by leaps and bounds. Then just before the revival ended, they held a special meeting for children, "to bring the young lambs to the fold." My aunt spoke of it for days ahead. That night I was escorted to the front row and placed on the mourners' bench with all the other young sinners, who had not yet been brought to Jesus.

My aunt told me that when you were saved you saw a light, and something happened to you inside! And Jesus came into your life! And God was with you from then on! She said you could see and hear and feel Jesus in your soul. I believed her. I had heard a great many old people say the same thing and it seemed to me they ought to know. So I sat there calmly in the hot, crowded church, waiting for Jesus to come to me.

The preacher preached a wonderful rhythmical sermon, all moans and shouts and lonely cries and dire pictures of hell, and then he sang a song about the ninety and nine safe in the fold, but one little lamb was left out in the cold. Then he said: "Won' t you come? Won' t you come to Jesus? Young lambs, won' t you come?" And he held out his arms to all us young sinners there on the mourners' bench. And the little girls cried. And some of them jumped up and went to Jesus right away. But most of us just sat there.

A great many old people came and knelt around us and prayed, old women with jet-black faces and braided hair, old men with work-gnarled hands. And the church sang a song about the lower lights are burning, some poor sinners to be saved. And the whole building rocked with prayer and song.

Still I kept waiting to *see* Jesus.

Finally all the young people had gone to the altar and were saved, but one boy and me. He was a rounder's son named Westley. Westley and I were surrounded by sisters and deacons praying. It was very hot in the church, and getting late now. Finally Westley said to me in a whisper: "God damn! I'm tired o' sitting here. Let's get up and be saved." So he got up and was saved.

Then I was left all alone on the mourners' bench. My aunt came and knelt at my knees and cried, while prayers and songs swirled all around me in the little church. The whole congregation prayed for me alone, in a mighty wail of moans and voices. And I kept waiting serenely for Jesus, waiting, waiting — but he didn't come. I wanted to see him, but nothing happened to me. Nothing! I wanted something to happen to me, but nothing happened.

I heard the songs and the minister saying: "Why don't you come? My dear child, why don't you come to Jesus? Jesus is

waiting for you. He wants you. Why don' t you come? Sister Reed, what is this child' s name?"

"Langston," my aunt sobbed.

"Langston, why don' t you come? Why don' t you come and be saved? Oh, Lamb of God! Why don' t you come?"

Now it was really getting late. I began to be ashamed of myself, holding everything up so long. I began to wonder what God thought about Westley, who certainly hadn' t seen Jesus either, but who was now sitting proudly on the platform, swinging his knickerbockered legs and grinning down at me, surrounded by deacons and old women on their knees praying. God had not struck Westley dead for taking his name in vain or for lying in the temple. So I decided that maybe to save further trouble, I' d better lie, too, and say that Jesus had come, and get up and be saved.

So I got up.

Suddenly the whole room broke into a sea of shouting, as they saw me rise. Waves of rejoicing swept the place. Women leaped in the air. My aunt threw her arms around me. The minister took me by the hand and led me to the platform.

When things quieted down, in a hushed silence, punctuated by a few ecstatic “Amen,” all the new young lambs were blessed in the name of God. Then joyous singing filled the room.

That night, for the last time in my life but one — for I was a big boy twelve years old — I cried. I cried, in bed alone, and couldn’ t stop. I buried my head under the quilts, but my aunt heard me. She woke up and told my uncle I was crying because the Holy Ghost had come into my life, and because I had seen Jesus. But I was really crying because I couldn’ t bear to tell her that I had lied, that I had deceived everybody in the church, that I hadn’ t seen Jesus, and that now I didn’ t believe there was a Jesus any more, since he didn’ t come to help me.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is salvation? Is it important to young Hughes that he be saved? Why does he expect to be saved at the revival meeting?
2. Hughes varies the length and structure of his sentences throughout the essay. How does this variety capture and reinforce the rhythms and drama of the evening’ s events? Explain.
3. What would be gained or lost if the essay began with the first two sentences combined as follows: “I was

saved from sin when I was going on thirteen, but I was not really saved” ?

4. Identify the subordinating conjunctions in [paragraph 15](#). (Glossary: [Subordination](#)) What is it about the ideas in this last paragraph that makes it necessary for Hughes to use subordinating conjunctions?
5. How does Hughes’ s choice of words, or diction, help establish a realistic atmosphere for a religious revival meeting? (Glossary: [Diction](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Why does Hughes cry on the night of his being “saved” ? What makes the story of his being saved so ironic? (Glossary: [Irony](#))
2. Identify the coordinating conjunctions in [paragraph 3](#). (Glossary: [Coordination](#)) Rewrite the paragraph without them. Compare your paragraph with the original, and explain what Hughes gains by using coordinating conjunctions.
3. In what ways is Westley’ s role important in Hughes’ s narrative?

Classroom Activity Using Effective Sentences

Using coordination or subordination, rewrite each set of short sentences as a single sentence. Here is an example:

ORIGINAL: This snow is good for Colorado' s economy. Tourists
 are now flocking to ski resorts.

REVISED: This snow is good for Colorado' s economy because
 tourists are now flocking to ski resorts.

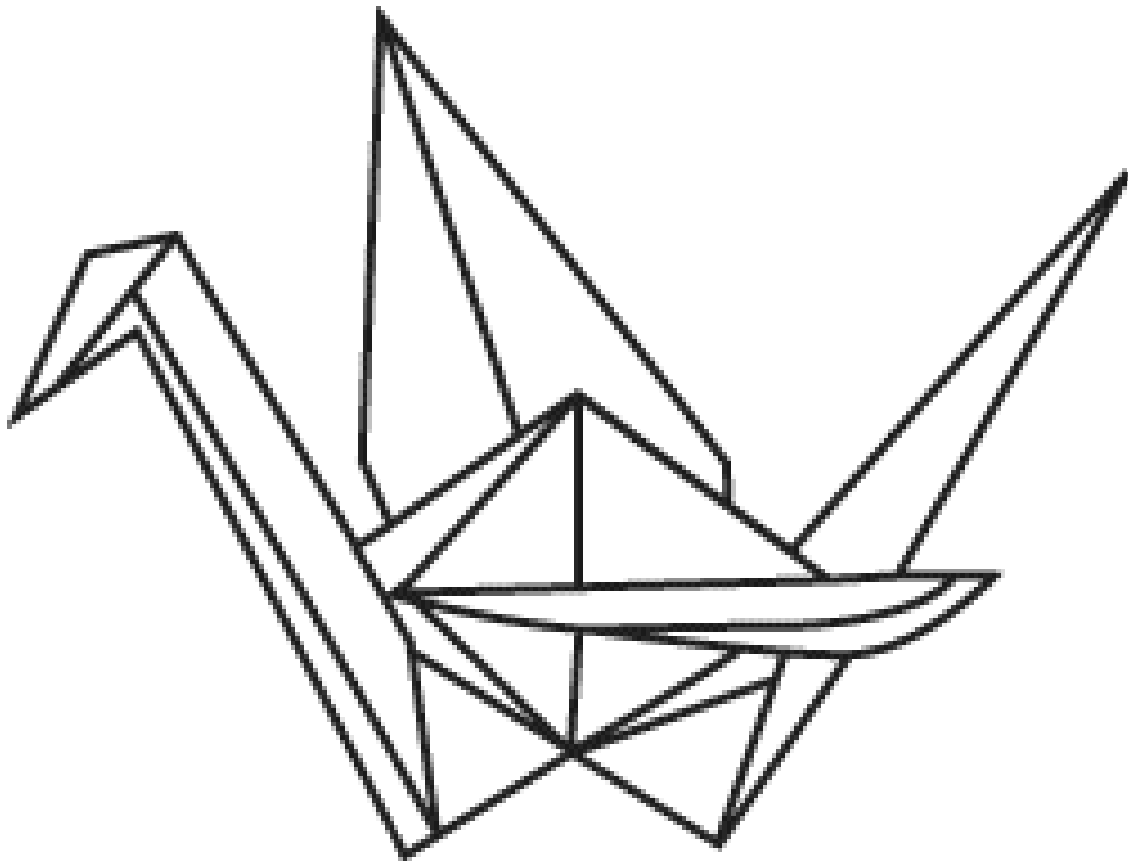
1. I can take the 6:30 express train. I can catch the 7:00 bus.
2. Miriam worked on her research paper. She interviewed five people for the paper. She worked all weekend. She was tired.
3. Juan' s new job kept him busy every day. He did not have time to work out at the gym for over a month.
4. The Statue of Liberty welcomes newcomers to the United States. It was a gift of the French government. It was completely restored for the nation' s two hundredth birthday. It is more than 120 years old.
5. Carla is tall. She is strong. She is a team player. She is the starting center on the basketball team.
6. Betsy loves Bach' s music. She also likes Scott Joplin.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Like the young Hughes, we sometimes find ourselves in situations in which, for the sake of conformity, we do things we do not believe in. Consider one such experience you have had, and write an essay about it. What in human nature makes us occasionally act in ways that contradict our inner feelings? As you write, pay attention to your sentence variety.
2. At the end of his essay, Langston Hughes suffers alone. He cannot bring himself to talk about his dilemma with his aunt or uncle or other people in the church. Have you ever found yourself in a predicament with no one to turn to for advice or help? Why can it be so difficult for us to seek the help of others? Write an essay in which you explore answers to this question. Consider examples from your own experience and what you have seen and read about other people. Look for opportunities where your sentence variety can enhance the interest and drama of your essay.



CHAPTER 10 Writing with Sources



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Some of the writing you do in college will be based on your personal experiences, but many of your college assignments will ask you to do some research — to write with sources. Although most of us can do basic research — locate and evaluate print and online sources, take notes from those sources, and document those sources — we have not necessarily learned how to integrate these sources effectively and purposefully into our essays. (For more information on basic research and documentation practices, see [Chapter 23](#).) Your purpose in writing with sources is not

to present quotations that report what others have said about your topic. Your goal is to take ownership of your topic by analyzing, evaluating, and synthesizing the materials you have researched. By learning how to view the results of research from your own perspective, you can arrive at an informed opinion of your topic. In short, you become a participant in a conversation with your sources about your topic.

To help you on your way, this chapter provides advice on the following:

1. Using outside sources in your writing ([p. 223](#))
2. Summarizing, paraphrasing, and quoting sources ([p. 226](#))
3. Integrating summaries, paraphrases, and direct quotations into the text of your essay using signal phrases ([p. 230](#))
4. Synthesizing sources ([p. 232](#))
5. Avoiding plagiarism when writing with sources ([p. 235](#))

In addition, one student essay and two professional essays model different ways of engaging meaningfully with outside sources and of reflecting that engagement in writing.

USE OUTSIDE SOURCES IN YOUR WRITING

Each time you introduce an outside source into your essay, be sure that you are using that source in a purposeful way.

Outside sources can be used to

- support your thesis,
- support your points with statements from noted authorities,
- offer memorable wording of key terms or ideas,
- extend your ideas by introducing new information, and
- articulate opposing positions for you to argue against.

Consider Pamela Paul's use of an outside source in the following passage from her essay "Let Children Get Bored Again," published in *The New York Times* on February 22, 2019.

If someone around here is bored, someone else must have failed to enlighten or enrich or divert. And how can anyone — child or adult — claim boredom when there's so much that can and should be done? Immediately.

But boredom is something to experience rather than hastily swipe away. And not as some kind of cruel Victorian conditioning, recommended because it's awful and toughens you

up. Despite the lesson most adults learned growing up — boredom is for boring people — boredom is useful. It's good for you.

If kids don't figure this out early on, they're in for a nasty surprise. School, let's face it, can be dull, and it isn't actually the teacher's job to entertain as well as educate. Life isn't meant to be an endless parade of amusements. "That's right," a mother says to her daughter in Maria Semple's 2012 novel, *Where'd You Go Bernadette*. "You are bored. And I'm going to let you in on a little secret about life. You think it's boring now? Well, it only gets more boring. The sooner you learn it's on you to make life interesting, the better off you'll be."

Here Paul uses a piece of dialogue from Maria Semple's novel to support her point that boredom is a necessary part of life because it spawns creativity and builds self-sufficiency.

The following passage comes from "Nature in the Suburbs," an essay that first appeared in *A Guide to Smart Growth: Shattering Myths, Providing Solutions*. The essay was adapted and published separately by the Heritage Foundation in 2004. Here environmentalist Jane S. Shaw uses several sources to substantiate her belief that "there is no reason to be pessimistic about the ability of wildlife to survive and thrive in the suburbs."

This new ecology is different, but it is often friendly to animals, especially those that University of Florida biologist

Larry Harris calls “meso-mammals,” or mammals of medium size. They do not need broad territory for roaming to find food, as moose and grizzly bears do. They can find places in the suburbs to feed, nest, and thrive, especially where gardens flourish.

One example of the positive impact of growth is the rebound of the endangered Key deer, a small white-tailed deer found only in Florida and named for the Florida Keys. According to *Audubon* magazine, the Key deer is experiencing a “remarkable recovery.” The news report continues: “Paradoxically, part of the reason for the deer’s comeback may lie in the increasing development of the area.” Paraphrasing the remarks of a university researcher, the reporter says that human development “tends to open up overgrown forested areas and provide vegetation at deer level — the same factors fueling deer population booms in suburbs all over the country.”

Note that in the last sentence of the second paragraph, Shaw is careful to say that she is quoting the *Audubon* reporter’s paraphrase of a university researcher’s thoughts and not the reporter’s.

Sometimes source material is too long and detailed to be quoted directly in its entirety. In such cases, a writer will choose to summarize or paraphrase the material in his or her own words before introducing it in an essay. For example, notice how Scott Barry Kaufman, PhD, summarizes a lengthy creative-achievement study for use in his essay “Dreams of Glory,” which appeared in the March 2014 issue of *Psychology Today*.

In one of the longest and most comprehensive studies of creative achievement ever conducted, psychologist E. Paul Torrance followed a group of elementary school children for more than 30 years. He collected a wide variety of indicators of creative and scholastic promise. Strikingly, he found that the best predictor of lifelong personal and publicly recognized creative achievement ... was the extent to which children had a clear future-focused image of themselves.

Here Kaufman introduces his summary by citing Torrance's name and giving his professional credentials (research psychologist). After briefly identifying the subjects and the length of the study as well as the data collected, Kaufman concludes with a pointed statement of Torrance's conclusion.

Finally, in the following passage from *The Way We Really Are: Coming to Terms with America's Changing Families* (1998), Stephanie Coontz uses outside sources to present the position that she will argue against.

The fallback position for those in denial about the socioeconomic transformation we are experiencing is to admit that many families are in economic stress but to blame their plight on divorce and unwed motherhood. Lawrence Mead of New York University argues that economic inequalities stemming from differences in wages and employment patterns "are now trivial in comparison to those stemming from family structure." David Blankenhorn claims that the "primary fault line" dividing privileged and nonprivileged Americans is no longer "race, religion, class, education, or gender" but family structure. Every major newspaper in the country has published editorials

and opinion pieces along these lines. This “new consensus” produces a delightfully simple, inexpensive solution to the economic ills of America’s families. From Republican Dan Quayle to the Democratic Party’s Progressive Policy Institute, we hear the same words: “Marriage is the best anti-poverty program for children.”

Now I am as horrified as anyone by irresponsible parents who yield to the temptations of our winner-take-all society and abandon their family obligations. But we are kidding ourselves if we think the solution to the economic difficulties of America’s children lies in getting their parents back together. Single-parent families, it is true, are five to six times more likely to be poor than two-parent ones. But correlations are not the same as causes. The association between poverty and single parenthood has several different sources, suggesting that the battle to end child poverty needs to be fought on a number of different fronts.

By letting the opposition articulate its own position, Coontz reduces the possibility of being criticized for misrepresenting her opponents while setting herself up to give strong voice to her thesis.

LEARN TO SUMMARIZE, PARAPHRASE, AND QUOTE FROM YOUR SOURCES

When taking notes from your print and online sources, you must decide whether to summarize, paraphrase, or quote directly. The approach you take is largely determined by the content of the source passage and the way that you envision using it in your essay. Each technique — summarizing, paraphrasing, and quoting — will help you incorporate source material into your essays. Making use of all three of these techniques rather than relying on only one or two will keep your text varied and interesting.

Summary

When you **summarize** material from one of your sources, you capture in condensed form the essential idea of a passage, an article, or an entire chapter. Summaries are particularly useful when you are working with lengthy, detailed arguments or long passages of narrative or descriptive background information in which the details are not germane to the overall thrust of your essay. You simply want to capture the essence of the passage because you are confident that your

readers will readily understand the point being made or do not need to be convinced of its validity. Because you are distilling information, a summary is always shorter than the original; often a chapter or more can be reduced to a paragraph, or several paragraphs to a sentence or two. Remember, in writing a summary you should use your own words.

Consider the following paragraphs, in which Richard Lederer compares big words with small words in some detail:

When you speak and write, there is no law that says you have to use big words. Short words are as good as long ones, and short, old words — like *sun* and *grass* and *home* — are best of all. A lot of small words, more than you might think, can meet your needs with a strength, grace, and charm that large words do not have.

Big words can make the way dark for those who read what you write and hear what you say. Small words cast their clear light on big things — night and day, love and hate, war and peace, and life and death. Big words at times seem strange to the eye and the ear and the mind and the heart. Small words are the ones we seem to have known from the time we were born, like the hearth fire that warms the home.

— Richard Lederer, [“The Case for Short Words,”](#) pp. 195 – 96

A student wishing to capture the gist of Lederer’s point without repeating his detailed contrast created the accompanying summary note.

Summary Note

Short Words

Lederer favors short words for their clarity, familiarity, durability, and overall usefulness.

— Richard Lederer, [“The Case for Short Words,”](#) 195 - 96

✓ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Summarizing

Paraphrase

When you **paraphrase** material from a source, you restate the information in your own words instead of quoting directly. Unlike a summary, which gives a brief overview of the essential information in the original, a paraphrase seeks to maintain the same level of detail as the original, to aid readers in understanding or believing the information presented. Your paraphrase should closely parallel the presentation of ideas in the original, but it should not use the same words or sentence structure as the original. Even though you are using your own words in a paraphrase, it's important to remember that you are borrowing ideas and therefore must acknowledge the source of these ideas with a citation.

How would you paraphrase the following passage from “The Ways of Meeting Oppression” by Martin Luther King Jr.?

If the American Negro and other victims of oppression succumb to the temptation of using violence in the struggle for freedom, future generations will be the recipients of a desolate night of bitterness, and our chief legacy to them will be an endless reign of meaningless chaos. Violence is not the way.

— Martin Luther King Jr., [“The Ways of Meeting Oppression,”](#)
p. 449

Paraphrase Note

Nonviolence

African Americans and other oppressed peoples must not resort to taking up arms against their oppressors because to do so would lead the country into an era of turmoil and confusion. Confrontation will not yield the desired results.

— Martin Luther King Jr., [“The Ways of Meeting Oppression,”](#) 445

In most cases, it is best to summarize or paraphrase material — which by definition means using your own words — instead of quoting verbatim (word for word). Capturing an idea in your own words demonstrates that you have thought about and understood what your source is saying.

Direct Quotation

With a direct quotation, you copy the words of your source exactly, putting all quoted material in quotation marks. When you make a direct quotation note, check the passage carefully for accuracy, including punctuation and capitalization. Be selective about what you choose to quote. Reserve direct quotation for important ideas stated memorably, for especially clear explanations by authorities, and for arguments by proponents of a particular position in their own words.

Consider the accompanying direct quotation note. It quotes several sentences from Julie Zhuo's ["Where Anonymity Breeds Contempt"](#) (p. 85), arguing that anonymity encourages uncivil, trollish comments.

Direct Quotation Note

Effects of Anonymous Comments

"Psychological research has proven again and again that anonymity increases unethical behavior. Road rage bubbles up in the relative anonymity of one's car. And in the online world, which can offer total anonymity, the effect is even more pronounced... There's even a term for it: the online disinhibition effect."

— Julie Zhuo, ["Where Anonymity Breeds Contempt,"](#) 85

On occasion you’ ll find a long, useful passage with some memorable wording in it. Avoid the temptation to quote the whole passage; instead, try combining summary or paraphrase with direct quotation. Consider the following paragraph from Mary Sherry’ s “In Praise of the F Word” :

Passing students who have not mastered the work cheats them and their employers who expect graduates to have basic skills. We excuse this dishonest behavior by saying kids can’ t learn if they come from terrible environments. No one seems to stop to think that — no matter what environments they come from — most kids don’ t put school first on their list unless they perceive something is at stake. They’ d rather be sailing.

— Mary Sherry, [“In Praise of the F Word,”](#) p. 542

In the accompanying quotation and paraphrase note, notice how the student is careful to put quotation marks around all words borrowed directly.

Quotation and Paraphrase Note

Passing Not the Answer

Students and prospective employers are often deceived when students are passed through the school system, even if their work doesn’ t merit passing. The public “excuse[s] this dishonest behavior by saying kids can’ t learn if they come from terrible environments.” But has anyone ever questioned the fact that “most kids,” in spite of environment, “don’ t put school first on their

list unless they perceive something is at stake”? Without an incentive, students will choose most anything over school.

— Mary Sherry, [“In Praise of the F Word,”](#) 538

If you are taking notes on the computer instead of by hand, you must be especially careful. You will need to avoid the temptation to simply copy and paste in an unorganized fashion from online sources, a practice that will likely lead to unintentional plagiarism (see [pp. 235 – 239](#)). Make sure you identify all summaries, paraphrases, and direct quotations appropriately and carefully distinguish them from your own ideas as you take notes and annotate sources. Keep track of the sources you are working with for each of your notes. It is important to stay organized and be methodical when it comes to note taking.

INTEGRATE BORROWED MATERIAL INTO YOUR TEXT

Whenever you want to use borrowed material (such as a summary, a paraphrase, or a direct quotation), your goal is to integrate these sources smoothly and logically and not disrupt the flow of your essay or confuse your readers. It is best to introduce borrowed material with a **signal phrase**, which alerts readers that borrowed information is about to be presented.

A signal phrase consists of at least the author's name and a verb (such as "Stephen King contends"). Signal phrases help readers follow your train of thought. When you integrate a summary, paraphrase, or quotation into your essay, vary your signal phrases and choose verbs for the signal phrases that accurately convey the tone and intent of the writer you are citing. A signal phrase also offers an opportunity to introduce the writer's bias, perspective, or expertise on the issue. (See [pp. 54 – 55](#) and [pp. 597 – 598](#) for more on bias.) If a writer is arguing, use the verb *argues* (or *asserts*, *claims*, or *contends*); if a writer is contesting a particular position or fact, use the verb *contests* (or *denies*, *disputes*, *refutes*, or *rejects*). Verbs that are specific to the situation in your essay will bring your

readers into the intellectual debate (and avoid the monotony of all-purpose verbs like *says* or *writes*). The following examples show how you can vary signal phrases to add precision to your essay:

To summarize Amy Tan’s observations about the English language, ...

Social activist and nutrition guru Dick Gregory demonstrates that ...

Mary Sherry, a literacy teacher and educational writer, advocates ...

Brené Brown rejects the belief that “shame” ...

Bharati Mukherjee, an immigrant who chose to embrace United States citizenship, exposes ...

Additional Signal Phrase Verbs			
acknowledges	compares	grants	reasons
adds	confirms	implies	reports
admits	declares	insists	responds
believes	endorses	points out	suggests

Well-chosen signal phrases help you integrate summaries, paraphrases, and quotations into the flow of your essay. Besides, signal phrases let your reader know who is speaking and, in the case of summaries and paraphrases, exactly where your ideas end and someone else's begin. Never confuse your reader with a quotation that appears suddenly, with no introduction. Unannounced quotations leave your reader wondering how the quoted material relates to the point you are trying to make. Look at the following student example. The quotation is from Nancy Gibbs's "The Magic of the Family Meal," an essay that appeared in *Time* magazine on June 4, 2006.

Unannounced Quotation

Older Americans love to reminisce about the value of family dinners that they enjoyed during their childhoods, the ones that Norman Rockwell immortalized in his cover illustrations for the *Saturday Evening Post*. These dinners were times when family members caught up with one another, exchanged ideas, got to know each other. It was there at the dining table that children learned their family's values, history, and culture. But family dinners gradually became less frequent as parents got caught up in careers and children became involved in more and more activities. As more people caught meals on the run, some began to realize that something was now missing. Not surprisingly, family dinners are now back in the news. "[T]he more often families eat together, the less likely kids are to smoke, drink, do drugs, get depressed, develop eating disorders, and consider suicide, and the more likely they are

to do well in school, delay having sex, eat their vegetables, learn big words, and know which fork to use” (Gibbs). When was the last time you ate dinner with your family?

In the following revision, the student integrates the quotation into the text by means of a signal phrase, in which she gives the writer’s name and position, as well as a brief description of the article in which the quotation appeared. The student provides this context so that the reader can better understand how the quotation fits into the discussion.

Announced Quotation

Older Americans love to reminisce about the value of family dinners that they enjoyed during their childhoods, the ones that Norman Rockwell immortalized in his cover illustrations for the *Saturday Evening Post*. These dinners were times when family members caught up with one another, exchanged ideas, got to know each other. It was there at the dining table that children learned their family’s values, history, and culture. But family dinners gradually became less frequent as parents got caught up in careers and children became involved in more and more activities. As more people caught meals on the run, some began to realize that something was now missing. Not surprisingly, family dinners are now back in the news. *Time* magazine editor Nancy Gibbs, in her report on the resurgence in family dining, emphasizes that “the more often families eat together, the less likely kids are to smoke, drink, do drugs, get depressed, develop eating disorders, and consider suicide, and the more likely they are to do well in school, delay having sex, eat their vegetables, learn big words, and know which fork

to use.” When was the last time you ate dinner with your family?

SYNTHESIZE SEVERAL SOURCES TO DEEPEN YOUR DISCUSSION

Synthesis enables you to weave together your own ideas with the ideas of others — the sources you have researched for your essay — in the same paragraph, so as to deepen your discussion or to arrive at a new interpretation or conclusion. By learning how to synthesize the results of your research from your own perspective, you can arrive at an informed opinion of your topic.

When you synthesize several sources in your writing, you create a conversation among your sources in which you take an active role. Sometimes you will find yourself discussing two or three sources together to show a range of views regarding a particular topic or issue — this is called *informational* or *explanatory synthesis*. At other times you will have opportunities to play your sources against one another so as to delineate the opposing positions — this is called *persuasive* or *argument synthesis*.

In the following example from her essay “The Qualities of Good Teachers,” student Marah Britto uses informational synthesis to combine her own thoughts about good teachers with the thoughts of three other writers whose essays appear

in *Models for Writers* (parenthetical citations refer to pages in this text). In doing so, she explains the range of attributes that distinguish good teachers from their peers.

We have all experienced a teacher who in some way stands out from all the others we have had, a teacher who has made an important difference in each of our lives. While most of us can agree on some of the character traits — dedication, love for students, patience, passion for his/her subject — that such teachers have in common, we cannot agree on that special something that sets them apart, that distinguishes them from the crowd. For me, it was my sixth-grade teacher Mrs. Engstrom, a teacher who motivated with her example. She never asked me to do anything that she was not willing to do herself. How many teachers show their love of ornithology by taking a student out for a bird walk at 5:30 in the morning, on a school day no less? For Thomas L. Friedman, it was his high school journalism teacher, Hattie M. Steinberg. In “My Favorite Teacher,” he relates how her insistence upon the importance of

“fundamentals” (94) made a lifelong impression on him, so much so that he never had to take another journalism course. For Mary Sherry, it was her son’s high school English teacher Mrs. Stifter who made a difference. During his senior year she played “the trump card of failure” (537) on him, which encouraged the son to perform better academically. And for Helen Keller, it was her loving and dedicated teacher Anne Mansfield Sullivan who would “reveal all things to me” (100). After many attempts to make the connection between objects and words spelled out on Keller’s hand, Sullivan made the breakthrough. Keller remembers, “the mystery of language was revealed to me. I knew then that ‘w-a-t-e-r’ meant the wonderful cool something that was flowing on my hand” (101).

Interestingly, isn't it mutual respect and appreciation that is at the heart of any memorable student-teacher bond?

This second example is taken from student Bonnie Sherman's essay "Should Shame Be Used as Punishment?" Here she uses argument synthesis deftly to combine Hawthorne's use of shame in *The Scarlet Letter* with two opposing essays about shame as punishment, both of which appear in this text. Notice how Sherman uses her own reading of *The Scarlet Letter* as evidence to side ultimately with Professor Kahan's position.

Shame has long been used as an alternative punishment to more traditional sentences of corporeal punishment, jail time, or community service. American colonists used the stocks to publicly humiliate citizens for their transgressions. In *The Scarlet Letter*, for example, Nathaniel Hawthorne recounts the story of how the community of Boston punished Hester Prynne for her adulterous affair by having her wear a scarlet letter "A" on her breast as a badge of shame. Such punishments were controversial then and continue to spark heated debate in the world of criminal justice today. Social activist Dick Gregory shows just how cruel and personally damaging shaming punishments can be in his narrative "Shame." The fatherless Gregory recounts how one of his elementary school teachers asked her students how much their fathers would give to the Community Chest. When Gregory tried to make a pledge for "his Daddy," his teacher upbraided him in front of the whole class, saying, "we are collecting this money for you and your kind, Richard Gregory" and "we know you don't have a Daddy" (145). The shame he felt that day changed Gregory and his

world. As Brené Brown, research professor at the University of Houston, explains in her essay “What Is Shame?”, “shame is the intensely painful feeling or experience of believing that we are flawed and therefore unworthy of love or belonging” (422). In contrast, Yale Law School professor Dan M. Kahan believes that “critics’ anxieties about shame ... seem overstated,” and he persuasively supports this position in his essay “Shame Is Worth a Try” by citing a study showing that the threat of public humiliation generates more compliance than does the threat of jail time (130).

Instead of simply presenting your sources in a quotation here and a summary there in your essay, look for opportunities to use synthesis — to go beyond an individual source by relating several of your sources to one another and to your own thesis. Use the following checklist to help you with synthesis in your writing.

Checklist for Writing a Synthesis

1. Start by writing a brief summary of each source that you will be referring to in your synthesis.
2. Explain in your own words how your sources are related to one another and to your own ideas. For example, what assumptions do your sources share? Do your sources present opposing views? Do your sources illustrate a range or diversity of opinions? Do your sources support or challenge your ideas?

3. Have a clear idea or topic sentence for each paragraph before starting to write.
4. Combine information from two or more sources with your own ideas to support or illustrate your main idea.
5. Use signal phrases and parenthetical citations to show your readers the source of your borrowed materials.
6. Have fresh interpretations or conclusions as a goal each time you synthesize sources.

AVOID PLAGIARISM

Honesty and accuracy with sources are essential. Any material that you have borrowed word for word must be placed within quotation marks and be properly cited. Any idea, explanation, or argument that you have paraphrased or summarized must be documented, and you must show clearly where the paraphrased or summarized material begins and ends. In short, to use someone else's idea — whether in its original form or in an altered form — without proper acknowledgment is to be guilty of **plagiarism**.

You must acknowledge and document the source of your information whenever you do any of the following:

- Quote a source word for word
- Refer to information and ideas from another source that you present in your own words as either a paraphrase or a summary
- Cite statistics, tables, charts, graphs, or other visuals

You do not need to document the following types of information:

- Your own observations, experiences, ideas, and opinions

- Factual information available in many sources (information known as *common knowledge*)
- Proverbs, sayings, or familiar quotations

For a discussion of MLA style for in-text documentation practices, see [pages 597 – 612](#) of Chapter 23. For a discussion of APA style, see [pages 613 – 623](#) of Chapter 23.

The Council of Writing Program Administrators offers the following helpful definition of *plagiarism* in academic settings for administrators, faculty, and students: “In an instructional setting, plagiarism occurs when a writer deliberately uses someone else’s language, ideas, or other (not common knowledge) material without acknowledging its source.” Accusations of plagiarism can be substantiated even if plagiarism is accidental. A little attention and effort during the note-taking stage can go a long way toward eliminating inadvertent plagiarism. Check all direct quotations against the wording of the original, and double-check your paraphrases to be sure that you have not used the writer’s wording or sentence structure. It is easy to forget to put quotation marks around material taken verbatim or to use the same sentence structure and most of the same words — substituting a synonym here and there — and treat it as a paraphrase. In working closely with the ideas and words of others, intellectual honesty demands that we distinguish

between what we borrow — acknowledging it in a citation — and what is our own.

While writing, be careful whenever you incorporate one of your notes into your paper. Make sure that you put quotation marks around material taken verbatim, and double-check your text against your notes — or, better yet, against the original if you have it on hand — to make sure that your quotation is accurate. When paraphrasing or summarizing, make sure you do not inadvertently borrow key words or sentence structures from the original.

Using Quotation Marks for Language Borrowed Directly

When you use another person's exact words or sentences, you must enclose the borrowed language in quotation marks.

Without quotation marks, you give your reader the impression that the wording is your own. Even if you cite the source, you are guilty of plagiarism if you fail to use quotation marks. The following examples demonstrate both plagiarism and a correct citation for a direct quotation.

Original Source

Minority groups often find their freedom restricted by the imposition of the norms of the dominant culture, and that

restriction has been enough to incite serious political unrest. Members of the minority group want to express themselves and their unique identity freely. Without coercion, it is difficult to repress a group's desire to speak their own language and practice their own religion — to choose how to live their lives in a way that gives them meaning.

— Donna Hicks, [“Independence,”](#) p. 169

Plagiarism

Minority groups often find their freedom restricted by the imposition of the norms of the dominant culture, and that restriction has been enough to incite serious political unrest, writes Donna Hicks, an associate of the Weatherhead Center for International Affairs. She believes that members of the minority group want to express themselves and their unique identity freely. Without coercion, it is difficult to repress a group's desire to speak their own language and practice their own religion — to choose how to live their lives in a way that gives them meaning ([169](#)).

Correct Citation of Borrowed Words in Quotation Marks

“Minority groups often find their freedom restricted by the imposition of the norms of the dominant culture, and that restriction has been enough to incite serious political unrest,” writes Donna Hicks, an associate of the Weatherhead Center for International Affairs. She believes that “[m]embers of the minority group want to express themselves and their unique identity freely. Without coercion, it is difficult to repress a group's desire to speak their own language and

practice their own religion — to choose how to live their lives in a way that gives them meaning” ([169](#)).

Using Your Own Words and Word Order When Summarizing and Paraphrasing

When summarizing or paraphrasing a source, you must use your own language. Pay attention to word choice and word order, especially if you are paraphrasing. Remember that it is not enough simply to use a synonym here or there and think that you have paraphrased the source; you *must* restate the original idea in your own words, using your own style and sentence structure. In the following examples, notice how plagiarism can occur when care is not taken in the wording or sentence structure of a paraphrase. Notice that in the acceptable paraphrase, the student writer uses her own language and sentence structure.

Original Source

Stereotypes are a kind of gossip about the world, a gossip that makes us prejudge people before we ever lay eyes upon them. Hence it is not surprising that stereotypes have something to do with the dark world of prejudice. Explore most prejudices (note that the word means prejudgment) and you will find a cruel stereotype at the core of each one.

— Robert L. Heilbroner, “Don’ t Let Stereotypes Warp Your Judgments,” *Think* magazine, June 1961, p. 43

Unacceptably Close Wording

According to Heilbroner, stereotypes are a kind of gossip in which we prejudge other people even before we ever lay eyes on them. That stereotypes are related to the dark world of prejudice should not be surprising. If you explore the core of most prejudices, beliefs that literally prejudge, you will discover a cruel stereotype lurking (43).

Unacceptably Close Sentence Structure

Heilbroner believes that stereotypes are images of people, images that enable people to prejudge other people before they have seen them. Therefore, no one should find it surprising that stereotypes are somehow related to prejudice. Examine most prejudices (the word literally means prejudgment) and you will uncover a vicious stereotype at the center of each (43).

Acceptable Paraphrase

Heilbroner believes that there is a link between stereotypes and the hurtful practice of prejudice. Stereotypes make for easy conversation, a kind of shorthand that enables us to find fault with people before ever meeting them. If you were to dissect most human prejudices, you would likely discover an ugly stereotype lurking somewhere inside them (43).

Review the following Avoiding Plagiarism box as you proofread your final draft and check your citations one last time. If

at any time while you are taking notes or writing your essay you have a question about plagiarism, consult your instructor for clarification and guidance before proceeding.

Avoiding Plagiarism

Questions to Ask about Direct Quotations

- Do quotation marks clearly indicate the language that I borrowed verbatim?
- Is the language of the quotation accurate, with no missing or misquoted words or phrases?
- Do the brackets or ellipsis marks clearly indicate any changes or omissions I have introduced?
- Does a signal phrase naming the author introduce each quotation?
- Does the verb in the signal phrase help establish a context for each quotation?
- Does a parenthetical page citation follow each quotation?

Questions to Ask about Summaries and Paraphrases

- Is each summary or paraphrase written in my own words and style?
- Does each summary or paraphrase accurately represent the opinion, position, or reasoning of the original writer?

- Does each summary or paraphrase start with a signal phrase so that readers know where my borrowed material begins?
- Does each summary or paraphrase conclude with a parenthetical page citation?

Questions to Ask about Facts and Statistics

- Do I use a signal phrase or some other marker to introduce each fact or statistic that is not common knowledge so that readers know where the borrowed material begins?
- Is each fact or statistic that is not common knowledge clearly documented with a parenthetical page citation?

*How to Teach Children That Failure Is the
Secret to Success*

Tara Haelle



Jim Coventry

Tara Haelle was born in Alameda County, California, in 1978. She has both a BA in English and an MA in photojournalism

from the University of Texas at Austin. She specializes in writing about health and science and has numerous publication credits, having published in *Scientific American*, *Slate*, *Forbes*, and *Politico*, among many others. Haelle has taken on the anti-vaccine movement and delivered a TEDx talk in Oslo, Norway, “Why Parents Fear Vaccines.” Her first book, co-authored with Emily Willingham, is *The Informed Parent: A Science-Based Resource for Your Child’s First Four Years* (2016). In 2018 she published *Vaccination Investigation*, an examination of the history, science, and controversy surrounding vaccines. She has also published nonfiction children’s books: *Seasons, Tides, and Lunar Phases* (2016); *Edible Sunlight* (2016); *Insects as Predators* (2016); and *Insects as Parasites* (2016).

In this article, which was initially published in the National Public Radio column “Health News” on May 6, 2016, Haelle writes about how parents can have a good or bad influence on how children respond to their own failures. As you read, pay attention to how Haelle integrates quotations from experts and published studies to support her thesis rather than relying on her own personal experiences. (Note that Haelle’s article was published online, with a journalistic style that does not necessarily require the same more formal or complete citations that you will need to use in academic writing. For more on citation style, see [Chapter 23](#).)

Reflecting on What You Know

How were you raised to think about failure? Were you punished for failure, or did you learn to accept failure as a part of the learning process? Were failures in some areas of your life accepted while others were not? Consider the impact these issues have on your attitude toward failure today, especially as it applies to your education.

Is failure a positive opportunity to learn and grow, or is it a negative experience that hinders success? How parents answer that question has a big influence on how much children think they can improve their intelligence through hard work, a study says. “Parents are a really critical force in child development when you think about how motivation and mindsets develop,” says Kyla Haimovitz, a professor of psychology at Stanford University. She coauthored the study, published in *Psychological Science* with colleague Carol Dweck, who pioneered research on mindsets. “Parents have this powerful effect really early on and throughout childhood to send messages about what is failure, how to respond to it.”

Although there’s been a lot of research on how these forces play out, relatively little looks at what parents can do to motivate their kids in school, Haimovitz says. This study begins filling that gap. “There is a fair amount of evidence showing that when children view their abilities as more malleable and something they can change over time, then they

deal with obstacles in a more constructive way,” says Gail Heyman, a professor of psychology at the University of California at San Diego who was not involved in this study.

But communicating that message to children is not simple.

“Parents need to represent this to their kids in the ways they react about their kids’ failures and setbacks,” Haimovitz says. “We need to really think about what’s visible to the other person, what message I’m sending in terms of my words and my deeds.” In other words, if a child comes home with a D on a math test, how a parent responds will influence how the child perceives their own ability to learn math. Even a well-intentioned, comforting response of “It’s OK, you’re still a great writer” may send the message that it’s time to give up on math rather than learn from the problems they got wrong, Haimovitz explains.

She and Dweck conducted a series of smaller studies to explore how the interactions between parents’ failure and intelligence mindsets affected their children’s beliefs about intelligence. First they interviewed 73 parents and their fourth- and fifth-grade children about their beliefs on failure and intelligence. The parents were mostly mothers with at least a college degree; they lived in the San Francisco Bay Area. The questions focused on whether they viewed intelligence as something that could change and whether they saw failure as positive, facilitating growth and

enhancing productivity or as negative, debilitating and inhibiting learning.

The way children perceived “being smart” was not related to how their parents perceived intelligence, but it was related to how their parents reacted toward failure. “Parents who had more of a failure-is-debilitating mindset had children who were significantly more likely to believe that intelligence is fixed,” they found, even after accounting for how parents perceived their children’s academic success.

“The more parents believed that failure is debilitating, the more likely their children were to see them as concerned with their performance outcomes and grades rather than their learning and improvement,” the study found.

Then the researchers surveyed 160 different parents online to find out how they would respond to their child coming home with a failing quiz grade. Those who saw failure as negative were more likely to worry about their child’s abilities in that subject or to comfort their child about not being talented in all subjects. But parents who saw failure as an opportunity were more likely to ask their child what they learned from the quiz, what they still can learn and whether asking the teacher for help would be useful.

Through two more surveys of 102 Bay Area parents and their children and 100 fourth- and fifth-grade students, the

researchers found that children could correctly identify their parents' beliefs about failure but not necessarily about intelligence — and it was the former that matched up with the children's own beliefs about intelligence. Finally, the researchers conducted a randomized experiment with 132 parents to discover whether parents' failure beliefs directly cause their children's beliefs through parents' reactions to failure: they did. “The takeaway is that when your child is struggling on something or has setbacks, don't focus on their abilities, focus on what they can learn from it,” Haimovitz says. One way, she says, is to ask a child: “How can you use this as a jumping-off point?”

But it's unclear how much the study's findings relate to children of various ethnic, racial and socioeconomic backgrounds. Related research Heyman has done in China revealed a mixed bag in terms of results. “Cultures have very different beliefs about effort and ability, and asking subtly different questions you can get different answers,” Heyman says.

Whereas academic success often correlates with athletic or social success among white students, the same is not necessarily true among black or Latino students, according to Cleopatra Abdou, an assistant professor of psychology at the University of Southern California. What is consistent across cultures, however, is the powerful influence that beliefs

people internalize as children follow them through life.

“The messages we get from our parents, whether explicitly or symbolically or subconsciously, stay with us and are very hard to unlearn and to overcome” if they’ re not helpful, she says. “Sometimes we have internalized faulty beliefs or beliefs that don’ t serve us.”

Further, taking the learn-from-failure message too far might backfire eventually. “If you’ re being told this message you can learn anything and you’ ve done everything you can and you’ re not getting anywhere, then maybe at a certain point you’ re going to say I just don’ t believe this,” she adds. Further, children’ s mindsets can also be influenced by their temperament, such as their tolerance for frustration, Heyman says. “One thing we do know in recent years, there’ s too much blaming of parents,” Heyman says. “Temperament is extremely important and it’ s biologically based, and to deny that causes all kinds of problems.”

The challenge for parents is to support children without setting them up for failure. “There’ s this very difficult fine line between parents and teachers helping children enough so that they can do things on their own that they couldn’ t do otherwise but not to help them so much that they expect other people to do it for them and don’ t get pulled up to a higher level,” Heyman says. “You slowly pull back

as the kids get better on their own, but not let them flail around so much that they get frustrated and give up.”

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Haelle states that parents have a “big influence on how much children think they can improve their intelligence through hard work” ([paragraph 1](#)). Did this statement surprise you? Why or why not?
2. In [paragraph 2](#), Haelle quotes a psychologist, Gail Heyman, who was not involved in the study conducted by Kyla Haimovitz and Carol Dweck. What is the advantage of consulting a third party for comment on the issues that the study is based on?
3. You’re probably familiar with the old saying, “Do as I say, not as I do.” How does this relate to Haimovitz’s statement, “We need to really think about what’s visible to the other person, what message I’m sending in terms of my words and my deeds” (3)? Why are words given equal importance here?
4. Haimovitz states, “One way [to deal with failure] is to ask a child, ‘How can you use this as a jumping-off point?’ ” (7). What does she mean by this? In your own experience with failure, how helpful would this advice be to you?
5. Haelle quotes Heyman: “There’s too much blaming of parents” (10). Do you agree? If this is true, what

does that say about the study done by Haimovitz and Dweck?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What do you think Haelle's purpose in writing this essay is? Does she seem more intent on arguing for a particular position or on reporting what researchers have discovered so that parents can make informed decisions about raising their children?
2. Much of the focus in Haelle's article is on how parents view failure. Why is the way people look at failure so important? How do you react to failure? Another important question explored by the researchers is: What is the nature of intelligence? What do you think intelligence is, and what do you see as the relationship (if any) between failure and intelligence?
3. In [paragraphs 8](#) and [9](#), Haelle concedes that other experts point out that there may be cultural limits to Haimovitz and Dweck's findings. Why is it important to account for cultural differences when looking at the conclusions of any study? What consistency across cultures did researcher Cleopatra Abdou discover in her work?

Classroom Activity Using Writing with Sources

Use the examples of signal phrases and parenthetical citations on [pages 230 – 32](#) as models for integrating the quotation into the flow of the discussion in each of the following two paragraphs. The quotation in the first example comes from page 100 of William L. Rathje’ s article “Rubbish!” in the December 1989 issue of *The Atlantic*. Rathje teaches at the University of Arizona, where he directs the Garbage Project.

Most Americans think that we are producing more trash per person than ever, that plastic is a huge problem, and that paper biodegrades quickly in landfills. “The biggest challenge we will face is to recognize that the conventional wisdom about garbage is often wrong.”

The quotation in the second example comes from page 99 of Rita Dove’ s essay “Loose Ends” from her 1995 book *The Poet’ s World*. Dove is a former poet laureate of the United States and teaches at the University of Virginia.

Television, it could be argued, presents life in tidy almost predictable thirty- and sixty-minute packages. As any episode of *Friends*, *House*, or *Law and Order* demonstrates, life on television, though exciting, is relatively easy to follow. Humor, simultaneous action, and special effects cannot overshadow the fact that each show has a beginning, a middle, and an end. “Life ... is

ragged. Loose ends rule.” For many Americans, television provides an escape from their disjointed day-to-day lives.

Compare your signal phrases with those of your classmates, and discuss how smoothly each integrates the quotation into the passage.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Haelle’s article addresses the idea that intelligence can be improved through hard work, which is revealed through students’ performance in school. Research the relationship between intelligence and educational achievement. Write an essay, using sources, in which you argue whether the two are the same or if it’s a mistake to judge intelligence by performance in an educational setting.
2. Haelle quotes Gail Heyman in [paragraph 10](#):
“Temperament is extremely important, and it’s biologically based.” Research how much biology determines personality versus environmental factors. Write an essay, using sources, in which you argue whether nature (biology) or nurture (environment) is the primary determinant of a child’s personality.

We Need to Talk About Kids and Smartphones

Markham Heid



Kelly Baldwin Heid

Markham Heid is a freelance reporter based in Philadelphia. He received his BA in English from the University of Michigan in 2005 and his MS in Journalism from Northwestern University in 2009. He has written about health-related topics for many publications including *Time*, the *Washington Examiner*, *Men's Health*, *Southern Living*, and *Vice*. His reporting has earned awards from the Maryland-Delaware-DC Press Association and from the Society of Professional Journalists.

In the following selection, originally published in *Time* magazine on October 10, 2017, Heid reports that smartphones are having a significant effect on behavior and communication among teens. Notice how Heid uses outside sources like anecdotes, statistics, and expert opinions to illuminate the possible correlation between young people's use of smartphones and their mental health difficulties.

Reflecting on What You Know

Do you have a smartphone? If so, how often do you use it?

Does your smartphone use impact you physically and/or emotionally? Explain.

Nina Langton thought she had no right to be depressed. She had a great group of friends, lived in a prosperous neighborhood and was close with her parents. Like most 16-year-olds at her Connecticut high school, Nina spent much of her free time on her smartphone. But unlike many of her

classmates, she was never “targeted” on social media — her word for the bullying and criticism that takes place daily on apps like Snapchat. “Part of what made my depression so difficult was that I didn’ t understand why I was feeling so sad,” she says.

Later, after her attempted suicide and during her stay at a rehabilitation facility, Nina and her therapist identified body-image insecurity as the foundation of her woe. “I was spending a lot of time stalking models on Instagram, and I worried a lot about how I looked,” says Nina, who is now 17. She’ d stay up late in her bedroom, looking at social media on her phone, and poor sleep — coupled with an eating disorder — gradually snowballed until suicide felt like her only option. “I didn’ t totally want to be gone,” she says. “I just wanted help and didn’ t know how else to get it.”

Nina’ s mom, Christine Langton, says she was “completely caught off guard” by her daughter’ s suicide attempt. “Nina was funny, athletic, smart, personable … depression was just not on my radar,” she says. In hindsight, Christine says she wishes she had done more to moderate her daughter’ s smartphone use. “It didn’ t occur to me not to let her have the phone in her room at night,” she says. “I just wasn’ t thinking about the impact of the phone on her self-esteem or self-image.”

It seems like every generation of parents has a collective freak-out when it comes to kids and new technologies; television and video games each inspired widespread hand-wringing among grownups. But the inescapability of today's mobile devices — combined with the allure of social media — seems to separate smartphones from older screen-based media. Parents, teenagers and researchers agree that smartphones are having a profound impact on the way adolescents today communicate with one another and spend their free time. And while some experts say it's too soon to ring alarm bells about smartphones, others argue that we understand enough about young people's emotional and developmental vulnerabilities to recommend restricting kids' escalating phone habits.

The latest statistics on teenage mental health underscore the urgency of this debate. Between 2010 and 2016, the number of adolescents who experienced at least one major depressive episode leaped by 60%, according to a nationwide survey conducted by a branch of the Department of Health and Human Services. The 2016 HHS survey of 17,000 kids found that about 13% of them had at least one major depressive episode the prior year, compared with 8% of the kids surveyed in 2010. Suicide deaths among people ages 10 to 19 have also risen sharply; among teenage girls, suicide has reached 40-year highs, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. All this follows a period during the late 1990s

and early 2000s when rates of adolescent depression and suicide mostly held steady or declined.

“These increases are huge — possibly unprecedented,” says Jean Twenge, a professor of psychology at San Diego State University and the author of *iGen*, which examines how today’s superconnected teens are less happy and less prepared for adulthood than past generations. In a peer-reviewed study that will appear later this year in the journal *Clinical Psychological Science*, Twenge shows that, after 2010, teens who spent more time on digital devices were more likely to report mental-health issues than those who spent time on nonscreen activities.

Using data collected between 2010 and 2015 from more than 500,000 adolescents nationwide, Twenge’s study found that kids who spent three hours a day or more on smartphones or other electronic devices were 34% more likely to suffer at least one suicide-related behavior — including feeling hopeless or seriously considering suicide — than kids who used devices two hours a day or less. Among kids who used devices five or more hours a day, 48% had at least one suicide-related outcome. Overall, kids in the study who spent low amounts of time engaged in real-life social interaction but high amounts of time on social media were the most likely to be depressed.

Twenge is quick to acknowledge that her research does not prove that a cause-and-effect relationship exists between smartphones and depression. Some experts have pointed to the aftermath of the Great Recession or rising student workloads as possible non-device explanations for young people's recent struggles. "But when you look at the economic or homework data, it doesn't line up with the rise in teen suicide or depression," Twenge says. Youth smartphone ownership does. "I'm open to exploring other factors, but I think the more we learn about kids and smartphones, the more we're going to see that limiting their exposure is a good idea."

Others agree that it's time to approach adolescent device use with greater caution. "What this generation is going through right now with technology is a giant experiment, and we don't know what's going to happen," says Frances Jensen, chair of neurology at the University of Pennsylvania's Perelman School of Medicine. While the science on kids and technology is incomplete, Jensen says that what we know about the minds of tweens and teens suggests that giving a young person all-the-time access to an Internet-connected device "may be playing with fire."

To understand how device use may be affecting a young person's mental health, it's important to recognize the complex changes occurring in an adolescent's still-

developing brain. For one thing, that brain is incredibly plastic and able to adapt — that is, physically change — in response to novel activities or environmental cues, says Jensen, who is also the author of *The Teenage Brain*.

Some research has already linked media multitasking — texting, using social media and rapidly switching among smartphone-based apps — with lower gray-matter volume in the brain's anterior cingulate cortex (ACC), a region involved in emotion processing and decision-making. More research has associated lower ACC volumes with depression and addiction disorders.

“We know for a fact that teens have very underdeveloped impulse control and empathy and judgment, compared with adults,” Jensen says. This may lead them to disturbing online content or encounters — stuff a more mature mind would know to avoid. Teens also have a hyperactive risk-reward system that allows them to learn — but also to become addicted — much more quickly than grownups, she says. Research has linked social media and other phone-based activities with an uptick in feel-good neurochemicals like dopamine, which could drive compulsive device use and promote feelings of distraction, fatigue or irritability when kids are separated from their phones.

Another area of the brain — the prefrontal cortex — is critical for focus and interpreting human emotion, and doesn't fully develop until a person's mid-20s, says Paul Atchley, a professor of psychology at the University of Kansas. "During our teenage years, it's important to train that prefrontal cortex not to be easily distracted," he says. "What we're seeing in our work is that young people are constantly distracted and also less sensitive to the emotions of others."

But some scientists contend that there isn't enough evidence to condemn smartphones. "I see the rise in depression, especially among girls, and I understand why people are making these connections with new technologies," says Candice Odgers, a professor of psychology and neuroscience at Duke University who has published research on teenagers and tech. "But so far we have very little data to suggest mobile technologies are causing anxiety or social impairments." She points to evidence that some young people, particularly marginalized groups like LGBT youth, can derive benefits from online support networks and communication with friends and family. Odgers adds that jumping to conclusions and vilifying smartphones may lead us away from factors that may turn out to be more significant — a worry raised by other experts.

As researchers debate appropriate public health messaging, kids are receiving their first smartphone at ever-younger

ages — the average is 10, according to one recent estimate — and they’ re spending more and more time on their devices.

“I am probably on my phone 10 hours a day,” says Santi Potocnik Senarighi, a 16-year-old 11th grader in Denver. Even when he’ s not using his phone, it’ s always with him, and he never considers taking a break. “This is part of my life and part of my work, and [that] means I need to be in constant contact.”

Santi’ s dad, Billy Potocnik, says he worries about his son’ s phone habit. But every one of Santi’ s friends has a smartphone and uses it constantly, and so Potocnik says confiscating his son’ s phone seems oppressive. To complicate matters, many schools and after-school groups now use social media or online platforms to coordinate events or post grades and homework. “It’ s not as simple as saying, O.K., time to take a break from your phone,” Potocnik says.

Colleen Nisbet has been a high school guidance counselor for more than two decades. One of her duties at Connecticut’ s Granby Memorial High School is to monitor students during their lunch periods. “Lunch was always a very social time when students were interacting and letting out some energy,” she says. “Now they sit with their phones out and barely talk to each other.”

This scene — of young people gathering in parks or at houses only to sit silently and stare at screens — comes up frequently when talking with parents and kids. “When you’ re with people you don’ t know well or there’ s nothing to talk about, phones are out more because it’ s awkward,” says Shannon Ohannessian, a 17-year-old senior at Farmington High School in Connecticut.

That avoidance of face-to-face engagement worries Brian Primack, director of the University of Pittsburgh’ s Center for Research on Media, Technology and Health. “Human beings are social animals,” he says. “We evolved over millions of years to respond to eye contact and touch and shared laughter and real things right in front of us.” If smartphones are interfering with a teen’ s facility for these normal human behaviors, that’ s a big deal, he adds.

But while they’ re not always speaking out loud, kids today are talking to each other — and about each other — on their phones. Not all of it is friendly. “They tell me they’ re making comments or criticizing each other to friends while they’ re all sitting together,” says Nisbet. Backbiting and gossip are nothing new, of course. But research suggests that, even among adults, the Internet has a disinhibition effect that leads people to speak in coarser, crueler ways than they would offline.

Maryellen Pachler, a Yale-trained nurse practitioner who specializes in the treatment of adolescent anxiety disorders, says the glamor and gleam of social media is also fueling a rise in teen anxiety. “My patients see their friends’ Snapchat or Instagram photos where they look so happy, and they feel like they’ re the only ones who are faking it,” she says, referencing what researchers call the highlight-reel effect of social media. “I want to tell them, Listen, this girl you’ re jealous of — she was in here with me yesterday!”

Teenagers agree that social-media whitewashing is the rule, not the exception. “No one’ s going to post something that makes them look bad,” Ohannessian says. “I know that, but it’ s still hard to separate what you see on social media from real life.”

There are doubtless many factors contributing to teen depression. Parents say kids today are busier than ever before, with their lives increasingly crammed with the extracurriculars required to gain admission to a good college. But even researchers who aren’ t ready to slam smartphones say it’ s important to restrict an adolescent’ s device habit. “I don’ t think these devices are the main cause, but I think they contribute to a lot of the things we worry about,” says David Hill, director of the American Academy of Pediatrics Council on Communications and Media. He

counsels parents to set more limits — especially when it comes to phones in the bedroom at night.

Educators are also grappling with smartphone-related dilemmas. Most schools allow smartphone use between classes and during free periods, but teachers say keeping students off their phones during class has become a tremendous burden. Now some schools are fighting back. Starting this fall, a few teamed up with a company called Yondr to restrict student smartphone access during school hours. Yondr makes lockable phone pouches that students keep with them but that can't be opened until the end of the day.

Allison Silvestri, the principal at San Lorenzo High School, near Oakland, Calif., says that since the school implemented the restrictions, “the changes have been profound.” Kids are more focused and engaged during class, and student journals suggest that the high schoolers are feeling less stress. Silvestri says fewer fights have broken out this semester — a benefit she attributes to the absence of social media. “They have to look each other in the eye to make conflict happen,” she says. “There's so much more joy and interaction, and I can't count the number of parents who have asked me, ‘How do I buy this for my home?’ ”

The experiment at San Lorenzo doesn't meet the standards of the scientific method. But it's one more bit of evidence

tying mobile devices to the troubles today's teenagers are facing. While there are helpful and healthy ways young people can use smartphones to enrich their lives, it's becoming harder to argue that the status quo — ubiquitous teen smartphone ownership, with near constant Internet access — is doing kids good.

A few months after her suicide attempt, Nina Langton addressed her classmates and spoke openly about her depression. She described the stigma of mental illness and lamented the fact that, while many teens experience depression, few are willing to talk about it. “I was worried for so long about opening up about my struggles, because I thought I would be judged,” she said.

After her speech, “so many people my age reached out to me about their own experiences with technology and depression and therapy,” she says. “I think this is a big problem that needs to be talked about more.”

Markham Heid, “We Need to Talk About Kids and Smartphones,” *Time.com*, October 10 2017. Copyright © 2017 by TIME USA LLC. All rights reserved. Used under license.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. With what anecdote does Heid open his essay?
(Glossary: [Anecdote](#)) How does this anecdote support his overall point?
2. What statistics does Heid present in paragraph 5 to establish the “urgency” concerning the debate about whether smartphones generate mental health issues? Do you find these statistics effective in supporting his argument? Why or why not?
3. Identify Heid’s topic sentence in paragraph 9 and explain how it helps him to announce the quotation from Frances Jensen. (Glossary: [Topic Sentence](#))
4. What signal phrase does Heid use in the opening sentence of [paragraph 14](#)? (Glossary: [Signal Phrase](#)) Does this signal phrase indicate argument or contestation of a fact? In this paragraph, what point does Heid say scientists are making about smartphones?
5. What issue does Billy Potocnik encounter when he considers trying to do something about his son Santi’s excessive smartphone use (16)?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. At the end of [paragraph 4](#), Heid engages in persuasive synthesis: he refers to two sides of a debate (“some experts” and “others”) to establish a connection between smartphone use and adolescent mental health

issues. Why do you think Heid does not explicitly name the sources he is synthesizing in this paragraph? Is this paragraph effective in supporting his argument? Why or why not?

2. Heid writes that “research has linked social media and other phone-based activities with an uptick in feel-good neurochemicals like dopamine, which could drive compulsive device use and promote feelings of distraction, fatigue or irritability when kids are separated from their phones” (12). Do you feel that the neuroscience described here would also translate to adults using smartphones? Why do you suppose Heid avoids discussing the impact of smartphones on adults?
3. In [paragraph 14](#), Heid summarizes the ideas of professor Candice Odgers, who thinks that technology can be good for connecting “marginalized groups.” Name one other way in which social media can have a positive impact. Do the positive impacts of smartphones that Heid does not mention undermine his argument? Why or why not?

Classroom Activity Using Writing with Sources

For each of the following quotations, write an acceptable paraphrase and then a paraphrase with a partial quotation

that avoids plagiarism (see [pp. 227 – 28](#) and [237 – 39](#)). Pay careful attention to the word choice and sentence structure of the original.

The sperm whale is the largest of the toothed whales. Moby Dick was a sperm whale. Generally, male toothed whales are larger than the females. Female sperm whales may grow thirty-five to forty feet in length, while the males may reach sixty feet.

— Richard Hendrick, *The Voyage of the Mimi*

Astronauts from over twenty nations have gone into space, and they all come back, amazingly enough, saying the very same thing: the earth is a small, blue place of profound beauty that we must take care of. For each, the journey into space, whatever its original intents and purposes, became above all a spiritual one.

— Al Reinert, *For All Mankind*

One of the usual things about education in mathematics in the United States is its relatively impoverished vocabulary. Whereas the student completing elementary school will already have a vocabulary for most disciplines of many hundreds, even thousands of words, the typical student will have a mathematics vocabulary of only a couple of dozen words.

— Marvin Minsky, *The Society of Mind*

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write a short essay in which you formulate an argument of your own on the topic of teens and smartphones. You may argue that smartphones have an adverse effect on teens' mental health; or, alternately, you may argue that the correlation is overstated and that the mental health effects may not actually be caused by smartphones. To support your argument, you may use your own personal experiences and observations, as well as the information in Heid' s essay. Before stating your thesis, summarize or paraphrase part of Heid' s argument that is relevant to your own view on the topic or that you will refute in your essay. (Glossary: [Thesis](#), [Summary](#), [Paraphrase](#))
2. Using at least one quotation and one paraphrase from any article in *Models for Writers*, write an essay that describes three possible solutions to a problem that you see in society. (Glossary: [Summary](#), [Paraphrase](#)) You may write about smartphones, but for additional inspiration, look at the readings in the Social Issues and Activism thematic cluster (see [pp. xxxiii - xxxiv](#)). In your essay, you may develop your own solutions or you may argue in favor of (or against) one or more solutions proposed by the author of the article you are using as a source. Be sure to

use signal phrases to introduce all borrowed materials.

*The English-Only Movement: Can America
Proscribe Language with a Clean Conscience?*

Jake Jamieson



Jake Jamieson

An eighth-generation Vermonter, Jake Jamieson was born in Berlin, Vermont, and grew up in nearby Waterbury. He graduated from the University of Vermont in 1996 with a degree in elementary education and a focus in English. After graduation, he “bounced around” California and Colorado before landing in the Boston area, where he directed the product innovation and training department at iProspect, a search-engine marketing company. Jamieson then moved back to Montpelier, Vermont, where he started his own web design company.

Jamieson wrote the following essay while he was a student at the University of Vermont and has updated it for inclusion in this book. As a believer in the old axiom “If it isn’ t broken, don’ t fix it,” Jamieson thinks that the official-English crowd wants to fix a system that seems to be working just fine. In this essay, he tackles the issue of legislating English as the official language of the United States. As you read, notice how he uses outside sources to present various pieces of the English-only position. He then tries to undercut that position by using his own thinking and examples as well as the opinions of experts who support him. Throughout his essay, Jamieson uses MLA style for his in-text citations and his list of works cited.

Reflecting on What You Know

It is now possible to visit many countries and be understood in English, regardless of other languages that are spoken in the host country. If you were to emigrate, how hard would you work to learn the predominant language of your chosen country? What advantages would you gain by learning that language, even if you could get by in English? How would you feel if the country had a law that required you to use its language in its schools and businesses? Write down your thoughts about these questions.

Many people think of the United States as a giant cultural “melting pot” where people from other countries come together and bathe in the warm waters of assimilation. In this scenario, the newly arrived immigrants readily adopt American cultural ways and learn to speak English. For others, however, this serene picture of the melting pot analogy does not ring true. These people see the melting pot as a giant cauldron into which immigrants are tossed; here their cultures, values, and backgrounds are boiled away in the scalding waters of discrimination. At the center of the discussion about immigrants and assimilation is language: should immigrants be required to learn English, or should accommodations be made so they can continue to use their native languages?

Those who argue that the melting pot analogy is valid believe that immigrants who come to America do so willingly and

should be expected to become a part of its culture instead of hanging on to their past. For them, the expectation that immigrants will celebrate this country' s holidays, dress as Americans dress, embrace American values, and most importantly speak English is not unreasonable. They believe that assimilation offers the only way for everyone in this country to live together in harmony and the only way to dissipate the tensions that inevitably arise when cultures clash. A major problem with this argument, however, is that there is no agreement on what exactly constitutes the "American way" of doing things.

Not everyone in America is of the same religious persuasion or has the same set of values, and different people affect vastly different styles of dress. There are so many sets of variables that it would be hard to defend the argument that there is only one culture in the United States. Currently, the one common denominator in America is that the majority of us speak English, and because of this a major movement is being staged in favor of making English the country' s "official" language while it is still the country' s national and common language. Making English America' s "official" language would change the ground rules and expectations surrounding immigrant assimilation. According to the columnist and social commentator Charles Krauthammer, making English the "official" language has important implications:

“Official” means the language of the government and its institutions. “Official” makes clear our expectations of acculturation. “Official” means that every citizen, upon entering America’s most sacred political space, the voting booth, should minimally be able to identify the words *president* and *vice president* and *county commissioner* and *judge*. The immigrant, of course, has the right to speak whatever he wants. But he must understand that when he comes to the United States, swears allegiance, and accepts its bounty, he undertakes to join its civic culture. In English. (112)

Many reasons are given to support the notion that making English the official language of the land is a good idea and that it is exactly what this country needs, especially in the face of the growing diversity of languages in metropolitan areas. Indeed, in a recent survey one Los Angeles school reported sixty different languages spoken in the homes of its students (Natl. Education Assn., par. 4).

Supporters of English-only contend that all government communication must be in English. Because communication is absolutely necessary for democracy to survive, they believe that the only way to ensure the existence of our nation is to make sure a common language exists. Making English official would ensure that all government business, from ballots to official forms to judicial hearings, would have to be conducted in English. According to former senator and presidential candidate Bob Dole, “Promoting English as our

national language is not an act of hostility but a welcoming act of inclusion.” He goes on to state that while immigrants are encouraged to continue speaking their native languages, “thousands of children [are] failing to learn the language, English, that is the ticket to the ‘American Dream’ ” (qtd. in Donegan 51). Political and cultural commentator Greg Lewis echoes Dole’s sentiments when he boldly states, “To succeed in America … it’s important to speak, read, and understand English as most Americans speak it. There’s nothing cruel or unfair in that; it’s just the way it is” (par. 5).

For those who do not subscribe to this way of thinking, however, this type of legislation is anything but the “welcoming act of inclusion” that it is described to be. Many of them, like Myriam Marquez, readily acknowledge the importance of English but fear that “talking in Spanish — or any other language, for that matter — is some sort of litmus test used to gauge American patriotism” (“Why and When” A12). Others suggest that anyone attempting to regulate language is treading dangerously close to the First Amendment and must have a hidden agenda of some type. Why, it is asked, make a language official when it is already firmly entrenched and widely used in this country without legislation to mandate it? According to language diversity advocate James Crawford, the answer is plain and simple: “discrimination.” He states that “it is certainly more respectable to discriminate by language than by race” or

ethnicity. He points out that “most people are not sensitive to language discrimination in this nation, so it is easy to argue that you’ re doing someone a favor by making them speak English” (qtd. in Donegan 51). English-only legislation has been criticized as bigoted, anti-immigrant, mean-spirited, and steeped in nativism by those who oppose it, and some go so far as to say that this type of legislation will not foster better communication, as is the claim, but will instead encourage a “fear of being subsumed by a growing ‘foreignness’ in our midst” (Underwood 65).

For example, when a judge in Texas ruled that a mother was abusing her five-year-old girl by speaking to her only in Spanish, an uproar ensued. This ruling was accompanied by the statement that by talking to her daughter in a language other than English, the mother was “abusing that child and ... relegating her to the position of house maid.” The National Association for Bilingual Education (NABE) condemned this statement for “labeling the Spanish language as abuse.” The judge, Samuel C. Kiser, subsequently apologized to the housekeepers of the country, adding that he held them “in the highest esteem,” but stood firm on his ruling (qtd. in Donegan 51). One might notice that he went out of his way to apologize to the housekeepers he might have offended but saw no need to apologize to the millions of Spanish speakers whose language had just been belittled in a nationally publicized case.

This tendency of official-English proponents to put down other languages is one that shows up again and again, even though they maintain that they have nothing against other languages or the people who speak them. If there is no malice intended toward other languages, why is the use of any language other than English tantamount to lunacy according to an almost constant barrage of literature and editorial opinion? In a recent listing of the “New Year’s Resolutions” of various conservative organizations, a group called U.S. English, Inc., stated that the U.S. government was not doing its job of convincing immigrants that they “must learn English to succeed in this country.” Instead, according to Stephen Moore and his associates, “in a bewildering display of irrationality, the U.S. government makes it possible to vote, file a tax return, get married, obtain a driver’s license, and become a U.S. citizen in many languages” (46).

Now, according to this mindset, not only is speaking any language other than English abusive, but it is also irrational and bewildering. What is this world coming to when people want to speak and make transactions in their native language? Why do they refuse to change and become more like us? Why can’t immigrants see that speaking English is quite simply the right way to go? These and many other questions like them are implied by official-English proponents when they discuss the issue.

Conservative attorney David Price argues that official-English legislation is a good idea because most English-speaking Americans prefer “out of pride and convenience to speak their native language on the job” (A13). This statement implies not only that the pride and convenience of non-English-speaking Americans is unimportant but that their native tongues are not as important as English. The scariest prospect of all is that this opinion is quickly gaining popularity all around the country. It appears to be most prevalent in areas with high concentrations of Spanish-speaking residents.

To date, a number of official-English bills and one amendment to the Constitution have been proposed in the House and Senate. There are more than twenty-seven states — including Missouri, North Dakota, Florida, Massachusetts, California, Virginia, and New Hampshire — that have made English their official language, and more are debating the issue every day. An especially disturbing fact about this debate — and it was front and center in 2007 during the discussions and protests about what to do with America’s 12.5 million illegal immigrants — is that official-English laws always seem to be linked to anti-immigration legislation, such as proposals to limit immigration or to restrict government benefits to immigrants.

Although official-English proponents maintain that their bid for language legislation is in the best interest of immigrants, the facts tend to show otherwise. University of Texas Professor Robert D. King strongly believes that

“language does not threaten American unity.” He recommends that “we relax and luxuriate in our linguistic richness and our traditional tolerance of language differences” (64). A decision has to be made in this country about what kind of message we will send to the rest of the world. Do we plan to allow everyone in this country the freedom of speech that we profess to cherish, or will we decide to reserve it only for those who speak English? Will we hold firm to our belief that everyone is deserving of life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness in this country? Or will we show the world that we believe in these things only when they pertain to ourselves and people like us? “The irony,” as Hispanic columnist Myriam Marquez observes, “is that English-only laws directed at government have done little to change the inevitable multicultural flavor of America” (“English-Only Laws” A10).

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Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What question does Jamieson seek to answer in his essay? How does he answer this question?
2. How does Jamieson respond to the people who argue that the melting pot analogy is valid? Do you agree with his counterargument?

3. For what purpose does Jamieson quote Greg Lewis in [paragraph 5](#)? What would have been lost had he dropped the Lewis quotation? Explain.
4. In [paragraph 7](#), Jamieson presents the example of the Texas judge who ruled that speaking to a child only in Spanish constituted abuse. What point does this example help Jamieson make?
5. Jamieson is careful to use signal phrases to introduce each of his quotations and paraphrases. How do these signal phrases help readers follow the flow of the argument in his essay?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Jamieson assumes that “there are so many sets of variables that it would be hard to defend the argument that there is only one culture in the United States” (3). Do you accept this assumption, or do you see a dominant American culture with many regional variations? Explain.
2. Does Jamieson have any discernable biases? If so, what are they, and how did they affect your reading of the essay?
3. James Crawford believes that the official-English legislation is motivated by “discrimination” (5). What do you think he means? Why do you think the discussions of English-only legislation and

immigration are so frequently linked? Explain. What do you see as the intent of English-only legislation? Do you think it is possible for English-only laws and multiculturalism to coexist in the United States? Why?

Classroom Activity Using Writing with Sources

Using the examples on [page 227](#) as a model, write a paraphrase for each of the following paragraphs — that is, restate the original ideas in your own words, using your own style and sentence structure. Then compare your paraphrases with those of your classmates.

The great offense of the cell phone in public is not the intrusion of its ring, although that can be infuriating when it interrupts a tranquil moment. It is the fact that even when the phone does not ring at all, and is being used quietly and discreetly, it renders a public place less public. It turns the boulevardier into a sequestered individual, the flaneur into a figure of privacy. And suddenly the meaning of the street as a public place has been hugely diminished.

— Paul Goldberger, “Disconnected Urbanism”

The history of a nation is more often the result of the unexpected than of the planned. In many cases it turns on momentous events. In 1968, American history was determined

by a garbage men' s strike. As Martin Luther King Jr. and the members of the SCLC commenced planning the Poor Peoples' March on Washington, the garbage men of Memphis, Tennessee, were embroiled in a wage dispute with Mayor Henry Loeb. On February 12th, the garbage men, most of whom were black, went on strike. What began as a simple dispute over wages soon developed into a full-fledged racial battle between the predominantly black union, local 1733, and the white power structure of the City of Memphis.

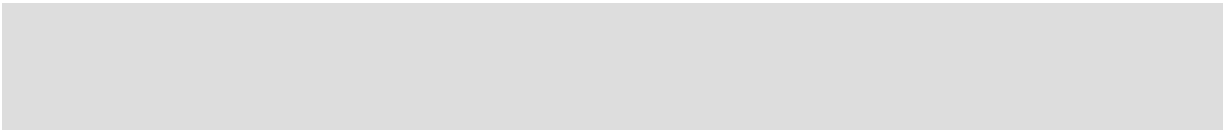
— Robert L. Walsh and Leon F. Burrell, *The Other America*

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. It' s no secret that English is the common language of the United States, but few of us know that the country has been cautious about promoting a government-mandated official language. Why do you suppose the federal government has chosen to take a hands-off position on the language issue? If it has not been necessary to mandate English in the past, why do you think people now feel a need to declare English the “official language” of the United States? Do you think this need is real? Write an essay in which you articulate your position on the English-only issue. Support your position with your

own experiences and observations as well as with several outside sources.

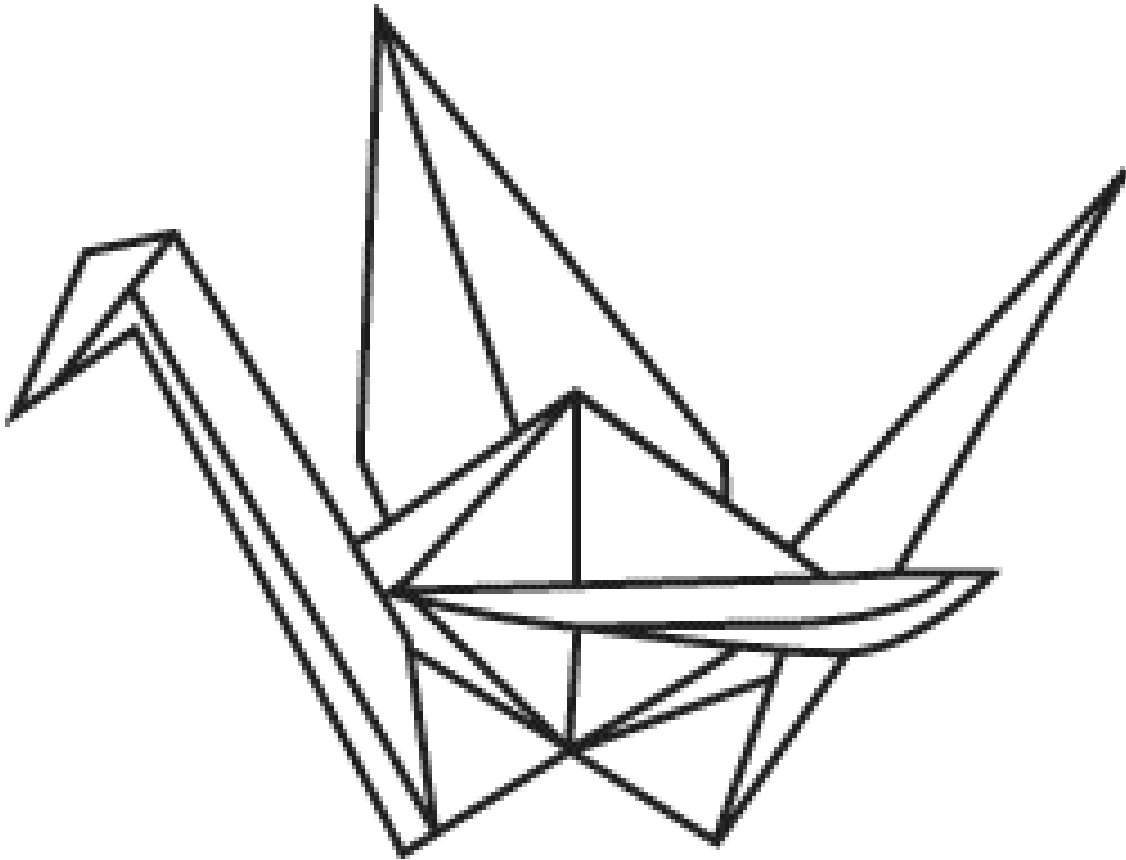
2. Is the English-only debate a political issue, a social issue, an economic issue, or some combination of the three? In this context, what do you see as the relationship between language and power? Write an essay in which you explore the relationship between language and power as it pertains to non-English-speaking immigrants living and functioning within an English-speaking dominant culture.



PART THREE The Language of the Essay



CHAPTER 11 Voice



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Voice is a writer's personality as it shows itself on the written page. Each writer's unique nature is revealed via the themes, tone, attitude, organizational patterns, sentence structures, diction, grammar, and even punctuation that he or she uses. In short, no one else is like you in their thoughts, beliefs, spirit, speech, or words, and so it follows that no one else writes with your voice. The following example of voice is from a student whose feelings about her hair have changed significantly over time:

I' ve never been good with hair. My hair is a physical culmination of my heritage — a biracial tangle of curl and kink. It shapeshifts: when it' s wet, it falls in long, loose tendrils. When it' s dry, it shrinks and fros and not a comb on this Earth can get through it. I never learned how to braid, how to style, or do anything past a ponytail. I still prefer to cut my hair myself, leaving it choppy and uneven half of the time, and forget to shampoo on a regular basis. But I do *love* my hair, and this is a sought-after skill. For girls like me to love their hair is for our self-hatred to be reversed inch by inch. But it was not always this way for me.

— Mya Nunnally, [“Mixed Results”](#) (p. 33)

Nunnally moves easily from herself to her cultural heritage and quickly back again to the physical attributes of her hair. With this narrowing and widening of the lens of her experience, she voices her appreciation of the particular within the universal. Using rapid but appropriate pacing, she moves deftly from the love she has for her hair to a concern that loving one' s own hair is not easy for her or for other black girls.

In another example of voice, a Native American father writes a letter to his five-year-old son' s teacher, introducing the real Wind-Wolf and describing his special talents. The teacher had described the boy as a “slow learner,” a label that his father argues is anything but accurate:

While you are trying to teach him your new methods, helping him learn new tools for self-discovery and adapt to his new learning environment, he may be looking out the window as if daydreaming. Why? Because he has been taught to watch and study the changes in nature. It is hard for him to make the appropriate psychic switch from the right to the left hemisphere of the brain when he sees the leaves turning bright colors, the geese heading south, and the squirrels scurrying around for nuts to get ready for the harsh winter. In his heart, in his young mind, and almost by instinct, he knows that this is the time of the year when he is supposed to be with people gathering and preparing fish, deer meat, and native plants and herbs, and learning his assigned tasks in this role. He is caught between two worlds, torn by two distinct cultural systems.

— Robert G. Lake-Thom (Medicine Grizzly Bear), [“An Indian Father’s Plea”](#) (p. 316)

Lake-Thom is clearly upset, but rather than voice his anger, he maintains a measured tone and uses an impressive range of evidence to support his argument. His voice is steady, his purpose clear, and his truths convincing. Rather than dismissing his son’s teacher, Lake-Thom models the behavior of a true teacher in defense of his son.

In the following paragraph, author Sarah Smarsh reveals her voice as she describes where she is from:

We were country people in the middle of the country, living in a way that, I gather from things that were said to me over the

years, some middle-class people in cities and suburbs on coasts thought had died long ago. For someone who never worked on a farm, for whom the bread and meat in deli sandwiches seemed to magically materialize without agricultural labor, the center of the country was a place flown over but not touched.

— Sarah Smarsh, [“Heartland”](#) (p. 173)

Smarsh’ s voice carries sadness and dismay when she says that she comes from a part of the country and a way of life that many people thought “had died long ago.” She then pivots quickly to express an equally profound irony: that the center of the United States is where much of our food is produced and yet is “a place flown over but not touched.” The reader gets a sense through Smarsh’ s voice that she is sad because of how disconnected American society has become.

It is helpful in understanding voice to examine how different writers reveal their voices when dealing the same subject. The following three excerpts focus on the concept of shame.

Now there was shame everywhere. It seemed like the whole world had been in that classroom, everyone had heard what the teacher had said, everyone had turned around and felt sorry for me. There was shame in going to the Worthy Boys Annual Christmas Dinner for you and your kind, because everyone knew what a worthy boy was. Why couldn’ t they just call it the Boys Annual Dinner; why’ d they have to give it a name? There was shame in wearing the brown and orange and white plaid mackinaw the welfare gave to three thousand boys. Why’ d it have to be the same for everybody so when you walked down the street the

people could see you were on relief? It was a nice warm mackinaw and it had a hood, and my Momma beat me and called me a little rat when she found out I stuffed it in the bottom of a pail full of garbage way over on Cottage Street. There was shame in running over to Mr. Ben's at the end of the day and asking for his rotten peaches, there was shame in asking Mrs. Simmons for a spoonful of sugar, there was shame in running out to meet the relief truck. I hated that truck, full of food for you and your kind. I ran into the house and hid when it came. And then I started to sneak through the alleys, to take the long way home so that people going into White's Eat Shop wouldn't see me. Yeah, the whole world heard the teacher that day, we all know you don't have a Daddy.

— Dick Gregory, ["Shame"](#) (pp. 145 - 46)

Is shame an appropriate criminal punishment? Many courts and legislators around the country think so. Steal from your employer in Wisconsin and you might be ordered to wear a sandwich board proclaiming your offense. Drive drunk in Florida or Texas and you might be required to place a conspicuous "DUI" bumper sticker on your car. Refuse to make your child-support payments in Virginia and you will find that your vehicle has been immobilized with an appropriately colored boot (pink if the abandoned child is a girl, blue if a boy).

— Dan M. Kahan, ["Shame Is Worth a Try"](#) (pp. 128 - 29)

There are a couple of helpful ways to think about shame. First, shame is the fear of disconnection. We are psychologically, emotionally, cognitively, and spiritually hardwired for connection, love, and belonging. Connection, along with love and belonging (two expressions of connection), is why we are

here, and it is what gives purpose and meaning to our lives. Shame is the fear of disconnection — it's the fear that something we've done or failed to do, an ideal that we've not lived up to, or a goal we have not accomplished makes us unworthy of connection. *I am not worthy or good enough for love, belonging, or connection.* I'm unlovable. I don't belong. Here's the definition of shame that emerged from my research:

Shame is the intensely painful feeling or experience of believing that we are flawed and therefore unworthy of love and belonging.

— Brené Brown, ["What Is Shame?"](#) (p. 426)

Once his teacher had “shamed” him by telling the class that he had no father, Dick Gregory found that shame was lurking around every corner, beneath his clothes, and in every public space he approached. His voice is straightforward and lucid, which gives additional power to his account of his childhood experience. In the second excerpt, Dan Kahan describes the use of shame as a different kind of social enforcer, one used purposely by the state to instill a sense of responsibility in people who violate the law. His voice is provocative and venturesome; you sense that he sees some merit in the idea of public shaming. Finally, Brené Brown voices her definition of shame, derived as it is from her research, as an “intensely painful feeling or experience” that disconnects us from all that we love. Brown is a TED Talk presenter and carries that

easy-to-listen-to voice over into her writing. Three voices: each honest, each penetrating, each purposeful.

Writing cannot exist without voice, but you weaken your voice if you do not give it proper respect and attention. To make sure your voice rings true and authentic, that it accurately reflects who you are, consider the following:

- **Understand your unique voice.** Inexperienced writers sometimes struggle with how they think they should sound — particularly in academic writing — rather than valuing the way they naturally sound. Know yourself. Write with your own voice rather than with one that sounds like someone else or one that you think your reader wants to hear. Pay attention to the ideas, values, and interests that reveal who you are and the unique way you view the world. Speak up. Don't be afraid to be heard. Writing in your own voice will make you comfortable as a writer and, just as importantly, will allow you to nurture your writing as it evolves over time.
- **Listen to your voice as often as you can.** Listening to your own voice will help you refine it and make sure that your writing is authentic. Read your writing aloud so that you get used to your voice. Ask yourself, *Is that me? Does it sound like me?* Ask yourself if the pace or speed of your prose is the way you normally sound in speech. Are you being too methodical, breezy, long-

winded, monotonous, labored, clipped, pompous, or academic? What about the rhythm of your writing? Is it similar to the way you speak? With practice, you'll be able to detect when you stray from sounding like yourself.

- **Recognize and appreciate the techniques and strategies that let your voice be heard.** A keen awareness of subject, topic, thesis, organization, diction, the interplay of abstract words with those that are concrete and specific, sentence structure, and other rhetorical devices and modes you are learning in *Models for Writers* will help you highlight the special features of your thoughts and feelings. Having a firm grasp of these and other principles discussed throughout this text will make you aware of the possibilities that they afford you in creating your own voice. For example, do you favor loose or periodic sentences? Do you tend to place your thesis statements at the beginnings or ends of paragraphs? Do you use lots of figures of speech? All of these elements can contribute to your voice as a writer.
- **Do not confuse voice with style.** Style may seem similar to voice, but it's important to understand that voice is a subset of style. For example, you may naturally write in a highly descriptive style or in a poetic style, but doing so does not tell us anything about your *voice*, how you personally go about writing. Voice explains how a particular writer expresses himself or herself within a particular style or way of writing. For example, M. Scott

Momaday's voice is unique within the category of writers we consider poetic prose stylists. Any writer can, with practice, imitate another writer's style, but your voice is your own. Be yourself and demonstrate your honesty, and your readers will recognize your authenticity.

- **Take risks.** One might think that there is little room for a fresh voice in certain kinds of writing, particularly in nonfiction writing — such as essays, reports, summaries, memos, and emails — that often necessitate reason, observation, facts, objectivity, and an obvious purpose. But it is precisely in such writing, constrained as it often is by the demands of convention, that an identifiable personal voice is both most noticed and most appreciated. Remember that creativity and freshness are always possible but should never exceed what is appropriate and in good taste. Push the limits where you can, but hold to them where you must.
- **Respect your readers.** Readers are more likely to remember and to enjoy what you have to say if they recognize the sincerity of your voice. Your voice can inform, excite, and entertain your readers, and can encourage them to see the world in new and interesting ways. Hold them in your grip with the confidence in your voice, but do nothing that violates the trust they have put in you or makes them think you are less than sincere.
- **Realize that your voice will evolve.** It is unlikely that your voice will remain static throughout your life, nor would you be happy if it did. In subtle and sometimes

dramatic ways you are changing every day, month, and year. Expect your writer's voice to reflect your personal growth and to evolve as you do. Be sensitive to those changes that enrich your special way of connecting to your readers.

*A Pleasure to Burn: One Family's Hot-Sauce
Heirloom*

Brooklyn White



Bitch Media

Brooklyn White is a writer with interests ranging from the cultural and personal significance of fashion, hair, and makeup to politics, African American culture, and women in rap. She grew up in Shreveport, Louisiana and is based in Brooklyn, New York. Her writing has been published in *Teen Vogue*, *Garage* magazine, *InStyle*, *Fashionista*, and more. Currently, she is the Senior Editor of Girls United, a mentoring initiative that aims to connect and empower a community of young black women.

The following selection was published in August 2019 in *Bitch*, a feminist magazine. This essay reveals the literal and metaphorical significance of hot sauce to White's family culture. In the essay, White's voice is revealed through a variety of strategies such as specificity of detail, colloquial dialogue, and even the incorporation of song lyrics.

Reflecting on What You Know

Do you like spicy food? Explain why or why not.

My mom ambled through my door just before midnight. She was visiting from Dallas, Texas, to see my 3-month-old daughter and preach the gospel. At 46 years old, she'd devoted herself full-time to ministry. As she relaxed her small body on the couch, she handed me her takeout box of soul food and

asked me to warm it up for her. “Do y’ all have any hot sauce?” she asked.

Damn, I didn’ t. I knew the real question, though, was whether I had any Original Louisiana Brand Hot Sauce (OLBHS). In Shreveport, Louisiana, where I grew up, my matriarchal family cared more about OLBHS than ketchup and relish — and, for that matter, than about nomadic uncles and estranged fathers. The bottle was gently laid on the table during meals, a steadfast reminder that every dish needs just a bit more heat. At birthday parties, after-church dinners, and funerals, hot sauce brought sharp comfort, much like a slick-tongued family member. Its presence let us know that our idiosyncrasies were considered, which made us feel more cared for. In my family, we joke that our babies wear vials of hot sauce around their necks to ward off evil.

In the past 20 years, hot sauce’ s popularity has been kept aflame by culture’ s torch. In 1999, Sammy Kershaw paid the ultimate homage to the only sauce that’ s “hotter than a fireball” in his song “Louisiana Hot Sauce.” Beyoncé gave a famous shout-out to hot sauce in her 2016 hit “Formation” — “I got hot sauce in my bag/ Swag” — and the red stuff has been celebrated in songs by Young M.A and Travis Scott, who croons “shake it real fast like hot sauce” in his 2016 song “Hot Sauce.” In 2016, when Hillary Clinton mentioned always carrying hot sauce with her, many saw it as a

calculated ploy to get the Black vote. According to *Quartz*, the U.S. hot-sauce market has grown by 150 percent since 2000; much of that growth has to do with changing racial and class demographics. More than half of U.S. households have hot sauce in their kitchens, and Louisiana-style hot sauce is the most popular variety sold to restaurants and food suppliers.

In my family, harming yourself is unholy, unless that harm is eyes watering from tasting hot sauce. My maternal great-grandfather, Louis Hilton White Sr., was a preacher in the Church of God in Christ. His wife, Charles Ann White, was a missionary, as were two of her daughters. My family *is* religion itself. Preaching and adhering to strict religious principles is our family's way of making life about something greater than ourselves. We aren't allowed to pierce our ears or get tattoos. But sizzling bottom lips, tingling tongues, and burning sinuses won't make St. Peter turn you away at the gates of heaven. As a fifth-generation church girl, I have learned that pain is not only inevitable but normal. After my great-aunt Jeannie's sudden death in 2010, I let religion go. She was the holiest, most stand-up woman that I have ever known, and I wondered why God would take one of the people who cared about me the most. I wanted to nothing to do with a religion so cruel.

Like my mother, aunt Jeannie was a preacher, and we spent our time together trying to understand each other. She had no idea why I was obsessed with Myspace. I wondered why she woke up every day at 5 a.m. to pray. But in my family, no matter our differences or spiritual shortcomings, we knew we could always sit down over some hot sauce - drenched Southern Classic fried chicken and fries. I know that the sting of a tattoo needle, the quick jab from a piercing gun at Claire' s, and the pain that comes from eating hot Voodoo Curse - flavored wings are the same because I' ve experienced all three. We choose these things to control our pain, to become masters of our own discomfort. Hot sauce has continuously proven that there is some inkling of similarity between all the women in my family. We are all at least a wee bit hotheaded, especially when it comes to pregnancy. During my first prenatal appointment, my ob-gyn told me to lay off of the spicy foods to avoid heartburn. At the time, I didn' t object. But with every bland meal, I increasingly regretted not pressing my doctor harder. My mother, on the other hand, told me that she' d unregrettably indulged in spicy foods when she was pregnant with my brother. So I took her advice, and had a hot link, some curry, and shrimp with hot sauce during my pregnancy. And hot red beans and rice. And piquant¹ lentils. Nearly a year without spice? C' mon, doc. Get real.

When my mother came to visit three months after I' d given birth, my fiancé and I had only been living in our apartment

for two months, and we were still rounding up the essentials. Original Louisiana Brand Hot Sauce should' ve been higher on the list. The taste for hot sauce is a gift that has grown with every generation, and as time has passed, the women in my family have become less afraid of the fire. My mother finally pierced her ears, my great-aunt Rosetta has a rosary² tattooed around her ankle, and my younger sister takes care of herself — getting over our fear of being alone and overcompensating by taking care of others. And unlike my austere and pious mother who keeps her missteps to herself, I choose to share my own screwups without the same trepidation³ because I don' t want pain to silence or shape me. I want to prove that I can stand the heat.

My mother is back in Dallas, and I' m settled into my home with my own little family. We finally bought some Original Louisiana Brand Hot Sauce. It goes on everything: popcorn, french fries, and delicate relationships. The bottle sits in my utterly-too-tiny cabinet, reminding me of aunt Jeannie and my praying mama. One day, I will give my daughter her first taste of hot sauce. Maybe it will hurt, or maybe she' ll love it so much that she' ll wear a vial of it around her neck, like a charm.

¹*piquant*: pleasantly sharp in taste.

²*rosary*: a string of beads used for counting prayers in the Catholic faith.

³*trepidation*: nervousness.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How does White' s use of colloquial dialogue and verb selection in her opening paragraph contribute to her voice in this essay?
2. In paragraph 2, how does White indicate that hot sauce was comforting to her family?
3. White' s topic sentence in paragraph 4 is “In my family, harming yourself is unholy, unless that harm is eyes watering from tasting hot sauce.” (Glossary: [Topic Sentence](#)) What does she mean by this statement?
4. How does White' s family evolve to become “less afraid of fire” (6) by the end of the essay?
5. In what way is hot sauce a family heirloom for White?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. White' s essay is rife with wordplay and literary devices. Select one instance where she uses wordplay or a literary device and evaluate whether it supports or detracts from her purpose. (Glossary: [Purpose](#))
2. What can you infer about White' s interests and personality from her voice in this essay?

3. Why do you suppose White focuses mainly on her “matriarchal family” (2)? Support your answer with specific details from the essay.

Classroom Activity Using Voice

Interview a partner about the types of foods they and their family like to eat. If you have the technology to record what they say and your instructor allows it, feel free to record what they say. (If you do record, be sure to get permission both from your instructor and from the classmate you are recording.) Next, choose one line from your interview with your partner and write down that line exactly as your partner said it; do not change the grammar, syntax or put the statement in your own words. Now write a paragraph that describes what is unique about what your partner said and about how they said it. Finally, as a class, discuss what you learned about voice from this activity.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write a short essay about your voice as a writer. To do this, consider writing paragraphs about two or

more of the following topics. After writing paragraphs about two or more of these topics, write a concluding paragraph that summarizes the qualities of your voice.

- What does your voice sound like literally? Do you have an accent? Do you use standard written English grammar or do you have to code-switch (change your language) in school? Is your voice high pitched or deep? Do you use certain phrases repeatedly when you talk?
 - What is your culture of origin and how does it impact the way you speak and write? Do people generally praise your writing or say that it needs work?
 - What ideas or subjects do you often think about?
 - What is the number one way that you feel that you are different from many other people?
 - What is your overall attitude toward life? What examples from your own life or way of being reveal that attitude?
2. Using White' s essay as an example, write an essay about an object in your life that has metaphorical significance. As you write, pay attention to ways you can showcase your unique voice.

Curate

Wilfred McClay



Courtesy of Julie Holt McClay

Wilfred McClay is a U.S. historian who received his undergraduate degree in 1974 from St. John's College, known

for curriculum centered on the study of foundational books in Western culture. In 1987 he received his PhD from Johns Hopkins University, one of several universities where he has taught. At the University of Oklahoma, he became G.T. and Libby Blankenship Chair in the History of Liberty and director of the Center for the History of Liberty. McClay has written and edited books on ethics, humanities, and intellectual history, including *The Masterless: Self and Society in Modern America* (1994), *A Student's Guide to U.S. History* (2000), *Figures in the Carpet: Finding the Human Person in the American Past* (2007), *Why Place Matters: Geography, Identity and Civic Life in Modern America* (2014), and *Land of Hope: An Invitation to the Great American Story* (2019). He has also written numerous articles including "Beyond the Right to Life," (*The New Atlantis*, 2006), "Obama's Middle Eastern Policy and the 2012 Election," (*The Jerusalem Review*, 2012) and "Uncomfortable Belief" (*First Things*, 2018).

The following essay was originally published in *The Hedgehog Review* — a publication of the University of Virginia's Institute for Advanced Studies in Culture — in the spring of 2018. With an erudite and analytical voice, McClay describes his reaction to the use of the word *curate* in contemporary culture. In his view, people use the word because it shows refinement and engenders a perceived respect from those who hear it.

Reflecting on What You Know

Think of a word that you use often. Why do you think you use it so much? Do other people use this word as often as you do?

I last encountered the “c” word on a visit to a recently opened independent bookstore, an immensely agreeable place where a lover of books could wile away many delightful hours. Like any bibliophile,¹ I am inclined to hail the mere survival of such stores with a champagne toast, and to greet the creation of new ones as a token, however faint, of civilizational recovery. I also tend to rate the people running such establishments among the real heroes of our time. So at the risk of sounding even the least bit ungracious toward the owners of this particular store, I must confess to being somewhat taken aback by publicity materials that described their inventory as “thoughtfully curated.” Those slightly smug and self-congratulatory words made me wince. Book lovers ought to be word lovers too, and this usage felt all wrong, its intrusion into this happy scene a microbetrayal.

I suspect that my strong reaction was spurred by a more general problem. In the demimonde² of Facebook and the like, everyone is in the public relations racket, and everyday life takes on the texture of a real-estate commercial, with constant inflation of language and imagery in the service of

self-presentation. Why is it no longer enough to say that a store stocks a fine assortment of important and interesting titles? Is “selection” not a fancy enough word anymore? Does it not convey in plain and accessible English the central idea — that this is not a Barnes and Noble or any other cookie-cutter franchise operation, but that the proprietors have instead exercised independent taste and judgment in assembling their offerings? Why do we need to have the pretentious and mystifying notion or “curation” drifting in and fogging up the air?

“Curation” lends to the proceedings a certain air of quasi-professionalism. It seeks to claim for the proprietors an exquisitely refined faculty of discrimination, a sense that “objective” higher standards are being enacted and adhered to. The selection that has been made, we are being assured, was not a product of whim or fancy, let alone crass commercialism. It reflects deep wisdom and heightened competence, a sensibility like that of the museum curator or wealthy collector, or the sommelier³ who truly knows his wines, rather than the all-too-human idiosyncrasy of enthusiastic but uncredentialed amateurs offering the reading public an assortment of “books we like, and that we hope you will like too.” And, as the word’s allusion to museums and museum work subtly suggests, the use of “curate” carries overtones of social climbing, of seeking to associate oneself

with the “better sort” of people — tasteful, knowledgeable, attractive, suave, well-to-do.

Perhaps this reaction seems petty and ungenerous. But the sudden ubiquity of the verb “curate” gives one the feeling that a sort of linguistic occupation force crept in and took over in the dead of night. It is as if everyone else went to a workshop on the subject while you were fast asleep, and then you awoke, like Rip Van Winkle,⁴ to a changed world, full of new locutions⁵ you were expected to adopt instantly, without the benefit of explanation or justification. When, and why, did break-ins become “home invasions”? When, and why, did the weatherman begin referring to rain and snow as “precipitation events”? When and how did hotel rooms come to be described as “breakout”? (And should one take extra care to secure one’s possessions if one stays in such a room?) To live in this century is to be asking such questions all the time.

I am all for the vitality of spontaneous linguistic creativity, as we see it in the constant adaption and development of slang. That fountain of invention is the energy of life itself. But there is nothing spontaneous or winsome⁶ about this other kind of change. It is prescriptivism⁷ with a vengeance. These awkward and abstract ways of expressing things are impositions upon the language. They have the same feel to them as the array of politically

correct euphemisms — “differently abled,” or “visually impaired,” or “sanitation engineer,” or pick your own — with which we are constantly being badgered. These days, the breaking wheel of language revision never seems to stop turning. Whether these innovations proceed from a cultural-political agenda desirous of controlling discourse, or merely from a modern compulsion to invent jargon as a way of marking off social territory and driving away poachers, one always feels, when forced to adopt them, as if one is being fitted for braces, or lined up dutifully for a third-grade class photo.

But “curate” is a little different. It is not a word imposed, but one adopted eagerly, even anxiously, by those who use it, because it bestows the prestige of cultivation, learning, and *esprit de finesse* upon activities that might otherwise seem plain and unexceptional, even vulgar. This is a game that more and more want to play. Caesar’s Palace in Las Vegas recently announced the renovation of its Palace Tower, featuring décor “curated by top designers.”

“Curation” is a dressing-up intensifier, serving the same function in our current speech as the adjectival heel lift supplied by “artisanal” cheeses or “craft” coffee.

Sprinkle the fairy dust of high-sounding words over the ungainly contours⁸ of something quite ordinary, and you may be able to transform it into something special, in the way

that a gentle snowfall can turn an ugly tool shed into a dreamy cottage, inhabited by elves. Even if you are running a thrift shop — and yes, it is not hard to find proprietors of thrift shops who identify themselves as “curators” of their establishments — you too can boast that your shop’s contents are “thoughtfully curated.” That sounds a whole lot better than saying “We don’t take used underwear or stuff that has holes in it.” But there is a lot to be said for respecting and loving ordinary things on their own terms, seeing that they are beautiful even without makeup, rather than always trying to tart them up into something grand and gilded.⁹

But to be fair, there is another element folded into the meaning of “curate,” one running deep but not readily visible, that may also explain some of its appeal. The word derives from the Latin *curare*, to take care, and has in its historical ancestry the notion of a “curate” as one who is charged with the care of souls. This more spiritual meaning survives here and there, as for example in the “curate” of an Anglican parish church; and the faint aura of it surely still remains a part of the word we use to describe the museum professional. The religion of art persists, after all, as witness the flocks of culture-vultures that stream into our galleries on Sundays, standing in long lines to perform their spiritual duties. Perhaps in some instances, such as that of the independent bookstore, it can even be said that

the “thoughtful curation” of the inventory reflects an attentiveness to the needs of the soul. One earnestly wants it to be so.

But the word “curate” itself may be too corrupted by misuse to be able to carry such larger meanings much longer. As in so many other respects, Silicon Valley leads the way. It is now commonplace to speak of “social curation,” which means something akin to “the wisdom of the crowd,” the belief that the most meaningful way of sorting through and selecting and organizing masses of data is by the aggregation of the opinions and tastes of millions of completely independent individuals. There is a good deal to be said for this view, but the process it describes is the very opposite of curation itself, a word that, if it is to mean anything at all, means the application of a conscious sensibility and organizing intelligence. The spirit of curation resides in the saying that one man plus the truth makes a majority. The spirit of “social” curation is the belief, well captured in the title of a best-selling 1959 record album, that “50,000,000 Elvis Fans Can’ t Be Wrong.”

Which may well be true. But when we start calling all those Elvis fans curators, then that’ s a sure sign that “curation” has left the building.

¹ *bibliophile*: a lover of books.

²*demimonde*: a separate world with a bad reputation.

³*sommelier*: a restaurant waiter or server who is knowledgeable about wine.

⁴ *Rip Van Winkle*: character in a short story of the same name by Washington Irving (1783–1859) who falls asleep and wakes up twenty years later.

⁵*locutions*: words or expressions typical of a specific culture or group.

⁶*winsome*: pleasing.

⁷*prescriptivism*: in language studies, the belief that one variation of a language is superior to others.

⁸ *ungainly countours*: rough edges.

⁹*gilded*: coated with gold.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Why, in paragraph 1, does McClay wince at the description of an independent bookstore as “carefully curated” ?
2. What does McClay mean by “the demimonde of Facebook and the like” (2)? In his view, what has been the impact of social media on language and imagery? What does this type of language reveal about McClay’ s voice as a writer?

3. In paragraph 3, McClay indicates that *curation* is often associated with what careers? What does his knowledge about and mention of these careers indicate about him?
4. In paragraph 8, McClay explores the spiritual dimension of the word *curate* by describing the word's Latin etymology. How does this description relate to the larger point he is making about the word?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Find one instance in the text where McClay's voice can be described as playful. Find one instance where it can be described as scholarly. Do you feel that McClay presents a unified voice in this essay? Why or why not?
2. What can you infer about McClay's interests and personality from his voice in this essay?
3. In paragraph 3, McClay writes about his ideal bookstore, which is not "curated" but instead is organized by uncredentialed amateurs. However, his biography reveals that he is a significantly credentialed professional. Does the contrast between what McClay wants in a bookstore and the values he embodies professionally impact the success of his

essay? Is there anything about his essay that feels *curated* to you? Explain your answers.

Classroom Activity Using Voice

In a small group with two or three classmates, collect three to five objects from around the classroom or from fellow group members. Together, curate a mini art exhibit of these objects. Exhibit them on or near one of the group member's desks, attending to a possible meaning of the objects' arrangement. For example, if each group member has a red pen, your group might curate an exhibit of red pens arranged in a square to represent frustration over teacher feedback — or you could stack your phones under a desk to make a comment about technological distraction.

Next, as a class, gather by each exhibit and discuss possible messages of each curatorial team (without the team explaining themselves). Then discuss the voice (personality) that comes through in each exhibit. Think about location, repetition, and the shape of objects when thinking about the voice of the exhibit. Is the voice playful, serious, logical, comedic, belligerent, disparaging, forceful or something else? What about the

exhibit makes you label the voice as you do? If you can't label the voice of the exhibit, why do you think you can't?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write a short essay that analyzes your voice in an essay you have already written (it can be an essay for this course or for another course). In your analysis, you may examine any of the following elements and explain how each element works to reveal your unique voice: themes, tone, attitude, organizational patterns, sentence structures, diction, grammar, and punctuation.
2. Write a short essay in which you analyze a word of your choice. You may use a word in the dictionary, a slang word, or a word in a language other than English that is important to you. Each body paragraph should explore a different meaning or association you have with the word or commentary you would like to make about the word. Be sure to include a specific thesis statement and topic sentences in each paragraph. (Glossary: Thesis; Topic Sentence)

We Should All Be Feminists

Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie



rune hellestad/Getty Images

Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie was born in 1977 in Nigeria, where she was raised in the house that had formerly been occupied

by famous Nigerian writer Chinua Achebe. Her father, the country's first professor of statistics, taught at the University of Nigeria, and her mother was the first female registrar at the university. Adichie excelled in her studies of medicine and pharmacy while also editing the campus medical student magazine, *The Compass*. Eventually, she left Nigeria for the United States to study at Drexel University in Philadelphia, transferring later to Eastern Connecticut University and eventually receiving a master's degree in creative writing from Johns Hopkins University. While Adichie was still an undergraduate, she began working on her first novel, *Purple Hibiscus*, which was released late in 2003 and earned her the Commonwealth Writer's Prize: Best First Book. Her other books include *Half of a Yellow Sun* (2006), *The Thing Around Your Neck* (2009), and *Americanah* (2013). She has received numerous awards and recognitions, including a MacArthur Foundation "Genius Grant" in 2008.

In this essay, adapted from her acclaimed TED Talk titled "We Should All Be Feminists," Adichie speaks about the negative connotations she has confronted surrounding the word "feminist." Her voice is revealed clearly throughout the essay, as she confronts in plain terms and everyday examples the oppression of women and the role that gender plays in society. As you read, notice how Adichie's sentence structure and conversational tone contribute to her voice as a writer.

Reflecting on What You Know

What does the word “feminism” mean to you? Do you consider yourself a feminist? Why or why not?

We do a great disservice to boys in how we raise them. We stifle the humanity of boys. We define masculinity in a *very* narrow way. Masculinity is a hard, small cage, and we put boys inside this cage. We teach boys to be afraid of fear, of weakness, of vulnerability. We teach them to mask their true selves, because they have to be, in Nigerian-speak, a *hard man*. In secondary school, a boy and a girl go out, both of them teenagers with meager pocket money. Yet the boy is expected to pay the bills, always, to prove his masculinity. (And we wonder why boys are more likely to steal money from their parents.)

What if both boys and girls were raised *not* to link masculinity and money? What if their attitude was not “the boy has to pay,” but rather, “whoever has more should pay”? Of course, because of their historical advantage, it is mostly men who *will* have more today. But if we start raising children differently, then in fifty years, in a hundred years, boys will no longer have the pressure of proving their masculinity by material means.

But by far the worst thing we do to males — by making them feel they have to be hard — is that we leave them with *very*

fragile egos. The *harder* a man feels compelled to be, the weaker his ego is. And then we do a much greater disservice to girls, because we raise them to cater to the fragile egos¹ of males. We teach girls to shrink themselves, to make themselves smaller. We say to girls, “You can have ambition, but not too much. You should aim to be successful but not too successful, otherwise you will threaten the man. If you are the breadwinner in your relationship with a man, pretend that you are not, especially in public, otherwise you will emasculate him.”

But what if we question the premise² itself? Why should a woman’s success be a threat to a man? What if we decide to simply dispose of that word — and I don’t know if there is an English word I dislike more than this — *emasculation*.

A Nigerian acquaintance once asked me if I was worried that men would be intimidated by me. I was not worried at all — it had not even occurred to me to be worried, because a man who would be intimidated by me is exactly the kind of man I would have no interest in.

Still, I was struck by this. Because I am female, I’m expected to aspire to marriage. I am expected to make my life choices always keeping in mind that marriage is the most important. Marriage can be a good thing, a source of joy, love and mutual support. But why do we teach girls to aspire

to marriage, yet we don' t teach boys to do the same? I know a Nigerian woman who decided to sell her house because she didn' t want to intimidate a man who might want to marry her. I know an unmarried woman in Nigeria who, when she goes to conferences, wears a wedding ring because she wants her colleagues to — according to her — “give her respect.” The sadness in this is that a wedding ring will indeed automatically make her seem worthy of respect, while not wearing a wedding ring would make her easily dismissible — and this is in a modern workplace. I know young women who are under so much pressure — from family, from friends, even from work — to get married that they are pushed to make terrible choices. Our society teaches a woman at a certain age who is unmarried to see it as a deep personal failure. While a man at a certain age who is unmarried has not quite come around to making his pick.

It is easy to say, “But women can just say no to all this.” But the reality is more difficult, more complex. We are all social beings. We internalize ideas from our socialization. Even the language we use illustrates this. The language of marriage is often a language of ownership, not a language of partnership. We use the word *respect* for something a woman shows a man, but not often for something a man shows a woman. Both men and women will say, “I did it for peace in my marriage.” When men say it, it is usually about something they should not be doing anyway. Something they say to their

friends in a fondly exasperated way, something that ultimately proves to them their masculinity — “Oh, my wife said I can’ t go to clubs every night, so now, for peace in my marriage, I go only on weekends.” When women say “I did it for peace in my marriage,” it is usually because they have given up a job, a career goal, a dream.

We teach females that in relationships, compromise is what a woman is more likely to do. We raise girls to see each other as competitors — not for jobs or accomplishments, which in my opinion can be a good thing, but for the attention of men. We teach girls that they cannot be sexual beings in the way boys are. If we have sons, we don’ t mind knowing about their girlfriends. But our daughters’ boyfriends? God forbid. (But we of course expect them to bring home the perfect man for marriage when the time is right.)

We police girls. We praise girls for virginity but we don’ t praise boys for virginity (and it makes me wonder how exactly this is supposed to work out, since the loss of virginity is a process that usually involves two people of opposite genders). Recently a young woman was gang-raped in a university in Nigeria, and the response of many young Nigerians, both male and female, was something like this:

“Yes, rape is wrong, but what is a girl doing in a room with four boys?”

Let us, if we can, forget the horrible inhumanity of that response. These Nigerians have been raised to think of women as inherently guilty. And they have been raised to expect so little of men that the idea of men as savage beings with no self-control is somehow acceptable.

We teach girls shame. *Close your legs. Cover yourself.* We make them feel as though by being born female, they are already guilty of something. And so girls grow up to be women who cannot say they have desire. Who silence themselves. Who cannot say what they truly think. Who have turned pretence into an art form. I know a woman who hates domestic work, but she pretends that she likes it, because she has been taught that to be “good wife material,” she has to be — to use that Nigerian word — *homely*. And then she got married. And her husband’s family began to complain that she had changed. Actually, she had not changed. She just got tired of pretending to be what she was not.

The problem with gender is that it prescribes how we *should* be rather than recognizing how we are. Imagine how much happier we would be, how much freer to be our true individual selves, if we didn’t have the weight of gender expectations.

¹*ego*: a person’s opinion of himself or herself.

²*premise*: an unstated argument or assumed position.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Adichie argues that the current definition of masculinity is a “hard, small cage” (paragraph 1). How does she support this statement?
2. Adichie says that men are required to be “hard,” yet doing so weakens their ego. How does this happen? What examples does she use to support her statement?
3. Analyze Adichie’s sentences in paragraph 3. How does she use sentence structure to heighten a sense of contrast between our treatment of genders?
4. Why does Adichie dislike the word “emasculatation” (4) so much?
5. In paragraph 6, Adichie repeats the phrase “I know” How does repetition of this phrase help her make her point? What other examples of repetition can you find in her writing? (Glossary: [Repetition](#); [Parallelism](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Adichie concludes, “Imagine how much happier we would be, how much freer to be our true individual selves, if we didn’t have the weight of gender expectations” (12). What does she mean by this? Do

the examples she uses effectively convey the “weight” of gender expectations? Explain.

2. Adichie says that the language of marriage is a “language of ownership, not a language of partnership” (7). What examples does she give to support this? Can you think of other examples that she does not use?
3. This essay was originally adapted from a speech. What aspects of Adichie’s sentence structure seem more reflective of oral communication than written communication? Do you think Adichie’s voice would come across differently if she had written the essay originally, rather than adapting it from a speech? Why or why not? Provide specific examples.

Classroom Activity Using Voice

Mark the sentences in Adichie’s article according to what different types and devices she uses: long or short sentences, periodic or loose sentences, subordination, coordination, and parallelism. Make the markup visual to illuminate patterns or tendencies in her writing. Try highlighting in different colors or using a mixture of solid underlining or dashes. How often does Adichie use active voice, and when does she use the passive voice? When you are finished, what can you say about Adichie’s

voice based on her sentences? Is there a trend? Discuss your results with others in your class. Talk about how you can use similar techniques in your own essays.

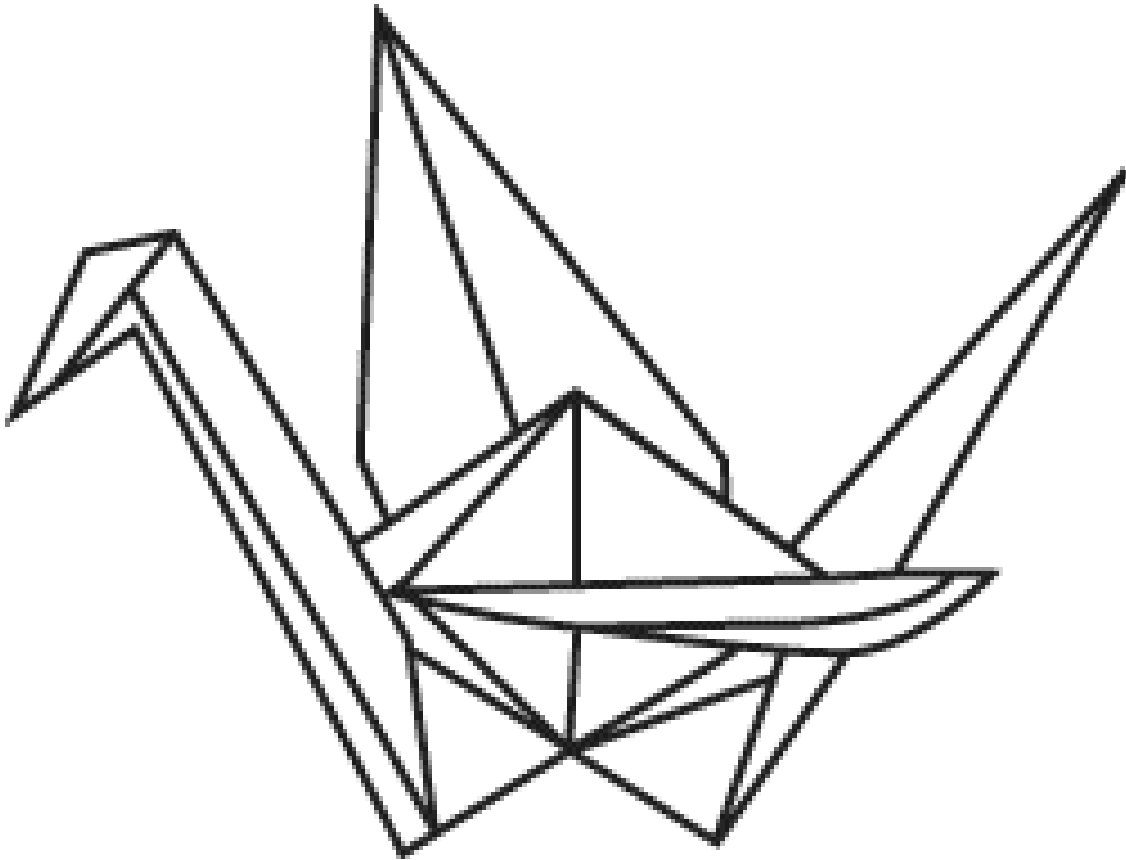
Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Adichie is concerned with how men and women are affected by gender stereotypes. In what ways have you been affected by cultural expectations of the roles men and women should play? Write an essay in which you examine how you have rejected or resisted cultural expectations about gender. Supply specific details to support your thesis. (Glossary: [Thesis](#)) As you write, pay attention to ensure that your unique voice comes through in your essay.
2. One of Adichie's controlling ideas is that not only will women benefit from feminism, but men will, too. Consider the points she makes about gender roles that men are forced to conform to and how her examples support the argument that feminism will free men as well as women from stereotypical expectations. Write an essay in which you argue that men will or will not benefit from feminism. You may wish to watch Adichie's TED Talk online, called "We Should All Be Feminists," to get a fuller understanding of her argument. As you write, read one or more of your

paragraphs aloud to make sure that your writing and your argument reflect your authentic voice.



CHAPTER 12 Diction and Tone



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DICTION

Diction refers to a writer's choice and use of words. Good diction is precise and appropriate: the words mean exactly what the writer intends, and the words are well suited to the writer's subject, purpose, and intended audience.

Careful writers do not merely come close to saying what they want to say; rather, they select words that convey their exact meaning. Perhaps Mark Twain put this idea best when he said, "The difference between the right word and the almost right word is the difference between lightning and the lightning bug." Inaccurate, imprecise, or inappropriate diction fails to convey the writer's intended meaning and may cause confusion and misunderstanding for the reader.

Connotation and Denotation

Both connotation and denotation refer to the meanings of words. Denotation is the dictionary meaning of a word — its literal meaning. Connotative meanings are the associations or emotional overtones that words have acquired. For example, the word *home* denotes a place where someone lives, but it connotes warmth, security, family, comfort, affection, and other more private thoughts and images. The word *residence*

also denotes a place where someone lives, but its connotations are legal, colder, and more formal.

Many words in English have synonyms, or words with very similar denotations — for example, *mob*, *crowd*, *multitude*, and *bunch*. Deciding which to use depends largely on the connotations of each synonym and the context in which the word is to be used. For example, you might say, “There was a crowd at the lecture,” but not “There was a mob at the lecture.” Good writers are sensitive to both the denotations and the connotations of words.

Abstract and Concrete Words

Abstract words name ideas, conditions, and emotions — things nobody can touch, see, or hear. Some abstract words are *love*, *wisdom*, *cowardice*, *beauty*, *fear*, and *liberty*. People often disagree about abstract things. You might find a forest beautiful, whereas someone else might find it frightening — and neither of you would be wrong. Beauty and fear are ideas; they exist in your mind. Concrete words refer to things we can touch, see, hear, smell, and taste, such as *sandpaper*, *soda*, *birch tree*, *smog*, *cow*, *sailboat*, *rocking chair*, and *pancake*. If you disagree with someone on a concrete issue — for example, you claim that the forest is mostly birch trees, whereas the other person says it is

mostly pine — only one of you can be right, and both of you can be wrong; the kinds of trees that grow in the forest is a concrete fact, not an abstract idea.

Good writing balances ideas and facts, and it also balances abstract and concrete diction. If the writing is too abstract and has too few concrete facts and details, it will be unconvincing and tiresome. If the writing is too concrete and devoid of abstract ideas and emotions, it will seem mundane and dry.

General and Specific Words

General and specific do not necessarily refer to opposites. The same word can often be either general or specific, depending on the context: *Dessert* is more specific than *food* but more general than *chocolate cream pie*. Being specific is like being concrete: chocolate cream pie is something you can see and taste. Being general, on the other hand, is like being abstract. Food, dessert, and even pie are large classes of things that bring to mind only general tastes or images.

Good writing moves back and forth from the general to the specific. Without specific words, generalities can be unconvincing and even confusing: the writer's idea of "good food" may be very different from the reader's. But writing

that does not connect its specific details to each other through generalization often lacks focus and direction.

Clichés

A word, phrase, or expression that has become trite through overuse is called a cliché. Let's assume your roommate has just returned from an evening out. You ask her, "How was the concert?" She responds, "The concert was okay, but they had us *packed in there like sardines*. How was your evening?" And you reply, "Well, I finished my term paper, but the noise here is enough to *drive me crazy*. The dorm is a real *zoo*." The italicized expressions were once vivid and colorful, but through constant use they have grown stale and ineffective. Experienced writers always try to avoid such clichés as *believe it or not*, *at the end of the day*, *the bottom line is*, *last but not least*, *hits the spot*, *let's face it*, *sneaking suspicion*, *step in the right direction*, and *went to great lengths*. They strive to use fresh language.

Jargon

Jargon, or technical language, is the special vocabulary of a trade or profession. Writers use jargon with an awareness of their audience. If their audience is a group of co-workers or professionals, jargon may be used freely. If the audience

is general, jargon should be used sparingly and carefully so that readers can understand it. Jargon becomes inappropriate when it is overused, used out of context, or used pretentiously. For example, computer terms like *input*, *output*, and *feedback* are sometimes used in place of *contribution*, *result*, and *response* in other fields, especially in business. Using computer jargon outside of talking about computers may be excluding or dehumanizing. For example, if a manager asks her direct report what his “output” has been for the past year, she may be implying that he is only a machine that receives and processes information according to a program, not an individual contributing to the company.

Formal and Informal Diction

Diction is appropriate when it suits the occasion for which it is intended. If the situation is informal — a friendly email, for example — the writing may be colloquial; that is, its words may be chosen to suggest the way people talk with one another. If, on the other hand, the situation is formal — an academic paper or a research report, for example — the words should reflect this formality. Informal writing tends to be characterized by slang, contractions, references to the reader, and concrete nouns. Formal writing tends to be impersonal, abstract, and free of contractions and references

to the reader. Formal writing and informal writing are the extremes. Most writing falls between the two and is a blend of the formal and informal elements that best fit the context.

TONE

Tone is the attitude a writer takes toward the subject and the audience. Tone is conveyed by the voice we use to express ourselves in our writing. The tone may be friendly, hostile, bitter, sarcastic, angry, serious, mocking, whimsical, humorous, enthusiastic, skeptical, indifferent, facetious, sad, and so on.

As you read the following paragraphs, notice how each writer creates a different tone and how that tone is supported by the diction — the writer's particular choice and use of words.

Nostalgic

When I was six years old, I thought I knew a lot. How to jump rope, how to skip a rock across a pond, and how to color and stay between the lines — these were all things I took great pride in. Nothing was difficult, and my days were carefree. That is, until the summer when everything became complicated and I suddenly realized I didn't know that much.

— Heather C. Blue, student

Angry

That man over there says that women need to be helped into carriages, and lifted over ditches, and to have the best place everywhere. Nobody ever helps me into carriages, or over mud-puddles, or gives me any best place! And ain' t I a woman? Look at me! Look at my arm! I have ploughed and planted, and gathered into barns, and no man could head me! And ain' t I a woman? I could work as much and eat as much as a man — when I could get it — and bear the lash as well! And ain' t I a woman? I have borne thirteen children, and seen them most all sold off to slavery, and when I cried out with my mother' s grief, none but Jesus heard me! And ain' t I a woman?

- Sojourner Truth, “Ain' t I a Woman?”

Sarcastic

Ultimately, the plutocratic takeover of rural America has a downside for the wealthy too. The more expensive a resort town gets, the farther its workers have to commute to keep it functioning. And if your heart doesn' t bleed for the dishwasher or landscaper who commutes two to four hours a day, at least shed a tear for the wealthy vacationer who gets stuck in the ensuing traffic. It' s bumper to bumper westbound out of Telluride, Colorado, every day at 5, or eastbound on Route 1 out of Key West, for the Lexuses as well as the beat-up old pickup trucks.

- Barbara Ehrenreich, “This Land Is Their Land”

Objective or Academic

In 2006 an American big-game hunter from Idaho shot and killed the first documented wild polar-grizzly bear hybrid, a mostly white male covered in patches of brown fur with long grizzly-like claws, a humped back, and eyes ringed by black skin... Brendan Kelly, then an Alaska-based biologist with the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, started to wonder which other species might be interbreeding as a result of a changing Arctic landscape.

- Katherine Bagley, "Climate Change Is Causing Some Mixed-Up Wildlife"

Business or Professional

The renovation of the County Courthouse is progressing on schedule and within budget. Although the cost of certain materials is higher than our original bid indicated, we expect to complete the project without exceeding the estimated costs because the speed with which the project is being completed will reduce overall labor expenses.

- Tran Nuguélen, project engineer

Dramatic

Every day you walk on it, your baby crawls across it, and your dog rolls around on it. Your child may accidentally drop a piece of candy on it and eat the candy anyway. All the while you are unaware that your floor is made with a toxic chemical that has proven to cause various types of cancer and other serious health risks. Vinyl flooring — one of today's most

affordable, durable, and easily installed flooring options —
is manufactured using vinyl chloride.

-Mina Raine, student

Irony

Once upon a time there was a small, beautiful, green and graceful country called Vietnam. It needed to be saved. (In later years no one could remember exactly what it needed to be saved from, but that is another story.) For many years Vietnam was in the process of being saved by France, but the French eventually tired of their labors and left. Then America took on the job. America was well equipped for country saving. It was the richest and most powerful nation on earth. It had, for example, nuclear explosives on hand and ready to use equal to six tons of TNT for every man, woman, and child in the world. It had huge and very efficient factories, brilliant and dedicated scientists, and most (but not everybody) would agree, it had good intentions. Sadly, America had one fatal flaw — its inhabitants were in love with technology and thought it could do no wrong. A visitor to America during the time of this story would probably have guessed its outcome after seeing how its inhabitants were treating their own country. The air was mostly foul, the water putrid, and most of the land was either covered with concrete or garbage. But Americans were never much on introspection, and they didn't foresee the result of their loving embrace on the small country. They set out to save Vietnam with the same enthusiasm and determination their forefathers had displayed in conquering the frontier.

- The Sierra Club, "Vietnam Defoliation: A Fable for Our Times"

The diction and tone of an essay are subtle forces, but they exert a tremendous influence on readers. They are instrumental in determining how we will feel while reading an essay and what attitude we will have toward its argument or the points it makes. Readers react in a variety of ways. An essay written informally but with a largely angry tone may make one reader defensive and unsympathetic; another may believe that the author is being unusually honest and courageous and may admire these qualities and feel moved by them. Either way, the diction and tone of the piece have made a strong emotional impression. As you read the essays in this chapter and throughout this book, see if you can analyze how the diction and tone shape your reactions.

Me Talk Pretty One Day

David Sedaris



Ralph Orlowski/Getty Images

David Sedaris was born in 1956 in Binghamton, New York, and grew up in Raleigh, North Carolina. He briefly attended

Western Carolina University and Kent State University but ultimately graduated from the Art Institute of Chicago in 1987. Before becoming a writer, Sedaris worked as a mover, an office temp, a housekeeper, and an elf in a department store Christmas display — an experience he wrote about in his celebrated essay “Santaland Diaries.” He has contributed to National Public Radio, *Harper’s*, *Details*, *The New Yorker*, and *Esquire* and has won several awards, including the James Thurber Prize for American Humor. Sedaris often writes about his quirky Greek family and his travels with his partner, Hugh Hamrick, with whom he currently lives in London. His essays and stories have been collected in several best-selling books, including *Barrel Fever* (1994), *Holidays on Ice* (1997), *Naked* (1997), *Dress Your Family in Corduroy and Denim* (2004), *When You Are Engulfed in Flames* (2008), *Squirrel Seeks Chipmunk: A Modest Bestiary* (2010), and *Let’s Explore Diabetes with Owls* (2013), whose audio version was nominated for a Grammy Award for Best Spoken Word Album.

The following essay about taking French lessons in Paris first appeared in *Esquire* in March 1999 and later became the title piece for Sedaris’s fourth book, *Me Talk Pretty One Day* (2000). As you read, pay attention to how he uses his words to play with the ideas of language, understanding, and belonging.

Reflecting on What You Know

Have you ever been in a situation in which you did not speak the prevalent language — for example, in a foreign country, in a language class, or among a group of people who spoke a language other than yours? How did you feel about not being able to communicate? How, if at all, did you get your thoughts across to others?

At the age of forty-one, I am returning to school and having to think of myself as what my French textbook calls “a true debutant.” After paying my tuition, I was issued a student ID, which allows me a discounted entry fee at movie theaters, puppet shows, and Festyland, a far-flung amusement park that advertises with billboards picturing a cartoon stegosaurus sitting in a canoe and eating what appears to be a ham sandwich.

I’ ve moved to Paris in order to learn the language. My school is the Alliance Française, and on the first day of class, I arrived early, watching as the returning students greeted one another in the school lobby. Vacations were recounted, and questions were raised concerning mutual friends with names like Kang and Vlatnya. Regardless of their nationalities, everyone spoke what sounded to me like excellent French. Some accents were better than others, but the students exhibited an ease and confidence I found intimidating. As an added discomfort, they were all young,

attractive, and well dressed, causing me to feel not unlike Pa Kettle¹ trapped backstage after a fashion show.

I remind myself that I am now a full-grown man. No one will ever again card me for a drink or demand that I weave a floor mat out of newspapers. At my age, a reasonable person should have completed his sentence in the prison of the nervous and the insecure — isn' t that the great promise of adulthood? I can' t help but think that, somewhere along the way, I made a wrong turn. My fears have not vanished. Rather, they have seasoned and multiplied with age. I am now twice as frightened as I was when, at the age of twenty, I allowed a failed nursing student to inject me with a horse tranquilizer, and eight times more anxious than I was the day my kindergarten teacher pried my fingers off my mother' s ankle and led me screaming toward my desk. "You' ll get used to it," the woman had said.

I' m still waiting.

The first day of class was nerve-racking because I knew I' d be expected to perform. That' s the way they do it here — everyone into the language pool, sink or swim. The teacher marched in, deeply tanned from a recent vacation, and rattled off a series of administrative announcements. I' ve spent some time in Normandy,² and I took a monthlong French class

last summer in New York. I' m not completely in the dark, yet I understood only half of what this teacher was saying.

“If you have not *meismslsxp* by this time, you should not be in this room. Has everybody *apzkiubjxow*? Everyone? Good, we shall proceed.” She spread out her lesson plan and sighed, saying, “All right, then, who knows the alphabet?”

It was startling because a) I hadn' t been asked that question in a while, and b) I realized, while laughing, that I myself did not know the alphabet. They' re the same letters, but they' re pronounced differently.

“Ahh.” The teacher went to the board and sketched the letter *A*. “Do we have anyone in the room whose first name commences with an ahh?”

Two Polish Annas raised their hands, and the teacher instructed them to present themselves, giving their names, nationalities, occupations, and a list of things they liked and disliked in this world. The first Anna hailed from an industrial town outside of Warsaw and had front teeth the size of tombstones. She worked as a seamstress, enjoyed quiet times with friends, and hated the mosquito.

“Oh, really,” the teacher said. “How very interesting. I thought that everyone loved the mosquito, but here, in front

of all the world, you claim to detest him. How is it that we' ve been blessed with someone as unique and original as you? Tell us, please. ”

The seamstress did not understand what was being said, but she knew that this was an occasion for shame. Her rabbit mouth huffed for breath, and she stared down at her lap as though the appropriate comeback were stitched somewhere alongside the zipper of her slacks.

The second Anna learned from the first and claimed to love sunshine and detest lies. It sounded like a translation of one of those Playmate of the Month data sheets, the answers always written in the same loopy handwriting: “Turn-ons: Mom’ s famous five-alarm chili! Turnoffs: Insincerity and guys who come on too strong!!!”

The two Polish women surely had clear notions of what they liked and disliked, but, like the rest of us, they were limited in terms of vocabulary, and this made them appear less than sophisticated. The teacher forged on, and we learned that Carlos, the Argentine bandoneon³ player, loved wine, music, and, in his words, “Making sex with the women of the world.” Next came a beautiful young Yugoslavian who identified herself as an optimist, saying that she loved everything life had to offer.

The teacher licked her lips, revealing a hint of the sadist⁴ we would later come to know. She crouched low for her attack, placed her hands on the young woman's desk, and said, "Oh, yeah? And do you love your little war?"⁵

While the optimist struggled to defend herself, I scrambled to think of an answer to what had obviously become a trick question. How often are you asked what you love in this world? More important, how often are you asked and then publicly ridiculed for your answer? I recalled my mother, flushed with wine, pounding the table late one night, saying, "Love? I love a good steak cooked rare. I love my cat, and I love ..." My sisters and I leaned forward, waiting to hear our names. "Tums," our mother said. "I love Tums." The teacher killed some time accusing the Yugoslavian girl of masterminding a program of genocide, and I jotted frantic notes in the margins of my pad. While I can honestly say that I love leafing through medical textbooks devoted to severe dermatological conditions, it is beyond the reach of my French vocabulary, and acting it out would only have invited unwanted attention.

When called upon, I delivered an effortless list of things I detest: blood sausage, intestinal paté, brain pudding. I'd learned these words the hard way. Having given it some thought, I then declared my love for IBM typewriters, the French word for "bruise," and my electric floor waxer. It

was a short list, but still I managed to mispronounce IBM and afford the wrong gender to both the floor waxer and the typewriter. Her reaction led me to believe that these mistakes were capital crimes in the country of France.

“Were you always this *palicmkrexjs*?” she asked. “Even a *fiuscrzsws tociwegixp* knows that a typewriter is feminine.”

I absorbed as much of her abuse as I could understand, thinking, but not saying, that I find it ridiculous to assign a gender to an inanimate object incapable of disrobing and making an occasional fool of itself. Why refer to Lady Flesh Wound or Good Sir Dishrag when these things could never deliver in the sack?

The teacher proceeded to belittle everyone from German Eva, who hated laziness, to Japanese Yukari, who loved paintbrushes and soap. Italian, Thai, Dutch, Korean, Chinese — we all left class foolishly believing that the worst was over. We didn’ t know it then, but the coming months would teach us what it is like to spend time in the presence of a wild animal. We soon learned to dodge chalk and to cover our heads and stomachs whenever she approached us with a question. She hadn’ t yet punched anyone, but it seemed wise to prepare ourselves against the inevitable.

Though we were forbidden to speak anything but French, the teacher would occasionally use us to practice any of her five fluent languages.

“I hate you,” she said to me one afternoon. Her English was flawless. “I really, really hate you.” Call me sensitive, but I couldn’ t help taking it personally.

Learning French is a lot like joining a gang in that it involves a long and intensive period of hazing. And it wasn’ t just my teacher; the entire population seemed to be in on it. Following brutal encounters with my local butcher and the concierge⁶ of my building, I’ d head off to class, where the teacher would hold my corrected paperwork high above her head, shouting, “Here’ s proof that *David* is an ignorant and uninspired *ensigiejsokhix*.”

Refusing to stand convicted on the teacher’ s charges of laziness, I’ d spend four hours a night on my homework, working even longer whenever we were assigned an essay. I suppose I could have gotten by with less, but I was determined to create some sort of an identity for myself. We’ d have one of those “complete the sentence” exercises, and I’ d fool with the thing for hours, invariably settling on something like, “A quick run around the lake? I’ d love to. Just give me a minute to strap on my wooden leg.” The teacher, through word and action, conveyed the message that,

if this was my idea of an identity, she wanted nothing to do with it.

My fear and discomfort crept beyond the borders of my classroom and accompanied me out onto the wide boulevards, where, no matter how hard I tried, there was no escaping the feeling of terror I felt whenever anyone asked me a question. I was safe in any kind of a store, as, at least in my neighborhood, one can stand beside the cash register for hours on end without being asked something so trivial as, “May I help you?” or “How would you like to pay for that?”

My only comfort was the knowledge that I was not alone. Huddled in the smoky hallways and making the most of our pathetic French, my fellow students and I engaged in the sort of conversation commonly overheard in refugee camps.

“Sometimes me cry alone at night.”

“That is common for me also, but be more strong, you. Much work, and someday you talk pretty. People stop hate you soon. Maybe tomorrow, okay?”

Unlike other classes I have taken, here there was no sense of competition. When the teacher poked a shy Korean woman in the eyelid with a freshly sharpened pencil, we took no comfort in

the fact that, unlike Hyeyoon Cho, we all knew the irregular past tense of the verb “to defeat.” In all fairness, the teacher hadn’ t meant to hurt the woman, but neither did she spend much time apologizing, saying only, “Well, you should have been paying more attention.”

Over time, it became impossible to believe that any of us would ever improve. Fall arrived, and it rained every day. It was mid-October when the teacher singled me out, saying, “Every day spent with you is like having a cesarean section.” And it struck me that, for the first time since arriving in France, I could understand every word that someone was saying.

Understanding doesn’ t mean that you can suddenly speak the language. Far from it. It’ s a small step, nothing more, yet its rewards are intoxicating and deceptive. The teacher continued her diatribe, and I settled back, bathing in the subtle beauty of each new curse and insult.

“You exhaust me with your foolishness and reward my efforts with nothing but pain, do you understand me?”

The world opened up, and it was with great joy that I responded, “I know the thing what you speak exact now. Talk me more, plus, please, plus.”

¹*Pa Kettle*: someone who is simple or unsophisticated; the name of a character in a series of comic movies popular in the 1950s.

²*Normandy*: a province in northwestern France.

³*bandoneon*: a small accordion popular in South America.

⁴*sadist*: one who finds pleasure in being cruel to others.

⁵ “... *your little war*”: the Balkan War (1991–2001), which consisted of armed conflict and genocide in the territory of the former Yugoslavia.

⁶*concierge*: a doorman in a French apartment building.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Sedaris’ s tone is humorous. What words in particular help him create this tone? Did you find yourself smiling or laughing out loud as you read his essay? If so, what specific passages affected you this way?
2. In paragraph 3, Sedaris confesses that he still harbors fear and anxiety about school. In the context of his story, why is it important for him to share this thought with his readers? Explain.
3. What is your impression of Sedaris and his classmates? What words and phrases does he use to describe himself and them?
4. Why do you think Sedaris uses nonsense jumbles of letters — *meismslsxp* and *palicmkrexjs*, for example

— in several places? How would his essay be different had he used the real words instead?

5. Sedaris explains that “learning French is a lot like joining a gang in that it involves a long and intensive period of hazing” (22). Why does this simile mean to you? Do you think his experience would have been the same had he taken the French class in the United States instead of in Paris? Explain.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What assumptions does Sedaris make about learning a second language as an adult? Does his actual experience at the Alliance Française measure up to his expectations? Explain.
2. In paragraph 29, Sedaris’ s French teacher tells him that “every day spent with you is like having a cesarean section.” Why is Sedaris’ s ability to recount this insult significant? What does the teacher’ s “cesarean section” metaphor mean?
3. How would you evaluate Sedaris’ s teacher? Given that she inspired Sedaris to apply himself to his work, do you think she was an effective teacher? Would her methods have had the same effect on you? Why or why not?

Classroom Activity Using Diction and Tone

Good writers rely on strong verbs — verbs that contribute significantly to what is being said.

Sportswriters, for example, are acutely aware of the need for strong action verbs because they must repeatedly describe similar situations. It is not enough for them to say that a team wins or loses; they must describe the type of win or loss more precisely. As a result, verbs such as *beat*, *bury*, *edge*, *shock*, and *trounce* are common in sports headlines. In addition to describing the act of winning, each of these verbs makes a statement about the quality of the victory. Like sportswriters, we all write about actions that are performed daily. If we were restricted to using only the verbs *eat*, *drink*, *sleep*, and *work* for each of these activities, our writing would be repetitious, monotonous, and most likely wordy.

Together with a small group of classmates, list as many verbs as you can that could be used in place of these four. What connotative differences do you find in your lists of alternatives? What is the importance of these connotative differences for you as writers? In which writing situations would you use certain words but not others?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write a narrative essay recounting a humorous incident in your life. (Glossary: [Narration](#)) Use the following questions to start thinking about the incident: Where were you? What happened? Who witnessed the incident? Did you think it was humorous at the time? Do you view it differently now? Why or why not? Choose words and phrases for your narrative that convey a humorous tone.
2. As Sedaris' s essay illustrates, fitting in often depends on our ability to communicate with authenticity — using the appropriate pronunciation, terminology, or slang — to a particular audience. (Glossary: [Audience](#); Jargon; [Slang](#)) Have you ever felt alienated by a group because you didn' t use its lingo appropriately, or have you ever alienated someone else for the same reason? Write a narrative essay in which you recount one such event. (Glossary: [Narration](#)) Be sure to use diction and tone creatively to convey your meaning. Before you begin, you might find it helpful to refer to your response to the Reflecting on What You Know prompt for this selection.

*Momma, the Dentist, and Me**

Maya Angelou



Syracuse Newspapers/Frank Ordonez/ The Image Works

Best-selling author and poet Maya Angelou (1928 - 2014) was an educator, historian, actress, playwright, civil rights

activist, producer, and director. She is best known as the author of *I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings* (1970), the first book in a series that constitutes her complete autobiography, and for poems such as “Still I Rise” and “On the Pulse of the Morning,” a characteristically optimistic poem on the need for personal and national renewal that she read at President Bill Clinton’s inauguration in 1993. Starting with her beginnings in St. Louis in 1928, Angelou’s autobiography presents a life of joyful triumph over hardships that tested her courage and threatened her spirit. It includes the titles *All God’s Children Need Traveling Shoes* (1986), *The Heart of a Woman* (1997), and *A Song Flung Up to Heaven* (2002). Her final book was *Mom & Me & Mom* (2013), a memoir of her relationship with her mother. At the time of her death, Angelou was the Reynolds Professor of American Studies at Wake Forest University and had received more than fifty honorary degrees.

In the following excerpt from *I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings*, Angelou narrates what happened, and what might have happened, when her grandmother, the “Mamma” of the story, took her to a local white dentist. As you read, consider Angelou’s word choices and how they contribute to the story’s success, particularly as you gauge the effect of the italicized paragraphs.

Reflecting on What You Know

When you were growing up, were you ever present when one or both of your parents were arguing with another adult about a matter concerning you? What were the circumstances? Narrate the events that brought about the controversy and show how it was resolved. Were you embarrassed by your parents' actions, or were you happy that they stood up for you?

The angel of the candy counter had found me out at last, and was exacting excruciating penance for all the stolen Milky Ways, Mounds, Mr. Goodbars, and Hersheys with Almonds. I had two cavities that were rotten to the gums. The pain was beyond the bailiwick¹ of crushed aspirins or oil of cloves. Only one thing could help me, so I prayed earnestly that I'd be allowed to sit under the house and have the building collapse on my left jaw. Since there was no Negro dentist in Stamps, nor doctor either, for that matter, Momma had dealt with previous toothaches by pulling them out (a string tied to the tooth with the other end looped over her fist), pain killers, and prayer. In this particular instance the medicine had proved ineffective; there wasn't enough enamel left to hook a string on, and the prayers were being ignored because the Balancing Angel was blocking their passage.

I lived a few days and nights in blinding pain, not so much toying with as seriously considering the idea of jumping in the well, and Momma decided I had to be taken to a dentist. The nearest Negro dentist was in Texarkana, twenty-five miles

away, and I was certain that I' d be dead long before we reached half the distance. Momma said we' d go to Dr. Lincoln, right in Stamps, and he' d take care of me. She said he owed her a favor.

I knew there were a number of whitefolks in town that owed her favors. Bailey and I had seen the books which showed how she had lent money to Blacks and whites alike during the Depression, and most still owed her. But I couldn' t aptly remember seeing Dr. Lincoln' s name, nor had I ever heard of a Negro' s going to him as a patient. However, Momma said we were going, and put water on the stove for our baths. I had never been to a doctor, so she told me that after the bath (which would make my mouth feel better) I had to put on freshly starched and ironed underclothes from inside out. The ache failed to respond to the bath, and I knew then that the pain was more serious than that which anyone had ever suffered.

Before we left the Store, she ordered me to brush my teeth and then wash my mouth with Listerine. The idea of even opening my clamped jaws increased the pain, but upon her explanation that when you go to a doctor you have to clean yourself all over, but most especially the part that' s to be examined, I screwed up my courage and unlocked my teeth. The cool air in my mouth and the jarring of my molars dislodged what little remained of my reason. I had frozen to the pain,

my family nearly had to tie me down to take the toothbrush away. It was no small effort to get me started on the road to the dentist. Momma spoke to all the passers-by, but didn' t stop to chat. She explained over her shoulder that we were going to the doctor and she' d “pass the time of day” on our way home.

Until we reached the pond the pain was my world, an aura that haloed me for three feet around. Crossing the bridge into whitefolks' country, pieces of sanity pushed themselves forward. I had to stop moaning and start walking straight. The white towel, which was drawn under my chin and tied over my head, had to be arranged. If one was dying, it had to be done in style if the dying took place in whitefolks' part of town.

On the other side of the bridge the ache seemed to lessen as if a whitebreeze blew off the whitefolks and cushioned everything in their neighborhood — including my jaw. The gravel road was smoother, the stones smaller, and the tree branches hung down around the path and nearly covered us. If the pain didn' t diminish then, the familiar yet strange sights hypnotized me into believing that it had.

But my head continued to throb with the measured insistence of a bass drum, and how could a toothache pass the calaboose,² hear the songs of the prisoners, their blues and

laughter, and not be changed? How could one or two or even a mouthful of angry tooth roots meet a wagonload of powhitetrash children, endure their idiotic snobbery, and not feel less important?

Behind the building which housed the dentist's office ran a small path used by servants and those tradespeople who catered to the butcher and Stamps's one restaurant. Momma and I followed that lane to the backstairs of Dentist Lincoln's office. The sun was bright and gave the day a hard reality as we climbed up the steps to the second floor.

Momma knocked on the back door and a young white girl opened it to show surprise at seeing us there. Momma said she wanted to see Dentist Lincoln and to tell him Annie was there. The girl closed the door firmly. Now the humiliation of hearing Momma describe herself as if she had no last name to the young white girl was equal to the physical pain. It seemed terribly unfair to have a toothache and a headache and have to bear at the same time the heavy burden of Blackness.

It was always possible that the teeth would quiet down and maybe drop out of their own accord. Momma said we would wait. We leaned in the harsh sunlight on the shaky railings of the dentist's back porch for over an hour.

He opened the door and looked at Momma. “Well, Annie, what can I do for you?”

He didn’ t see the towel around my jaw or notice my swollen face.

Momma said, “Dentist Lincoln. It’ s my grandbaby here. She got two rotten teeth that’ s giving her a fit.”

She waited for him to acknowledge the truth of her statement. He made no comment, orally or facially.

“She had this toothache purt’ near four days now, and today I said, ‘Young lady, you going to the Dentist.’ ”

“Annie?”

“Yes, sir, Dentist Lincoln.”

He was choosing words the way people hunt for shells.

“Annie, you know I don’ t treat nigra, colored people.”

“I know, Dentist Lincoln. But this here is just my little grandbaby, and she ain’ t gone be no trouble to you …”

“Annie, everybody has a policy. In this world you have to have a policy. Now, my policy is I don’ t treat colored

people.”

The sun had baked the oil out of Momma’ s skin and melted the Vaseline in her hair. She shone greasily as she leaned out of the dentist’ s shadow.

“Seem like to me, Dentist Lincoln, you might look after her, she ain’ t nothing but a little mite.³ And seems like maybe you owe me a favor or two.”

He reddened slightly. “Favor or no favor. The money has all been repaid to you and that’ s the end of it. Sorry, Annie.” He had his hand on the doorknob. “Sorry.” His voice was a bit kinder on the second “Sorry,” as if he really was.

Momma said, “I wouldn’ t press on you like this for myself but I can’ t take No. Not for my grandbaby. When you come to borrow my money you didn’ t have to beg. You asked me, and I lent it. Now, it wasn’ t my policy. I ain’ t no moneylender, but you stood to lose this building and I tried to help you out.”

“It’ s been paid, and raising your voice won’ t make me change my mind. My policy …” He let go of the door and stepped nearer Momma. The three of us were crowded on the small landing. “Annie, my policy is I’ d rather stick my hand in a dog’ s mouth than in a nigger’ s.”

He had never once looked at me. He turned his back and went through the door into the cool beyond. Momma backed up inside herself for a few minutes. I forgot everything except her face which was almost a new one to me. She leaned over and took the doorknob, and in her everyday soft voice she said, "Sister, go on downstairs. Wait for me. I' ll be there directly."

Under the most common of circumstances I knew it did no good to argue with Momma. So I walked down the steep stairs, afraid to look back and afraid not to do so. I turned as the door slammed, and she was gone.

Momma walked in that room as if she owned it. She shoved that silly nurse aside with one hand and strode into the dentist' s office. He was sitting in his chair, sharpening his mean instruments and putting extra sting into his medicines. Her eyes were blazing like live coals and her arms had doubled themselves in length. He looked up at her just before she caught him by the collar of his white jacket.

"Stand up when you see a lady, you contemptuous scoundrel." Her tongue had thinned and the words rolled off well enunciated. Enunciated and sharp like little claps of thunder.

The dentist had no choice but to stand at R. O. T. C.⁴ attention. His head dropped after a minute and his voice was humble. “Yes, ma’ am, Mrs. Henderson. ”

“You knave, do you think you acted like a gentleman, speaking to me like that in front of my granddaughter?” She didn’ t shake him, although she had the power. She simply held him upright.

“No, ma’ am, Mrs. Henderson. ”

“No, ma’ am, Mrs. Henderson, what?” Then she did give him the tiniest of shakes, but because of her strength the action set his head and arms to shaking loose on the ends of his body. He stuttered much worse than Uncle Willie. “No, ma’ am, Mrs. Henderson, I’ m sorry. ”

With just an edge of her disgust showing, Momma slung him back in his dentist’ s chair. “Sorry is as sorry does, and you’ re about the sorriest dentist I ever laid my eyes on. ” (She could afford to slip into the vernacular⁵ because she had such eloquent command of English.)

“I didn’ t ask you to apologize in front of Marguerite, because I don’ t want her to know my power, but I order you, now and herewith. Leave Stamps by sundown. ”

“Mrs. Henderson, I can’ t get my equipment …” He was shaking terribly now.

“Now, that brings me to my second order. You will never again practice dentistry. Never! When you get settled in your next place, you will be a veterinarian caring for dogs with the mange, cats with the cholera, and cows with the epizootic. Is that clear?”

The saliva ran down his chin and his eyes filled with tears.

“Yes, ma’ am. Thank you for not killing me. Thank you, Mrs. Henderson. ”

Momma pulled herself back from being ten feet tall with eightfoot arms and said, “You’ re welcome for nothing, you varlet,⁶—I wouldn’ t waste a killing on the likes of you. ”

On her way out she waved her handkerchief at the nurse and turned her into a crocus sack of chicken feed.

Momma looked tired when she came down the stairs, but who wouldn’ t be tired if they had gone through what she had. She came close to me and adjusted the towel under my jaw (I had forgotten the toothache; I only knew that she made her hands gentle in order not to awaken the pain). She took my hand. Her voice never changed. “Come on, Sister.”

I reckoned we were going home where she would concoct a brew to eliminate the pain and maybe give me new teeth too. New teeth that would grow overnight out of my gums. She led me toward the drugstore, which was in the opposite direction from the Store. “I’ m taking you to Dentist Baker in Texarkana.”

I was glad after all that I had bathed and put on Mum⁷ and Cashmere Bouquet talcum powder. It was a wonderful surprise. My toothache had quieted to solemn pain, Momma had obliterated the evil white man, and we were going on a trip to Texarkana, just the two of us.

On the Greyhound she took an inside seat in the back, and I sat beside her. I was so proud of being her granddaughter and sure that some of her magic must have come down to me. She asked if I was scared. I only shook my head and leaned over on her cool brown upper arm. There was no chance that a dentist, especially a Negro dentist, would dare hurt me then. Not with Momma there. The trip was uneventful, except that she put her arm around me, which was very unusual for Momma to do.

The dentist showed me the medicine and the needle before he deadened my gums, but if he hadn’ t I wouldn’ t have worried. Momma stood right behind him. Her arms were folded and she checked on everything he did. The teeth were extracted and

she bought me an ice cream cone from the side window of a drug counter. The trip back to Stamps was quiet, except that I had to spit into a very small empty snuff can which she had gotten for me and it was difficult with the bus humping and jerking on our country roads.

At home, I was given a warm salt solution, and when I washed out my mouth I showed Bailey the empty holes, where the clotted blood sat like filling in a pie crust. He said I was quite brave, and that was my cue to reveal our confrontation with the peckerwood dentist and Momma' s incredible powers.

I had to admit that I didn' t hear the conversation, but what else could she have said than what I said she said? What else done? He agreed with my analysis in a lukewarm way, and I happily (after all, I' d been sick) flounced into the Store. Momma was preparing our evening meal and Uncle Willie leaned on the door sill. She gave her version.

“Dentist Lincoln got right uppity. Said he' d rather put his hand in a dog' s mouth. And when I reminded him of the favor, he brushed it off like a piece of lint. Well, I sent Sister downstairs and went inside. I hadn' t never been in his office before, but I found the door to where he takes out teeth, and him and the nurse was in there thick as thieves. I just stood there till he caught sight of me.” Crash bang the pots on the stove. “He jumped just like he was sitting on a

pin. He said, ‘Annie, I done tole you, I ain’ t gonna mess around in no niggah’ s mouth.’ I said, ‘Somebody’ s got to do it then,’ and he said, ‘Take her to Texarkana to the colored dentist’ and that’ s when I said, ‘If you paid me my money I could afford to take her.’ He said, ‘It’ s all been paid.’ I tole him everything but the interest been paid. He said, ‘ ’ Twasn’ t no interest.’ I said, ‘ ’ Tis now. I’ ll take ten dollars as payment in full.’ You know, Willie, it wasn’ t no right thing to do, ’ cause I lent that money without thinking about it.

“He tole that little snippety nurse of his’ n to give me ten dollars and make me sign a ‘paid in full’ receipt. She gave it to me and I signed the papers. Even though by rights he was paid up before, I figger, he gonna be that kind of nasty, he gonna have to pay for it.”

Momma and her son laughed and laughed over the white man’ s evilness and her retributive⁸ sin.

I preferred, much preferred, my version.

*This title is original to *Models for Writers* and does not appear in the Maya Angelou work.

¹*bailiwick*: a specific area of interest, skill, or authority.

²*calaboose*: a jail.

³*mite*: a very small creature.

⁴*R. O. T. C.* : Reserve Officers Training Corps of the U.S. military.

⁵*vernacular*: the everyday language spoken by people of a particular country or region.

⁶*varlet*: a rascal; lowlife.

⁷*Mum*: a brand of deodorant.

⁸*retributive*: demanding something in repayment, especially punishment.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How would you describe Angelou's tone in this narrative? Point out some words and phrases that led you to this conclusion.
2. Compare and contrast the content and style of the interaction between Momma and the dentist that is given in italics with the one given at the end of the narrative. (Glossary: [Comparison and Contrast](#))
3. How does the diction in the quotations differ from the diction Angelou uses in her narration as she tells the story? What effect does this difference have on your experience as a reader?
4. Angelou tells her story chronologically and in the first person. (Glossary: [Point of View](#)) What are the advantages of first-person narration? How does her

choice to use this point of view affect her diction and tone?

5. This is a story of pain — and not just the pain of a toothache. What words does Angelou use to describe the pain of the toothache, and how does that enhance the impression of her pain? What other pain does she tell of in this autobiographical piece, and what word does she use to describe it?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What is Angelou's purpose in relating this story? (Glossary: [Purpose](#))
2. What do you think Angelou means when she states, "On the other side of the bridge the ache seemed to lessen as if a whitebreeze blew off the whitefolks and cushioned everything in their neighborhood — including my jaw" (6)? How long did Angelou's pain relief last? Why?
3. Why do you suppose Angelou says she prefers her own version of the episode to that of her grandmother?

Classroom Activity Using Diction and Tone

Writers of all sorts have to match their language to the occasion for writing. In the Gettysburg Address, the text of which follows, President Abraham Lincoln was presented with the grave and monumental occasion of commemorating lives lost in war. He declares it “fitting and proper” that the nation designate part of the battlefield as a memorial. Read the speech and then discuss how Lincoln finds a similarly “fitting and proper” diction for his speech. Which words or phrases best reflect the seriousness of the occasion?

Four score and seven years ago our fathers brought forth on this continent, a new nation, conceived in Liberty, and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal.

Now we are engaged in a great civil war, testing whether that nation, or any nation so conceived and so dedicated, can long endure. We are met on a great battle-field of that war. We have come to dedicate a portion of that field, as a final resting place for those who here gave their lives that that nation might live. It is altogether fitting and proper that we should do this.

But, in a larger sense, we can not dedicate — we can not consecrate — we can not hallow — this ground. The brave men, living and dead, who struggled here, have consecrated it, far above our poor power to add or detract. The world will little note, nor long remember what we say here, but it can never forget what they did here. It is for us the living, rather, to be dedicated here to the unfinished

work, which they who fought here have thus far so nobly advanced. It is rather for us to be here dedicated to the great task remaining before us — that from these honored dead we take increased devotion to that cause for which they gave the last full measure of devotion — that we here highly resolve that these dead shall not have died in vain — that this nation, under God, shall have a new birth of freedom — and that government of the people, by the people, for the people, shall not perish from the earth.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write a few paragraphs about an actual event — either a personal event or a historical event — adopting one of the particular tones listed on [pages 289 – 291](#). Then write about the same event using two different tones so that you have three versions of the same event. How did you create the different tones? Does one tone work better for recounting the event than another? Why?
2. Every person who tells a story puts his or her signature on it in some way — by the sequencing of events, the amount and type of details used, and the tone the teller employs. Consider a time when you and a relative or friend experienced the same interesting sequence of events differently, then tell the story of those events from your unique perspective.

(Glossary: [Point of View](#)) Once you have done so, try telling the story from what you imagine the other person's perspective to be. Perhaps you even heard the other person actually tell the story, using word choice to inject his or her personality. What is the same in both versions? How do the renditions differ?

An Indian Father's Plea

Robert G. Lake-Thom (Medicine Grizzly Bear)



Courtesy of Robert Lake-Thom

Robert G. Lake-Thom, also known as Medicine Grizzly Bear, is a traditional Native American healer and spiritual teacher, following methods he learned from healers, ceremonial leaders, and religious leaders of several tribes. His ancestry is Karuk, Seneca, Cherokee, and Anglo. He was a professor of Native American studies for over twenty years, teaching at Gonzaga University, Humboldt State University, and Eastern Montana College (now Montana State University Billings). Lake-Thom is the author of multiple books on Native American shamanic life and ceremonies, including *Chilula* (1982), *Native Healer* (1991), *Spirits of the Earth* (1997), and *The Call of the Great Spirit* (2001).

Lake-Thom wrote “An Indian Father’s Plea” in response to the negative effects Western education practices were having on his children as well as on Native American children across the nation. In this piece — which has been used for over two decades in both teacher training workshops and Indian education programs — Lake-Thom responds to a teacher who labeled his child a “slow learner,” explaining the education his son has already received. Although he acknowledges that this education may seem foreign to the teacher, he explains that it has developed the boy’s sensitivity to the world and honed skills important to his culture. As you read, notice how Lake-Thom chose his words wisely in order to explain clearly and passionately the education of a Native American child.

Reflecting on What You Know

Think about a time when your way of learning and understanding seemed out of sync with what you were being taught. What does it tell you about your education? Under what circumstances or with what methods do you learn best?

Wind-Wolf knows the names and migration patterns of more than 40 birds. He knows there are 13 tail feathers on a perfectly balanced eagle. What he needs is a teacher who knows his full measure.

Dear teacher, I would like to introduce you to my son, Wind-Wolf. He is probably what you would consider a typical Indian kid. He was born and raised on a reservation. He has black hair, dark brown eyes, olive complexion. And like so many Indian children his age, he is shy and quiet in the classroom. He is 5 years old, in kindergarten, and I can't understand why you have already labeled him a "slow learner."

At the age of 5, he has already been through quite an education compared with his peers in Western society. At his first introduction into this world, he was bonded to his mother and to the Mother Earth in a traditional native childbirth ceremony. And he has been continuously cared for by his mother, father, sisters, cousins, uncles, grandparents, and extended tribal family since this ceremony.

From his mother's warm and loving arms, Wind-Wolf was placed in a secure and specially designed Indian baby basket. His father and the medicine elders conducted another ceremony with him that served to bond him with the essence of his genetic father, the Great Spirit, the Grandfather Sun, and the Grandmother Moon. This was all done in order to introduce him properly into the new and natural world, not the world of artificiality, and to protect his sensitive and delicate soul. It is our people's way of showing the newborn respect, ensuring that he starts his life on the path of spirituality.

The traditional Indian baby basket became his "turtle's shell" and served as the first seat for his classroom. He was strapped in for safety, protected from injury by the willow roots and hazel wood construction. The basket was made by a tribal elder who had gathered her materials with prayer and in a ceremonial way. It is the same kind of basket that our people have used for thousands of years. It is specially designed to provide the child with the kind of knowledge and experience he will need in order to survive in his culture and environment.

Wind-Wolf was strapped in snugly with a deliberate restriction upon his arms and legs. Although you in Western society may argue that such a method serves to hinder motor-skill development and abstract reasoning, we believe it forces the child to first develop his intuitive faculties,

rational intellect, symbolic thinking, and five senses. Wind-Wolf was with his mother constantly, closely bonded physically, as she carried him on her back or held him in front while breast-feeding. She carried him everywhere she went, and every night he slept with both parents. Because of this, Wind-Wolf's educational setting was not only a "secure" environment, but it was also very colorful, complicated, sensitive, and diverse. He has been with his mother at the ocean at daybreak when she made her prayers and gathered fresh seaweed from the rocks, he has sat with his uncles in a rowboat on the river while they fished with gill nets, and he has watched and listened to elders as they told creation stories and animal legends and sang songs around the campfires.

He has attended the sacred and ancient White Deerskin Dance of his people and is well-acquainted with the cultures and languages of other tribes. He has been with his mother when she gathered herbs for healing and watched his tribal aunts and grandmothers gather and prepare traditional foods such as acorn, smoked salmon, eel, and deer meat. He has played with abalone shells, pine nuts, iris grass string, and leather while watching the women make beaded jewelry and traditional native regalia. He has had many opportunities to watch his father, uncles, and ceremonial leaders using different kinds of songs while preparing for the sacred dances and rituals.

As he grew older, Wind-Wolf began to crawl out of the baby basket, develop his motor skills, and explore the world around him. When frightened or sleepy, he could always return to the basket as a turtle withdraws into its shell. Such an inward journey allows one to reflect in privacy on what he has learned and to carry the new knowledge deeply into the unconscious and the soul. Shapes, sizes, colors, texture, sound, smell, feeling, taste, and the learning process are therefore functionally integrated — the physical and spiritual, matter and energy, conscious and unconscious, individual and social.

For example, Wind-Wolf was with his mother in South Dakota while she danced for seven days straight in the hot sun, fasting, and piercing herself in the sacred Sun Dance Ceremony of a distant tribe. He has been doctored in a number of different healing ceremonies by medicine men and women from diverse places ranging from Alaska and Arizona to New York and California. He has been in more than 20 different sacred sweat-lodge rituals — used by native tribes to purify the mind, body, and soul — since he was 3 years old, and he has already been exposed to many different religions of his racial brothers: Protestant, Catholic, Asian Buddhist, and Tibetan Lamaist.

It takes a long time to absorb and reflect on these kinds of experiences, so maybe that is why you think my Indian child

is a slow learner. His aunts and grandmothers taught him to count and know his numbers while they sorted out the complex materials used to make the abstract designs in the native baskets. He listened to his mother count each and every bead and sort out numerically according to color while she painstakingly made complex beaded belts and necklaces. He learned his basic numbers by helping his father count and sort the rocks to be used in the sweat-lodge — seven rocks for a medicine sweat, say, or 13 for the summer solstice ceremony. (The rocks are later heated and doused with water to create purifying steam.) And he was taught to learn mathematics by counting the sticks we use in our traditional native hand game. So I realize he may be slow in grasping the methods and tools that you are now using in your classroom, ones quite familiar to his white peers, but I hope you will be patient with him. It takes time to adjust to a new cultural system and learn new things.

He is not culturally “disadvantaged,” but he is culturally “different.” If you ask him how many months there are in a year, he will probably tell you 13. He will respond this way not because he doesn’ t know how to count properly, but because he has been taught by our traditional people that there are 13 full moons in a year according to the native tribal calendar and that there are really 13 planets in our solar system and 13 tail feathers on a perfectly balanced

eagle, the most powerful kind of bird to use in ceremonial healing.

But he also knows that some eagles may only have 12 tail feathers, or seven, that they do not all have the same number. He knows that the flicker has exactly 10 tail feathers; that they are red and black, representing the directions of east and west, life and death; and that this bird is considered a “fire” bird, a power used in native doctoring and healing. He can probably count more than 40 different kinds of birds, tell you and his peers what kind of bird each is and where it lives, the seasons in which it appears, and how it is used in a sacred ceremony. He may also have trouble writing his name on a piece of paper, but he knows how to say it and many other things in several different Indian languages. He is not fluent yet because he is only 5 years old and required by law to attend your educational system, learn your language, your values, your ways of thinking, and your methods of teaching and learning.

So you see, all of these influences together make him somewhat shy and quiet — and perhaps “slow” according to your standards. But if Wind-Wolf was not prepared for his first tentative foray into your world, neither were you appreciative of his culture. On the first day of class, you had difficulty with his name. You wanted to call him Wind, insisting that Wolf must somehow be his middle name. The

students in the class laughed at him, causing further embarrassment.

While you are trying to teach him your new methods, helping him learn new tools for self-discovery and adapt to his new learning environment, he may be looking out the window as if daydreaming. Why? Because he has been taught to watch and study the changes in nature. It is hard for him to make the appropriate psychic switch from the right to the left hemisphere of the brain when he sees the leaves turning bright colors, the geese heading south, and the squirrels scurrying around for nuts to get ready for a harsh winter. In his heart, in his young mind, and almost by instinct, he knows that this is the time of the year he is supposed to be with people gathering and preparing fish, deer meat, and native plants and herbs, and learning his assigned tasks in this role. He is caught between two worlds, torn by two distinct cultural systems.

Yesterday, for the third time in two weeks, he came home crying and said he wanted to have his hair cut. He said he doesn' t have any friends at school because they make fun of his long hair. I tried to explain to him that in our culture, long hair is a sign of masculinity and balance and is a source of power. But he remained adamant in his position.

To make matters worse, he recently encountered his first harsh case of racism. Wind-Wolf had managed to adopt at least one good school friend. On the way home from school one day, he asked his new pal if he wanted to come home to play with him until supper. That was OK with Wind-Wolf's mother, who was walking with them. When they all got to the little friend's house, the two boys ran inside to ask permission while Wind-Wolf's mother waited. But the other boy's mother lashed out: "It is OK if you have to play with him at school, but we don't allow those kind of people in our house!" When my wife asked why not, the other boy's mother answered, "Because you are Indians, and we are white, and I don't want my kids growing up with your kind of people."

So now my young Indian child does not want to go to school anymore (even though we cut his hair). He feels that he does not belong. He is the only Indian child in your class, and he is well-aware of this fact. Instead of being proud of his race, heritage, and culture, he feels ashamed. When he watches television, he asks why the white people hate us so much and always kill our people in the movies and why they take everything away from us. He asks why the other kids in school are not taught about the power, beauty, and essence of nature or provided with an opportunity to experience the world around them firsthand. He says he hates living in the city and that he misses his Indian cousins and friends. He asks why one young white girl at school who is his friend

always tells him, “I like you, Wind-Wolf, because you are a good Indian.”

Now he refuses to sing his native songs, play with his Indian artifacts, learn his language, or participate in his sacred ceremonies. When I ask him to go to an urban powwow or help me with a sacred sweat-lodge ritual, he says no because “that’ s weird” and he doesn’ t want his friends at school to think he doesn’ t believe in God.

So, dear teacher, I want to introduce you to my son, Wind-Wolf, who is not really a “typical” little Indian kid after all. He stems from a long line of hereditary chiefs, medicine men and women, and ceremonial leaders whose accomplishments and unique forms of knowledge are still being studied and recorded in contemporary books. He has seven different tribal systems flowing through his blood; he is even part white. I want my child to succeed in school and in life. I don’ t want him to be a dropout or juvenile delinquent or to end up on drugs and alcohol because he is made to feel inferior or because of discrimination. I want him to be proud of his rich heritage and culture, and I would like him to develop the necessary capabilities to adapt to, and succeed in, both cultures. But I need your help.

What you say and what you do in the classroom, what you teach and how you teach it, and what you don’ t say and don’ t

teach will have a significant effect on the potential success or failure of my child. Please remember that this is the primary year of his education and development. All I ask is that you work with me, not against me, to help educate my child in the best way. If you don' t have the knowledge, preparation, experience, or training to effectively deal with culturally different children, I am willing to help you with the few resources I have available or direct you to such resources.

Millions of dollars have been appropriated by Congress and are being spent each year for "Indian Education." All you have to do is take advantage of it and encourage your school to make an effort to use it in the name of "equal education." My Indian child has a constitutional right to learn, retain, and maintain his heritage and culture. By the same token, I strongly believe that non-Indian children also have a constitutional right to learn about our Native American heritage and culture, because Indians play a significant part in the history of Western society. Until this reality is equally understood and applied in education as a whole, there will be a lot more schoolchildren in grades K-2 identified as "slow learners."

My son, Wind-Wolf, is not an empty glass coming into your class to be filled. He is a full basket coming into a different environment and society with something special to

share. Please let him share his knowledge, heritage, and culture with you and his peers.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Lake-Thom begins this essay by describing his son and listing a few examples of what his son knows. Why do you think he starts in this way? Is this an appropriate writing strategy? Explain.
2. How would you describe Lake-Thom's tone in this selection? How does his diction support his tone? Point to specific words and phrases that helped to reach this conclusion.
3. Lake-Thom describes the specially designed baby basket as a "turtle's shell" (5). Why does he use this metaphor? What similarities is he pointing out? (Glossary: [Figure of Speech](#))
4. In speaking about his son, Lake-Thom writes, "He is not culturally 'disadvantaged,' but he is culturally 'different'" (11). Why do you suppose Lake-Thom thinks it's important for Wind-Wolf's teacher to know the difference here? What exactly is it that Lake-Thom wants for his son? Explain.
5. Discuss why Wind-Wolf would say there are thirteen months in a year. How does his father explain this "mistake" to the teacher?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Lake-Thom writes that the ritual introducing the child to his baby basket is a “way of showing the newborn respect” (4). In what ways is his essay more generally a call for showing respect? (Glossary: [Purpose](#)) How would you expect Wind-Wolf’s teacher to respond to Lake-Thom’s plea?
2. According to Lake-Thom, what are the advantages to the way his son has learned about the world? In what areas does Wind-Wolf have greater knowledge than his classmates, who are not from Native American families?
3. How would you describe Wind-Wolf’s emotional reaction to his new school? What experiences have most affected him? Do you see any benefits that this new form of education might afford Wind-Wolf? Explain.

Classroom Activity Using Diction and Tone

Writers create and control tone in their writing in part through the words they choose. For example, the words *laugh*, *cheery*, *dance*, and *melody* help create a tone of celebration. Make a list of the words that come to mind when considering each of the following tones:

humorous

authoritative

tentative

angry

triumphant

repentant

Compare your lists of words with those of others in the class. What generalizations can you make about the connotations associated with each of these tones?

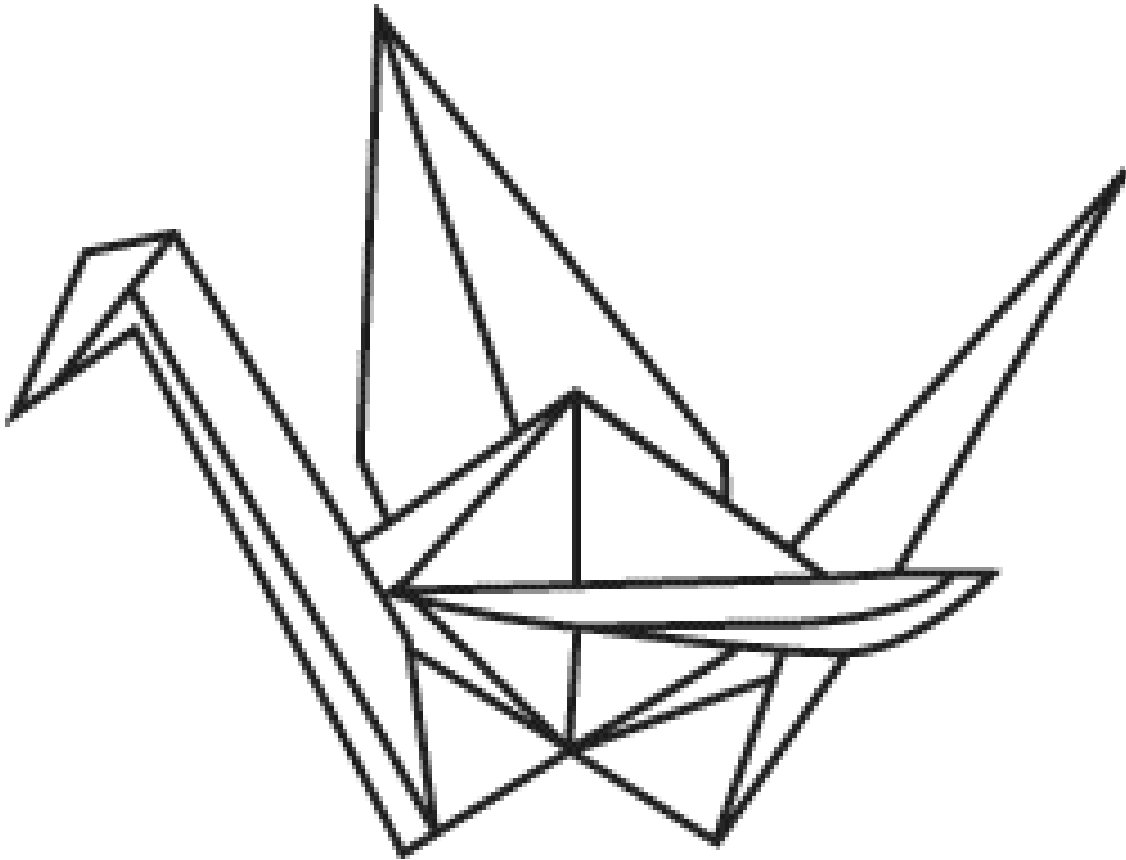
Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write a history of your education, both inside and outside the classroom. When did you begin to learn? What have your greatest achievements and hardest challenges been? You might find it helpful to think of the history of your education as a simple narrative. (Glossary: [Narration](#)) Look for opportunities where you can use supporting strategies such as comparison and contrast or process analysis to strengthen your essay.
2. Though Lake-Thom is writing for a specific audience — the teacher — he published his letter so that the public could also learn from his experience with Wind-Wolf’s first weeks of school. Think of a subject on which you have strong feelings, and write an open letter to persuade readers of your view. Using “An Indian Father’s Plea” as a model, try to

combine passionate expression with careful planning and structure. (Glossary: [Persuasion](#))



CHAPTER 13 Figurative Language



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Figurative language is language used in an imaginative rather than a literal sense. Although it is most often associated with poetry, figurative language is used widely in our daily speech and in our writing. Prose writers have long known that figurative language brings freshness and color to writing and helps clarify ideas. For example, when asked by his teacher to explain the concept of brainstorming, one student replied, “Well, brainstorming is like having a tornado in your head.” This figurative language helps others imagine the

whirl of ideas in this young writer's head as he brainstorms a topic for writing.

The two most common figures of speech are the simile and the metaphor. A simile compares two essentially different ideas or things and uses *like* or *as* to link them.

I was taught that candles are like house cats — domesticated versions of something wild and dangerous.

— Sloane Crosley, *I Was Told There'd Be Cake*

I walked toward her and hailed her as a visitor to the moon might salute a survivor of a previous expedition.

— John Updike, *Assorted Prose*

A metaphor compares dissimilar ideas or things without using *like* or *as*.

She was very old and small and she walked slowly in the dark pine shadows, moving a little from side to side in her steps, with the balanced heaviness and lightness of a pendulum in a grandfather clock.

— Eudora Welty, *A Worn Path*

Charm is the ultimate weapon, the supreme seduction, against which there are few defenses.

— Laurie Lee, *I Can't Stay Long*

To expand the richness of a particular comparison, writers sometimes use several sentences or even a whole paragraph to develop a metaphor. Such a comparison is called an *extended metaphor*.

The point is that you have to strip down your writing before you can build it back up. You must know what the essential tools are and what job they were designed to do. If I may belabor the metaphor on carpentry, it is first necessary to be able to saw wood neatly and to drive nails. Later you can bevel the edges or add elegant finials, if that is your taste. But you can never forget that you are practicing a craft that is based on certain principles. If the nails are weak, your house will collapse. If your verbs are weak and your syntax is rickety, your sentences will fall apart.

— William Zinsser, *On Writing Well*

Another frequently used figure of speech is personification. In personification, the writer attributes human qualities to ideas or objects.

The moon bathed the valley in a soft, golden light.

— Corey Davis, student

Blond October comes striding over the hills wearing a crimson shirt and faded green trousers.

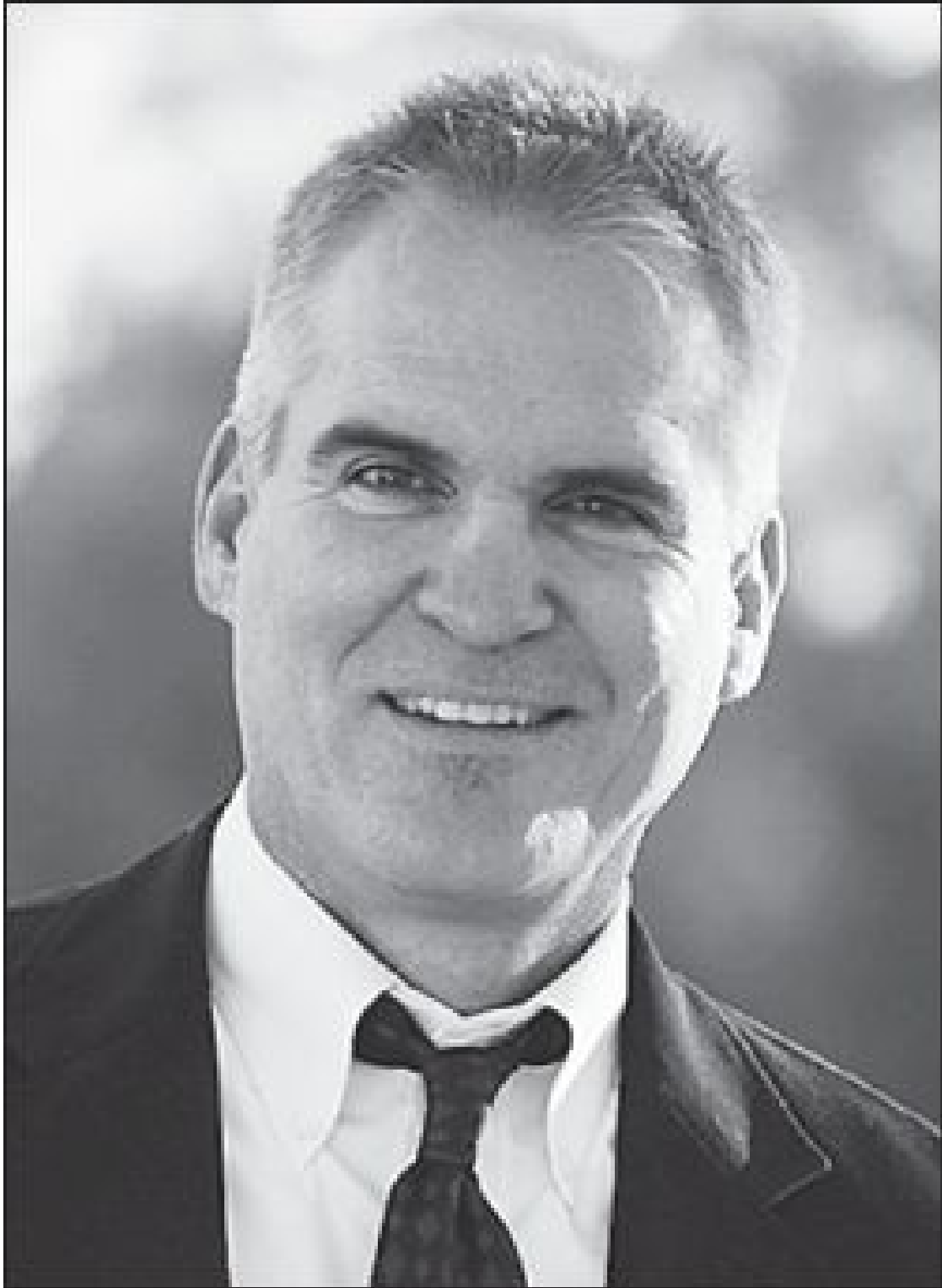
— Hal Borland, *Borland Country*

Procrastination is the thief of time. Collar him.

In all the preceding examples, notice how the writers' use of figurative language enlivens their prose and emphasizes their ideas. Each vividly communicates an idea or the essence of an object by comparing it to something concrete and familiar. In each case, too, the figurative language grows out of the writer's thinking, reflecting the way he or she sees the material. Be similarly honest in your use of figurative language, keeping in mind that figures of speech should never be used merely to dress up your writing. Above all, use them to develop your ideas and clarify your meaning for the reader.

The Barrio

Robert Ramirez



Courtesy of Robert Ramirez

Robert Ramirez was born in Edinburg, Texas, in 1949. After graduating from the University of Texas - Pan American, he

taught writing and held the positions of cameraman, reporter, anchor, and producer for the local news on KGBT-TV, the CBS affiliate in Harlingen, Texas. He is retired from working as an alumni fund-raiser for the University of Texas - Pan American, now known as University of Texas Rio Grande Valley.

The following essay first appeared in *Pain and Promise: The Chicano Today* (1972), edited by Edward R. Simmen. Notice how Ramirez uses figurative language, particularly metaphors, to awaken the reader's senses to the sights, sounds, and smells that are the essence of the barrio.

Reflecting on What You Know

Where did you grow up? What do you remember most about your childhood neighborhood? How did it feel as a young person to live in this world? Do you still call this neighborhood “home”? Explain.

The train, its metal wheels squealing as they spin along the silvery tracks, rolls slower now. Through the gaps between the cars blinks a streetlamp, and this pulsing light on a barrio streetcorner beats slower, like a weary heartbeat, until the train shudders to a halt, the light goes out, and the barrio is deep asleep.

Throughout Aztlán¹ (the Nahuatl term meaning “land to the north”), trains grumble along the edges of a sleeping

people. From Lower California, through the blistering Southwest, down the Rio Grande² to the muddy Gulf, the darkness and mystery of dreams engulf communities fenced off by railroads, canals, and expressways. Paradoxical³ communities, isolated from the rest of the town by concrete columned monuments of progress, and yet stranded in the past. They are surrounded by change. It eludes their reach, in their own backyards, and the people, unable and unwilling to see the future, or even touch the present, perpetuate the past.

Leaving from the expressway or jolting across the tracks, one enters a different physical world permeated by a different attitude. The physical dimensions are impressive. It is a large section of town which extends for fifteen blocks north and south along the tracks, and then advances eastward, thinning into nothingness beyond the city limits. Within the invisible (yet sensible) walls of the barrio are many, many people living in too few houses. The homes, however, are much more numerous than on the outside.

Members of the barrio describe the entire area as their home. It is a home, but it is more than this. The barrio is a refuge from the harshness and the coldness of the Anglo world. It is a forced refuge. The leprous people are isolated from the rest of the community and contained in their section of town. The stoical pariahs of the barrio accept their fate,

and from the angry seeds of rejection grow the flowers of closeness between outcasts, not the thorns of bitterness and the mad desire to flee. There is no want to escape, for the feeling of the *barrio* is known only to its inhabitants, and the material needs of life can also be found here.

The *tortillería* [tortilla factory] fires up its machinery three times a day, producing steaming, round, flat slices of *barrio* bread. In the winter, the warmth of the tortilla factory is a wool *sarape* [blanket] in the chilly morning hours, but in the summer, it unbearably toasts every noontime customer.

The *panadería* [bakery] sends its sweet messenger aroma down the dimly lit street, announcing the arrival of fresh, hot sugary *pan dulce* [sweet rolls].

The small corner grocery serves the meal-to-meal needs of customers, and the owner, a part of the neighborhood, willingly gives credit to people unable to pay cash for foodstuffs.

The barbershop is a living room with hydraulic chairs, radio, and television, where old friends meet and speak of life as their salted hair falls aimlessly about them.

The pool hall is a junior level country club where ' *chucos* [young men], strangers in their own land, get together to shoot pool and rap, while veterans, unaware of the cracking, popping balls on the green felt, complacently play dominoes beneath rudely hung *Playboy* foldouts.

The *cantina* [canteen or snackbar] is the night spot of the barrio. It is the country club and the den where the rites of puberty are enacted. Here the young become men. It is in the taverns that a young dude shows his *machismo* through the quantity of beer he can hold, the stories of *rucas* [women] he has had, and his willingness and ability to defend his image against hardened and scarred old lions.

No, there is no frantic wish to flee. It would be absurd to leave the familiar and nervously step into the strange and cold Anglo community when the needs of the Chicano⁴ can be met in the barrio.

The barrio is closeness. From the family living unit, familial relationships stretch out to immediate neighbors, down the block, around the corner, and to all parts of the barrio. The feeling of family, a rare and treasurable sentiment, pervades and accounts for the inability of the people to leave. The barrio is this attitude manifested on the countenances⁵ of the people, on the faces of their homes, and in the gaiety of their gardens.

The color-splashed homes arrest your eyes, arouse your curiosity, and make you wonder what life scenes are being played out in them. The flimsy, brightly colored, wood-frame houses ignore no neon-brilliant color. Houses trimmed in orange, chartreuse, lime-green, yellow, and mixtures of these and other hues beckon the beholder to reflect on the peculiarity of each home. Passing through this land is refreshing like Brubeck,⁶ not narcoticizing like revolting rows of similar houses, which neither offend nor please.

In the evenings, the porches and front yards are occupied with men calmly talking over the noise of children playing baseball in the unpaved extension of the living room, while the women cook supper or gossip with female neighbors as they water the *jardines* [gardens]. The gardens mutely echo the expressive verses of the colorful houses. The denseness of multicolored plants and trees gives the house the appearance of an oasis or a tropical island hideaway, sheltered from the rest of the world.

Fences are common in the barrio, but they are fences and not the walls of the Anglo community. On the western side of town, the high wooden fences between houses are thick, impenetrable walls, built to keep the neighbors at bay. In the barrio, the fences may be rusty, wire contraptions or thick green shrubs. In either case you can see through them and feel no sense of intrusion when you cross them.

Many lower-income families of the barrio manage to maintain a comfortable standard of living through the communal action of family members who contribute their wages to the head of the family. Economic need creates interdependence and closeness. Small bare-footed boys sell papers on cool, dark Sunday mornings, deny themselves pleasantries, and give their earnings to *mamá*. The older the child, the greater the responsibility to help the head of the household provide for the rest of the family.

There are those, too, who for a number of reasons have not achieved a relative sense of financial security. Perhaps it results from too many children too soon, but it is the homes of these people and their situation that numbs rather than charms. Their houses, aged and bent, oozing children, are fissures⁷ in the horn of plenty. Their wooden homes may have brick-pattern asbestos tile on the outer walls, but the tile is not convincing.

Unable to pay city taxes or incapable of influencing the city to live up to its duty to serve all the citizens, the poorer barrio families remain trapped in the nineteenth century and survive as best they can. The backyards have well-worn paths to the outhouses, which sit near the alley. Running water is considered a luxury in some parts of the barrio. Decent drainage is usually unknown, and when it rains, the water stands for days, an incubator of health hazards and an

avoidable nuisance. Streets, costly to pave, remain rough, rocky trails. Tires do not last long, and the constant rattling and shaking grind away a car' s life and spread dust through screen windows.

The houses and their *jardines*, the jollity of the people in an adverse world, the brightly feathered alarm clock pecking away at supper and cautiously eyeing the children playing nearby, produce a mystifying sensation at finding the noble savage⁸ alive in the twentieth century. It is easy to look at the positive qualities of life in the barrio, and look at them with a distantly envious feeling. One wishes to experience the feelings of the barrio and not the hardships. Remembering the illness, the hunger, the feeling of time running out on you, the walls, both real and imagined, reflecting on living in the past, one finds his envy becoming more elusive, until it has vanished altogether.

Back now beyond the tracks, the train creaks and groans, the cars jostle each other down the track, and as the light begins its pulsing, the barrio, with all its meanings, greets a new dawn with yawns and restless stretchings.

¹*Aztlán*: the mythical place of origin of the Aztec peoples.

²*Rio Grande*: a river flowing from southwest Colorado to Texas and Mexico and into the Gulf of Mexico.

³*paradoxical*: seemingly contradictory.

⁴*Chicano*: an American of Mexican descent.

⁵*countenances*: facial expressions that indicate mood or character.

⁶*Dave Brubeck* (1920 – 2012): pianist, composer, and conductor of “cool” modern jazz.

⁷*fissures*: narrow openings or cracks.

⁸*noble savage*: in literature, an idealized concept of an uncivilized human.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is the *barrio*? Where is it? What does Ramirez mean when he states, “There is no want to escape, for the feeling of the *barrio* is known only to its inhabitants, and the material needs of life can also be found here” (4)?
2. Ramirez uses Spanish phrases throughout his essay. Why do you suppose he uses them? What is their effect on the reader? He also uses the words *home*, *refuge*, *closeness*, and *family*. What do they connote in the context of this essay? (Glossary: [Connotation/Denotation](#)) In what ways, if any, are they essential to the writer’s purpose? (Glossary: [Purpose](#))
3. Identify several metaphors and similes that Ramirez uses in his essay, and explain why they are

particularly appropriate.

4. In paragraph 6, Ramirez uses personification when he refers to the aroma of freshly baked sweet rolls as a “messenger.” Cite other words or phrases that Ramirez uses to give human characteristics to the barrio.
5. Explain Ramirez’ s use of the imagery of walls and fences to describe a sense of cultural isolation. What might this imagery symbolize? (Glossary: [Symbol](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What evidence does Ramirez give to support the following claim: “Members of the barrio describe the entire area as their home. It is a home, but it is more than this” (4)?
2. Some of the best figurative language arises out of a need to explain or make a situation clear. Have you found yourself using figurative language to explain a situation? What were the circumstances?
3. Ramirez begins with a relatively positive picture of the barrio but ends on a more disheartening note. (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#)) Why does he organize his essay in this way? What might the effect have been had he reversed these images?

Classroom Activity Using Figurative Language

Create a metaphor or simile that would be helpful in describing each item in the following list. To illustrate the process, the first one has been completed for you.

1. Skyscraper: The skyscraper sparkled like a huge glass needle.
2. Unbelievable sunset
3. Intelligent student
4. Crowded bus
5. Slow-moving car
6. Pillow
7. Narrow alley
8. Greasy french fries
9. Wild surf
10. Roller coaster

Compare your metaphors and similes with those written by other members of your class. Which metaphors and similes seem to work best for each item on the list? Why? Do any seem tired or clichéd?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. In paragraph 19, Ramirez states, “One wishes to experience the feelings of the barrio and not the hardships.” Explore his meaning in light of what you have just read and any experience or knowledge you may have of “ghetto” living. In what way can it be said that the hardships of such living are a necessary part of its “feelings”? How might barrio life change, for better or for worse, if the city were to “live up to its duty to serve all the citizens” (18)?
2. Write a brief essay in which you describe your own neighborhood. (Glossary: [Description](#)) You may find it helpful to review what you wrote in response to the Reflecting on What You Know prompt for this selection. Use figurative language where appropriate and effective.

Of Fledglings and Freshmen

Trish O' Kane



Jim Carrier

Trish O' Kane is a lecturer in the Rubenstein School of Environment and Natural Resources at the University of

Vermont. She has several advanced degrees, including an MA in International Journalism from the University of Southern California and a PhD in Environment and Resources from the University of Wisconsin-Madison. An advocate for environmental justice, she designed a program called

“Birding to Change the World” at the University of Vermont. O’ Kane has written and edited several books, including *Guatemala: A Guide to the People, Politics and Culture* (1998). She has also authored reports including “Baseline Avian Biodiversity Survey for Warner Park” (Wild Warner and the Madison Parks Division, 2013) and *The Power of the Sword: Hate Violence in the State of Alabama* (Center for Democratic Renewal, 2002). Additionally, her writing has appeared in a plethora of newspapers. *The New York Times* has published her articles “Pattern of Migration” (2007), “What the Sparrows Told Me” (2014), and the following selection, “Of Fledglings and Freshman” (2019), which originally appeared on September 5, 2019.

In this article, O’ Kane uses figurative language to compare her experience advising freshman to helping fledgling birds. As you read, look for the ways in which O’ Kane seeks to enliven and emphasize her points using figurative language.

Reflecting on What You Know

What is your experience with birds? Are there any kinds of birds that you especially like or dislike? Have you ever

studied them — for example, by going birding? Explain.

As brown-eyed susans and fuchsia coneflowers have taken over my garden, in that last glorious wave of Vermont's summer, I feel wistful because my seasonal gig is ending. For three months a year, I am an avian¹ extension agent: unpaid, self-appointed and yes, I made up the title. I help eastern bluebirds, black-capped chickadees and tree swallows raise their young in five tiny wooden birdhouses in Burlington. The houses on poles help bird species that need cavities to nest in.

The rest of the year I teach environmental studies at the University of Vermont and serve as a freshmen adviser. The jobs are surprisingly similar. In both spheres — the avian and the academic — I work with creatures who make me laugh, make me cry and inspire me not to give up on this troubled world. While I am a bit sad cleaning out empty nests from the birdhouses, I am excited as I spruce up syllabuses for my incoming students, especially the 18 fluttering, nervous, hungry-for-the-world freshmen I'll be advising during their first year.

On the avian front, it was a good season, with 14 fledglings exiting the houses (the exception was one dead baby tree swallow, a runt half the size of the three siblings on top of it). The truth is human birdhouse managers really don't do

much. I mostly sit at a picnic table watching the parents carry in insects every few minutes, amazed at how hard they work. I intervene only in emergencies like the panicked call from a birdhouse-manager-in-training about an ant infestation in a tree swallow nest. The babies had just hatched and I rushed to her condo complex, imagining a Hitchcockian² scene of ants swarming the tiny pink, featherless babies, eating them alive in the 20 minutes it took to ride my bike over there.

When a birdhouse nest gets infested with insects, or is blown down in a storm, we build a new nest. I am terrible at it, so I carry around an old sparrow nest instead. That day, we opened the little door — while the mother hovered overhead, clicking furiously at us — grabbed the nest, scooped the babies out, put them in a brown lunch bag, threw away the ant-infested nest, and hurriedly cleaned out the house and sprayed the pole with a grease gun. Then I took my standby sparrow nest, plopped the babies in it, put them back in the ant-free house and retreated. I counted 30 seconds before the parents zoomed in and took over. The replacement sparrow nest was prickly, while tree swallow nests are lined with feathers and as soft as a boudoir.³ The next day my assistant discovered that the parents had spread a piece of plastic wrap under the babies to mimic the softness of their old nest and add insulation.

As with the birds in the summer, I mostly watch the freshmen, and intervene only in emergencies: a freshman with a drug problem (pick up the phone, call the counseling center, off you go), a sobbing young man in a rough breakup with a high school sweetheart and doubting his reason to exist (push the tissues and bowl of organic, free-range, local maple jelly beans toward him, listen carefully, give him a hug, send to the counseling center and file a report).

In my academic job, I also become like the bird parents. I tell my advisees, especially the girls, to watch for predators at drunken parties. I show all my students where the intellectual food is on campus, helping them sign up for classes. I encourage them to jump out of that birdhouse or off that tree trunk they are clinging to — try a new major, learn a new language, go join that poetry club or band or dance class. I even feed them during a weekly “Teatime with Trish,” served on my Irish grandmother’s china set.

Both groups are funny, endearing, scared, occasionally clumsy, vulnerable, daring, pesky and prone to sudden bursts of energy. And both are very curious. Freshmen remind me of young chickadees. Last week three chickadee fledglings landed on my right hand when I held it out with seed. Two clung to my fingertips and just stared at me, ignoring the seeds. Some freshmen drop into office hours and teatimes in the same way. They just want to know who I am. We talk about great reads,

mostly. I have a Post-it list on my wall of books students have recommended.

I am from the “Animal House” 1980s college generation and did not have a first-year adviser, so I am a bit dubious about the hand-holding now required in academia. But campuses across the country are reporting increasing anxiety and depression among undergraduates (with the mess we’ re leaving them, it’ s no wonder). So this is where the job gets tricky: resisting the urge to over-rescue. With fledgling birds, most of the time, you do nothing. When I volunteered at a wildlife rehabilitation hospital, I learned that one of the most frequent mistakes humans make is to see that fluffy, big-eyed fledgling sitting under a bush or at the base of a tree, assume it needs help, stick it in a shoe box and bring it to a rehabber. Yes, that is a dangerous time in a young bird’ s life, but the parents are nearby. And so are freshman advisers, watching some of the time, but mostly, we let them flop around and fend for themselves. And I know now, after 14 years of teaching at universities, that they will fly.

The distraught young man and the girl with a pot problem were both in my first freshman brood in Burlington four years ago. But I was the one wiping away tears in May as I watched him cross the stage to get his diploma. In four years he had become a birding mentor for a little boy from Nepal and a

public environmental educator, and now he's doing his dream job in conservation education.

The girl with the drug issue grew out of it; most of them do. She became a passionate anti-racist educator in her freshman class and used the lynching photography website Without Sanctuary to teach her peers about the history of lynching in the United States. A very nervous, scared girl in my second freshman brood, who clutched my wrist with scrawny fingers that felt like chickadee talons the day we met, was one of the best thinkers and writers in all my classes. She became very passionate about local democracy and then jumped out of the university tree to study in Latin America.

In the third freshman brood, I had a student who was so upset about the Parkland shooting that she emailed me insistently, saying, "I just have to do something." I suggested that she call our Republican, gun-owning governor and ask for a meeting. Two weeks later I found myself sitting in Gov. Phil Scott's chambers with her and 12 other students all in business attire. For 30 minutes they told their stories of growing up in fear of school shootings, of attending funerals for children (one freshman was from near Sandy Hook), and implored him to sign pending legislation. After meeting with dozens of student groups, he signed a gun bill 13 days later as National Rifle Association protesters yelled "traitor."

So as I say goodbye to the chickadees and bluebirds, I say hello to my incoming fledglings. Some of them are already seasoned post-Parkland warriors and Sunrise Movement foot soldiers. I can't wait to see what they have to teach me.

¹*avian*: relating to birds.

²*Hitchcockian*: similar to the movies of American filmmaker Alfred Hitchcock, known as “the Master of Suspense.”

³*boudoir*: a woman's private dressing room.

Trish O' Kane, “Of Fledglings and Freshmen,” *The New York Times*, September 5, 2019. Copyright © 2019 by The New York Times. All rights reserved. Used under license.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is O' Kane's “seasonal gig” (1)? What does she do when not working with birds?
2. In this essay, O' Kane uses the figure of speech known as an extended metaphor. Name at least one aspect of freshman advising that she illuminates using this figurative gesture.
3. What simile does O' Kane use in paragraph 6? How does O' Kane help her advisees, according to this paragraph?
4. In what ways does O' Kane personify her birds and zoomorphize (attribute animal characteristics to) her student advisees in paragraph 7?

5. Name one specific example of “flight” (achievement) by O’ Kane’ s student advisees that she describes at the end of the essay.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. In discussions of metaphor, one may consider the tenor of the metaphor (its subject) and the vehicle (the part of the metaphor that helps emphasize the subject). What is the tenor of this essay? What is the vehicle? Do you find that this is an essay more about birds, more about freshman, or equally about both? Explain your answer.
2. In your own words, explain O’ Kane’ s approach to academic advising. Do you feel that it is an effective approach for advising freshman? Explain your answer.
3. How would you characterize O’ Kane’ s voice in this essay? Point to specific elements, like diction, sentence structure, and organization, to support your answer.

Classroom Activity Using Figurative Language

Imagine each of the following abstract nouns as a character. What would each character look like? How would it act or talk? Choose one of these characters, and write a substantial descriptive paragraph, developing your ideas. What does this imaginative leap to personification reveal about the abstraction?

1. Friendship
2. Jealousy
3. Justice
4. Frustration
5. Perfection

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Using at least two forms of figurative language (like simile, metaphor, and personification), write an essay that explores the ideal characteristics of an academic advisor or mentor.
2. Write an analytical essay about your first moments as a high school student or your first moments as a college student using an extended metaphor (or simile) that help your readers understand the key features of your academic experience. Try to avoid clichés. (Glossary: [Cliché](#)) For example, instead of saying “My freshman orientation week was a disaster,” you might say something like “My

freshman orientation week was a hurricane.” Even better is if your tenor and vehicle both involve experiences you have had: “My freshman orientation week was like cleaning out the cluttered basement after the hurricane hit our town.” As you plan your essay, decide how much attention to give each part of your metaphor.

*Fahrenheit 59: What a Child's Fever Might Tell
Us about Climate Change*

Audrey Schulman



Miriam Berkley

Novelist Audrey Schulman was born in Montreal, Quebec, Canada, in 1963. She attended Sarah Lawrence College from

1981 to 1983 and graduated from Barnard College in 1985. Schulman has worked as a scriptwriter, a computer consultant, and an internet website designer while developing her skills as a writer. In her first novel, *The Cage* (1995), Schulman tells the story of a young female photographer who is sent to the wilds of northern Canada to study polar bears. She followed this with *Swimming with Jonah* (1999), *A House Named Brazil* (2000), *The Third Way* (2009), *Three Weeks in December* (2010), and *Theory of Bastards* (2018). She is also the cofounder of Home Energy Efficiency Team (HEET), a nonprofit organization dedicated to increasing energy efficiency education to reduce the effects of climate change. Her articles on global climate change and severe climatic events have appeared in *E Magazine*, *Conservation Matters*, *Ms.*, and *Grist*.

In “Fahrenheit 59,” first published in the January–February 2007 issue of *Orion* magazine, Schulman explores the inner workings of climate change. As you read, pay attention to how she makes an argument, organizes a vivid analogy (her son’s body and its ability to deal with temperature changes and illness), and uses other writing strategies to explain how the earth deals with the complexities of climate change.

Reflecting on What You Know

How concerned are you about climate changes or global warming? What, if anything, do you think needs to be done?

Have you personally made any lifestyle changes as a result of your concerns? If so, describe what you have done.

Yesterday afternoon, my six-year-old son practiced swimming with me. Delighted with the water and my attention, Corey stayed in for forty minutes. Despite the water's chill, I knew if I took his temperature it would be close to 98.6° Fahrenheit. For an hour afterward he ran through the humid July heat, playing tag with his cousins, his hair damp with sweat. Still, a reading would have shown his body to be within a degree or two of 98.6° .

This stability is a product of homeostasis. A holy word for biologists, *homeostasis* refers to an organism's ability to maintain its ideal temperature and chemistry.

Each species has its own preferred level of warmth, but among most mammals the possible range is surprisingly narrow, generally between 97° and 103° F. Each body's temperature works to optimize the function of its enzymes, which are critical to its every chemical interaction. Too cold, and these catalysts slow down. Too hot, and they break down entirely.

Such homeostatic regulation depends on a mechanism known as negative feedback: a response that maintains a system's balance. Yesterday, for example, when Corey ran in the hot

sun, his cheeks got rosy as more blood moved to the surface, maximizing heat loss off his skin. No, his body said to his increasing temperature.

It turns out that our bodies' homeostasis can provide an analogy with which to understand the complexities of climate change — and the human response to it. Over geological time, the biosphere uses negative feedbacks in a way that maintains a stable global average temperature. When the earth's oceans heat up past a certain point, for example, hurricanes (which thrive only on warm water) increase their intensity, leaving a trail of stirred-up nutrients. The food creates a massive bloom of phytoplankton,¹ which suck in enough of the greenhouse gas carbon dioxide to start cooling the global climate.

Conversely, when temperatures fall too low, vast quantities of methane are released into the atmosphere, possibly in part because ice sheets build up, lowering sea levels and exposing coastal methane hydrates. As a greenhouse gas twenty times more powerful than carbon dioxide, the methane warms the biosphere quickly.

Through a large array of negative feedbacks like these, the biosphere has managed to maintain a relatively stable temperature, despite massive volcanic eruptions of greenhouse gasses and orbital and solar irregularities. To earth-based

organisms, the fluctuations may have seemed severe, allowing ice sheets to roll in or crocodiles to paddle across the Arctic. But through its self-corrections, the biosphere has remained habitable.

According to New York University biology professor Tyler Volk, the sun's temperature has increased 30 percent over the course of earth's history, which would have increased temperatures about one hundred degrees were it not for the cooling effect of phytoplankton and other life. And scientists calculate that the earth would be a frigid fifty to sixty degrees colder without any greenhouse gases. Over the last million years, the biosphere has remained within about eighteen degrees of 59° F.

Humanity's intemperate carbon emissions, however, have severely tested these negative feedbacks. Since 1900 alone, the earth has warmed more than a full degree — one-fifth the entire temperature range over the past ten thousand years. The earth is now within two degrees of its warmest levels in one million years.

The increased heat dries up the soil faster and pumps water vapor into the clouds, exaggerating the severity of drought, then rain. Gentle summer days turn into baking onslaughts, temperate-zone drizzles become tropical monsoons, tropical diseases and pests have whole new latitudes to conquer, and

temperate-zone animals and plants are fleeing toward the poles. The increased heat has also warmed the oceans, causing hurricanes to grow in intensity.

And when a situation becomes extreme enough, biological systems can abandon their attempts at moderation. Corey crawled into bed with me in the middle of last night, saying his head hurt. His hands and face felt hot. Touching his ribs I could feel his heart racing. Ill with the flu, his body no longer fought to maintain its normal temperature. Instead it was using positive feedbacks, reactions that amplify a change, to create a fever. Holding him close in bed, I could feel his muscles violently shivering, creating heat and more heat. Within an hour of the first symptoms, his temperature was 102° .

Positive feedbacks can also shift the earth's climate quickly, with the kind of results seen in the latest global warming news. As ice sheets melt near the poles, for example, the water slips through the crevasses to the rock below. At some point the water pools up enough to raise the glacier just a fraction, greasing its slide into the ocean. James Hansen of the Goddard Institute, whose science has been uncannily accurate since he alerted Congress in 1988 to signs of human-induced climate change, points out that this phenomenon can cause millennia-old ice sheets to disappear with an explosive splash. At that point, white ice no longer

reflects sunlight into space. Instead, dark water draws the sunlight in as heat, accelerating the rise in the earth' s temperature. Yes, the water says, yes.

The thaw of the Siberian permafrost may provide another example of a positive feedback. Roughly 400,000 megatons of dead plant matter that has never finished decaying because it has been frozen, the permafrost is now thawing more rapidly than expected, according to recent reports. Because all this plant flesh is wet — under snow that' s now melting — the decay is engineered by anaerobic bacteria, which metabolize the plants straight into methane, that muscular greenhouse gas. Once truly underway, this release of methane would dwarf any effect humans have on climate change. There' d be no more discussion of Energy Star appliances or raising the emission standards of cars. The rising temperatures would effectively no longer be powered by us, or subject to our influences. The system would take over.

As medical researchers have discovered in the past decade, our bodies give us fevers for a specific reason: certain antibodies and other infection-fighting agents function optimally at 100° F or higher. When Corey' s body detected the presence of overly aggressive microbes, it turned its thermostat up high. His hypothalamus made his muscles shiver, minimized the blood flow to his skin, conserved heat in his gut. For a little while, his body could withstand a high

temperature while the immune system brought out its heavy artillery. Overall this strategy tends to work well: Corey slept straight through the day, and, late in the afternoon, he sat up, skinnier and ferociously thirsty, but healthy again. Research shows, however, that while the feverish response may preserve the human organism as a whole, some of the immune system's agents have side effects: their activity can kill many "innocent" nonaggressive cells.

We should take note. It may seem a poetic stretch to say the earth itself ever sickens or has a fever. Seen from a distance, the earth itself does not become more or less "healthy" — just more or less populated with life. But as seen from the ground, the view is rather different. If our planet's feedback systems switch over from negative to positive and the biosphere heats up fast, the earth will certainly seem feverishly ill to a number of species, many of which will not survive.

In terms of our planetary climate, it's easy to guess which species is playing the role of overly aggressive microbe. But we do have a choice. Some human cultures, through their agriculture and hunting, have respected and adapted to ecological limits. We have the ability to shape our destiny — to be microbial attackers, or humble cells inside a living body.

¹*phytoplankton*: ocean-dwelling microscopic plants.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How does Schulman's organizational pattern help her develop the analogy between her son's illness and the earth's climate changes? Would her essay work as well if she changed the order of her discussion? Why or why not?
2. Schulman begins her essay with narration, describing what happens to her son Corey before discussing what is happening to the earth's climate and the relationship between the two subjects. Why does she begin this way? Is her combination of writing strategies effective here? Explain.
3. What is homeostasis? How does it work in humans? Why is it an important concept to understand? Why does Schulman need to explain it early in her essay?
4. What is negative feedback? How does the author use her son to explain this concept?
5. According to Schulman, how has the biosphere used negative feedback to maintain a relatively constant temperature over time?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. How does Schulman use her son's fever to explain what is happening to the earth's climate today? What writing strategies does she combine in these passages? Does her analogy help you better understand climate change? Explain.
2. In the final paragraph, Schulman says that "it's easy to guess which species is playing the role of overly aggressive microbe." In terms of her analogy, in what ways can human beings be considered "overly aggressive microbes"? Does this analogy help you explain what is happening to our planetary climate? Explain.
3. Schulman uses a variety of writing strategies in this essay. Identify as many as you can.

Classroom Activity Using Figurative Language

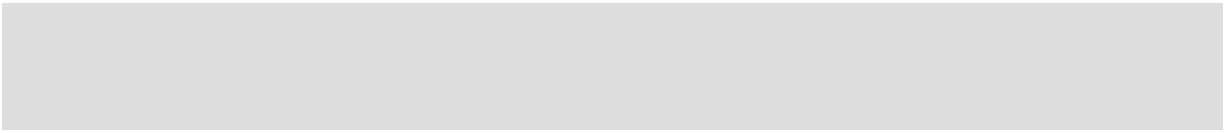
The entry for [Analogy](#) in the Glossary of Useful Terms (p. 642) reads as follows:

A special form of comparison in which the writer explains something unfamiliar by comparing it with something familiar: "A transmission line is simply a pipeline for electricity. In the case of a water pipeline, more water will flow through the pipeline as water pressure increases. The same is true of electricity in a transmission line."

As a class, discuss analogies and how they might be useful in your writing. Be prepared with an analogy of your own to contribute to the discussion.

Suggested Writing Assignments

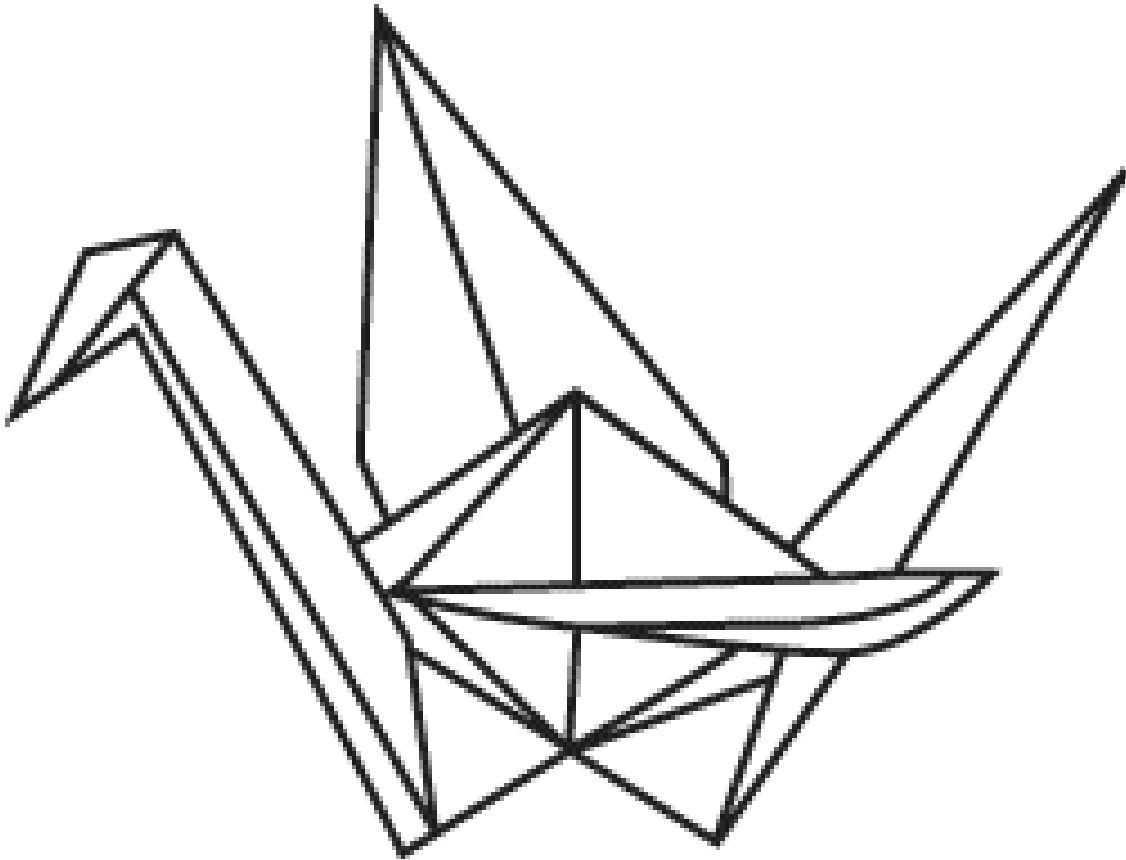
1. Schulman concludes: “Some human cultures, through their agriculture and hunting, have respected and adapted to ecological limits. We have the ability to shape our destiny — to be microbial attackers, or humble cells inside a living body” (16). Which choice do you think Schulman recommends? Write an essay in which you propose measures that could be taken on your college campus to make it more climate-friendly. What energy-saving measures are already being taken? What can be done to control carbon dioxide emissions? What measures do you think would have the greatest effect? You may find it helpful to review your response to the Reflecting on What You Know prompt for this selection before you start writing.
2. Using Schulman’s essay as a model, write an essay in which you create an analogy to explain a complex idea or concept such as freedom, capitalism, populism, life insurance, air pollution, or metabolism.
(Glossary: [Analogy](#))



PART FOUR Types of Essays



CHAPTER 14 Illustration



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Illustration is the use of examples — facts, opinions, samples, and anecdotes or stories — to make ideas more concrete and generalizations more specific and detailed. Examples enable writers to both tell and show what they mean. The more specific the example, the more effective it is. For instance, in an essay about alternative sources of energy, a writer might offer an example of how a local architecture firm designed a home heated by solar collectors instead of by a conventional oil, gas, or electric system.

A writer uses examples to clarify or support the thesis in an essay and the main ideas in paragraphs. Sometimes a single striking example suffices; at other times a whole series of related examples is necessary. The following paragraph presents a single extended example — an explanation of weather as a chaotic system:

The weather provides the most familiar example of a chaotic system. Meteorologists make thousands upon thousands of measurements of wind speed, air temperature, and barometric pressure in their efforts to predict the weather. They do pretty well with 24- and 48-hour forecasts, and sometimes they even get the seven-day predictions right. But no matter how fancy the measurements and the computer simulations, there is no way to predict what the weather will be a year from now. The chaotic nature of atmospheric motion is sometimes dramatized as the “butterfly effect,” which says that in a chaotic system an effect as small as a butterfly’s flapping its wings in Singapore may eventually make it rain in Texas.

— Robert M. Hazen and James Trefil, *Science Matters: Achieving Scientific Literacy*

This single example is effective because it is familiar to many readers. Hazen and Trefil explain the idea of a chaotic system in a simple manner and use an example familiar to all so readers better understand the point they are trying to make.

In contrast, another writer supports his topic sentence about the growth of the fast-food industry with several examples:

The extraordinary growth of the fast food industry has been driven by fundamental changes in American society. Adjusted for inflation, the hourly wage of the average U.S. worker peaked in 1973 and then steadily declined for the next twenty-five years. During that period, women entered the workforce in record numbers, often motivated less by a feminist perspective than by a need to pay the bills. In 1975, about one-third of American mothers with young children worked outside the home; today almost two-thirds of such mothers are employed. As the sociologists Cameron Lynne Macdonald and Carmen Sirianni have noted, the entry of so many women into the workforce has greatly increased demand for the types of services that housewives traditionally perform: cooking, cleaning, and child care. A generation ago, three-quarters of the money used to buy food in the United States was spent to prepare meals at home. Today about half of the money used to buy food is spent at restaurants — mainly at fast food restaurants.

— Eric Schlosser, *Fast Food Nation*

Schlosser uses numerous examples and adequate evidence to support his topic sentence. By citing specific examples of key changes in American society that have led to tremendous growth in the fast-food industry, Schlosser makes his point strong and convincing.

The following strategies will help you use illustration effectively:

- Begin by thinking of ideas and generalizations about your topic that you can make clearer and more persuasive by illustrating them with facts, anecdotes, or specific details.
- Focus primarily on your main point — the central generalization that you will develop in your essay.
- Be alert for other statements or references that may benefit from illustration.

Points that are already clear and uncontroversial and that your readers will understand and immediately agree with can stand on their own as you pass along quickly to your next idea; belaboring the obvious wastes your time and energy, as well as your reader's. Often, however, you will find that examples add clarity, color, and weight to what you say.

Consider the following generalization:

Americans are a pain-conscious people who would rather get rid of pain than seek and cure its root causes.

This assertion is broad and general; it raises the following questions: How so? What does this mean exactly? Why does the writer think so? The statement could be the topic sentence of a paragraph or even the thesis of an essay or of an entire book. You could make the generalization stronger and more meaningful through illustrations. You might support this statement by citing situations or cases in which Americans

have gone to the drugstore instead of to a doctor, as well as by supplying sales figures per capita of painkillers in the United States as compared with other countries.

Illustration is so useful and versatile a strategy that it is found in all kinds of writing, and it is essential for writing a successful argument essay. In an essay arguing that non-English-speaking students starting school in the United States should be taught English as a second language, student writer Hilda Alvarado could have made her point in a few words with an unsupported generalization:

Not only are non-English-speaking students in English-only schools unable to understand the information they are supposed to be learning, but they are also subject to frequent embarrassment and teasing from their classmates.

Instead, Alvarado supports her argument with the following illustration, drawn from her own experience as a Spanish-speaking child in an English-only school:

Without the use of Spanish, unable to communicate with the teacher or students, for six long weeks we guessed at everything we did. When we lined up to go anywhere, neither my sister nor I knew what to expect. Once, the teacher took the class on a bathroom break, and I mistakenly thought we were on our way to the cafeteria for lunch. Before we left, I grabbed our lunch money, and one of the girls in line began sneering and pointing. Somehow she figured out my mistake before I did.

When I realized why she was laughing, I became embarrassed and threw the money into my sister's desk as we walked out of the classroom.

— Hilda Alvarado, student

By offering an illustration, Alvarado makes her point more vividly and effectively.

Be Specific

Natalie Goldberg



Ritch Davidson/Cosmic Photography

Born in 1948 in Brooklyn, New York, Natalie Goldberg has made a specialty of writing about writing. Her first and best-

known work, *Writing Down the Bones: Freeing the Writer Within*, was published in 1986. Goldberg's advice to would-be writers is, on the one hand, practical and pithy; on the other, it is almost mystical in its call to know and appreciate the world. Her other books about writing include *Wild Mind: Living the Writer's Life* (1990), *Living Color* (1996), *Thunder and Lightning: Cracking Open the Writer's Craft* (2000), *Old Friend from Far Away: The Practice of Writing Memoir* (2008), and *The True Secret of Writing* (2013). Goldberg has also written fiction. Her first novel, *Banana Rose*, was published in 1994. She is also a painter whose work is exhibited in Taos, New Mexico. *Living Color: A Writer Paints Her World* (1997) is about painting as her second art form, and *Top of My Lungs* (2002) is a collection of poetry and paintings. Her most recent books are *The Great Spring: Writing, Zen, and This Zig-Zag Life* (2016) and *Let the Whole Thundering World Come Home: A Memoir* (2018), both reflections about her life.

In "Be Specific," a chapter from *Writing Down the Bones*, Goldberg brings us out of abstract ideas and "close to the ground." As you read, pay attention to how she uses illustration to demonstrate her point about being specific in one's writing.

Reflecting on What You Know

Suppose someone says to you, “I walked in the woods.” What do you envision? Write down what you see in your mind’s eye. Now suppose someone says, “I walked in the redwood forest.” Again, write down what you see. How are the two descriptions different, and why?

Be specific. Don’t say “fruit.” Tell what kind of fruit — “It is a pomegranate.” Give things the dignity of their names. Just as with human beings, it is rude to say, “Hey, girl, get in line.” That “girl” has a name. (As a matter of fact, if she’s at least twenty years old, she’s a woman, not a “girl” at all.) Things, too, have names. It is much better to say “the geranium in the window” than “the flower in the window.” “Geranium” — that one word gives us a much more specific picture. It penetrates more deeply into the beingness of that flower. It immediately gives us the scene by the window — red petals, green circular leaves, all straining toward sunlight.

About ten years ago I decided I had to learn the names of plants and flowers in my environment. I bought a book on them and walked down the tree-lined streets of Boulder,¹ examining leaf, bark, and seed, trying to match them up with their descriptions and names in the book. Maple, elm, oak, locust. I usually tried to cheat by asking people working in their yards the names of the flowers and trees growing there. I was

amazed how few people had any idea of the names of the live beings inhabiting their little plot of land.

When we know the name of something, it brings us closer to the ground. It takes the blur out of our mind; it connects us to the earth. If I walk down the street and see “dogwood,” “forsythia,” I feel more friendly toward the environment. I am noticing what is around me and can name it. It makes me more awake.

If you read the poems of William Carlos Williams,² you will see how specific he is about plants, trees, flowers — chicory, daisy, locust, poplar, quince, primrose, black-eyed Susan, lilacs — each has its own integrity. Williams says, “Write what’ s in front of your nose.” It’ s good for us to know what is in front of our nose. Not just “daisy,” but how the flower is in the season we are looking at it — “The days-eye hugging the earth / in August ... brownedged, / green and pointed scales / armor his yellow.”^{*} Continue to hone your awareness: to the name, to the month, to the day, and finally to the moment.

Williams also says: “No idea, but in things.” Study what is “in front of your nose.” By saying “geranium” instead of “flower,” you are penetrating more deeply into the present and being there. The closer we can get to what’ s in front of our nose, the more it can teach us everything. “To see the

World in a Grain of Sand, and a heaven in a Wild Flower
...” [**](#)

In writing groups and classes too, it is good to quickly learn the names of all the other group members. It helps to ground you in the group and make you more attentive to each other’ s work.

Learn the names of everything: birds, cheese, tractors, cars, buildings. A writer is all at once everything — an architect, French cook, farmer — and at the same time, a writer is none of these things.

[1](#)*Boulder*: a city in Colorado.

[2](#)*William Carlos Williams* (1883 – 1963): American poet.

[*](#)William Carlos Williams, “Daisy,” in *The Collected Earlier Poems* (New York: New Directions, 1938). [Goldberg’ s note]

[**](#)William Blake, “The Auguries of Innocence.” [Goldberg’ s note]

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What examples of flowers and fruits does Goldberg use to prove her point about illustration? How do these examples support her thesis? (Glossary: [Thesis](#))
2. Goldberg states, “I was amazed how few people had any idea of the names of the live beings inhabiting

their little plot of land” (2). How well do you know the names of the plants, flowers, and trees that grow where you live? Would you be able to write in detail about the flora and fauna surrounding you, even if you didn’ t know their names? How?

3. How does Goldberg “specifically” follow the advice she gives writers in this essay?
4. Goldberg makes several lists of the names of things. What purpose do these lists serve? (Glossary: [Purpose](#))
5. Throughout the essay, Goldberg instructs the reader to be specific and to be aware of the physical world. Of what besides names is the reader advised to be aware? Why?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What specific audience does Goldberg address? (Glossary: [Audience](#)) What in the essay led you to this conclusion?
2. What do you think Goldberg means when she states, “Give things the dignity of their names” (1)? Why, according to Goldberg, should writers refer to things by their specific names? How do you feel when people call you by your name instead of just saying, “Hey you” ? Explain.

3. In paragraphs 3, 5, and 6, Goldberg cites a number of advantages to be gained by knowing the names of things. What are these advantages? Do they sound reasonable to you? Why or why not?

Classroom Activity Using Illustration

Consider the following paragraph from the rough draft of a student paper on Americans' obsession with losing weight. The student writer wanted to show the extreme actions people sometimes take to improve their appearance.

Americans have long been obsessed with thinness — even at the risk of dying. In the 1930s, people took dinitrophenol, an industrial poison, to lose weight. It boosted metabolism but caused blindness and some deaths. Since that time, dieters have experimented with any number of bizarre schemes that seemed to work wonders in the short term but often end in disappointment or disaster in the long term. Some weight-loss strategies have even led to life-threatening eating disorders.

— Harry Crouse, student

Try your hand at revising this paragraph, supplying specific examples of “bizarre schemes” or “weight-loss strategies” you have tried, observed, or read about.

Share your examples with others in your class. Which examples best illustrate and support the central idea in the writer' s topic sentence?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Goldberg likes William Carlos Williams' s statement, "No idea, but in things" (5). What does this statement mean to you? Using this line as both a title and a thesis, write your own argument for the use of the specific over the general in a certain field — news reporting, writing poetry, or making music, for example. (Glossary: [Argumentation](#)) Use illustration to support your argument, providing specific, appropriate examples.
2. Write a brief essay advising your readers of something they should do. Title your essay, as Goldberg does, with a directive ("Be Specific"). Tell your readers how they can improve their lives by taking your advice, and give strong examples of the behavior you are recommending. Support your argument with specific and appropriate examples.

Adventures of the Dork Police

Michael Gardner



Mark Andreas

Michael Gardner is a retired police officer from the Cincinnati Police Department and an innovator in the use of verbal persuasion tactics rather than physical force in conflict resolution. In 1981, he and his wife Debbie, a retired sheriff, founded the Survive Institute, which helps companies, schools, and communities learn empowering self-defense strategies. Gardner and his wife have written a book titled *Raising Kids That Can Protect Themselves* (2004).

The following selection was published in *Sweet Fruit from the Bitter Tree: 61 Stories of Creative Compassionate Ways Out of Conflict*, edited by Mark Andreas (2011). In this excerpt, Gardner explores how disputes can be solved through “visual and verbal persuasion.” As you read, consider the function of anecdotes in the development of Gardner’s argument and whether you find these stories compelling.

Reflecting on What You Know

Reflect on a time when you or someone you know took a nontraditional approach to a situation and still achieved a good result. Why did your approach lead to this desirable outcome? What are the benefits or drawbacks to taking a nontraditional approach?

A lot of the calls we got on night shift were domestic violence runs. Cops hate making domestic runs because they’re so dangerous, but for research purposes my partner

and I asked other cops, “Do you mind if we start taking over your domestic runs so we can experiment with defusing hostile situations?” Of course we got no objections.

Traditionally, police officers are limited to only four choices for controlling situations — visual and verbal persuasion, chemical irritant, impact weapon, and deadly force. In training, most emphasis was on weaponry defense, without nearly enough on visual and verbal defense. My partner and I saw the need to stretch our flexibility to hundreds of choices in this uncharted territory.

The traditional approach in police work for a domestic run was to show up at an apartment and bang on the door using a raid-type knock with the police night stick, BAM BAM BAM BAM! I even hate it when the UPS or mail carrier bangs on my door to give me something I *want*, so I tried to imagine how someone already in emotional distress would be angered even more with a raid-type bang on their door. To be less intrusive and confrontational we started showing up and doing the “shave and haircut” knock, a very light “Rap ta-ta tap tap, tap tap.” Even if the people inside didn’t catch on to the jingle, it was a less invasive knock, and its association with a harmless advertisement was more to relax *us* than the people inside. It kept us at a condition orange — alert, but not the red of alarmed. We would even joke sometimes going into an apartment, “Hey let’s be condition purple.” What

we were really saying was, “Hey let’ s not get red, because if we go in there red, we’ re going to have a fight.”

The usual question police were trained to ask when entering a home was, “What’ s the problem here?” Well, if you enter after a loud raid-type knock and ask them, “What’ s the problem here?” they’ ll give you a problem, usually several. They may tell you their problems from twenty years ago.

Instead we’ d ask something like, “What have you decided to do between the time you called us and the time we got here?” That put them in solution mode. Other times we’ d ask people to step out into the hallway so they wouldn’ t feel the need to defend their turf. We also purposely wore our hats when we approached, so when we did enter their house or apartment we could take them off as a sign of respect.

My partner and I became known to our fellow officers as the Dork Police, because no one knew what crazy thing we were going to do next. They were equally amazed at our success in non-violent control of tense situations. We experimented daily with ways of startling subjects into confusion in order to interrupt their dangerous mental patterns and provide a space for something more positive.

For example, we would sometimes approach potentially dangerous domestic disputes with our jackets purposely

buttoned improperly, or with our caps pulled down so our ears stuck out. Other times we' d say "no" while nodding our heads up and down. Unless the combatants were too intoxicated or high to observe this odd behavior, they stopped, at least temporarily. They couldn' t help responding to what they saw. Then it was hard for them to pick up their fight where they had left off.

Sometimes we' d walk into a shouting match between a couple, and we' d just run over and switch the channel on the TV set. If one of them said, "Hey, what the hell are you doing?" We' d say cheerfully, "Hey, you' re not going to listen to us anyway, so we' re going to watch some TV."

All we were trying to do was get them to refocus out of their anger and onto something else. We would do anything to create a change. Once that was accomplished, we' d offer suggestions for where couples could go for longer-term help.

Using humor was particularly useful when performing routine, uncomfortable tasks like patting down or frisking a suspect. While maintaining physical control, we would like to say, "You don' t have any hand grenades, swords, or bazookas hidden on you, do you?" Subjects generally laughed it off. Now and then, one would disclose that he had a knife or razor.

When couples were screaming at each other we' d start sniffing and shouting out. "Oh, do you smell gas? Where' s your stove? There must be a burner on!" While the fight was temporarily stopped, my partner and I would go to the kitchen and pretend to check the stove for gas leaks. After a few minutes of sniffing the stove and kitchen area, we would advise the people that everything was OK, then ask "What else can we help you with?" The response was amazing. Often they said, "Nothing, officer ...". If the argument did begin again, all my partner and I had to do was to sniff with a concerned look on our faces. With this pattern interruption, the subjects' personal fighting became secondary to the threat of a gas explosion in their home. They may even start getting an unconscious connection of, *Every time I start getting nasty there' s danger, maybe I should try something else.*

Other times, we would enter a residence and be greeted by someone standing in a fighting position and shouting, "You two think you can take me? Come on!" We would mirror his stance, but hold our palms up instead of making fists, saying, "No way. We heard how tough you are. We can' t beat you, we' d have to call ten more guys in here." If that statement had any effect, we would follow up with, "Why don' t we talk first, then you can kick our butts." On several occasions the potentially violent subject changed his mind. And if he didn' t respond to our initial statement,

that signaled us to try something else. Initially it was hard for us to give this kind of “pull” statement when a violent subject “pushed” us verbally. We instinctively wanted to “push” back with an “attack” statement. Yet the patience of our “pull” statement always minimized the force of our arrest.

One time we had a husband and wife close to killing each other. They were shouting countless obscenities at each other, and their hand gestures were disjointed and out of sync with the tone and tempo of their verbal language. I remembered the metaphor of an orchestra conductor — when people talk in rhythm with their gestures it tends to be good venting; letting their anger come out verbally rather than physically. But when their gestures are short, choppy, stab-like motions, disconnected from their language, it is likely that they’ re about to explode physically. This couple was actually making verbal threats like, “I’ m going to kill you, you son of a bitch!” “You’ re dead, mother-fucker!”

In a flash I said, “In all my years of police work, I’ ve never seen somebody able to express their anger like you can! I appreciate that, because sometimes things really piss me off and I wish I could express my anger like you are!” I was empathizing with them to bring their attention to me and to the importance of what they were feeling, and away from a fight.

Another time we came into an argument with the woman yelling and screaming at her husband. I said to her, “I bet you don’ t talk to the mailman this way, do you?”

“What? Of course not!”

“And I bet you don’ t talk to your car mechanic that way, do you?”

“No, of course not!”

“Well the reason you talk to your husband like that is obviously because you care a whole lot more about what he says than what the mailman or the mechanic says.”

“Yeah, well I guess so.”

My questions first took her attention away from her emotions and what she was mad about. Then I offered her a new meaning for her outburst — it was because she *cared* about her husband. After about 15-20 minutes of me telling them how frustrated I was at not being able to express my feelings the way they could, they started counseling me. Soon it was apparent by the way they were sitting next to each other and looking at each other that they were eager to be left alone. I think we reframed their anger toward each other to such an extent that they wanted us gone so they could make up!

Once we came into a heated dispute and I said to the man,
“Hey, you don’ t work for the city, do you?”

“NO!”

“That car out there with the lights on, that’ s not your car, is it?”

“NO!”

“You don’ t want us here, do you?”

“NO!”

“You’ ll be happy when we leave here, won’ t you?”

“F — K yeah!”

This way I matched him and let him express himself. He was in the mood to disagree, so I started with questions all of which let him say “No.” Then I shifted to a “Yes” question, leading him to a more positive place and getting his explicit agreement that when we left he’ d be happy. It might sound like a small thing, but it made a huge difference. Now we were on the same page and he was more relaxed — no longer disagreeing with everything we said.

We' d also do a thing I called "word salad." I never did it in a disrespectful way, but when people get violent they' re behaving worse than childish. Sometimes I' d say, "What you' re saying here sounds like a phonological ambiguity to me, so rather than jeopardize any other litigation circumstances why don' t you just take a walk and let things cool off?"

They got so confused by the first part of my sentence, they would jump on the first thing that made sense, usually responding. "I' ll just take a walk and cool off a bit."

I' d say, "Great, I appreciate that."

Often we would use many of these different tactics one after the other, until we found what worked. By systematically attempting to stop violence by using our appearance or words, we put ourselves in a position where we would be much more justified — both emotionally and legally — if we ended up having to resort to a higher degree of force. Yet in all these experiments on permanent night shift, and during my thirty-year police career, I never fired my gun. I had to use mace on a person only once, simply because the man was so intoxicated I couldn' t communicate with him. We had tried many things, but he just wasn' t there because of the alcohol. He had a little paring knife that he wouldn' t drop. Technically I could have shot him, but I had been relaxed and

aware enough to keep a table between us, so I was able to subdue him with the mace. As amazing as these techniques were for defusing violence in the moment, our biggest success was that we stopped getting return calls from the places we visited. Before we started using these techniques, it was common to get calls from the same location two or three times a night. Sometimes my partner and I would spend 15 or 30 minutes out on a call, and we'd get in trouble from our supervisor because he wanted us in and out. If they didn't straighten up right away he wanted us to simply arrest them. But we knew we could save time in the long run by coming to a peaceful resolution...

Unfortunately, it's very difficult to measure what *doesn't* happen, but I can say confidently that I was involved in hundreds of peaceful resolutions that would have ended up in arrests or fights had we used traditional police procedure. Ever since my eyes were opened to what is possible, I've been studying and researching how police officers everywhere can increase their choices by using visual and verbal persuasion to prevent, or at least minimize, their use of force in violent situations. Believe me, police officers all over this country need new tools for accomplishing their duties. They are hungry for positive education that will enhance their control over themselves and others. No group of professionals needs flexibility more than police officers.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Gardner sets up his argument by describing the traditional approach that most police officers must take when they encounter conflict. What are the four choices usually available to police officers? Why do you suppose Gardner decided to describe these first? (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#))
2. Name one reason that the traditional approaches that police officers take may not work, according to Gardner.
3. Why do you think Gardner tells specific stories about some situations and generalizes other situations? Does this strategy make his argument more effective or less effective? Explain.
4. Which of Gardner's many examples did you find most interesting? Did you find this example effective as well? Explain.
5. When speaking about frisking a suspect, Gardner writes "humor was particularly useful" (10). Identify another situation in which Gardner reports using humor to resolve conflict, and comment on the sentence-level tactics that he uses to make the situation funny — or to make his writing funny.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What assumptions about human nature do Gardner and his partner make in devising their strategies to “defus[e] hostile situations” (1)? What, according to Gardner, was the goal of their persuasion tactics?
2. Gardner writes that when threatened he and his partner “instinctively wanted to ‘push’ back with an ‘attack’ statement. Yet the patience of our ‘pull’ statement always minimized the force of our arrest” (12). How would you define a “push” statement and a “pull” statement? Give an example of each. What would be the equivalent of a “push” statement and a “pull” statement in an argument essay? Explain.
3. Gardner alludes to but does not directly describe situations in which the persuasion tactics he and his partner used did not work. Why does Gardner make the decision not to go in-depth about such moments? In what ways might this decision be related to Gardner’s purpose in this essay? (Glossary: [Purpose](#))

Classroom Activity Using Illustration

While some writers like Gardner use a number of examples to illustrate and support their thesis statements, other writers have occasion to use a single striking example to make their central point. Using the model statement and

example that follows, think of a single example that might be used to best illustrate each of the following potential thesis statements.

MODEL: Seatbelts save lives. (*Example: Your aunt was in a car accident, but a seatbelt saved her life.*)

Friends can be very handy.

Good study skills can improve a student' s grades.

Loud music can damage your hearing.

Humor can often make a bad situation more tolerable.

Social media isn' t all that it' s cracked up to be.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write an essay that argues for an innovative strategy to resolve a particular type of conflict. Describe the type of conflict clearly with an appropriate level of detail, and build your argument by using at least two personal anecdotes. (Glossary: [Details](#); [Anecdotes](#))
2. The heavily reported police killings of black Americans such as Michael Brown, Philando Castile, George Floyd, Eric Garner, Trayvon Martin, Tamir Rice, Alton Sterling, and Breonna Taylor — among many others — make Gardner' s ideas important to consider and relevant to current social and political movements. Look up the events associated with one of these killings and write an essay arguing for a

different way or ways that the conflict could have been handled. Apply at least one idea from “Adventures of the Dork Police” in your essay.

Old Things, Used Things

Priscilla Long



Jerry Jaz

A nonfiction and fiction author, Priscilla Long has written extensively about the craft of writing. Long was born in

Pennsylvania, grew up in Maryland, and now writes from Washington state. She earned her MFA in Creative Writing from the University of Washington in 1990 and has received numerous awards in both teaching and writing, including the Richard Hugo House Founders' Award and a Seattle Arts Commission award. Some of her many books include *Crossing Over: Poems* (2015), *Fire and Stone: Where Do We Come From? What Are We? Where Are We Going?* (2016), *Minding the Muse: A Handbook for Painters, Composers, Writers, and Other Creators* (2016), and *The Writer's Portable Mentor: A Guide to Art, Craft, and the Writing Life* (Second Edition, 2018). Additionally, Long's science column, *Science Frictions*, appeared weekly on *The American Scholar* website for nearly two years. Long has written a plethora of other creative non-fiction essays for various publications.

The following selection, originally published in the fall 2015 edition of *The Antioch Review*, was a notable essay acknowledged in *The Best American Essays 2016*. It was also nominated for a Pushcart Prize, an accolade for work published by small presses. Long's verbal illustration techniques support her main idea that older technologies are, in fact, still helpful. As you read, look for the facts, opinions, and specific anecdotes that the author uses to illustrate her ideas.

Reflecting on What You Know

Name one kind of technology — such as phones, cars, or computers — that has changed since you were a child. Do you feel that the current version of this technology is better than what it was when you were a child? Explain.

I have always cherished old things, used things, things marked by the passage of time and human events.

— Henry Miller

What good is a wind-up clock? Who needs, any more, a Mead composition book, college ruled? What's the point of a dip pen? Why pack an abacus, if, indeed, you ever did pack an abacus¹? Why bother to make change when cash registers make change? Why learn to add when calculators add? Of what possible use is a box of stationery with matching envelopes, each requiring a postage stamp? Why bother with books, the kind made of pages you turn, when you've got a screen? Who needs a rake when you've got a leaf-blower? Who needs a workhorse when you've got a tractor? Who needs a fiddle when your mp3 player can fiddle?

What good are old things? Old technologies, old machines, old tools, old skills?

A key argument made by David Edgerton in his old (2007) book *The Shock of the Old* is that old technology is not past technology. Old technologies are in vigorous use around the

world, along with what Edgerton calls Creole technologies — old and new fused into a third thing, a different thing. In some situations, Edgerton writes, the use of old technology is more efficacious than the use of new. Skilled abacus users are swift calculators. The workhorse works more cost-effectively than does a tractor on some farms and on some jobs. *Old* should not automatically connote *backward*. What's really old, he insists, is our ideology about invention and innovation — that new is better, that to innovate is to advance, that anyone lacking the latest device is out of date, that a country lacking the latest technological “advances” are the opposite of advanced — backward.

Technologies shift constantly, and stay the same, and regress, depending on who you are and where you are. With any new gizmo we should ask: What is this good for and who is it good for? What do we gain and what do we lose? How does giving over a particular skill to a device affect our brain's capacity to think, to remember, to concentrate, to create? What particular gains are worth the loss of a capacity or skill?

I grew up on a commercial dairy farm on the Eastern Shore of Maryland. We supplemented our income by growing strawberries and selling them door-to-door in town. Our parents gave us a stern lesson in making change — you don't subtract, you *count*. The box of strawberries costs \$3.68. The lady at the

door gives you five bucks. You count up from \$3.68 to \$5 and that' s the change. So, \$3.69, \$3.70 (that' s two pennies); \$3.80, \$3.90, \$4 (that' s three dimes); \$4 to \$5 (that' s one dollar). Get it? Most cashiers working today do not.

Some older technologies produce a higher-quality product. Who would claim that a Hostess Twinkie tastes as good as a chocolate cake made from scratch? Robots, it turns out, are unable to properly wash the windows of skyscrapers, according to *The New York Times*. The treacherous but rather well-paid job of washing windows in the clouds supported by a teetering scaffold lowered from the roof must be done by humans; robots miss intricate corners and edges intrinsic to the elegant designs of glass-clad skyscrapers. Who wants their expensive vista splotched or dirt-edged? Another old technology still in vigorous use (and also making a comeback) is the workhorse on small- to medium-sized farms. Amish farmers in Pennsylvania have always used horses — sometimes along with a tractor — and their farms are debt-free and productive. The workhorse idea is catching on elsewhere; for one thing, oats and grass are cheaper than gasoline. (See articles on the subject in *Small Farmer' s Journal*.)

In music, vinyl is the old thing, the record, played on the record player or phonograph. Then came the digitalized CD, played on the CD player. Then came mp3s streamed from iTunes or played on the iPod, and which clipped off the high and low

notes that allegedly the human ear can' t hear. Then came Neil Young, the musician, who in 1982 hated the loss of sound on the first CDs, and later hated the worse loss of sound on mp3s. (Among audiophiles debate rages over the audio qualities of vinyl vs. CD vs. mp3. I trust Neil Young' s musician' s ear.) Young talked to digital pioneer Steve Jobs, who brought us Apple and iPod and iTunes and mp3s. Jobs loved music; at home he listened to it on vinyl. Neil Young' s firm PonoMusic has developed a digital music listening device, the Pono, which claims to correct all this, to give a listening experience close to that heard in the recording studio. I say more power to Pono, the newest new thing going.

But back to old things. Vinyl is not the oldest old thing. The oldest old thing is what folks gave up when the phonograph (and later the radio) arrived to play music for them. They gave up the common everyday skill of playing music on one or more instruments. I caught a glimpse of the old way when I visited the west coast of Ireland in 1973. Everyone went to the pubs, including nuns, including children. And everyone played an instrument, or so it seemed to me. Children were taught the penny whistle, the bodhran (drum), the bones,² the Melodeon,³ and that haunting Irish manner of traditional a cappella singing. Instructing children in their musical inheritance was taken very seriously, and musical wizards of all ages played in the pubs. Whether these

traditions are still going strong I do not know, but at the time I was blown away.

Turning now to language. We write on screen, read on screen. And what's the difference? The screen is more lightweight (and you need only one) than the physical book with its sheets folded into pages and cut open, its gutter, type-box, fixed margins, its actual design, its binding, perhaps in linen or leather. Who needs it? Why not dump the book, except as a nostalgic object? Isn't this the future?

Writing entered human history only about 6,000 years ago, but reading likely goes back much further, to tracking animals, according to reading psychologist Stanislas Dehaene. You are tracking a deer, the hoofmarks on the forest floor representing "signs" that stand for "deer" and that proceed in a certain direction. To our brain, letters may be analogous to animal tracks on a terrain. And according to studies of what the brain does while reading, the brain may understand the physical book as a type of terrain. There's a spatial aspect, the left or verso side, the right or recto side, to speak in bibliographic terms. The ground the story covers is represented by the thickness of the part you've read on your left versus the thickness remaining on your right. Elements of the story necessary for comprehension, the moment Oliver Twist raises his bowl to beg for more porridge, may be incorporated into memory in part by where on the page

it falls in relation to the two type boxes and eight corners. That and turning the page physically helps the brain form a mental map of the contents of the book. Cognitive tests of people reading on screen versus reading on the printed page suggest that readers on screen retain less information. Screen readers also spend more time searching for words, scrolling, browsing, and clicking, as opposed to just sitting there reading. Also, when reading a printed book, we are more likely to go back and reread a passage we don' t fully understand.

Reading brings us to writing and writing brings us to handwriting. Should we abandon handwriting entirely, in favor of tapping keys? Neuroscientific studies suggest that we should keep on teaching children handwriting and that we should keep writing by hand ourselves, even as we also type on the keyboard. "Children not only learn to read more quickly when they first learn to write by hand," writes Maria Konnikova in a *New York Times* article titled "What' s Lost as Handwriting Fades," "but they also remain better able to generate ideas and retain information." When children make letters by hand, another study showed, three areas of the brain go active (the left fusiform gyrus, the inferior frontal gyrus, and the posterior parietal cortex). When they tap a key to get the same letter, these areas of the brain remain quiet. Even in adults, fast typing "may diminish our ability to process new information," according

to Konnikova. Finally, consider a *Scientific American* article titled “A Learning Secret: Don’ t Take Notes with a Laptop.” The article reports on a study suggesting that students who take notes by hand on paper actually learn more. Since you can handwrite many fewer words than you can type in the same amount of time, as you take notes by hand, you “listen, digest, and summarize” and you engage more closely with the material and you end up ahead.

I’ m a writer in several genres and I begin virtually every piece or poem in a notebook with pen in hand. In the notebook I do discovery writing to find out what I want to say. I mutter and mumble and question. (*Do I want to talk about photography in this piece or is that one thing too many? People will probably call me an Old Fart. Should I talk about the slow food movement, the slow art movement? Is this an environmental piece, a treatise on walking to the store? Wow, I could include just about anything. Is there anything that doesn’ t have an older technology?*) I ruminate on content but also on structure. Decisions are made.

Then, of course, I move to the keyboard.

I adore my laptop. I surf the Internet just as anyone does. I’ ve spent more than fifteen years as the editor of an online history encyclopedia (HistoryLink.org), and it’ s obvious to me that digital is the way for encyclopedias to

go, given the ease of updating and correcting existing entries and adding new ones. I pursue musical fascinations on YouTube, scoping movements and careers from Muddy Waters⁴ to Dolly Parton⁵ to Mick Jagger⁶ to Miles Davis.⁷ I don' t really "like" Facebook, but I do use it. I tweet. I maintain an author website. I shop online occasionally. I have bonded to my smartphone.

I don' t suggest we refuse new technologies, only that we slow down, consider the source, consider the cost to our brain, our capacities, our native brilliance. We should all become fluent speakers in the land of computers. But we should also keep reading books the old way, at least some of the time. We should keep writing by hand, at least some of the time. If our handwriting is terrible, we should work on it, relearn it, practice it, take one of the new handwriting courses, maybe even learn calligraphy. And while we' re at it, let' s start a movement to walk to the store, to bake chocolate cake from scratch, to rake those leaves.

¹*abacus*: a tool for making mathematical calculations by sliding counters along rods.

²*the bones*: a folk instrument made of animal bones or sticks that are knocked against each other.

³*Melodeon*: a small accordion.

⁴*Muddy Waters*: McKinley Morganfield (1913 – 1983), American singer-songwriter known as “the father of Chicago blues.”

⁵*Dolly Parton*: born 1946, influential American country singer-songwriter.

⁶*Mick Jagger*: Michael Philip Jagger (born 1943), English songwriter and lead singer of the Rolling Stones.

⁷*Miles Davis* (1926 – 1991): influential American jazz musician and composer.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. According to Long, what is David Edgerton’s argument in his book *The Shock of the Old*? How does this argument form a foundation for Long’s main idea?
2. What type of example does Long use in paragraph 5? What point is she making about cashiers today and the technology that they use?
3. What is the topic sentence in paragraph 6? Are the multiple illustrations in this paragraph effective in expressing Long’s main idea in the paragraph and in her essay as a whole? Why or why not?
4. Long writes, “To our brain, letters may be analogous to animal tracks on a terrain (10). What does she mean by this statement?
5. In what way does Long clarify her overall main idea in her conclusion? Do you find her conclusion

effective? Why or why not? (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Would you describe the questions in Long's opening paragraphs as hooks for her introduction, illustrations of her main idea, or both? Explain.
2. In paragraph 4, Long presents a number of questions that she believes we should ask about "any new gizmo." Do you think that it is important to ask such questions about new products? Explain your answer with reference to a "new gizmo" you've encountered.
3. Are you a member of Priscilla Long's intended audience (Glossary: [Audience](#))? Explain.

Classroom Activity Using Illustration

In preparation for an essay about gift giving, think about meaningful presents that you would like to give or receive. In your opinion, what is an ideal gift? Illustrate your idea of an ideal gift by briefly describing one or more of the best gifts you have ever received or given. Share your examples of best gifts with

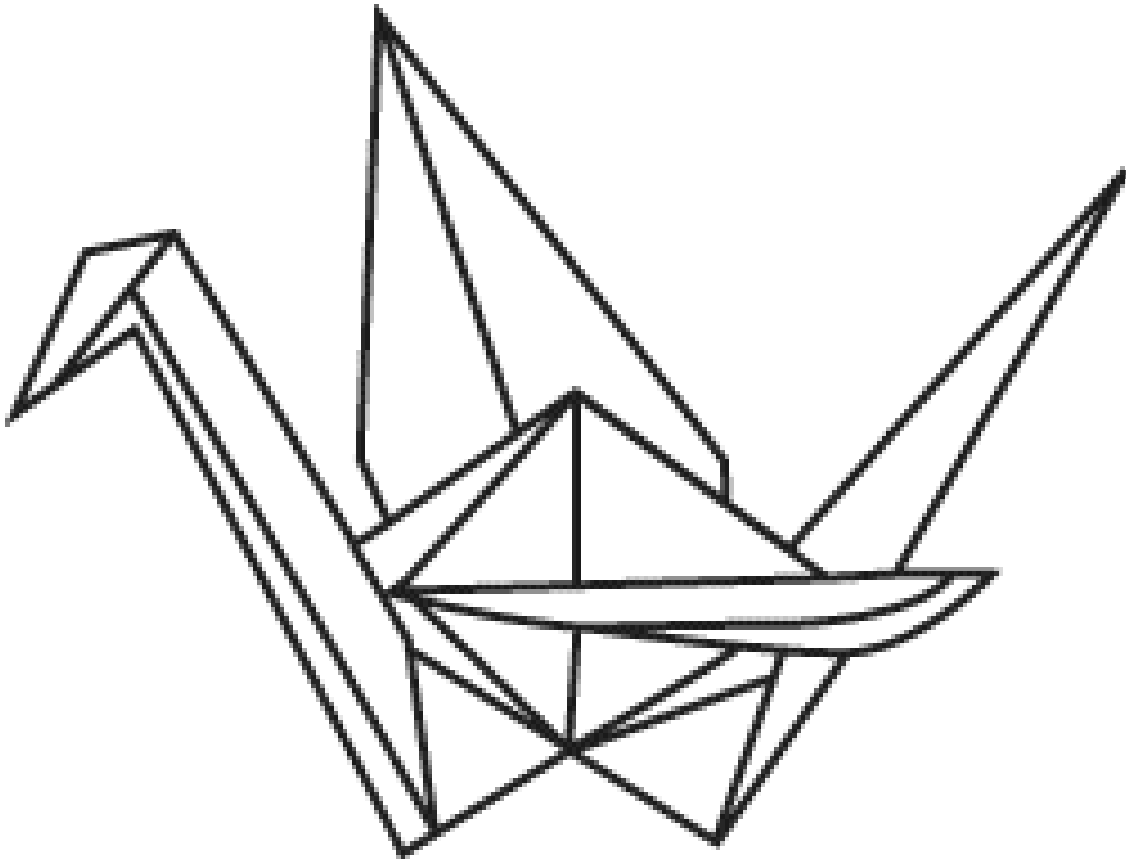
classmates and discuss any generalizations you can make about such gifts.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write an essay about something old that you wish still existed. You may write about a form of technology, an object, or an idea. Support your overall main idea with anecdotal illustrations from your own experience or observations.
2. Create a thesis statement about the unintended consequence or consequences of a form of technology that many people use frequently. Support your point with illustrations. Make sure you include at least two types of examples (such as facts, opinions, sample objects, or anecdotes) in your essay.



CHAPTER 15 Narration



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

To narrate is to tell a story or to recount a series of events. Whenever you relate an incident or use an anecdote (a very brief story) to make a point, you use narration. In its broadest sense, narration is any account of any event or series of events. We all love to hear stories; some people believe that sharing stories is a part of what defines us as human beings. Good stories are interesting, sometimes suspenseful, and always instructive because they give us insights into the human condition. Although most often associated with fiction, narration is effective and useful in

all kinds of writing. For example, in [“Anxiety: Challenge by Another Name”](#) (p. 73), James Lincoln Collier narrates what happened and what he learned when he was invited by a friend to spend the summer on the Argentinian Pampas.

ELEMENTS OF NARRATION

Good narration has five essential features:

- a clear context
- well-chosen and thoughtfully emphasized detail
- a logical, often chronological organization
- an appropriate and consistent point of view
- a meaningful point or purpose

Consider the following narrative from a student essay titled “I Remember Love” :

I remember standing in my driveway that evening after we got back from dinner; her eyes sparkled in the dim light from my truck’ s interior as she stood beside it with the door open. I held her hands while we talked about spending Christmas morning with our families, and that we would not see each other until the evening. I told her that I had a Christmas gift for her so she did not have to wait until the following evening. I recall the excitement in her eyes when I handed her the wrapped present with a card attached to the top of the package. She asked me if she could open it right then, and I told her I didn’ t mind; however, I recommended that she at least save the card for Christmas morning. She agreed, and she seemed so happy after opening the gift; she hugged me tightly, and we kissed as we held on to each other in the cold night air.

I remember when she was walking away, I wanted to yell out “I love you,” but in that moment, I also remember thinking that there was no reason to rush it. I figured there would be plenty of time to tell her that I loved her, and I remember that she meant more to me than anyone or anything I had ever known. The few seconds it took her to leave my sight may have been the same few seconds in which I experienced the deepest thoughts of my life as I realized the woman of my dreams was right in front of me, and I finally found the person who made me feel complete. I thought about how she was all I wanted as I stood spellbound by everything from the kiss to her eyes. Even after she had driven out of view, I still stood there for several minutes in the cold of night, thinking that she would be the last girl I would ever kiss; I recall being completely all right with this idea, and I hoped she felt the same way. As I walked inside the house, I felt better than I ever had before or since.

— Skyler Waid, student

This story contains all the elements of good narration. The writer begins by establishing a clear context for his narrative by telling when, where, and to whom the action happened. He has chosen details well, including enough details so that we know what is happening but not so many that we become overwhelmed, confused, or bored. The writer organizes his narration logically with a beginning that sets the scene, a middle that relates an exchange between him and his girlfriend, and an end that makes his point, all arranged chronologically. He tells the entire story from the first-

person point of view. The writer could have chosen to tell his story from the third-person point of view. In this point of view, the narrator is not a participant in the action and uses the pronouns *he* and *she* instead of *I*. Finally, he reveals the purpose of his narration: to recount his experience of the first time he fell in love.

In the following example, Tara Westover narrates an interaction with one of her professors near the beginning of her time at the University of Cambridge. Again we experience the event directly through the writer's eyes, and also through her ears, as she includes dialogue to make us feel that we were there with her that day.

A gust of wind swept over the parapet and Dr. Kerry teetered, clutching the wall. I stepped up onto the ridge so he could flatten himself against the buttress. He stared at me, waiting for an explanation.

"I've roofed my share of hay sheds," I said finally.

"So your legs are stronger? Is that why you can stand in this wind?"

I had to think before I could answer. "I can stand in this wind, because I'm not trying to stand in it," I said. "The wind is just wind. You could withstand these gusts on the ground, so you can withstand them in the air. There is no difference. Except the difference you make in your head."

He stared at me blankly. He hadn't understood.

"I'm just standing," I said. "You are all trying to compensate, to get your bodies lower because the height scares you. But the crouching and the sidestepping are not natural. You've made yourselves vulnerable. If you could just control your panic, this wind would be nothing."

"The way it is nothing to you," he said.

— Tara Westover, ["Pygmalion,"](#) pp. 487–88

As you begin to write your own narration, take time to ask yourself why you are telling your story. Your purpose in writing will influence which events and details you include and which you leave out. You should include enough details about the action and its context so that your readers can understand what's going on. However, you should not get so carried away with details that your readers become confused or bored by an excess of information. In good storytelling, deciding what to leave out is as important as deciding what to include.

NARRATIVE ORGANIZATION

Be sure to give some thought to the organization of your narrative. Chronological organization is natural in narration because it is a reconstruction of the original order of events, but it is not always the most interesting. To add interest to your storytelling, try using a technique common in the movies and theater called *flashback*. Begin your narration midway through the story with an important or exciting event, and then use flashback to fill in what happened earlier. Notice how one student uses this very technique. She disrupts the chronological organization of her narrative by beginning in the recent past and then uses a flashback to take us back to when she was a youngster:

Essay opens
in recent past

It was a Monday afternoon, and I was finally home from track practice. The coach had just told me that I had a negative attitude and should contemplate why I was on the team. My father greeted me in the living room.

Dialogue
creates
historical
present

"Hi, honey. How was practice?"

"Not good, Dad. Listen, I don't want to do this anymore. I hate the track team."

"What do you mean *hate*?"

"The constant pressure is making me crazy."

"How so?"

"It's just not fun anymore."

"Well, I'll have to talk to the coach —"

"No! You're supposed to be my father, not my coach."

"I am your father, but I'm sure . . ."

"Just let me do what I want. You've had your turn."

He just let out a sigh and left the room. Later he told me that I was wasting my "God-given abilities." The funny part was that none of my father's anger hit me at first. All I knew was that I was free.

Essay
returns in
time to when
troubles
began

My troubles began the summer I was five years old. It was late June . . .

—Trena Isley, student

Description

The excerpt reads as follows.

It was a Monday afternoon, and I was finally home from track practice. The coach had just told me that I had a negative attitude and should contemplate why I was on the team. My father greeted me in the living room. An accompanying annotation reads, Essay opens in recent past.

“Hi, honey. How was practice?”

“Not good, Dad. Listen, I don’ t want to do this anymore. I hate the track team.” An accompanying annotation reads, Dialogue creates historical present.

“What do you mean hate?”

“The constant pressure is making me crazy.”

“How so?”

“It’ s just not fun anymore.”

“Well, I’ ll have to talk to the coach (em dash)”

“No! You’ re supposed to be my father, not my coach.”

“I am your father, but I’ m sure (ellipsis)”

“Just let me do what I want. You’ ve had your turn.”

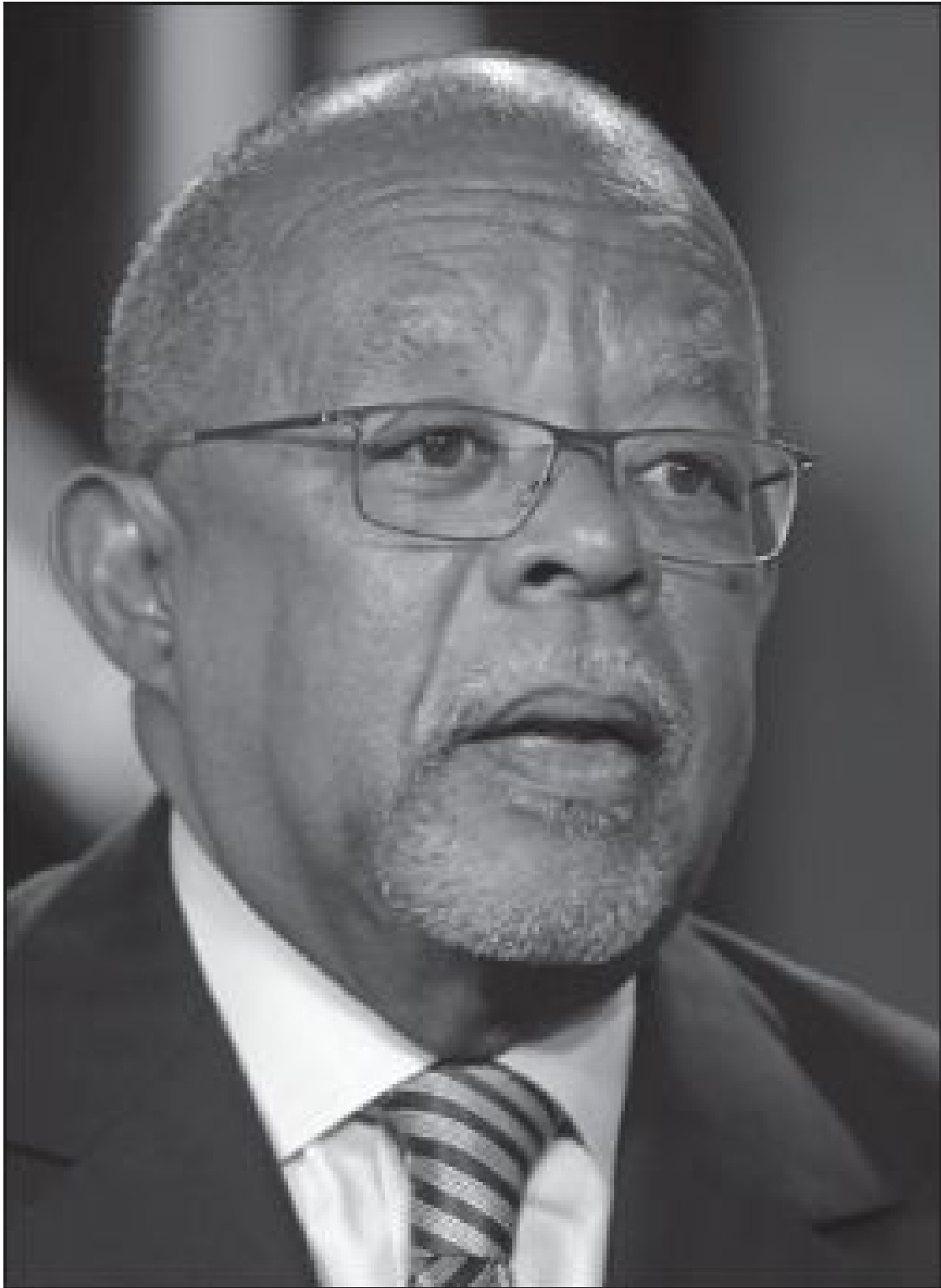
He just let out a sigh and left the room. Later he told me that I was wasting my “God-given abilities.” The funny part was that none of my father’ s anger hit me at first. All I knew was that I was free.

My troubles began the summer I was five years old. It was late June (ellipsis) An accompanying annotation reads, Essay returns in time to when troubles began.

The writer’ s name reads, Trena Isley, student.

What's in a Name?

Henry Louis Gates Jr.



Frederick M. Brown/Getty Images

One of the preeminent African American scholars of our time, Henry Louis Gates Jr. was born in West Virginia in 1950. He

is the Alphonse Fletcher University Professor and director of the W. E. B. Du Bois Institute for African and African American Research at Harvard University. Among his impressive list of publications are *The Signifying Monkey: A Theory of Afro-American Literary Criticism* (1988), *Loose Canons: Notes on Culture Wars* (1992), *Thirteen Ways of Looking at a Black Man* (1999), *Mr. Jefferson and Miss Wheatley* (2003), and *Black in Latin America* (2011). He has also hosted several PBS documentary series: *Finding Your Roots* (2012–present), *The African Americans* (2013), *Africa's Great Civilizations* (2013), *Reconstruction: America After the Civil War* (2019). His *Colored People: A Memoir* (1994) recollects his youth growing up in Piedmont, West Virginia, and his emerging sexual and racial awareness. Gates studied history at Yale University. Then, with the assistance of an Andrew W. Mellon Foundation Fellowship and a Ford Foundation Fellowship, he pursued advanced degrees in English at Clare College at the University of Cambridge. He has been honored with a MacArthur Foundation Fellowship, inclusion on *Time* magazine's "25 Most Influential Americans" list, a National Humanities Medal, and election to the American Academy of Arts and Letters.

In this essay, excerpted from a longer article published in the fall 1989 issue of *Dissent* magazine, Gates tells the story of an early encounter with the language of prejudice. As you read, notice that he feels the sting of racism

firsthand when he learns how one of the “bynames” used by white people to define African Americans robs them of their identity. Pay attention to how Gates’ s use of dialogue gives immediacy and poignancy to his narration.

Reflecting on What You Know

Reflect on the use of racially charged language. For example, has anyone ever used a racial epithet or name to refer to you? When did you first become aware that such names existed? How do you feel about being characterized by your race? If you yourself have ever used such names, what was your intent in using them? What was the response of others?

The question of color takes up much space in these pages, but the question of color, especially in this country, operates to hide the graver questions of the self.

— James Baldwin, 1961

... blood, darky, Tar Baby, Kaffir, shine ... moor, blackamoor, Jim Crow, spook ... quadroon, meriney, red bone, high yellow ... Mammy, porch monkey, home, homeboy, George ... spearchucker, schwarze, Leroy, Smokey ... mouli, buck, Ethiopian, brother, sistah ...

— Trey Ellis, 1989

I had forgotten the incident completely, until I read Trey Ellis’ s essay, “Remember My Name,” in a recent issue of the *Village Voice*¹ (June 13, 1989). But there, in the middle

of an extended italicized list of the bynames of “the race” (“the race” or “our people” being the terms my parents used in polite or reverential discourse, “jigaboo” or “nigger” more commonly used in anger, jest, or pure disgust), it was: “George.” Now the events of that very brief exchange return to mind so vividly that I wonder why I had forgotten it.

My father and I were walking home at dusk from his second job. He “moonlighted” as a janitor in the evenings for the telephone company. Every day but Saturday, he would come home at 3:30 from his regular job at the paper mill, wash up, eat supper, then at 4:30 head downtown to his second job. He used to make jokes frequently about a union official who moonlighted. I never got the joke, but he and his friends thought it was hilarious. All I knew was that my family always ate well, that my brother and I had new clothes to wear, and that all of the white people in Piedmont, West Virginia, treated my parents with an odd mixture of resentment and respect that even we understood at the time had something directly to do with a small but certain measure of financial security.

He had left a little early that evening because I was with him and I had to be in bed early. I could not have been more than five or six, and we had stopped off at the Cut-Rate Drug Store (where no black person in town but my father could sit

down to eat, and eat off real plates with real silverware) so that I could buy some caramel ice cream, two scoops in a wafer cone, please, which I was busy licking when Mr. Wilson walked by.

Mr. Wilson was a very quiet man, whose stony, brooding, silent manner seemed designed to scare off any overtures of friendship, even from white people. He was Irish, as was one-third of our village (another third being Italian), the more affluent among whom sent their children to “Catholic School” across the bridge in Maryland. He had white straight hair, like my Uncle Joe, whom he uncannily resembled, and he carried a black worn metal lunch pail, the kind that Riley² carried on the television show. My father always spoke to him, and for reasons that we never did understand, he always spoke to my father.

“Hello, Mr. Wilson,” I heard my father say.

“Hello, George.”

I stopped licking my ice cream cone, and asked my Dad in a loud voice why Mr. Wilson had called him “George.”

“Doesn’ t he know your name, Daddy? Why don’ t you tell him your name? Your name isn’ t George.”

For a moment I tried to think of who Mr. Wilson was mixing Pop up with. But we didn' t have any Georges among the colored people in Piedmont; nor were there colored Georges living in the neighboring towns and working at the mill.

“Tell him your name, Daddy.”

“He knows my name, boy,” my father said after a long pause.
“He calls all colored people George.”

A long silence ensued. It was “one of those things,” as my Mom would put it. Even then, that early, I knew when I was in the presence of “one of those things,” one of those things that provided a glimpse, through a rent³ curtain, at another world that we could not affect but that affected us. There would be a painful moment of silence, and you would wait for it to give way to a discussion of a black superstar such as Sugar Ray⁴ or Jackie Robinson.⁵

“Nobody hits better in a clutch than Jackie Robinson.”

“That’ s right. Nobody.”

I never again looked Mr. Wilson in the eye.

¹*Village Voice*: a nationally distributed weekly newspaper published in New York City from 1955 through 2018.

²*Riley*: Chester A. Riley, the lead character on the U.S. television show *The Life of Riley*, a sitcom popular in the 1950s.

³*rent*: torn.

⁴*Sugar Ray*: Walker Smith Jr. (1921–1989), American professional boxer and six-time world champion.

⁵*Jackie Robinson*: Jack Roosevelt Robinson (1919–1972), the first black baseball player in the major leagues in the modern era.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Gates prefaces his essay with two quotations. What is the meaning of each quotation? Why do you suppose Gates uses both quotations? How does each relate to his purpose? (Glossary: [Purpose](#))
2. Gates begins by explaining where he got the idea for his essay. How well does this approach work? Is it an approach you could see yourself using often? Explain.
3. How do you explain the fact that even though the event Gates narrates took place when he was a small boy, he has never forgotten it? What about the incident makes it an indelible memory for him?
4. Gates describes and provides some background information about Mr. Wilson in paragraph 4. (Glossary: [Description](#)) What is Gates' s purpose in providing this information? (Glossary: [Purpose](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What is “one of those things,” as Gates’ s mom put it (12)? In what ways is “one of those things” really Gates’ s purpose in telling this story?
2. What conflict, if any, do you see in the fact that Gates’ s family use racially charged language amongst themselves but take offense when such language is directed at them by others? How do you reconcile these differing responses, if at all? How do you think Gates himself might reconcile them?
3. The name “George” is not, on its face, a racially charged name. What makes it so for Gates and his father?

Classroom Activity Using Narration

Beginning at the beginning and ending at the end is not the only way to tell a story. Think of the events in a story that you would like to tell. Don’ t write the story, but simply list the events that need to be included. Be sure to include at least ten major events in your story. Now play with the arrangement of those events so as to avoid the chronological sequencing of them that would naturally come to mind. Try to develop as many patterns as you can, but be careful that you have a

purpose in developing each sequence and that you do not create something that might confuse a listener or reader. Discuss your results with your classmates.

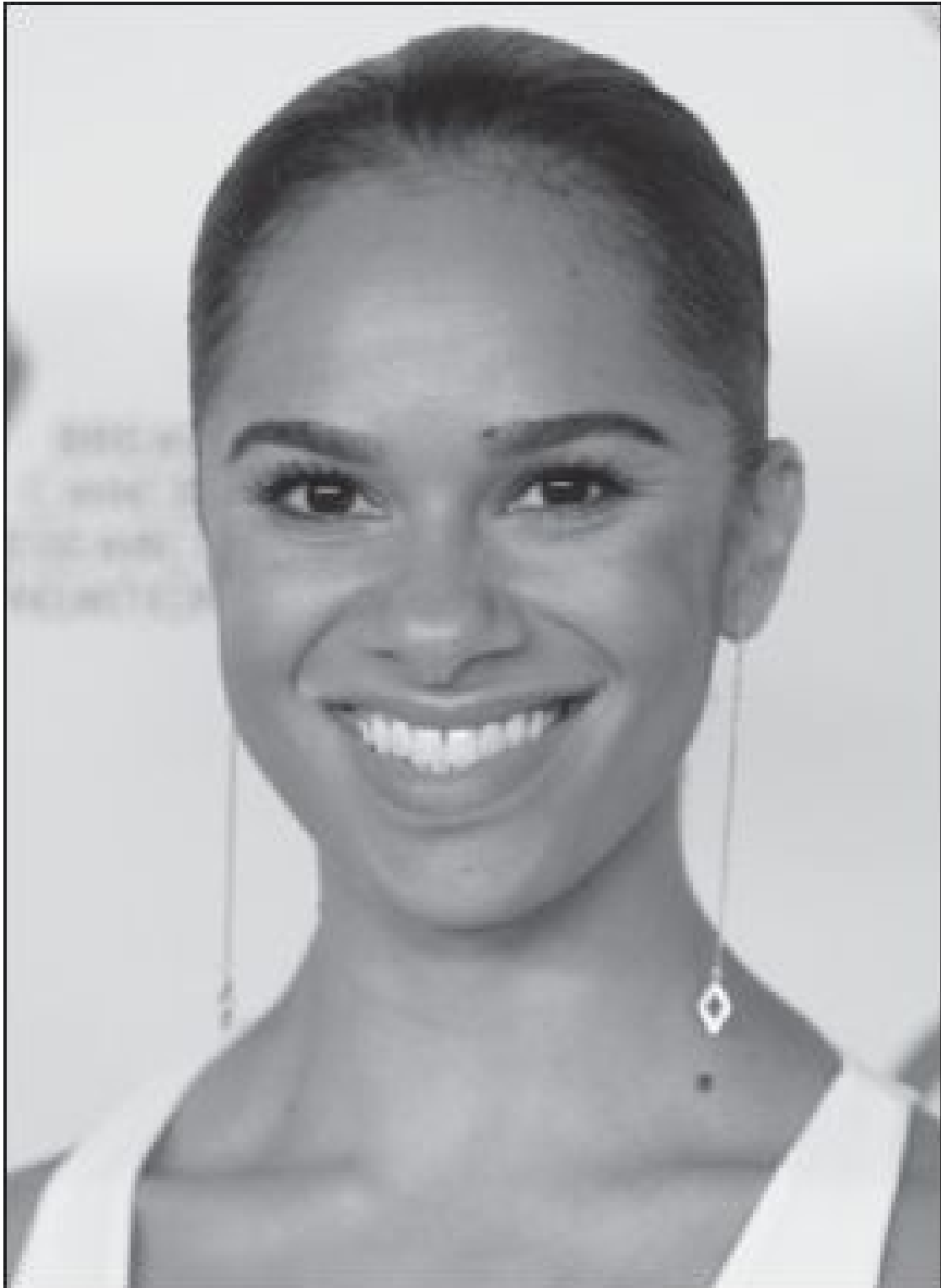
Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Using Gates' s essay as a model, identify something that you have recently read that reminds you of a story from the past. Perhaps an article about how local high school students helped the community reminds you of a community project you and your classmates were involved in. Or perhaps reading about some act of heroism reminds you of a situation in which you performed (or failed to perform) a similar deed. Make sure that you have a purpose in telling the story, that you establish a clear context for it, and that you have enough supporting details to enrich your story. (Glossary: [Purpose](#); [Details](#)) Also think about how to begin and end your story and which narrative sequence you will use. (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#))
2. How do you feel about your name? Do you like it? Does it sound pleasant? Do you think that your name shapes your identity in a positive or a negative way, or do you think that it has no effect on your sense of who you are? Write an essay about your name and the way it helps or fails to help you present yourself to the

world. Be sure to develop your essay using narration by including several anecdotes or a longer story involving your name. (Glossary: [Anecdote](#))

Life in Motion

Misty Copeland



Noam Galai/WireImage/Getty Images

Born in Kansas City, Missouri, in 1982, Misty Copeland was raised in Los Angeles, California. She began dancing as a

member of the drill team in her middle school. The team's coach took note of her skills, and soon she was learning ballet at the San Pedro Dance Center. Copeland's career in dance has been nothing short of outstanding and includes first-place prize at the Music Center Spotlight Awards and scholarships to attend ballet school. She joined the American Ballet Theatre (ABT) in 2001 and by 2007 had become a soloist. In 2015, she was named a principal dancer for ABT, the first African American woman to be so named in the seventy-five-year history of the company. In 2014, she was appointed by Barack Obama to the President's Council on Fitness, Sports, and Nutrition.

This selection, which comes from her autobiography *Life in Motion* (2014), details the tumultuous time in Copeland's life when her family — her mother, her mother's new boyfriend Alex, and her five brothers and sisters — were living in a motel. Her dance instructor, Cindy Bradley, invited Copeland to live with her so they could continue their dance studies together. As you read, think about the context Copeland establishes for her story of her dance career and the details she uses to bring to life both her life's problems and her love for dance.

Reflecting on What You Know

Think about interests you have held throughout your life. It might be dance, like Misty Copeland, or something entirely

different, such as sports, art, music, science, theater, writing, or cooking. How supportive have other people been of you in your pursuit of that interest? Can you cite particular ways in which that interest has (or has not) been supported?

We stayed with Ray for about a year before moving even farther away from our onetime home in San Pedro to a town called Montebello, where we lived in another cramped apartment with Mommy's next boyfriend, Alex. He was Latino and seemed a little more at ease in his own skin than Ray, but he wasn't much more stable. We were never sure if Alex had a real job. And just like at Ray's, Mommy and Alex slept in the one bedroom while we kids spread blankets and pillows wherever we could find a clear spot on the living room floor.

The neighborhoods where Ray and Alex lived weren't dicey like the streets where Auntie Monique and Uncle Charles lived, but their apartments were meant as basic, temporary housing for young men who partied all night and woke up at noon, not for a family with six children. And in those cramped spaces, the scraping back of a kitchen chair or the ringing of the telephone seemed louder, as if the smallness and clutter amplified the sound...

Then, a few months after we began living with Alex, he lost his apartment. Again, we moved, this time into a motel. He came with us.

It was called the Sunset Inn, two stories of stucco¹ just off a busy highway. We were now in Gardena, a town right next to San Pedro. We were closer to our old neighborhood, but this place, this part of town, didn' t feel like home.

Our room was toward the back of the top story. We children slept on the couch and the floor in the large front room, but I would often disappear into Mommy' s bedroom after school, trying to drift away in a dream or a dance. Our front porch looking out over the Pacific was long gone, replaced by an outdoor hallway that we and the other motel tenants shared.

I tried to make the best of it. I would pretend the hallway was a veranda and I' d sit there, soaking up the sun. And I turned the rail into my very own barre, which I would grab hold of to balance as I stretched toward the sky. Or I would place [my brother] Cameron' s tiny hands on the cool metal and shift him into various ballet positions, the way Cindy had first done with me...

Often we had no money at all. We would run our hands around the couch cushions and through the carpet to find change. Then we' d go to the corner store to see if we could afford something to eat. Eventually, Mommy applied for food stamps.

I still tried to appear perfect at school, arriving long before the first bell, carrying out my duties as hall monitor

and as leader of the drill team. I withdrew even more inside myself as I tried to keep it all a secret, not telling my friends that we' d moved again, that I didn' t have my own room ... let alone a bed. I' d always spent more time at my friends' homes than they' d spent at mine, so it wasn' t that hard to pretend my life was as it should be.

It was harder to make myself forget. I was grateful to hide from the chaos for a little while at the dance studio, inside ballet, where there were rules and life was dignified. Beautiful. I had continued to go to the studio every day despite the turmoil at home, taking the half hour drive with Cindy from school, and then riding an hour on the bus to get home to the motel.

The weeks rushed by. My mastery of ballet deepened, and soon I had my first show. It was at the Palos Verdes Art Center and billed as an "afternoon of art, music, and cultural enrichment," performed for a mostly elderly and white audience of about two hundred.

On the program was an older teenage girl who sang some forgettable pop standard, a group of high schoolers who performed a modern-dance routine, and me, the only ballerina in the bunch. Cindy had created a simple routine that blended the positions, spins, and leaps that I had managed to learn

up to that point. I wore my black leotard with a pink chiffon skirt, with a blush-colored rose tucked in my hair.

Mommy wasn' t there. Neither were my brothers or sisters. Only Cindy.

But I had performed ballet solo in front of a crowd for the first time, and by then I was in love. It was fun, exciting — and each day I couldn' t wait for the bell to ring after sixth period so I could rush out the door, jump into Cindy' s car, and head to the studio.

Mommy, however, was starting to change her mind about my ballet dreams.

When Jeff couldn' t give her a lift, Erica would catch the bus, riding an hour each way to pick me up from class so I wouldn' t have to take public transportation by myself. The two of us would get home after dark, often exhausted.

One night after Erica and I returned home from our long trek from the studio, Mommy sat down beside me. She said ballet class, so far away, wasn' t working out.

“It' s too much,” she said, shaking her head, sadness faintly clouding her eyes. “You need to be able to get home earlier to spend time with your brothers and sisters. And

both you and Erica are missing out on time with your friends. I know you' re liking this class, but you' ll only be a kid once. ”

I knew that Mommy meant well, that she was speaking from a place of concern, but I don' t think she really understood that for me, ballet had become more than a hobby — it was what helped me stand alone, even shine bright. I desperately needed it.

The day after Mommy told me I would have to quit ballet, Cindy was waiting for me in front of the school, rifling through her organizer, looking up from time to time to see if I' d appeared.

I opened the car door and got in beside her.

“I' m going to have to stop dancing,” I blurted out before breaking down in tears. “My mother says that the studio' s too far. That it' s too much, that I' m missing out on time with my friends and family.”

Perhaps she would have been better able to understand if, like many concerned parents of ballerinas, my mother had been worried about my struggling schoolwork or fatigue. But this excuse seemed flimsy, even to me.

Cindy looked as though she' d forgotten how to breathe. Her eyes were wide and glistening. We sat there for a few minutes, silent.

“Well then,” she finally said, “at least I can drive you home.”

I was too tired to protest, too grief-stricken to guard my secret. I gave her my address.

We were quiet in the car. I tried to imagine what would fill the space that ballet had occupied, and I kept coming up empty. Finally, Cindy pulled to a stop. Staring at the run-down motel where my family was living, she looked as stunned as she had when I told her that I couldn' t dance with her anymore.

“Thanks for the ride,” I whispered as I hurried out of the car. Upstairs, I fumbled for the room key and entered the living room, blankets rolled up near the spots where they would later be unfurled as makeshift beds.

I' m sure Mommy didn' t believe she was being neglectful. After all, we hadn' t always lived that way, with pallets on the floor. We hadn' t always called a motel — with a lobby window to slide our rent check through — home. We didn' t

always sleep around the corner from a highway lined with liquor stores and sketchy taco joints.

But that' s how we lived now. That' s what Cindy saw.

There was a knock on the door. Mommy, who' d been in the bedroom with Alex, came out and opened it.

Cindy stood there tentatively. I could feel the tension building in the small space, a nearly tangible thing. I just wanted to disappear. She met my eyes where I sat withdrawn on the floor. I believe that she knew this was it: she either brought me with her that night and into the world she believed I was born to be a part of, or I would never dance again.

The two women huddled a while, talking softly, crying, too. Mommy made it very clear that she had five other children. I was not, nor could I be, the center of her universe. I knew that — but I needed to be that to someone. “I can’ t leave her,” Cindy said, tears streaming down her face. “I want Misty to come live with me.” Then Mommy sighed and looked around the crowded motel room.

And she let me go.

¹*stucco*: a type of plaster used to cover and decorate walls.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. In paragraph 1, Copeland recounts how her family moved from the home of one of her mother's boyfriends (Ray) to the home of another (Alex). How important — or unimportant — are these men in Copeland's life? What details does Copeland use to give you this impression?
2. Often in narration, writers adhere to the mantra "show, don't tell." Identify three examples of where Copeland "shows" rather than "tells," and discuss how effective those passages are.
3. In paragraph 2, Copeland describes the effect of the "scraping back of a kitchen chair or the ringing of the telephone." What mood does this detail set for the reader, and what does it tell you about the family's living conditions? (Glossary: [Dominant Impression](#))
4. Copeland tells her dance instructor, Cindy, that her mother says she must stop dancing (21). Why is this so devastating to Copeland? What has dance come to mean to her?
5. What is the mother's rationale for letting Copeland go live with her dance instructor? How powerful to you was this ending? Why?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Did Copeland's early living conditions and family life bring her down or motivate her to realize her aspirations? What evidence do you have to support your conclusion?
2. Copeland tried to be "perfect" in her endeavors beyond dancing. Why do you suppose this was so? Is the pursuit of perfection something that we apply only to certain aspects of our lives, or is it something that becomes — or should become — a way of life? Explain.
3. How do you explain Copeland's drive to achieve her goals despite seemingly crushing odds? She found numerous ways around her adversities. For example, she "turned the rail [in the hallway] into her very own barre" (6), a seemingly insignificant act but nonetheless a very telling one. Do you think she was simply born with this passion or was it developed out of necessity? Explain.

Classroom Activity Using Narration

One of Copeland's themes in *Life in Motion* is that circumstances outside one's own control can either help or hinder one's personal, educational, or professional

development. To practice chronological order, consider a situation in which you encountered a difficulty in your development, particularly from a circumstance that was not entirely within your ability to control. Recount how you overcame, or were not able to overcome, that barrier. Rather than write a draft of an essay at this point, simply list the events that occurred in chronological order. If you like to draw or direct films, compose the sequence in a comic or storyboard. Then consider whether there is a more dramatic order you might use if you were actually to write an essay.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Narrate a story from your family's history. It may be based on a meaningful photograph or family home video. It may be a story you have heard told by someone else in your family, such as a parent or grandparent, and one that is told in different ways (depending on who is telling it!). Use plenty of strong relevant details, a consistent viewpoint, and a logical organization. Be sure that a reader who is not a member of your family can follow the storyline and all of the characters.
2. Sadly, the relationship between Misty Copeland, her mother Sylvia, and her dance teacher, Cindy, went

sour in the time after this excerpt. There was much acrimony and even lawsuits before a peace was achieved between the parties, all of which played out in the Los Angeles-area media because of Copeland's growing popularity as a ballet prodigy. Research child custody cases like Copeland's and others. Write an essay in which you argue under what circumstances children can and should be removed from their parents' care and authority.

The Gentle Tasaday

Grace Talusan



Alonso Nichols

Based in Boston, Massachusetts, Grace Talusan is a writer and teacher who was born in the Philippines and emigrated to the United States as a child. In 1999, she earned her MFA in Writing from the University of California, Irvine. She has taught at the University of Oregon, Tufts University, and Brandeis University, and has worked as a writing tutor with nonprofit organization GrubStreet, Inc. Her writing has been published widely, in magazines and journals such as *Tufts Magazine*, *Brevity*, *Our Own Voice*, *Del Sol Review*, and *Boston Magazine*. She was a 2014 Fulbright Scholar, and in 2017 she won the Restless Books Prize for New Immigrant Writing for her first book, *The Body Papers*, a memoir composed of essays that explore many themes, including identity, trauma, and illness.

The following selection from *The Body Papers* is written in the first person from the point of view of the author as a child. Talusan narrates an experience when her fourth-grade teacher learned that she was from the Philippines, and what starts out as an attempt to celebrate the young Talusan's culture turns into a moment of shame when her teacher shows the class an inaccurate representation of Filipino people. As you read, pay attention to Talusan's first-person point of view, her use of specific details, and the organization of her narrative.

Reflecting on What You Know

Describe a moment when, as a child, you were taught about another country or another culture — by a teacher, a family member, or anyone else. Did you have a positive experience or a negative experience? Has anything about your perception of the experience changed as you' ve gotten older?

One day in our fourth-grade geography unit, my teacher announced that the next country we would study would be the Philippines.

I raised my hand and waved it back and forth. “My parents are from there!” So was I, but back then, I didn’ t think of myself as being anything other than American.

My teacher was surprised; she thought we were Chinese. She invited my father to come and talk to the class about the Philippines.

I was queasy with excitement as I watched him spread decorations from our walls onto two desks pushed together: *Weapons of Moroland*, a black plaque of tiny metal swords from Mindanao.¹ A lamp of round flat shells strung together. His fanciest *barong* Tagalog shirt,² the one woven from *piña*³ cloth. It may have been the same one he wore when he married my mother. He almost included in the display a carved wooden figurine of a man sitting in a barrel. When you lifted the barrel off the man, he was naked and, boing, a stick as long

as one of his legs popped straight out from the center of his body. I begged him to leave Barrel Man at home. My classmates clapped for my father, and my teacher was so impressed with the authentic Philippine artifacts that she asked him to leave the display up until our country study was over.

The next week during social studies, my teacher said, “Today we will learn about the Tasaday people. Has anyone heard of the Tasaday?” She stared right at me.

I shook my head. She went on and described a lost tribe recently discovered in the Philippine jungle. The story was that they had been untouched by modern life since the Stone Age. They were a window to humanity’s early days.

“Are you sure you didn’t know about the Tasaday in the Philippines?” she asked me.

I had never heard of them from my parents or anyone else, but the teacher had proof, a filmstrip. As my teacher threaded the canister of film into the projector, a boy tapped me on the back. “Do you want to see a filmstrip?” he asked.

My friend whispered loudly, “Don’t answer him.”

Flattered by his attention, I nodded. The boy cupped his hand around his eye as if it was a camera lens and moved his other

hand in a circle next to his ear. “Good,” he said. “I’ ll film and you can strip.”

Everyone laughed and I did not know where to set my gaze. Were they picturing me taking off my clothes?

The teacher asked someone to get the lights. She explained that even though the Tasaday were backward and lived in caves, they were a noble and peaceful people, whose vocabulary had no words for “war” or “enemy.”

I had no idea what the Philippines looked like. We didn’ t bring family photo albums with us to America, and I’ d never seen anything about the Philippines depicted on the news or movies. The images on the filmstrip made me sink into my seat. The boys whooped at glimpses of breasts and bare thighs. They reacted the same way when issues of *National Geographic* with topless brown skinned women were passed around. I covered my face with my hands so no one could see my reaction. There was an old man with long earlobes and he perched like a seabird, his arms hugging his thin brown legs like wet wings. Another man with curly hair crouched near a cooking fire, his butt parted with a thick vine and a leaf wrapped around his crotch like a package. The image reminded me of one of my favorite snacks, rice and coconut milk steamed in a banana leaf, and I shivered, imagining what it would be like to open up the packet to find this man’ s

genitals in it. A woman held a baby to her long, flat breasts, the reddish nipples pointing away from each other like lazy eyes. She stared into the camera, waiting for something. She looked at me as if to say, "You are a Tasaday, too." I expected to see this same stare from my classmates. I was used to this feeling, all eyes on the different one, the foreign other, and I hated it.

There was Lobo, a child with shoulder-length curly hair. My classmates argued over the child's gender. Boys didn't have hair like that. Someone pointed to me and said, "There's your future husband." I was mute with shame.

Another image showed a banana leaf piled high with dead frogs, tadpoles, newts, and lizards. The Tasaday squatted naked on the cave floor. Some people were sitting on large rocks, their skin dusty with ash, drying in the sun like the lizards they ate. The class came to life with noises of disgust. "They're going to eat that? That's their food?" My classmates teased me, wondering if the sandwich meat between my Wonder bread was made of reptiles.

At the time, I knew no more about the Philippines than my classmates, so I could not tell them that the Tasaday were considered a hoax. Manuel Elizalde Jr, an amateur anthropologist, introduced the group to the world, allegedly promising money to those needy folks in exchange for this

performance of primitivism. And he was right. It was what people wanted to see. Briefly, the world's attention suddenly focused on the Philippines, and here I was in an American fourth-grade classroom, seeing the first images of my home country I'd been exposed to since we emigrated.

I was relieved when our study of the Philippines ended and I could dismantle the display of our family's decorations: As I loaded the things into my bag, I noticed that some of the metal blades were missing from the black plaque and some *capiz* shells⁴ from the hanging lamp were cracked. As I folded my father's barong, I noticed the shirt was stamped by multiple shoe treads. The barong must have slid from the desk to the floor. I brushed the delicate beige cloth, stiff like paper, but couldn't erase the shoe prints from its back.

¹*Mindanao*: the second-largest island in the Philippines.

²*barong Tagalog shirt*: an embroidered formal shirt.

³*piña*: fabric made from leaves of the pineapple plant.

⁴*capiz shells*: oyster shells used in windowpanes, lamps, chandeliers, and other household items.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What causes Talusan's shift from being excited about the study of the Philippines to being "relieved when [it] ended" (17)?

2. How does Talusan's teacher characterize the Tasaday? How does Talusan react to this characterization? Why?
3. What was Manuel Elizalde Jr.'s career, and how did he create the hoax of the Tasaday people? Why did the hoax work, according to Talusan?
4. Why does Talusan end this selection by focusing on the shoe prints on her father's artifacts? What figurative significance do the artifacts and the shoe prints have?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Trauma can be defined at its most basic level as an extremely stressful and troubling experience. How would you define it? Based on your definition of trauma, is the experience that Talusan describes a traumatic experience? Explain your answer.
2. A key feature of narration is deciding what to omit, or leave out. What details or kinds of details or experiences does Talusan appear to omit from her essay? Why do you think she chooses to omit them?
3. Talusan's narrative involves several people who ask questions, such as her teacher, who asks, "Are you sure you didn't know about the Tasaday in the Philippines?" (7). Analyze this question or any other question that someone asks in the essay. What does the question reveal about the person who is

asking it? How do the questions that Talusan includes contribute to her purpose?

Classroom Activity Using Narration

In a small group with two or three classmates, narrate some positive and negative experiences that you had in school. Be as specific as possible in your storytelling. Then, with your group members, brainstorm some ideas for how the educational system could be improved to prevent negative experiences and promote positive ones. Share the results of your discussion with the class.

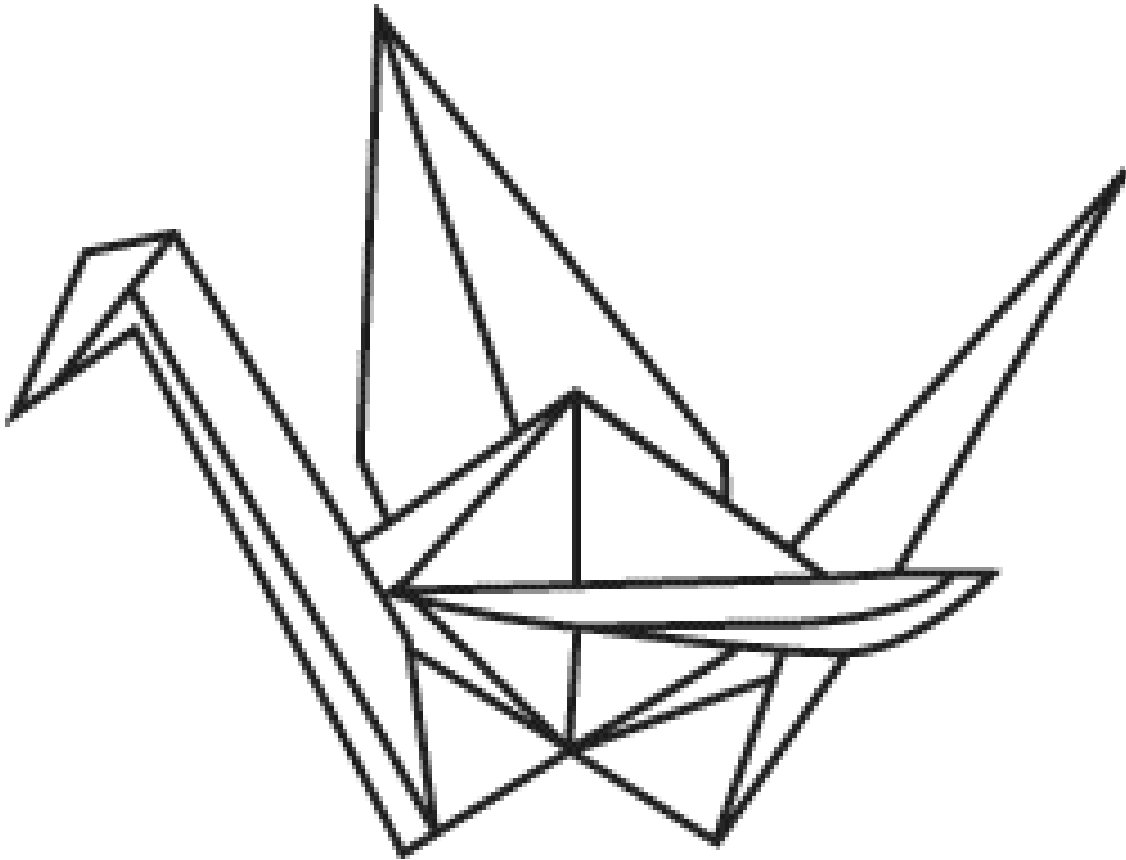
Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Talusan writes, “I had no idea what the Philippines looked like” (13). Write a narrative essay in the first person about something you did not know as a child but came to know through a specific moment in your childhood or adulthood. For example, your essay could explore the moment you learned that not all of your friends’ parents had the same amount of money, or that your ancestry is different from what you had believed.

2. Write a narrative essay about a moment in your childhood or adolescence when you were embarrassed or ashamed. As you write, pay attention to your point of view, specific details, and organization.



CHAPTER 16 Description



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

To describe is to create a verbal picture. A person, a place, a thing — even an idea or a state of mind — can be made vividly concrete through description. In the following passage, Mark Twain describes the Mississippi River in the late afternoon:

I still kept in mind a certain wonderful sunset which I witnessed when steamboating was new to me. A broad expanse of the river was turned to blood; in the middle distance the red hue brightened into gold, through which a solitary log came floating, black and conspicuous; in one place a long, slanting

mark lay sparkling upon the water; in another the surface was broken by boiling, tumbling rings that were as many tinted as an opal; where the ruddy flush was faintest was a smooth spot that was covered with graceful circles and radiating lines, ever so delicately traced; the shore on our left was densely wooded, and the somber shadow that fell from this forest was broken in one place by a long, ruffled trail that shone like silver; and high above the forest wall a clean-stemmed dead tree waved a single leafy bough that glowed like a flame in the unobstructed splendor that was flowing from the sun. There were graceful curves, reflected images, woody heights, soft distances, and over the whole scene, far and near, the dissolving lights drifted steadily, enriching it every passing moment with new marvels of coloring.

— Mark Twain, *Life on the Mississippi*

Writing any description requires that the writer gather many details about a subject, relying not only on what the eyes see but on the other sense impressions — touch, taste, smell, and hearing — as well. From this catalog of details, the writer selects those that will create a dominant impression — the single quality, mood, or atmosphere the writer wishes to emphasize. Consider, for example, the details Cherokee Paul McDonald uses to evoke the dominant impression in the following passage, and contrast them with those in the subsequent example by student Dan Bubany:

I was coming up on the little bridge in the Rio Vista neighborhood of Fort Lauderdale, deepening my stride and my

breathing to negotiate the slight incline without altering my pace. And then, as I neared the crest, I saw the kid.

He was a lumpy little guy with baggy shorts, a faded T-shirt and heavy sweat socks falling down over old sneakers.

Partially covering his shaggy blond hair was one of those blue baseball caps with gold braid on the bill and a sailfish patch sewn onto the peak. Covering his eyes and part of his face was a pair of those stupid-looking ' 50s-style wrap-around sunglasses.

He was fumbling with a beat-up rod and reel, and he had a little bait bucket by his feet. I puffed on by, glancing down into the empty bucket as I passed.

— Cherokee Paul McDonald, ["A View from the Bridge,"](#) pp.
115 – 16

For this particular Thursday game against Stanford, Fleming wears white gloves, a maroon sport coat with brass buttons, and gray slacks. Shiny silver-framed bifocals match the whistle pressed between the lips on his slightly wrinkled face, and he wears freshly polished black shoes so glossy that they reflect the grass he stands on. He is not fat, but his coat neatly conceals a small, round pot belly.

— Dan Bubany, student

The dominant impression that McDonald creates of the young boy is one of a scruffy little urchin. There is nothing about the boy's appearance that suggests any thought was given to

what he is wearing. Bubany, on the other hand, creates a dominant impression of a neat, polished man.

Writers must also carefully plan the order in which to present their descriptive details. The pattern of organization must fit the subject of the description logically and naturally and must be easy to follow. For example, visual details can be arranged spatially — from left to right, top to bottom, near to far — or in any other logical order. Other patterns include smallest to largest, softest to loudest, least significant to most significant, and most unusual to least unusual.

How much detail is enough? There is no fixed answer. A good description includes enough vivid details to create a dominant impression and to bring a scene to life but not so many that readers are distracted, confused, or bored. In an essay that is purely descriptive, there is room for much detail. Usually, however, writers use description to create the setting for a story, to illustrate ideas, to help clarify a definition or a comparison, or to make the complexities of a process more understandable. Such descriptions should be kept short and should include just enough detail to make them clear and helpful.

The Corner Store

Eudora Welty



Philip Gould/Getty Images

One of the most honored and respected writers of the twentieth century, Eudora Welty was born in 1909 in Jackson,

Mississippi, where she lived most of her life and where she died in 2001. Her first book, *A Curtain of Green* (1941), is a collection of short stories. Although she went on to become a successful writer of novels, essays, and book reviews, among other genres (as well as a published photographer), she is most often remembered as a master of the short story. In 1980, Welty was awarded the prestigious Presidential Medal of Freedom, and in 1996 she won the French Legion of Honor. *The Collected Stories of Eudora Welty* was published in 1982. Her other best-known works include a collection of essays, *The Eye of the Story* (1975); her autobiography, *One Writer's Beginnings* (1984); and a collection of book reviews and essays, *The Writer's Eye* (1994). Welty's novel *The Optimist's Daughter* won the Pulitzer Prize for Fiction in 1973. In 1999, the Library of Congress published two collections of her work: *Welty: Collected Novels* and *Welty: Collected Essays and Memoirs*.

Welty's description of the corner store, taken from an essay in *The Eye of the Story* about growing up in Jackson, recalls for many readers the neighborhood store in the town or city where they grew up. As you read, pay attention to the effect Welty's spatial arrangement of descriptive details has on the dominant impression of the store.

Reflecting on What You Know

Write about a store you frequented as a child. Maybe it was the local supermarket, the hardware store, or the corner convenience store. Using your five senses (sight, smell, taste, touch, and hearing), describe what you remember about the place.

Our Little Store rose right up from the sidewalk; standing in a street of family houses, it alone hadn' t any yard in front, any tree or flower bed. It was a plain frame building covered over with brick. Above the door, a little railed porch ran across on an upstairs level and four windows with shades were looking out. But I didn' t catch on to those.

Running in out of the sun, you met what seemed total obscurity inside. There were almost tangible smells — licorice recently sucked in a child' s cheek, dill pickle brine¹ that had leaked through a paper sack in a fresh trail across the wooden floor, ammonia-loaded ice that had been hoisted from wet croker sacks² and slammed into the icebox with its sweet butter at the door, and perhaps the smell of still untrapped mice.

Then through the motes of cracker dust, cornmeal dust, the Gold Dust of the Gold Dust Twins³ that the floor had been swept out with, the realities emerged. Shelves climbed to high reach all the way around, set out with not too much of any one thing but a lot of things — lard, molasses, vinegar,

starch, matches, kerosene, Octagon soap (about a year' s worth of octagon-shaped coupons cut out and saved brought a signet ring⁴ addressed to you in the mail). It was up to you to remember what you came for, while your eye traveled from cans of sardines to tin whistles to ice-cream salt to harmonicas to flypaper (over your head, batting around on a thread beneath the blades of the ceiling fan, stuck with its testimonial catch).

Its confusion may have been in the eye of its beholder. Enchantment is cast upon you by all those things you weren' t supposed to have need for, to lure you close to wooden tops you' d outgrown, boys' marbles and agates in little net pouches, small rubber balls that wouldn' t bounce straight, frail, frazzly kite string, clay bubble pipes that would snap off in your teeth, the stiffest scissors. You could contemplate those long narrow boxes of sparklers gathering dust while you waited for it to be the Fourth of July or Christmas, and noisemakers in the shape of tin frogs for somebody' s birthday party you hadn' t been invited to yet, and see that they were all marvelous.

You might not have even looked for Mr. Sessions when he came around his store cheese (as big as a doll' s house) and in front of the counter looking for you. When you' d finally asked him for, and received from him in its paper bag,

whatever single thing it was that you had been sent for, the nickel that was left over was yours to spend.

Down at a child's eye level, inside those glass jars with mouths in their sides through which the grocer could run his scoop or a child's hand might be invited to reach for a choice, were wineballs, all-day suckers, gumdrops, peppermints. Making a row under the glass of a counter were the Tootsie Rolls, Hershey bars, Goo Goo Clusters, Baby Ruths. And whatever was the name of those pastilles that came stacked in a cardboard cylinder with a cardboard lid? They were thin and dry, about the size of tiddledy-winks,⁵ and in the shape of twisted rosettes. A kind of chocolate dust came out with them when you shook them out in your hand. Were they chocolate? I'd say, rather, they were brown. They didn't taste of anything at all, unless it was wood. Their attraction was the number you got for a nickel.

Making up your mind, you circled the store around and around, around the pickle barrel, around the tower of Crackerjack boxes; Mr. Sessions had built it for us himself on top of a packing case like a house of cards.

If it seemed too hot for Crackerjacks, I might get a cold drink. Mr. Sessions might have already stationed himself by the cold-drinks barrel, like a mind reader. Deep in ice water that looked black as ink, murky shapes — that would come up

as Coca-Colas, Orange Crushes, and various flavors of pop — were all swimming around together. When you gave the word, Mr. Sessions plunged his bare arm in to the elbow and fished out your choice, first try. I favored a locally bottled concoction called Lake' s Celery. (What else could it be called? It was made by a Mr. Lake out of celery. It was a popular drink here for years but was not known universally, as I found out when I arrived in New York and ordered one in the Astor bar.) You drank on the premises, with feet set wide apart to miss the drip, and gave him back his bottle and your nickel.

But he didn' t hurry you off. A standing scale was by the door, with a stack of iron weights and a brass slide on the balance arm, that would weigh you up to three hundred pounds. Mr. Sessions, whose hands were gentle and smelled of carbolic,⁶ would lift you up and set your feet on the platform, hold your loaf of bread for you, and taking his time while you stood still for him, he would make certain of what you weighed today. He could even remember what you weighed the last time, so you could subtract and announce how much you' d gained. That was goodbye.

¹*brine*: salty water used to preserve or pickle food.

²*croker sacks*: sacks or bags made of burlap — a coarse, woven fabric.

³*Gold Dust Twins*: twins named Goldie and Dusty who advertised the Gold Dust washing powder, developed in the late 1880s.

⁴*signet ring*: a ring bearing an official-looking seal.

⁵*tiddledy-winks*: playing pieces from the game Tiddledy-Winks, flat and round in shape, the size of quarters (tiddledies) and dimes (winks).

⁶*carbolic*: a sweet, musky-smelling chemical once used in soap.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What pattern of organization does Welty use in this essay — chronological, spatial, or logical?
(Glossary: [Organization](#)) If she uses more than one, where precisely does she use each type?
2. In paragraph 2, Welty describes the smells that a person encountered when entering the corner store. Why do you think she presents these smells before giving any visual details of the inside of the store?
3. What impression of Mr. Sessions does Welty create? What details contribute to this impression?
(Glossary: [Details](#))
4. Why does Welty place certain pieces of information in parentheses? What, if anything, does this information add to your understanding of the corner store? Might this information be left out? Explain.
5. Comment on Welty's ending. (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#)) Is it too abrupt? Why or why not?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What do you think of when you hear the phrase “neighborhood store”? Did you grow up with any stores like the one Welty describes in your neighborhood? If not, what kinds of stores do you remember from your childhood? What did Mr. Sessions’ store contribute to Welty’s neighborhood in Jackson, Mississippi? What did Mr. Sessions himself contribute? Explain.
2. What do you think Welty’s purpose was in writing this essay? (Glossary: [Purpose](#)) Is her tone appropriate for her purpose and her subject matter? (Glossary: [Tone](#)) How so?
3. What dominant impression does Welty create in her description of the corner store? (Glossary: [Dominant Impression](#)) How does she create this dominant impression?

Classroom Activity Using Description

Make a long list of the objects and people in your classroom as well as the physical features of the room — desks, windows, chalkboard, students, professor, dirty

walls, burned-out lightbulb, a clock that is always ten minutes fast, and so on. Determine a dominant impression that you would like to create in describing the classroom. Now choose from your list those items that would best illustrate the dominant impression you have chosen. Your instructor may wish you to compare your response with those of other students.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Using Welty's essay as a model, describe your neighborhood store or supermarket. Gather a large quantity of detailed information from memory and from an actual visit to the store if that is still possible. You may find it helpful to reread what you wrote in response to the Reflecting on What You Know prompt for this selection. Then, try to select those details that will help you create a dominant impression of the store. Finally, organize your examples and illustrations according to a clear organizational pattern.
2. Write a short essay about a special event — or choose a normal day to capture. Consider the feeling of the day you're describing: celebratory, anxious, sleepy, bustling, and so on. Using Welty's essay as a model, write a description of the scene from your

memory, choosing details that capture the dominant impression you identified.

The Gloves of Summer

David Jenemann



University of Vermont

David Jenemann writes about whatever fascinates him, even the baseball glove, which is the focus of his most recent book,

The Baseball Glove: History, Material, Meaning, and Value (2018). A professor of film and television theory at the University of Vermont, Jenemann also authored *Adorno in America* (2007) and articles in journals like *Parallax* and *Flow*. His interests have grown into cultural critique; he received grants from the Gladys Krieble Delmas Foundation to develop a lecture series on happiness. Currently, he is working on a book about anti-intellectualism in the United States.

In the following selection from *The Baseball Glove*, Jenemann uses the five senses — even taste — to describe a glove. His description is so specific that the reader might feel the weight of a glove in his or her hand. Jenemann's vivid imagery helps him connect the simple baseball glove to larger themes, like national identity, childhood nostalgia, and memory.

Reflecting on What You Know

Think of an object that was often in your hands in your childhood or early adolescence. Maybe, like Jenemann, it was a baseball glove. Maybe it was a popsicle that you ate at the end of every summer swim meet, an engine that you rebuilt with your uncle, or your mom's hand on the city bus. Using your five senses, imagine the many different ways you could describe that object.

What is the first sensation that comes to mind when you think about a baseball glove?

Maybe it's the smell. There is something utterly distinctive about the smell of a baseball glove. Like "new car smell," or "Chinatown," a baseball glove is an amalgam¹ of aromas combining together to produce a scent unlike anything else. Even though individual expressions of the form may vary (a Subaru smells different than a Porsche and Montreal's Chinatown is distinct from New York's or San Francisco's), there is nevertheless no mistaking the smell of a new car for the smell of Chinatown.

It is the same for a baseball glove. New, there is the odor of leather, and coupled with that is the smell of the tanning process that gives the leather its character. Each color of dye imparts a slightly different scent character. A black glove, a walnut glove, and a red glove will all smell slightly different. Perhaps, at the wrist strap there is the funk of lamb's wool and the slightly acrid, caustic tinge of new stitching in the embroidered label. The lettering, burned into the leather, imparts more notes.

But the smell of a new glove is like an opening movement when compared to the symphony of a broken-in and well-used glove — a sonnet compared to an epic poem. A well-worn glove still holds the memory of the new glove as an undertone, but it

also holds the scent of infield clay and outfield grass. Depending on how it is broken in, an older glove will smell of glove oil, or neats-foot oil,² or Vaseline. Or maybe, alongside the grass and the dust, it will smell just slightly of shaving cream, of lanolin, of a parent or grandparent, who smelled something like that glove when they taught you to shave or when they sat close by your side and told you the mysteries of the game like they were revealing to you the meaning of the world.

And lastly, a well-worn glove will smell like sweat and salt. The lambswool and the padding and the leather itself will absorb the smell of the wearer, of the days in the sun spent playing and the nights on the couch spent pounding the pocket into just the right shape.

Or maybe the sensation you first experience is what a glove looks like. Again, a new glove and old present a different aesthetic. New, the leather fairly shines, its lacing and stitching, crisp, clean and true. Its label stands off from the leather like a billboard on a buff landscape — which is just what the label is — advertising to the world that the owner is partisan of Rawlings, with its classic sweeping white script on a red background. Then there are the aspirational “E’ s” for Easton, vectoring in three directions into infinity, or some players will sport the geometric “M’ s” and abstracted “runbird” distinctive to

Mizuno, or maybe, depending on the player and the year, is the profile — not unlike the face on the old buffalo nickel — of Comanche Chief Peta Nocona on the wrist of a Nokona ball glove.

As with the smell of a broken-in glove, the look of an older model is likewise distinctive. The pocket is darker where the sweat and the oil and a thousand caught balls combine, the tooled letters in the palm obliterated by endless pounding. The labels are faded and frayed. For some, the laces will be cracked and re-knotted; for others, there will be efforts at repair, sprucing up, and customization: New laces and cleaned leather, inked and painted sections, providing a player's glove with personality. This past summer, a teammate of mine arrived at a game with a glove he had bought on eBay. It was a basic, conservative Rawlings first basemen's mitt, walnut brown in color, but the previous owner had relaced the entire glove with baby blue laces. We both agreed it was one of the most beautiful things we had ever seen.

Sound, likewise, plays its part in the experience of a glove. A new glove gently creaks as you bend and fold it, the fibers of the leather straining as the owner tries to make it pliable. The thumb and pinky softly click — “tick, tick!” — together as you stiffly close your hand, trying to loosen the glove's hinges. The sounds of a new glove are tentative and expectant, but soon, those sounds will be replaced by

more assertive ones. The fingers will snap together with force and you' ll hear the explosive pop of a baseball hitting the pocket of the glove. When people describe the sounds of a game of baseball, they often talk about "the crack of the bat" as though that is somehow unique to the game, but wooden bats and mallets strike balls in many sports. For me, the sound of a ball meeting a glove is truly unlike any sound in the world. In one of the interviews for the book, I traveled to Meriden, Connecticut, to speak to the "Glovesmith" Dave Katz, who breaks in gloves for people. As we spoke, Dave and I took turns pounding a ball into one of my gloves. The audio file of our interview is punctuated with that sound just as surely as the written transcript is dotted with periods and commas.

Of course, for you, the sense of touch might be the first thing you experience. The stiffness of a new glove fights against the tendons of your hands and fingers. It is frankly uncomfortable to try on a new glove. The leather is slick and unnatural, and you have to contort your hand into a stiffened claw to put your fingers in their stalls — the space for your fingers to rest while waiting for action. Broken in, the feel of a glove is something else altogether. It fits — well, not really like a glove, not these days. Rather, a well-worn glove feels more like a hammer in the hand, a tool exquisitely designed to do a certain job (catching a nine-inch circumference sphere), and the increasing suppleness of

the leather as it breaks in only enhances the efficiency with which it accomplishes that task.

Finally, lest you think you are forgotten — although I can' t imagine there are many people for whom this the primary sensation of the glove — a glove has a taste. Watch a game at any level. Little Leaguers will be distractedly gnawing on their laces, while older players will use their teeth to tighten them so as to not have to take the glove off of their hands while in the field. Here, as with the other senses, the taste of the glove — of leather and sunshine and dust — is all its own.

All of this is to say that a baseball glove is a profoundly material object, appealing to all of the senses, and no account of a baseball glove' s cultural significance can — or should — ignore that materiality. The material facts of a baseball glove' s existence come into being as the result of a set of historical and cultural processes. The transformation of a piece of raw material, generally — although not exclusively — a piece of leather made from tanned steer hide, into a consumer product suited to playing the game of baseball seems like a relatively straightforward, even inevitable, process. But when considered in light of the history of the game, of changing ideas about gender, masculinity, race, and national identity, of evolving concepts of fair play, and of a transforming global economy,

we can see that the material fact of a baseball glove is neither straightforward nor is it inevitable.

¹*amalgam*: a mixture or combination.

²*neatsfoot oil*: oil rendered from cattle feet, used to soften and preserve leather.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Jenemann uses specific examples and details to describe the baseball glove. For each of the five senses, identify one example.
2. Throughout this selection, Jenemann incorporates figurative language to make his description more interesting. Identify at least four examples of figurative language. (Glossary: [Figurative Language](#))
3. What pattern or patterns of organization does Jenemann use in this essay? For example, does he use a chronological, spatial, or logical pattern? How do you know?
4. The first paragraph of Jenemann's essay differs from a traditional introduction. (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#)) How does it differ? Why do you suppose Jenemann chose to begin this way?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What dominant impression does Jenemann create in his description of the baseball glove? (Glossary: [Dominant Impression](#)) What details does he use to create this dominant impression?
2. What is the implied main idea of this descriptive essay? If you were to write a thesis for this essay, what would it be? (Glossary: [Thesis](#))
3. In the final paragraph, Jenemann writes, “But when considered in light of the history of the game, of changing ideas about gender, masculinity, race, and national identity, of evolving concepts of fair play, and of transforming global economy, we can see that the material fact of a baseball glove is neither straightforward nor is it inevitable.” These are big themes. Which do you think is best connected to Jenemann’s description?

Classroom Activity Using Description

In small groups, find an interesting object to describe. Collaborate to create a list of details about that object. Without ever explicitly stating what the object is, write one short descriptive paragraph about it. Then, trade your paragraph (but not your object) with another group. After a few minutes of discussion, each group will present what they think the original object was and why.

What kinds of details seem to work better than others?
Explain.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Look at the objects you regularly bring to class with you — such as books, pens, planners, and a cell phone — and choose one to describe. To begin your description, list all of the details that you associate with the object. You may want to organize these details by the five senses. Next, write a paragraph with a clear topic sentence that expresses the dominant impression you want to make with the details. Finally, write an essay in which you expand upon this dominant expression with body paragraphs that describe the various parts of your object.
2. In Jenemann's description of the baseball glove, he hits on a lot of larger themes: national identity, childhood nostalgia, even gender and masculinity. Identify a larger theme that interests you; it can be one of the themes that Jenemann discusses or a different theme altogether. Now, think of an object that, to your mind, expresses or embodies this theme. Write a three- to five-paragraph essay with a thesis statement relating to the theme. Use physical details of the object you chose to create your description and support the thesis.



Look It Up!

Mia Schon



Emanuelle Elazar

Mia Schon is a mosaic muralist and instructor based in Tel Aviv, Israel. A Boston native, she graduated from the University of Michigan in 2009 with a BA in Fine Art and Design. In 2014, she decided to focus on public art and moved to Tel Aviv, where she has created large, colorful mosaics throughout the city and countryside. Her work has been featured in *Time Out* magazine and *The Jerusalem Post*. Schon's style tends to be colorful and upbeat: for example, one of her recent murals features brightly colored tiles around the simple words, "I love you so much."

In the following selection first published in *At My Pace: Lessons from Our Mothers* (2016), a collection of essays edited by Jill Ebstein, Schon describes how she has been deeply influenced by her mother's character, especially by her way of "always asking and answering." By using examples from her mother's life and clear, concise details, the reader understands Schon's mother's strength, her influence on Schon, and something about Schon herself.

Reflecting on What You Know

Think of a person who has greatly influenced you. This could be a parent, relative, mentor, friend, or even the author of your favorite book. Rather than considering the physical traits of that person, think about the moments or experiences you shared with that person and the impact he or she had on you.

When you think of your mother, what image do you see? I picture my mother, perched at the edge of her seat at our kitchen table, perusing the dense Sunday edition of *The Boston Globe*, sipping her spiced tea. Page after page she will sit and read, patiently sifting through each story, each section, as if she is the editor-in-chief. Diligent and curious, she has great range of thought — from the mundane to the sublime. She is always asking and answering, and she has made my two sisters and me that way, too.

“Why does my stomach hurt?” one of us might have asked. Or, “Where is New Hampshire?” Her answer has always been “Look it up!” as if to say, “Take responsibility for what you know.” She has modeled that we need to own our knowledge, and we need to grow it.

This approach has served my mom well. Early in her career, she had her own graphic design business called the Right Type. She took on a variety of assignments, even when she was unsure of how to execute them. Her approach was to say *yes* and figure out *how* later. On her desk were stacks of how-to books on small businesses, design, organization — you name it. She progressed to starting the Paint Bar with my sister, a studio/bar where anyone can sign up for a paint class and have fun. From an early age, we witnessed how small businesses emerge without a resident MBA at the helm or any major financial backing. When my sisters and I have had

similar yearnings, we knew that some combination of “look it up” and a catchy GoDaddy domain name could get us started.

One other thing has served her well: the ability to say, “I don’ t know.” A variation of this theme is, “Tell me more.” Either works. If we need to find an answer, it is no more complicated than reaching out and finding someone in the know (and don’ t assume that person has a big degree either). My mom’ s approach, simply put, is some combination of “Don’ t feel intimidated,” “People are people,” and “What’ s the worst that could happen?” Then there is her PS and battle cry: “Put your idea into the world and take charge. Make something happen.”

So I did. Two years ago I left my job and community in Boston to move to Tel Aviv. It felt risky, but I was going to take my curiosity to a whole new level. After all, I had seen my mom leap into new places most of her life without fear — first with her graphic design business and then later when she started the Paint Bar. On the precipice of making the decision, I was anxious. Maybe she was too but chose not to show it. She advised me to be still and listen to my heart. With that, I decided to trust myself.

First I had to ask myself some hard questions. As an artist, I wondered whether people would be interested in my art and more practically, how could I support myself. Did I even have

the curiosity, grit, and gall to answer these questions? Well, my mom taught me to persist until questions are answered, even when faced with potentially dire consequences. We were in dire territory here, so my question was, “Could I manage failure if that were the outcome?” while knowing I would certainly plan for better.

I courageously took the plunge. During my darker moments, I have wondered, “How does my mom do this?” And then I see her in my mind’s eye, interacting with the public, making everyone feel that they have her full attention. She is that dual threat of both listening and telling a good story. If I can just duplicate her love of life and knack for inquisitive chatting, I think that will at least get me started on the right path.

But then there’s one more trick up her sleeve: she refuses to stay static. She has never just stuck with what she knows. In recent years she has added blogging, Instagram, and soul cycling to her repertoire, all with the enthusiasm of a millennial. So I’ve decided that too must be part of my plunge: I must find ways to continue to stretch myself. If I groove that behavior now, then when I am old (written with a smile), hopefully I will still be doing that.

My final PS is that my mom has been through some very challenging times. She lost her parents way too early and

then survived a failed marriage. I am wondering whether she read some book on resilience, or did she just know, at some instinctive level, that sometimes, we just need to push on. So many lessons, so little time. I will start by making my plunge into my creative work in Israel, and when I hit a rough spot, be resilient (though I haven' t read the book). After I catch my breath, I will proceed to asking the right questions, because that' s how I was taught to “make something happen.”

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Schon uses chronological order to organize her descriptive essay. If you were to plot the major events she discusses on a timeline, what would those events be?
2. After reading Schon' s essay, how would you describe her mother? How much do you know about the mother' s physical appearance, and how much about how her character and behavior? Identify the descriptive details that worked best for you.
3. Schon uses anecdotes in the body paragraphs of her essay to show how her mother raised her and her two sisters to be strong women. Which anecdote do you think is the most effective? Why?
4. What risk did Schon take because of her mother' s influence? Why did she feel comfortable taking this

risk?

5. Do you find Schon' s concluding paragraph effective? Why or why not? Can you think of other ways in which Schon might have ended her essay?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What is the most important thing Schon learned from her mother? What specific examples in the essay show this?
2. In the last sentence of the introduction, Schon says that her mother influenced both her and her two sisters. Is there enough information in the essay about Schon' s sisters? If there is, identify specific instances. If not, find places where Schon could expand with more information about her sisters.
3. Identify Schon' s tone. (Glossary: [Tone](#)) Find three specific sentences that exemplify this tone. Explain why and how they do.

Classroom Activity Using Description

Important advice for writing well is to show rather than tell. Your task with this activity is to reveal a person' s character. For example, to indicate that

someone is concerned about current events without coming out and saying so, you might show her reading the morning newspaper. Or you might show a person's degree of formality by including their usual greeting: *How ya doing?* In other words, the things a person says and does are often important indicators of personality and character. Choose one of the following traits, and make a list of at least four ways to show that someone possesses that trait. Share your list with the class, and discuss the “show, not tell” strategies you have used.

plain and uncomplicated	thoughtful	independent
reckless	politically involved	quick-witted
artistic	irresponsible	public- spirited
a sports lover	conversationalist	loyal

Suggested Writing Assignments

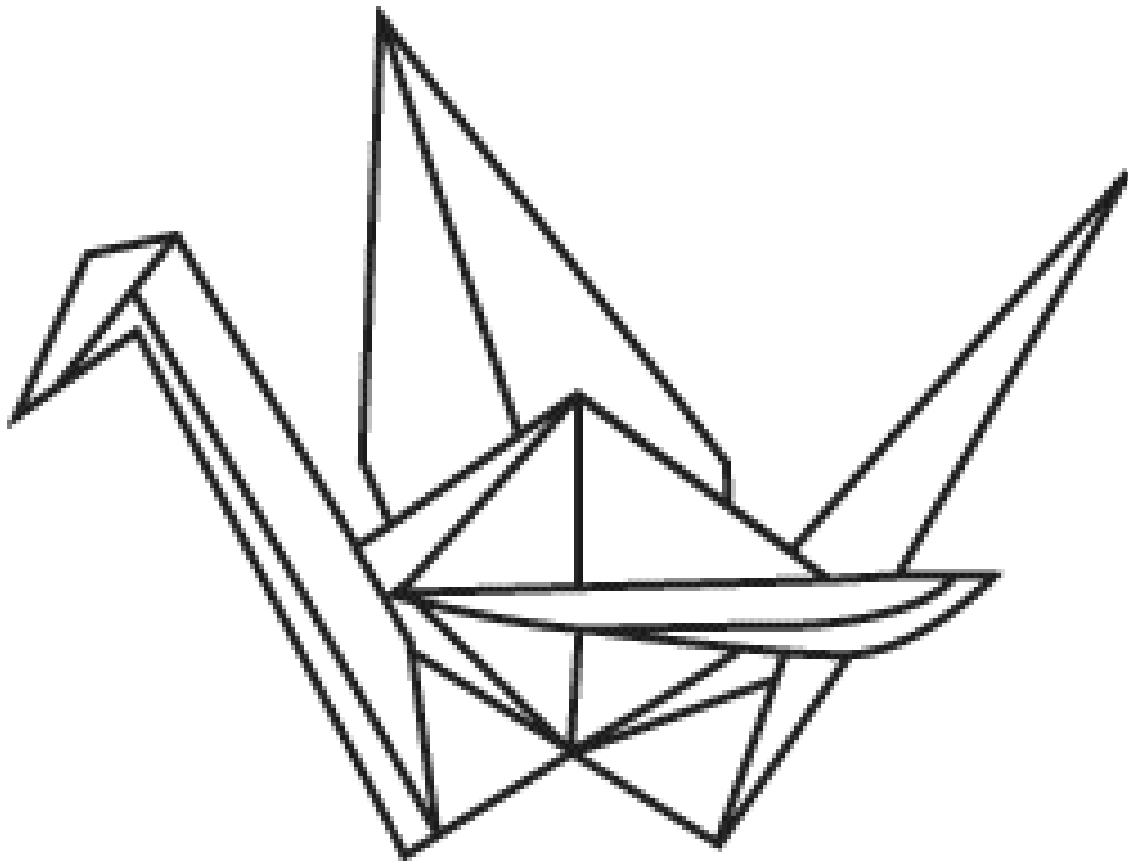
1. In this selection, Schon lists several ways in which her mother influenced her in positive ways. However, in our daily lives, we don't always realize when

we' ve made a positive impression on someone else. Think back over the last week or so. What is one action you took that made a positive impression on another person — or, alternately, an act by another person that had a positive impact on you? Write a brief essay in which you describe that positive act and convey its importance.

2. The Reflecting on What You Know prompt at the beginning of this reading selection asked you to think of a person who has greatly influenced you. Consider this person again, and write a five-paragraph essay in which each of the three body paragraphs focuses on one influential moment or experience.



CHAPTER 17 Process Analysis



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

When you give someone directions to your home, tell how to make ice cream, or explain how a president is elected, you are using [process analysis](#). Process analysis usually arranges a series of events in order and relates them to one another, as narration and cause and effect do, but process analysis has a different emphasis. Whereas narration tells mainly *what* happens and cause and effect focuses on *why* it happens, process analysis tries to explain — in detail — *how* it happens.

There are two types of process analysis: directional and informational.

DIRECTIONAL PROCESS ANALYSIS

The *directional* type of process analysis provides instructions on how to do something. These instructions can be as brief as the directions for making instant coffee printed on the label or as complex as the directions in a manual for assembling a new gas grill. Directional process analysis gives the reader directions to follow that will lead to the desired results.

Consider these directions for performing the Heimlich maneuver:

Stand behind the victim, wrap your arms around the victim's waist, and make a fist. Place the thumb side of your fist against the victim's upper abdomen, below the ribcage and above the navel. Grasp your fist with your other hand and press into her upper abdomen with a quick upward thrust. Do not squeeze the ribcage. Repeat until the stuck object is expelled.

— Joshua Piven and David Borgenicht, *The Worst-Case Scenario Survival Handbook: Life*

Piven and Borgenicht present clear, step-by-step directions for performing the Heimlich maneuver on a choking victim, being careful to present enough detail and instruction so that any person would be able to perform the maneuver.

After explaining in two previous paragraphs the first two steps involved in learning how to juggle, a student writer moves to the important third step. Notice here how he explains the third step, offers advice on what to do if things go wrong, and encourages his readers' efforts — all useful in directional process analysis:

Step three is merely a continuum of "the exchange" with the addition of the third ball. Don' t worry if you are confused — I will explain. Hold two balls in your right hand and one in your left. Make a perfect toss with one of your balls in your right hand and then an exchange with the one in your left hand. The ball coming from your left hand should now be exchanged with the, as of now, unused ball in your right hand. This process should be continued until you find yourself reaching under nearby chairs for bouncing tennis balls. It is true that many persons' backs and legs become sore when learning how to juggle because they' ve been picking up balls that they' ve inadvertently tossed around the room. Try practicing over a bed; you won' t have to reach down so far. Don' t get too upset if things aren' t going well; you' re probably keeping the same pace as everyone else at this stage.

- William Peterson, student

INFORMATIONAL PROCESS ANALYSIS

The *informational* type of process analysis, on the other hand, tells how something works, how something is made, or how something occurs. You would use informational process analysis if you wanted to explain how the human heart functions, how an atomic bomb works, how hailstones are formed, how you selected the college you are attending, or how the polio vaccine was developed. Rather than giving specific directions, informational process analysis explains and informs.

In the following illustration, Jim Collins uses informational process analysis to explain a basic legislative procedure — how a bill becomes a law.

Clarity is crucial for successful process analysis. The most effective way to explain a process is to divide it into steps and to present those steps in a clear (usually chronological) sequence. Transitional words and phrases such as *first*, *next*, *after*, and *before* help to connect steps to one another. Naturally, you must be sure that no step is omitted or given out of order. Also, you may sometimes have to explain *why* a certain step is necessary, especially if it is not obvious.

With intricate, abstract, or particularly difficult steps, you might use analogy or comparison to clarify the steps for your reader.



Description

"The infographic is represented as a paper scroll, with face and legs. The paper scroll says, "Hi, my name is Bill, but I'm changing it to law." The infographic illustrates how a bill becomes law. The infographic shows ten steps with respective illustrations on the body of the paper scroll. The steps displayed in the infographic are as follows. Step 1. The text reads, A bill may originate from: (bullet) A member of the House or Senate. (bullet) Constituents. (bullet) An Executive Communication (this includes the President). An accompanying illustration depicts Bill (as a paper scroll) walking. Step 2. The text reads, But it can only be introduced from the House or Senate (ellipsis). Step 3. The text reads, (ellipsis) where it must be sponsored by a Representative or a Senator. An accompanying illustration depicts Bill walking hand-in-hand with a Senator in formals. Step 4. The text reads, In either the House or Senate, the Bill is sent to the appropriate committee to discuss the Bill's pros and cons. An accompanying illustration depicts Bill being discussed in the House of Senators, sitting around a table. Text below reads, "We'll track a Bill that originated in the House." Step 5. The text reads, Then the full house debates the Bill. An accompanying illustration depicts Bill standing amid two groups, debating. Step 6. The text reads, As many as 100 amendments may be added at this stage. An accompanying illustration depicts the paper scroll (bill) with a several sticky notes on its body. Step 7. The text reads, A vote is taken, and the Bill passes to the Senate, where it is similarly debated. An accompanying illustration depicts Bill moving from left toward right. Step 8. The text reads, Then it's back to the House for further debate until both Houses are happy with the exact

wording. An accompanying illustration depicts Bill walking from right toward left. Step 9. The text reads, Once the language is agreed, the Bill becomes Law when the President signs it. An accompanying illustration depicts the President signing the Bill. Step 10. The text reads, But if he will not sign it, the Bill can still become Law: a two-thirds majority of both Houses can override the president's veto. An accompanying illustration depicts the President standing with arms crossed and says, "I won't sign." Two pie charts, representing two-thirds of the House and Senate, stand beside. They shake hands and say, "But we will!" A man stands beneath the huge paper scroll as he walks a dog. He asks, "Does it ever go as smoothly as this?" The dog replies, "No."

The Principles of Poor Writing

Paul W. Merrill



Courtesy of the Carnegie Observatories.

Paul Willard Merrill (1887 - 1961) was a noted astronomer whose specialty was spectroscopy — the measurement of a

quantity as a function of either wavelength or frequency. Merrill earned his AB at Stanford University in 1908 and his PhD at the University of California in 1913. After spending three years at the University of Michigan, Merrill went to work at the National Bureau of Standards, concentrating on aerial photography in the visible and infrared spectra. He was the first to propose doing infrared astronomy from airplanes. In 1919, he joined the Mt. Wilson Observatory, located near Pasadena, California, where he spent more than three decades researching peculiar stars, especially long-period variables. He received the Bruce Medal and the Henry Draper Medal, had an asteroid and a lunar crater named after him, and authored four books: *The Nature of Variable Stars* (1938), *Spectra of Long-Period Variable Stars* (1940), *Lines of the Chemical Elements in Astronomical Spectra* (1956), and *Space Chemistry* (1963). This essay first appeared in the January 1947 issue of *Scientific Monthly*.

As Merrill states in the beginning of this essay, “Poor writing is so common that every educated person ought to know something about it.” As a scientist himself, he suspects that many scientists who write poorly do so more by ear than by a set of principles, which he freely offers in this essay. As you read, consider how Merrill describes his process for an audience of all writers, including his science community.

Reflecting on What You Know

Describe your three greatest weaknesses in writing. What do you think you can do to remedy each one?

Books and articles on good writing are numerous, but where can you find sound, practical advice on how to write poorly? Poor writing is so common that every educated person ought to know something about it. Many scientists actually do write poorly, but they probably perform by ear without perceiving clearly how their results are achieved. An article on the principles of poor writing might help. The author considers himself well qualified to prepare such an article; he can write poorly without half trying.

The average student finds it surprisingly easy to acquire the usual tricks of poor writing. To do a consistently poor job, however, one must grasp a few essential principles:

1. Ignore the reader.
2. Be verbose, vague, and pompous.
3. Do not revise.

Ignore the Reader

The world is divided into two great camps: yourself and others. A little obscurity or indirection in writing will keep the others at a safe distance. Write as if for a diary. Keep your mind on a direct course between yourself and the

subject; don' t think of the reader — he makes a bad triangle. This is fundamental. Constant and alert consideration of the probable reaction of the reader is a serious menace to poor writing; moreover, it requires mental effort. A logical argument is that if you write poorly enough, your readers will be too few to merit any attention whatever.

Ignore the reader wherever possible. If the proposed title, for example, means something to you, stop right there; think no further. If the title baffles or misleads the reader, you have won the first round. Similarly, all the way through you must write for yourself, not for the reader. Practice a deadpan technique, keeping your facts and ideas all on the same level of emphasis with no telltale hints of relative importance or logical sequence. Use long sentences containing many ideas loosely strung together. *And* is the connective most frequently employed in poor writing because it does not indicate cause and effect, nor does it distinguish major ideas from subordinate ones. *Because* seldom appears in poor writing, nor does the semicolon — both are replaced by *and*.

Camouflage transitions in thought. Avoid such connectives as *moreover*, *nevertheless*, *on the other hand*. If unable to resist the temptation to give some signal for a change in thought, use *however*. A poor sentence may well begin with *however* because to the reader, with no idea what comes next,

however is too vague to be useful. A good sentence begins with the subject or with a phrase that needs emphasis.

The “hidden antecedent” is a common trick of poor writing. Use a pronoun to refer to a noun a long way back, or to one decidedly subordinate in thought or syntax; or the pronoun may refer to something not directly expressed. If you wish to play a little game with the reader, offer him the wrong antecedent as bait; you may be astonished how easy it is to catch the poor fish.

In ignoring the reader, avoid parallel constructions which give the thought away too easily. I need not elaborate, for you probably employ inversion frequently. It must have been a naive soul who said, “When the thought is parallel, let the phrases be parallel.”

In every technical paper omit a few items that most readers need to know. You had to discover these things the hard way; why make it easy for the reader? Avoid defining symbols: never specify the units in which data are presented. Of course it will be beneath your dignity to give numerical values of constants in formulae. With these omissions, some papers may be too short; lengthen them by explaining things that do not need explaining. In describing tables, give special attention to self-explanatory headings; let the reader hunt for the meaning of *Pr.*

Be Verbose, Vague, and Pompous

The cardinal sin of poor writing is to be concise and simple. Avoid being specific: it ties you down. Use plenty of deadwood: include many superfluous words and phrases. Wishful thinking suggests to a writer that verbosity somehow serves as a cloak or even as a mystic halo by which an idea may be glorified. A cloud of words may conceal defects in observation or analysis, either by opacity or by diverting the reader’ s attention. Introduce abstract nouns at the drop of a hat — even in those cases where the magnitude of the motion in a downward direction is inconsiderable. Make frequent use of the words *case, character, condition, former* and *latter, nature, such, very*.

Poor writing, like good football, is strong on razzle-dazzle, weak on information. Adjectives are frequently used to bewilder the reader. It isn’ t much trouble to make them gaudy or hyperbolic; at the least they can be flowery and inexact.

Deadwood	
BIBLE:	Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar’ s.
POOR:	In the case of Caesar it might well be considered appropriate from a moral or ethical point of view to render to that potentate all of those goods and materials of whatever character or quality which can be shown to have had their original source in any portion of the domain of the latter.

SHAKESPEARE: I am no orator as Brutus is.

POOR: The speaker is not, what might be termed as adept in the profession of public speaking, as might be properly stated of Mr. Brutus. (Example from P. W. Swain. *Amer. J. Physics*, 13, 318, 1945.)

CONCISE: The dates of several observations are in doubt.

POOR: It should be mentioned that in the case of several observations there is room for considerable doubt concerning the correctness of the dates on which they were made.

REASONABLE: Exceptionally rapid changes occur in the spectrum.

POOR: There occur in the spectrum changes which are quite exceptional in respect to the rapidity of their advent.

REASONABLE: Formidable difficulties, both mathematical and observational, stand in the way.

POOR: There are formidable difficulties of both a mathematical and an observational nature that stand in the way.

Case

REASONABLE: Two sunspots changed rapidly.

POOR: There are two cases where sunspots changed with considerable rapidity.

REASONABLE: Three stars are red.

POOR: In three cases the stars are red in color.

Razzle-Dazzle

Immaculate precision of observation and extremely delicate calculations ...

It would prove at once a world imponderable, etherealized. Our actions would grow grandific.

Well for us that the pulsing energy of the great life-giving dynamo in the sky never ceases.

Well, too, that we are at a safe distance from the flame-licked whirlpools into which our earth might drop like a pellet of waste fluff shaken into the live coals of a grate fire.

Do Not Revise

Write hurriedly, preferably when tired. Have no plan; write down items as they occur to you. The article will thus be spontaneous and poor. Hand in your manuscript the moment it is finished. Rereading a few days later might lead to revision — which seldom, if ever, makes the writing worse. If you submit your manuscript to colleagues (a bad practice), pay no attention to their criticisms or comments. Later, resist firmly any editorial suggestion. Be strong and infallible; don' t let anyone break down your personality. The critic may be trying to help you or he may have an ulterior motive, but the chance of his causing improvement in your writing is so great that you must be on guard.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. *Irony* is the use of words to suggest something different from their meaning. At what point in the essay did you realize that Merrill is being ironic? (Glossary: [Irony](#)) Did his title, introduction, or actual advice tip you off? Explain.
2. Is the author's process analysis the directional type or the informational type? What leads you to this conclusion?
3. Why has Merrill ordered his three process steps in this particular way? Could he have used a different order? (Glossary: [Organization](#)) Explain.
4. How useful are the author's examples in helping you understand his principles? Do you agree with all his examples? (Glossary: [Example](#)) Explain.
5. Why do you suppose Merrill chose to use irony to show his readers that they needed to improve their writing? (Glossary: [Irony](#)) What do you see as the potential advantages and disadvantages to such a strategy?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. In what types of writing situations is irony especially useful? (Glossary: [Irony](#))
2. Merrill discusses the concepts of coordination and subordination in paragraph 4. (He uses the word *subordinate*, but not the words *coordinate* or

coordination.) What do these two terms mean with respect to writing, and why is their use so important in effective writing?

3. In paragraph 9, Merrill ironically writes, “The cardinal sin of poor writing is to be concise and simple. Avoid being specific: it ties you down.” Of course, he means just the opposite. One response to his advice might be that it can’ t be followed all the time because some topics and ideas are too deep and complicated to be expressed concisely and simply. How would you argue against that idea?

Classroom Activity Using Process Analysis

Most do-it-yourself jobs require that you follow a set process to achieve results. Imagine you are writing an online How To article for one of the following household activities:

cleaning windows
repotting a plant
making burritos
changing a flat tire
unclogging a drain
doing laundry

Would you list the steps by number? Write paragraphs? Include images or illustrations? Work with classmates to create your article, either as a prototype on paper or, if you have the resources, as a web page.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write a process analysis in which you explain the steps you usually follow when deciding to make a purchase of some importance or expense to you. *Hint:* It's best to analyze your process with a specific product in mind. Do you compare brands, store prices, and so on? What are your priorities — that the item be stylish or durable, offer good overall value, or give high performance?
2. Try writing a process analysis essay in which you are ironic about the steps that need to be followed. For example, in an essay on how to lose weight by changing your diet or increasing your exercise, you might cast in a positive light all the things that absolutely should not be done. These might include parking as close as you can to your destination to avoid walking, or buying a half gallon of your favorite ice cream instead of a pint because the half gallons are on sale.

Designate a Place for Each Thing

Marie Kondo



Taylor Hill/Getty Images

Marie Kondo was born in Japan in 1985 and studied at Tokyo Woman' s Christian University. At age nineteen, while still a

student, Kondo started her own consulting business teaching people how to be organized. She created what is known as the KonMari system: gathering one's possessions together by category and then keeping only the items that "spark joy" in one's life. She is now a world-famous organizing consultant and lifestyle expert, and her books have been published in over forty languages. Her first English-language book was *The Life-Changing Magic of Tidying Up: The Japanese Art of Decluttering and Organizing* (2014); her newest is *Spark Joy: An Illustrated Master Class on the Art of Organizing and Tidying Up* (2016). In 2015, she was named one of *Time magazine's* 100 Most Influential People. In 2019, she launched the Netflix reality series *Tidying Up with Marie Kondo*, in which she visits people in their homes to help them organize their personal belongings and their lives.

In this excerpt from *The Life-Changing Magic of Tidying Up*, Kondo demonstrates the benefits of making sure that every item one owns has its particular place. As you read, notice how the process of simply stepping into her home reveals the benefits of her organized life.

Reflecting on What You Know

Do you consider yourself to be an organized or disorganized person? How important is being organized to you? Does your level of organization affect how you get tasks done for school, work, or home?

This is the routine I follow every day when I return from work. First, I unlock the door and announce to my house, “I’ m home!” Picking up the pair of shoes I wore yesterday and left out in the entranceway, I say, “Thank you very much for your hard work,” and put them away in the shoe cupboard. Then I take off the shoes I wore today and place them neatly in the entranceway. Heading to the kitchen, I put the kettle on and go to my bedroom. There I lay my handbag gently on the soft sheepskin rug and take off my outdoor clothes. I put my jacket and dress on a hanger, say, “Good job!” and hang them temporarily from the closet doorknob. I put my tights in a laundry basket that fits into the bottom right corner of my closet, open a drawer, select the clothes I feel like wearing inside, and get dressed. I greet the waist-high potted plant by the window and stroke its leaves.

My next task is to empty the contents of my handbag on the rug and put each item away in its place. First I remove all the receipts. Then I put my wallet in its designated box in a drawer under my bed with a word of gratitude. I place my train pass and my business card holder beside it. I put my wristwatch in a pink antique case in the same drawer and place my necklace and earrings on the accessory tray beside it. Before closing the drawer, I say, “Thanks for all you did for me today.”

Next, I return to the entrance and put away the books and notebooks I carried around all day (I have converted a shelf of my shoe cupboard into a bookshelf). From the shelf below it I take out my “receipt pouch” and put my receipts in it. Then I put my digital camera that I use for work in the space beside it, which is reserved for electrical things. Papers that I’ ve finished with go in the recycle bin beneath the kitchen range. In the kitchen, I make a pot of tea while checking the mail, disposing of the letters I’ ve finished with.

I return to my bedroom, put my empty handbag in a bag, and put it on the top shelf of the closet, saying, “You did well. Have a good rest.” From the time I get in the door to the moment I close the closet, a total of only five minutes has passed. Now I can go back to the kitchen, pour myself a cup of tea, and relax.

I did not give you this account to boast about my beautiful lifestyle, but rather to demonstrate what it’ s like to have a designated spot for everything. Keeping your space tidy becomes second nature. You can do it effortlessly, even when you come home tired from work, and this gives you more time to really enjoy life.

The point in deciding specific places to keep things is to designate a spot for *every* thing. You may think, “It would

take me forever to do that,” but you don’ t need to worry. Although it seems like deciding on a place for every item must be complicated, it’ s far simpler than deciding what to keep and what to discard. Since you have already decided what to keep according to type of item and since those items all belong to the same category, all you need to do is store them near each other.

The reason every item must have a designated place is because the existence of an item without a home multiplies the chances that your space will become cluttered again. Let’ s say, for example, that you have a shelf with nothing on it. What happens if someone leaves an object that has no designated spot on that shelf? That one item will become your downfall. Within no time that space, which had maintained a sense of order, will be covered with objects, as if someone had yelled, “Gather round, everybody!”

You only need to designate a spot for every item once. Try it. You’ ll be amazed at the results. No longer will you buy more than you need. No longer will the things you own continue to accumulate. In fact, your stock on hand will decrease. The essence of effective storage is this: designate a spot for every last thing you own. If you ignore this basic principle and start experimenting with the vast range of storage ideas being promoted, you will be sorry. Those

storage “solutions” are really just prisons within which to bury possessions that spark no joy.

One of the main reasons for rebound¹ is the failure to designate a spot for each item. Without a designated spot, where are you going to put things when you finish using them? Once you choose a place for your things, you can keep your house in order. So decide where your things belong and when you finish using them, put them there. This is the main requirement for storage.

¹*rebound*: in Kondo’s method, this means falling back into patterns of disorganization or clutter.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Why does Kondo talk to the inanimate objects in her home? What tone does that give to her writing?
(Glossary: [Tone](#))
2. Kondo gives the reader a step-by-step rendering of the process that she goes through when she comes home from work. What type of process is it — directional or informational? What leads you to that conclusion?
3. What transitional words or phrases does Kondo use to keep the process clear?
4. In paragraph 6, the first sentence is typed in a boldface font and the word *every* is italicized. Why

does Kondo use this extra emphasis?

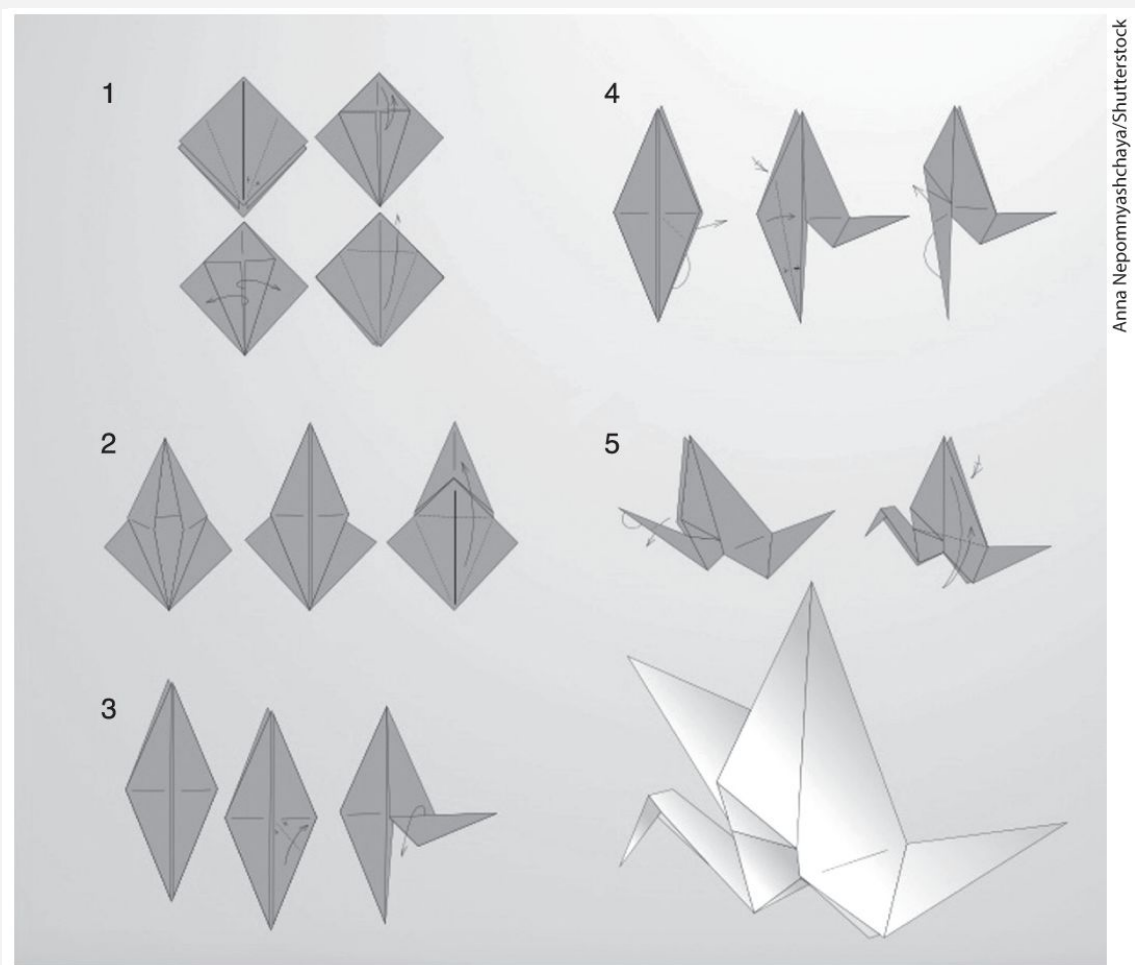
5. Kondo states, “The reason every item must have a designated place is because the existence of an item without a home multiplies the chances that your space will become cluttered again” (7). Have you found this to be true? Explain.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Kondo describes the routine that she uses every day when she comes home. Instead of being a mindless activity, the process is deliberate and reveals her theory of organization. Why is it important to include her philosophy rather than just detailing her routine? What does this philosophy reveal about Kondo’s values and her purpose?
2. One benefit to Kondo’s organizational technique is that she says you’ll never buy more than you need of something. Why is this?
3. Making sure everything has a place seems like simple advice. Why do you think this advice is so difficult for so many people to follow?

Classroom Activity Using Process Analysis

Review the following illustrations detailing the process of making an origami crane, like the ones depicted on the cover of this book. Try to make one yourself. Then, working with your classmates, try writing instructions to supplement these visual directions. Discuss what the written instructions add to the visual ones. Do they make the process easier?



Description

"The steps are as follows. Step 1. It shows four square-sized origami base papers. The first paper is

folded in half, diagonally. A crease forms. The edges of the paper from either end are to be folded, thereafter. It is unfolded, then. The paper shows three creases, which forms the bird base with two-petal fold. The creases are indicated with lines, folds are indicated with dotted lines. Several arrows are marked to indicate the directions in which the paper has to be folded and unfolded. Step 2. In this step, the top flap of the bird base is opened. The left and right edges form. The petal fold has to be repeated on the other end so as to form a diamond shape with folds. Step 3. Flip one of the folds of the diamond shaped paper to create a sharp-edged wing. Step 4. Similarly, create the other wing, while folding the other side. Step 5. Finally, create an inside reverse fold to create legs, heads of the crane. Flatten the wings. The origami crane is ready.”

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Kondo's work is about organizing the things in one's life. Write a process analysis in which you create your own lifestyle advice. Choose something that many people do in life, perhaps on a daily basis, and write about how they can do that activity better if they follow your advice. Make the steps of the process clear to your readers with good transitions and appropriate detail.

2. A central theme behind Kondo's work is that an organized and clutter-free life is a better, more productive, and happier life. Do you agree? Write an argument in defense of your answer. Provide specific details to support your argument, based on your own life, observations, and reading.

Spiders' Legs Are Hydraulic Masterpieces

Helen Czerski



Keith Morris/Alamy

Born in Greater Manchester, England, Helen Czerski (b. 1978) is an oceanographer, physicist, television host, and writer.

She studied natural sciences at Churchill College and received a PhD in experimental explosives physics. Czerski advocates taking every available opportunity to learn and maintaining curiosity about a broad range of topics. To this end, her research and programs have disseminated information on diverse topics ranging from icebergs to ocean bubbles. Additionally, Czerski is an expert in making physics accessible to a wide audience. Her book *Storm in a Teacup* (2017) employs everyday objects and experiences to illustrate more challenging physics concepts; her articles and columns, many of which also strive to make physics concepts widely engaging, have been published in such venues as *Focus Magazine* and *The Wall Street Journal*. In 2018, Czerski was the recipient of the William Thomson, Lord Kelvin Medal and Prize from the Institute of Physics.

The following article appeared in Czerski's "Everyday Physics" column in *The Wall Street Journal* on September 1, 2019. A process analysis essay, it explains how spiders use hydraulics to walk.

Reflecting on What You Know

Czerski writes that "thinking about spider anatomy for too long makes me wince" (2). Do you wince when you think about spiders? Do you find them interesting, or do you have another reaction entirely? What do you already know about spiders?

I' ve recently started to hear tales of unwelcome houseguests. But instead of unwashed dishes and loud music, the complaints focus on the visitors' habit of creeping out from tiny hiding places, scuttling across floorboards and making people jump. In early autumn, the house spiders come out to play.

I' m no arachnophobe, but thinking about spider anatomy for too long does make me wince. I find them fascinating in a slightly icky way, and this is a rare case where I' m happier being fascinated from a distance. But the way a spider moves is a beautiful lesson in mechanics. Within their spindly frame, spiders are hiding a sophisticated system of hydraulics that is essential to their movement.

A spider going for a walk is deeply impressive. Each leg has seven segments, so with eight legs, that' s 56 individual body parts to coordinate. Spiders have an exoskeleton, an external frame made of chitin and protein with no internal bones. There are muscles inside the exoskeleton that pull on it to flex the legs and bend them inward. But for two of the major joints in each leg, there are no extensor muscles, which means there' s no muscular way to pull the legs outward again. This is where the spider' s internal plumbing comes in handy.

All eight legs are attached to the front part of the spider, the prosoma or cephalothorax, which also carries the eyes and mouthparts. Inside the prosoma there's a fluid called hemolymph that takes the place of blood. Like our blood, it's a transport system, carrying oxygen and nutrients. But instead of flowing through pipes like our veins and arteries, it just fills the spaces between other organs.

Hemolymph is mostly water, and that gives it a useful characteristic: It can't be compressed. You can't squeeze it and make it smaller. Just like a water-filled balloon, if you try to squeeze it in one place, it will push into the surroundings somewhere else so that its overall volume stays the same.

This is the key point about any hydraulic system: As the fluid is pushed into another space, it transmits a force. So instead of using muscles to extend its major leg joints, the spider squeezes on the fluid in its prosoma; the hemolymph is forced out and down the legs, pushing the leg joints outward. When the spider relaxes the internal pressure, the extra fluid flows back into the prosoma and the spider is ready for the next step. Using fluid pressure like this is so effective that it has been called a "hydraulic skeleton."

This is why dead spiders are found with their legs curled up: The tension in the flexor muscles pulls the legs inward, and

there is no longer any internal pressure in the hemolymph to push them back out.

Like any system, hydraulics has its advantages and disadvantages, the most obvious being the possibility of a puncture. Spiders do have mechanisms for sealing the hole if they lose a leg and can run around quite happily afterward, but they're very vulnerable to punctures at sites that can't be easily sealed.

We tend to associate hydraulics with heavy machinery, but the spider is a living demonstration that it has far more delicate and intricate possibilities. Scientists and engineers have already been inspired by spiders to design tools for use in space that operate using a similar hydraulic system. So next time you see a spider scuttle across the floor, it's worth taking a moment to appreciate all of its hidden subtlety. Even your least favorite house guest can be fascinating company.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. In paragraph 2, Czerski writes that "the way a spider moves is a beautiful lesson in mechanics." How does spider movement relate to mechanics? Explain.

2. Write down any one of Helen Czerski' s topic sentences and a supporting detail that she uses to illustrate her point. (Glossary: [Topic Sentence](#); Glossary: [Illustration](#))
3. Is this a directional process analysis essay or an informational process analysis essay? How do you know?
4. When spiders die, what happens to their legs and why?
5. What is one disadvantage of a spider' s hydraulic system, according to Czerski?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Czerski begins her essay with two paragraphs about the unpleasantness of spiders and her reaction to their anatomy. Why do you think she begins this way rather than jumping right into the science behind the movement of spiders' legs? Do you feel that her decision to start this way is effective? (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#))
2. What is Czerski' s tone in this piece, and how do you know? (Glossary: [Tone](#)) How does the author' s tone contribute to her overall purpose? (Glossary: [Purpose](#))
3. After reading this essay, do you agree with Czerski that "A spider going for a walk is deeply impressive" (3)? Explain your answer.

Classroom Activity Using Process Analysis

With a classmate, look up any one of the following physics-related topics online. (If you are unable to go online in class, your instructor can provide you with information on each topic.) After answering the question briefly, come up with a comparison that would help a reader begin to understand the process, similar to the way that Czerski helps us understand spider legs by comparing them to hydraulics. Share your comparison with your teacher or the full class.

1. How does popcorn pop?
2. How does gravity help a ballpoint pen work?
3. How do playground swings work?

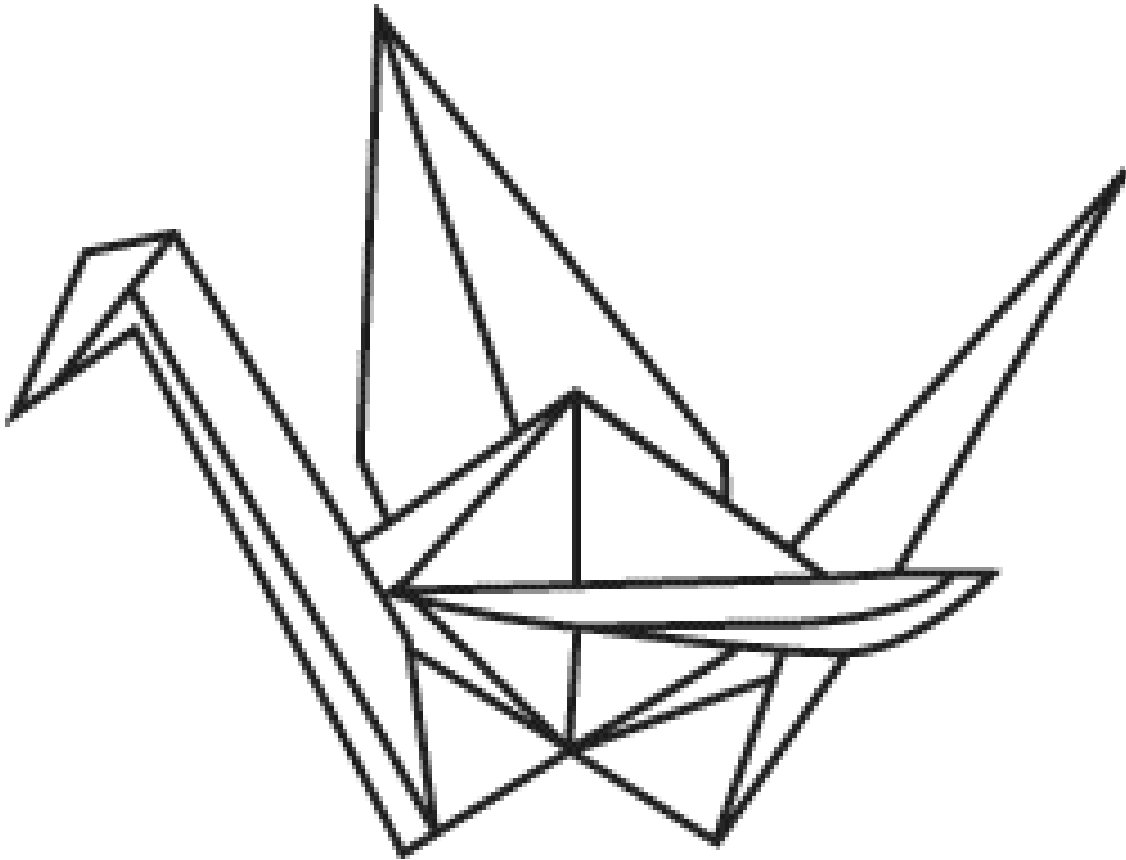
Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Brainstorm a list of objects that you use every day. From your list, choose one object and find out how that object works (or how one aspect of how it works). Finally, write an informational process analysis essay explaining how the object works to another person who may not know.

2. Write an informational process analysis essay about your learning style, or write a directional process analysis paper explaining how others can learn like you. The essay will be more engaging if you include your quirks or even aspects of your learning style that you wish were different. Include specific examples and use clear transitions to support your main ideas.



CHAPTER 18 Definition



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Definition allows you to communicate precisely what you want to say. At its most basic level, you will frequently need to define key words. Your reader needs to know just what you mean when you use unfamiliar words (such as *accoutrement*), words that are open to various interpretations (such as *liberal*), or familiar words that are used in a particular sense. Important terms that are not defined or that are defined inaccurately confuse readers and hamper communication.

Consider the opening paragraph from a student essay titled “Secular Mantras” :

Remember *The Little Engine That Could*? That’s the story about the tiny locomotive that hauled the train over the mountain when the big, rugged locomotives wouldn’t. Remember how the Little Engine strained and heaved and chugged, “I think I can — I think I can — I think I can” until she reached the top of the mountain? That’s a perfect example of a secular mantra in action. You have probably used a secular mantra (pronounce it “mantruh”) already today. It’s any word or group of words that helps you use your energy when you consciously repeat it to yourself. You must understand two qualities about secular mantras to be able to recognize one.

— Keith Eldred, student

Eldred engages his readers with the story of the Little Engine and then uses that example to lead into a definition of *secular mantra*. He concludes the paragraph with a sentence that tells readers what is coming next.

You can define a word by giving a synonym, a formal definition, or an extended definition. Each approach is useful in its own way.

SYNONYMS

The first method of definition is to give a *synonym* — that is, to use a word that has nearly the same meaning as the word you wish to define (*face* for *countenance*, *nervousness* for *anxiety*). No two words have exactly the same meaning, but you can pair an unfamiliar word with a familiar one to clarify your meaning.

FORMAL DEFINITIONS

Another way to define a word quickly, often within a single sentence, is to give a *formal definition* — to place the term in a general class and then distinguish it from other members of that class by describing its particular characteristics, as in the following examples:

<i>Word</i>	<i>Class</i>	<i>Characteristics</i>
A watch	is a mechanical device	that is used for telling time and is usually carried or worn.
Semantics	is an area of linguistics	that is concerned with the study of the meaning of words.

EXTENDED DEFINITIONS

The third method of defining a word is to give an *extended definition* — that is, to use one or more paragraphs (or even an entire essay) to define a new or difficult term or to rescue a controversial word from misconceptions that may obscure its meaning. In an essay-length extended definition, you provide your readers with information about the meaning of a single word, a concept, or an object. You must consider what your readers already know, or think they know, about your topic. Are there popular misconceptions that need to be corrected? Are some aspects of the topic seldom considered? Have particular experiences helped you understand the topic? You can use synonyms or formal definitions in an extended definition, but you must convince readers to accept your particular understanding of the word, concept, or object.

In the following two-paragraph sequence, the writers provide an extended definition of *restorative justice*, an important concept in the field of criminal justice:

The criminal justice response focuses on arresting, convicting, and punishing the offender for his actions. During such tragedies, the losses suffered by the offender and his family members typically are overlooked. Restorative justice, by recognizing the connections and relationships (whether healthy, strained, or contemptuous) among offenders, victims, their

family members, and the community seeks to address crime in a more holistic manner. It seeks to heal and strengthen communities by providing a restorative process for everyone affected by a serious crime.

Howard Zehr, a pioneer in restorative justice theory, practice, and scholarship, outlines the key principles of restorative justice: “1) crime is a violation of people and of interpersonal relationships; 2) violations create obligations; 3) the central obligation is to put right the wrongs.” Too often the criminal justice system loses sight of human nature, causing it to ignore many of the emotional consequences of the entire process. Even though the present criminal justice system leads to a verdict and a judgment that purports to right the scales of justice, the collateral damage can be staggering. The offender is often encouraged by his lawyers to deny or minimize responsibility. Though punished, the offender is rarely held personally accountable by publicly acknowledging his guilt, facing his victims, and offering an apology or the truth. In fact, the traditional justice system encourages many offenders to continue to deny responsibility, even in prison, and to blame others for their own actions. Restorative justice encourages offender accountability by stressing dialogue and truth-telling as central to putting things right and repairing personal relationships.

— Elizabeth Beck, Sarah Britto, and Arlene Andrews, *In the Shadow of Death: Restorative Justice and Death Row Families*

Another term that illustrates the usefulness of extended definition is *obscene*. What is obscene? Books that are banned in one school system are considered perfectly acceptable in

another. Movies that are shown in one town cannot be shown in a neighboring town. The meaning of *obscene* has been clouded by contrasting personal opinions as well as by conflicting social norms. Therefore, if you use the term *obscene* (and especially if you tackle the issue of obscenity itself), you must define clearly and thoroughly what you mean by that term — that is, you have to give an extended definition. There are a number of methods you might use to develop such a definition. You could define *obscene* by explaining what it does not mean. You could also make your meaning clear by narrating an experience, by comparing and contrasting it to related terms (such as *pornographic* or *erotic*), by citing specific examples, or by classifying the various types of obscenity. Any of these methods could help you develop an effective definition.

What Is Shame?

Brené Brown



AP Images/Chris Pizzello

Brené Brown is a research professor at the University of Texas in Houston. Born in San Antonio, she attended the

University of Texas at Austin, where she earned her BA and then her MA, both in Social Work. She later received her PhD from the University of Houston. Her professional interests include courage, empathy, shame, and vulnerability. She is the author of a number of bestselling books, which include *I Thought It Was Just Me (but it isn't): Telling the Truth About Perfectionism, Inadequacy, and Power* (2007); *The Gifts of Imperfection: Letting Go of Who We Think We Should Be and Embracing Who We Are* (2010); and *Daring Greatly: How the Courage to Be Vulnerable Transforms the Way We Live, Love, Parent, and Lead* (2012). Brown is also a motivational speaker and has presented TED talks titled “The Power of Vulnerability” and “Listening to Shame.” She and her husband live with their children in Houston.

The following selection is taken from *Daring Greatly*. As you read, notice how Brown carefully defines *shame* and then provides over a dozen real-life examples to clarify her definition. Next she explores three other emotions — *guilt*, *embarrassment*, and *humiliation* — that we often confuse with shame and shows how they are both related to, and different from, shame.

Reflecting on What You Know

Think of a few times when you felt shame for something you said or did, both when you were younger and more recently. How did you feel? What did you do with those feelings? Was

the experience different when you were younger than it is now? If so, how?

What Is Shame and Why Is It So Hard to Talk about It?

(If you're pretty sure that shame doesn't apply to you, keep reading; I'll clear that up in the next couple of pages.)

I start every talk, article, and chapter on shame with the Shame 1-2-3s, or the first three things that you need to know about shame, so you'll keep listening:

1. We all have it. Shame is universal and one of the most primitive human emotions that we experience. The only people who don't experience shame lack the capacity for empathy and human connection. Here's your choice: Fess up to experiencing shame or admit that you're a sociopath. *Quick note: This is the only time that shame seems like a good option.*
2. We're all afraid to talk about shame.
3. The less we talk about shame, the more control it has over our lives.

There are a couple of very helpful ways to think about shame. First, shame is the fear of disconnection. We are psychologically, emotionally, cognitively, and spiritually hardwired for connection, love, and belonging. Connection,

along with love and belonging (two expressions of connection), is why we are here, and it is what gives purpose and meaning to our lives. Shame is the fear of disconnection — it's the fear that something we've done or failed to do, an ideal that we've not lived up to, or a goal that we've not accomplished makes us unworthy of connection. *I'm not worthy or good enough for love, belonging, or connection.* I'm unlovable. I don't belong. Here's the definition of shame that emerged from my research:

Shame is the intensely painful feeling or experience of believing that we are flawed and therefore unworthy of love and belonging.

People often want to believe that shame is reserved for people who have survived an unspeakable trauma, but this is not true. Shame is something we all experience. And while it feels as if shame hides in our darkest corners, it actually tends to lurk in all of the familiar places. Twelve “shame categories” have emerged from my research:

- Appearance and body image
- Money and work
- Motherhood/fatherhood
- Family
- Parenting
- Mental and physical health

- Addiction
- Sex
- Aging
- Religion
- Surviving trauma
- Being stereotyped or labeled

Here are some of the responses we received when we asked people for an example of shame:

- Shame is getting laid off and having to tell my pregnant wife.
- Shame is having someone ask me, “When are you due?” when I’ m not pregnant.
- Shame is hiding the fact that I’ m in recovery.
- Shame is raging at my kids.
- Shame is bankruptcy.
- Shame is my boss calling me an idiot in front of the client.
- Shame is not making partner.
- Shame is my husband leaving me for my next-door neighbor.
- Shame is my wife asking me for a divorce and telling me that she wants children, but not with me.
- Shame is my DUI.
- Shame is infertility.
- Shame is telling my fiancé that my dad lives in France when in fact he’ s in prison.
- Shame is Internet porn.

- Shame is flunking out of school. Twice.
- Shame is hearing my parents fight through the walls and wondering if I' m the only one who feels this afraid.

Shame is real pain. The importance of social acceptance and connection is reinforced by our brain chemistry, and the pain that results from social rejection and disconnection is real pain. In a 2011 study funded by the National Institute of Mental Health and by the National Institute on Drug Abuse, researchers found that, as far as the brain is concerned, physical pain and intense experiences of social rejection hurt in the same way. So when I define shame as an intensely “painful” experience, I' m not kidding. Neuroscience advances confirm what we' ve known all along: Emotions can hurt and cause pain. And just as we often struggle to define physical pain, describing emotional pain is difficult. Shame is particularly hard because it hates having words wrapped around it. It hates being spoken.

Untangling Shame, Guilt, Humiliation, and Embarrassment

In fact, as we work to understand shame, one of the simpler reasons that shame is so difficult to talk about is vocabulary. We often use the terms *embarrassment*, *guilt*, *humiliation*, and *shame* interchangeably. It might seem overly picky to stress the importance of using the appropriate term

to describe an experience or emotion; however, it is much more than semantics.

How we experience these different emotions comes down to self-talk. How do we talk to ourselves about what's happening? The best place to start examining self-talk and untangling these four distinct emotions is with shame and guilt. The majority of shame researchers and clinicians agree that the difference between shame and guilt is best understood as the difference between "I am bad" and "I did something bad."

Guilt = I did something bad.

Shame = I am bad.

For example, let's say that you forgot that you made plans to meet a friend at noon for lunch. At 12:15 P.M., your friend calls from the restaurant to make sure you're okay. If your self-talk is "I'm such an idiot. I'm a terrible friend and a total loser" — that's shame. If, on the other hand, your self-talk is "I can't believe I *did* that. What a crappy thing *to do*" — that's guilt.

Here's what's interesting — especially for those who automatically think, *You should feel like a terrible friend!* or *A little shame will help you keep your act together next time*. When we feel shame, we are most likely to protect

ourselves by blaming something or someone, rationalizing our lapse, offering a disingenuous apology, or hiding out. Rather than apologizing, we blame our friend and rationalize forgetting: “I told you I was really busy. This wasn’ t a good day for me.” Or we apologize halfheartedly and think to ourselves, *Whatever. If she knew how busy I am, she’ d be apologizing.* Or we see who is calling and don’ t answer the phone at all, and then when we finally can’ t stop dodging our friend, we lie: “Didn’ t you get my e-mail? I canceled in the morning. You should check your spam folder.”

When we apologize for something we’ ve done, make amends, or change a behavior that doesn’ t align with our values, guilt — not shame — is most often the driving force. We feel guilty when we hold up something we’ ve done or failed to do against our values and find they don’ t match up. It’ s an uncomfortable feeling, but one that’ s helpful. The psychological discomfort, something similar to cognitive dissonance¹, is what motivates meaningful change. Guilt is just as powerful as shame, but its influence is positive, while shame’ s is destructive. In fact, in my research I found that shame corrodes the very part of us that believes we can change and do better.

We live in a world where most people still subscribe to the belief that shame is a good tool for keeping people in line. Not only is this wrong, but it’ s dangerous. Shame is highly

correlated with addiction, violence, aggression, depression, eating disorders, and bullying. Researchers don't find shame correlated with positive outcomes at all — there are no data to support that shame is a helpful compass for good behavior. In fact, shame is much more likely to be the cause of destructive and hurtful behaviors than it is to be the solution.

Again, it is human nature to want to feel worthy of love and belonging. When we experience shame, we feel disconnected and desperate for worthiness. When we're hurting, either full of shame or even just feeling the fear of shame, we are more likely to engage in self-destructive behaviors and to attack or shame others. In the chapters on parenting, leadership, and education, we'll explore how shame erodes our courage and fuels disengagement, and what we can do to cultivate cultures of worthiness, vulnerability, and shame resilience.

Humiliation is another word that we often confuse with *shame*. Donald Klein captures the difference between shame and humiliation when he writes, "People believe they deserve their shame; they do not believe they deserve their humiliation." If John is in a meeting with his colleagues and his boss, and his boss calls him a loser because of his inability to close a sale, John will probably experience that as either shame or humiliation.

If John's self-talk is "God, I am a loser. I'm a failure" — that's shame. If his self-talk is "Man, my boss is so out of control. This is ridiculous. I don't deserve this" — that's humiliation. Humiliation feels terrible and makes for a miserable work or home environment — and if it's ongoing, it can certainly become shame if we start to buy into the messaging. It is, however, still better than shame. Rather than internalizing the "loser" comment, John's saying to himself, "This isn't about me." When we do that, it's less likely that we'll shut down, act out, or fight back. We stay aligned with our values while trying to solve the problem.

Embarrassment is the least serious of the four emotions. It's normally fleeting and it can eventually be funny. The hallmark of embarrassment is that when we do something embarrassing, we don't feel alone. We know other folks have done the same thing and, like a blush, it will pass rather than define us.

Getting familiar with the language is an important start to understanding shame.

1*cognitive dissonance*: in psychology, an uncomfortable mental state that a person experiences when he or she does something that is inconsistent with his or her beliefs or values.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How does Brown define *shame*?
2. How does Brown explain the difference between *shame* and *guilt*? What are some examples she uses to show this distinction?
3. According to Brown, which usually motivates a person to change his or her behavior: shame or guilt? Why?
4. In Brown's view, what is the difference between *shame* and *humiliation*? Why is this difference significant?
5. How comfortable do you feel about discussing shame? Why, according to Brown, is it so important that we talk about our experiences with it?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Brown says, "Shame is real pain" (6). What does she mean by this? How is this statement important to her larger argument?
2. Brown defines *shame*, *guilt*, *humiliation*, and *embarrassment*, and explains the differences between each of these terms. Do you agree with her explanation? Why or why not? Do you disagree with her characterization of any of these emotions?
3. Recently, there has been a lot of discussion around the issue of body shaming, especially on social

media. Based on this reading, what do you think Brown would say about this issue? Why? Support your answer with specific examples from the reading.

Classroom Activity Using Definition

Define one of the following terms formally by putting it in a class and then by describing its characteristics to differentiate it from other words in the same class. (See [p. 423.](#))

EXAMPLE: Friendship (word) is a type of human relationship (class) that forms by choice and circumstance rather than by genetic relation or forced interaction (characteristics).

lasagna	cosmetic surgery	Monopoly (game)
pride	French (the language)	Hinduism
cello	Pomeranian	

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Carefully read Dick Gregory's essay [“Shame”](#) (pp. 143 – 46), an account of an experience he had in elementary school. Think about why he felt such

powerful shame as a result of that experience. Then consider how Brené Brown might respond to Gregory's essay. Based on what Brown says in her own essay, what advice do you think she would give Gregory?

Write a brief essay answering this question.

2. Brown emphatically states that “the less we talk about shame, the more control it has over our lives” (1). Using experiences from your own life or situations that you have observed, write an essay in which you agree or disagree with Brown's position.

Who Gets to Be “Hapa” ?

Akemi Johnson



Twitter/Akemi Johnson

Born in Oakland, California, in 1982, Akemi Johnson received a bachelor's degree in East Asian Studies at Brown University before studying at the famed Iowa Writer's Workshop, where she received her MFA in fiction writing. She has been the recipient of a Fulbright grant to Japan, a Pushcart Prize nomination, and the James D. Phelan Award from the San Francisco Foundation. Johnson has written for a variety of publications, including *The Nation*, the *Asian American Literary Review*, and *Roads & Kingdoms*. She has also contributed to National Public Radio's *All Things Considered* and *Code Switch*, a channel and blog concerned with "the overlapping themes of race, ethnicity and culture." Johnson is the author of *Night in the American Village: Women in the Shadow of the U.S. Military Bases in Okinawa* (2019). She has taught writing at George Washington University, the University of Hawaii at Manoa, and the University of Iowa.

The following selection first appeared as part of NPR's *Code Switch* on August 8, 2016. As you read this essay, notice how Johnson first defines the Hawaiian word *hapa* from a personal perspective and then explores its different uses and connotations, including the word's connection to the Hawaiian people and their history and culture.

Reflecting on What You Know

What words have you heard used to describe your own ethnic or racial identity? Were those words largely positive, negative,

or mixed? How do you feel when you hear those words?

Sunset in Waikiki: Tourists sipping mai tais¹ crowded the beachside hotel bar. When the server spotted my friend and me, he seemed to relax. “Ah,” he said, smiling. “Two hapa girls.”

He asked if we were from Hawaii. We weren’ t. We both have lived in Honolulu — my friend lives there now — but hail from California. It didn’ t matter. In that moment, he recognized our mixed racial backgrounds and used “hapa” like a secret handshake, suggesting we were aligned with him: insiders and not tourists.

Like many multiracial Asian-Americans, I identify as hapa, a Hawaiian word for “part” that has spread beyond the islands to describe anyone who’ s part Asian or Pacific Islander. When I first learned the term in college, wearing it felt thrilling in a tempered² way, like trying on a beautiful gown I couldn’ t afford. Hapa seemed like the identity of lucky mixed-race people far away, people who’ d grown up in Hawaii as the norm, without “Chink” taunts, mangled name pronunciations, or questions about what they were.

Over time, as more and more people called me hapa, I let myself embrace the word. It’ s a term that explains who I am and connects me to others in an instant. It’ s a term that

creates a sense of community around similar life experiences and questions of identity. It's what my fiancé and I call ourselves, and how we think of the children we might have: second-generation hapas.

But as the term grows in popularity, so does debate over how it should be used. Some people argue that hapa is a slur and should be retired. “[It] is an ugly term born of racist closed-mindedness much like ‘*half-breed*’ or ‘*mulatto*,’ ” design consultant Warren Wake wrote to Code Switch after reading my piece on a “hapa Bachelorette.”

Several scholars told me it's a misconception that hapa has derogatory³ roots. The word entered the Hawaiian language in the early 1800s, with the arrival of Christian missionaries who instituted a Hawaiian alphabet and developed curriculum for schools. Hapa is a transliteration of the English word “half,” but quickly came to mean “part,” combining with numbers to make fractions. (For example, hapalua is half. Hapaha is one-fourth.) Hapa haole — part foreigner — came to mean a mix of Hawaiian and other, whether describing a mixed-race person, a fusion song, a bilingual Bible, or pidgin⁴ language itself.

This original use was *not* negative, said Kealalokahi Losch, a professor of Hawaiian studies and Pacific Island studies at Kapi'olani Community College. “The reason [hapa] feels good

is because it's always felt good," he told me. Losch has been one of the few to study the earliest recorded uses of the term, buried in Hawaiian-language newspapers, and found no evidence that it began as derogatory. Because the Hawaiian kingdom was more concerned with genealogy than race, he explained, if you could trace your lineage to a Hawaiian ancestor, you were Hawaiian. Mixed Hawaiian did not mean less Hawaiian.

Any use of hapa as a slur⁵ originated with outsiders, Losch said. That includes New England missionaries, Asian plantation workers and the U.S. government, which instituted blood quantum laws to limit eligibility for Hawaiian homestead lands. On the continental U.S., some members of Japanese-American communities employed hapa to make those who were mixed "feel like they were not really, truly Japanese or Japanese-American," said Duncan Williams, a professor of religion and East Asian languages and cultures at the University of Southern California. He said this history may have led some to believe the word is offensive.

For Losch, "hapa haole" — meaning part Hawaiian, part other — always has been positive. "This is absolutely who I am," he said. The license plate on his car reads, "HAPA H." His family members have been proud hapa haole for generations. An issue for him is when non-Hawaiians call

themselves hapa. “There are times when it feels like identity theft,” he said.

This is arguably the trickier and more significant conflict around the term. Hapa, middle school teacher Piikea Kalakau told me, means part Native Hawaiian — not part Asian. “I ... am personally frustrated with the world misusing this word ... ,” she wrote in an e-mail.

I followed up with Kalakau by phone. The widespread use of hapa, she said, is a form of cultural appropriation, just as offensive as hula dancer dolls shaking their hips on car dashboards. She said correcting the definition of hapa is part of a larger Native Hawaiian “movement to take back our culture.” She said her people were fighting to thrive again after surviving colonization and its damage to their language, culture and population. Kalakau encouraged me and other mixed Asian-Americans to find labels from our own heritages. “I wouldn’ t use a Japanese word or a Filipino word to describe myself because it doesn’ t fit,” she said.

Mixed-race Chinese-American scholar Wei Ming Dariotis works through this dilemma in her 2007 essay, “Hapa: The Word of Power.” In it, she details her difficult decision to stop using hapa, though the term had formed the foundation of her identity and community. “To have this symbolic word used by Asians, particularly by Japanese Americans, as though it is

their own,” she writes, “seems to symbolically mirror the way Native Hawaiian land was first taken by European Americans, and is now owned by European Americans, Japanese and Japanese Americans and other Asian American ethnic groups that numerically and economically dominate Native Hawaiians in their own land.”

The desire of many Native Hawaiians to reclaim this word is often linked to a larger call for change. In Hawaii, a growing sovereignty⁶ movement maintains that the late 19th-century overthrow and annexation of the kingdom were illegal and the islands should again exercise some form of self-governance. But even within that movement opinions on hapa vary. I spoke with attorney Poka Laenui, who said he has been involved in the Hawaiian sovereignty movement for more than 40 years. He told me, in the “idea of aloha” — the complex blend that includes love, compassion and generosity — he doesn’t mind if the term is shared. “If our word can be used to assist people in identifying and understanding one another, who am I to object?” he said...

Hapa has become a meaningful part of who I am. But now I understand this frustrates and offends others. Now, when I think of hapa, I think about the history of Hawaii and identity theft. I think about helping obscure a group of people by swapping my story for theirs.

Hapa is a word I don' t think I should use anymore. But I also don' t know how I will let it go.

1*mai tai*: popular beach cocktail made with rum and fruit juices.

2*tempered*: balanced; not too extreme.

3*derogatory*: negative or insulting; showing a low opinion of someone or something.

4*pidgin*: a common, simplified language used to communicate between speakers of different languages.

5*slur*: an insulting name or remark.

6*sovereignty*: freedom from control.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. The server in Waikiki is happy to see Johnson and her friend. What does their interaction suggest about living in Hawaii?
2. Professor Kealalokahi Losch states, “The reason [hapa] feels good is that it’ s always felt good” (7). Why is that?
3. Johnson says that identity theft is the “trickier and more significant conflict around the term [hapa]” (10). What is the meaning of “identity theft” in this context? Who is the thief and who is the victim?

4. How does Johnson show that the use of the word *hapa* is connected to the history of the colonization of Hawaii?
5. Why does Johnson ultimately decide to avoid the use of the term *hapa*, as it applies to herself?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What do you see as Johnson's purpose in writing this essay? Does she simply want to define the word *hapa*, or is she after something more? Explain.
2. Johnson states that when she encountered the word *hapa* in college, she embraced the term: "Hapa seemed like the identity of lucky mixed-raced people far away ..." (3). Why were those people lucky, in Johnson's mind? What does this suggest about growing up as a mixed-race person — particularly a part-Asian person — in the United States?
3. In paragraph 5, Johnson introduces the issue of whether the word *hapa* is a slur. What is the evidence that it is a slur? What is the evidence that it's not? Which do you find more convincing?

Classroom Activity Using Definition

The connotation of a term depends on the context. Choose one of the following terms, and provide two definitions — one positive and one negative — that could apply to the term in different contexts.

player

intellectual

overachiever

salt-of-the-earth

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. In Johnson's essay, the issue of "cultural appropriation" becomes central to whether or not she feels comfortable using the term *hapa* to describe herself. Write an essay in which you define a term like *hapa* and argue that cultural appropriation is or is not a problem. Use specific examples to support your viewpoint.
2. Johnson's essay discusses her relationship to the word *hapa*. Choose a word or term that you use to identify yourself. Perhaps it is a word or identity that you have come to question, as Johnson does. Write an essay explaining your relationship to the term and why you identify with it. Define the term as it is used today, and also investigate its history: how it was created, who created it, and under what circumstances. Provide examples that illustrate how

the use of the term may be empowering or problematic.
(Glossary: [Illustration](#))

What Happiness Is

Eduardo Porter



Miniam Berkley

Eduardo Porter was born in 1963, in Phoenix, Arizona, of a Mexican mother and an American father. When he was six, his

family moved to Mexico City, where he lived until he graduated from the Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México in 1987 with a degree in physics. Later he earned an MSc from the Imperial College of Science and Technology in London, England. Porter started his career in journalism at Notimex, a Mexican news agency, where he wrote mostly in Spanish about the stock market and the financial world. In 2000, he moved to the Los Angeles bureau of *The Wall Street Journal*, where he covered issues related to the Hispanic community, then to *The New York Times* in 2004, first as an economics writer in the newsroom and later as a member of the editorial board. Once at the *Times*, he had the opportunity to explore his long-standing interest in the ubiquity of prices. “Slowly,” he shared, “the broader idea that prices are involved in every one of our decisions, that economics affect people’s behavior gelled for me.” His research resulted in *The Price of Everything: Solving the Mystery of Why We Pay What We Do*, published in 2011. From 2012 to 2018, he wrote the Economic Scene column for the *Times*. His most recent book is *American Poison: How Radical Hostility Destroyed Our Promise* (2020).

In the following selection, taken from the “The Price of Happiness” chapter in *The Price of Everything*, Porter sheds some light on the “slippery concept” of happiness. As you read his essay, notice how he explores many different perspectives — from Gandhi, Lincoln, and Kennedy to Freud and even Snoopy — on the meaning of happiness, the pursuit

of which is guaranteed in the U.S. Constitution, before settling on a broad definition from the world of economics.

Reflecting on What You Know

What makes you happy — a good relationship? A delicious meal? Satisfying or rewarding work? Money? Is *happiness* a term that's easy for you to define, or do you find it somewhat elusive? Explain.

Happiness is a slippery concept, a bundle of meanings with no precise, stable definition. Lots of thinkers have taken a shot at it. “Happiness is when what you think, what you say, and what you do are in harmony,” proposed Gandhi. Abraham Lincoln argued “most people are about as happy as they make up their minds to be.” Snoopy, the beagle-philosopher in *Peanuts*, took what was to my mind the most precise stab at the underlying epistemological problem. “My life has no purpose, no direction, no aim, no meaning, and yet I'm happy. I can't figure it out. What am I doing right?”

Most psychologists and economists who study happiness agree that what they prefer to call “subjective well-being” comprises three parts: satisfaction, meant to capture how people judge their lives measured up against their aspirations; positive feelings like joy; and the absence of negative feelings like anger.

It does exist. It relates directly to objective measures of people's quality of life. Countries whose citizens are happier on average report lower levels of hypertension in the population. Happier people are less likely to come down with a cold. And if they get one, they recover more quickly. People who are wounded heal more quickly if they are satisfied with their lives. People who say they are happier smile more often, sleep better, report themselves to be in better health, and have happier relatives. And some research suggests happiness and suicide rates move in opposite directions. Happy people don't want to die.

Still, this conceptual *mélange*¹ can be difficult to measure. Just ask yourself how happy you are, say, on a scale of one to three, as used by the General Social Survey. Then ask yourself what you mean by that. Answers wander when people are confronted with these questions. We entangle gut reactions with thoughtful analysis, and confound sensations of immediate pleasure with evaluations of how life meshes with our long-term aspirations. We might say we know what will make us happy in the future — fame, fortune, or maybe a partner. But when we get to the future, it rarely does. While we do seem to know how to tell the difference between lifelong satisfaction and immediate well-being, the immediate tends to contaminate the ontological.²

During an experiment in the 1980s, people who found a dime on top of a Xerox machine before responding to a happiness survey reported a much higher sense of satisfaction with life than those who didn't. Another study found that giving people a chocolate bar improved their satisfaction with their lives. One might expect that our satisfaction with the entire span of our existence would be a fairly stable quantity — impervious to day-to-day joys and frustrations. Yet people often give a substantially different answer to the same question about lifetime happiness if it is asked again one month later.

Sigmund Freud³ argued that people “strive after happiness; they want to become happy and to remain so.” Translating happiness into the language of economics as “utility,” most economists would agree. This simple proposition gives them a powerful tool to resist Bobby Kennedy's⁴ proposal to measure not income but something else. For if happiness is what people strive for, one needn't waste time trying to figure out what makes people happy. One must only look at what people do. The fact of the matter is that people mostly choose to work and make money. Under this optic, economic growth is the outcome of our pursuit of well-being. It is what makes us happy.

This approach has limitations. We often make puzzling choices that do not make us consistently happier. We smoke despite

knowing about cancer and emphysema. We gorge on chocolate despite knowing it will make us unhappy ten pounds down the road. Almost two thirds of Americans say they are overweight, according to a recent Gallup poll. But only a quarter say they are seriously trying to lose weight. In the 1980s a new discipline called Prospect Theory — also known as behavioral economics — deployed the tools of psychology to analyze economic behavior. It found all sorts of peculiar behaviors that don't fit economics' standard understanding of what makes us happy. For instance, losing something reduces our happiness more than winning the same thing increases it — a quirk known as loss aversion. We are unable to distinguish between choices that have slightly different odds of making us happy. We extrapolate from a few experiences to arrive at broad, mostly wrong conclusions. We herd, imitating successful behaviors around us.

Still, it remains generally true that we pursue what we think makes us happy — and though some of our choices may not make us happy, some will. Legend has it that Abraham Lincoln was riding in a carriage one rainy evening, telling a friend that he agreed with economists' theory that people strove to maximize their happiness, when he caught sight of a pig stuck in a muddy riverbank. He ordered the carriage to stop, got out, and pulled the pig out of the muck to safety. When the friend pointed out to a mud-caked Lincoln that he had just disproved his statement by putting himself through great

discomfort to save a pig, Lincoln retorted: “What I did was perfectly consistent with my theory. If I hadn’ t saved that pig I would have felt terrible.’ ’

So perhaps the proper response to Bobby Kennedy’ s angst is to agree that pursuing economic growth often has negative side effects — carbon emissions, environmental degradation — that are likely to make us unhappy down the road. Still, it remains true that American citizens — and the citizens of much of the world — expend enormous amounts of time and energy pursuing more money and a bigger GDP because they think it will improve their well-being. And that will make them happy.

¹ *mélange*: a mixture of often incongruous elements.

² *ontological*: relating to the nature of being or existence.

³ *Sigmund Freud* (1856 – 1939): founder of psychoanalysis, a set of theories that involve understanding unconscious desires.

⁴ *Bobby Kennedy*: Robert F. Kennedy (1925 – 1968), U.S. senator and 1968 presidential candidate; younger brother of President John F. Kennedy.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Porter opens his essay with the statement,
“Happiness is a slippery concept, a bundle of

meanings with no precise, stable definition.” How does he illustrate this generalization? (Glossary: [Example](#)) How effective did you find this beginning? (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#))

2. According to Porter, what are the three parts of what psychologists and economists call “subjective well-being” (2)? Why is it useful to have this information when discussing the meaning of happiness? Explain.
3. In what ways is happiness related to a person’s “quality of life” (3)? What character traits, according to Porter, do happy people possess?
4. What point does Porter make with the story about Abraham Lincoln and the pig?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What assumptions does Porter make about happiness? Do you agree with his assumptions? Explain why or why not.
2. What do you think Porter means when he says, “While we do seem to know how to tell the difference between lifelong satisfaction and immediate well-being, the immediate tends to contaminate the ontological” (4). Do you agree with him? Explain your answer with a personal experience or observation.

3. How does Porter use economics to explain what he thinks happiness is? What are the limitations, if any, of his economic model?

Classroom Activity Using Definition

Definitions often depend on perspective, as Porter illustrates in his essay with the word *happiness*. Discuss with your classmates other words or terms (*competition, wealth, success, jerk, superstar, failure, poverty, luxury, beauty*) whose definitions depend on one's perspective. Choose several of these words, and write brief definitions for each of them from your perspective. Share your definitions with your classmates, and discuss how perspective affects the way we define things in our world differently.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Using Porter's essay as a model, write a short essay in which you define one of the following abstract terms or another similar term of your choosing. Before beginning to write, you may find it helpful to

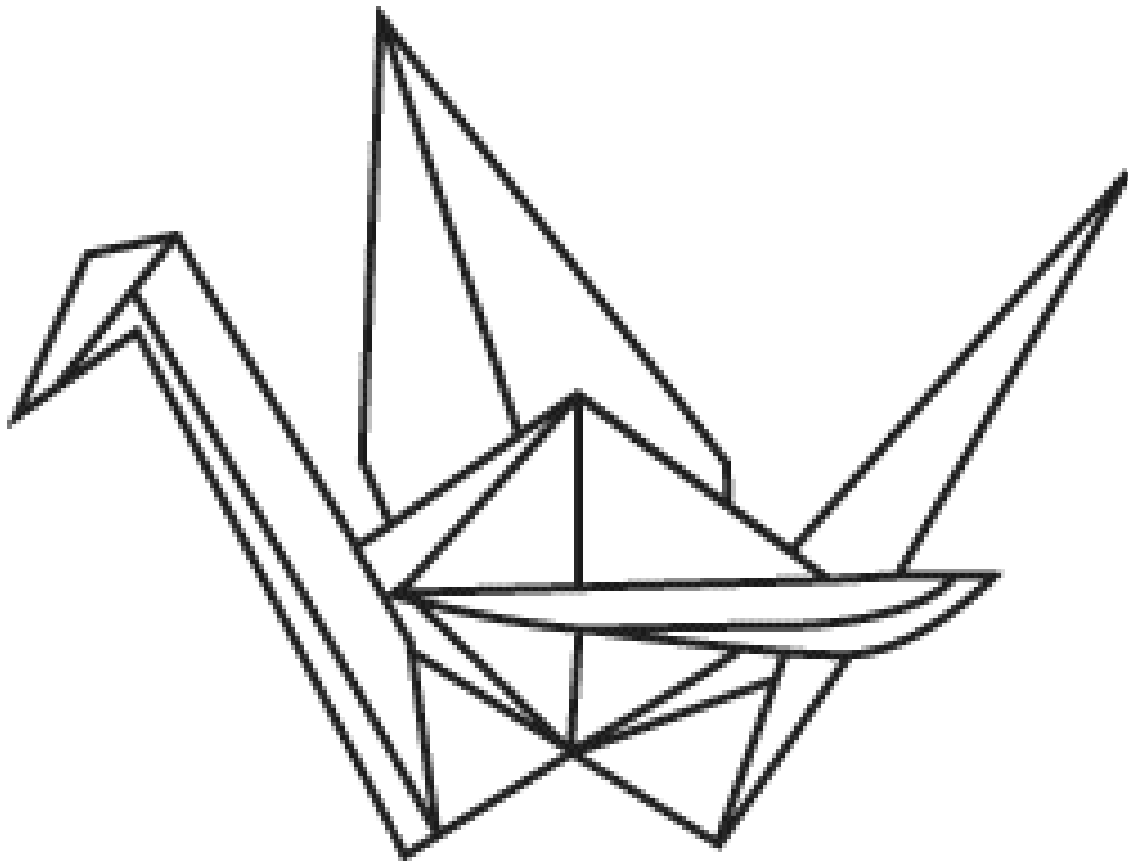
review what you and your classmates discovered in the Classroom Activity for this selection.

friendship	freedom	trust
commitment	love	hate
peace	liberty	charm
success	failure	beauty

2. How much stock do you put in Porter’ s claim that “people mostly choose to work and make money... It is what makes us happy” ? Or do you side with Bobby Kennedy’ s “proposal to measure not income but something else” (6)? Write an essay in which you present your position in this debate on what happiness is.



CHAPTER 19 Division and Classification



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

A writer practices [division](#) by separating a class of things or ideas into categories following a clear principle or basis. In the following paragraph, journalist Robert MacNeil establishes categories of speech according to their level of formality:

It fascinates me how differently we all speak in different circumstances. We have levels of formality, as in our clothing. There are very formal occasions, often requiring written English: the job application or the letter to the editor — the

dark suit, serious-tie language, with everything pressed and the lint brushed off. There is our less formal out-in-the-world language — a more comfortable suit, but still respectable. There is language for close friends in the evenings, on weekends — bluejeans-and-sweat-shirt language, when it's good to get the tie off. There is family language, even more relaxed, full of grammatical short cuts, family slang, echoes of old jokes that have become intimate shorthand — the language of pajamas and uncombed hair. Finally, there is the language with no clothes on; the talk of couples — murmurs, sighs, grunts — language at its least self-conscious, open, vulnerable, and primitive.

— Robert MacNeil, *Wordstruck: A Memoir*

With classification, on the other hand, a writer groups individual objects or ideas into already established categories. Division and classification can operate separately but often accompany each other. Here, for example, is a passage about levers in which the writer first discusses generally how levers work. In the second paragraph, the writer uses division to establish three categories of levers and then uses classification to group individual levers into those categories:

Every lever has one fixed point called the “fulcrum” and is acted on by two forces — the “effort” (exertion of hand muscles) and the “weight” (object's resistance). Levers work according to a simple formula: the effort (how hard you push or pull) multiplied by its distance from the fulcrum (effort arm) equals the weight multiplied by its distance from the fulcrum

(weight arm). Thus two pounds of effort exerted at a distance of four feet from the fulcrum will raise eight pounds located one foot from the fulcrum.

There are three types of levers, conventionally called “first kind,” “second kind,” and “third kind.” Levers of the first kind have the fulcrum located between the effort and the weight. Examples are a pump handle, an oar, a crowbar, a weighing balance, a pair of scissors, and a pair of pliers. Levers of the second kind have the weight in the middle and magnify the effort. Examples are the handcar crank and doors. Levers of the third kind, such as a power shovel or a baseball batter’s forearm, have the effort in the middle and always magnify the distance.

The following paragraph introduces a classification of the kinds of decisions one has to make when purchasing a smartphone:

When you are shopping for a smartphone, you have a great number of options from which to choose. Among these are manufacturer, model, price, carrier, and phone features. In the area of features alone, one has to consider the different kinds of operating systems, battery, screen sizes and resolutions, storage capacities, and types of cameras that are available.

— Freddy Chessa, student

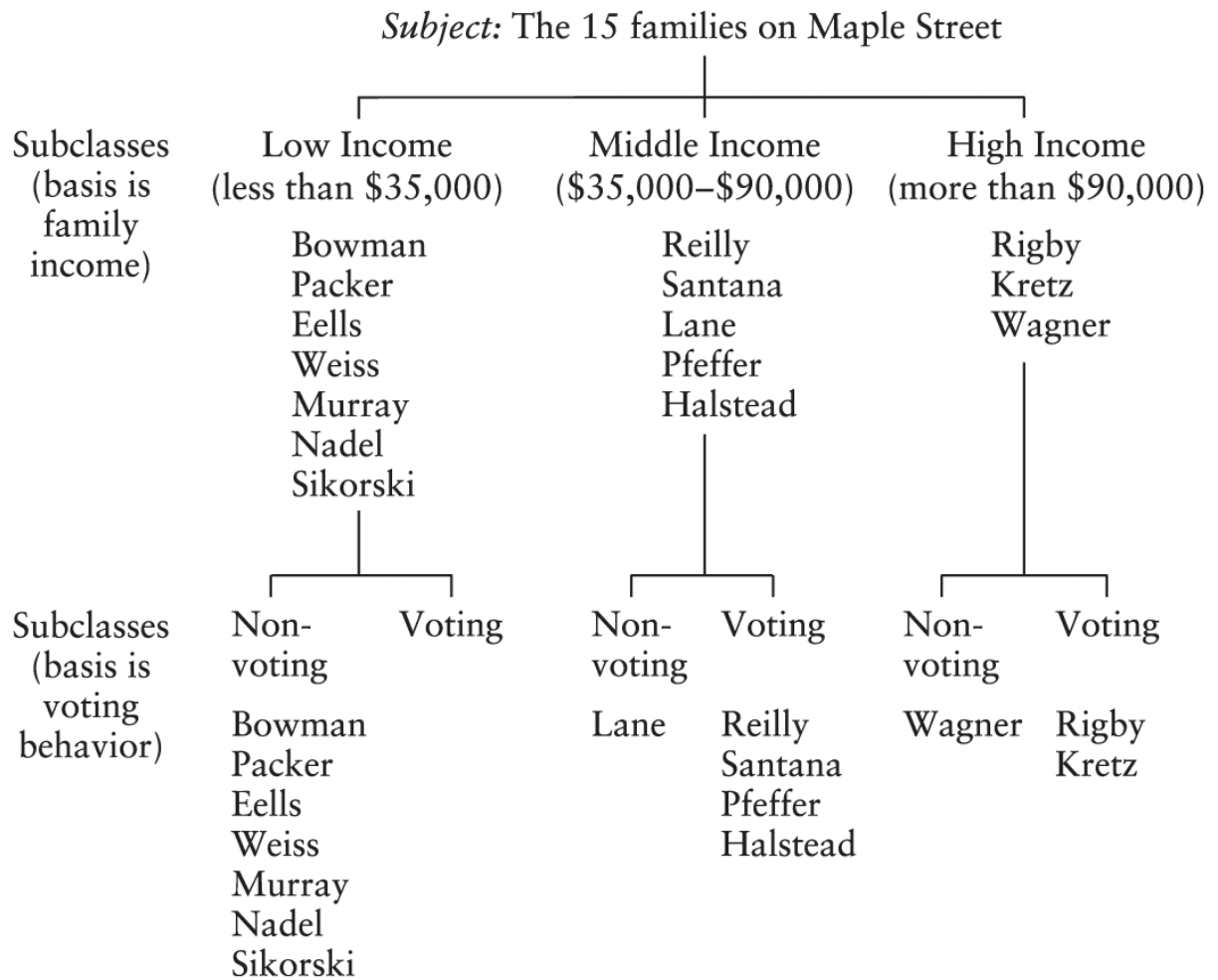
In writing, division and classification are affected directly by the writer’s practical purpose — what the writer wants to explain or prove. That purpose determines the class of

things or ideas being divided and classified. For instance, a writer might divide television programs according to their audiences (adults, families, or children) and then classify individual programs into each category to show that television networks value certain audiences more than others. A writer who is concerned about violence in television programming would divide programs into those with and without fights and murders and then classify various programs into those categories. Writers with other purposes would divide television programs differently (by the day and time of broadcast, for example, or by the number of women featured in prominent roles) and then classify individual programs accordingly.

Another example may help clarify how division and classification work hand in hand in writing. Suppose a sociologist wants to determine whether income level influences voting behavior in a particular neighborhood. The sociologist chooses as her subject the fifteen families living on Maple Street. Her goal then becomes to group these families in a way that is relevant to her purpose. She knows that she wants to divide the neighborhood in two ways — according to (1) income level (low, middle, and high) and (2) voting behavior (voters and nonvoters) — but her process of division won't be complete until she can classify the fifteen families into her five groupings.

In confidential interviews with each family, the sociologist learns what the family's income is and whether any member of the household voted in a state or federal election in the last four years. Based on this information, she classifies each family according to her established categories and at the same time divides the neighborhood into the subclasses that are crucial to her study. Her work leads her to construct the following diagram of her divisions and classifications.

Purpose: To group 15 families according to income and voting behavior and to study the relationships between the two.



Description

"The title of the chart at the top center reads, Subject: The fifteen families on maple street. The families are divided into two subclasses. The first subclass is based on family income and the second subclass is based on voting behavior. The first subclass has three divisions: Low Income (less than 35,000 dollars), Middle Income (35,000–90,000 dollars) and High Income (more than 90,000 dollars). The families mentioned below the low income division are: Bowman, Packer, Eells, Weiss, Murray, Nadel, and Sikorski. The families mentioned below the middle income division are: Reilly, Santana, Lane, Pfeffer, and Halstead. The families mentioned below the high income division are: Rigby, Kretz,

and Wagner. All the three divisions are sub-divided into Non-voting and Voting. All the families with low income are nonvoters. From the families of middle income, only the Lane family votes, while Reilly, Santana, Pfeffer, and Halstead are nonvoters. From the families of high income, the Wagner family is nonvoters, while Rigby and Kretz are voters."

Conclusion: On Maple Street, there seems to be a relationship between income level and voting behavior: the low-income families are nonvoters.

The diagram showing the relationship between voting practices and income allows the sociologist to visualize her division and classification system and its essential components — subject, basis or principle of division, subclasses or categories, and conclusion. Her ultimate conclusion depends on her ability to work back and forth among divisions, subclasses, and the actual families to be classified.

The following guidelines can help you use division and classification in your writing:

1. *Identify a clear purpose, and use a principle of division that is appropriate to that purpose.* If you want to examine the common characteristics of four-year athletic scholarship recipients at your college or university, you might consider the following principles of division: program of study, sport, place of origin, or gender. It would not be useful to divide students on the basis of

their favorite type of music because that seems irrelevant to your purpose.

2. *Divide your subject into unique categories.* An item can belong to only one category. For example, don't divide students as men, women, and athletes.
3. *Make your division and classification complete.* Your categories should account for all items in a subject class. In dividing students on the basis of geographic origin, for example, don't consider only the United States because such a division does not account for foreign students. For your classification to be complete, every student must be placed in one of the established categories.
4. *State the conclusion that your division and classification lead you to draw.* For example, after conducting your division and classification of athletic scholarship recipients, you might conclude that the majority of male athletes with athletic scholarships come from the western United States.

The Ways of Meeting Oppression

Martin Luther King Jr.



Bettmann/Getty Images

Martin Luther King Jr. (1929 - 1968) was the leading spokesman for the rights of African Americans during the 1950s and

1960s. He established the Southern Christian Leadership Conference, organized many civil rights demonstrations, and opposed the Vietnam War and the draft. Beginning in 1960, King was a pastor at the Ebenezer Baptist Church in Atlanta, where both his father and his grandfather had served. In 1964, he was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize for his resistance to racial oppression and discrimination. King was assassinated at the age of thirty-nine in Memphis, Tennessee, where he had traveled to provide leadership and support to striking sanitation workers. In 1983, President Ronald Reagan signed a bill creating a national holiday to honor King's life and legacy.

In the following essay, taken from his book *Strive Toward Freedom* (1958), King classifies the three ways that oppressed people throughout history have reacted to their oppressors. As you read, pay particular attention to how King orders his discussion of the three types of oppression to support his argument, which is expressed in his conclusion.

Reflecting on What You Know

Isaac Asimov once said, "Violence is the last refuge of the incompetent." What are your thoughts on the reasons for violent behavior on either a personal or a national level? Is violence ever justified? If so, under what circumstances?

Oppressed people deal with their oppression in three characteristic ways. One way is acquiescence: the oppressed resign themselves to their doom. They tacitly adjust themselves to oppression, and thereby become conditioned to it. In every movement toward freedom some of the oppressed prefer to remain oppressed. Almost 2800 years ago Moses¹ set out to lead the children of Israel from the slavery of Egypt to the freedom of the promised land. He soon discovered that slaves do not always welcome their deliverers. They become accustomed to being slaves. They would rather bear those ills they have, as Shakespeare pointed out, than flee to others that they know not of. They prefer the “fleshpots of Egypt” to the ordeals of emancipation.

There is such a thing as the freedom of exhaustion. Some people are so worn down by the yoke of oppression that they give up. A few years ago in the slum areas of Atlanta, a Negro guitarist used to sing almost daily: “Been down so long that down don’ t bother me.”² This is the type of negative freedom and resignation that often engulfs the life of the oppressed.

But this is not the way out. To accept passively an unjust system is to cooperate with that system; thereby the oppressed become as evil as the oppressor. Noncooperation with evil is as much a moral obligation as is cooperation with good. The oppressed must never allow the conscience of

the oppressor to slumber. Religion reminds every man that he is his brother's keeper. To accept injustice or segregation passively is to say to the oppressor that his actions are morally right. It is a way of allowing his conscience to fall asleep. At this moment the oppressed fails to be his brother's keeper. So acquiescence — while often the easier way — is not the moral way. It is the way of the coward. The Negro cannot win the respect of his oppressor by acquiescing; he merely increases the oppressor's arrogance and contempt. Acquiescence is interpreted as proof of the Negro's inferiority. The Negro cannot win the respect of the white people of the South or the peoples of the world if he is willing to sell the future of his children for his personal and immediate comfort and safety.

A second way that oppressed people sometimes deal with oppression is to resort to physical violence and corroding hatred. Violence often brings about momentary results. Nations have frequently won their independence in battle. But in spite of temporary victories, violence never brings permanent peace. It solves no social problem; it merely creates new and more complicated ones.

Violence as a way of achieving racial justice is both impractical and immoral. It is impractical because it is a descending spiral ending in destruction for all. The old law of an eye for an eye leaves everybody blind. It is immoral

because it seeks to humiliate the opponent rather than win his understanding; it seeks to annihilate rather than to convert. Violence is immoral because it thrives on hatred rather than love. It destroys community and makes brotherhood impossible. It leaves society in monologue rather than dialogue. Violence ends by defeating itself. It creates bitterness in the survivors and brutality in the destroyers. A voice echoes through time saying to every potential Peter, “Put up your sword.” ³ History is cluttered with the wreckage of nations that failed to follow this command.

If the American Negro and other victims of oppression succumb to the temptation of using violence in the struggle for freedom, future generations will be the recipients of a desolate night of bitterness, and our chief legacy to them will be an endless reign of meaningless chaos. Violence is not the way.

The third way open to oppressed people in their quest for freedom is the way of nonviolent resistance. Like the synthesis in Hegelian⁴ philosophy, the principle of nonviolent resistance seeks to reconcile the truths of two opposites — acquiescence and violence — while avoiding the extremes and immoralities of both. The nonviolent resister agrees with the person who acquiesces that one should not be physically aggressive toward his opponent; but he balances the equation by agreeing with the person of violence that

evil must be resisted. He avoids the nonresistance of the former and the violent resistance of the latter. With nonviolent resistance, no individual or group need submit to any wrong, nor need anyone resort to violence in order to right a wrong.

It seems to me that this is the method that must guide the actions of the Negro in the present crisis in race relations. Through nonviolent resistance the Negro will be able to rise to the noble height of opposing the unjust system while loving the perpetrators of the system. The Negro must work passionately and unrelentingly for full stature as a citizen, but he must not use inferior methods to gain it. He must never come to terms with falsehood, malice, hate, or destruction.

Nonviolent resistance makes it possible for the Negro to remain in the South and struggle for his rights. The Negro's problem will not be solved by running away. He cannot listen to the glib suggestion of those who would urge him to migrate en masse to other sections of the country. By grasping his great opportunity in the South he can make a lasting contribution to the moral strength of the nation and set a sublime example of courage for generations yet unborn.

By nonviolent resistance, the Negro can also enlist all men of good will in his struggle for equality. The problem is not

a purely racial one, with Negroes set against whites. In the end, it is not a struggle between people at all, but a tension between justice and injustice. Nonviolent resistance is not aimed against oppressors but against oppression. Under its banner consciences, not racial groups, are enlisted.

¹ *Moses*: a Hebrew prophet, teacher, and leader in the fourteenth to thirteenth centuries B.C.E.

² *“Been down ... bother me”*: lyric possibly adapted from “Stormy Blues” by American jazz singer Billie Holiday (1915–1959).

³ *“Put up your sword”*: Jesus’ s words to the apostle Peter, who had drawn a sword to defend him from arrest; Jesus surrendered himself for trial and crucifixion (John 18:11).

⁴ *Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel (1770–1831)*: German philosopher.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is King’ s thesis? (Glossary: [Thesis](#))
2. How does classifying the three types of resistance to oppression help him develop his thesis?
3. Why do you suppose King discusses acquiescence, violence, and nonviolent resistance in that order? What organizational principle does he use to rank them?
4. How does King’ s organizational pattern help him build his argument and support his thesis? Would his

argument work as well if he had changed the order of his discussion? Why or why not?

5. King states that he favors nonviolent resistance over the other two ways of meeting oppression. What disadvantages does he see in meeting oppression with acquiescence or with violence?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. King writes, “Oppressed people deal with their oppression in three characteristic ways.” He clearly rejects two of those ways, acquiescence and violence, in favor of nonviolent resistance. What are some forms of nonviolent resistance that you have read about or have experienced that have been effective? Do you think that nonviolent resistance is *always* effective? Does nonviolent resistance have any limitations that King does not acknowledge in his essay? Explain.
2. King states, “There is such a thing as the freedom of exhaustion” (2). Why, according to King, is this type of freedom “negative”?
3. What other notable people in history have espoused a belief in nonviolent resistance? Share with the class what you know about their beliefs and activities.

Classroom Activity Using Division and Classification

Discuss in class why you believe that division and classification are important ways of thinking about everyday life. Give examples of how you use the two complementary strategies when you use a computer search engine, shop online, select items in your local supermarket, or look for textbooks in your college bookstore.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Using King' s essay as a model, write an essay on various solutions to a current social or personal problem. Organize your ideas according to a rational scheme relying on the principles of division and classification. Be sure that you have a clear thesis statement and that the division and classification you employ help convince your reader of your ideas and beliefs.
2. King' s use of division and classification in “The Ways of Meeting Oppression” is simple, logical, and natural. He knows that the oppressed can' t give in to their oppressors, can' t answer violence with

violence, and therefore must take a third path of nonviolent resistance to rise above their enemies. Using King' s essay as a model, write an essay in which you discuss how to respond to prejudice, hatred, competition, greed, aggression, or some other social force that we all find difficult to overcome.

Cheating Is Good for You

Mia Consalvo



Courtesy Mia Consalvo

Born in 1969, Mia Consalvo has a PhD in Mass Communications from the University of Iowa. Her area of interest is game studies, with a particular focus on players and the culture of gameplay. Consalvo has held positions at Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Chubu University (Japan), Ohio University, the University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, and the University of Iowa. She is currently the Canada Research Chair in Game Studies and Design at Concordia University in Montreal, Canada. She has authored or coauthored numerous works, including *Women and Everyday Uses of the Internet: Agency and Identity* (2002) with Susanna Paasonen, *The Handbook of Internet Studies* (2012) with Charles Ess, *Players and Their Pets: Gaming Communities from Beta to Sunset* (2015) with Jason Begy, *Atari to Zelda: Japan's Videogames in Global Context* (2016), and *Real Games: What's Legitimate and What's Not in Contemporary Videogames* (2019).

This selection is adapted from *Cheating: Gaining an Advantage in Videogames* (2007) and was originally published in *Forbes* on December 14, 2006. In it, Consalvo argues that there are benefits to (some) cheating. As you read, notice how Consalvo uses division to explain the major reasons for cheating in videogaming and to argue that it has resulting benefits.

Reflecting on What You Know

What is your attitude toward cheating when playing games?
Under what circumstances, if any, would you cheat? Do you

think of cheating when playing video games differently than cheating in other types of games, such as sports or board games? Why?

Most of the time, we think of cheating as despicable. Cheating is what lazy people do. It's the easy way out. Calling someone a cheater is rarely a compliment, and being cheated is never a good thing.

At least, in everyday life it isn't — outside of the occasional “cheat day” on a diet. But what about in the world of video games? After spending the last five years talking with game players, game developers, security experts and others, I've learned a few counterintuitive things about cheating.

First, everybody cheats. Some may justify it, others proudly proclaim it, and others will deny their cheating vigorously, but it's a common activity. Players use walkthroughs, cheat codes, social engineering techniques (basically being crafty and tricking others), hacks and other unauthorized software. Cheats are popular, big business and not going away anytime soon. Individual gamers set boundaries for what they will or won't do, and there are several general reasons why people cheat. But either way, can the activity be good for you?

When I first started examining the practice of cheating, I took it as a given that most people viewed it as a negative activity. Cheating implies that you aren' t a good enough player to finish a game on your own, or that you want an unfair — and unearned — advantage over other players. Yet in researching why people cheat and how they cheat, I' ve found that, much of the time, cheating actually implies a player is actively engaged in a game and wants to do well, even when the game fails *them*.

There are four major reasons why players cheat in a game: they' re stuck, they want to play God, they are bored with the game, or they want to be a jerk. The overwhelming reason most players cheat is because they get stuck. Either the game is poorly designed, too hard, or the players are so inexperienced that they can' t advance. A boss monster can' t be beaten, or a puzzle solved, or the right direction found. In such situations, players face a choice: they either cheat or stop playing altogether.

The next most common reason is that we all like to play God sometimes. We want all the weapons or all the goodies, and we want them now. We don' t want to wade through 20 levels to get to the one we like best — we want to beam directly there. We don' t want to drive around in a boring car — we want to “unlock” the invincible bicycle instead. In those

situations, cheating is about extending the play experience for ourselves. No one is harmed in the process.

Third, we can get bored with games. But as with an annoying novel, we still want the option of flipping to the last page to see how things turn out. In a game, we may find the fighting tedious, or the storyline dreary, or the never-ending grind to reach higher levels in World of Warcraft just too much trouble, and so we use some sort of cheat to jump ahead in the game's timeline, maybe all the way to the conclusion.

And finally, some people just can't resist cheating others. We want to overwhelm others, not just defeat them. We'll use "aimbots" (programs that automatically aim and shoot for us) or "wall hacks" (programs that allow you to see and even walk through walls) to gain every advantage in an online shooting game. Or we'll intercept the data stream in an online poker game to find out what cards our opponent is actually holding.

But even if everyone does it, why is cheating actually good for us?

First, players get stuck all the time. It doesn't matter if you are a master at real-time strategy games — if it's your first action-adventure game, you might be really bad at it.

Likewise, maybe the game developer rushed the game out the door with less than perfect directions or a less than perfect design. In those situations, cheating lets the player keep playing the game they spent good money on. It can mean the difference between completing a game and abandoning it mid-stream.

Imagine reading a book and getting to a difficult passage in chapter three. And then imagine the book won't let you skip to chapter four until you have signified you understand that passage. This is how many video games are designed.

Now imagine instead that players can consult walkthroughs (in essence, detailed, step-by-step directions to winning a game) on an "as-needed" basis to help them through the troublesome spots, or receive "hints" that help them figure things out on their own. Players who have completed the game create these walkthroughs for later players. In short, players are teaching one another and learning from each other, and getting only the information they need to keep going. Everyone is taking an active part in playing and learning how to play. This is a good thing for everyone involved.

Next, players often use cheat codes, which unlock special items or powers, to get the most value from a game. This suggests that players enjoy the game so much that when they

reach the end, they want to play it more. That means more opportunities for interaction with the game. Cheat codes can be hidden in a game for players to find and then share with others. Or, codes can be awarded to excellent players, or given to newer, more tentative players to encourage them to keep playing. Cheat codes can keep the experience enjoyable in different ways for different players.

What about when players get bored? Game designers don't usually want them skipping to the end of a game. Yet does the game need to have a linear progression? Could players choose where in the game to go next, or the elements they want to tackle? Are there different ways to succeed — through battle, through puzzle solving, through dialog? Different players have different skill sets, so giving everyone an equal shot at doing well is preferable. As is allowing players to more quickly get to the sections they find rewarding.

But what about the jerks? Everyone wants a perfect opponent like Lisa Simpson, but more often we end up playing with her brother Bart. In EVE Online, for instance, one player, Nightfreeze, allegedly cheated his in-game friends and rivals out of hundreds of millions of in-game "credits" using nothing but fake accounts, a public library's telephone, some help from friends, and his wits.

In such situations, the value is found not in the cheating itself, but in our reaction to it.

There are a couple of things that can be done to either stop this sort of cheating or make it a positive aspect of play. Users themselves often encourage a culture of non-cheating, making cheating not cool. Most commonly, player communities can take an active role in deciding what happens when people are discovered cheating. Psychologists have found that when playing games, if players aren't allowed to punish others they suspect of cheating, the game community falls apart. People will even pay money out of their own pocket to punish cheaters. So figuring out ways to keep the larger community involved in dealing with cheaters can keep the group engaged in ways that "regular" game play might never allow for.

As counter-intuitive as it may seem, cheating can sometimes be good for you. It can keep you active and involved in a game, reward game play and allow expert players to teach others. It can indicate to developers when games are too hard or flawed, and it can even help a community form. We will never get rid of cheating, but at least in games, we can make it a positive thing, even a way to teach and learn.

Mia Consalvo, "Cheating Is Good For You," Forbes.com, December 14, 2006. Copyright © 2006 by Forbes Inc. All rights reserved. Used under license.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What was your reaction to the comment that “everybody cheats” (3)?
2. What is the principle of division that Consalvo presents in paragraph 5? What are the divisions?
3. Can you think of a reason people cheat at video games besides what Consalvo presents?
4. What is the analogy that Consalvo uses in paragraph 7 and again in paragraph 11? (Glossary: [Analogy](#)) Is the analogy helpful in explaining particular aspects of video game cheating? Why or why not?
5. How does Consalvo use division in describing the benefits of cheating?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. In paragraph 2, Consalvo says that cheating in everyday life isn’ t a good thing. Why then could it be considered acceptable in a gaming environment?
2. Consalvo states that “cheating actually implies a player is actively engaged in a game and wants to do well, even when the game fails *them*” (paragraph 4). Why is cheating a way to “do well” in a game and not a failure based on the player’ s lack of integrity and ability?

3. In paragraph 15, Consalvo asks, “But what about the jerks?” Did you find her explanation of the benefits from jerks cheating to be convincing? Why or why not?

Classroom Activity Using Division and Classification

Examine the following list of entertainers, movies, and occupations. Determine at least three principles that could be used to divide the items listed in each group. Finally, classify the items in each group according to one of the principles you have established.

Entertainers	
Brad Pitt	Mariah Carey
Cardi B	Kevin Hart
Jay Z	Jennifer Lawrence
Movies	
<i>Star Wars</i>	<i>The Hangover</i>
<i>A Christmas Story</i>	<i>Psycho</i>
<i>Jurassic Park</i>	<i>Titanic</i>
Occupations	
physician' s assistant	elementary school teacher

attorney

plumber

firefighter

accountant

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Consalvo argues that there are benefits to cheating when playing video games. Consider, however, whether cheating in other areas of life can be beneficial. Write an argument in which you defend your conclusion. Use division and classification to organize the essay, such as by types of cheating, situations in which cheating occurs, which persons are being victimized, or other principles.
2. The strategy of division and classification is most effective when used to reveal something surprising or to help readers recognize nuance. For example, some people might have thought “cheating is cheating,” but division helps show that it is a more complex concept. Think of another concept or controversial term that is mistakenly regarded as simple. Write an essay using division and classification to show the complexity of the concept, and use strong examples to illustrate the categories you develop.

Mother Tongue

Amy Tan



Mark Mainz/Getty Images Entertainment/Getty Images

Amy Tan was born in 1952 in Oakland, California, to parents who had emigrated from China. Though her mother and teachers encouraged her to pursue a career in math or science, she found an irrepressible interest in literature, and in her first year at college, she changed her major from pre-med to English. She earned bachelor's and master's degrees from San Jose State University, but she did not begin writing fiction until she was thirty-three. Her first book, *The Joy Luck Club* (1987), was published two years later to great acclaim and was later adapted into a successful film. Her other novels include *The Kitchen God's Wife* (1991), *The Hundred Secret Senses* (1995), *The Bonesetter's Daughter* (2000), and, most recently, *The Valley of Amazement* (2013). She has also written several nonfiction books and two children's books.

This essay, "Mother Tongue," first appeared in *The Threepenny Review* in 1990. It is born out of Tan's realization that she speaks not one but many "Englishes." As you read, pay careful attention to how she divides these forms of the language into categories, and consider how multiple Englishes make her writing richer.

Reflecting on What You Know

How different is the language you speak at home from the one you speak at school? Do you talk differently with your mother

than you do with your friends or your boss? How many different languages do you speak on any given day?

I am not a scholar of English or literature. I cannot give you much more than personal opinions on the English language and its variations in this country or others.

I am a writer. And by that definition, I am someone who has always loved language. I am fascinated by language in daily life. I spend a great deal of my time thinking about the power of language — the way it can evoke an emotion, a visual image, a complex idea, or a simple truth. Language is the tool of my trade. And I use them all — all the Englishes I grew up with.

Recently, I was made keenly aware of the different Englishes I do use. I was giving a talk to a large group of people, the same talk I had already given to half a dozen other groups. The nature of the talk was about my writing, my life, and my book, *The Joy Luck Club*. The talk was going along well enough, until I remembered one major difference that made the whole talk sound wrong. My mother was in the room. And it was perhaps the first time she had heard me give a lengthy speech, using the kind of English I have never used with her. I was saying things like, “The intersection of memory upon imagination” and “There is an aspect of my fiction that relates to thus-and-thus” — a speech filled with carefully

wrought grammatical phrases, burdened, it suddenly seemed to me, with nominalized¹ forms, past perfect tenses, conditional phrases, all the forms of standard English that I had learned in school and through books, the forms of English I did not use at home with my mother.

Just last week, I was walking down the street with my mother, and I again found myself conscious of the English I was using, the English I do use with her. We were talking about the price of new and used furniture and I heard myself saying this: "Not waste money that way." My husband was with us as well, and he didn't notice any switch in my English. And then I realized why. It's because over the twenty years we've been together I've often used that same kind of English with him, and sometimes he even uses it with me. It has become our language of intimacy, a different sort of English that relates to family talk, the language I grew up with.

So you'll have some idea of what this family talk I heard sounds like, I'll quote what my mother said during a recent conversation which I videotaped and then transcribed. During this conversation, my mother was talking about a political gangster in Shanghai who had the same last name as her family's, Du, and how the gangster in his early years wanted to be adopted by her family, which was rich by comparison. Later, the gangster became more powerful, far richer than my

mother' s family, and one day showed up at my mother' s wedding to pay his respects. Here' s what she said in part:

“Du Yusong having business like fruit stand. Like off the street kind. He is Du like Du Zong — but not Tsung-ming Island people. The local people call putong, the river east side, he belong to that side local people. That man want to ask Du Zong father take him in like become own family. Du Zong father wasn' t look down on him, but didn' t take seriously, until that man big like become a mafia. Now important person, very hard to inviting him. Chinese way, came only to show respect, don' t stay for dinner. Respect for making big celebration, he shows up. Mean gives lots of respect. Chinese custom. Chinese social life that way. If too important won' t have to stay too long. He come to my wedding. I didn' t see, I heard it. I gone to boy' s side, they have YMCA dinner. Chinese age I was nineteen.”

You should know that my mother' s expressive command of English belies how much she actually understands. She reads the *Forbes* report, listens to *Wall Street Week*, converses daily with her stockbroker, reads all of Shirley MacLaine' s books with ease — all kinds of things I can' t begin to understand. Yet some of my friends tell me they understand 50 percent of what my mother says. Some say they understand 80 to 90 percent. Some say they understand none of it, as if she were speaking pure Chinese. But to me, my mother' s English is perfectly clear, perfectly natural. It' s my mother

tongue. Her language, as I hear it, is vivid, direct, full of observation and imagery. That was the language that helped shape the way I saw things, expressed things, made sense of the world.

Lately, I' ve been giving more thought to the kind of English my mother speaks. Like others, I have described it to people as "broken" or "fractured" English. But I wince when I say that. It has always bothered me that I can think of no way to describe it other than "broken," as if it were damaged and needed to be fixed, as if it lacked a certain wholeness and soundness. I' ve heard other terms used, "limited English," for example. But they seem just as bad, as if everything is limited, including people' s perceptions of the limited English speaker.

I know this for a fact, because when I was growing up, my mother' s "limited" English limited my perception of her. I was ashamed of her English. I believed that her English reflected the quality of what she had to say. That is, because she expressed them imperfectly her thoughts were imperfect. And I had plenty of empirical evidence to support me: the fact that people in department stores, at banks, and at restaurants did not take her seriously, did not give her good service, pretended not to understand her, or even acted as if they did not hear her.

My mother has long realized the limitations of her English as well. When I was fifteen, she used to have me call people on the phone to pretend I was she. In this guise, I was forced to ask for information or even to complain and yell at people who had been rude to her. One time it was a call to her stockbroker in New York. She had cashed out her small portfolio and it just so happened we were going to go to New York the next week, our very first trip outside California. I had to get on the phone and say in an adolescent voice that was not very convincing, "This is Mrs. Tan."

And my mother was standing in the back whispering loudly, "Why he don' t send me check, already two weeks late. So mad he lie to me, losing me money."

And then I said in perfect English, "Yes, I' m getting rather concerned. You had agreed to send the check two weeks ago, but it hasn' t arrived."

Then she began to talk more loudly. "What he want, I come to New York tell him front of his boss, you cheating me?" And I was trying to calm her down, make her be quiet, while telling the stockbroker, "I can' t tolerate any more excuses. If I don' t receive the check immediately, I am going to have to speak to your manager when I' m in New York next week." And sure enough, the following week there we were in front of this astonished stockbroker, and I was sitting there red-

faced and quiet, and my mother, the real Mrs. Tan, was shouting at his boss in her impeccable broken English.

We used a similar routine just five days ago, for a situation that was far less humorous. My mother had gone to the hospital for an appointment, to find out about a benign brain tumor a CAT scan had revealed a month ago. She said she had spoken very good English, her best English, no mistakes. Still, she said, the hospital did not apologize when they said they had lost the CAT scan and she had come for nothing. She said they did not seem to have any sympathy when she told them she was anxious to know the exact diagnosis, since her husband and son had both died of brain tumors. She said they would not give her any more information until the next time and she would have to make another appointment for that. So she said she would not leave until the doctor called her daughter. She wouldn't budge. And when the doctor finally called her daughter, me, who spoke in perfect English — lo and behold — we had assurances the CAT scan would be found, promises that a conference call on Monday would be held, and apologies for any suffering my mother had gone through for a most regrettable mistake.

I think my mother's English almost had an effect on limiting my possibilities in life as well. Sociologists and linguists probably will tell you that a person's developing language skills are more influenced by peers. But I do think that the

language spoken in the family, especially in immigrant families which are more insular, plays a large role in shaping the language of the child. And I believe that it affected my results on achievement tests, I.Q. tests, and the SAT. While my English skills were never judged as poor, compared to math, English could not be considered my strong suit. In grade school I did moderately well, getting perhaps B's, sometimes B-plus, in English and scoring perhaps in the sixtieth or seventieth percentile on achievement tests. But those scores were not good enough to override the opinion that my true abilities lay in math and science, because in those areas I achieved A's and scored in the ninetieth percentile or higher.

This was understandable. Math is precise; there is only one correct answer. Whereas, for me at least, the answers on English tests were always a judgment call, a matter of opinion and personal experience. Those tests were constructed around items like fill-in-the-blank sentence completion, such as, "Even though Tom was _____, Mary thought he was _____." And the correct answer always seemed to be the most bland combinations of thoughts, for example, "Even though Tom was shy, Mary thought he was charming," with the grammatical structure "even though" limiting the correct answer to some sort of semantic opposites, so you wouldn't get answers like, "Even though Tom was foolish, Mary thought he was ridiculous." Well, according to my mother, there were

very few limitations as to what Tom could have been and what Mary might have thought of him. So I never did well on tests like that.

The same was true with word analogies, pairs of words in which you were supposed to find some sort of logical, semantic relationship — for example, “*Sunset* is to *nightfall* as _____ is to _____.” And here you would be presented with a list of four possible pairs, one of which showed the same kind of relationship: *red* is to *stoplight*, *bus* is to *arrival*, *chills* is to *fever*, *yawn* is to *boring*: Well, I could never think that way. I knew what the tests were asking, but I could not block out of my mind the images already created by the first pair, “*sunset* is to *nightfall*” — and I would see a burst of colors against a darkening sky, the moon rising, the lowering of a curtain of stars. And all the other pairs of words — *red*, *bus*, *stoplight*, *boring* — just threw up a mass of confusing images, making it impossible for me to sort out something as logical as saying: “A sunset precedes nightfall” is the same as “a chill precedes a fever.” The only way I would have gotten that answer right would have been to imagine an associative situation, for example, my being disobedient and staying out past sunset, catching a chill at night, which turns into feverish pneumonia as punishment, which indeed did happen to me.

I have been thinking about all this lately, about my mother's English, about achievement tests. Because lately I've been asked, as a writer, why there are not more Asian Americans represented in American literature. Why are there few Asian Americans enrolled in creative writing programs? Why do so many Chinese students go into engineering? Well, these are broad sociological questions I can't begin to answer. But I have noticed in surveys — in fact, just last week — that Asian students, as a whole, always do significantly better on math achievement tests than in English. And this makes me think that there are other Asian American students whose English spoken in the home might also be described as “broken” or “limited.” And perhaps they also have teachers who are steering them away from writing and into math and science, which is what happened to me.

Fortunately, I happen to be rebellious in nature and enjoy the challenge of disproving assumptions made about me. I became an English major my first year in college, after being enrolled as premed. I started writing nonfiction as a freelancer the week after I was told by my former boss that writing was my worst skill and I should hone my talents toward account management.

But it wasn't until 1985 that I finally began to write fiction. And at first I wrote using what I thought to be wittily crafted sentences, sentences that would finally prove

I had mastery over the English language. Here' s an example from the first draft of a story that later made its way into *The Joy Luck Club*, but without this line: "That was my mental quandary in its nascent state." A terrible line, which I can barely pronounce.

Fortunately, for reasons I won' t get into today, I later decided I should envision a reader for the stories I would write. And the reader I decided upon was my mother, because these were stories about mothers. So with this reader in mind — and in fact she did read my early drafts — I began to write stories using all the Englishes I grew up with: the English I spoke to my mother, which for lack of a better term might be described as "simple" ; the English she used with me, which for lack of a better term might be described as "broken" ; my translation of her Chinese, which could certainly be described as "watered down" ; and what I imagined to be her translation of her Chinese if she could speak in perfect English, her internal language, and for that I sought to preserve the essence, but neither an English nor a Chinese structure. I wanted to capture what language ability tests can never reveal: her intent, her passion, her imagery, the rhythms of her speech and the nature of her thoughts.

Apart from what any critic had to say about my writing, I knew I had succeeded where it counted when my mother finished

reading my book and gave me her verdict: “So easy to read.”

1*nominalized*: describing when a word is used as a noun. For example, the adjective Asian is nominalized to identify a group of people, Asians.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How does Tan’ s profession affect her discussion of language in this essay? How does she describe a writer’ s special relationship to language?
2. Where and how does Tan use the English she learned in school? Besides this “standard English” (paragraph 3), what other categories does her language fit into?
3. Tan describes her mother’ s English as “vivid, direct, full of observation and imagery” (6). Reread the transcript of Tan’ s mother’ s side of the conversation in paragraph 5, and note places where you see these qualities in her speech.
4. As she tries to classify her mother’ s English, Tan finds that all of the terms she can think of unsatisfying are unsatisfying. What is wrong with “broken” and “limited” as descriptors?
5. What is “terrible” about the line Tan quotes from an early draft of a story that became part of *The Joy Luck Club* (19)? How does she find a solution to this problem with her writing?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. How does Tan' s essay play on the phrase “mother tongue” ? What does this term mean in common usage, and how does Tan add to or alter this definition?
2. There is an apparent contradiction in the scene with the stockbroker when Tan describes her mother' s “impeccable broken English” (12). What does she mean by this? How would you explain the contradiction?
3. In paragraphs 15 and 16, Tan discusses her difficulties with questions on English tests that call for “fill-in-the-blank sentence completion” and facility with “word analogies.” Why do you suppose such questions vexed her? Explain.

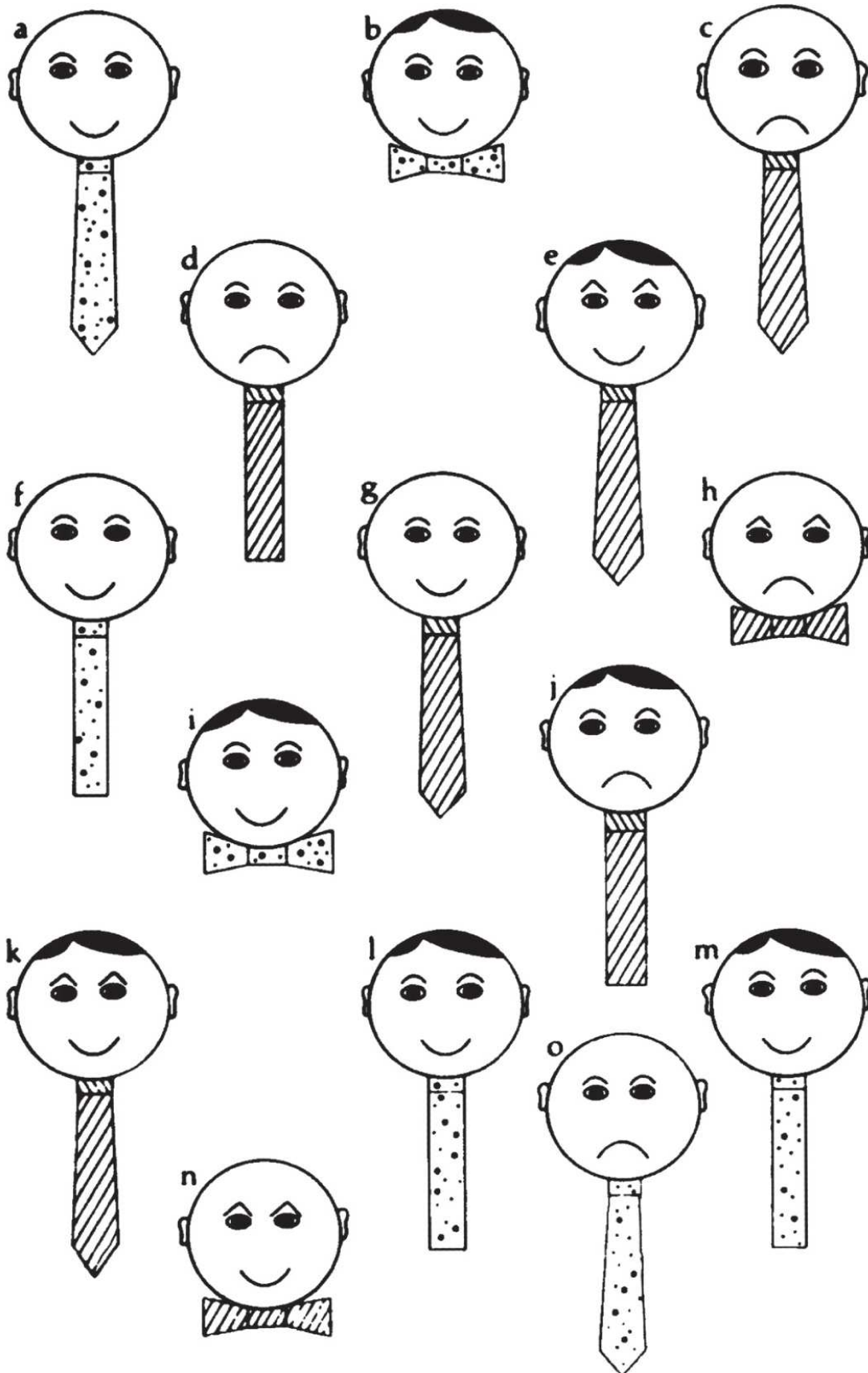
Classroom Activity Using Division and Classification

The drawing on [page 462](#) is a basic exercise in classification. Use annotations, a list, a chart, or another method to determine the features all the figures have in common, and establish the general class to which they belong. Next, establish subclasses by determining the distinctive features that distinguish one subclass

from another. Finally, place each figure in an appropriate subclass within your classification system. You may wish to compare your system with those developed by other members of the class, and discuss any differences that exist.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Think back to your response to the Reflecting on What You Know prompt, and create a set of classifications for the kinds of language you speak. Then write versions of the same brief story (you might choose a family legend like the one Tan's mother recounts) in each of these languages. How is the telling of the story different when you write with different audiences in mind? (Glossary: [Audience](#))
2. Music can be classified into many different types (jazz, country, pop, rock, soul, rap, classical, big band, western, blues, gospel). Each of these large classifications has a lot of variety within it. Write an essay in which you identify your favorite type of music as well as at least three subclassifications of that music. Explain the characteristics of each category, and use two or three artists and their songs as examples.

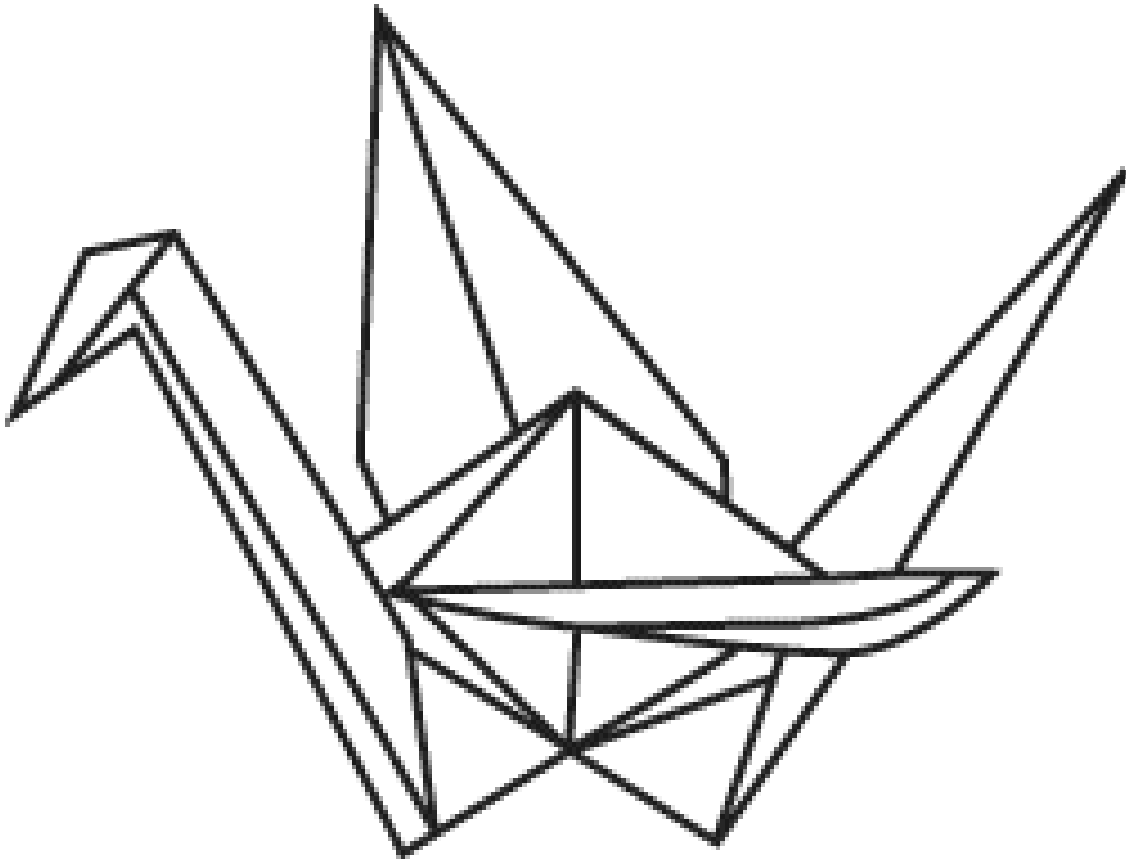


Description

"Face A. A smiling face, bald headed, rounded eyebrows, spotted necktie with a pointed end. Face B. A smiling face, hair, rounded eyebrows, spotted bowtie. Face C. A frowning face, bald headed, rounded eyebrows, striped necktie with a pointed end. Face D. A frowning face, bald headed, rounded eyebrows, striped necktie with a flat end. Face E. A smiling face, hair, angled eyebrows, smile, striped necktie with a pointed end. Face F. A smiling face, bald headed, rounded eyebrows, spotted necktie with a flat end. Face G. A smiling face, bald headed, rounded eyebrows, spotted necktie with a pointed end. Face H. A frowning face, bald headed, angled eyebrows, striped bowtie. Face I. A smiling face, hair, rounded eyebrows, spotted bowtie. Face J. A frowning face, hair, angled eyebrows, striped necktie with a flat end. Face K. A smiling face, hair, angled eyebrow, striped necktie with a pointed end. Face L. A smiling face, hair, rounded eyebrows, smile, spotted necktie with a flat end. Face M. A smiling face, hair, rounded eyebrows, spotted necktie with a flat end. Face N. A smiling face, hair, angled eyebrows, striped bowtie. Face O. A frowning face, bald headed, rounded eyebrows, spotted necktie with pointed end."



CHAPTER 20 Comparison and Contrast



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

A [comparison](#) points out the ways that two or more people, places, or things are alike. A [contrast](#) points out how they differ. The subjects of a comparison or contrast should be in the same class or general category; if they have nothing in common, there is no good reason for putting them side by side.

The function of any comparison or contrast is to clarify and explain. The writer's purpose may be simply to inform or to make readers aware of similarities or differences that are

interesting and significant in themselves. Or the writer may explain something unfamiliar by comparing it with something very familiar, perhaps explaining the game of squash by comparing it with tennis. Finally, the writer can point out the superiority of one thing by contrasting it with another — for example, showing that one product is the best by contrasting it with all its competitors.

ORGANIZING A COMPARISON OR CONTRAST

As a writer, you have two main options for organizing a comparison or contrast: the subject-by-subject pattern or the point-by-point pattern. For a short essay comparing and contrasting Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, and San Diego, California, as vacation destinations, you would probably follow the *subject-by-subject* pattern of organization. With this pattern, you first discuss the points you wish to make about one city and then discuss the corresponding points for the other city. An outline of the body of your essay might look like this:

Subject-by-Subject Pattern
I. Philadelphia A. Climate B. Public transportation C. Tourist attractions (museums, zoos, theme parks) D. Accommodations
II. San Diego A. Climate B. Public transportation C. Tourist attractions (museums, zoos, theme parks) D. Accommodations

The subject-by-subject pattern presents a unified discussion of each city by emphasizing the cities and not the four points of comparison. Because these points are relatively few, readers should easily remember what you said about Philadelphia's climate when you later discuss San Diego's climate and should be able to make the appropriate connections between them.

For a somewhat longer essay comparing and contrasting solar energy and wind energy, however, you should consider using the *point-by-point* pattern of organization. With this pattern, your essay is organized according to the various points of comparison. Discussion alternates between solar and wind energy for each point of comparison. An outline of the body of your essay might look like this:

Point-by-Point Pattern			
I.	Installation expenses	IV.	Convenience
	A. Solar		A. Solar
	B. Wind		B. Wind
II.	Efficiency	V.	Maintenance
	A. Solar		A. Solar
	B. Wind		B. Wind
III.	Operating costs	VI.	Safety

A. Solar	A. Solar
B. Wind	B. Wind

With the point-by-point pattern, the writer makes immediate comparisons between solar and wind energy so that readers can consider each similarity and difference separately.

Each organizational pattern has its advantages. In general, the subject-by-subject pattern is useful in short essays, in which few points are being considered; the point-by-point pattern is preferable in long essays, in which numerous points are being considered.

MAKING THE COMPARISON OR CONTRAST SIGNIFICANT

A good essay of comparison and contrast tells readers something significant that they do not already know — that is, it must do more than merely point out the obvious. As a rule, therefore, writers tend to draw contrasts between things that are usually perceived as being similar or comparisons between things usually perceived as being different. In fact, comparison and contrast often go together. For example, an essay about the twin cities of Minneapolis and St. Paul might begin by showing how much they are alike but end with a series of contrasts revealing how much they differ. A consumer magazine might report the contrasting claims made by six car manufacturers and then go on to demonstrate that all the cars actually do much the same thing in the same way.

The following student essay about hunting and photography explores the increasing popularity of photographic safaris. After first pointing out the obvious differences between hunting with a gun and hunting with a camera, the writer focuses on the similarities between the two activities, which make many hunters willing to trade their guns for cameras. Notice how she successfully uses the subject-by-subject

organizational plan in the body of her essay to explore three key similarities between hunters and photographers.

Guns and Cameras

The hunter has a deep interest in the apparatus he uses to kill his prey. He carries various types of guns, different kinds of ammunition, and special sights and telescopes to increase his chances of success. He knows the mechanics of his guns and understands how and why they work. This fascination with the hardware of his sport is practical — it helps him achieve his goal — but it frequently becomes an end, almost a hobby in itself.

Not until the very end of the long process of stalking an animal does a game hunter use his gun. First he enters into the animal's world. He studies his prey, its habitat, its daily habits, its watering holes and feeding areas, its migration patterns, its enemies and allies, its diet and food chain. Eventually the hunter himself becomes animal-like, instinctively sensing the habits and moves of his prey. Of course, this instinct gives the hunter a better chance of killing the animal; he knows where and when he will get the best shot. But it gives him more than that. Hunting is not just pulling the trigger and killing the prey. Much of it is a multifaceted and ritualistic identification with nature.

After the kill, the hunter can do a number of things with his trophy. He can sell the meat or eat it himself. He can hang the animal's head on the wall or lay its hide on the floor or even sell these objects. But any of these uses is a luxury, and its cost is high. An animal has been destroyed; a life has been eliminated.

Like the hunter, the photographer has a great interest in the tools he uses. He carries various types of cameras, lenses, and film to help him get the picture he wants. He understands the way cameras work, the uses of telephoto and micro lenses, and often the technical procedures of printing and developing. Of course, the time and interest a photographer invests in these mechanical aspects of his art allow him to capture and produce the image he wants. But as with the hunter, these mechanics can and often do become fascinating in themselves.

The wildlife photographer also needs to stalk his “prey” with knowledge and skill in order to get an accurate “shot.” Like the hunter, he has to understand the animal’s patterns, characteristics, and habitat; he must become animal-like in order to succeed. And like the hunter’s, his pursuit is much more prolonged and complicated than the shot itself. The stalking processes are almost identical and give many of the same satisfactions.

The successful photographer also has something tangible to show for his efforts. A still picture of an animal can be displayed in a home, a gallery, a shop; it can be printed in a publication, as a postcard, or as a poster. In fact, a single photograph can be used in all these ways at once; it can be reproduced countless times. And despite all these ways of using his “trophies,” the photographer continues to preserve his prey.

— Barbara Bowman, student

USING ANALOGY

Analogy is a special form of comparison. When a subject is unobservable, complex, or abstract — when it is so unfamiliar that readers may have trouble understanding it — analogy can be effective. By pointing out certain similarities between a difficult subject and a more familiar or concrete subject, writers can help their readers grasp the difficult subject. Unlike a true comparison, though, which analyzes items that belong to the same class (breeds of dogs or types of engines), analogy pairs things from different classes that have nothing in common except through the imagination of the writer. In addition, whereas comparison seeks to illuminate specific features of both subjects, the primary purpose of analogy is to clarify the one subject that is complex or unfamiliar. For example, to explore the similarities (and differences) between short stories and novels (two forms of fiction), you would probably choose comparison. Short stories and novels belong to the same class (fiction), and your purpose is to reveal something about both. If, however, your purpose is to explain the craft of fiction writing, you might note its similarities to the craft of carpentry. In this case you would be drawing an analogy because the two subjects clearly belong to different classes. Carpentry is the more concrete subject and the one more

people will have direct experience with. If you use your imagination, you will easily see many ways that the tangible work of the carpenter can be used to help readers understand the abstract work of the novelist.

Depending on its purpose, an analogy can be made in a sentence or in several paragraphs to clarify a particular aspect of the larger topic being discussed, or it can provide the organizational strategy for an entire essay. Consider the following analogy:

People are like stained-glass windows. They sparkle and shine when the sun is out, but when the darkness sets in, their true beauty is revealed only if there is a light from within.

— Elisabeth Kübler-Ross

An analogy can also help a writer address an abstract issue. In the following, the Harvard Nuclear Study Group raises the questions “What is the balance between American and Soviet nuclear arsenals? Who is ahead?”

When the question is asked in this manner, it might appear easy to give a definitive and objective answer. Unfortunately, this is not the case. No definitive answer is possible.

This can best be understood by way of analogy. Comparing the nuclear arsenals of the superpowers is like comparing the strengths of two football teams. Each team may be stronger in some departments: one in running, the other in passing; one in

special teams, the other in placekicking. Specialists try to predict the winner by comparing, for example, one side's aerial attack with the other side's pass defense. This is a better comparison than contrasting the quarterbacks or receivers. But the accuracy of such complicated predictions cannot be known until the game is over.

— The Harvard Nuclear Study Group, *Living with Nuclear Weapons*

On a Plate

Toby Morris



The Wireless

Toby Morris is a cartoonist and illustrator who lives and works in Auckland, New Zealand. His webcomic, *The Pencilsword*, presents a series of comics that, through image and text, address issues such as social inequality, the meaning of success, and what gets omitted in history. Morris has authored two collections of his cartoons, both based on his life experiences: *Allendaags: A Year in Amsterdam* (2011) and *Don't Puke on Your Dad: A Year in the Life of a New Father* (2013). He has also published two books for children, including *The Day the Costumes Stuck* (2017).

Morris' s comic "On a Plate" was published on the *Wireless* in May 2015. In this graphic essay, Morris describes the incremental development of privilege by contrasting two characters, Richard and Paula, who grow up with different socioeconomic statuses and family situations. This graphic essay is intended to be read from left to right, top to bottom, and the images and text interact to create meaning. As you read the first two comic panels (boxes that contain image and text), pay attention to the contrasting details and try to predict which character will wind up in a place of greater privilege.

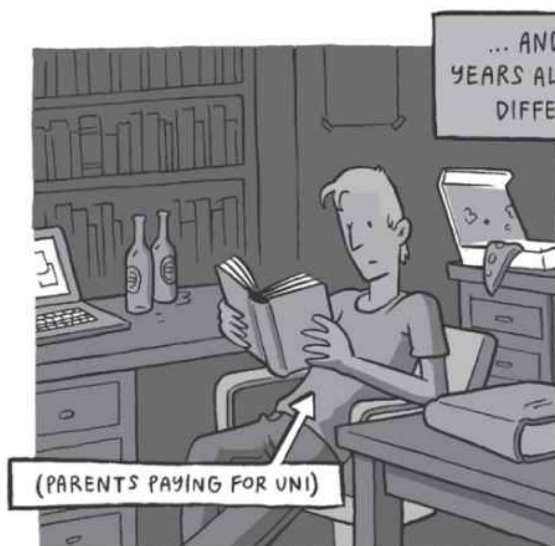
Reflecting on What You Know

How do you define *privilege*? List several different types of privilege and describe where you see certain privileges at work in our society. How and why do these privileges happen?



Description

"The first panel shows a toddler and the text reads, "This is Richard. His parents are doing ok." The second panel shows another toddler and the text reads, "And this is Paula. Her parents? not so much." The third panel shows Richard sitting in a room with blocks that have numbers and letters on them. The text reads, "Richard's house is warm and dry. His shelves are full of books and his fridge is full of food." The fourth panel shows Paula sitting in a room by a door where there is a silhouette of a person at the door and another person walks past her. The text reads, "Paula's house is full of people and not much else. It's damp and noisy and she keeps getting sick." The fifth panel shows teenage Richard doing his homework, while his parents say, "Good boy!" and "Clever!" He is smiling, has a lot of study materials on his table and the walls are full of educational posters. The text reads, "Richard's parents will do anything for their baby (ellipsis)." The last panel shows teenage Paula sitting alone on a couch watching T V and looking unhappy. The text reads, "(ellipsis) and so will Paula's. That's why they're working two jobs." "



Description

"The first panel shows Richard talking to his teacher. He wears the school uniform. The teacher's desk looks well-organized. Two boys talk to each other in the foreground. The text reads, "Richard goes to a great school. Well resourced, good kids. His teachers love their job." The second panel shows Paula's teacher tired and thinking "Oh man, I need a new job," while the students run around the classroom. The text reads, "At Paula's school, the class sizes are large, the school is underfunded, and looks it. Her teachers are tired, stretched thin from the stress." The third panel shows Richard showing his reports to his parents. His mother says, "B plus? Oh dear, we need to get you a tutor (ellipsis)." In the fourth panel, Paula's parents hold her report. Her mother says, "B? Hey, not bad!" The text above reads, "So maybe we can see why the expectations set for Richard might be slightly different to those set for Paula." The text above the fifth and the sixth panel reads, "(ellipsis) and over the years all these little differences (ellipsis)." The fifth panel shows Richard sitting in a room with an open pizza box, laptop, and open bottles, while reading a book. Text at the bottom left reads, "Parents paying for university." The sixth panel shows Paula reading a book while doing the dishes. The book is placed on a shelf mounted on the wall adjacent to the kitchen sink. Text at the bottom right reads, "juggling work and polytech, still getting in debt." "



Description

"The first panel shows Richard and his father in a conversation in their living room. His father is seated on a couch while reading a book. He says, "I have friends working there - I' ll have a word, and get you an internship," and Richard replies, "Thanks Dad." In the second panel, Paula sits beside her sick father lying in bed. The father says, "You should be finishing your studies, not looking after me," and she replies, "Dad you' re sick." The word, sick, is underlined. The text above both the panels reads, " (ellipsis) They start to add up. To build into something bigger." In the third panel, Richard is seated in front of a banker, who stands to offers a handshake, and says, "Yep, the loan is approved. Congratulations!" In the fourth panel, Paula is conversing with another banker, who tells her, "Look, we just can' t help you. Maybe try Eazee Finance?" The text above both the panels reads, "And because each little difference sneaks by unnoticed (ellipsis)." The fifth panel shows Richard at his workplace. He works on the laptop. A man in suit says, "Oh you' re Roger' s boy right? I' ve heard good things, keeping my eye on you (ellipsis)." The text above reads, "Then maybe Richard starts to believe that he deserves to be on top. That he did it all himself." The word, deserve, is underlined. The sixth panel shows Paula at her workplace. She wears an apron. The backdrop shows a pan, a stack of dishes, and kitchen countertop. A man says, "OK, you' ve got the job, but I' m watching you sweetie (ellipsis)." The text above reads, "And maybe Paula starts to settle. Learns to 'know her place.' " "



FURTHER READING: LOOK UP AUCKLAND CITY MISSION'S 'SPEAKING FOR OURSELVES' BOOKLET

@XTOTL 2015

Description

"The first panel shows a party hosted for Richard. A banner in the background reads, "Congratulations Richard." The panel shows Richard surrounded by several men and women in suits and evening gowns. They all hold their wine glasses. A man standing beside Richard says, "What is the secret to your success." In the second panel, Paula is a server in the same party serving snacks to the guests. She stands behind the guests and says, "Um (ellipsis) excuse me

(ellipsis).” Text reads, “But I hope not.” The third and fourth panels are linked. The panels show Paula offering snacks to Richard. Richard picks a piece and says, “Less whining, more hard work I say. I’ m sick of people asking for handouts. No one ever handed me anything on plate.” A text on Paula’ s side reads “I really hope not.” Text at the bottom reads, Further reading: look up Auckland city mission’ s ‘speaking for ourselves’ booklet.”

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Which pattern of organization does Morris’ s graphic essay follow? How do you know?
2. List the points of contrast that Morris presents.
3. What pattern of organization would Morris have been using if he had placed all of the images and text about Paula on one page, and all of the images and text about Richard on the next page? What would have been gained or lost by this organizational method?
4. What do you think Morris means when he states, “But I hope not” and “I really hope not” in two panels at the end of the graphic essay? Are these words intended for both characters or for Paula only? Explain.
5. “On a Plate” is Morris’ s most widely shared comic on social media. Why do you think this piece has reached such a large audience? (Glossary: [Audience](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What did you think about Morris' s choice to convey his ideas in the form of a comic strip? Do you think he made his point more effectively than he could have using words only? Explain. What, if anything, confused or impressed you about his work?
2. A good comparison or contrast should inform readers of something they do not know or haven' t fully considered. Did Morris' s comic make you think of something you didn' t know or hadn' t fully considered? If so, what?
3. Richard' s and Paula' s paths do not cross until the final two panels, when Richard says, "No one ever handed me anything on a plate." Being handed something on a plate is an idiom for being given something without having to work for it. (Glossary: [Idiom](#)) In the final panel, the reader sees Paula literally handing Richard oysters on a plate. Why does Morris conclude his comic in this way? Why do you think he keeps the multiple-panel format rather than concluding his graphic essay in one large panel?

Classroom Activity Using Comparison and Contrast

In groups of two or three, decide on two people, places, or things worthy of comparison and/or contrast, and be prepared to explain why. Choose an artist from your group who is anywhere between skilled cartoonist and partial master of the stick figure. The artist will draw eight panels (medium-sized squares) on a sheet of paper in the same layout used by Morris. Next, as a group, decide on the points of comparison that each pair of panels will make to best achieve your purpose. Group members should guide the artist in drawing images and text in the panels. Keep in mind that the role of the artist is not merely to illustrate the text, but to add new dimensions to it. If your group finishes before everyone else is done, switch your comic with another group who has finished. Write the other group's reason for comparison or contrast as you understand it at the bottom of their paper. Switch your papers back and discuss what made your reason for comparison or contrast come across or how you might have conveyed your reason more clearly.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Look back at Morris's graphic essay. Using your own words, and no pictures, write an essay contrasting Richard's experience with Paula's. Use Morris's captions (words in boxes) to help inspire your topic

sentences and the visual details as examples for your paragraphs.

2. Think about the kinds of privileges you enjoy or have never experienced. Plan and write a comparison or contrast essay that explores the relationship between your unique privilege profile and someone else's unique privilege profile. If you are stuck, think back to the Reflecting on What You Know question, which asked you to list different types of privilege. You may choose either pattern of organization, but make sure your reason for comparison and/or contrast is clear to your reader.

Two Ways to Belong in America

Bharati Mukherjee



AP Photo/Marty Lederhandler

Bharati Mukherjee (1940 - 2017) was born into an aristocratic family in Calcutta (now Kolkata), India, in 1940. She earned

bachelor' s and master' s degrees from the University of Calcutta, and in 1961, she pursued her long-held desire to become a writer by earning an MFA at the University of Iowa and eventually a PhD in English and comparative literature. She lived in Canada for fourteen years, until legislation against South Asians prompted her to move with her American husband back to the United States. Mukherjee taught at McGill University; Skidmore College; Queens College, City University of New York; and the University of California - Berkeley. She published several novels, including *The Tiger' s Daughter* (1971), *Jasmine* (1989), *The Holder of the World* (1993), and *Miss New India* (2011); two collections of short stories, *Darkness* (1985) and *The Middleman and Other Stories* (1988), for which she won the National Book Critics Circle Award; and works of nonfiction, including *Political Culture and Leadership in India* (1991) and *Regionalism in Indian Perspective* (1992).

The following essay was first published in the *New York Times* in 1996 in response to legislation that gave expedited citizenship for legal immigrants living in the United States. As you read Mukherjee' s essay, notice how she has organized her presentation of the different views that she and her sister hold toward citizenship.

Reflecting on What You Know

The word *immigrant* has many connotations. If you have moved to the United States from another country, what associations does the word have for you and your family? If you were born in the United States, what associations does the word have for you? Discuss the word *immigrant* with your classmates. How does one's perspective affect the associations that this word has for them? Explain.

This is a tale of two sisters from Calcutta, Mira and Bharati, who have lived in the United States for some thirty-five years, but who find themselves on different sides in the current debate over the status of immigrants. I am an American citizen and she is not. I am moved that thousands of long-term residents are finally taking the oath of citizenship. She is not.

Mira arrived in Detroit in 1960 to study child psychology and preschool education. I followed her a year later to study creative writing at the University of Iowa. When we left India, we were almost identical in appearance and attitude. We dressed alike, in saris; we expressed identical views on politics, social issues, love and marriage in the same Calcutta convent-school accent. We would endure our two years in America, secure our degrees, then return to India to marry the grooms of our father's choosing.

Instead, Mira married an Indian student in 1962 who was getting his business administration degree at Wayne State University. They soon acquired the labor certifications necessary for the green card of hassle-free residence and employment.

Mira still lives in Detroit, works in the Southfield, Michigan, school system, and has become nationally recognized for her contributions in the fields of preschool education and parent-teacher relationships. After thirty-six years as a legal immigrant in this country, she clings passionately to her Indian citizenship and hopes to go home to India when she retires.

In Iowa City in 1963, I married a fellow student, an American of Canadian parentage. Because of the accident of his North Dakota birth, I bypassed labor-certification requirements and the race-related “quota” system that favored the applicant’s country of origin over his or her merit. I was prepared for (and even welcomed) the emotional strain that came with marrying outside my ethnic community. In thirty-three years of marriage, we have lived in every part of North America. By choosing a husband who was not my father’s selection, I was opting for fluidity, self-invention, blue jeans and T-shirts, and renouncing three thousand years (at least) of caste-observant, “pure culture” marriage in the Mukherjee family. My books have often been read as

unapologetic (and in some quarters overenthusiastic) texts for cultural and psychological “mongrelization.” It’s a word I celebrate.

Mira and I have stayed sisterly close by phone. In our regular Sunday morning conversations, we are unguardedly affectionate. I am her only blood relative on this continent. We expect to see each other through the looming crises of aging and ill health without being asked. Long before Vice President Gore’s “Citizenship USA” drive, we’d had our polite arguments over the ethics of retaining an overseas citizenship while expecting the permanent protection and economic benefits that come with living and working in America.

Like well-raised sisters, we never said what was really on our minds, but we probably pitied one another. She, for the lack of structure in my life, the erasure of Indianness, the absence of an unvarying daily core. I, for the narrowness of her perspective, her uninvolvedness with the mythic depths or the superficial pop culture of this society. But, now, with the scapegoating of “aliens” (documented or illegal) on the increase, and the targeting of long-term legal immigrants like Mira for new scrutiny and new self-consciousness, she and I find ourselves unable to maintain the same polite discretion. We were always unacknowledged adversaries, and we are now, more than ever, sisters.

“I feel used,” Mira raged on the phone the other night. “I feel manipulated and discarded. This is such an unfair way to treat a person who was invited to stay and work here because of her talent. My employer went to the INS and petitioned for the labor certification. For over thirty years, I’ ve invested my creativity and professional skills into the improvement of *this* country’ s preschool system. I’ ve obeyed all the rules, I’ ve paid my taxes, I love my work, I love my students, I love the friends I’ ve made. How dare America now change its rules in midstream? If America wants to make new rules curtailing benefits of legal immigrants, they should apply only to immigrants who arrive after those rules are already in place.”

To my ears, it sounded like the description of a long-enduring, comfortable yet loveless marriage, without risk or recklessness. Have we the right to demand, and to expect, that we be loved? (That, to me, is the subtext of the arguments by immigration advocates.) My sister is an expatriate, professionally generous and creative, socially courteous and gracious, and that’ s as far as her Americanization can go. She is here to maintain an identity, not to transform it.

I asked her if she would follow the example of others who have decided to become citizens because of the anti-immigration bills in Congress. And here, she surprised me.

“If America wants to play the manipulative game, I’ ll play it too,” she snapped. “I’ ll become a U.S. citizen for now, then change back to Indian when I’ m ready to go home. I feel some kind of irrational attachment to India that I don’ t to America. Until all this hysteria against legal immigrants, I was totally happy. Having my green card meant I could visit any place in the world I wanted to and then come back to a job that’ s satisfying and that I do very well.”

In one family, from two sisters alike as peas in a pod, there could not be a wider divergence of immigrant experience. America spoke to me — I married it — I embraced the demotion from expatriate aristocrat to immigrant nobody, surrendering those thousands of years of “pure culture,” the saris¹, the delightfully accented English. She retained them all. Which of us is the freak?

Mira’ s voice, I realize, is the voice not just of the immigrant South Asian community but of an immigrant community of the millions who have stayed rooted in one job, one city, one house, one ancestral culture, one cuisine, for the entirety of their productive years. She speaks for greater numbers than I possibly can. Only the fluency of her English and the anger, rather than fear, born of confidence from her education, differentiate her from the seamstresses, the domestics, the technicians, the shop owners, the millions of hardworking but effectively silenced documented immigrants as

well as their less fortunate “illegal” brothers and sisters.

Nearly twenty years ago, when I was living in my husband’s ancestral homeland of Canada, I was always well-employed but never allowed to feel part of the local Quebec or larger Canadian society. Then, through a Green Paper that invited a national referendum on the unwanted side effects of “nontraditional” immigration, the Government officially turned against its immigrant communities, particularly those from South Asia.

I felt then the same sense of betrayal that Mira feels now. I will never forget the pain of that sudden turning, and the casual racist outbursts the Green Paper elicited. That sense of betrayal had its desired effect and drove me, and thousands like me, from the country.

Mira and I differ, however, in the ways in which we hope to interact with the country that we have chosen to live in. She is happier to live in America as an expatriate Indian than as an immigrant American. I need to feel like a part of the community I have adopted (as I tried to feel in Canada as well). I need to put roots down, to vote and make the difference that I can. The price that the immigrant willingly pays, and that the exile avoids, is the trauma of self-transformation.

¹*saris*: garments worn by South Asian women consisting of fabric, usually brightly colored, draped to form a long skirt and shoulder or head covering.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is Mukherjee' s thesis? (Glossary: [Thesis](#))
2. Mukherjee has used comparison and contrast as her organizing principle. What type of comparison and contrast has she used? Why is the pattern of organization that Mukherjee has used appropriate for her subject and her purpose?
3. What arguments does Mukherjee make for becoming a U.S. citizen? What arguments does her sister make for retaining her Indian citizenship?
4. Why does Mukherjee' s sister feel “used” by attempts to change U.S. laws regarding benefits for noncitizens?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What does Mukherjee mean when she says, “The price that the immigrant willingly pays, and that the exile avoids, is the trauma of self-transformation” (15)? What insight, if any, does this bring to any discussion of immigration to the United States?

2. Mukherjee chooses to let her sister, Mira, speak for herself in this essay. What do you think would have been lost had Mukherjee simply reported what Mira felt and believed? Explain by discussing several of Mira's statements.
3. At the end of paragraph 11, Mukherjee asks a question. How does she answer it? How would you answer it? Explain.

Classroom Activity Using Comparison and Contrast

In preparation for writing an essay of comparison and contrast on two world leaders (or popular singers, actors, or sports figures), write out answers to the following questions:

1. Who could I compare and contrast?
2. What is my purpose?
3. Which are more interesting — their similarities or their differences?
4. What specific points should I discuss?
5. What organizational pattern will best suit my purpose: subject-by-subject or point-by-point?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Mukherjee writes about the relationship she had with her sister in paragraph 7 by saying that “we never said what was really on our minds, but we probably pitied one another.” These types of differences are played out on a larger scale when immigrants who have transformed themselves into Americans are confronted by those who have chosen to retain their ethnic identity, and these tensions often lead to name-calling and aggressive prejudice. Similar situations also exist within the Latino, African American, and Southeast Asian American communities and perhaps among all immigrant groups. Write an essay comparing and contrasting the choices of lifestyle that members of an ethnic or cultural community you are familiar with make as they try to find a comfortable place in American society.
2. Mukherjee presents her sister’s reasons for not becoming a citizen and supports them with statements her sister has made. Imagine that you are Mira Mukherjee. Write a counterargument to the one presented by your sister that gives your reasons for remaining an Indian citizen. Consider that you have already broken with tradition by marrying a man not of your father’s choosing and also that the “trauma of self-transformation” is much deeper and more complicated than your sister has represented it in

the conclusion of her essay. Can you say that you are holding to tradition when you are not? Can you engage in a challenging self-transformation if it is not genuinely motivated?

Pygmalion

Tara Westover



Lorentz Gullachsen/Contour/Getty Images

Tara Westover grew up in a Mormon family in Idaho. Her parents did not believe in modern medicine or education, and

so Westover was homeschooled and did not enter a traditional classroom until she was seventeen. She studied on her own to pass the ACT test and entered Brigham Young University in Utah, earning her bachelor's degree in 2008. After graduating, she won a Gates Cambridge Scholarship, which enabled her to attend Trinity College at Cambridge University in England. There, she earned her Master of Philosophy in 2009 and her PhD in History in 2014. Westover's first book, *Educated: A Memoir* (2018), describes her journey in pursuit of education. The book has won numerous awards, including the *Los Angeles Times* Book Prize and the Book of the Year award from the American Booksellers Association. It was also chosen by former president Barack Obama and by Oprah Winfrey for their reading lists.

In the following selection from *Educated*, Westover describes her feelings of inadequacy when she arrives at Cambridge. The title of this selection, "Pygmalion," refers to a play by Irish playwright George Bernard Shaw about the transformation of a poor woman into a "lady." As you read, notice the contrast that Westover perceives between herself and her fellow classmates, as well as the contrast between her initial feelings and what her professors eventually tell her about her academic work.

Reflecting on What You Know

Think about a time when you felt inadequate or unqualified for a particular role. Psychologists call this “imposter syndrome.” Did you feel like you didn’ t belong or that you couldn’ t do what the role required? What did you do with those feelings?

The first time I saw King’ s College, Cambridge, I didn’ t think I was dreaming, but only because my imagination had never produced anything so grand. My eyes settled on a clock tower with stone carvings. I was led to the tower, then we passed through it and into the college. There was a lake of perfectly clipped grass and, across the lake, an ivory-tinted building I vaguely recognized as Greco-Roman. But it was the Gothic chapel, three hundred feet long and a hundred feet high, a stone mountain, that dominated the scene.

I was taken past the chapel and into another courtyard, then up a spiral staircase. A door was opened, and I was told that this was my room. I was left to make myself comfortable. The kindly man who’ d given me this instruction did not realize how impossible it was.

Breakfast the next morning was served in a great hall. It was like eating in a church, the ceiling was cavernous, and I felt under scrutiny, as if the hall knew I was there and I shouldn’ t be. I’ d chosen a long table full of other students from BYU. The women were talking about the clothes

they had brought. Marianne had gone shopping when she learned she' d been accepted to the program. "You need different *pieces* for Europe," she said.

Heather agreed. Her grandmother had paid for her plane ticket, so she' d spent that money updating her wardrobe.

"The way people dress here," she said, "it' s more refined. You can' t get away with jeans."

I thought about rushing to my room to change out of the sweatshirt and Keds I was wearing, but I had nothing to change into. I didn' t own anything like what Marianne and Heather wore — bright cardigans accented with delicate scarves. I hadn' t bought new clothes for Cambridge, because I' d had to take out a student loan just to pay the fees. Besides, I understood that even if I had Marianne' s and Heather' s clothes, I wouldn' t know how to wear them.

Dr. Kerry appeared and announced that we' d been invited to take a tour of the chapel. We would even be allowed on the roof. There was a general scramble as we returned our trays and followed Dr. Kerry from the hall. I stayed near the back of the group as we made our way across the courtyard.

When I stepped inside the chapel, my breath caught in my chest. The room — if such a space can be called a room — was voluminous, as if it could hold the whole of the ocean.

We were led through a small wooden door, then up a narrow spiraling staircase whose stone steps seemed numberless. Finally the staircase opened onto the roof, which was heavily slanted, an inverted V enclosed by stone parapets. The wind was gusting, rolling clouds across the sky; the view was spectacular, the city miniaturized, utterly dwarfed by the chapel. I forgot myself and climbed the slope, then walked along the ridge, letting the wind take me as I stared out at the expanse of crooked streets and stone courtyards.

“You’ re not afraid of falling,” a voice said. I turned. It was Dr. Kerry. He had followed me, but he seemed unsteady on his feet, nearly pitching with every rush of wind.

“We can go down,” I said. I ran down the ridge to the flat walkway near the buttress. Again Dr. Kerry followed but his steps were strange. Rather than walk facing forward, he rotated his body and moved sideways, like a crab. The wind continued its attack. I offered him an arm for the last few steps, so unsteady did he seem, and he took it.

“I meant it as an observation,” he said when we’ d made it down. “Here you stand, upright, hands in your pockets.” He gestured toward the other students. “See how they hunch? How they cling to the wall?” He was right. A few were venturing onto the ridge but they did so cautiously, taking the same ungainly side steps Dr. Kerry had, tipping and swaying in the

wind; everyone else was holding tightly to the stone parapet, knees bent, backs arched, as if unsure whether to walk or crawl.

I raised my hand and gripped the wall.

“You don’ t need to do that,” he said. “It’ s not a criticism.”

He paused, as if unsure he should say more. “Everyone has undergone a change,” he said. “The other students were relaxed until we came to this height. Now they are uncomfortable, on edge. You seem to have made the opposite journey. This is the first time I’ ve seen you at home in yourself. It’ s in the way you move: it’ s as if you’ ve been on this roof all your life.”

A gust of wind swept over the parapet and Dr. Kerry teetered, clutching the wall. I stepped up onto the ridge so he could flatten himself against the buttress. He stared at me, waiting for an explanation.

“I’ ve roofed my share of hay sheds,” I said finally.

“So your legs are stronger? Is that why you can stand in this wind?”

I had to think before I could answer. “I can stand in this wind, because I’ m not trying to stand in it,” I said. “The wind is just wind. You could withstand these gusts on the ground, so you can withstand them in the air. There is no difference. Except the difference you make in your head.”

He stared at me blankly. He hadn’ t understood.

“I’ m just standing,” I said. “You are all trying to compensate, to get your bodies lower because the height scares you. But the crouching and the sidestepping are not natural. You’ ve made yourselves vulnerable. If you could just control your panic, this wind would be nothing.”

“The way it is nothing to you,” he said.

I WANTED THE MIND of a scholar, but it seemed that Dr. Kerry saw in me the mind of a roofer. The other students belonged in a library; I belonged in a crane.

The first week passed in a blur of lectures. In the second week, every student was assigned a supervisor to guide their research. My supervisor, I learned, was the eminent Professor Jonathan Steinberg, a former vice-master of a Cambridge college, who was much celebrated for his writings on the Holocaust.

FOR TWO MONTHS I had weekly meetings with Professor Steinberg. I was never assigned readings. We read only what I asked to read, whether it was a book or a page.

None of my professors at BYU had examined my writing the way Professor Steinberg did. No comma, no period, no adjective or adverb was beneath his interest. He made no distinction between grammar and content, between form and substance. A poorly written sentence was a poorly conceived idea, and in his view the grammatical logic was as much in need of correction. “Tell me,” he would say, “why have you placed this comma here? What relationship between these phrases are you hoping to establish?” When I gave my explanation sometimes he would say, “Quite right,” and other times he would correct me with lengthy explanations of syntax.

After I’ d been meeting with Professor Steinberg for a month, I wrote an essay comparing Edmund Burke with Publius, the persona under which James Madison, Alexander Hamilton and John Jay had written *The Federalist Papers*. I barely slept for two weeks: every moment my eyes were open, I was either reading or thinking about those texts.

From my father I had learned that books were to be either adored or exiled. Books that were of God — books written by the Mormon prophets or the Founding Fathers — were not to be studied so much as cherished, like a thing perfect in itself.

I had been taught to read the words of men like Madison as a cast into which I ought to pour the plaster of my own mind, to be reshaped according to the contours of their faultless model. I read them to learn what to think, not how to think for myself. Books that were not of God were banished; they were a danger, powerful and irresistible in their cunning.

To write my essay I had to read books differently, without giving myself over to either fear or adoration.

I finished the essay and sent it to Professor Steinberg. Two days later, when I arrived for our next meeting, he was subdued. He peered at me from across the table. I waited for him to say the essay was a disaster, the product of an ignorant mind, that it had overreached, drawn too many conclusions from too little material.

“I have been teaching in Cambridge for thirty years,” he said. “And this is one of the best essays I’ ve read.”

I was prepared for insults but not for this.

Professor Steinberg must have said more about the essay but I heard nothing. My mind was consumed with a wrenching need to get out of that room. In that moment I was no longer in a clock tower in Cambridge. I was seventeen, in a red jeep, and a boy I loved had just touched my hand. I bolted.

I could tolerate any form of cruelty better than kindness. Praise was a poison to me; I choked on it. I wanted the professor to shout at me, wanted it so deeply I felt dizzy from the deprivation. The ugliness of me had to be given expression. If it was not expressed in his voice, I would need to express it in mine.

I don' t remember leaving the clock tower, or how I passed the afternoon. That evening there was a black-tie dinner. The hall was lit by candlelight, which was beautiful, but it cheered me for another reason: I wasn' t wearing formal clothing, just a black shirt and black pants, and I thought people might not notice in the dim lighting. My friend Laura arrived late. She explained that her parents had visited and taken her to France. She had only just returned. She was wearing a dress of rich purple with crisp pleats in the skirt. The hemline bounced several inches above her knee, and for a moment I thought the dress was whorish, until she said her father had bought it for her in Paris. A gift from one' s father could not be whorish. A gift from one' s father seemed to me the definitive signal that a woman was not a whore. I struggled with this dissonance — a whorish dress, gifted to a loved daughter — until the meal had been finished and the plates cleared away.

At my next supervision, Professor Steinberg said that when I applied for graduate school, he would make sure I was

accepted to whatever institution I chose. "Have you visited Harvard?" he said. "Or perhaps you prefer Cambridge?"

I imagined myself in Cambridge, a graduate student wearing a long black robe that swished as I strode through ancient corridors. Then I was hunching in a bathroom, my arm behind my back, my head in the toilet. I tried to focus on the student but I couldn't. I couldn't picture the girl in the whirling black gown without seeing that *other* girl. Scholar or whore, both could not be true. One was a lie.

"I can't go," I said. "I can't pay the fees."

"Let me worry about the fees," Professor Steinberg said.

IN LATE AUGUST, on our last night in Cambridge, there was a final dinner in the great hall. The tables were set with more knives, forks and goblets than I'd ever seen; the paintings on the wall seemed ghostly in the candlelight. I felt exposed by the elegance and yet somehow made invisible by it. I stared at the other students as they passed, taking in every silk dress, every heavily lined eye. I obsessed over the beauty of them.

At dinner I listened to the cheerful chatter of my friends while longing for the isolation of my room. Professor Steinberg was seated at the high table. Each time I glanced

at him, I felt that old instinct at work in me, tensing my muscles, preparing me to take flight.

I left the hall the moment dessert was served. It was a relief to escape all that refinement and beauty — to be allowed to be unlovely and not a point of contrast. Dr. Kerry saw me leave and followed.

It was dark. The lawn was black, the sky blacker. Pillars of chalky light reached up from the ground and illuminated the chapel, which glowed, moonlike, against the night sky.

“You’ ve made an impression on Professor Steinberg,” Dr. Kerry said, falling into step beside me. “I only hope he has made some impression on you.”

I didn’ t understand.

“Come this way,” he said, turning toward the chapel. “I have something to say to you.”

I walked behind him, noticing the silence of my own footfalls, aware that my Keds didn’ t click elegantly on stone the way the heels worn by other girls did.

Dr. Kerry said he’ d been watching me. “You act like someone who is impersonating someone else. And it’ s as if you think

your life depends on it.”

I didn’ t know what to say, so I said nothing.

“It has never occurred to you,” he said, “that you might have as much right to be here as anyone.” He waited for an explanation.

“I would enjoy serving the dinner,” I said, “more than eating it.”

Dr. Kerry smiled. “You should trust Professor Steinberg. If he says you’ re a scholar — ‘pure gold,’ I heard him say — then you are.”

“This is a magical place,” I said. “Everything shines here.”

“You must stop yourself from thinking like that,” Dr. Kerry said, his voice raised. “You are not fool’ s gold, shining only under a particular light. Whomever you become, whatever you make yourself into, that is who you always were. It was always in you. Not in Cambridge. In *you*. You are gold. And returning to BYU, or even to that mountain you came from, will not change who you are. It may change how others see you, it may even change how you see yourself — even gold

appears dull in some lighting — but *that* is the illusion. And it always was.”

I wanted to believe him, to take his words and remake myself, but I’ d never had that kind of faith. No matter how deeply I interred the memories, how tightly I shut my eyes against them, when I thought of my *self*, the images that came to mind were of *that* girl, in the bathroom, in the parking lot.

I couldn’ t tell Dr. Kerry about that girl. I couldn’ t tell him that the reason I couldn’ t return to Cambridge was that being here threw into great relief every violent and degrading moment of my life. At BYU I could almost forget, allow what had been to blend into what was. But the contrast here was too great, the world before my eyes too fantastical. The memories were more real — more believable — than the stone spires.

To myself I pretended there were other reasons I couldn’ t belong at Cambridge, reasons having to do with class and status: that it was because I was poor, had grown up poor. Because I could stand in the wind on the chapel roof and not tilt. *That* was the person who didn’ t belong in Cambridge: the roofer, not the whore. *I can go to school*, I had written in my journal that very afternoon. *And I can buy new clothes. But I am still Tara Westover. I have done jobs no Cambridge student would do. Dress us any way you like, we are not the*

same. Clothes could not fix what was wrong with me. Something had rotted on the inside.

Whether Dr. Kerry suspected any part of this, I' m not sure. But he understood that I had fixated on clothes as the symbol of why I didn' t, and couldn' t, belong. It was the last thing he said to me before he walked away, leaving me rooted, astonished, beside that grand chapel.

“The most powerful determinant of who you are is inside you,” he said. “Professor Steinberg says this is Pygmalion. Think of the story, Tara.” He paused, his eyes fierce, his voice piercing. “She was just a cockney in a nice dress. Until she believed in herself. Then it didn' t matter what dress she wore.”

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. How does Westover feel compared to her classmates Marianne and Heather? How do you know?
2. Describe Westover' s relationships with Dr. Kerry and with Professor Steinberg. How do they each treat her?
3. At the beginning of this selection, what has Westover learned about books? What does she need to learn in order to write the essays that she is assigned?
4. Dr. Kerry tells Westover, “You are not fool' s gold, shining only under a particular light” (52). What

does he mean by this?

5. Identify two or three examples of figurative language that Westover uses. Explain how each works in the context of the selection.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Westover tells Dr. Kerry, “I can stand in this wind, because I’ m not trying to stand in it” (17). What do you think she means? Explain.
2. Why does Westover use the title “Pygmalion” ? What specific events or episodes in this selection relate to this title? What is the title’ s significance in Westover’ s life and her personal journey?
3. What advice do you think Westover would give another person who wanted to do something big, like pursuing an education? Support your answer with specific examples from the selection.

Classroom Activity Using Comparison and Contrast

Carefully read the following paragraphs from Neil Postman’ s book *Amusing Ourselves to Death: Public*

Discourse in the Age of Show Business (1985), and then answer the questions that follow.

We were keeping our eye on 1984. When the year came and [Orwell's] prophecy didn't, thoughtful Americans sang softly in praise of themselves. The roots of liberal democracy had held. Wherever else the terror had happened, we, at least, had not been visited by Orwellian nightmares. But we had forgotten that alongside Orwell's dark vision, there was another — slightly older, slightly less well known, equally chilling: Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World*.

Contrary to common belief even among the educated, Huxley and Orwell did not prophesy the same thing. Orwell warns that we will be overcome by an externally imposed oppression. But in Huxley's vision, no Big Brother is required to deprive people of their autonomy, maturity and history. As he saw it, people will come to love their oppression, to adore the technologies that undo their capacities to think.

What Orwell feared were those who would ban books. What Huxley feared was that there would be no reason to ban a book, for there would be no one who wanted to read one. Orwell feared those who would deprive us of information. Huxley feared those who would give us so much that we would be reduced to passivity and egoism...

As Huxley remarked in *Brave New World Revisited*, the civil libertarians and rationalists who are ever on the alert to oppose tyranny "failed to take into account man's almost infinite appetite for distractions." In 1984, Huxley

added, people are controlled by inflicting pain. In *Brave New World*, they are controlled by inflicting pleasure. In short, Orwell feared that what we hate will ruin us. Huxley feared that what we love will ruin us.

This book is about the possibility that Huxley, not Orwell, was right.

What is Postman's point in these five paragraphs? How does he use comparison and contrast to make this point? How has he organized his material? Did you find this organization effective for the ideas he is presenting? Explain.

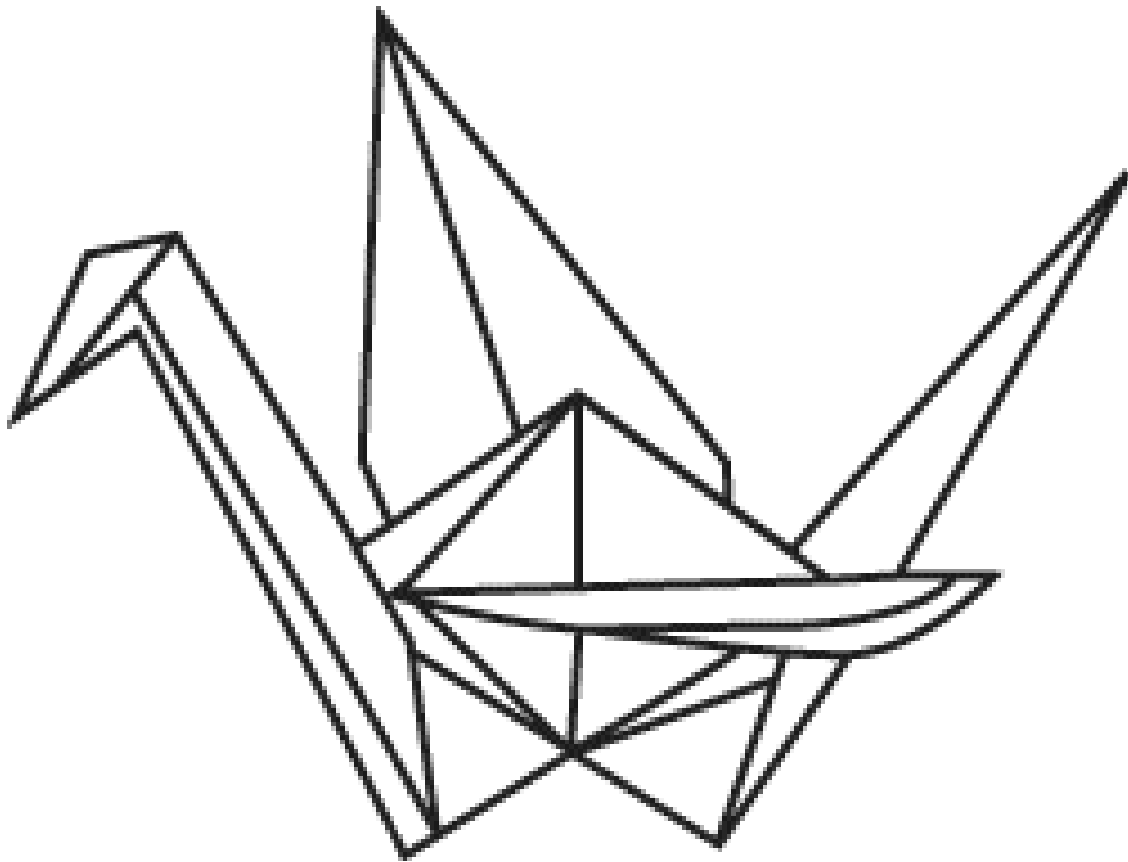
Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Select two teachers you have had or known. Compare the characteristics of each teacher by making a list or a diagram. Then write a brief essay in which you compare and contrast each teacher's characteristics. Did each teacher have strengths that were effective? Did the teachers have any notable weaknesses, in your opinion? Do you consider one a better teacher? Why or why not?
2. Westover was home-schooled through high school. Do you think that home-schooling is effective? Why or why not? Write a brief essay in which you present an

argument about the value of home-schooling. In your essay, you may want to compare and contrast the advantages and disadvantages of home-schooling versus public school. If you know someone who was home-schooled, or if you were home-schooled yourself, you may draw upon these perspectives and experiences to support your argument.



CHAPTER 21 Cause and Effect



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

Every time you answer a question that asks *why*, you engage in *causal analysis* — you try to determine a *cause* or series of causes for a particular *effect*. When you answer a question that asks *what if*, you try to determine what *effect* will result from a particular *cause*. You will have many opportunities to use [cause and effect](#) in your college writing. For example, in history, you might be asked to determine the causes of the 1991 breakup of the Soviet Union; in political science, you might be asked to determine the critical issues in the 2020 U.S. presidential election; in

sociology, you might be asked to analyze the effects that the opioid epidemic has had on communities in the rural United States; and in economics, you might be asked to predict what will happen if the federal government enacts a large tax cut.

Fascinated by the effects that private real estate development was having on his neighborhood, a student writer decided to find out what was happening in the older sections of cities across the country. In his first paragraph, Kevin Cunningham describes three possible effects (or fates) of a city's aging. In his second paragraph, he singles out one effect — redevelopment — and discusses in detail the effect it has had on Hoboken, New Jersey.

One of three fates awaits the aging neighborhood.

Effect: *decay*

Effect: urban
renewal

Effect:
redevelopment

Effects of
redevelopment

Decay may continue until the neighborhood becomes a slum. It may face urban renewal, with old buildings being razed and ugly new apartment houses taking their place.

Or it may undergo redevelopment, in which government encourages the upgrading of existing housing stock by offering low-interest loans or outright grants; thus, the original character of the neighborhood may be retained or restored, allowing the city to keep part of its identity.

An example of redevelopment at its best is Hoboken, New Jersey. In the early 1970s, Hoboken was a dying city, with rundown housing and many abandoned buildings. However, low-interest loans enabled some younger residents to refurbish their homes, and soon the area began to show signs of renewed vigor. Even outsiders moved in and rebuilt some of the abandoned houses. Today, whole blocks have been restored, and neighborhood life is active again. The city does well, too, because property values are higher and so are property taxes.

—Kevin Cunningham, student

Description

The first paragraph reads, “One of three fates awaits the aging neighborhood. Decay may continue until the neighborhood becomes a slum. An accompanying annotation reads, Effect: decay. It may face urban renewal, with old buildings being razed and ugly new apartment houses taking their place. An accompanying annotation reads, Effect: urban renewal. Or it may undergo redevelopment, in which

government encourages the upgrading of existing housing stock by offering low-interest loans or outright grants; thus, the original character of the neighborhood may be retained or restored, allowing the city to keep part of its identity.” Accompanying annotations read, Effect: redevelopment. Effects of redevelopment.

The second paragraph reads, “An example of redevelopment at its best is Hoboken, New Jersey. In the early 1970s, Hoboken was a dying city, with rundown housing and many abandoned buildings. However, low-interest loans enabled some younger residents to refurbish their homes, and soon the area began to show signs of renewed vigor. Even outsiders moved in and rebuilt some of the abandoned houses. Today, whole blocks have been restored, and neighborhood life is active again. The city does well, too, because property values are higher and so are property taxes.” The writer’s name reads, Kevin Cunningham, student.

In the following example, popular author Bill Bryson explains why the transition from being hunter-gatherers to farmers and city dwellers did not have a beneficial effect on humans:

Even on Orkney, where prehistoric life was probably as good as it could get, an analysis of 340 ancient skeletons showed that hardly any people lived beyond their twenties.

What killed the Orcadians was not dietary deficiency but disease. People living together are vastly more likely to spread illness from household to household, and the close exposure to animals through domestication meant that flu (from pigs or fowl), smallpox and measles (from cows and sheep), and

anthrax (from horses and goats, among others) could become part of the human condition, too. As far as we can tell, virtually all of the infectious diseases have become endemic only since people took to living together. Settling down also brought a huge increase in “human commensals” — mice, rats, and other creatures that live with and off us — and these all too often acted as disease vectors.

So sedentism meant poorer diets, more illness, lots of toothache and gum disease, and earlier deaths. What is truly extraordinary is that these are all still factors in our lives today.

—Bill Bryson, *At Home: A Short History of Private Life*

Determining causes and effects is usually a complex process. One reason is that *immediate causes* are readily apparent (because they are closest to the effect) and *ultimate causes* are not as apparent (because they are somewhat removed and even hidden). Furthermore, ultimate causes may bring about effects that themselves become immediate causes, thus creating a *causal chain*. Consider the following causal chain: Sally, a computer salesperson, prepared extensively for a meeting with an important client (ultimate cause), impressed the client (immediate cause), and made a very large sale (effect). The chain did not stop there: the large sale caused her to be promoted by her employer (effect). For a detailed example of a causal chain, read Barry Commoner’s analysis of

the near disaster at the Three Mile Island nuclear facility in the introduction to [Chapter 5](#) (p. [112](#)).

A second reason causal analysis can be complex is that an effect may have several possible or actual causes, and a cause may have several possible or actual effects. An upset stomach may be caused by eating spoiled food, but it may also be caused by overeating, flu, allergy, nervousness, pregnancy, or any combination of factors. Similarly, the high cost of electricity may have multiple effects — higher profits for utility companies, fewer sales of electrical appliances, higher prices for other products, and the development of alternative sources of energy.

AVOIDING LOGICAL FALLACIES

Sound reasoning and logic are present in all good writing, but they are central to any causal analysis. Writers of believable causal analysis examine their material objectively and develop their essays carefully. They examine all causes and effects methodically and then evaluate them. They are convinced by their own examination of the material but are not afraid to admit that other causes and effects might exist. Above all, they do not let their own prejudices interfere with the logic of their analyses and presentations.

Because people are accustomed to thinking of causes with their effects, they sometimes commit an error in logic known as the “after this, therefore because of this” fallacy (in Latin, *post hoc, ergo propter hoc*). This [logical fallacy](#) leads people to believe that one event somehow caused a second event, just because the second event followed the first — that is, they sometimes make causal connections that are not proven. For example, if students perform better after a free breakfast program is instituted at their school, one cannot assume that the improvement was caused by the breakfast program. There could be any number of other causes for this effect, and a responsible writer would analyze and consider them all before suggesting a cause.

For more on logical fallacies and how to avoid them, see [Chapter 22](#), [pages 523 - 524](#).

Why We Crave Horror Movies

Stephen King



KENZO TRIBOUILLARD/AFP/Getty Images

Stephen King's name is synonymous with horror stories. Born in 1947, King is a 1970 graduate of the University of Maine. He worked as a janitor in a knitting mill, a laundry worker, and a high school English teacher before he struck it big with his writing. Many consider King to be the most successful writer of modern horror fiction today, and in 2015 the National Endowment for the Arts awarded him the National Medal of Arts for his contributions as an author. To date, King has written dozens of novels, collections of short stories, and screenplays, among other works. His books have sold hundreds of millions of copies worldwide, and many of his novels have been made into popular motion pictures, including *Stand by Me*, *Misery*, *The Green Mile*, *Dreamcatcher*, *It*, and *The Dark Tower*. His books, starting with *Carrie* in 1974, also include *Salem's Lot* (1975), *The Shining* (1977), *The Stand* (1978), *The Dead Zone* (1979), *Christine* (1983), *Pet Sematary* (1983), *The Dark Half* (1989), *The Girl Who Loved Tom Gordon* (1999), *From a Buick 8* (2002), *Under the Dome* (2009), *Joyland* (2013), *Doctor Sleep* (2013), *End of Watch* (2016), *Sleeping Beauties* (with his son Owen King, 2017), *The Outsider* (2018), and *The Institute* (2019). His other works include *Danse Macabre* (1981), a nonfiction look at horror in the media, and *On Writing: A Memoir of the Craft* (2000). The widespread popularity of horror books and films shows that many people share King's fascination with the macabre.

In the following selection, originally published in *Playboy* in 1982 — a variation on “The Horror Movie as Junk Food” chapter in *Danse Macabre* — King analyzes the reasons we flock to horror movies.

Reflecting on What You Know

What movies have you seen recently? Do you prefer watching any one particular kind of movie — comedy, drama, science fiction, or horror, for example — over others? How do you explain your preference?

I think that we’ re all mentally ill; those of us outside the asylums only hide it a little better — and maybe not all that much better, after all. We’ ve all known people who talk to themselves, people who sometimes squinch their faces into horrible grimaces when they believe no one is watching, people who have some hysterical fear — of snakes, the dark, the tight place, the long drop ... and, of course, those final worms and grubs that are waiting so patiently underground.

When we pay our four or five bucks and seat ourselves at tenth-row center in a theater showing a horror movie, we are daring the nightmare.

Why? Some of the reasons are simple and obvious. To show that we can, that we are not afraid, that we can ride this roller coaster. Which is not to say that a really good horror movie

may not surprise a scream out of us at some point, the way we may scream when a roller coaster twists through a complete 360 or plows through a lake at the bottom of the drop. And horror movies, like roller coasters, have always been the special province of the young; by the time one turns forty or fifty, one's appetite for double twists or 360-degree loops may be considerably depleted.

We also go to reestablish our feelings of essential normality; the horror movie is innately conservative, even reactionary. Freda Jackson as the horrible melting woman in *Die, Monster, Die!* confirms for us that no matter how far we may be removed from the beauty of a Robert Redford or a Diana Ross, we are still light-years from true ugliness.

And we go to have fun.

Ah, but this is where the ground starts to slope away, isn't it? Because this is a very peculiar sort of fun, indeed. The fun comes from seeing others menaced — sometimes killed. One critic has suggested that if pro football has become the voyeur's¹ version of combat, then the horror film has become the modern version of the public lynching.

It is true that the mythic, "fairy-tale" horror film intends to take away the shades of gray... It urges us to put away our more civilized and adult penchant for analysis and

to become children again, seeing things in pure blacks and whites. It may be that horror movies provide psychic relief on this level because this invitation to lapse into simplicity, irrationality, and even outright madness is extended so rarely. We are told we may allow our emotions a free rein ... or no rein at all.

If we are all insane, then sanity becomes a matter of degree. If your insanity leads you to carve up women like Jack the Ripper or the Cleveland Torso Murderer,² we clap you away in the funny farm (but neither of those two amateur-night surgeons was ever caught, heh-heh-heh); if, on the other hand, your insanity leads you only to talk to yourself when you're under stress or to pick your nose on your morning bus, then you are left alone to go about your business ... though it is doubtful that you will ever be invited to the best parties.

The potential lyncher is in almost all of us (excluding saints, past and present; but then, most saints have been crazy in their own ways), and every now and then, he has to be let loose to scream and roll around in the grass. Our emotions and our fears form their own body, and we recognize that it demands its own exercise to maintain proper muscle tone. Certain of these emotional muscles are accepted — even exalted — in civilized society; they are, of course, the emotions that tend to maintain the status quo of civilization

itself. Love, friendship, loyalty, kindness — these are all the emotions that we applaud, emotions that have been immortalized in the couplets of Hallmark cards and in the verses (I don' t dare call it poetry) of Leonard Nimoy.³

When we exhibit these emotions, society showers us with positive reinforcement; we learn this even before we get out of diapers. When, as children, we hug our rotten little puke of a sister and give her a kiss, all the aunts and uncles smile and twit and cry, “Isn’ t he the sweetest little thing?” Such coveted treats as chocolate-covered graham crackers often follow. But if we deliberately slam the rotten little puke of a sister’ s fingers in the door, sanctions follow — angry remonstrance from parents, aunts, and uncles; instead of a chocolate-covered graham cracker, a spanking.

But anticivilization emotions don’ t go away, and they demand periodic exercise. We have such “sick” jokes as, “What’ s the difference between a truckload of bowling balls and a truckload of dead babies?” (You can’ t unload a truckload of bowling balls with a pitchfork ... a joke, by the way, that I heard originally from a ten-year-old.) Such a joke may surprise a laugh or a grin out of us even as we recoil, a possibility that confirms the thesis: if we share a brotherhood of man, then we also share an insanity of man. None of which is intended as a defense of either the sick joke or insanity but merely as an explanation of why the best

horror films, like the best fairy tales, manage to be reactionary, anarchistic,⁴ and revolutionary all at the same time.

The mythic horror movie, like the sick joke, has a dirty job to do. It deliberately appeals to all that is worst in us. It is morbidity unchained, our most base instincts let free, our nastiest fantasies realized ... and it all happens, fittingly enough, in the dark. For those reasons, good liberals often shy away from horror films. For myself, I like to see the most aggressive of them — *Dawn of the Dead*, for instance — as lifting a trap door in the civilized forebrain and throwing a basket of raw meat to the hungry alligators swimming around in that subterranean river beneath.

Why bother? Because it keeps them from getting out, man. It keeps them down there and me up here. It was Lennon and McCartney who said that all you need is love, and I would agree with that.

As long as you keep the gators fed.

¹*voyeur*: one who observes from a distance.

²*Jack the Ripper or the Cleveland Torso Murderer*: serial murderers who were active in the 1880s and the 1930s, respectively.

³*Leonard Nimoy* (1931–2015): an actor famous for playing Mr. Spock on the U.S. television series *Star Trek*, which aired from 1966 to

1969, and in its many film versions.

⁴*anarchistic*: against any authority; favoring anarchy.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What, according to King, causes people to crave horror movies? What other reasons can you add to King's list?
2. Identify the analogy King uses in paragraph 3, and explain how it works. (Glossary: [Analogy](#))
3. What emotions does society applaud? Why? Which ones does King label "anticivilization emotions" (11)?
4. In what ways is a horror movie like a sick joke? What is the "dirty job," or effect, that the two have in common (12)?
5. What is King's tone? (Glossary: [Tone](#)) Point to particular words or sentences that lead you to this conclusion.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. What does King mean when he states that "the horror movie is innately conservative, even reactionary" (4)? How might you rewrite this paragraph to help the reader better understand what he is saying?

2. King starts his essay with the attention-grabbing sentence “I think that we’ re all mentally ill.” How does he develop this idea of insanity in his essay? What does he mean when he says, “The potential lyncher is in almost all of us” (9)? How does King’ s last line relate to the theme of mental illness?
3. By many accounts, King is politically liberal. Yet he writes, “Good liberals often shy away from horror films” (12). Do you see a contradiction between the author’ s personal outlook and his artistic fascination with evil? If so, how would you reconcile these two apparently opposing forces?

Classroom Activity Using Cause and Effect

Use the following test, developed by William V. Haney, to determine your ability to accurately analyze evidence that is presented to you. After completing Haney’ s test, discuss your answers with other members of your class.

The Uncritical Inference Test

Directions

1. You will read a brief story. Assume that all of the information presented in the story is definitely

- accurate and true. Read the story carefully. You may refer back to the story whenever you wish.
2. You will then read statements about the story. Answer them in numerical order. *Do not go back* to fill in answers or to change answers. This will only distort your test score.
 3. After you read each statement carefully, determine whether the statement is:
 - a. “T” — meaning: On the basis of the information presented in the story the statement is *definitely true*.
 - b. “F” — meaning: On the basis of the information presented in the story the statement is *definitely false*.
 - c. “?” — The statement *may* be true (or false) but on the basis of the information presented in the story you cannot be definitely certain. (If any part of the statement is doubtful, mark the statement “?”.)
 4. Indicate your answer by circling either “T” or “F” or “?” opposite the statement.

The Story

Babe Smith has been killed. Police have rounded up six suspects, all of whom are known gangsters. All of them are known to have been near the scene of the killing at the approximate time that it occurred. All had substantial motives for wanting Smith killed. However,

one of these suspected gangsters, Slinky Sam, has positively been cleared of guilt.

Statements about the Story

1. Slinky Sam is known to have been near the scene of the killing of Babe Smith.	T	F	?
2. All six of the rounded-up gangsters were known to have been near the scene of the murder.	T	F	?
3. Only Slinky Sam has been cleared of guilt.	T	F	?
4. All six of the rounded-up suspects were near the scene of Smith' s killing at the approximate time that it took place.	T	F	?
5. The police do not know who killed Smith.	T	F	?
6. All six suspects are known to have been near the scene of the foul deed.	T	F	?
7. Smith' s murderer did not confess of his own free will.	T	F	?
8. Slinky Sam was not cleared of guilt.	T	F	?
9. It is known that the six suspects were in the vicinity of the cold-blooded assassination.	T	F	?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write an essay in which you analyze, in light of King' s remarks about the causes of our cravings for horror movies, a horror movie you' ve seen. In what ways did the movie satisfy your "anticivilization emotions" (11)? How did you feel before going to the theater? How did you feel when leaving?
2. One way to understand a person' s life is as a series of causes and effects in which decisions large and small lead to present circumstances. Take a look back at a decision you' ve made in your life and examine the dynamics of the situation. For instance, perhaps you didn' t want to go to college but decided to do it anyway. Why weren' t you interested, what changed your mind, and what has been the difference? Maybe your dreams were crushed and you made an unwise decision that has had reverberating effects. Once you' ve settled on your past decision, write a letter to your former self, giving yourself specific advice for living your life, using specific details about the causes and effects of your actions to support your main idea. For instance, you might tell your younger self that it isn' t wise to seek immediate gratification and put off college. (For an example of this kind of letter, look up famous tennis player Pete Sampras' s "Letter to My Younger Self," published in *The Players' Tribune* on June 29, 2015.)

Black Men and Public Space

Brent Staples



Brent Staples

Brent Staples was born in Chester, Pennsylvania, in 1951, the oldest of nine children. He earned a BA at Widener University

and a PhD at the University of Chicago. He worked for *The New York Times* as an assistant editor for metropolitan news and as editor of *The New York Times Book Review* before he joined the paper's editorial board in 1990. His writing, focusing on the areas of education, criminal justice, and economics, appears frequently in the opinion pages. He is also the author of a memoir, *Parallel Time: Growing Up in Black and White* (1994), winner of the Anisfield-Wolf Book Award.

In "Black Men and Public Space," first published in *Ms.* magazine in 1986, Staples describes his nighttime experiences on city streets. He tries to understand the effects he has on other pedestrians, even as he recognizes that the ultimate causes of the tension in these encounters are persistent and damaging stereotypes about African American men.

Reflecting on What You Know

Have you ever felt scared or intimidated when you were out in public? Have you ever sensed that someone felt scared or intimidated by you? What do you think causes these anxieties?

My first victim was a woman — white, well dressed, probably in her late twenties. I came upon her late one evening on a deserted street in Hyde Park, a relatively affluent neighborhood in an otherwise mean, impoverished section of Chicago. As I swung onto the avenue behind her, there seemed to be a discreet, uninflamatory distance between us. Not so.

She cast back a worried glance. To her, the youngish black man — a broad six feet two inches with a beard and billowing hair, both hands shoved into the pockets of a bulky military jacket — seemed menacingly close. After a few more quick glimpses, she picked up her pace and was soon running in earnest. Within seconds, she disappeared into a cross street.

That was more than a decade ago. I was twenty-two years old, a graduate student newly arrived at the University of Chicago. It was in the echo of that terrified woman's footfalls that I first began to know the unwieldy inheritance I'd come into — the ability to alter public space in ugly ways. It was clear that she thought herself the quarry of a mugger, a rapist, or worse. Suffering a bout of insomnia, however, I was stalking sleep, not defenseless wayfarers. As a softy who is scarcely able to take a knife to a raw chicken — let alone hold one to a person's throat — I was surprised, embarrassed, and dismayed all at once. Her flight made me feel like an accomplice in tyranny. It also made it clear that I was indistinguishable from the muggers who occasionally seeped into the area from the surrounding ghetto. The first encounter, and those that followed, signified that a vast, unnerving gulf lay between nighttime pedestrians — particularly women — and me. And I soon gathered that being perceived as dangerous is a hazard in itself. I only needed to turn a corner into a dicey situation, or crowd some frightened, armed person in a foyer

somewhere, or make an errant move after being pulled over by a policeman. Where fear and weapons meet — and they often do in urban America — there is always the possibility of death.

In that first year, my first away from my hometown, I was to become thoroughly familiar with the language of fear. At dark, shadowy intersections, I could cross in front of a car stopped at a traffic light and elicit the *thunk, thunk, thunk, thunk* of the driver — black, white, male, or female — hammering down the door locks. On less traveled streets after dark, I grew accustomed to but never comfortable with people crossing to the other side of the street rather than pass me. Then there were the standard unpleasantries with policemen, doormen, bouncers, cabdrivers, and others whose business it is to screen out troublesome individuals *before* there is any nastiness.

I moved to New York nearly two years ago and I have remained an avid night walker. In central Manhattan, the near-constant crowd cover minimizes tense one-on-one street encounters. Elsewhere — in SoHo, for example, where sidewalks are narrow and tightly spaced buildings shut out the sky — things can get very taut indeed.

After dark, on the warrenlike¹ streets of Brooklyn where I live, I often see women who fear the worst from me. They seem to have set their faces on neutral, and with their purse

straps strung across their chests bandolier²-style, they forge ahead as though bracing themselves against being tackled. I understand, of course, that the danger they perceive is not a hallucination. Women are particularly vulnerable to street violence, and young black males are drastically overrepresented among the perpetrators of that violence. Yet these truths are no solace against the kind of alienation that comes of being ever the suspect, a fearsome entity with whom pedestrians avoid making eye contact.

It is not altogether clear to me how I reached the ripe old age of twenty-two without being conscious of the lethality nighttime pedestrians attributed to me. Perhaps it was because in Chester, Pennsylvania, the small, angry industrial town where I came of age in the 1960s, I was scarcely noticeable against a backdrop of gang warfare, street knifings, and murders. I grew up one of the good boys, had perhaps a half-dozen fistfights. In retrospect, my shyness of combat has clear sources.

As a boy, I saw countless tough guys locked away; I have since buried several, too. They were babies, really — a teenage cousin, a brother of twenty-two, a childhood friend in his mid-twenties — all gone down in episodes of bravado played out in the streets. I came to doubt the virtues of intimidation early on. I chose, perhaps unconsciously, to remain a shadow — timid, but a survivor.

The fearsomeness mistakenly attributed to me in public places often has a perilous flavor. The most frightening of these confusions occurred in the late 1970s and early 1980s, when I worked as a journalist in Chicago. One day, rushing into the office of a magazine I was writing for with a deadline story in hand, I was mistaken for a burglar. The office manager called security and, with an ad hoc posse, pursued me through the labyrinthine halls, nearly to my editor's door. I had no way of proving who I was. I could only move briskly toward the company of someone who knew me.

Another time I was on assignment for a local paper and killing time before an interview. I entered a jewelry store on the city's affluent Near North Side. The proprietor excused herself and returned with an enormous red Doberman pinscher straining at the end of a leash. She stood, the dog extended toward me, silent to my questions, her eyes bulging nearly out of her head. I took a cursory look around, nodded, and bade her good night.

Relatively speaking, however, I never fared as badly as another black male journalist. He went to nearby Waukegan, Illinois, a couple of summers ago to work on a story about a murderer who was born there. Mistaking the reporter for the killer, police officers hauled him from his car at gunpoint and but for his press credentials would probably have tried

to book him. Such episodes are not uncommon. Black men trade tales like this all the time.

Over the years, I learned to smother the rage I felt at so often being taken for a criminal. Not to do so would surely have led to madness. I now take precautions to make myself less threatening. I move about with care, particularly late in the evening. I give a wide berth to nervous people on subway platforms during the wee hours, particularly when I have exchanged business clothes for jeans. If I happen to be entering a building behind some people who appear skittish, I may walk by, letting them clear the lobby before I return, so as not to seem to be following them. I have been calm and extremely congenial on those rare occasions when I' ve been pulled over by the police.

And on late-evening constitutionals I employ what has proved to be an excellent tension-reducing measure: I whistle melodies from Beethoven and Vivaldi and the more popular classical composers. Even steely New Yorkers hunching toward nighttime destinations seem to relax, and occasionally they even join in the tune. Virtually everybody seems to sense that a mugger wouldn' t be warbling bright, sunny selections from Vivaldi' s *Four Seasons*. It is my equivalent of the cowbell that hikers wear when they know they are in bear country.

¹*warrenlike*: maze-like or crowded.

²*bandolier*: a belt worn across the body, often with pockets to hold ammunition.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. One of the challenges Staples takes up in this essay is to recognize himself as a cause. What effects does he have on other people? How does he explain those reactions?
2. Discuss Staples' s word choice in the first paragraph. How does the language contribute to the feeling of the scene? Which words do you find most telling? (Glossary: [Diction](#))
3. How does Staples see himself? How does he believe others see him? Discuss the contrast between these two views. (Glossary: [Comparison and Contrast](#))
4. How does Staples describe the complex emotions he felt after the encounter with his “first victim” ? Discuss the mix of feelings he mentions in paragraph 2.
5. Learning that others fear him becomes, in turn, a source of fear for Staples. Why? Why is causing fear “a hazard in itself” (2)?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Staples finds that he has “the ability to alter public space in ugly ways” (2). What does he mean by “ugly” in this sentence? What is ugly about the encounters he describes in the rest of the essay?
2. What technique does Staples come up with for diminishing the tension in these public encounters? Why does he think it works? What do you think of this solution?
3. Staples ends with a metaphor that likens him to a hiker in “bear country” (12). Discuss the implications of this comparison. (Glossary: [Figure of Speech](#))

Classroom Activity Using Cause and Effect

In preparation for writing a cause-and-effect essay, list four effects (two on society and two on personal behavior) for one of the following: television, airplanes, microwave ovens, smartphones, the internet, social media, entertainment streaming services, or an item of your choice. For example, the automobile could be said to have had the following effects:

Society

A national highway system developed, based on asphalt roads.

Petroleum and insurance industries expanded in size and influence.

Personal Behavior

People with cars can live far from public transportation. Suburban and rural drivers walk less than urban dwellers.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. In 2012, twenty-five years after Staples published his essay, a young black man, Trayvon Martin, was shot and killed by George Zimmerman on a street in Sanford, Florida. Martin's death and Zimmerman's subsequent acquittal in 2013 sparked nationwide protests and helped start the Black Lives Matter movement. First, do a little research to familiarize yourself with the Martin case and to be sure you have the facts. (Refer to Evaluating Sources in [Chapter 23](#), to ensure that you consult credible, unbiased sources.) Then, consider whether you agree with some or all of the ideas Staples presents in his essay and why. Finally, write an essay applying Staples's cause-and-effect analysis to the Martin case. What might his experiences have to tell us about Martin's death? You might also look up, and incorporate into your discussion, the editorial in which Staples addresses the Trayvon Martin case ("Young, Black,

Male, and Stalked by Bias,” published in *The New York Times* on April 14, 2012).

2. One way to think of ourselves is in terms of the influences that have caused us to be who we are. What contributed to making you who you are — parents, peers, teachers, or coaches? Your neighborhood or cultural heritage? Friends you identify with or heroes you look up to? Write an essay in which you discuss two or three of your most important influences, considering the effects they have had on your life.

Sexism Starts in Childhood

Melinda Wenner Moyer



Melinda Wenner Moyer

Melinda Wenner Moyer is a science journalist and contributing editor at *Scientific American*. She graduated from the

University of Michigan and New York University. Her early writing appeared in institutional journals, including publications for the University of Pittsburgh School of Medicine. More recently, she has written for *Slate*, *The New York Times*, and *Mother Jones*. Her recent work focuses on the 2018 hearings surrounding Supreme Court Justice Brett Kavanaugh and on the long-term effects of sexual assault on teenagers, among other topics. In 2019, Moyer received the Bricker Award for Science Writing in Medicine.

Originally published in *Slate*, Moyer's essay "Sexism Starts in Childhood" traces the path of influence ideas about gender come to create in an individual's life. As you read, note Moyer's use of academic studies as sources, and consider both the immediate causes and ultimate causes that she suggests. What solution does she settle on, and how is this "paradox" a particularly challenging resolution?

Reflecting on What You Know

Think back to your childhood and make a list of your favorite toys. Be descriptive in your language and imagery. Identify who gave these toys to you and how old you were. How did your choice of toys change as you grew up? Were any of these toys gender-specific? Are there patterns that you notice in the list of toys in terms of color, type, or other elements? What, if anything, do those toys say about the gender expectations that our culture places on its children?

With every sexual harassment scandal that hits, I feel all the emotions: anger, betrayal, heartbreak that something I vaguely sensed turns out to really be true. I also feel a growing sense of fear — not for me, but for my kids. How do I shape my son into a man who respects women and treats them as equals? Is it possible for him to breathe society's misogynistic¹ air every day without succumbing? How do I instill in my daughter the confidence, resolve, and resilience to thrive in a culture that will incessantly² push her down?

So I did what I always do in these “I wonder” situations: I dug into the science and talked to researchers. I asked them how and why kids develop gender stereotypes and sexist behavior, and what parents can do to prevent them. Thankfully, parents can make a difference. We don't have as much of an influence on these trajectories as we might like — peers and culture are more powerful — but parents certainly can take steps, even with toddlers and preschoolers, to ensure that their kids grow up less sexist and more egalitarian³ than our culture tells them to be.

It's helpful to understand how kids develop an understanding of gender and its importance. Children are constantly observing the world — mainly, studying people and their differences — and making inferences based on what they see and hear about these differences. “The kid looks to the

world to say, *Which of these things are important?*” explains Rebecca Bigler, a psychologist and women’s and gender studies researcher at the University of Texas at Austin. By their first birthdays, most babies can distinguish between male and female faces — but adults are the ones who tell them that gender matters, because we constantly point it out.

“We use gendered nouns all the time: ‘Good morning, boys and girls,’ ‘What a good girl,’ ‘The man is at the corner,’ ‘Ask that lady’ ,” Bigler explains, and “that tells kids that gender is really important — because otherwise, why do you label it hundreds of times a day?”

Once kids know to pay attention to gender, they also start drawing black-and-white conclusions about its meaning, because that’s how kids’ brains work — they create rigid, overgeneral rules and categories. Crude stereotypes, if you will. They might decide, based on examples they see, that women cook and are teachers, and that men play football and are firefighters — but that men never cook and women never fight fires. They’ll start to discern the power discrepancy between the genders when they notice, say, that all U.S. presidents have been men. They might even draw causal inferences from it: *If the most powerful position in the country is always held by men, then I guess men must inherently be smarter and more capable than women.*

Ultimately, based on what they observe, kids decide that “there are a lot of essential and innate differences between

boys and girls,” says Christia Spears Brown, a psychologist at the University of Kentucky and the author of *Parenting Beyond Pink and Blue*. That power discrepancy is worse in America than most people realize: In 2007, the World Economic Forum analyzed 128 countries in terms of gender differences in economic participation, educational attainment, political empowerment, and health. The U.S. came in at No. 31, behind Bulgaria and Namibia. If you want gender equality, move to Scandinavia or New Zealand.

As kids start to build these gender stereotypes, they start conforming to them, too — in part because they are rewarded for doing so. Research has shown that parents (particularly dads) preferentially offer kids gender-appropriate toys; they also tend to reward kids for playing with them and scold them for playing with stereotypically inappropriate toys. Parents are also more tolerant when sons are physically aggressive with peers and siblings than when daughters act in a similar way. Teachers, according to one recent study, also tend to encourage gender-stereotypical behavior among girls. And peers pile on the pressure, too. Kids — boys especially — punish each other, sometimes cruelly, when gender rules are broken and often exclude others on the basis of gender. One study watched preschool boys while they were playing and found that when boys showed interest in stereotypically girls’ toys like play kitchens, dollhouses, or dresses, other boys interrupted by hitting and ridiculing them. As

kids continue to practice these gendered behaviors, they become routine and weave into their self-identity.

OK, but, some of you might be thinking, my son was obsessed with trucks when he was practically a baby. Aren't some gender stereotypes driven by biology rather than culture?

Researchers concede this is a very difficult question to answer, in part because we can never really separate out nature from nurture, even in babies. “Boys and girls have different biological experiences prenatally, and different biological and social experiences from the time they are born, and these influences interact with one another, so disentangling them is difficult,” says Carol Martin, a child development researcher at Arizona State University. Still, it's likely that peer and parental influences still shape even early gendered behavior: “Most of it is [that] kids are playing with what their parents buy them,” Brown says. Or they're mimicking what other toddlers of their gender do — toddlers who might gravitate toward gender-appropriate toys because of what they have been offered or encouraged to play with before. There *is* evidence that testosterone levels in early development influence play behavior, but it's unclear how much of an effect these hormones have. But boys and girls both love dolls, Brown says — it's just that with girls, they're called “dolls” and with boys, they're called “action figures.”

Certainly, though, as kids get older — 8, 9, 10 — they develop more cognitive flexibility, and many realize that gender norms are largely based on social conventions. But at around the same time, children also start to develop moral reasoning, and in some kids, these gender stereotypes get moralized instead of relaxed — kids start to think that girls are expected to be demure⁴ and boys are expected to be assertive simply because “this is the right thing to do,” says Campbell Leaper, a developmental and social psychologist at the University of California, Santa Cruz.

And here’s the crux⁵ of the problem: The more ingrained kids’ gender stereotypes become, the more easily they conclude that girls are inferior to boys — that boys have higher status because they biologically deserve it. (And they’ll continue to believe it as adults: On average, parents rate sons as more intelligent than daughters.) Making matters worse, as kids transition into adolescence, these gendered stereotypes shift in an important way: They become sexualized. Research suggests that adolescents with strong gender stereotypes start to believe that boys are constantly seeking out sex and that girls should strive to look pretty and seek boys’ sexual attention. Studies also find that the more strongly boys believe these stereotypes, the more likely they are to make sexual comments, to tell sexual jokes in front of girls, and to grab women.

Interestingly, research also suggests that stereotypical beliefs about gender are stronger among boys than girls. This could be in part because boys feel more cultural and parental pressure to conform to gender expectations than girls do. It's less culturally acceptable for boys to pretend to be princesses than it is for girls to play Superman, and boys know that and respond accordingly. Researchers hypothesize that this discrepancy exists in part because of the status difference in our culture between women and men. "A lower status group [in this case, girls] generally is more apt to adopt the characteristics of the high-status group [boys] because it could enhance their status esteem, whereas a high-status group is less likely to adopt the characteristics of a low-status or low-power group, because that might be viewed as status loss," Leaper explains. It's not that men and boys are whispering to each other, *Psst! we're the more powerful gender, so don't mess with the status quo*. It's more of a subconscious behavior.

Let me pause here and quickly review. Many people roll their eyes at the pushback against seemingly innocuous⁶ cultural traditions like dressing boys in blue and girls in pink and buying kids gendered toys. I, too, have wondered, *What's the big deal?* because on the surface, these customs seem innocent enough. But the research I've just described charts a compelling and worrying path from these traditions to the development of childhood beliefs that, geez, yeah, girls and

boys must really be quite different — and, given the gender hierarchy that's widely visible, that girls must somehow be inferior. Then, when these stereotypes morph during adolescence, they lead to something even more sinister: The idea that girls are sex objects and that boys are sex-obsessed, that it's OK for guys to cross sexual boundaries because that's just how guys are. This is the kind of mindset that could lead a Harvey Weinstein or a James Toback to believe they have a right to help themselves to women's bodies. So, yeah: Dressing your baby girl in pink ruffles might be cute, but it may also feed a dangerous societal monster.

Let's move on to some good news: We as parents can definitely instill more egalitarian gender beliefs in our kids. First, and perhaps most easily, we can encourage our kids to play with kids of the other gender. In a 2001 study, Carol Martin and her colleague Richard Fabes at Arizona State studied preschoolers' and kindergartners' play patterns and found that the more kids played with children of their own gender, the more stereotypically gendered their behavior became — so the boys who played mainly with other boys began to play more forcefully and actively while the girls who played with other girls started playing less aggressively.

“Encouraging co-ed friendships is one of the most important things parents (and teachers) can do,” Martin says. “When they interact with each other like this, both girls and boys

learn about each other and their similarities, become more comfortable with one another, and we believe that it may provide a kind of social resiliency allowing them to deal with a range of social experiences.”

We can also push against gender stereotypes by pointing them out and raising questions. When a sexist scenario unfolds on a TV show your kid is watching (because, surprise!, skewed gender ratios and stereotypes are a big problem in children’s television and commercials), bring it up right then and there, Bigler says: *Why do you think they’re only showing boys going on these adventures? Do you think that’s fair?* Use everyday experiences as conversation starters, too. If you’re at a store and a stranger tells your daughter, *Oh what a pretty dress*, build on it. “You could reply with ‘Thank you, yes, her dress is pretty, and she’s very smart, too,’ ” Bigler says. Or, if you’d prefer to avoid confrontation, discuss the comment’s implications with your daughter afterward. “You can say, ‘Why did she say your dress was pretty? I think that has something to do with how she thinks girls should look. I wonder if she says boys look pretty. I’m kind of offended — I think your dress *is* pretty, but I don’t think that’s what’s important about you,’ ” Bigler says.

Crucially, too, challenge your kids when *they* make sexist comments. You’ll get plenty of opportunities. Just a few

days ago, my 6-year-old told me about a game he had played at a party that “only boys could play.” I asked him some questions and got a conversation going. Eventually he concluded: It’s not fair to exclude girls just because they are girls. Research suggests that these tactics work and can last. In a 2009 study, Bigler and her colleagues coached a group of 5- to 10-year-olds to verbally challenge various types of sexist remarks. (In response to “You can’t play this, you’re a girl,” they’d be taught to reply, “You can’t say that girls can’t play.”) Practicing these retorts during the intervention led kids to continue using them even six months later; girls in the study (but not boys) also developed and maintained more egalitarian gender beliefs.

Parents might also want to avoid gendered toys, outfits, and expectations so that they don’t reinforce the message that boys and girls really *are* different and we want them to stay that way. Try not to frown when your son says he wants to try ballet; don’t let your daughter give up on sports or science quickly just because she’s a girl. (This column isn’t about raising nongender-conforming kids, but if your kids don’t identify with their assigned gender, please listen to and support them — doing so may help them more than you realize.) Also, limit the number of times you unnecessarily refer to gender in conversation with your kids. Instead of saying “Those girls are playing soccer,” say “Those kids

are playing soccer.” It’s hard: As soon as I started paying attention to gendered language, I realized that I’m constantly saying things like “You’re such a strong girl!” to my daughter, highlighting her gender for no reason. (“You’re so strong” would be better.)

You could also talk to your kids’ teachers about limiting gender distinctions at school. One of Bigler’s studies found that when teachers seated students according to gender and verbally called out their genders (“Hey, boys” and “OK, girls” instead of just “Listen up, students”), they became more likely than other kids to believe gender stereotypes later on. And in a 2010 study, researchers asked preschool teachers to emphasize gender in one classroom for two weeks — they had kids line up by gender, created separate boys’ and girls’ bulletin boards, and labeled groups and individuals according to gender — while teachers in another classroom did the opposite. Before and after the intervention, they tested the students’ gender attitudes. They found that, after the two weeks, students in the gender-emphasized class had stronger gender stereotypes. They also rated peers of the other sex more negatively and played less with them.

It’s kind of a paradox,⁷ then: We should do what we can to limit the cultural and linguistic traditions that emphasize gender distinctions so that, hopefully, our kids won’t get

overly focused on gender differences. At the same time, though, we need to talk to our kids about sexism and gender stereotypes and challenge their sexist and stereotypical comments. Ultimately, this two-pronged approach makes sense. We want our kids to consider girls and boys as equals, but we also need them to build a mental framework that helps them understand — and fight against — everything that stands in equality’s way.

Melinda Wenner Moyer, “Sexism Starts in Childhood,” *SLATE*, November 6, 2017. Copyright © 2017 by The Slate Group. All rights reserved. Used under license.

¹ *misogynistic*: characterized by hatred of women.

² *incessantly*: constantly, without interruption.

³ *egalitarian*: equal in terms of social, political, or economic relationships.

⁴ *demure*: modest, reserved.

⁵ *crux*: the main or central feature.

⁶ *innocuous*: harmless.

⁷ *paradox*: a seemingly contradictory statement or situation.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Moyer begins her essay with a series of questions. Is this an effective introduction strategy? How does the

introduction connect to the conclusion? (Glossary: [Beginnings and Endings](#))

2. Moyer cites multiple academic sources. Identify examples of direct quotes and summaries that she uses. Which of these sources do you find most effective at establishing her credibility? Why? (Glossary: [Supporting Evidence](#))
3. In her final paragraph, Moyer settles on a solution, which she describes as “kind of a paradox.” What specific solution does she offer, and what makes it a paradox?
4. Moyer begins her essay with a personal narrative strategy, and inserts her authorial voice into the work later when she says, “Let me pause here” (10). She also directly addresses the audience several times. Why do you suppose she does this?
5. Moyer uses transitions throughout the essay. Identify three different transitions that she uses to move the reader between topics. How do these transitions help progress her ideas? (Glossary: [Transitions](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Moyer’s essay presents some of the complexities involving the development of gender bias and beliefs about gender. According to her, part of this complexity requires separating “nature from nurture,

even in babies” (6). Do you think that it is possible to separate “nature” from “nurture”? Do you think that Moyer makes a persuasive case for this separation in her essay? Why or why not?

2. Moyer alternates between a formal tone and an informal tone in this essay. (Glossary: [Tone](#)) Identify passages that convey these different tones. Do you find her combination of formal and informal tones effective? Why or why not?
3. Moyer attempts to build a case for how gender stereotypes are created in people, beginning at birth and continuing through adolescence. Using research and outside sources, she identifies the following as factors that influence our beliefs about gender:
 - The language and pronouns adults use when speaking to infants
 - The rigidity of young minds in creating “overgeneral rules and categories”
 - The decisions parents make about toys and clothing
 - Adolescent brain development

Do you think Moyer is successful in demonstrating a cause-effect relationship between each of the above factors and its impact on gender beliefs and behaviors? Do you find some of Moyer’s cause-effect explanations more persuasive than others? Why or why not?

Classroom Activity

Cause-and-effect essays can be written from different perspectives. A writer can look at the effects of an incident or event, or they can look at the root causes of that same incident. Below is a chart which reflects these strategies.

	Effect		Cause	
Cause -----	Effect	OR	Cause -----	Effect
	Effect		Cause	

With two or three classmates, discuss important milestones in your life: for example, high school graduation, your first job, school achievements, sports moments, or theatrical activities. Choose one of these moments to explore. Approach the moment from both cause and effect perspectives, and create two charts of your own in the style of those depicted above. Finally, discuss with your group which strategy is most effective for the topic: beginning with a cause and then considering several effects, or beginning with the effect and then examining the causes. Why do you find this strategy most effective? Here is an example:

STRATEGY 1

Cause

Effect - Money

First job as a library page

Effect - Better exposure to books

Effect - Learned to work with professionals

STRATEGY 2

Cause - Desire for work experience

Effect - First job as a library page

Cause - Desire for money

Cause - Desire for time away from home

Suggested Writing Assignments

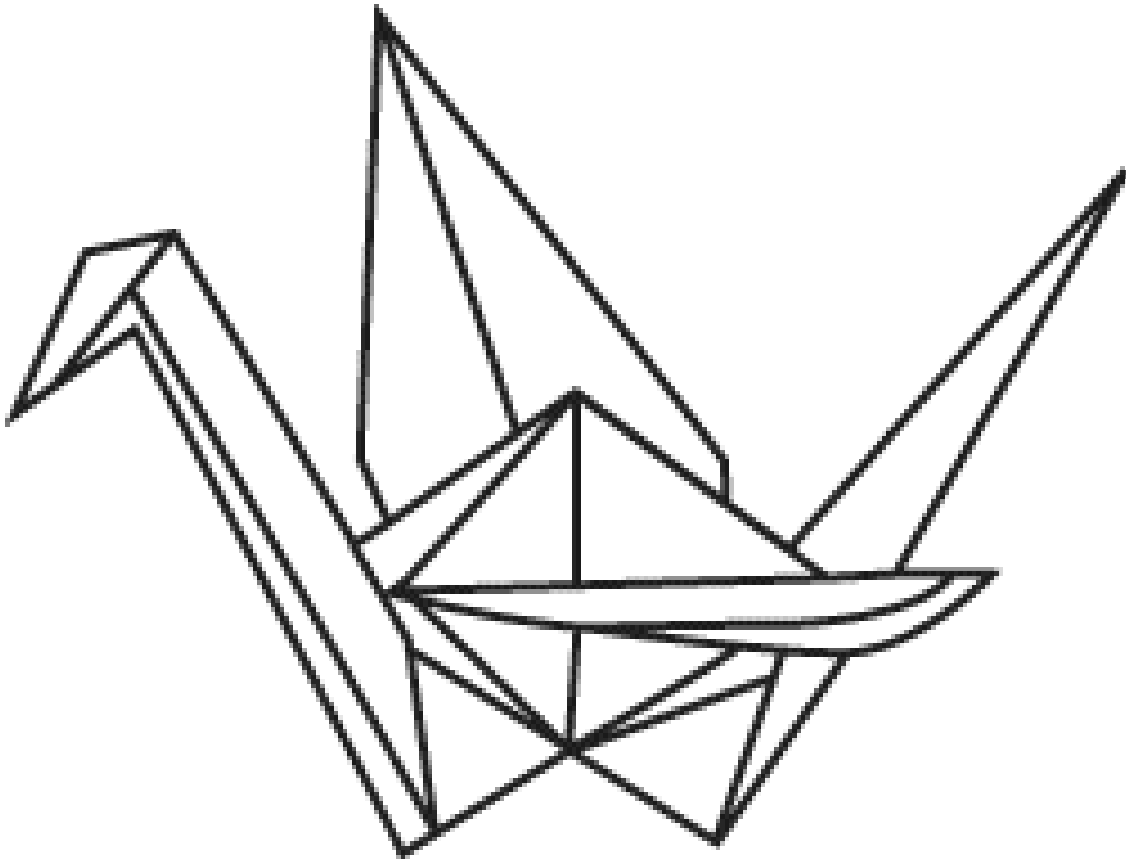
1. Using Moyer's essay as a model, write your own causal analysis essay about another belief that begins in early childhood and transforms with age. You might want to consider relationships you have had with the following topics: hobbies, sports, technology, social media, or nature. Or you can choose a different topic of your own. As you develop your essay, trace the causes and effects that you've personally experienced over time, and consider how those experiences have built upon one another.
2. Moyer highlights the effects of toys on a child's sense of self and gender. In 2019, Mattel created a Braille version of the popular card game Uno. This release had multiple positive effects, including greater accessibility and inclusion of a population that is often neglected by the gaming industry.

Research one of the following toys and highlight the effects it has had on children and culture. Consider both the causes for the toy's creation (i.e., to what audience was the manufacturer trying to appeal?) and effects the toy has created.

- Barbie
- Lammily Doll
- Wonder Crew
- Mattel Gender Neutral Dolls
- Lego Women of NASA
- Batman action figures



CHAPTER 22 Argument



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

The word *argument* probably brings to mind a verbal disagreement of the sort that nearly everyone has encountered. Such disputes are satisfying when you convert someone to your point of view. More often, though, verbal arguments are inconclusive and frustrating because you might fail to make your position understood or may believe that your opponent has been stubborn and unreasonable. Because verbal arguments generally arise spontaneously, they cannot be thoughtfully planned or researched. Indeed, it is often

not until later that the convincing piece of evidence or the forcefully phrased assertion finally comes to mind.

Written arguments share common goals with spoken ones: they attempt to convince a reader to agree with a particular point of view, to make a particular decision, or to pursue a particular course of action. Written arguments, however, usually involve more deliberate argumentation, including the presentation of well-chosen evidence and the artful control of language. Writers of arguments must imagine their probable audience and predict the sorts of objections that may be raised. In written arguments such as academic essays, writers must also choose in advance a specific, sufficiently detailed thesis or proposition. There is a greater need to be organized; to choose the most effective types of evidence from all that is available; and to determine the strategies of rhetoric, language, voice, and style that will best suit the argument's subject, purpose, and thesis and ensure its effect on the intended audience. Such work can be far more satisfying than spontaneous oral argument.

True arguments make assertions about which there is a legitimate and recognized difference of opinion. An argument without an opposing side is not an argument. Readers probably do not need to be convinced that falling in love is a beautiful and intense experience, that crime rates should be reduced, or that computers are changing the world; most

people would agree with such assertions. But not everyone would agree that women experience love more intensely than men, that the death penalty reduces the incidence of crime, or that computers are changing the world for the worse; these assertions are arguable and reveal differing perspectives. Regardless of an argument's form or structure, an argument's primary purpose is to set forth a particular point of view and rebut any opposing views, with the hope of creating change, whether that means changing someone's mind or spurring action. Here are a few more examples of arguments that seek to create change:

- A leading heart specialist might argue in a popular magazine that too many doctors are advising patients to have pacemakers implanted when the devices are not necessary.
- A writer for a small-town newspaper might write an editorial urging that a local agency supplying food to needy families be given a larger percentage of the town's budget.
- A foreign-policy specialist might produce a long and complex book attempting to prove that the current administration exhibits no consistent policy in its relationship with other countries and that the Department of State needs to be overhauled.

Argumentation often uses the other rhetorical strategies covered in [Chapters 14](#) to [21](#). You may find it necessary to

define, to compare and contrast, to analyze causes and effects, to classify, to describe, or to narrate.

THINKING CRITICALLY ABOUT ARGUMENT

Consider Ethos, Logos, and Pathos

Classical thinkers believed that all rhetorical communication has three parts: the *speaker* (or writer) who comments on a *subject* to an *audience*. We may discuss these parts separately, but in actual rhetorical situations they are inseparable, with each influencing the other two. Moreover, the ancients recognized the importance of three elements of argumentation: *ethos*, which is related to the speaker/writer; *logos*, which is related to the subject; and *pathos*, which is related to the audience.

Ethos (the Greek word for “character”) has to do with the authority, credibility, and, to a certain extent, morals of the speaker/writer. The classical rhetoricians believed that the speaker/writer must be credible and argue for a worthwhile cause. Arguing for a questionable cause was not acceptable. But how does one establish credibility? Sometimes it is gained through achievements — that is, the speaker has had experience with an issue, has argued the subject before,

and has been judged to be honest and sincere. In your own writing, establishing such credentials is not always possible, so you will need to be especially concerned with presenting your argument reasonably, sincerely, and without excessive emotion. Finally, you should always respect your audience — as well as your opposition — in your writing.

Logos (Greek for “word”) is related to the subject and is the effective presentation of the argument itself. Is the thesis or claim worthwhile? Is it logical, consistent, and well supported by evidence? Is the evidence factual, reliable, and convincing? Finally, is the argument thoughtfully organized and clearly presented so that it will affect the audience? This aspect of argumentation is the most difficult to accomplish and the most rewarding.

Logical appeals are directed at the audience’ s intellect, understanding, and knowledge. Writers move carefully from assertion to evidence to conclusion and sometimes use an almost mathematical system of proof and counterproof. Logical argument is often found in scientific or philosophical articles, legal decisions, and technical proposals, but also in many disciplines in which writers use rational thought or hard evidence such as statistics.

Arguing logically also means avoiding logical fallacies, or errors that result from faulty reasoning. You can learn more

about these in the box on [pages 523 - 24](#).

Pathos (Greek for “emotion”) relates to the audience and their emotions — their feelings, values, and even their biases and prejudices. These appeals involve diction, figurative language, analogy, rhythmic patterns of speech, and a tone that will encourage a positive response — or a strategic angry response. Persuasion often tries to get the audience to take action. Visuals such as photographs or even certain fonts can also appeal to emotion; music used in film or presentations can have a similar emotional effect.

Be careful in your appeals to emotion. Certain buzzwords, slanted diction, or loaded language can be used by the audience to counterattack or may cause resentment. Remember that audiences can range from friendly and sympathetic to hostile and resistant, with myriad possibilities in between. A friendly audience will welcome new information and support your position; a hostile audience will look for flaws in your logic and examples of dishonest manipulation. When addressing an uncommitted audience, use caution, subtlety, and critical thinking.

Use Inductive and Deductive Reasoning

It is the writer's attempt to convince, not explain, that is of primary importance in an argumentative essay. In this respect, it is helpful to keep in mind that there are two basic patterns of thinking and presenting our thoughts that are followed in argumentation: induction and deduction.

Inductive reasoning, the more common type of reasoning, moves from specific examples to a general statement. The writer makes an *inductive leap* from the evidence to the generalization. For example, after considering enrollment statistics, a writer might conclude that students do not like to take courses offered early in the morning or late in the afternoon.

Deductive reasoning, in contrast, moves from a general statement to a specific conclusion. It works on the model of the syllogism, a three-part argument that consists of a major premise, a minor premise, and a conclusion, as in the following example:

- a. All women are mortal. (*Major premise*)
- b. Jeanne is a woman. (*Minor premise*)
- c. Jeanne is mortal. (*Conclusion*)

A syllogism will fail to work if either of the premises is untrue:

- a. All living creatures are mammals. (*Major premise*)

- b. A butterfly is a living creature. (*Minor premise*)
- c. A butterfly is a mammal. (*Conclusion*)

The problem is immediately apparent. The major premise is false: many living creatures are not mammals, and a butterfly happens to be one of the nonmammals. Consequently, the conclusion is invalid.

☑ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Persuasive Appeals

WRITING ARGUMENTS

Writing an argument is a challenging assignment that can be very rewarding. By nature, an argument must be carefully reasoned and thoughtfully structured to have maximum effect. Therefore, allow yourself enough time to think about your thesis; to gather the evidence you need; and to draft, revise, edit, and proofread your essay. Fuzzy thinking, confused expression, and poor organization will be immediately evident to your reader and will diminish your chances for completing the assignment successfully. The following seven steps will remind you of some key features of arguments and help you sequence your activities as you research and write.

1. Determine the Thesis or Proposition

Begin by deciding on a topic that interests you and that has some significant differences of opinion or some points that you have questions about. Find out what's in the news about your topic, what people are saying about it, and what authors and instructors are emphasizing as important intellectual arguments. As you pursue your research, consider what

assertion or assertions you can make about your topic. The more specific you make the thesis or proposition, the more directed your research can become and the more focused your ultimate argument will be. Don' t hesitate to modify or even reject an initial thesis as your research warrants.

A thesis can be placed anywhere in an argument, but while learning to write arguments, you should place the statement of your controlling idea near the beginning of your composition. Explain the importance of the thesis, and make clear to your reader that you share a common concern or interest in this issue. State your central assertion directly in your first or second paragraph so that your reader will have no doubt or confusion about your position. You may also wish to lead off with a striking piece of evidence to capture your reader' s interest.

2. Take Account of Your Audience

In no other type of writing is the question of audience more important than in argumentation. The tone you establish, the type of diction you choose, the kinds of evidence you select to buttress your assertions, and the organizational pattern you follow can influence your audience to trust you and believe your assertions. If you judge the nature of your audience accurately; respect its knowledge of the subject;

and correctly envision whether it is likely to be hostile, neutral, complacent, or receptive, you will be able to tailor the various aspects of your argument appropriately. (For more on audience, refer to the discussion of ethos, pathos, and logos on [pp. 522 – 24.](#))

3. Gather the Necessary Supporting Evidence

For each point of your argument, provide appropriate and sufficient evidence: verifiable facts and statistics, illustrative examples and narratives, or quotations from authorities. Don't overwhelm your reader with evidence, but don't skimp, either. Demonstrate your command of the topic and control of the thesis by choosing carefully from all the evidence at your disposal.

4. Settle on an Organizational Pattern

Once you think that you have sufficient evidence to make your assertion convincing, consider how best to organize your argument. To some extent, your organization will depend on your method of reasoning — inductive, deductive, or a combination of the two. For example, is it necessary to

establish a major premise before moving on to discuss a minor premise? Have you tested your major and minor premises? Are they valid? Should most of your evidence precede your direct statement of an assertion or follow it? Will induction work better with the particular audience you have targeted? As you present your primary points, you may find it effective to move from least important to most important or from most familiar to least familiar. A scratch outline can help, but often a writer's most crucial revisions in an argument involve rearranging its components into a sharper, more coherent order. Often it is difficult to tell what that order should be until the revision stage of the writing process.

5. Consider and Address Opposition to Your Argument

As you proceed with your argument, you may wish to take into account well-known and significant opposing arguments. To ignore opposing views would be to suggest to your reader any one of the following: you don't know about the opposing views, you know about them and are obviously and unfairly weighting the arguments in your favor, or you know about them and have no reasonable answers for them. Grant the validity of opposing arguments or refute them, but respect your reader's intelligence by addressing the objections to your assertion. Your reader will in turn respect you for doing so.

6. Avoid Faulty Reasoning

Have someone read your argument for errors in judgment and for faulty reasoning. Sometimes others can more easily see problems because they aren't intimately tied to your assertion. These errors are typically called [logical fallacies](#). Review the Logical Fallacies box below, making sure that you have not made any of these errors in reasoning.

Logical Fallacies

Oversimplification: A simple solution to what is clearly a complex problem or a simple solution to a problem that the writer does not fully understand: *We have a balance-of-trade deficit because foreigners make better products than we do.* This fallacy often occurs when the writer attempts to offer a cause for an event — such as a fire, a natural disaster, or a mechanical failure — and doesn't consider other possibilities.

Hasty generalization: A fallacy often found in inductive reasoning (reasoning from the particular to the general) wherein the writer uses too little evidence or evidence that is not representative to reach a conclusion: *My grandparents, like most older folks, don't understand their Social Security benefits.*

Post hoc, ergo propter hoc: (Latin for “After this, therefore because of this.”) Confusing chance with causation. Just because one event comes after another in time does not mean the first event caused the second: *I went swimming yesterday, and the next thing I knew, I had a cold. Every time I wear my orange sweater to a basketball game, we win.* Swimming may or may not be the cause of the cold, and one fan’s clothing is not the reason a team wins or loses.

Begging the question: Arriving at a conclusion based on a premise (a statement used as the basis of an argument) that does not have adequate support:

Gambling is wrong because people should stay away from games of chance. Lying is wrong because it’s always best to tell the truth. The first example describes gambling as a game of chance but does not offer proof of what is wrong with it. In the second example, the arguer has failed to provide proof of anything.

False analogy: An analogy compares something unfamiliar to something familiar with the hope that the unfamiliar becomes more clearly understood. False analogies ignore important dissimilarities between the items being compared and therefore do not serve as proof: *If we can put a man on the moon, we should be able to cure the common cold.* Although the two tasks are scientifically complex, there is no reason

to believe that accomplishing them involves the same knowledge, skills, or processes.

Either/or thinking: The fallacy of seeing only two alternatives in a situation when, in fact, there may be other possibilities. During the great protest era of the 1960s, many citizens demonstrated against the government. Those who were opposed to the demonstrators simplified the problems our country was facing at the time with posters and bumper stickers reading: *America: Love it or leave it!* This either/or thinking ignores the many possibilities for thought and action that lie between the two extremes of loving the country or leaving it.

Non sequitur: (Latin for “It does not follow.”) The writer uses an inference or a conclusion that is not clearly related to the established premises or evidence: *The witness was very sincere and convincing. Her testimony was reliable.* Showing sincerity or being convincing does not necessarily prove the witness’ s reliability. One can be sincere and convincing but also inaccurate.

If you are having difficulty identifying various kinds of logical fallacies, you are not alone. Whereas they are sometimes easier to identify in the writing of others, they are often difficult to identify in our own writing. Logical fallacies sometimes occur because the argument is based on

premises that are not true, the evidence is insufficient for the claims, and erroneous conclusions are drawn. One way to identify logical fallacies in your own writing is to take the position of someone arguing against you. What would you find wrong with your argument and for what reasons? Becoming your own adversary will help you detect and avoid errors in reasoning and strengthen your arguments. Complete the activity in the box below to practice identifying and correcting logical fallacies.

Detecting Logical Fallacies

Each of the following may contain one or more examples of faulty reasoning. Analyze each to determine what, if anything, is wrong with it. If you find an error in logic, determine which of the logical fallacies is occurring and do your best to correct it.

1. Don' t lend books to friends. They never return them.
2. I am not in favor of his argument for a new school because he' s so liberal and likes to spend money.
3. Don' t ever invest in the stock market. You could lose a ton of money.
4. ISIS no longer controls most of its former territory, so we don' t need to be afraid of terrorism any longer.

5. Larry the Cable Guy said to take the medicine he was advertising and not “get heartburn in the first place.”
6. He’ ll make a great coach. He was an excellent quarterback when he played.
7. We ought to close the pool at the hotel because someone drowned there.
8. The juror was released from the drunk-driving case because he had been a binge drinker in college.
9. Reducing the number of unemployment checks a person can receive will result in more people finding jobs.
10. Exit exams for college seniors will improve the quality of instruction.

7. Conclude Forcefully

In the conclusion of your essay, be sure to restate your position in new language, at least briefly. Besides persuading your reader to accept your point of view, you may also want to encourage some specific course of action. Above all, your conclusion should not introduce new information that may surprise your reader. It should seem to follow naturally, almost seamlessly, from the series of points that you have carefully established in the body of the essay. Don’ t overstate your case, but at the same time don’ t qualify your conclusion with the use of too many words or

phrases like *I think*, *in my opinion*, *maybe*, *sometimes*, and *probably*. These words can make you sound indecisive and fuzzy-headed rather than rational and sensible.

☑ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Arguable Claims LearningCurve > Topic, Purpose, and Audience

☑ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Reasoning and Logical Fallacies

TAKING A STAND

Even though you have chosen a topic, gathered information about it, and established a thesis statement or proposition, you need to take a stand — to fully commit yourself to your beliefs and ideas about the issue before you. If you try to work with a thesis that you have not clearly thought through or are confused about, or if you take a position you do not fully believe in or care about, it will show in your writing. Your willingness to research, to dig up evidence, to find the most effective organizational pattern for your material, to construct strong paragraphs and sentences, and to find just the right diction to convey your argument is a direct reflection of just how strongly you take a stand — and how much you believe in that stand. With a strong stand, you can argue vigorously and convincingly.

Becoming Disabled

Rosemarie Garland-Thomson



Courtesy Rosemarie Garland-Thomson

Born in 1946, Rosemarie Garland-Thomson earned her PhD in English from Brandeis University. She is currently a

professor of English and bioethics at Emory University. A strong proponent of disability rights, Garland-Thomson has spent much of her career pioneering the field of critical disability studies, which seeks to analyze the experiences of individuals with disabilities and to develop better strategies for the inclusion of those with disabilities in society. Garland-Thomson was inspired by the disability rights movement and other civil rights movements to assert her identity as a person with a disability and to encourage others with disabilities to assert their identities as well. Garland-Thomson's essays have appeared in *The New York Times*, *The New Yorker*, and the *Huffington Post*. She is also the author of several books, including *Freakery: Cultural Spectacles of the Extraordinary Body* (1996), *Disabilities Studies: Enabling the Humanities* (2002), *Staring: How We Look* (2009), and *Extraordinary Bodies: Figuring Physical Disability in American Culture and Literature* (2010). Garland-Thomson has lectured internationally and has been presented with many awards and honors, including the 2010 Society for Disabilities Senior Scholar Award.

In the following essay, published in *The New York Times* on August 19, 2016, Garland-Thomson advocates for those who have disabilities to assert their identities and for those who do not have disabilities to learn how to cooperate with people in the disability community rather than seeing them as fundamentally broken. As you read, think about Garland-

Thomson' s intended audience and how both her evidence and organizational pattern gradually reveal an expanded target audience.

Reflecting on What You Know

Have others ever made a comment that revealed lack of awareness about an aspect of your identity or personality? If so, how did you react and why? Did you choose to educate them about yourself? Have you ever made such a comment to someone else? How did he or she react?

Not long ago, a good friend of mine said something revealing to me: “I don’ t think of you as disabled,” she confessed.

I knew exactly what she meant; I didn’ t think of myself as disabled until a few decades ago, either, even though my two arms have been pretty significantly asymmetrical¹ and different from most everybody else’ s my whole life.

My friend’ s comment was meant as a compliment, but followed a familiar logic — one that African-Americans have noted when their well-meaning white friends have tried to erase the complications of racial identity by saying, “I don’ t think of you as black,” or when a man compliments a woman by saying that he thinks of her as “just one of the guys.”

This impulse to rescue people with disabilities from a discredited identity, while usually well meaning, is decidedly at odds with the various pride movements we've come to know in recent decades. Slogans like "Black Is Beautiful" and "We're Here, We're Queer, Get Used to It!" became transformative taunts for generations of people schooled in the self-loathing of racism, sexism and heterosexism. Pride movements were the psycho-emotional equivalents of the anti-discrimination and desegregation laws that asserted the rights of full citizenship to women, gay people, racial minorities and other groups. More recently, the Black Lives Matter and the L.G.B.T. rights movement have also taken hold.

Yet pride movements for people with disabilities — like Crip Power or Mad Pride — have not gained the same sort of traction in the American consciousness. Why? One answer is that we have a much clearer collective notion of what it means to be a woman or an African-American, gay or transgender person than we do of what it means to be disabled.

A person without a disability may recognize someone using a wheelchair, a guide dog or a prosthetic² limb, or someone with Down syndrome, but most don't conceptualize these people as having a shared social identity and a political status. "They" merely seem to be people to whom something

unfortunate has happened, for whom something has gone terribly wrong. The one thing most people do know about being disabled is that they don't want to be that.

Yet disability is everywhere once you start noticing it. A simple awareness of who we are sharing our public spaces with can be revelatory. Wheelchair users or people with walkers, hearing aids, canes, service animals, prosthetic limbs or breathing devices may seem to appear out of nowhere, when they were in fact there all the time.

A mother of a 2-year-old boy with dwarfism who had begun attending Little People of America events summed this up when she said to me with stunned wonder, "There are a lot of them!" Until this beloved child unexpectedly entered her family, she had no idea that achondroplasia is the most common form of short stature or that most people with the condition have average-size parents. More important, she probably did not know how to request the accommodations, access the services, enter the communities or use the laws that he needs to make his way through life. But because he is hers and she loves him, she will learn a lot about disability.

The fact is, most of us will move in and out of disability in our lifetimes, whether we do so through illness, an injury or merely the process of aging.

The World Health Organization defines disability as an umbrella term that encompasses impairments, activity limitations and participation restrictions that reflect the complex interaction between “features of a person’s body and features of the society in which he or she lives.” The Americans with Disabilities Act tells us that disability is “a physical or mental impairment that substantially limits one or more major life activities.”

Obviously, this category is broad and constantly shifting, so exact statistics are hard to come by, but the data from our most reliable sources is surprising. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention estimates that one in five adults in the United States is living with a disability. The National Organization on Disability says there are 56 million disabled people. Indeed, people with disabilities are the largest minority group in the United States, and as new disability categories such as neurodiversity, psychiatric disabilities, disabilities of aging and learning disabilities emerge and grow, so does that percentage.

Disability growth areas — if you will — include diagnostic categories such as depression, anxiety disorders, anorexia, cancers, traumatic brain injuries, attention-deficit disorder, autoimmune disease, spinal cord injuries, autistic spectrum disabilities and dementia. Meanwhile, whole categories of disability and populations of people with

certain disabilities have vanished or diminished significantly in the 20th century with improved public health measures, disease prevention and increased public safety.

Because almost all of us will experience disability sometime in our lives, having to navigate one early in life can be a great advantage. Because I was born with six fingers altogether and one quite short arm, I learned to get through the world with the body I had from the beginning. Such a misfit between body and world can be an occasion for resourcefulness. Although I certainly recognized that the world was built for what I call the fully fingered, not for my body, I never experienced a sense of losing capacity, and adapted quite readily, engaging with the world in my preferred way and developing practical workarounds for the life demands my body did not meet. (I used talk-to-text technology to write this essay, for example.)

Still, most Americans don't know how to be disabled. Few of us can imagine living with a disability or using the technologies that disabled people often need. Since most of us are not born into disability but enter into it as we travel through life, we don't get acculturated³ the way most of us do in our race or gender. Yet disability, like any challenge or limitation, is fundamental to being human — a part of every life. Clearly, the border between “us” and

“them” is fragile. We just might be better off preparing for disability than fleeing from it.

Yet even talking about disability can be a fraught experience. The vocabulary of this status is highly charged, and for even the most well-meaning person, a conversation can feel like stepping into a maze of courtesy, correctness and possible offense. When I lecture about disability, someone always wants to know — either defensively, earnestly or cluelessly — the “correct” way to refer to this new politicized identity.

What we call ourselves can also be controversial. Different constituencies have vibrant debates about the politics of self-naming. “People first” language asserts that if we call ourselves “people with disabilities,” we put our humanity first and consider our impairment a modification. Others claim disability pride by getting our identity right up front, making us “disabled people.” Others, like many sign language users, reject the term “disability.”

The old way of talking about disability as a curse, tragedy, misfortune or individual failing is no longer appropriate, but we are unsure about what more progressive, more polite, language to use. “Crippled,” “handicapped” and “feeble-minded” are outdated and derogatory. Many pre-Holocaust eugenic categories that were indicators for state-

sponsored sterilization or extermination policies — “idiot,” “moron,” “imbecile” and even “mentally retarded” — have been discarded in favor of terms such as “developmentally delayed” or “intellectually disabled.” In 2010, President Obama signed Rosa’s Law, which replaced references to “mental retardation” with “intellectual disability” in federal statutes.

The author and scholar Simi Linton writes about learning to be disabled in a hospital after a spinal cord injury — not by way of her rehabilitation but rather by bonding with other young people new to disability. She calls this entering into community “claiming disability.” In “Sight Unseen,” an elegant explication of blindness and sight as cultural metaphors, Georgina Kleege wryly suggests the difference between medical low vision and blindness as a cultural identity by observing that, “Writing this book made me blind,” a process she calls gaining blindness rather than losing sight.

Like them, I had no idea until the 1980s what it meant to be disabled, that there was a history, culture and politics of disability. Without a disability consciousness, I was in the closet.

Since that time, other people with disabilities have entered the worlds in which I live and work, and I have found

community and developed a sturdy disability identity. I have changed the way I see and treat myself and others. I have taken up the job of teaching disability studies and bioethics⁴ as part of my work. I have learned to be disabled.

What has been transformed is not my body, but my consciousness.

As we manage our bodies in environments not built for them, the social barriers can sometimes be more awkward than the physical ones. Confused responses to racial or gender categories can provoke the question “What are you?” Whereas disability interrogations are “What’s wrong with you?” Before I learned about disability rights and disability pride, which I came to by way of the women’s movement, I always squirmed out a shame-filled, “I was born this way.” Now I’m likely to begin one of these uncomfortable encounters with, “I have a disability,” and to complete it with, “And these are the accommodations I need.” This is a claim to inclusion and right to access resources.

This coming out has made possible what a young graduate student with a disability said to me after I gave a lecture at her university. She said that she understood now that she had a right to be in the world.

We owe much of this progress to the Americans with Disabilities Act of 1990 and the laws that led up to it. Starting in the 1960s, a broad disability rights movement encouraged legislation and policy that gradually desegregated the institutions and spaces that had kept disabled people out and barred them from exercising the privileges and obligations of full citizenship. Education, transportation, public spaces and work spaces steadily transformed so that people with disabilities came out of hospitals, asylums, private homes and special schools into an increasingly rebuilt and reorganized world.

That changed landscape is being reflected politically, too, so much so that when Donald Trump mocked the movement of a disabled reporter, most of the country reacted with shock and outrage at his blatant discrimination, and that by the time the Democratic National Convention rolled round, it seemed natural to find the rights and dignity of people with disabilities placed front and center. Hillary Clinton's efforts early in her career to secure the right to an education for all disabled children was celebrated; Tom Harkin, the former Iowa senator and an author of the Americans with Disabilities Act, marked the law's 26th anniversary and called for improvements to it. People with disabilities were featured speakers, including Anastasia Somoza, who received an ovation for her powerful speech. President Obama, in his address, referred to "black, white,

Latino, Asian, Native American; young, old; gay, straight; men, women, folks with disabilities, all pledging allegiance, under the same proud flag.”

Becoming disabled demands learning how to live effectively as a person with disabilities, not just living as a disabled person trying to become nondisabled. It also demands the awareness and cooperation of others who don’ t experience these challenges. Becoming disabled means moving from isolation to community, from ignorance to knowledge about who we are, from exclusion to access, and from shame to pride.

Rosemarie Garland-Thomson, “Becoming Disabled,” *The New York Times*, August 19, 2016. Copyright © 2016 by The New York Times. All rights reserved. Used under license.

¹*asymmetrical*: having two sides or parts that are not the same.

²*prosthetic*: relating to an artificial part or device.

³*acculturated*: accustomed or modified to belong to a group or culture, usually through a long process of exposure and learning.

⁴*bioethics*: the study of the ethics of biological research, especially medical research.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Quote an example of at least one line that reveals Garland-Thomson’ s appeal to *pathos* (Greek for

“emotion”) in the first nine paragraphs of her essay. What emotion is she attempting to evoke in her reader? Is it effective in convincing you to agree with her argument?

2. Why does Garland-Thomson include the World Health Organization’ s definition of disability in the middle of her essay? Does this kind of support help her argument? How?
3. Garland-Thomson writes that “most of us will move in and out of disability in our lifetimes” (9). How does this statement expand her audience? (Glossary: [Audience](#))
4. Garland-Thomson writes of the definition of disability, “Obviously, this category is broad and constantly shifting, so exact statistics are hard to come by, but the data from our most reliable sources is surprising” (11). Here, Garland-Thomson includes a disclaimer to prove that she is avoiding faulty reasoning. Does this disclaimer strengthen or weaken her argument? Explain.
5. Name at least one strategy that Garland-Thomson uses to create a forceful conclusion.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. According to Garland-Thomson, “[The] impulse to rescue people with disabilities from a discredited

identity, while usually well meaning, is decidedly at odds with the various pride movements we've come to know in recent decades" (4). What does she mean that people with disabilities have a "discredited identity"? What might cause a group with a discredited identity to avoid a public display of pride in that identity?

2. One of the important aspects of argumentation is judging the nature of your audience correctly. As you began to read "Becoming Disabled," were you hostile, neutral, complacent, or receptive? Why? Describe a part of the essay that kept you as the same type of reader or that helped you change your position. (Glossary: [Audience](#))
3. Why is Garland-Thomson's title, "Becoming Disabled," so apt? Explain.

Classroom Activity Using Argument

Take a stand! Literally. This is a movement activity that will help you generate a successful thesis statement and build a strong sense of audience for your next essay.

1. On a piece of scrap paper or a notecard, write down an arguable claim or thesis statement, which your professor will then collect.

2. Stand in the front of the classroom. If you are unable to stand, ask your professor to provide necessary accommodation for you, such as a chair in front of the class.
3. Your professor will read aloud one of the thesis statements that he or she has collected.
4. Move to your right as far you can go if you agree with the thesis statement that your professor read aloud (think “right” = “correct”). Move to your far left if you disagree with the statement. Move to the middle if the thesis statement sounds unclear to you or you hold a perspective somewhere in the middle. Feel free to stand anywhere on the continuum between disagreement and agreement and to move your position at any time if you hear ideas from the classroom audience that shift your perspective.
5. Your professor will call on a select number of individuals standing at the front of the class to say why they are standing where they are (according to how much they agree with the statement) and to give examples of their perspectives. He or she will then read as many thesis statements as time permits.
6. When the activity is done, write a paragraph to reflect on what you learned from your classmates (your classroom audience), and to think how what you learned affects your thesis statement. For example, do you need to revise your thesis statement for greater clarity? Even if your thesis statement was

not read aloud, the kinds of comments made during this activity should help you reflect on your own thesis and essay.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write an essay using (or inspired by) one of the following thesis statements:
 - Elementary school students with intellectual disabilities should be placed in mainstream classrooms.
 - Rather than build separate facilities for those with physical disabilities, architects should design buildings that are as accessible to those with physical disabilities as to those without physical disabilities (example: Each bathroom stall should be as accessible to people who use wheelchairs as to people who do not).
 - Online classes empower people with disabilities.
2. Begin the introduction paragraph of an argument essay on a topic of your choice with an anecdote that will appeal to *pathos* (emotion) in your audience. You might start with a story from your life with which you feel some emotional connection or a story that you have recently seen on the news that would create sympathy in your audience. Then try writing the same introduction beginning with an appeal to *logos* (logic

and reason). Select the introduction that works best and write a draft of your essay.

In Praise of the F Word

Mary Sherry



Courtesy of Mary Sherry

Mary Sherry was born in 1941 in Bay City, Michigan. She received a BA from Dominican University and an MBA from the

University of St. Thomas. She later founded a research and publishing company specializing in information for economic and development organizations. About her early writing career, Sherry comments: “My interest in writing began in high school. I wrote for the school paper and wound up as editor my senior year. I started out majoring in math in college but found my writing skills were stronger, so I switched, thinking I would be good at writing technical materials. That eventually happened, but my first nationally published work was based on an experience at a church meeting. I have been observing events, writing about them and getting such essays published ever since.” Sherry has taught in adult-literacy programs and has written essays on educational problems for various newspapers, including *The Wall Street Journal* and *America* magazine. She also served on the city council in her current home of Burnsville, Minnesota, from 1994 to 2016.

In the following essay, originally published in *Newsweek* in 1991, Sherry takes a provocative stance — that the threat of flunking is a “positive teaching tool.” She believes students would be better off if they had a “healthy fear of failure,” and she marshals a series of logical appeals to both clarify and support her argument.

Reflecting on What You Know

Comment on what you see as the relationship between learning and grades. Do teachers and students pay too much attention to grades at the expense of learning? Or are grades not seen as that important?

Tens of thousands of eighteen-year-olds will graduate this year and be handed meaningless diplomas. These diplomas won' t look any different from those awarded their luckier classmates. Their validity will be questioned only when their employers discover that these graduates are semiliterate.

Eventually a fortunate few will find their way into educational-repair shops — adult-literacy programs, such as the one where I teach basic grammar and writing. There, high-school graduates and high-school dropouts pursuing graduate-equivalency certificates will learn the skills they should have learned in school. They will also discover they have been cheated by our educational system.

As I teach, I learn a lot about our schools. Early in each session I ask my students to write about an unpleasant experience they had in school. No writers' block here! "I wish someone would have made me stop doing drugs and made me study." "I liked to party and no one seemed to care." "I was a good kid and didn' t cause any trouble, so they just passed me along even though I didn' t read well and couldn' t write." And so on.

I am your basic do-gooder, and prior to teaching this class I blamed the poor academic skills our kids have today on drugs, divorce, and other impediments to concentration necessary for doing well in school. But, as I rediscover each time I walk into the classroom, before a teacher can expect students to concentrate, he has to get their attention, no matter what distractions may be at hand. There are many ways to do this, and they have much to do with teaching style. However, if style alone won' t do it, there is another way to show who holds the winning hand in the classroom. That is to reveal the trump card¹ of failure.

I will never forget a teacher who played that card to get the attention of one of my children. Our youngest, a world-class charmer, did little to develop his intellectual talents but always got by. Until Mrs. Stifter.

Our son was a high-school senior when he had her for English.

"He sits in the back of the room talking to his friends," she told me. "Why don' t you move him to the front row?" I urged, believing the embarrassment would get him to settle down. Mrs. Stifter looked at me steely-eyed over her glasses.

"I don' t move seniors," she said. "I flunk them." I was flustered. Our son' s academic life flashed before my eyes. No teacher had ever threatened him with that before. I regained my composure and managed to say that I thought she was right. By the time I got home I was feeling pretty good

about this. It was a radical approach for these times, but, well, why not? “She’ s going to flunk you,” I told my son. I did not discuss it any further. Suddenly English became a priority in his life. He finished out the semester with an A.

I know one example doesn’ t make a case, but at night I see a parade of students who are angry and resentful for having been passed along until they could no longer even pretend to keep up. Of average intelligence or better, they eventually quit school, concluding they were too dumb to finish. “I should have been held back” is a comment I hear frequently. Even sadder are those students who are high-school graduates who say to me after a few weeks of class, “I don’ t know how I ever got a high-school diploma.”

Passing students who have not mastered the work cheats them and the employers who expect graduates to have basic skills. We excuse this dishonest behavior by saying kids can’ t learn if they come from terrible environments. No one seems to stop to think that — no matter what environments they come from — most kids don’ t put school first on their list unless they perceive something is at stake. They’ d rather be sailing.

Many students I see at night could give expert testimony on unemployment, chemical dependency, abusive relationships. In spite of these difficulties, they have decided to make

education a priority. They are motivated by the desire for a better job or the need to hang on to the one they' ve got. They have a healthy fear of failure.

People of all ages can rise above their problems, but they need to have a reason to do so. Young people generally don' t have the maturity to value education in the same way my adult students value it. But fear of failure, whether economic or academic, can motivate both.

Flunking as a regular policy has just as much merit today as it did two generations ago. We must review the threat of flunking and see it as it really is — a positive teaching tool. It is an expression of confidence by both teachers and parents that the students have the ability to learn the material presented to them. However, making it work again would take a dedicated, caring conspiracy between teachers and parents. It would mean facing the tough reality that passing kids who haven' t learned the material — while it might save them grief for the short term — dooms them to long-term illiteracy. It would mean that teachers would have to follow through on their threats, and parents would have to stand behind them, knowing their children' s best interests are indeed at stake. This means no more doing Scott' s assignments for him because he might fail. No more passing Jodi because she' s such a nice kid.

This is a policy that worked in the past and can work today. A wise teacher, with the support of his parents, gave our son the opportunity to succeed — or fail. It's time we return this choice to all students.

¹*trump card*: a secret weapon; hidden advantage.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What is Sherry's thesis? (Glossary: [Thesis](#)) What evidence does she use to support her argument?
2. Sherry uses dismissive language to characterize objections to flunking — *cheats* and *dooms*. In your opinion, does she do enough to acknowledge the other side of the argument? Explain.
3. What is the “F word” discussed in the essay? Does referring to it in this way increase the effectiveness of the essay? Why?
4. Who makes up Sherry's audience? (Glossary: [Audience](#)) Are they receptive to the “F word”? Explain your answer.
5. In what way is Sherry qualified to comment on the potential benefits of flunking students? Do you think her induction is accurate?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. According to Sherry, “We must review the threat of flunking and see it as it really is — a positive teaching tool. It is an expression of confidence by both teachers and parents that the students have the ability to learn the material presented to them” (11). How can flunking students be “an expression of confidence” in them? Explain.
2. If schools were to embrace Sherry’s argument and begin flunking students who are not performing at expected levels, the default expectation that every student will pass might be reversed. What risks, if any, would such a change pose for students? What changes might be implemented to help students overcome the risks?
3. What are some of the challenges that teachers face in holding the line on grades and treating student performance realistically? For example, some teachers may be unable or unwilling to be confrontational about poor performance. School administrators may be unwilling to support teachers who need to flunk students, and may prefer instead to place the blame on the teachers themselves. What do you see as the main impediments to grading that accurately reflects students’ performance? How might you address those issues?

Classroom Activity Using Argument

A first-year composition student, Marco Schmidt, is preparing to write an essay in which he will argue that music should be a required course for all public high school students. He has compiled the following pieces of evidence:

- Informal interviews with four classmates. Three of the classmates stated that they would have enjoyed and benefited from taking a music course in high school, and the fourth stated that she would not have been interested in taking music.
- An article from a professional journal for teachers comparing the study habits of students who were involved in music and those who were not. The author, a psychologist, found that students who play an instrument or sing regularly have better study habits than students who do not.
- A brief article from a national newsmagazine praising an inner-city high school's experimental curriculum, in which music classes play a prominent part.
- The personal website of a high school music teacher who posts information about the successes and achievements of her former students.

Discuss these pieces of evidence with your classmates. Which are most convincing? Which provide the least

support for Marco' s argument? Why? What other types of evidence might Marco find to support his argument?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Write an essay in which you argue against Sherry' s thesis. (Glossary: [Thesis](#)) In what ways is flunking bad for students? Are there techniques more positive than a “fear of failure” that can be used to motivate students?
2. Think of something that involves short-term pain or sacrifice but that can be beneficial in the long run. For example, exercising requires exertion, but it may help prevent health problems. Studying and writing papers when you' d rather be having fun or even sleeping may seem painful, but earning a college degree leads to personal growth and development. Even if the benefits are obvious, imagine a skeptical audience, and write an argument in favor of the short-term sacrifice over the long-term consequences of avoiding it. (Glossary: [Audience](#))

It's Time for "They"

Farhad Manjoo



Mindy Best/Getty Images Entertainment/Getty Images

Farhad Manjoo is an American author and journalist who was born in South Africa in 1978. Manjoo graduated in 2000 from

Cornell University, where they served as the editor-in-chief of the student newspaper, the *Cornell Daily Sun*. A contributor to National Public Radio since 2009, Manjoo also wrote for *Slate* magazine from 2008 to 2013. Beginning in 2013, Manjoo covered technology for *The Wall Street Journal* and then became a *New York Times* opinion columnist in 2018.

The following article was published in *The New York Times* on July 10, 2019. As you read, consider the strategies that Manjoo uses to convince readers that using *they* as a singular, gender-neutral pronoun is not only useful, but essential. Notice how specific words show how strongly Manjoo feels about this change in language usage and the social and cultural norms that it represents.

Reflecting on What You Know

Have you heard the word *they* used as a singular, gender-neutral pronoun before? Do you use the singular *they* in reference to yourself or to other people? If so, why? If not, why not?

I am your stereotypical, cisgender, middle-aged suburban dad. I dabble in woodworking, I take out the garbage, and I covet my neighbor's Porsche. Though I do think men should wear makeup (it looks nice!), my tepid masculinity apparently rings loudly enough online and in person that most people guess that I go by "he" and "him." And that's fine; I

will not be offended if you refer to me by those traditional, uselessly gendered pronouns.

But “he” is not what you *should* call me. If we lived in a just, rational, inclusive universe — one in which we were not all so irredeemably obsessed by the particulars of the parts dangling between our fellow humans’ legs, nor the ridiculous expectations signified by those parts about how we should act and speak and dress and feel — there would be no requirement for you to have to assume my gender just to refer to me in the common tongue.

There are, after all, few obvious linguistic advantages to the requirement. When I refer to myself, I don’ t have to announce my gender and all the baggage it carries. Instead I use the gender-nonspecific “I.” Nor do I have to bother with gender when I’ m speaking directly to someone or when I’ m talking about a group of people. I just say “you” or “they.”

So why does standard English impose a gender requirement on the third-person singular? And why do elite cultural institutions — universities, publishers and media outlets like *The Times* — still encourage all this gendering? To get to my particular beef: When I refer to an individual whose gender I don’ t know here in *The Times*, why do I usually have to choose either “he” or “she” or, in the clunkiest

phrase ever cooked up by small-minded grammarians, “he or she” ?

The truth is, I shouldn’ t have to. It’ s time for the singular “they.” Indeed, it’ s well past time — and I’ d like to do my part in pushing “they” along.

So: If you write about me, interview me, tweet about me, or if you are a Fox News producer working on a rant about my extreme politics, I would prefer if you left my gender out of it. Call me “they” or “them,” as in: “Did you read Farhad’ s latest column — they’ ve really gone off the deep end this time!” And — unless you feel strongly about your specific pronouns, which I respect — I would hope to call you “they” too, because the world will be slightly better off if we abandoned unnecessary gender signifiers as a matter of routine communication. Be a “him” or “her” or anything else in the sheets, but consider also being a “they” and “them” in the streets.

I suspect my call will be dismissed as useless virtue-signaling, but there are several clear advantages, both linguistic and cultural, to the singular “they.” One of the main ones is that it’ s ubiquitous. According to linguists who study gender and pronouns, “they” and “them” are increasingly and widely seen as legitimate ways to refer to an individual, both generically and specifically, whether you

know their gender or not — as I just did right in this sentence.

“In our latest study, 90 percent of the time when people refer to a hypothetical person, they use ‘they,’ ” said Evan Bradley, who studies language and gender at Penn State.

But “they” is also used so commonly to refer to specific individuals that it doesn’ t trip people up. The same thing isn’ t true when you add a new, neutral pronoun to the language — something like “ze,” which in Bradley’ s research was not recognized by many people, and when it was used, it was often taken to refer specifically to gender-nonconforming people.

By contrast, “they” is universal and purely neutral, Bradley told me. When people encounter it, they infer nothing about gender. This makes singular “they” a perfect pronoun — it’ s flexible, inclusive, unobtrusive¹ and obviates the risk of inadvertent misgendering.² And in most circumstances, it creates perfectly coherent sentences that people don’ t have to strain to understand.

That’ s probably why the singular, gender-neutral “they” is common not just in transgender and nonbinary communities, for whom it is necessary, but also in mainstream usage, where it is rapidly becoming a standard way we refer to all people. If

you watch closely, you’ ll see the usage in marketing copy, on social media, in app interfaces and just about everywhere else you look. For instance, when Uber or Lyft wants to tell you that your driver has arrived, they send you a notification that says something like: “Juan is almost here. Meet them outside.”

Other than plainly intolerant people, there’ s only one group that harbors doubts about the singular “they” : grammarians. If you’ re one of those people David Foster Wallace called a “snoot,” Lyft’ s use of “them” to refer to one specific Juan rings grammatically icky to you. The singular, gender nonspecific “they” has been common in English as long as people have spoken English, but since the 18th century, grammar stylists have discouraged it on the grounds that “they” has to be plural. That’ s why institutions that cater to snoots generally discourage it. *The Times*, whose stylebook allows the singular “they” when the person being referred to prefers it, warns against its widespread usage: “Take particular care to avoid confusion if using they for an individual” the stylebook counsels.

I think that’ s too cautious; we should use “they” more freely, because language should not default to the gender binary. One truth I’ ve come to understand too late in life is how thoroughly and insidiously our lives are shaped by gender norms. These expectations are felt most acutely and

tragically by those who don' t conform to the standard gender binary — people who are transgender or nonbinary, most obviously.

But even for people who do mainly fit within the binary, the very idea that there is a binary is invisibly stifling. Every boy and girl feels this in small and large ways growing up; you unwittingly brush up against preferences that don' t fit within your gender expectations, and then you must learn to fight those expectations or strain to live within them.

But it was only when I had a son and a daughter of my own that I recognized how powerfully gendered constructs shape our development. From their very earliest days, my kids, fed by marketing and entertainment and (surely) their parents' modeling, seemed to hem themselves into silly gender norms. They gravitated to boy toys and girl toys, boy colors and girl colors, boy TV shows and girl TV shows. This was all so sad to me: I see them limiting their thoughts and their ambitions, their preferences and their identity, their very liberty, only to satisfy some collective abstraction. And there' s little prospect for escape: Gender is a ubiquitous prison for the mind, reinforced everywhere, by everyone, and only rarely questioned.

We' re a long way from eradicating these expectations in society. But we don' t have to be wary about eradicating them

in language.

“Part of introducing the concept of gender-neutral pronouns to people is to get them to ask, ‘Why does this part of society need to be gendered in the first place?’ ” said Jay Wu, director of communications at the National Center for Transgender Equality. They continued: “Part of how we fix that is more and more people noticing that things are so gendered and being like, why does it have to be that way? What benefit does it bring us?”

None, I say, other than confusion, anxiety and grief. Call me “they,” and I’ll call you “them.” I won’t mind, and I hope you won’t, either.

Farhad Manjoo, “It’s Time for ‘They’ ,” *The New York Times*, July 10, 2019. Copyright © 2017 by The New York Times. All rights reserved. Used under license.

¹*unobtrusive*: not obvious or aggressive.

²*misgendering*: identifying a person’s gender incorrectly.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What methods does Manjoo use to express their argument? What types of examples do they provide to

argue that “it’ s time for the singular ‘they’ ” (5)?

2. Manjoo quotes both Jay Wu and Evan Bradley to support their argument. How do Wu and Bradley contribute to the discussion?
3. Manjoo claims to have witnessed their children “limiting their thoughts and ambitions, their preferences and their identities, their very liberty” by following “silly” gender norms (15). What kinds of actions, specifically, is Manjoo writing about? Can you relate to similar limitations in your own experience?
4. Manjoo refers to “snoots” (12) and their resistance to the use of *they* as a singular pronoun. What is the snoots’ argument, and how does Manjoo reject it?
5. Manjoo starts this essay with a fairly humorous tone, but look at the contrast they create by describing gender as a “ubiquitous prison for the mind, reinforced everywhere, by everyone, and only rarely questioned” (15). What effect do those strong words have on the reader?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Manjoo imagines a world where “we were not all so irredeemably obsessed by the particulars of the parts dangling between our fellow humans’ legs” (2). Who

is the “we” that Manjoo refers to here? Does “we” mean all people, or to specific groups of people? How can you tell?

2. In this essay, Manjoo uses the first-person point of view, self-identifying as “your stereotypical, cisgender, middle-aged dad” (1). How do you think Manjoo’s identity and experience serve to clarify the perspective presented in this essay? Do you feel that Manjoo’s identity and experience effectively support their argument?
3. Who do you think is the audience for this essay, specifically? Does Manjoo address specific groups or types of people? Are there any points of view on the topic that Manjoo doesn’t speak to? Explain.

Classroom Activity Using Argument

In small groups, brainstorm lists of advantages and disadvantages of using the traditional third-person pronouns *he* and *she*. Then produce a similar list of advantages and disadvantages of the singular *they*.

Overall, which pronoun or pronouns do you and your group prefer: *he* and *she*, or the singular *they*? Why?

Suggesting Writing Assignments

1. Explore other ways that English grammar and social customs require gender reference — for example, you might say “Mr./Ms./Mrs./Miss” or “ma’ am/sir,” depending on the gender of the person you are addressing. Do these words represent the same or different challenges for writers and speakers as the traditional third-person pronouns *he* and *she*? Draft an essay, using some of Manjoo’ s techniques, to argue for or against changing these conventions.
2. Manjoo claims that when using traditional gender pronouns, “you unwittingly brush up against preferences that don’ t fit within your gender expectations, and then you must learn to fight those expectations or strain to live within them” (14). Do you agree with this perspective? Write a brief persuasive essay in which you explain why you agree or disagree. To support your argument, you may use material from Manjoo’ s essay, from other reading selections in *Models for Writers*, or from your own personal experience.

IS COLLEGE WORTH THE COST?

The authors of the three essays in this casebook set out to answer a question that may seem straightforward at first glance, but proves deceptively complex: Are the benefits of a college education worth it, considering the cost? The authors' interest in this topic is driven by the trend of increasing college tuition, combined with growing concern that these increasing costs may put college out of reach for many people in the United States. According to *U.S. News and World Report*, the average cost of college from 2000 to 2019 increased by 154% at private institutions and by 181% at public institutions. As a result, the average student today graduates with more debt than ever before. In response to these dynamics, the cost of college has become a major concern in the American national consciousness. Many companies have implemented student loan assistance programs as part of their benefits packages to entice young applicants. Politicians have increasingly attempted to address the cost of college, proposing policies ranging from free or reduced college tuition to forgiving student loan debt altogether.

Given the real, significant cost increases over the last several decades, is college still worth it? And, perhaps more

significantly, what do we actually mean by “worth it”? As the authors in this casebook point out, one way of measuring *worth* is purely financial: that is, does a college degree give students access to jobs that pay well enough to offset tuition costs? But on another, deeper level, the authors also consider the worth of the whole college experience — including the development of critical thinking skills, and the idea of higher education as a good in and of itself — separate from material concerns.

First, in “College May Not Be Worth It Anymore,” Ellen Ruppel Shell argues that the costs and benefits of college in the United States are linked to economic inequality, and that the payoff from a college degree varies greatly depending on each student’s socioeconomic class. Next, Logan Smith takes the discussion further in “Think for Yourself and Question the Benefits of Higher Education.” He posits that a college degree is worth it for some people and not others, and that the answer ultimately depends on each individual’s goals. Lastly, in “Will College Pay Off?” Peter Cappelli undertakes an in-depth analysis of the costs and benefits at various types of institutions and with different types of degrees. Overall, the three selections paint a complicated picture of higher education. While there may be no easy or simple answer to the question of whether college is worth it, the arguments in this unit will help you think about different aspects of the problem and decide where you stand

on the issue. As you read each essay, think about which arguments you find most persuasive — and why.

College May Not Be Worth It Anymore

Ellen Ruppel Shell



Ellen Ruppel

Ellen Ruppel Shell (b. 1952) grew up in Auburn, New York, and received her BA from the University of Rochester in 1974. She

is currently a professor of journalism at Boston University who writes, speaks, and comments on many topics, including consumer culture, economics, environmental matters, and social justice. A contributing editor for *The Atlantic*, Shell has also written articles for many other national publications, including *Scientific American*, *The Los Angeles Times*, *The Guardian*, *The Washington Post*, and *The New York Times*. She is also the author of four books: *A Child's Place: A Year in the Life of a Day Care Center* (1992), *The Hungry Gene: The Science of Fat and the Future of Thin* (2002), *Cheap: The High Cost of Discount Culture* (2009), and *The Job: Work and Its Future in a Time of Radical Change* (2018).

In the following essay, originally published in *The New York Times* on May 16, 2018, Shell connects the costs and benefits of a college education with economic inequality. She argues that the financial benefit of a college degree varies greatly depending on a student's socioeconomic status. In other words, in her view, a college degree may merely perpetuate society's financial imbalance and may not be worth it for all students.

Reflecting on What You Know

What does a college degree mean to you? For example, does it mean financial security, more job opportunities, or the

chance to pursue your dreams? Consider why a college degree connotes these things for you.

Last year, New York became the first state to offer all but its wealthiest residents tuition-free access to its public community colleges and four-year institutions. Though this Excelsior Scholarship didn't make college completely free, it highlights the power of the pro-college movement in the United States.

Recent decades have brought agreement that higher education is, if not a cure, then at least a protection against underemployment and the inequality it engenders. In 2012, President Barack Obama called a college degree an “economic imperative¹ that every family in America has to be able to afford.”

Americans strove to rise to that challenge: A third of them ages 25 to 29 now hold at least a bachelor's degree, and many paid heavily for the privilege. By last summer, Americans owed more than \$1.3 trillion in student loans, more than two and a half times what they owed a decade earlier.

Young people and their families go into debt because they believe that college will help them in the job market. And on average it does. But this raises a question: Does higher education itself offer that benefit, or are the people who

earn bachelor's degrees already positioned to get higher-paying jobs?

If future income was determined mainly by how much education people received, then you would assume that some higher education would be better than none. But this is often not the case.

People who have dropped out of college — about 40 percent of all who attend — earn only a bit more than do people with only a high school education: \$38,376 a year versus \$35,256. For many, that advantage is barely enough to cover their student loan debt.

And not all have even that advantage: African-American college dropouts on average earn less than do white Americans with only a high school degree. Meanwhile, low-income students of all races are far more likely to drop out of college than are wealthier students. Even with scholarships or free tuition, these students struggle with hefty fees and living costs, and they pay the opportunity cost of taking courses rather than getting a job.

The value of a college degree also varies depending on the institution bestowing it. The tiny minority of students who attend elite colleges do far better on average than those who attend nonselective ones. Disturbingly, black and Hispanic

students are significantly less likely than are white and Asian students to attend elite colleges, even when family income is controlled for. That is, students from wealthy black and Hispanic families have a lower chance of attending an elite college than do students from middle-class white families.

It's a cruel irony that a college degree is worth less to people who most need a boost: those born poor. This revelation was made by the economists Tim Bartik and Brad Hershbein. Using a body of data, the Panel Study of Income Dynamics, which includes 50 years of interviews with 18,000 Americans, they were able to follow the lives of children born into poor, middle-class and wealthy families.

They found that for Americans born into middle-class families, a college degree does appear to be a wise investment. Those in this group who received one earned 162 percent more over their careers than those who didn't.

But for those born into poverty, the results were far less impressive. College graduates born poor earned on average only slightly more than did high school graduates born middle class. And over time, even this small "degree bonus" ebbed away, at least for men: By middle age, male college graduates raised in poverty were earning less than nondegree holders born into the middle class. The scholars conclude,

“Individuals from poorer backgrounds may be encountering a glass ceiling² that even a bachelor’s degree does not break.”

The authors don’t speculate as to why this is the case, but it seems that students from poor backgrounds have less access to very high-income jobs in technology, finance and other fields. Class and race surely play a role.

We appear to be approaching a time when, even for middle-class students, the economic benefit of a college degree will begin to dim. Since 2000, the growth in the wage gap between high school and college graduates has slowed to a halt; 25 percent of college graduates now earn no more than does the average high school graduate.

Part of the reason is oversupply. Technology increased the demand for educated workers, but that demand has been consistently outpaced by the number of people — urged on by everyone from teachers to presidents — prepared to meet it.

No other nation punishes the “uneducated” as harshly as the United States. Nearly 30 percent of Americans without a high school diploma live in poverty, compared to 5 percent with a college degree, and we infer that this comes from a lack of education. But in 28 other wealthy developed countries, a lack of a high school diploma increases the probability of

poverty by less than 5 percent. In these nations, a dearth of education does not predestine citizens for poverty.

It shouldn' t here, either: According to the Bureau of Labor Statistics, fewer than 20 percent of American jobs actually require a bachelor' s degree. By 2026, the bureau estimates that this proportion will rise, but only to 25 percent.

Why do employers demand a degree for jobs that don' t require them? Because they can.

What all this suggests is that the college-degree premium³ may really be a no-college-degree penalty. It' s not necessarily college that gives people the leverage to build a better working life, it' s that not having a degree decreases whatever leverage they might otherwise have.

This distinction is more than semantic. It is key to understanding the growing chasm between educational attainment and life prospects. For most of us, it' s not our education that determines our employment trajectory but rather where that education positions us in relation to others.

None of this is to suggest that higher education is not desirable: I' ve encouraged my own children to take that path. But while we celebrate the most recent crop of college

graduates, we should also acknowledge the many more Americans who will never don a cap and gown. They, too, deserve the chance to prove themselves worthy of good work, and a good life.

Ellen Ruppell Shell, “College May Not Be Worth It Anymore,” *The New York Times*, May 16, 2018. Copyright © 2018 by The New York Times. All rights reserved. Used under license.

1*imperative*: a duty or responsibility.

2*glass ceiling*: a barrier that prevents further advancement in one’s career or life.

3*premium*: financial compensation above what a person would normally receive.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. In paragraphs 1 to 3, how does Shell establish her credibility?
2. According to Shell, “What all this suggests is that the college-degree premium may really be a no-college-degree penalty” (16). What does she mean?
3. In paragraph 9, Shell writes, “It’s a cruel irony that a college degree is worth less to people who most need a boost: those born poor.” If you were going to use this idea in your own research paper, how would you paraphrase it? (Glossary: [Paraphrase](#))

4. Identify and explain at least one strategy that Shell uses to create a forceful conclusion. (Glossary: [Beginning and Endings](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Does Shell use inductive or deductive reasoning? Explain how you know. (Glossary: [Deduction](#); Glossary: [Induction](#))
2. In paragraph 14, Shell writes, “Technology increased the demand for educated workers, but that demand has been consistently outpaced by the number of people [...] prepared to meet it.” Does she adequately support her claim that technology increased demand for “educated workers”? Why or why not? What additional examples can you think of that support or oppose this claim?
3. Who is the audience for this article? (Glossary: [Audience](#)) Explain using evidence from the text.

Classroom Activity Using Argument

One way to gain some experience in formulating an argumentative position on an issue and establishing your own thesis is to engage in a debate with someone who is

on the other side of the question. When we listen to arguments and think of refutations and counterarguments, we have a chance to rehearse and revise our position before we put it in written form.

Try this exercise using Shell' s question about the worth of a college education. Divide the class into pro and con sides. Each side should elect a spokesperson to present that group' s argument before the class. Have the class estimate of the success of each side in (1) articulating the position, (2) presenting ideas and evidence supporting that position, and (3) convincing the audience of its position. This classroom activity should give you some idea of the kind of work involved in preparing a written argument.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. The Reflecting on What You Know prompt before this reading selection asked you to consider what college means for you. Now that you' ve read Shell' s essay, consider what you could do in addition to required coursework that will help you achieve what you want out of college. For instance, you might secure an internship while pursuing your degree to help land a job after college. Write a short essay that makes

recommendations to incoming college students as to what they can do outside of class to support their education goals.

2. After carefully scrutinizing Shell' s argument, write a letter to her as your future self. In your letter, carefully illustrate — with at least three imagined future successes — how a college degree proved worth it for you.

*Think for Yourself and Question the Benefits of
Higher Education*

Logan Smith



Foundation for Economic Education

Logan Smith is a manager and senior consultant at Deloitte, one of the largest accounting organizations in the world. His previous professional experience includes positions at IBM and Liberty University. He holds a BS in Business Administration and Management from Virginia Tech and a MA in Intercultural Studies from the College at Southeastern.

The following essay was originally published online by the Foundation for Economic Education, a libertarian nonprofit organization, on July 2, 2019. In it, Smith posits that a college degree may be worth it for some people and not others, depending on each individual's personal and professional goals. He argues that the commonly assumed value proposition of college — that it is the path to a “good life” — has changed, and thus, how our society views the value of a degree should change, too.

Reflecting on What You Know

Consider what a “good life” is. For many people in the twentieth century, it was a home in the suburbs with children and a yard for them to play in. What is it now? What does a “good life” look like for you?

Graduation season has once again concluded, and 1.9 million Americans have left college behind and graduated with a bachelor's degree. The social and cultural pressures to attend college are high, and the financial expense to do so

is just as acute.¹ Major presidential candidates gin up their base by empathetically promising to absolve the self-inflicted financial troubles of student loans, blissfully punishing those who made sound financial college decisions. While presidential candidates are showcasing the victims of so-called nefarious student loans, celebrities are bribing university officials with millions of dollars simply to grant their children admission to state schools.

Does College Lead to the “Good Life” ?

Why has America become so obsessed with an 8 x 11-inch piece of paper? With the advent of the internet, all the information in the history of the world is practically at our fingertips. We tend to forget much of what we learned in college a short while after graduation, anyway, and the companies we work for are often more than willing to take the tax write-off to train employees with the skills they actually need. In light of these realities, it’s time to recognize that a four-year college education should no longer be considered a prerequisite, or even a favored pathway, to the “good life.”

The human drive toward attaining the “good life,” winning accolades, and earning respect from peers is nothing new. From the University of Karueein (859 AD) to the University of Phoenix Online, humans are attempting to better themselves

through experience and education. Originally, higher education was intended to produce academics — the world's philosophers and researchers. Its purpose was primarily the pursuit of knowledge and attainment of objective truth to assist in the interpretation of this reality.

But in 2019, in the United States of America, the guiding intent of higher education appears to have changed entirely. College degrees are about opening the door to the ideal job post-graduation (usually with a bit of binge-drinking and other extracurriculars thrown in for good measure). The college experience has become a path toward financial stability and not the method for attaining and discovering knowledge for knowledge's sake.

With this incentive shift toward monetary outcomes as the point of one's college experience, individuals and the culture at large are placing increasing emphasis on graduating at any cost. At times, when the four-year degree fails to provide an attractive job, the debt-laden recent grad will decide to gamble on the next degree with the hope of hitting the employment jackpot. And the costs can be high — enormous student loans, the opportunity cost of the time spent in college, or even the risk of incriminating oneself in a bribery scheme.

Students Are Crushed by College Debt

In fact, 44 million borrowers have collectively over 1.5 trillion in student loan debt, and the average student now graduates with \$37,172 in student loans. The federal government is routinely providing loans that would not be available in the private sector because of the associated risk. Except for individuals in STEM programs, the likelihood that a recent graduate will find a job closely related to their major is incredibly slim, and the return on investment (four years of time and \$100,000 in costs) is arguably non-existent.

The time and money spent to attain a college degree allow graduates to make a claim to a higher authority of one's capabilities. In today's generally atomized,² fragmented, and city-centric society, most employers don't live in a community where a young person's skills and maturity are known and trusted. In this world, the diploma's claim to authority seems to be necessary and convenient. However, people are starting to doubt the diploma's authority due to degree inflation (i.e., nearly everyone has one).

Further, if a student can gain admission to a university based on bribery when he or she otherwise wouldn't have met the entrance criteria but the student can still pass all the course work, then the academic credentials of the institution cannot be trusted. The college degree becomes an elitist and

classist rubber stamp of approval that further separates those with means from those without.

Corporations can easily provide an alternative to this culturally imposed debt trap, and many are starting to do so. They can accept competent applicants fresh out of high school and train them to perform the needed jobs. This model benefits the non-college educated individual (or the pre-college educated individual) because he or she can both earn an income and gain four years of employment experience rather than attending college full-time.

Market Forces in Higher Education

The model also enables greater flexibility and profitability for corporations (with subsequent benefits to the people those businesses serve) because they can pay non-college educated individuals less since these new hires aren't desperate to recoup financial losses from a college degree. If the social pressures toward a four-year college degree taper off, a majority of rational actors could be expected to jump at these opportunities and leave true academics to the academy.

There remains a genuine need for academics and for institutions of higher learning, research, and discussion. However, individuals who attend these institutions should be

those who are seeking the truth, developing their knowledge base, and strengthening their critical thinking — not simply treating college as their only path toward the American dream or general maturation.

Human maturation and personal development should and will occur regardless of the situation or context in which people find themselves. But the academy is a place for research, development, and thought that does not innately or immediately bring with it financial reward. If there is a financial reward associated with it, market forces will fund such endeavors.

The current societal obsession with college degrees frequently creates more barriers to entry and heavy negative trade-offs for individuals who are simply looking to work hard and support their families. Whether America's rising generation engages in “dirty jobs” or white collar jobs,³ college degrees should become a nice-to-have and not a must-have.

¹*acute*: serious, severe.

²*atomized*: made up of many individual pieces or fragments.

³*white collar jobs*: professional jobs, often considered to be high-status, which frequently require a college degree.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Smith uses headings to break down his argument. Do you think this organization helps his argument? Why or why not?
2. Smith writes, “With this incentive shift toward monetary outcomes as the point of one’s college experience, individuals and the culture at large are placing increasing emphasis on graduating at any cost” (5). What does he mean? Paraphrase his ideas in one to two sentences.
3. Smith begins paragraph 8 with the transition word “further.” (Glossary: [Transition](#)) How does this transition help his organization? What idea is he furthering?
4. According to Smith, how should we change the way we think about higher education? Explain using specific examples from the text.

Questions for Critical Reading

1. How would you describe Smith’s tone? (Glossary: [Tone](#)) Use specific examples from the text to explain.
2. In paragraph 4, Smith writes, “The college experience has become a path toward financial stability and not the method for attaining and

discovering knowledge for knowledge's sake.” In your experience, is this true for every college degree? Is it true for the degree that you are currently pursuing? Explain.

3. This reading, as well as the other readings in this casebook, discusses the costs and benefits of college. When making an educational decision, which costs and which benefits are most important to you?

Classroom Activity Using Argument

Organizing your argument effectively can be the key to persuading your audience. Depending on the complexity of the argument you are making, as well as your audience, you could present the same set of information and order it in different ways. Suppose, for example, you wanted to make the case that hydraulic fracturing — more commonly called fracking — is harmful to the environment. You could present the risks from least hazardous to most hazardous, or you could describe the process of fracking, noting areas of concern along the way.

In order to see how this works, first make a list of supporting details on the topic of your choice. Then

organize them according to any two of the following principles:

- From best to worst
- By process
- From least important to most important
- From simplest to most complicated
- From general to specific

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. According to Smith, “it’ s time to recognize that a four-year college education should no longer be considered a prerequisite, or even a favored pathway, to a good life” (2). Write a short essay in which you argue why he is correct or incorrect. You may support your argument with evidence drawn from his essay, from other readings in this book, or from your own personal experience.
2. All of the readings in this casebook encourage readers to look at the decision to attend college as something that should be objective and rational. In what ways is it? In what ways is it not either objective or rational? Write a brief essay in which you answer these questions.

Will College Pay Off?

Peter Cappelli



Courtesy of Peter Cappelli

Peter Cappelli is the George W. Taylor Professor of Management at the Wharton School of the University of

Pennsylvania. He is also a research associate at the National Bureau of Economic Research in Cambridge, Massachusetts. With degrees in industrial relations from Cornell University and in labor economics from Oxford University, Cappelli has served as a guest scholar at universities across the United States and with a variety of governmental organizations. He has published research on human resource practices, public policy on employment, and talent and performance management. His books include *Why Good People Can't Get Jobs* (2012) and *Will College Pay Off? A Guide to the Most Important Financial Decision You'll Ever Make* (2015).

In this selection from *Will College Pay Off?*, Cappelli evaluates the difficulty of deciding whether to attend college — and deciding which college to attend. Taking a detail-oriented approach, he compares the costs and benefits of different degrees at different types of schools.

Reflecting on What You Know

We make financial decisions every day. Some are small, like whether it's worth driving an extra two miles to save on gas, and some are big, like choosing which college to attend. Either way, we typically weigh the pros and cons of different options before we make any decision. What was the last big financial decision you made? What were some of the costs and benefits you considered?

Let's start with the costs. While tuition, room and board, and other charges are pretty clear, possible amounts of financial aid are less so. Then how should we calculate the "cost" of the time involved in college? What should we assume students would be doing otherwise? If they were working, what would they be doing, and how much would they be earning?

And complicating the calculation are points most people ignore: What if the student takes more than four years to graduate? What if he or she does not graduate at all? One or both of these troubling outcomes happen to the majority of students who enter college every year.

Then how should we think about the returns? The graduates would have been earning something even if they didn't go to college, so not everything they earn should be credited to the college. Once again, because more privileged and able people tend to go to college, they likely would be earning more than a typical person without a college degree. Then we have the problem, as they say in finance, that past returns are not necessarily indicative of future returns. Should we assume that one's wages in the future will be the same as they are for the average employee at the moment? That may be our best guess, but it may not be especially accurate.

Finally we have the problem that different bachelor' s degrees are not comparable from a labor-market perspective. A finance degree from an elite college positions one in a completely different labor market from a dance degree granted by a mediocre college. The variance in prospects across colleges and across degrees is so great that talking about "average" returns is irrelevant for an individual making a financial decision about which college to attend.

How one addresses these different issues, or whether they are addressed, explains why the estimates of the returns on a college degree vary so much. The Brookings Institution' s Hamilton Project, for example, calculates that the rate of return will be 15 percent per year, a terrific rate that beats all standard financial investments.¹ These returns, though, assume that everyone who enters college will graduate and that they will do so in four years, a heroic assertion at best, and that there is nothing different between the average person who stops his or her education with high school and the person who goes on to college and completes college except for that degree. They also assume that the college wage premium for every age group will be the same over the lifetime of a new graduate as it is now — that is, when today' s graduate turns thirty, the wage premium will be what it is for those who are age thirty now; when he or she turns fifty in twenty-five years or so, it will be what it is for

those who are age fifty today. As a reminder, the college wage premium right now is the highest in modern times.

Suppose someone offered you an opportunity to invest in a stock and promised you a rate of 15 percent per year on the basis of the assumption that current performance, which is at its peak, will remain unchanged. Would you take it? It certainly sounds attractive, but the person making the offer would be arrested because security lawsⁱ do not allow one to make claims like that for stocks precisely because there is no reason to believe it will be true — hence the caveatⁱⁱ that prior returns are not necessarily proof of future returns. But claims like these are commonplace in the world of college education.

There are other estimates of the return on a college degree that don't turn out so well. One of the best known and most sophisticated is conducted by the PayScale company, whose main business is to collect salary data. It works backward from personal information from about 17 million individuals to estimate the return on specific college degrees, in fact, for specific colleges. It makes some crucial and more realistic assumptions, such as including the probability that a student will take longer than four years to graduate from a given college. But it makes a similar assumption that future wage premiumsⁱⁱⁱ will look like current wage premiums, albeit using a college-by-college measure of the wage premium.

What PayScale reports is a college-by-college rate of return for bachelor's degrees from 1,310 different colleges, and those results are stunning in their variety. Brigham Young and Georgia Tech both top the list with a 12.5 percent annual return, but there are many schools that generate a negative return. The return at about one hundred colleges fails to keep up with inflation. Overall, the rate of return in this study is about half that given in the Brookings report.²

Businessweek teamed up with PayScale to do a separate calculation that included some additional and, it turns out, crucial adjustments, such as accounting for the fact that the college grads would have earned more if they had not gone to college than would the average high school grad. The reason, as we've noted throughout, is that they tend to have more abilities and relevant resources even before going to college. Out of the 835 colleges *Businessweek* examined, a stunning 191 — almost one in four — had a negative return on investment.³ The best thing a student in those schools could do to improve their rate of return is to leave. How much of that poor performance is due to the attributes of students who attend — just as how much of the success of graduates of elite schools is due to what the students arrive on campus with — is hard to know.

There are lots of things one could quibble with in these studies. They exclude from the college sample individuals who

go on to earn graduate degrees, which may take out some of the most able of the people who graduate from college, but they also ignore loans and their interest costs of attending college, which are now a huge part of the costs of college.

The big problem in any estimate of the future returns on education, though, is the need to guess where wages for college grads will be in the future. We know that the college wage premium has been all over the map in previous generations, and while one could tell a story saying that its current peak level will remain there for decades, there are equally compelling stories saying that it will not. For example, fans of the idea that technology is destiny argue that modern computing power is rapidly eliminating the jobs that don't require much thinking at the same time that it is creating lots of new opportunities for the educated. Other fans of technology is destiny say that hands-on skills, such as skilled trades, which don't require traditional classroom educations, are about the only jobs that computers can't do, so they are about the only ones that will remain in demand. College is a waste in that view.

So where does that leave an individual trying to decide what to do about college? The first conclusion, which is a big one, is that statements about what college will do on average for a student are irrelevant because the variation in results across schools and across fields is so great. It would be

like using the average temperature of the earth — fifty-five degrees — to decide whether to wear a coat today. It is a school-by-school story, perhaps even a major-by-major one within each school. There are colleges where attending them will do nothing for your future earnings, and while that may not be the only factor in deciding where to go to college, it ought to be something you know.

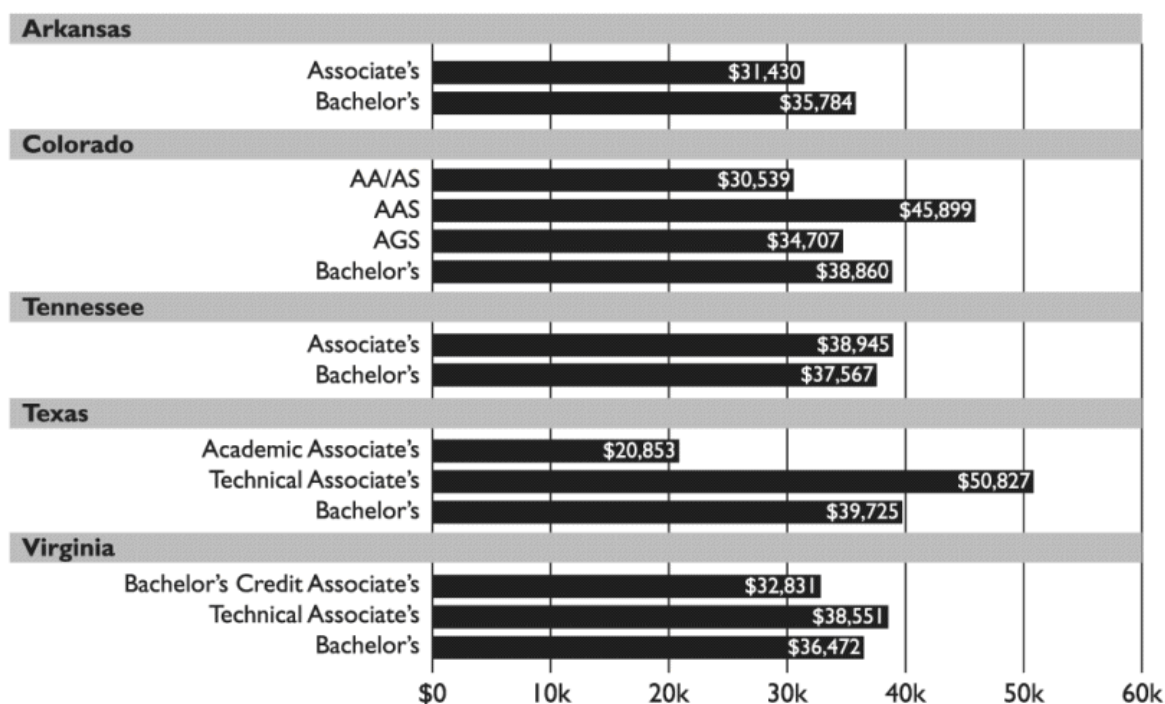
The second conclusion is the reminder that we just don't know with much certainty what things will look like in the future, and the farther out the guess, the less valid and useful guesses will be. The baby boomers^{iv} among us will remember when the standard advice for career success was to get a job with a big company because it would take care of you because that's the way things had operated before. How well did that work out?

The wrong conclusion to draw from all this uncertainty is to just give up: We don't know what will happen, so there is no point trying to figure it out. We can do better than that.

One of the things we do know is that current evidence beats forecasts specially when it comes to something as complicated as the labor market. Some of the most useful information about college outcomes is from a group called CollegeMeasures.org, which provides evidence on first-year earnings for college graduates by college and also by major

within different states [[Figure 22.1](#) on p. 568]. There are clear limits as to what information like this can tell us about the future, but at least it's not a guess. What we learn from them is more "it depends," but we get a sense of what success depends on.

(a) First-Year Earnings of Graduates with Associate's Versus Bachelor's Degrees, by State.



Rosa/Eschholz, Models for Writers, 14e, © 2021 Bedford/St. Martin's

(b) First-Year Earnings of Completers with Subbaccalaureate Credentials, by State

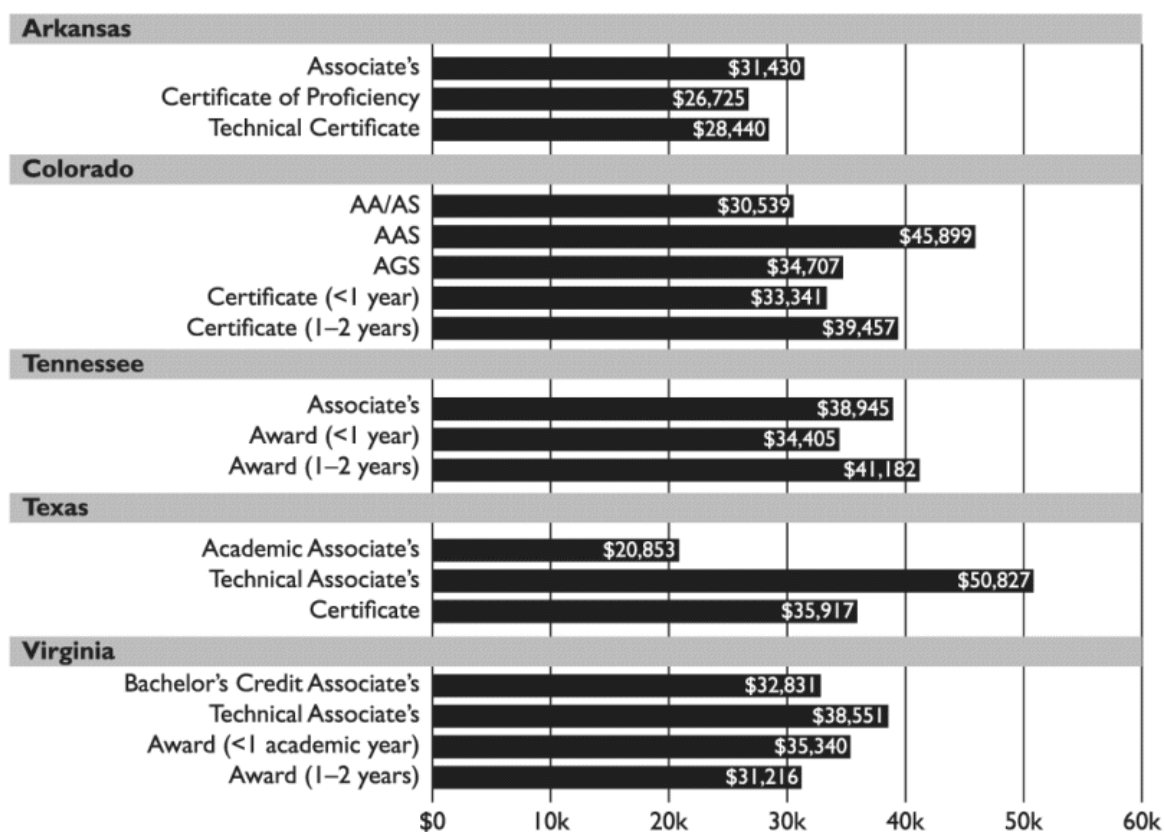


Figure 22.1. Higher Education Pays, but a Lot More for Some Graduates than for Others

Source: “College Education Pays: But a Lot More for Some Students than Others,” September 3, 2013, CollegeMeasures.org/category/reports.aspx.

Description

“First-year earnings of graduates with associate’ s versus bachelor’ s degrees, by state: Arkansas: Associate’ s; 31,430 dollars. Bachelor’ s; 35,784 dollars. Colorado: A A/ A S; 30,539 dollars. A A S; 45,899 dollars. A G S; 34,707 dollars. Bachelor’ s; 38,860 dollars. Tennessee: Associate’ s; 38,945 dollars. Bachelor’ s; 37,567 dollars. Texas: Academic Associate’ s, 20,853 dollars. Technical Associate’ s; 50,827 dollars. Bachelor’ s; 39,725 dollars. Virginia: Bachelor’ s Credit Associate’ s; 32,831 dollars. Technical Associate’ s; 38,551 dollars. Bachelor’ s; 36,472 dollars. First-year earnings of completers with sub-baccalaureate credentials, by state: Arkansas: Associate’ s; 31,430 dollars. Certificate of Proficiency; 26,725 dollars. Technical Certificate; 28,440 dollars. Colorado: A A/A S; 30,539 dollars. A A S; 45,899 dollars. A G S; 34,707 dollars. Certificate (less than 1 year); 33,341 dollars. Certificate (1 to 2 years); 39,457 dollars. Tennessee: Associate’ s; 38,945 dollars. Award (less than 1 academic year); 34,405 dollars. Award (1 to 2 years); 41,182 dollars. Texas: Academic Associate’ s; 20,853 dollars. Technical Associate’ s; 50,827 dollars. Certificate; 35,917 dollars. Virginia: Bachelor’ s Credit Associate’ s; 32,831 dollars. Technical Associate’ s; 38,551 dollars. Award (less than 1 academic year); 35,340 dollars. Award (1 to 2 years); 31,216 dollars.”

One thing we learn is that major can trump degree. Two-year community college degrees can pay more than average four-year degrees when the former are in a technical field that is in demand, in some cases stunningly so. In Texas, for example, recent grads with associate degrees in nuclear power technology earn just under \$100,000, while those in fire prevention and fire services earn close to \$90,000. Other two-year degrees, even if they are in technical areas, pay very little. Texas grads with a two-year degree in animal sciences are paid less than \$10,000 per year, which implies that on average even those who are working can't get full-time jobs. It doesn't seem to be the case that degrees in animal sciences are less challenging than degrees in fire prevention are, so it is not that the pay difference is due to sorting out more able students.

In the same field, though, the difference between a two-year and a four-year degree matters a lot. In information technology, for example, a bachelor's degree in Texas pays about double — \$60,000 — the average salary of two-year associate degree graduates. Not all technical degrees pay off, bursting another common assertion, and that is most noticeably so for STEM degrees. Again in Texas, a two-year sociology degree pays off a lot better than the equivalent chemistry, biology, or math degree, which is stunning given all the talk about the alleged demand in STEM fields. At the bachelor's level, that changes, as math degrees in

particular start to pay off more, but the sociology degree still pays better than the biology degree.

i *security laws*: financial regulations.

ii *caveat*: an explanation to prevent misunderstanding.

iii *premiums*: financial compensation above what a person would normally receive.

iv *baby boomers*: people born from around 1946 to 1964, especially those born in the United States.

¹Michael Greenstone and Adam Looney, “Where Is the Best Place to Invest \$102,000 — in Stocks, Bonds, or a College Degree?,” Hamilton Project, June 25, 2011, http://www.hamiltonproject.org/files/downloads_and_links/06_college_value.pdf.

²See PayScale, “2014 Payscale College ROI Report,” <http://www.payscale.com/college-roi/full-list/sortby/AnnualRoi/financial-aid/yes> (accessed October 2014).

³See Louis Lavelle, “College ROI: What We Found,” *Businessweek*, April 9, 2012, <http://www.businessweek.com/articles/2012-04-09/college-roi-what-we-found#p2>.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What does Cappelli mean when he claims that “different bachelor’ s degrees are not comparable

from a labor-market perspective” (4)? How is this claim important to his argument?

2. Which types of college degrees and majors does Cappelli argue pay off the most? Which types of degrees and majors does he argue pay off the least?
3. In paragraph 5, Cappelli cites calculations from the Brookings Institution’s Hamilton Project. However, he points out assumptions that the study made. What are the assumptions, and why are they important for the reader to understand?
4. Cappelli points out an incorrect conclusion that the reader may come to in paragraph 14. Which type of fallacy is he warning the reader against making? (Glossary: [Logical Fallacy](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. The thesis of Cappelli’s argument is implied rather than directly stated. Write a one-sentence thesis that would work for this article and accurately reflects Cappelli’s argument.
2. In what ways, if any, is Cappelli biased? How can you tell? If he is biased, does his bias matter? Why or why not? In what ways do you adjust your understanding of his argument based on his bias?
3. Cappelli’s examples appeal to the readers’ *ethos*, *pathos*, and *logos*. Identify examples and their

appeals throughout the text. Which examples did you find most persuasive? Why? (Glossary: [Ethos](#); Glossary: [Pathos](#); Glossary: [Logos](#))

Classroom Activity Using Argument

With a partner, jot down a list of five to ten factors that are important to consider when choosing where to vacation. Divide the list in half. Then, using only half of the factors on the list, try to convince your partner where to go for an ideal vacation. Then your partner will use the factors on the other half of the list to argue for a different ideal vacation spot. Once you have both made your arguments, discuss: which of you was more persuasive? What did your points have to do with it? Was what you said or how you said it more important? Why?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Cappelli illustrates myriad considerations that we might not even think about when we're making financial choices. Of the uncertainty we feel from this, he writes, "The wrong conclusion to draw from all this uncertainty is to just give up: We don't

know what will happen, so there is no point trying to figure it out. We can do better than that” (14).

Write a brief essay in which you argue one specific way we can “do better” when making an important decision that involves uncertainty. To support your argument, try to incorporate at least one personal example from a moment when you’ve been faced with uncertainty and made a wise decision.

2. Do you think it is important that everyone have access to a college education? Should we, as a society, take measures to ensure that college is affordable to all? Write a short essay that proposes three measures we should take to make college affordable or that gives three examples for why we’re already doing enough.

HOW REAL IS THE AUTOMATION THREAT?

The very word “automation” is enough to set some of us on edge. What does the word mean for you? Does it conjure visions of robots taking away our jobs, leading to mass unemployment and worldwide upheaval? Or does it bring to mind more mundane considerations, like whether specific functions — like checkout registers at the supermarket — will gradually be phased out and replaced with technology that does not require human workers?

Experts today debate what the future of automation holds. Whatever the future will bring, our present-day reality is that automation has brought some real changes, particularly in the industrial and manufacturing sectors where companies have laid off workers and some factories have gone completely “lights-out” — that is, entirely automated, with no workers at all. These and other technological changes continue to fuel anxiety for many people in the United States and around the globe about the threat that automation poses to jobs. Will self-driving cars and trucks eventually put truck drivers, food delivery drivers, and taxi and Uber drivers out of business? Will retail stores throughout the world follow the example of the physical Amazon Store, which

does not employ cashiers at checkout? These are all among the many automation-related questions that are debated today — and the answers are uncertain.

In this casebook, three authors each present a different argument about what the future of automation will look like — and what, if anything, we should do about it now. In

“Automation Is a Real Threat,” Alissa Quart argues that automation is a true danger and that governments across the world need to take concrete measures to protect workers.

Next, as a counterpoint to Quart, Lawrence Whittle claims that automation will be less damaging than many of us fear, in an article humorously titled “I, For One, Welcome Our Robot Overlords.” He argues that even as automation occurs,

“humans will remain very necessary” — and that new technologies are at least as likely to empower us with new job opportunities as to take away jobs. Finally, in “The Automation Delusion,” Hettie O’ Brien makes a different, bold argument that workers are in real danger, but not from automation: instead, according to her, the true threat to the workforce is “the consolidation of corporate power in the labor market.” As you read each of these three essays, consider which of the arguments you find most and least persuasive. After reading the selections, consider what *you* think automation’s effects will be, and whether you think action is needed to prevent those effects.

Automation Is a Real Threat

Alissa Quart



KALW

Alissa Quart (b. 1972) is executive editor of the Economic Hardship Reporting Project, an organization that aims to draw

public attention to poverty in the United States by reporting on vulnerable populations. Born in New York City, she received her BA in English Literature from Brown University in 1994 and her MS from the Columbia School of Journalism in 1997. She has written five nonfiction books on topics related to poverty, politics, and economic instability: *Branded* (2004), *Hothouse Kids* (2006), *Republic of Outsiders* (2014), *Squeezed: Why Our Families Can't Afford America* (2018), and *Thoughts and Prayers* (2019), as well as one poetry collection, *Monetized* (2015). She was a 2018 Columbia Journalism School Alumna, and she has also been a Nieman Fellow at Harvard. Additionally, she is an Emmy-nominated video writer and producer. Quart writes the “Outclassed” column for *The Guardian*, a liberal-leaning newspaper, in which this essay first appeared on August 8, 2017.

In “Automation is a Real Threat,” Quart warns against the rapid development of technologies that may render some jobs obsolete. She argues that we must take action to slow the trend of automation and protect workers.

Reflecting on What You Know

Do you think that automation has directly impacted you or someone you know? For example, do you know anyone who has lost their job as a result of new technologies?

We’ ve heard a lot lately about how humans will suffer thanks to robots.

Recently, these dark premonitions have come from famed techno-positive-ists like Elon Musk¹ and Bill Gates.² These grandees have offered their own solutions, from a robot tax or universal basic income. But among the dire warnings and the downright sci-fi utopias³ (a robot for president, anyone?), the actual human pain resulting from future job loss tends to be forgotten.

Given that 38% of US jobs could be lost to automation in the next 15 years, this tendency to gloss over the enormity of this number is puzzling. And yet, most would argue that we cannot and should not slow down “progress” : that any attempt to stymy it is embarrassingly Luddite.

My question to them: why? So what if we decelerated, and established a Slow Tech movement to match our Slow Food and Slow Fashion trends? Or at the very least, what if we started to rethink who owns autonomous trucks? The effect of robotization would be profoundly different if, say, truckers possessed their own autonomous vehicles rather than a corporation controlling them all.

In the meantime, we need to call automation what it is: a real threat, and a danger to critical human infrastructure.

What is “human infrastructure”? Well, infrastructure usually means electricity grids, power plants, roads, fiber optic cables and so on. Human infrastructure, on the other hand, is a phrase that lets us see that people are also, in the words of the Department of Homeland Security’s website, essential services. These things “underpin American society and serve as the backbone of our nation’s economy, security, and health.”

“Critical human infrastructure” could describe the guys in trucker-author Finn Murphy’s new memoir *The Long Haul*. Murphy explains to me that if long hauls become autonomous, as has been threatened in the next 10 years, his driver friends will most likely have their trucks foreclosed. With a limited education and in latter middle age, they’ll only be able work for places like Walmart — at best.

Tellingly, though, Murphy adds: “I am not going to take the Luddite perspective — driverless vehicles are going to happen. The Luddites put their wrenches in the weaving machines and they still existed. And there will still be these trucks.” (If Luddites were part of co-ops and had a stake in the automated looms that replaced them, would this have happened in the first place? Discuss.)

Murphy understands the sheer scale of what will happen to drivers like him. But the tech billionaires, cyborg⁴

jingoists,⁵ and various political pundits don't have the same empathy. They may touch on workers' potential distress, but then they tend to launch into strangely frisson-filled⁶ discussions of a future apocalypse.

Instead of working to give robots personhood status, we should concentrate on protecting our human workers. If that means developing a more cooperative approach to ownership of autonomous trucks so millions of drivers are not left out in the literal cold, so be it. For other job categories, from nurses and legal assistants to movie ushers and cashiers, perhaps we could concoct legislation to help all strata⁷ of workers who will be displaced by our mechanical friends.

One thing is for certain: this will inevitably mean we must reduce the speed at which automation is occurring.

Indeed, given how easy automated systems like driverless vehicles may be to hack — they are quite the security challenge, as former Uber employee/hacker Charlie Miller has said — slowing down the robots might also mean slowing down a serious global calamity. (Imagine that 1973 Stephen King short story *Trucks* about semi-trailers gone berserk — now imagine it authored by international hackers who turned vehicles into murderers and jackknifing⁸ American security.)

There are some ideas out there that seek to slow down the march of the cyborgs. The not-for-profit organization New York Communities for Change has been agitating against automation in trucking and driving, for instance. In February, the group launched a campaign targeting Elaine Chao and the Department of Transportation, which has billions of dollars set aside to subsidize the development and spread of autonomous vehicles.

“Many truckers are very fearful,” says Zachary Lerner, the group’s Senior Director of Labor Organizing, who has been organizing drivers against the driverless vehicles.

“Trucking is not the best job but it pays the most in lots of rural communities. They worry: are they going to support their families? And what will happen to all of the small towns built off the trucking economy?”

“Our demand is to freeze all the subsidies for the research on autonomous vehicle until there is a plan for workers who are going to lose their jobs,” Lerner says.

As part of this effort, NYCC regularly puts together conference calls between dozens of taxi, Uber, and Lyft drivers. They discuss how they’ve all gotten massive loans to get the cars for Uber and how they are still going to being paying off these loans when the robots come for their

jobs — the robot vehicles Uber has promised within the decade.

There has also been a smattering of other workers actions against automation: last year, 4,800 nurses at five Minnesota hospitals protested against a computer determining staffing choices as well as broader healthcare questions.

And then there's Bill Gates's fix: to have governments tax companies that use robots to raise alternative funds. These funds would in turn help displaced human workers train for irreplaceably human jobs and to perhaps lull the swift turn to automation. In early 2017, the business press attacked him, partly for hypocrisy. As *DailyWire* wrote, "Bill Gates Proposes One Of The Dumbest Ideas Ever To Fix The Economy." But what is so wrong with Gates' idea? He was at least trying to address the way that humans may be pushed out of the workforce by robots' metal hands (and their owners' hands within them).

His solution is echoed by thinkers like Martin Ford, the "futurist" author of 2015 book *Rise of the Robots*. Ford eschews the Luddite perspective, and sees his very own book's title as a sign of progress. Nevertheless, he tells me that for our society to remain equitable, we must "leverage that progress on behalf of everyone." That means, for Ford, that "if businesses use automation and get higher

profits as a result we then need do something about inequality,” by taxing the capital and profits rather than labor. Which is a lot easier than taxing robots, explains Ford, because “who is going to come in and figure out what to tax: is software a robot, for example?”

In addition, there are those who see Universal Basic Income (UBI) as the panacea⁹ to the cyborg revolution. When I spoke with UBI advocate Scott Santens, he wasn’ t critical of automated trucking or robotic nurses. Rather, he believes that due to them, will all need to be subsidized by a monthly basic income guarantee if we are to survive with any standard of living intact.

I think we should go further. Why not stand up for the values of humanity more directly? Why not ask why anything that will eject millions more human beings from their work is indeed “progress” ?

More than a century ago, the German Romantic writer ETA Hoffman wrote, in his story “Automata” : “Yet the coldest and most unfeeling executant will always be far in advance of the most perfect machines.”

This warmth and feeling must be honored, at the very least. If we don’ t at least try to make the future more equitable, most of us will left with simply scraps.

¹*Elon Musk* (b. 1971): founder and CEO of Tesla and SpaceX.

²*Bill Gates* (b. 1955): co-founder of Microsoft.

³*utopias*: perfect or ideal places.

⁴*cyborg*: a human with machine parts.

⁵*jingoists*: people who aggressively advocate for a cause.

⁶*frisson-filled*: full of emotional excitement.

⁷*strata*: layers.

⁸*jackknifing*: seriously damaging.

⁹*panacea*: a cure for all problems.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. In paragraphs 3, 6, and 17, Quart uses the word *Luddite*. Using the context clues in these paragraphs, what does *Luddite* mean?
2. Quart contrasts truck drivers like Finn Murphy with “tech billionaires, cyborg jingoists, and various political pundits” (7). What is she saying Murphy understands that these people don’t? What else can we understand about Quart’s argument through this comparison?
3. In paragraph 19, Quart uses rhetorical questions to further her argument. (Glossary: [Rhetorical](#))

Question) Explain the impact of these questions on the reader.

4. What does “human infrastructure” mean (4)?
Paraphrase this idea. (Glossary: Paraphrase)

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Throughout her essay, Quart focuses primarily on one specific aspect of automation: the replacement of truck drivers by self-driving vehicles. In your opinion, does this focus make her argument stronger or weaker? (Glossary: Focus) Why?
2. Describe Quart’s tone. (Glossary: Tone) What words or phrases in the text are clues?
3. Quart discusses ways that various groups and individuals are combatting automation. Do any of the solutions that she mentions seem effective to you? Which solution do you think is most effective, and which do you think is least effective? Why?

Classroom Activity Using Argument

One strategy for developing a strong argument that most people find convincing is illustration. An array of examples, both brief and extended, real and hypothetical,

have a remarkable ability to convince readers of the truth of a proposition. While it is possible to argue a case with one specific example that is both appropriate and representative, most writers find that a varied set of examples often makes a more convincing case.

Therefore, it is important to build a list of examples before you start to write so you can determine how varied they are rather than try to think of them while you are in the drafting process.

As an exercise in argumentation, choose one of the following position statements:

- More parking spaces should be provided for students on campus.
- Capital punishment is a relatively ineffective deterrent to crime.
- The Electoral College should be abolished.
- My school's in-state residency requirements for tuition are unfair.

Make a list of the kinds of information and examples that you would need in order to write an effective argumentative essay on the topic you choose. Indicate where and how you might obtain this information. Finally, share your list of examples with other students in your class who chose the same topic.

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. Do you agree with Quart that governments should take more aggressive measures to protect workers from automation? Write a brief essay in which you explain why you do or do not find her argument persuasive. In your essay, be sure to cite specific examples from Quart's article as you argue why you agree or disagree with her.
2. There are a variety of "slow" movements, including those mentioned by Quart in paragraph 3: "Slow Food" and "Slow Fashion." Quart proposes that we embrace "Slow Tech." Imagine what a "Slow Tech" movement might look like in practice, and write a short, persuasive essay that convinces your audience to embrace "Slow Tech." Alternatively, if you disagree with Quart and do not believe a "Slow Tech" movement is needed, you may write a brief essay arguing why you think it is not needed.

I, For One, Welcome Our Robot Overlords

Lawrence Whittle



Parsable Inc.

Lawrence Whittle is the chief executive officer at Parsable, a San Francisco-based technology company that develops

software intended to help businesses improve their day-to-day operations. He previously held leadership positions at other technology companies, most recently as the chief revenue officer at Persado, which develops AI-powered marketing tools. Parsable's stated goal is to free industrial workers from paper records and physical desks and to bring them into digital spaces, an effort which the company claims will improve efficiency, quality, and safety in the workplace. Through digital connections, Whittle envisions possibilities for the changing industrial landscape, whether those changes are driven by new technologies, environmental limitations, human resources, or economic forces.

In the following essay, which was originally published in *Newsweek* on February 7, 2019, Whittle discusses the impact of automation on both manufacturing and commercial industries. He also praises human ingenuity and our flexible intellect, which he argues will prevent the “robot overlords” from wholly taking over. And perhaps, he concludes, new technologies will free up some of our time so that we may pursue our hobbies and other endeavors.

Reflecting on What You Know

If you could automate any task, chore or errand in your life, what would it be? Consider why you chose the thing that you did. Because it is cumbersome? Boring? Mindless? What could you do with that free time?

For the last 17 years, the Japanese robotics company FANUC has been operating a very special factory. At this facility, robots build other robots — 50 of them each day. The building is “lights out,” meaning it operates without human intervention. It can do so for a month at a time.

If this sounds like the beginning of a Philip K. Dick¹ short story, it is. (Thankfully, though, FANUC employees get along far better with their robots than Dick’s protagonists do.)

Manufacturing isn’t the only sector where firms aspire to the lights-out model. Recently, a packing and shipping warehouse for Chinese retailer [JD.com](https://www.jd.com) made headlines by going almost entirely robotic. And with the prospect of automating white-collar work growing ever more likely, we could see lights-out offices one day, too. The trend has many concerned about mass unemployment. Though estimates vary, most experts say that America will lose tens of millions of jobs to automation in the next decade.

However, rumors of the death of jobs are premature. Here’s why: Going lights-out doesn’t necessarily make a facility more productive, even in manufacturing. Consider Toyota’s 1970s thwarted attempts to fully automate its plant in Tahara, Japan, or Tesla’s more recent failure to deliver Model 3s² using a highly automated production line.

There' s a reason that automation hype is outpacing reality: Automation transforms markets just as easily as it takes jobs. And the same developments that have affected manufacturing automation are likely to impact any other industry that attempts to create a "lights-out" model. Even in a highly automated world, humans will remain very necessary.

The Fight for the Factory of the Future

When we imagine the factory of the future, we tend to picture a more efficient, cost-effective version of the factory of the past. But that' s wrong. The technologies that power industry 4.0³ are also changing the ways factories function in today' s hyper-competitive global economy. Factories aren' t just becoming more automated — they' re also becoming more flexible. And human beings, not robots, are the key to that flexibility.

How? Here' s an example. While automation threatens low-skilled manufacturing jobs, it also drives down costs and reduces barriers to entry for newer, smaller manufacturers. By putting out small batches of quickly changing products, these new entrants drive up the number of choices available to consumers. The beer industry is a great example. Twenty years ago, macro brews like Budweiser and Miller dominated;

today, smaller craft breweries take up nearly a quarter of the market.

Over the long term, these trends create feedback loops that shift demand patterns. Consumers come to expect greater variety and a constant influx of new products. As a result, more established players must offer more choice, further reinforcing the shift in consumer expectations. Under these circumstances, scale can become a liability; after all, it's harder for large factories to change what they produce on a dime. This is part of the reason we see major beverage companies investing more in production facilities for their craft beer brands — small and flexible is the future.

What does this have to do with the lights-out factory? Large factories become especially inflexible when they're stocked with robots specialized for particular tasks. After all, more variety means more opportunity for breakdowns and disconnects — problems that people are better-suited to fix.

Lights-out factories have run into these issues from the beginning, with no obvious solution in sight. For example, early Apple manufacturing facilities were much closer to lights-out than the factories that assemble iPhones today. At one Macintosh plant opened in 1984, nearly 90 percent of the assembly process was automated. It closed only six years later. Steve Jobs⁴ ran into the same problem when he

attempted to launch the NeXT computer in 1988. His highly automated factories were unable to adapt when demand for the new devices flagged. Today, Apple relies on humans to assemble its products.

Where machines bring predictability and consistency to production processes, people bring more adaptive decision-making skills. And our human capacity to quickly respond to varying inputs is crucial, because some tasks cannot be automated without reducing the overall quality and safety of the output. Most manufacturers know this, though they don't necessarily publicize it. For example, BMW is famous for automating its factories, but there are still more than 10,000 employees at its South Carolina manufacturing campus.

The Future of the Workforce

What does all of this mean for industries outside of manufacturing? It means that despite the hype around cashierless Amazon Go stores and bookkeeperless back offices, it's unlikely we'll be seeing convenience stores or workplaces go totally "lights-out" anytime soon. Machine learning models, which must be trained and tuned to specific sets of data, are still less flexible than human employees — an important caveat in the constantly changing contemporary economy. Other industries will run into the same hiccups as manufacturing when they try to automate at scale.

The savviest manufacturing operations typically put people to work alongside collaborative robots, or “cobots.” Unlike the clunky machinery of the 20th century, cobots are designed to share space and interact with humans. According to an MIT study, cobots at a BMW plant are 85 percent more efficient than either humans or robots working alone.

Most important to the factory of the future, however, is not the way humans guide robots, but the way that technology can guide and empower humans. Tomorrow’s “connected worker” technologies have the potential to empower human actors with IoT⁵-enabled capabilities, allowing workers to gather data continuously and interact with the factory’s automated systems more smoothly. Human and machine will work as one.

This alternative to going “lights-out” is revolutionizing more than just the manufacturing industry. The city of Baltimore recently announced plans to install “smart trash cans” that will notify sanitation workers when they need to be emptied, increasing collection efficiency. In Amazon’s warehouses, which employ more than 125,000 people across the US, workers oversee robots that perform the tedious task of stacking and moving boxes, freeing people up for more high-level work. In each of these cases, automation augments human creativity, dexterity, and thought by adding a guardrail of consistency and predictability.

Concerns about automation and unemployment are real, and they deserve to be taken seriously. However, the news from the front lines of the automation revolution suggests that the workplaces of the future could be friendlier to humans than many people imagine. If other industries follow manufacturing’ s lead, we’ ll see tomorrow’ s advanced machines collaborating with, rather than replacing, their human coworkers.

¹*Philip K. Dick* (1928 – 1982): American science fiction author. Several of his stories involve robots attacking or otherwise interfering with humans.

²*Model 3*: an electric car that first appeared in 2017.

³*industry 4.0*: the automation of factories and related practices.

⁴*Steve Jobs* (1955 – 2011): co-founder, chairman, and CEO of Apple.

⁵*IoT*: the “Internet of Things,” a term for interrelated systems that can transfer data without any human interaction.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. Whittle begins by describing “lights out” factories (1). What does a “lights out” model of manufacturing mean, and how does it relate to automation?
2. What is Whittle’ s thesis? (Glossary: [Thesis](#)) In what ways does this thesis create clear expectations

for the reader?

3. In paragraph 5, Whittle uses the example of “macro brews” versus “craft breweries.” How does this example support his thesis?
4. How does Whittle summarize his argument in his final paragraph? How does this ending contribute to his overall argument? (Glossary: [Beginnings and endings](#))

Questions for Critical Reading

1. Whittle argues that even if robots take over some jobs, humans will still be necessary. Using a reverse outline, evaluate his argument. Is it effective? Why or why not?
2. Throughout the essay, Whittle consistently addresses opposing viewpoints. (Glossary: **Opposing Viewpoints**) Identify a few places where he does this. Do you think he refutes the opposing arguments effectively? Do these refutations improve Whittle’s own argument, in your opinion? Explain.
3. How might Whittle’s background and professional experience (see the headnote) affect his bias? Explain.

Classroom Activity

A good argument relies on the reasoned refutation of counterarguments. Yet counterarguments are difficult to see when you're writing because you may be so invested in your position that opposing views simply don't enter into your thinking. Work in groups of three and have each member of the group present a thesis. Have the other two members of the group present realistic counterarguments. Each presenter should then offer ways of rebutting the counterarguments to his or her position. The purpose of this Classroom Activity is to become more familiar with counterarguments and how you, as a writer, might answer them.

Here is an example of how this might work in your group.

Presenter offers a thesis: "The opioid crisis can best be solved by having tighter controls on the pharmaceutical industry."

Opponents offer counterarguments: "Big pharmaceutical companies have a lot of money and are difficult to regulate because of powerful lobbies working on their behalf."

Presenter gives rebuttals: "We can fight the big drug companies with new legislation to stop the overproduction of opioid medications. We can mount powerful public service announcements that bring pressure to bear on the ethics of those drug companies and their lobbyists. We can use advertising that makes the public more aware of the dangers of opioids, as was done with cigarette smoking."

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. In paragraph 10, Whittle refers to “cashierless Amazon Go stores and bookkeeperless back offices.” He uses these examples to show that companies, or producers, still need human workers to adapt to ever-changing jobs and markets. Write a short essay that explains why *consumers* might also want the support of a human cashier or a bookkeeper.
2. Whittle writes, “Where machines bring predictability and consistency to production processes, people bring more adaptive decision-making skills” (9). Expand on this idea by writing a brief essay in which you explain one or more skills that humans can perform that machines or technology cannot. You may support your argument with information from Whittle’s article, from other readings in this casebook, or from your own experience.

The Automation Delusion

Hettie O' Brien



Courtesy Hettie O'Brien

Hettie O' Brien is the online editor for *The New Statesman*, a left-leaning British magazine, where she writes about

politics and the environment, among other topics. She went to the University of St. Andrews for her undergraduate degree in philosophy, and she completed a master's in politics at Newnham College, Cambridge. She has worked for the BBC World Service and at the Centre for the Analysis of Social Media at the think tank Demos. Her work has appeared in *The Guardian*, the *Times Literary Supplement*, and *The London Review of Books*, among other publications.

The following essay was originally published in *The New Statesman* on May 10, 2019. Unlike Alissa Quart ([pp. 572 – 76](#)), O'Brien does not argue that new technologies will make large numbers of jobs obsolete. Instead, she predicts that new workplace technologies will accelerate the management trends that we are already seeing. In her view, we should worry about companies continuing to consolidate their power over workers, rather than worrying about automation.

Reflecting on What You Know

Think about a field or career path that you are interested in pursuing. What effect, if any, do you think automation might have on that field over the next ten years or so? Do you think the effect of automation on the field will be positive? Negative? Why?

Hide the batteries, unplug the router, learn to code: if there's a truth universally acknowledged, it's that robots

are coming for your job. According to this familiar story, our economic future will be one of mass unemployment. Automations will inevitably take the place of human workers. These robotic employees won't complain, suffer fatigue, or unionise.

The new robots will be “white collar,” predicts Richard Baldwin, author of the recently published *Globotics Upheaval: Globalization, Robotics, and the Future of Work*.

(“Globotics” is a clunky portmanteau of “globalisation” and “robotics”.¹) Western professionals, no matter how qualified, will be supplanted by low-wage foreigners working remotely via Skype and UpWork, and highly-tuned algorithms that can out-think human beings. Baldwin's advice? Don't compete with robots, or “tele-migrants” for that matter. Find the competitive edge in your own humanity. Become a Zumba¹ instructor.

Yet this narrative is dubious. An influential 2013 Oxford University paper suggesting that 47 per cent of US jobs were vulnerable to automation remains widely cited, but when its methods were replicated with different weightings, researchers obtained radically different results. A recent paper by the Institute for Public Policy Research (IPPR) found that the number of US jobs that could be wholly automated was relatively low: an estimated 5 per cent. Two other recent studies — one by the Organisation for Economic

Development (OECD) and one by the Roosevelt Institute — both suggest the consequences of automation depend more on politics than robotics. Far from being inevitable, the outcomes of new technology will be determined by conscious policy choices.

Automation anxiety has a long history. In the 1930s, John Maynard Keynes² warned of a new disease — “technological unemployment”. In 1961 US president John F. Kennedy established the Office of Automation and Manpower to study the “major domestic challenge of the 60s: to maintain full employment at a time when automation, of course, is replacing men”. As fears of technological obsolescence grew, his successor Lyndon B. Johnson inaugurated the National Commission on Technology, Automation, and Economic Progress to examine the risk of robots usurping human labour.

Yet automation isn’ t a linear process. The vacuum cleaner and washing machine have shown how new inventions destroy some jobs and create others, in part by reducing the burden of household labour. The IPPR paper found that automation generates more jobs in the long term than it eliminates — while also correlating with increasing productivity, as it takes fewer hours work to produce the same output. It’ s true that contemporary digital capitalism differs from previous incarnations, and that technological progress has accelerated (it took seven decades for phones to penetrate households,

but only nine years for smartphones to catch on). Yet technologies don' t exist in a void. Their introduction frequently exacerbates³ pre-existing underlying power dynamics within the economy.

Authors of the three papers agree on one point: new technologies could increase prosperity, but whether or not they do so will depend on how their economic fruits are distributed. If the robots ever come, what they are used for and who profits from them will be determined by economic distribution and property ownership regimes.

So why does optimism about the astonishing progress and transformative nature of robots persist? In part, because headlines blaring job losses drive more clicks. As the authors of the Roosevelt Institute report note, however, the reality is more complex. Were a robot revolution truly underway, we might expect to see an increase in worker productivity. But large-scale productivity gains continue to elude Western economies. Robot enthusiasts attempt to explain away this paradox: either economists are mis-measuring output, or new technologies are overly confined to selected firms, or productivity increases haven' t shown up in the statistics — yet.

The reality, though, might be that new digital technologies aren' t disrupting the economy as much as their advocates

suggest. Workers are right to be worried about new technologies — but not because they’ re about to be replaced. More than the spectre of job obsolescence,⁴ it’ s the consolidation of corporate power that haunts the labour market.

The history of management is partly one of attempting to measure and control work. Technologies that mimic human capabilities may further empower employers in a labour market already tilted in their favour. Trade union researcher Victor Figueroa observes that, just as unscrupulous employers have used microphones and email monitoring to pre-empt union organisers, Artificial Intelligence — which is already used to sift through employees in hiring processes — could also be deployed to create personality profiles to pre-empt strikes and identify insubordinate staff. In warehouses around the world, many workers already complain of inhumane conditions when algorithms set the pace of work.

AI and machine learning threaten to exacerbate existing trends, creating a new digital overseer at a time when union membership stands at a near-record low: union membership in the UK has plummeted from 13.2 million in 1979 to 6.2 million in 2017; in the US a mere 10.5 per cent of workers are unionised. As the OECD report observes, while anxieties over automation abound, the greater risk is of widening disparities between workers. Some will have every aspect of

their labour measured and analysed, while others will have the power to avert this fate, Figueroa predicts. Dystopian visions of advancing robots shouldn't distract from the more familiar struggles we face.

¹At several points in her essay, O'Brien places a period after, rather than before, quotation marks. This is standard style in British English, but is generally considered incorrect in academic American English.

¹*Zumba*: a group exercise and fitness program.

²*John Maynard Keynes* (1883 – 1946): influential British economist.

³*exacerbate*: to make worse.

⁴*obsolescence*: the process of becoming obsolete, no longer useful or needed.

Questions for Study and Discussion

1. What fear is O'Brien responding to in this essay? Find evidence in the essay, and restate it in your own words.
2. In paragraph 2, O'Brien refers to author Richard Baldwin, who argues that "the new robots will be 'white collar' ." What does Baldwin mean by this? Why doesn't O'Brien find Baldwin's argument persuasive?

3. O’ Brien writes that “automation isn’ t a linear process” (5). What does she mean? How is this claim relevant to her larger argument?
4. What does O’ Brien mean when she writes, “Technologies that mimic human capabilities may further empower employers in a labour market already tilted in their favour” (8)?

Questions for Critical Reading

1. In the first paragraphs of the essay, does O’ Brien use *ethos*, *pathos*, or *logos* (or some combination) to draw in her readers? Do these initial appeals make you more or less receptive to her argument? Why? (Glossary: [Ethos](#); Glossary: [Pathos](#); Glossary: [Logos](#))
2. In paragraph 7, O’ Brien writes, “More than the spectre of job obsolescence, it’ s the consolidation of corporate power that haunts the labour market.” Does O’ Brien include enough evidence to support this claim? Explain.
3. What is O’ Brien’ s tone? (Glossary: [Tone](#)) Do you think the tone makes her argument more persuasive? Why or why not? How does her tone compare to that of the other authors in this casebook?

Classroom Activity Using Argument

The Socratic method, named after the Greek philosopher Socrates' s approach to teaching, involves asking and answering questions to help develop a student' s thinking skills. Try it in class. In groups of three, begin with a broad question from the following list and take turns asking and answering questions until you have narrowed the issue into a useful argumentative thesis.

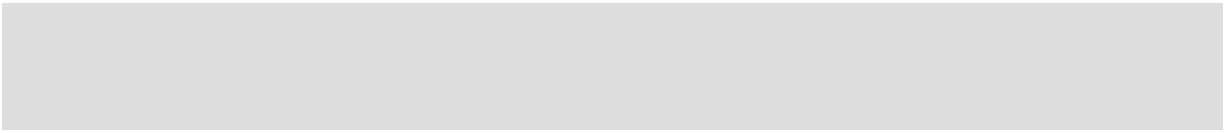
- Is automation good or bad?
- Does democracy work for everyone?
- Is income inequality inevitable?
- Does the government need tighter control of the pharmaceutical industry?

Suggested Writing Assignments

1. O' Brien uses several complex phrases whose meanings may not be immediately clear, like "pre-existing underlying power dynamics" (5), "consolidation of corporate power in the labour market," and "job obsolescence" (7). Pick one of these phrases from the article. Write a short definition essay in which you define the phrase and then explain whether you

agree or disagree with the way that O' Brien uses the phrase in her article.

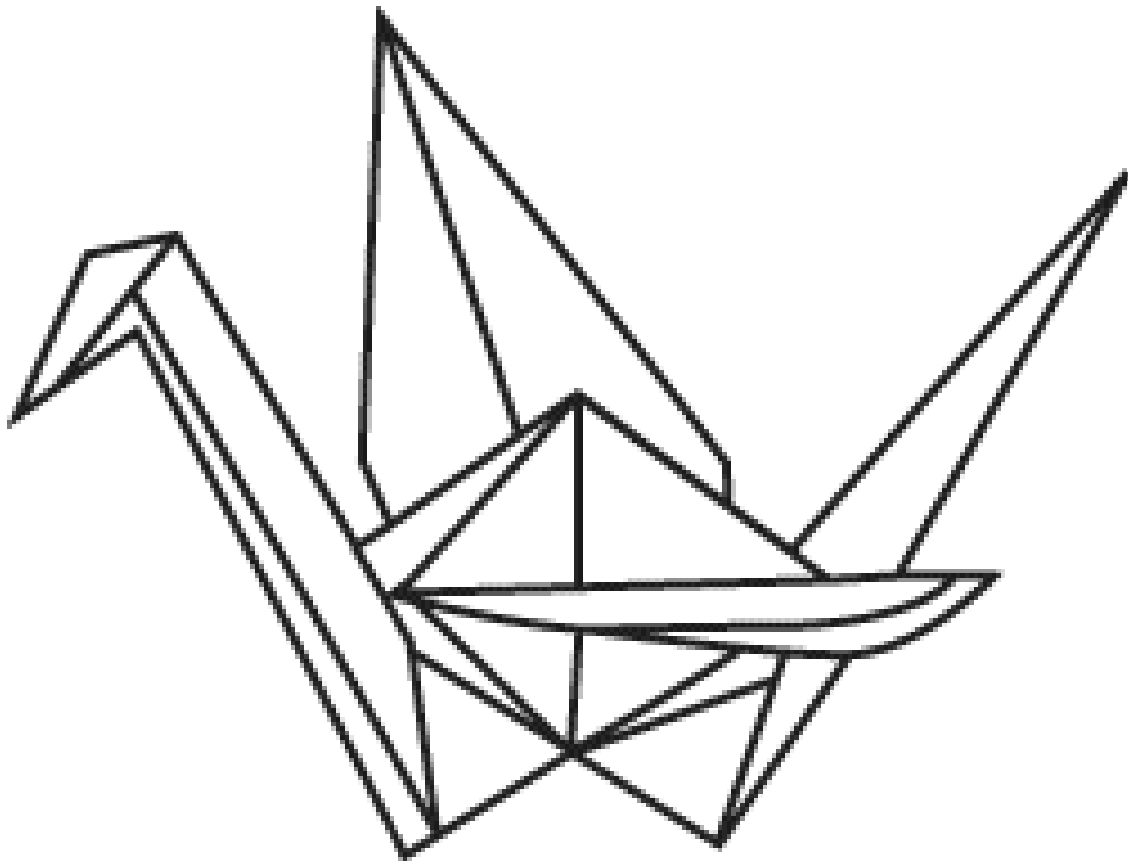
2. After reading O' Brien' s article and the other two readings in this casebook, write a brief argument essay in which you take a stand on the issue of automation. In your opinion, is automation a serious threat to workers, as Alissa Quart ([pp. 572 - 76](#)) argues, or is the threat overblown, as Lawrence Whittle ([pp. 578 - 82](#)) and O' Brien suggest? To support your argument, you may use evidence from any of the three articles.



PART FIVE Guides to Research and Editing



CHAPTER 23 A Brief Guide to Writing a Research Paper



Julia Ra/Shutterstock

The research paper is an important part of a college education — and for good reason. In writing a research paper, you gain a number of indispensable skills that you can adapt to other college assignments and to situations after graduation.

The real value of writing a research paper, however, goes beyond acquiring basic skills; it is a unique hands-on

learning experience. The purpose of a research paper is not to present a collection of quotations that show you can report what others have said about your topic. Rather, your goal is to [analyze](#), [evaluate](#), and [synthesize](#) the materials you research on a topic, gathering skills you can apply to research on other topics and in other disciplines. You learn how to view the results of research from your own perspective and to arrive at an informed opinion of a topic.

Writing a research paper is not very different from the other writing you will be doing in your college writing course. First you determine what you want to write about. Then you decide on a purpose, consider your audience, develop a thesis, collect your evidence, write a first draft, revise and edit, and prepare a final copy. What differentiates the research paper from other kinds of papers is your use of outside sources and how you acknowledge them. Your research will involve working with print and electronic sources and selecting the most appropriate sources from the many that are available on your topic. (See also [Chapter 10](#), Writing with Sources.)

In this chapter, you will learn some valuable research techniques:

- How to establish a realistic schedule for your research project

- How to conduct research on the internet using keyword searches
- How to evaluate sources
- How to analyze sources
- How to develop a working bibliography
- How to take useful notes
- How to acknowledge your sources using either Modern Language Association (MLA) style in-text citations and a list of works cited or American Psychological Association (APA) style in-text citations and a list of references
- How to present/format your research paper

ESTABLISHING A REALISTIC SCHEDULE

A research project easily spans several weeks. To avoid losing track of time and finding yourself facing an impossible deadline at the last moment, establish a realistic schedule for completing key tasks. By thinking of the research paper as a multistage process, you avoid becoming overwhelmed by the size of the whole undertaking.

Your schedule should allow at least a few days to accommodate unforeseen needs and delays. Use the following template, which lists the essential steps in writing a research paper, to plan your research schedule.

Research Paper Schedule

Task	Completion Date
1. Choose a research topic, and pose a worth while question.	<u> / / </u>
2. Locate sources.	<u> / / </u>
3. Develop a working bibliography.	<u> / / </u>
4. Evaluate and analyze your sources.	<u> / / </u>

5. Read your sources, taking complete and accurate notes.	<u> / / </u>
6. Develop a preliminary thesis, and make a working outline.	<u> / / </u>
7. Write a draft of your paper, including sources that you have summarized, paraphrased, and quoted.	<u> / / </u>
8. Visit your college writing center for help with your revision.	<u> / / </u>
9. Decide on a final thesis, and modify your outline.	<u> / / </u>
10. Revise your paper, and properly cite all borrowed materials.	<u> / / </u>
11. Prepare a list of works cited.	<u> / / </u>
12. Prepare the final manuscript, and proofread.	<u> / / </u>
13. Submit your research paper.	<u> / / </u>

FINDING AND USING SOURCES

You should use materials found through a search of your school library's holdings in print or online — including books, newspapers, journals, magazines, encyclopedias, pamphlets, brochures, and government documents — as your primary tools for research. These sources, unlike many sources found through a generic internet search, are often reviewed by experts in the field before they are published, are generally overseen by a reputable publishing company or organization, and are typically examined by editors and fact-checkers for accuracy and reliability.

The best place to start any search for print and online sources is your college library's home page. There you will find links to the catalog of book holdings, online reference works, periodical databases, and electronic journals, as well as a list of full-text databases. You'll also find links for subject study guides and for help conducting your research.

To get started, decide on some likely keyword search terms and try them out. You might have to try a number of different terms related to your topic to generate the best results. (For tips on refining your keyword searches, see the box on [p. 592](#).) Your goal is to create a preliminary listing of

books, magazine and newspaper articles, public documents and reports, and other sources that may be helpful in exploring your topic. At this early stage, it is better to err on the side of listing too many sources so that, later on, you will not have to relocate sources you discarded too hastily.

Internet sources can be informative and valuable additions to your research, and they are especially useful in providing recent data, stories, and reports. For example, you might find a just-published article from a university laboratory or a news story in your local newspaper's online archives. The internet offers a vast number of useful and carefully maintained resources, but it also contains much unreliable information. It is your responsibility to determine whether a given internet source should be trusted. (For advice on evaluating sources, see [pp. 595 – 97.](#))

CONDUCTING KEYWORD SEARCHES

When searching for sources about your topic in an electronic database, in the library's catalog, or on the internet, you should start with a keyword search. As obvious or simple as it may sound, the key to a successful keyword search is the quality of the keywords you generate about your topic. You might find it helpful to start a list of potential keywords as you begin your search and add to it as your work proceeds. Often you will discover meaningful combinations of keywords that will lead you directly to the sources you need.

Databases and library catalogs index sources by author, title, year of publication, and subject headings (which are assigned by a cataloger who has previewed the source). The object here is to find a keyword that matches one of the subject headings. Once you begin to locate sources on your topic, be sure to note the subject headings that are listed for each source. You can use these subject headings as keywords to lead you to additional book sources, as well as articles that are gathered in full-text databases (such as InfoTrac, LexisNexis, Expanded Academic ASAP, and JSTOR) to which your library subscribes.

The keyword search process is somewhat different when you are searching on the internet. It is always a good idea to look for search tips on the help screens or advanced search instructions for the search engine you are using before initiating a keyword search. When you type a keyword in the “Search” box, the search engine electronically scans internet sites to match your keyword to titles and texts. A search on the internet might yield a million hits, but the search engine’s algorithm puts the sources with the most relevant hits up front. After you scan the first couple of pages of results, you can decide whether these sites seem on topic. If they seem off topic, you will need to refine your search terms to narrow or broaden your search (for tips, see the Refining Keyword Searches box).

Refining Keyword Searches

Command terms and characters vary somewhat among electronic databases and search engines, but the following functions are almost universally accepted.

- Use quotation marks when you are searching for words in exact sequence — for example, “whooping cough” ; “Supreme Court.”
- Use AND or a plus sign (+) between words to narrow your search by specifying that all words need to

appear in a document — for example, tobacco AND cancer; Shakespeare + sonnet.

- Use NOT or a minus sign (–) between words to narrow your search by eliminating unwanted words — for example, monopoly NOT game; cowboys – Dallas.
- Use an asterisk (*) to indicate that you will accept variations of a term — for example, “food label*” for food labels, food labeling, and so forth.

EVALUATING SOURCES

You will not have to spend much time in the library to realize that you cannot read every print and online source that appears relevant. Given the abundance of sources, the key to successful research is identifying those books, articles, websites, and other sources that will help you the most. You must evaluate your potential sources to determine which materials you will read, which you will skim, and which you will simply eliminate. (See the Strategies for Evaluating Sources box that follows for some evaluation strategies and questions to assist you in identifying your most promising sources.) On the basis of your evaluation, select the most promising books, articles, and websites to pursue in depth for your research project.

Strategies for Evaluating Sources

Evaluating a Book

- Read the dust jacket or cover copy for insights into the book's coverage, its relevance, and the author's expertise. In the library catalog, read the summary, if there is one.

- Scan the copyright page or look at the online catalog record to check the publication year.
- Scan the table of contents, and identify any promising chapters.
- Read the author's preface, looking for his or her thesis and purpose. Do the thesis and purpose clearly relate to your topic?
- Check the index for key words or key phrases related to your research topic.
- In the online catalog record, check the subject terms associated with the book.
- Read the opening and concluding paragraphs of any promising chapters. If you are unsure about a chapter's usefulness, skim the whole chapter.
- Ask yourself: Does the source appear to be too general or too technical for my needs or audience?

Evaluating an Article

- Ask yourself what you know about the journal or magazine publishing the article:
 - Is the publication scholarly or popular? Scholarly journals (*American Economic Review*, *Journal of Marriage and the Family*, *Wilson Quarterly*) publish articles representing original research written by authorities in the field. Such articles always cite their sources in notes, reference lists, or works cited, which means that you can check their accuracy and delve deeper into the topic by

locating these sources. Popular news and general-interest magazines (*National Geographic*, *Smithsonian*, *Time*, *Ebony*), on the other hand, publish informative, entertaining, and easy-to-read articles written by editorial staff or freelance writers. Popular essays sometimes cite sources but often do not, making them somewhat less authoritative and less helpful in terms of extending your research.

- What is the reputation of the publication?
Determine the publisher or sponsor. Is it an academic institution, a commercial enterprise, or an individual? Does the publisher or publication have a reputation for accuracy and objectivity?
- Who are the readers of this publication?
- Try to determine the author's credentials. Is he or she an expert?
- Consider the title or headline of the article, the opening paragraph or two, and the conclusion. Does the source appear to be too general or too technical for your needs and audience?
- For articles in journals, read the abstract (a summary of the main points), if there is one at the beginning of the essay or in the online record.
- Examine any photographs, charts, graphs, or other illustrations that accompany the article. Determine how useful they might be for your research purposes.

Evaluating a Website

- Consider the type of website. Is this site a personal blog or professional publication? Often the URL, especially the top-level domain name, can give you a clue about the kinds of information provided and the type of organization behind the site. Common suffixes include:
 - .com* — business, commercial, or personal
 - .edu* — educational institution
 - .gov* — government-sponsored
 - .net* — various types of networks
 - .org* — nonprofit organization, but also some commercial or personal
- Examine the home page of the site:
 - Does the content appear to be related to your research topic?
 - Is the home page well maintained and professional in appearance?
 - Is there an *About* link on the home page that takes you to background information on the site's sponsor? Is there a mission statement, history, or statement of philosophy? Can you verify whether the site is official — that is, is it actually sanctioned by the organization or company?
 - If the site is sponsored by an organization, do additional research to find out more about the organization. What are the organization's stated goals or agenda? Who funds the organization? Does

the organization have any apparent bias that might influence the material on the website? (See also the Checklist for Analyzing a Writer's Position or Bias on [p. 598](#).)

- Identify the author of the site or article. What are the author's qualifications for writing on this subject?
- Determine when the site was last updated. Is the content current enough for your purposes?

ANALYZING SOURCES FOR POSITION AND BIAS

Before beginning to take notes, analyze each source carefully. Look for the writer's main ideas, key examples, strongest arguments, and conclusions. How would you summarize the writer's position? Does the writer have a discernible bias? In what ways, if any, has the writer's bias colored his or her claims and evidence? It is important to ask yourself where each writer stands relative to the other writers as well as to your own position on the subject. Be sure to read critically; it is easy to become absorbed in sources that support your beliefs. Ask yourself whether these like-minded sources consider the possible merits of alternative points of view. If only to test your own position, you should always seek out several independent sources with opposing viewpoints. By knowing exactly where each of your sources is positioned, you can more effectively use them in the context of your research paper.

Look for information about the authors themselves — information like that provided in the writer headnote that accompanies each selection in *Models for Writers*. Such information will help you determine the writer's authority and perspective or bias on the issue. You should also

consider the reputation and special interests of book publishers and magazines, because you are likely to get different views — conservative, liberal, international, feminist — on the same topic depending on which publication you read. Use the Checklist for Analyzing a Writer's Position and Bias that follows to assist you in analyzing each of your print and online sources for the writer's position and bias. For more discussion of analyzing a writer's position and bias, see [pp. 49 - 56](#) in [Chapter 2](#).

Checklist for Analyzing a Writer's Position and Bias

- What is the writer's [thesis](#)?
- How does the writer support this thesis? Does the [evidence](#) seem reasonable and representative, or is it mainly vague, anecdotal, or sensational?
- What is the writer's attitude toward the subject ([tone](#))?
- Is the author's [purpose](#) to inform? Or is it to argue for a particular position? If it's to argue, is the writer's appeal logical and reasoned, or is it largely emotional?
- Does the writer consider opposing viewpoints?
- What are the writer's basic assumptions? Which of these are stated, and which are implied? Are they acceptable?

- Does the writer have any discernible cultural, political, religious, or gender biases? Is the writer associated with a special-interest group, such as the American Medical Association, the National Organization for Women, the American Immigration Council, the Sierra Club, the National Education Association, the National Rifle Association, or Amnesty International?
- Is the writer an expert on the subject? Do other writers on the subject mention this author in their work?
- Does the publisher or publication have a reputation for accuracy and objectivity? Or does it have an inclination for a particular viewpoint?
- Is important information documented in notes or links so that it can be verified or corroborated in other sources?
- Does the source reflect current thinking and research in the field?

DEVELOPING A WORKING BIBLIOGRAPHY

As you discover books, journal and magazine articles, newspaper stories, and websites that you think might be helpful for writing your paper, you need to start maintaining a record of important information about each source. This record, called a *working bibliography*, will enable you to know where sources are located when it comes time to consult and acknowledge them in your paper and list of works cited (for MLA) or list of references (for APA). See [pages 597 – 612 \(MLA\)](#) and [613 – 23 \(APA\)](#) for an explanation of how to prepare these lists. In all likelihood, your working bibliography will contain more sources than you actually consult and include in your final list.

You may find it easy to make a separate bibliography document or index note for each work that you think might be helpful to your research. Alphabetize them by the authors' last names. By using a separate document or card for each book, article, or website, you can continually edit your working bibliography, dropping sources that do not prove helpful and adding new ones.

When conducting your research through your library's online offerings, you can copy bibliographic information from the online catalog and periodical indexes or from the internet and paste it directly into your document. Unlike hard copy notes or an index card, electronic documents allow you to search these sources throughout the research process. You can also track your project online with a citation manager. One advantage of the copy/paste option over the index card method is accuracy, especially in punctuation, spelling, and capitalization — details that are essential when accessing internet sites. One danger, however, is accidental plagiarism if you copy and paste information without acknowledging that it came from a source.

Checklist for a Working Bibliography

For Books

Library call number

Names of all authors, editors, and translators

Title and subtitle

Publication data:

Publisher's name

Date of publication

Edition number (if not the first) and volume number
(if applicable)

Online location information, if an online book

For Periodical Articles

Names of all authors

Title and subtitle of article

Title of journal, magazine, or newspaper (the
“container” in which the article appears)

Publication data:

Volume number and issue number

Date of issue

Page numbers

If found online, DOI (digital object identifier)
or direct, stable URL

For Internet Sources

Names of all authors, editors, compilers, or
sponsoring agents

Title and subtitle of the source

Title of the longer work (or “container”) in which
the source appears (an online periodical or book,
blog, website, or similar work)

Editor, compiler, publisher, or sponsor of the larger
work in which the document is contained

Date of release, online posting, or latest revision

Name of database or other type of even larger work
(or “container”) that houses the longer work

Format of online source (web page, email, scholarly
journal article, blog or social media post, and so
on)

DOI (digital object identifier) or direct, stable URL
Date of access (if no date of release, online
posting, or latest revision is provided)

For Other Sources

Name of author, government agency, organization,
company, recording artist, personality

Title of the work

Format (pamphlet, unpublished diary, interview,
television broadcast, government document, legal
document, address or lecture)

Publication or production data:

Name of publisher or producer

Date of publication, production, or release

Identifying codes or numbers (if applicable),
including URL if accessed online and version
number for apps or software

TAKING NOTES

As you read, take notes. You're looking for ideas, facts, opinions, statistics, examples, and other evidence that you think will be useful as you write your paper. Look for recurring themes, and notice where writers are in agreement and where they disagree. Your paper's effectiveness is largely determined by the quality — not necessarily the quantity — of your notes. Your purpose is not to present a collection of quotes showing that you've read all the material and know what others have said about your topic. Rather, your goal is to **analyze, evaluate, and synthesize** the information you collect — to enter into the discussion of the issues and take ownership of your topic. You want to view the results of your research from your own perspective and arrive at an informed opinion of your topic. (For more on writing with sources, see [Chapter 10](#).)

Now for some practical advice on taking notes. First, be systematic in your note taking. If you keep notes electronically, consider creating a separate file for each topic or source, or using an electronic research manager like Zotero. Title all documents using the same naming conventions. If you keep your notes by hand or on note cards, write one note per page or card and include the author's

full name, the complete title of the source, and a page number indicating the origin of the note. If you keep your notes organized, when you get to the planning and writing stage you will be able to sequence them according to the plan you have envisioned for your paper. Furthermore, should you decide to alter your organizational plan, you can easily reorder your notes to reflect those revisions.

Be very careful, though, when taking notes electronically — especially if you are taking your notes from an online source. It is easy and tempting to simply copy and paste phrases or whole paragraphs into your notes. This can get you into trouble, however, when you go to write your paper if you do not keep careful track of which words belong to the author and which are your own. For tips on avoiding plagiarism, see [Chapter 10, pages 235 – 39.](#)

Second, try not to take too many notes. Ask yourself, “How exactly does this material help prove or disprove my thesis?” Try to envision where in your paper you could use the information. If it does not seem relevant to your thesis, don’ t bother to take a note.

Once you decide to take a note, you must decide whether to summarize, paraphrase, or quote directly. The approach you take should be determined by the content of the passage and the way you plan to use it in your paper. For detailed advice

on summaries, paraphrases, and quotations, see [Chapter 10](#),
[pages 226 – 30](#).

DOCUMENTING SOURCES

Whenever you summarize, paraphrase, or quote a person's thoughts and ideas and whenever you use facts or statistics that are not commonly known or believed, you must properly acknowledge the source of your information. If you do not properly acknowledge ideas and information created by someone else, you are guilty of plagiarism — of using someone else's material but making it look as if it were your own (see pp. 235 - 39). You must document the source of your information whenever you do the following:

- Quote a source word for word
- Refer to information and ideas from another source that you present in your own words as either a paraphrase or a summary
- Cite statistics, tables, charts, or graphs

You do not need to document these types of information:

- Your own observations, experiences, and ideas
- Factual information available in a number of reference works (known as “common knowledge”)
- Proverbs, sayings, and familiar quotations

A reference to the source of your borrowed information is called a [citation](#). There are many systems for making citations, and your citations must consistently follow one of these systems. The documentation style recommended by the Modern Language Association (MLA) is commonly used in English and the humanities. Another common system is the American Psychological Association (APA) style, which is generally used in the social sciences. Your instructor will probably tell you which style to use. For more information on documentation styles, consult the appropriate manual or handbook.

✓ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Working with Sources (MLA)

MLA-STYLE DOCUMENTATION

There are two components of MLA-style documentation. *In-text citations* are placed in the body of your paper, and the *list of works cited* provides complete publication data for your in-text citations and is placed at the end of your paper. Both of these components are necessary for complete documentation.

In-Text Citations

In-text citations, also known as *parenthetical citations*, give the reader citation information immediately, at the point at which it is most meaningful. Rather than having to find a footnote or an endnote, the reader sees the citation as part of the writer's text.

Most in-text citations consist of only the author's last name and a page reference. Usually the author's name is given in an introductory, or *signal*, phrase at the beginning of the borrowed material, and the page reference is given in parentheses at the end. If the author's name is not given in a signal phrase, put it in parentheses along with the page reference. (For more information on signal phrases, see [pp. 230 - 32](#).) When you borrow material from two or more works by

the same author, you must include the title of the work in the signal phrase or a shortened version of it parenthetically at the end. (To shorten a title, use the first noun and any adjectives, minus any words like *The*, *A*, or *An*: “The Greatest Woman on the Planet” becomes “Greatest Woman.”) The parenthetical reference signals the end of the borrowed material and directs your readers to the list of works cited should they want to pursue a particular source. Treat electronic sources as you do print sources, keeping in mind that some electronic sources use paragraph numbers instead of page numbers. Consider the following examples of in-text citations, taken from the opening paragraph of student Charley Horton’s paper “How Humans Affect Our Global Environment.”

In-Text Citations (MLA Style)

Controversy has always shadowed public discussions of our environment and environmental policy. In her book *Silent Spring*, Rachel Carson first warned Americans about the dire consequences of the irresponsible use of herbicides and insecticides. As early as 1962, she clearly saw that “a grim specter has crept upon us almost unnoticed” (3). First decried as an alarmist, Carson is now revered as an early leader in the ecology movement. Today the debate is not limited to pesticides, where controversy still swirls around the use of certain lawn care products and their commercial agricultural counterparts. It has expanded to include often uncivil discussions about the causes of climate change. Audrey Schulman has written extensively on severe climatic events, and she

concludes that human behavior has had a direct impact on global climate change. She knows that while “some human cultures, through their agriculture and hunting, have respected and adapted to ecological limits” (332), others have not. Like her predecessor Rachel Carson, Schulman believes that Americans must act to avoid an ecological tragedy: “We have the ability to shape our destiny” (332).

Works Cited

Carson, Rachel. *Silent Spring*. 25th anniversary ed., Houghton Mifflin, 1987.

Schulman, Audrey. “Fahrenheit 59: What a Child’s Fever Might Tell Us about Climate Change.” *Models for Writers*, edited by Alfred Rosa and Paul Eschholz, 14th ed., Bedford/St. Martin’s, 2021, pp. 332 – 337.

In the preceding example, the student followed MLA style guidelines for his list of works cited. When constructing the list of works cited page for your paper, consult the following MLA guidelines, based on the *MLA Handbook*, 8th ed. (2016), where you will find model entries for a range of common sources.

List of Works Cited

In this section, you will find general MLA guidelines for creating a works-cited list, followed by sample entries that cover the citation situations you will encounter most often.

Make sure that you follow the formats as they appear on these pages. Although most college libraries and databases provide programs that will format citations, you will need to check the citations carefully, since these programs are often inaccurate.

Guidelines for Constructing Your MLA Works Cited Page

1. Begin the list on a fresh page following the last page of text.
2. Center the title *Works Cited* at the top of the page.
3. Double-space both within and between entries on your list.
4. Alphabetize your sources by the authors' last names. If you have two or more authors with the same last name, alphabetize first by last names and then by first names.
5. If you have two or more works by the same author, alphabetize by the first word of the titles, not counting *A*, *An*, or *The*. Use the author's name in the first entry and three unspaced hyphens followed by a period in subsequent entries: (---.).
6. For two authors, reverse only the name of the first author. For three or more authors, provide only the first author's name followed by a comma and *et al.* (and others).
7. If no author is known, alphabetize by title.

8. Begin each entry at the left margin. If the entry is longer than one line, indent the second and subsequent lines half an inch.
9. Italicize the titles of books, journals, magazines, and newspapers. Use quotation marks with titles of periodical articles, chapters, and essays within books, short stories, and poems.
10. Provide the names of other contributors, such as editors, translators, or illustrators, with explanations such as *translated by*.
11. Include edition or version numbers.
12. If the source is part of a sequence, include volume and/or issue numbers.
13. If the source has a publisher whose name differs significantly from the work it embodies or is contained by, include this publisher's name; otherwise, omit it.
14. If your source was accessed through a database, application, streaming service, or other larger "container," include information about that larger container after information about the original source. For a database, for example, include its name and the DOI or URL, separated by a comma.
15. Provide the location where the source was accessed. For print sources, this means page numbers, preceded by the prefix *p.* or *pp.* For online sources, this means a DOI or URL. For lectures or live

performances, this means the physical location where they took place.

PERIODICAL PRINT PUBLICATIONS: JOURNALS, MAGAZINES, AND NEWSPAPERS

ARTICLE IN A SCHOLARLY JOURNAL

For all scholarly journals — whether they paginate continuously throughout a given year or not — provide the volume number, the issue number, the publication date, and the page numbers. Separate the volume number and the issue number with a comma.

Masuzawa, Tomoko. “The Bible as Literature? — Note on a Litigious Ferment of the Concept ‘Comparative Literature.’” *Comparative Literature*, vol. 65, no. 3, Summer 2013, pp. 306 – 24.

ARTICLE IN A MAGAZINE

When citing a weekly or biweekly magazine, give the complete date (day, month, year). Abbreviate all months except May, June, and July.

Miller, John J. “Zora the Explorer.” *National Review*, 22 Dec. 2019, pp. 19 – 20.

When citing a magazine published every month or every two months, provide the month or months and year. If the article is not printed on consecutive pages — for example, an article might begin on [page 45](#) and then skip to [page 48](#) — include only the first page followed by a plus sign.

Hutson, Matthew. “How Memory Became Weaponized.” *Psychology Today*, Apr. 2019, pp. 58+.

ARTICLE IN A NEWSPAPER

Zinsmeister, Karl. “The War on Philanthropy.” *The Wall Street Journal*, 9 Jan. 2020, p. A17.

NONPERIODICAL PRINT PUBLICATIONS: BOOKS, BROCHURES, AND PAMPHLETS

BOOK WITH ONE AUTHOR

Shlaes, Amity. *Great Society: A New History*. Harper Collins, 2019.

Spell out the publisher’s name, but omit generic business words or abbreviations, such as *Corporation* or *Inc.* For

university presses, replace *university* and *press* with *UP*:
Write *Cambridge UP* for Cambridge University Press.

ANTHOLOGY

Lepucki, Edan, editor. *The Best Nonrequired Reading, 2019*.
Houghton Mifflin, 2019.

BOOK WITH TWO OR MORE AUTHORS

For a book with two authors, list the authors in the order in which they appear on the title page.

Kantor, Jodi, and Megan Twohey. *She Said: Breaking the Sexual Harassment Story That Helped Ignite a Movement*. Penguin, 2019.

For a book with three or more authors, list the first author last name first, followed by a comma and the abbreviation *et al.* (“and others”).

Glaser, John, et al. *Fuel to the Fire: How Trump Made America's Broken Foreign Policy Ever Worse (and How We Can Recover)*. Cato Institute, 2019.

WORK IN AN ANTHOLOGY

Altfeld, Heather. “Obituary for Dead Languages.” *The Best American Essays, 2019*. Edited by Rebecca Solnit and Robert Atwan. Houghton Mifflin, 2019, pp. 16 – 22.

AN ILLUSTRATED BOOK OR GRAPHIC NOVEL

Clemens, Samuel L. *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*.
Illustrated by Norman Rockwell, Heritage Books, 1940.

Bechdel, Alison, writer and artist. *Fun Home: A Family
Tragicomic*. Mariner Books, 2007.

BOOK PUBLISHED IN A SECOND OR SUBSEQUENT EDITION

Haviland, William, et al. *Cultural Anthropology: The Human
Challenge*. 15th ed., Cengage Learning, 2016.

GOVERNMENT PUBLICATION

United States, Department of Health and Human Services. *Eat
Healthy, Be Active, Community Workshops*. Government Printing
Office, 2012.

Give the government and the agency, and any departments with commas between them, followed by a period. Follow the source title with a period. In many cases, the publisher is the Government Printing Office, for U.S. government documents published before 2014, and Government Publishing Office in 2014 or after.

ONLINE PUBLICATIONS

The following guidelines and models for citing online sources or sources accessed online have been adapted from the most recent advice of the MLA, as detailed in the *MLA Handbook*, 8th ed. (2016).

For sources located or accessed online or through an online database, MLA style requires you to include either DOIs or direct URLs as locations for sources in works-cited entries. The following example illustrates an entry with the URL included.

Gan, Peter. "Can Mystical Peace Contribute to Global Peace?" *Peace and Conflict Studies*, vol. 26, no. 2, 2019, www.nsuworks.nova.edu/pcs/vol26/iss2/3/.

To format the URL, omit the *http://* prefix, but include the rest of the URL in full, including *www.* when applicable. Precede a DOI with *doi:* (no space). End both with a period. If a URL or a DOI must be divided across lines, break it before a period or a hyphen or before or after any other mark of punctuation. Do *not* add spaces, hyphens, or any other punctuation to indicate the break.

PERIODICAL ARTICLES PUBLISHED OR ACCESSED ONLINE

To cite an article, a review, an editorial, or a letter to the editor in a periodical (journal, magazine, or newspaper) accessed online, provide the author, the title of the article, the title of the publication, the volume and issue (for scholarly journals), and the date of issue, followed by the page numbers (if available), the publisher (if distinct from the publication), and the article's DOI or direct URL. Because the nature of online news can be fluid and content can change over time, include the time the story was posted, if available.

ARTICLE IN AN ONLINE SCHOLARLY JOURNAL

Dodd, Kirk. "What's in a Name? Shakespeare's Inventio and the Topic of 'Notatio' (Names)." *Early Modern Literary Studies*, vol. 21, no. 1, 2019, extra.shu.ac.uk/emls/journal/index.php/emla/article/view/474 /.

ARTICLE IN AN ONLINE MAGAZINE

Devega, Chauncey. "Democracy Fatigue and How to Fight It: Philosopher Henry Giroux on Life in the Age of Trump." *Salon*, 7 Jan. 2020, www.salon.com/2020/01/07/democracy-fatigue-and-how-to-fight-it-philosopher-henry-giroux-on-life-in-the-age-of-trump/.

ARTICLE IN AN ONLINE NEWSPAPER

Dunn, Marcia. "SpaceX Launches 60 More Satellites, Trying to Tone Them Down." *The Seattle Times*, 7 Jan. 2020, www.seattletimes.com/business/spaceX-launches-60-more-satellites-trying-to-tone-them-down/.

STORY FROM AN ONLINE NEWS SERVICE

Starr, Barbara. "US Forces on High Alert for Possible Iranian Drone Attacks, and Intelligence Shows Iran Moving Military Equipment." *CNN*, 7 Jan. 2020, www.cnn.com/2020/01/07/politics/us-iran-high-alert-drone-attacks/index.html.

PERIODICAL PUBLICATIONS ACCESSED IN ONLINE DATABASES

Here are some model entries for periodical publications collected in online databases/subscription services.

JOURNAL ARTICLE WITH A DOI

Diaz, Robert. "Transnational Queer Theory and Unfolding Terrorisms." *Criticism*, vol. 50, no. 3, 2009, pp. 533 - 41. *Project Muse*, doi:10.1353/crt.0.0072.

JOURNAL ARTICLE WITHOUT A DOI (USE URL)

Bachi, Salim, and Alison Rice. "The Place of Islam in Literature, Geography, Memory, and Exile." *Religion and*

Literature, vol. 43, no. 1, 2011, pp. 162 – 66. *JSTOR*,
www.jstor.org.proxy.wexler.hunter.cuny.edu/stable/23049365.

MAGAZINE ARTICLE

Keizer, Garret. “Sound and Fury: The Politics of Noise in a Loud Society.” *Harper’s Magazine*, Mar. 2001, pp. 39 – 48. *Academic Search Complete*, ebscohost.com.

NEWSPAPER ARTICLE

Porter, Eduardo. “Racial Identity Returns to American Politics.” *The New York Times*, 6 Jan. 2016, p. B1. *LexisNexis Academic*,
www.nytimes.com/2016/01/06/business/economy/racial-identity-and-its-hostilities-return-to-american-politics.html.

NONPERIODICAL WEB PUBLICATIONS

Nonperiodical web publications include all online content that does not fit into one of the previous two categories — articles published or accessed online, or articles accessed from an online database/subscription service.

BOOK OR PART OF A BOOK ACCESSED ONLINE

For a book available online, provide the author, the title, the editor (if any), original publication date (and other

information only if relevant), and the name of the database or website where it was accessed.

Hawthorne, Nathaniel. *The Blithedale Romance*. 1894. *Project Gutenberg*, 2000, www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2081.

If you are citing only part of an online book, include the title or name of the part directly after the author's name.

Woolf, Virginia. "Kew Gardens." *Monday or Tuesday*, 1921. Bartleby.com: *Great Books Online*, www.bartleby.com/85/7.html.

SPEECH, ESSAY, POEM, OR SHORT STORY FROM AN ONLINE SITE

If there is no date provided for the online publication of a source, include your date of access at the end of the entry after the word *Accessed*.

Faulkner, William. "On Accepting the Nobel Prize." 10 Dec. 1950. *The History Place: Great Speeches Collection*, www.historyplace.com/speeches/faulkner.htm. Accessed 12 Mar. 2019.

ONLINE GOVERNMENT PUBLICATION

New York State, Department of Taxation and Finance, New York State Tax Department. *Your Rights as a New York State Taxpayer*. 5 Dec. 2019, www.tax.ny.gov/tra/rights.htm.

WIKI ENTRY

“C. S. Lewis.” Wikipedia. 9 Jan. 2020,
[en.wikipedia.org/wiki/C. S. Lewis](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/C._S._Lewis).

No author is listed for a Wiki entry because the content is written collaboratively. Be sure to list the date of the exact version you are citing, and to provide a stable URL to this version. Find this URL by selecting the “View history” link at the top right corner of the page.

ADDITIONAL COMMON SOURCES

TELEVISION OR RADIO BROADCAST

“Everyone’s Waiting.” *Six Feet Under*. Directed by Alan Ball, performances by Peter Krause and Michael C. Hall, season 5, episode 12, HBO, 21 Aug. 2005.

FILM OR VIDEO RECORDING

Spielberg, Steven, director. *Schindler’s List*. Performances by Liam Neeson, Ralph Fiennes, and Ben Kingsley. 20th Anniversary ed., Universal Studios, 2013.

TELEVISION SHOW (VIA STREAMING SERVICE)

Carney, John, director. “Take Me as I Am: Whoever I Am.” *Modern Love*, season 1, episode 3, 18 Oct. 2019. Amazon Prime

Video, www.amazon.com/gp/video/detail/B07VNF53.

PODCAST (VIA APP)

“Happy Ending.” *Start Up*, season 3, episode 7, Gimlet, 9 June 2016. *Overcast: Podcast Player*, version 2.5.

INTERVIEW

Handke, Peter. “Facing His Critics.” Interview by Deborah Solomon, *The New York Times Magazine*, 2 July 2006, p. 13.

Begin with the name of the person being interviewed. For interviews that you conduct, provide the name of the person interviewed, the words *Personal interview*, and the date.

Bohjalian, Chris. Personal interview. 23 Mar. 2020.

CARTOON OR COMIC STRIP

Ramirez, Michael P. *Washington Examiner*, 19 Nov. 2019, p. 1.
Cartoon.

ADVERTISEMENT

Pearl Seas Cruises. *Smithsonian*, Jan.–Feb. 2020, p. 7.
Advertisement.

An Annotated Student MLA-Style Research Paper

Lesley Timmerman's assignment was to write an argument, and she was free to choose her own topic. After considering a number of possible topics and doing some preliminary research on several of them, she turned to a subject that she and her classmates had been discussing: the need for corporations to be socially responsible for their actions.

Timmerman began by brainstorming about her topic. She made lists of ideas, facts, issues, arguments, and opposing arguments. Once she was confident that she had amassed enough information to begin writing, she made a rough outline of an organizational plan she thought she could follow and ran it by her professor. With this plan in mind, she wrote a first draft of her essay. After taking a break from the draft for a day or two, Timmerman went back and examined it carefully, assessing how it could be improved.

After rereading her first draft, Timmerman saw that her organizational plan could be modified to emphasize the examples of PepsiCo and Walmart. She could then develop them as examples of the many socially responsible corporations that measure their success by the "triple bottom line" of "profit, planet, and people." And these two examples would

lead naturally into her discussion of what socially responsible corporations mean to employees and consumers alike. Timmerman scoured her sources to make sure that she was using the materials that best either supported or illustrated the points she wanted to make about corporate responsibility as well as the opposition' s argument.

The final draft of Timmerman' s research paper illustrates that she has learned how the parts of a well-researched and well-written paper fit together and how to make revisions that emulate some of the qualities of the model essays she had read and studied in class. The following is the final draft of her paper, which demonstrates MLA-style documentation and format for research papers.

Lesley Timmerman

Professor Jennifer Wilson

English 102

17 April 2017

Title is
focused and
announces
the thesis

Double space
between the
title and the
first para-
graph — and
throughout
the essay

An Argument for Corporate Responsibility

Opponents of corporate social responsibility (CSR) argue that a company's sole duty is to generate profits. According to them, by acting for the public good, corporations are neglecting their primary obligation to make money. However, as people are becoming more and more conscious of corporate impacts on society and the environment, separating profits from company practices and ethics does not make sense. Employees want to work for institutions that share their values,

1

Description

"The text reads, Lesley Timmerman; Professor Jennifer Wilson; English 102; 17 April 2017. (Left-aligned). The title at the center of the page reads, "An argument for corporate responsibility." An accompanying annotation reads, "Title is focused and announces the thesis." The first paragraph reads as follows. Opponents of corporate social responsibility (C S R) argue that a company's sole duty is to generate profits. According to them, by acting for the public good, corporations are neglecting their primary obligation to make money. However, as people are becoming more and more conscious of corporate. An annotation corresponding to the space between the title and the first paragraph reads, "Double space between the title and the first paragraph (em dash) and throughout the essay." "

Brief statement of one side of the issue	and consumers want to buy products from companies that are making an impact and improving people's lives. Furthermore, businesses exist in an interdependent world where the health of the environment and the well-being of society really do matter. For these reasons, corporations have to take responsibility for their actions, beyond making money for shareholders. For their own benefit as well as the public's, companies must strive to be socially responsible.	
Summary of the opposing view clearly introduced with signal phrase	In his article "The Case against Corporate Responsibility," <i>Wall Street Journal</i> writer Aneel Karnani argues that CSR will never be able to solve the world's problems. Thinking it can, Karnani says, is a dangerous illusion. He recommends that instead of expecting corporate managers to act in the public interest, we should rely on philanthropy and government regulation. Karnani maintains that "Managers who sacrifice profit for the common good . . . are in effect imposing a tax on their shareholders and arbitrarily deciding how that money should be spent." In other words, according to Karnani, corporations should not be determining what constitutes socially responsible behavior; individual donors and the government should. Certainly, individuals should continue to make charitable gifts, and governments should maintain laws and regulations to protect the public interest. However, Karnani's reasoning for why corporations should be exempt from social responsibility is flawed. With very few exceptions, corporations' socially responsible actions are not arbitrary and do not sacrifice long-term profits.	2
Lead-in to quotation		
1" margin on each side and at bottom		
Essayist's response to the quotation		
Author concisely states her position	In fact, corporations have already proven that they can contribute profitably and meaningfully to solving significant global problems by integrating CSR into their standard practices and long-term visions. Rather than focusing on shareholders' short-term profits, many companies have begun measuring	3

Description

"The first paragraph reads as follows. impacts on society and the environment, separating profits from company practices and ethics does not make sense. Employees want to work for institutions that share their values, and consumers want to buy products from companies that are making an impact and improving people's lives. Furthermore, businesses exist in an interdependent world where the health of the environment and the well-being of society really do matter. For these reasons, corporations have to take responsibility for their actions, beyond making money for shareholders. For their own benefit as well as the public's, companies must strive to be socially responsible. The first annotation corresponding to the first paragraph reads, "Brief statement of one side of the issue." The second paragraph reads: In his article 'The Case against Corporate Responsibility,' Wall Street Journal writer Aneel Karnani argues that C S R will never be able to solve the world's problems. Thinking it can, Karnani says, is a dangerous illusion. He recommends that instead of expecting corporate managers to act in the public interest, we should rely on philanthropy and government regulation. Karnani maintains that 'Managers who sacrifice profit for the common good (ellipsis) are in effect imposing a tax on their shareholders and arbitrarily deciding how that money should be spent.' In other words, according to Karnani, corporations should not be determining what constitutes socially responsible behavior; individual donors and the government should. Certainly, individuals should continue to make charitable gifts, and governments should maintain laws and regulations to protect the public interest. However, Karnani's reasoning for why corporations should be exempt

from social responsibility is flawed. With very few exceptions, corporations' socially responsible actions are not arbitrary and do not sacrifice long-term profits. The second annotation corresponding to the first few lines of the second paragraph reads, "Summary of the opposing view clearly introduced with signal phrase." The third annotation corresponding to the lines before the quotation reads, "Lead-in to quotation." The fourth annotation reads, "1 inch margin on each side and at bottom." The fifth annotation reads, "Essayist's response to the quotation." The third paragraph reads as follows. In fact, corporations have already proven that they can contribute profitably and meaningfully to solving significant. The sixth annotation corresponding to the third paragraph reads, "Author concisely states her position." "

Transitions
("For example,"
"also") alert
readers to
where the
writer is
taking them

Signal phrase
introduces
both the
direct quota-
tion and the
paraphrase
directly
following

Parenthetical
citations
clearly doc-
ument what
the author
has borrowed

their success by "profit, planet, and people" — what is known as the "triple bottom line." Businesses operating under this principle consider their environmental and social impacts, as well as their financial impacts, and make responsible and compassionate decisions. For example, such businesses use resources efficiently, create healthy products, choose suppliers who share their ethics, and improve economic opportunities for people in the communities they serve. By doing so, companies often save money. They also contribute to the sustainability of life on earth and ensure the sustainability of their own businesses. In their book *The Triple Bottom Line: How Today's Best-Run Companies Are Achieving Economic, Social, and Environmental Success*, coauthors Savitz and Weber demonstrate that corporations need to become sustainable, in all ways. They argue that "the only way to succeed in today's interdependent world is to embrace sustainability" (xi). The authors go on to show that for the vast majority of companies, a broad commitment to sustainability enhances profitability (Savitz and Weber 39).

For example, PepsiCo has been able to meet the financial expectations of its shareholders while demonstrating its commitment to the triple bottom line. In addition to donating over \$16 million to help victims of natural disasters, Pepsi has woven concerns for people and for the planet into its company practices and culture (Bejou 4). For instance, because of a recent water shortage in an area of India where Pepsi runs a plant, the company began a project to build community wells (Savitz and Weber 160). Though Pepsi did not cause the water shortage nor was its manufacturing threatened by it, "Pepsi realizes that the well-being of the community is part of the company's responsibility" (Savitz and Weber 161). Ultimately, Pepsi chose to look beyond the goal of maximizing short-term

4

Description

"The first paragraph reads, "global problems by integrating C S R into their standard practices and long-term visions. Rather than focusing on shareholders' short-term profits, many companies have begun measuring their success by

"profit, planet, and people" (em dash) what is known as the "triple bottom line." Businesses operating under this principle consider their environmental and social impacts, as well as their financial impacts, and make responsible and compassionate decisions. For example, such businesses use resources efficiently, create healthy products, choose suppliers who share their ethics, and improve economic opportunities for people in the communities they serve. By doing so, companies often save money. They also contribute to the sustainability of life on earth and ensure the sustainability of their own businesses. In their book *The Triple Bottom Line: How Today's Best-Run Companies Are Achieving Economic, Social, and Environmental Success*, coauthors Savitz and Weber demonstrate that corporations need to become sustainable, in all ways. They argue that "the only way to succeed in today's interdependent world is to embrace sustainability" (xi). The authors go on to show that for the vast majority of companies, a broad commitment to sustainability enhances profitability (Savitz and Weber 39)." The first annotation corresponding to the example given in the second paragraph reads, "Transitions ("For example," "also") alert readers to where the writer is taking them." The second annotation corresponding to the last part of the first paragraph reads, "Signal phrase introduces both the direct quotation and the paraphrase directly following." The second paragraph reads, "For example, PepsiCo has been able to meet the financial

expectations of its shareholders while demonstrating its commitment to the triple bottom line. In addition to donating over \$16 million to help victims of natural disasters, Pepsi has woven concerns for people and for the planet into its company practices and culture (Bejou 4). For instance, because of a recent water shortage in an area of India where Pepsi runs a plant, the company began a project to build community wells (Savitz and Weber 160). Though Pepsi did not cause the water shortage nor was its manufacturing threatened by it, “Pepsi” The third annotation corresponding to the citations in the paragraph reads, “Parenthetical citations clearly document what the author has borrowed.” ”

profits. By doing so, the company improved its relationship with this Indian community, improved people's daily lives and opportunities, and improved its own reputation. In other words, Pepsi embraced CSR and ensured a more sustainable future for everyone involved.

Another example of a wide-reaching company that is working toward greater sustainability on all fronts is Walmart. The corporation has issued a CSR policy that includes three ambitious goals: "to be fully supplied by renewable energy, to create zero waste and to sell products that sustain people and the environment" ("From Fringe"). As Dr. Doug Guthrie, dean of George Washington University's School of Business, noted in a recent lecture, if a company as powerful as Walmart were to succeed in these goals, the impact would be huge. To illustrate Walmart's potential influence, Dr. Guthrie pointed out that the corporation's exports from China to the United States are equal to Mexico's total exports to the United States. In committing to CSR, the company's leaders are acknowledging how much their power depends on the earth's natural resources, as well as the communities who produce, distribute, sell, and purchase Walmart's products. The company is also well aware that achieving its goals will "ultimately save the company a great deal of money" ("From Fringe"). For good reason, Walmart, like other companies around the world, is choosing to act in *everyone's* best interest.

5

Author now introduces statistical evidence that might have turned the reader off if introduced earlier

Recent research on employees' and consumers' social consciousness offers companies further reason to take corporate responsibility seriously. For example, studies show that workers care about making a difference (Meister). In many cases, workers would even take a pay cut to work for a more responsible, sustainable company. In fact, 45 percent of workers said they would take a 15 percent reduction in pay "for a job

6

Description

"The first paragraph reads, "realizes that the well-being of the community is part of the company's responsibility" (Savitz and Weber 161). Ultimately, Pepsi chose to look beyond the goal of maximizing short-term profits. By doing so, the company improved its relationship with this Indian community, improved people's daily lives and opportunities, and improved its own reputation. In other words, Pepsi embraced C S R and ensured a more sustainable future for everyone involved." The second paragraph reads, "Another example of a wide-reaching company that is working toward greater sustainability on all fronts is Walmart. The corporation has issued a CSR policy that includes three ambitious goals: "to be fully supplied by renewable energy, to create zero waste and to sell products that sustain people and the environment" ("From Fringe"). As Dr. Doug Guthrie, dean of George Washington University's School of Business, noted in a recent lecture, if a company as powerful as Walmart were to succeed in these goals, the impact would be huge. To illustrate Walmart's potential influence, Dr. Guthrie pointed out that the corporation's exports from China to the United States are equal to Mexico's total exports to the United States. In committing to C S R, the company's leaders are acknowledging how much their power depends on the earth's natural resources, as well as the communities who produce, distribute, sell, and purchase Walmart's products. The company is also well aware that achieving its goals will "ultimately save the company a great deal of money" ("From Fringe"). For good reason, Walmart, like other companies around the world, is choosing to act in everyone's best interest. The third paragraph reads, "Recent research on employees' and consumers'

social consciousness offers companies further reason to take corporate responsibility seriously. For example, studies show that workers care about making a difference (Meister). In many.” The annotation corresponding to the paragraph reads, “Author now introduces statistical evidence that might have turned the reader off if introduced earlier.” ”

that makes a social or environmental impact" (Meister). Even more said they would take a 15 percent cut in pay to work for a company with values that match their own (Meister). The numbers are most significant among Millennials (those born between, approximately, 1980 and the early 2000s). Eighty percent of Millennials said they "wanted to work for a company that cares about how it impacts and contributes to society," and over half said they would not work for an "irresponsible company" (Meister). Given this more socially conscious generation, companies are going to find it harder and harder to ignore CSR. To recruit and retain employees, employers will need to earn the admiration, respect, and loyalty of their workers by becoming "good corporate citizen[s]" (qtd. in "From Fringe").

Similarly, studies clearly show that CSR matters to today's consumers. According to an independent report, 80 percent of Americans say they would switch brands to support a social cause. Eighty-eight percent say they approve of companies' using social or environmental issues in their marketing. And 83 percent say they "wish more of the products, services and retailers would support causes" (Cone Communications 5-6). Other independent surveys corroborate these results, confirming that today's customers, especially Millennials, care about more than just price ("From Fringe"). Furthermore, plenty of companies have seen what happens when they assume that consumers do not care about CSR. For example, in 1997, when Nike customers discovered that their shoes were manufactured by child laborers in Indonesia, the company took a huge financial hit (Guthrie). Today, information-age customers are even more likely to educate themselves about companies' labor practices and environmental records. Smart corporations will listen to consumer preferences, provide transparency, and commit to integrating CSR into their long-term business plans.

Author
argues that
it is in the
companies'
interest to
be socially
responsible

Description

"The first paragraph reads, "cases, workers would even take a pay cut to work for a more responsible, sustainable company. In fact, 45 percent of workers said they would take a 15 percent reduction in pay "for a job that makes a social or environmental impact" (Meister). Even more said they would take a 15 percent cut in pay to work for a company with values that match their own (Meister). The numbers are most significant among Millennials (those born between, approximately, 1980 and the early 2000s). Eighty percent of Millennials said they "wanted to work for a company that cares about how it impacts and contributes to society," and over half said they would not work for an "irresponsible company" (Meister). Given this more socially conscious generation, companies are going to find it harder and harder to ignore CSR. To recruit and retain employees, employers will need to earn the admiration, respect, and loyalty of their workers by becoming "good corporate citizen[s]" (qtd. in "From Fringe"). The second paragraph reads, "Similarly, studies clearly show that C S R matters to today' s consumers. According to an independent report, 80 percent of Americans say they would switch brands to support a social cause. Eighty-eight percent say they approve of companies' using social or environmental issues in their marketing. And 83 percent say they "wish more of the products, services and retailers would support causes" (Cone Communications 5-6). Other independent surveys corroborate these results, confirming that today' s customers, especially Millennials, care about more than just price ("From Fringe"). Furthermore, plenty of companies have seen what happens when they assume that consumers do not care about CSR. For example, in 1997, when Nike

customers discovered that their shoes were manufactured by child laborers in Indonesia, the company took a huge financial hit (Guthrie). Today, information-age customers are even more likely to educate themselves about companies' labor practices and environmental records. Smart” The annotation corresponding to the second paragraph reads, “Author argues that it is in the companies' interest to be socially responsible.” ”

In this increasingly interdependent world, the case against CSR is becoming more and more difficult to defend. Exempting corporations and relying on government to be the world's conscience does not make good social, environmental, or economic sense. Contributors to a recent article in the online journal *Knowledge@Wharton*, published by the Wharton School of Business, agree. Professor Eric Orts maintains that "it is an outmoded view to say that one must rely only on the government and regulation to police business responsibilities. What we need is re-conception of what the purpose of business is" (qtd. in "From Fringe"). The question is, what should the purpose of a business be in today's world? Professor of Business Administration David Bejou of Elizabeth City State University has a thoughtful and sensible answer to that question. He writes:

8

Author's
lead-in to the
quotation
guides the
readers'
response to
the quota-
tion (long
quotation is
indented ½")

[I]t is clear that the sole purpose of a business is not merely that of generating profits for its owners. Instead, because compassion provides the necessary equilibrium between a company's purpose and the needs of its communities, it should be the new philosophy of business. (Bejou 1)

As Bejou implies, the days of allowing corporations to act in their own financial self-interest with little or no regard for their effects on others are over. None of us can afford such a narrow view of business. The world is far too interconnected. A seemingly small corporate decision — to buy coffee beans directly from local growers or to install solar panels — can affect the lives and livelihoods of many people and determine the environmental health of whole regions. A business, just like a government or an individual, therefore has an ethical responsibility to act with compassion for the public good.

9

Author ends
on an upbeat
note

Fortunately, corporations have many incentives to act responsibly. Customer loyalty, employee satisfaction, overall cost-savings, and long-term viability are just some of the

10

Description

“The first paragraph reads, “corporations will listen to consumer preferences, provide transparency, and commit to integrating C S R into their long-term business plans.” The second paragraph reads, “In this increasingly interdependent world, the case against C S R is becoming more and more difficult to defend. Exempting corporations and relying on government to be the world’ s conscience does not make good social, environmental, or economic sense. Contributors to a recent article in the online journal Knowledge@Wharton, published by the Wharton School of Business, agree. Professor Eric Orts maintains that “it is an outmoded view to say that one must rely only on the government and regulation to police business responsibilities. What we need is re-conception of what the purpose of business is” (qtd. in “From Fringe”). The question is, what should the purpose of a business be in today’ s world? Professor of Business Administration David Bejou of Elizabeth City State University has a thoughtful and sensible answer to that question. He writes: [I]t is clear that the sole purpose of a business is not merely that of generating profits for its owners. Instead, because compassion provides the necessary equilibrium between a company’ s purpose and the needs of its communities, it should be the new philosophy of business. (Bejou 1). The annotation corresponding to the block quote reads, “Author’ s lead-in to the quotation guides the readers’ response to the quotation (long quotation is indented half inch).” The second paragraph reads, “As Bejou implies, the days of allowing corporations to act in their own financial self-interest with little or no regard for their effects on others are over. None of us can afford such a narrow view of

business. The world is far too interconnected. A seemingly small corporate decision (em dash) to buy coffee beans directly from local growers or to install solar panels (em dash) can affect the lives and livelihoods of many people and determine the environmental health of whole regions. A business, just like a government or an individual, therefore has an ethical responsibility to act with compassion for the public good. ” ”

advantages businesses can expect to gain by embracing comprehensive CSR policies. Meanwhile, companies have very little to lose by embracing a socially conscious view. These days, compassion is profitable. Corporations would be wise to recognize the enormous power, opportunity, and responsibility they have to effect positive change.

Works Cited

Alphabetical
by author's
last name

Bejou, David. "Compassion as the New Philosophy of Business." *Journal of Relationship Marketing*, vol. 10, no. 1, 2011, pp. 1–6. *Business Source Complete*, doi:10.1080/15332667.2011.550098.

Hanging
indent ½"

Cone Communications. *2010 Cone Cause Evolution Study*, ppqty.com/2010_Cone_Study.pdf. Accessed 15 Mar. 2014.

An article on
a blog with-
out a known
author

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A clip from
YouTube

Guthrie, Doug. "Promoting a Comprehensive Approach to Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR)." George P. Schultz National Training College, Arlington, VA, 26 Apr. 2012. Address. YouTube, www.youtube.com/watch?v=99cJMe6wERc.

Karnani, Aneel. "The Case against Corporate Social Responsibility." *The Wall Street Journal*, Dow Jones, 23 Aug. 2010, www.wsj.com/articles/SB10001424052748703338004575230112664504890.

Meister, Jeanne. "Corporate Social Responsibility: A Lever for Employee Attraction & Engagement." *Forbes*, 7 June 2012, www.forbes.com/sites/jeannemeister/2012/06/07/corporate-social-responsibility-a-lever-for-employee-attraction-engagement/#.

Savitz, Andrew W., with Karl Weber. *The Triple Bottom Line: How Today's Best-Run Companies Are Achieving Economic, Social, and Environmental Success*. Jossey-Bass, 2006.

Description

"The paragraph reads as follows. Fortunately, corporations have many incentives to act responsibly. Customer loyalty, employee satisfaction, overall cost-savings, and long term viability are just some of the advantages businesses can expect to gain by embracing comprehensive CSR policies. Meanwhile, companies have very little to lose by embracing a socially conscious view. These days, compassion is profitable. Corporations would be wise to recognize the enormous power, opportunity, and responsibility they have to effect positive change. The corresponding annotation reads,

"Author ends on an upbeat note." The annotations corresponding to the citations are given in parentheses. The text under the "Works Cited" reads as follows. All entries utilize a hanging indent. Bejou, David. "Compassion as the New Philosophy of Business." *Journal of Relationship Marketing*, vol. 10, no. 1, 2011, pp. 1 to 6. Business Source Complete, d o i: 10.1080 slash 15332667.2011.550098.

(Alphabetical by author' s last name.) Cone Communications. 2010 Cone Cause Evolution Study, ppqty dot com slash 2010 underscore Cone underscore Study dot pdf. Accessed 15 Mar. 2014. (Hanging indent half inch.) "From Fringe to Mainstream: Companies Integrate C S R Initiatives into Everyday Business." Knowledge at Wharton, 14 Mar. 2014, knowledge dot wharton dot upenn dot edu slash article slash from en dash fringe en dash to en dash mainstream en dash companies en dash integrate en dash csr en dash initiatives en dash into en dash everyday en dash business slash. (An article on a blog without a known author.) Guthrie, Doug.

"Promoting a Comprehensive Approach to Corporate Social Responsibility (C S R)" George P. Schultz National Training College, Arlington, VA, (A clip from YouTube). Karnani,

Aneel. "The Case against Corporate Social Responsibility." The Wall Street Journal, Dow Jones, 23 Aug. 2010, w w w dot w s j dot com articles slash SB1000142405274870 3338004575230112664504890. Meister, Jeanne. "Corporate Social Responsibility: A Lever for Employee Attraction & Engagement." Forbes, 7 June 2012, w w w dot forbes dot com slash sites slash jeanne meister slash 2012 slash 06 slash 07 slash corporate en dash social en dash responsibility en dash a en dash lever en dash for en dash employee en dash attraction en dash engagement slash hash."

APA-STYLE DOCUMENTATION

The American Psychological Association (APA) recommends a simple, two-part system for documenting sources. The system consists of a brief *in-text citation* at the point where words or ideas have been borrowed from a source, and a *list of references* at the end of the paper, which includes complete bibliographical information for all sources cited in the text. The following recommendations are based on the *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association*, 7th ed. (2019).

In-Text Citations

APA style recommends the author-date citation system for sources cited in the text. At the appropriate point in the text, give the author's last name and year of publication. For all direct quotations, you must also include the page number preceded by *p.* (page numbers are not required with paraphrases and summaries). You can present this information in several different ways — at the beginning of the borrowed material: *According to DeAngelus (2017)*; at the end of the borrowed material: *(DeAngelus, 2017)*; or divided between the beginning and the end of the borrowed material: *According to DeAngelus, cognitive development can vary greatly from one*

child to another even within the same family (2017). When presenting the information parenthetically, use commas to separate the author's last name, year, and page number: (*DeAngelus, 2017, p. 27*). For a discussion of using signal phrases to integrate quotations, paraphrases, and summaries smoothly into your research paper, see [pages 230 – 32](#). If you are citing more than one source, list them in alphabetical order, in the same order as they appear in the references list, separated by semicolons: (*Andros, 2016; Carter, 2017; Zulin, 2007, p. 3*).

Each in-text citation directs your readers to the list of references should they want to pursue a particular source. Treat electronic sources as you would print sources, keeping in mind that some electronic sources use paragraph numbers instead of page numbers. Consider the following examples of APA in-text citations found in the opening paragraph of student Nancy Magnusson's paper "The English-Only Controversy."

In-Text Citations (APA Style)

Many people are surprised to discover that English is not the official language of the United States. Today, even as English literacy becomes a necessity for people in many parts of the world, some people in the United States believe its primacy is being threatened right at home. Much of the current controversy focuses on Hispanic communities with large Spanish-speaking populations who may feel little or no pressure to learn

English. Columnist and cultural critic Charles Krauthammer (2006) believes English should be America's official language. He notes that this country has been "blessed ... with a linguistic unity that brings a critically needed cohesion to a nation as diverse, multiracial and multiethnic as America" and that communities such as these threaten the bond created by a common language (p. 112). There are others, however, who think that the threat has been sensationalized, that "language does not threaten American unity. Benign neglect is a good policy for any country when it comes to language, and it's a good policy for America" (King, 1997, p. 64). Let's revisit the arguments on both sides of the English-only debate to determine what options are available to best serve America's growing number of non-English-speaking residents.

References

- King, R. D. (1997, April). Should English be the law? *Atlantic Monthly*, 279(4), 55 - 64.
- Krauthammer, C. (2006, June). In plain English: Let's make it official. *Time*, 167(24), 112.

In the preceding example, the student followed APA style guidelines for her reference list. When constructing the reference page for your paper, consult the following APA guidelines, where you will find model entries for common print and online sources.

List of References

In this section, you will find general APA guidelines for creating a list of references, followed by model entries that cover the citation situations you will encounter most often.

✓ For more practice, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers*: LearningCurve > Working with Sources (APA)

Guidelines for Constructing Your Reference Page

1. Place your list of sources on a separate page at the end of your paper.
2. Center the title *References*, in boldface type, at the top of the page. (See the model above.)
3. Double-space both within and between entries on your list.
4. Arrange your sources alphabetically by the authors' or editors' last names. If you have two or more authors with the same last name, alphabetize by the initials of the first name.
5. If you have two or more works by the same author, arrange them chronologically by year of publication, starting with the one published earliest. Arrange works published in the same year alphabetically by title, and use lowercase letters to differentiate them: (2013a), (2013b), (2013c). Include the author's name, including any initials, with all entries.

6. Reverse *all* authors' names within each entry, and use initials, not first and middle names (Burns, E. A.). Name up to twenty authors, separating names and parts of names with commas. Use an ampersand (&) instead of *and* before the last author's name. If there are more than twenty authors, use an ellipsis after the nineteenth author, followed by the last author's name.
7. If no author or editor is known, alphabetize by the first word of the title, not counting *A*, *An*, or *The*.
8. Begin each entry at the left margin, and indent subsequent lines five spaces.
9. Give the date of publication in parentheses after the last author's name, and add a period after it. For some journal, magazine, and newspaper articles, you will need to include the month and sometimes the day as well as the year (2017, December 2).
10. For book and article titles, capitalize the first word of the title, the first word of the subtitle if there is one, and any proper names. Begin all other words with lowercase letters. With titles of journals, capitalize all significant words (*Social Work with Groups: A Journal of Community and Clinical Practice*).
11. Italicize the titles of books, journals, magazines, newspapers, and websites. Do not italicize or put quotation marks around article titles.

12. For book publications, provide the publisher's name. For many commercial publishers, use shortened names, such as *Houghton* for Houghton Mifflin. Provide the full name of university presses, corporations, and professional associations. Omit such terms as *Publishers, Co.,* and *Inc.* Retain the term *Books* and, for academic publishers, *Press*.
13. Use the abbreviations *p.* and *pp.* for page numbers only for chapters or articles in edited books or reference works. When citing inclusive page numbers, give complete figures: 217 – 223.
14. For an online source, APA format stresses that you include the same elements, in the same order, as you would for a reference to a print source, and add as much electronic retrieval information as needed for others to locate each source. APA recommends using a DOI (digital object identifier), when available. Set the DOI as a URL in the following format:
<https://doi.org/xxxxxxx>. The DOI is more permanent and consistent than a typical URL. If no DOI is available, provide another URL where the source can be found. Include a retrieval statement before the URL (*Retrieved January 16, 2020, from ...*) only when the online source is intended to be updated regularly, as with social media pages or online dictionaries that are intended to be up-to-the-minute.

15. When dividing a URL at the end of a line, never insert a hyphen to mark the break. Do not italicize, underline, or use angle brackets with URLs, and do not add a period at the end of a URL.

PERIODICALS

JOURNAL ARTICLE WITH A DOI

Teresa, B. F. (2019). New dynamics of rent gap formation in New York City rent-regulated housing: Privatization, financialization, and uneven development. *Urban Geography*, 40(10), 1399 – 1421.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/02723638.2019.1603556>

APA requires that you provide the volume number, italicized, and the issue number in parentheses.

Kaplan, F. (2014). Linguistic capitalism and algorithmic mediation. *Representations*, 127(1), 57 – 63.
<https://doi.org/10.1525/rep.2014.127.1.57>

JOURNAL ARTICLE WITH A DOI AND MULTIPLE AUTHORS

When an article has up to 20 authors, present all the authors' names in your reference entry.

Melamed, D., Munn, C. W., Barry, L., Montgomery, B., & Okuwobi, O. F. (2019). Status characteristics, implicit bias, and the production of racial inequality. *American Sociological Review*, 84(6), 1013 – 1036.

<https://doi.org/10.1177/0003122419879101>

JOURNAL ARTICLE WITHOUT A DOI

Martin, R. H. (2019). Police recruit selection should include consideration of potential for future leadership. *Law Enforcement Executive Forum*, 19(4), 39 – 51.

If there is no DOI assigned and the article is retrieved online, provide the URL of the specific web page where you found the article.

Bertolt, B. & Masse, L. E. J. S. (2019). Mapping political homophobia in Senegal. *African Studies Quarterly*, 18(4), 21 – 39. <https://sites.clas.ufl.edu/africa-asq/files/v18i4a2.pdf>

MAGAZINE ARTICLE (MONTHLY OR WEEKLY)

Lidz, F. (2020, January–February). Nature’s pharmacy. *Smithsonian*, 50(1), 42 – 53.

Calhoun, A. (2020, January). The sleepless generation. *Time*, 195(2), 48 – 51.

ONLINE MAGAZINE ARTICLE

Ruzek, J. I. (2020, January). Disaster response, mental health, and community resilience. *Psychiatric Times*, 37(1).
<https://www.psychiatrictimes.com/climate-change/disaster-response-mental-health-and-community-resilience>

NEWSPAPER ARTICLE (DAILY OR WEEKLY)

Dallek, M. (2020, January 5). Swamp fever. *The Washington Post*, B1-B2.

When the article appears on discontinuous pages, provide all page numbers.

Wong, C. H., & Kazer, W. (2020, January 9). Hong Kong's protests reverberate in Taiwan. *The Wall Street Journal*, A1, A10.

ONLINE NEWSPAPER ARTICLE

Wilson, S. (2020, January 22). On Australia's Kangaroo Island, a fight to stay alive. *The Washington Post*.
https://www.washingtonpost.com/national/on-australias-kangaroo-island-a-fight-to-stay-alive/2020/01/21/2475a3ee-3c01-11ea-adf6-42d4cf92556b_story.html

BOOKS, REFERENCE BOOKS, AND BOOK CHAPTERS

BOOK WITH ONE AUTHOR

Brown, B. (2017). *Braving the wilderness: The quest for true belonging and the courage to stand alone*. Random House.

BOOK WITH TWO TO TWENTY AUTHORS

Beck, E., Britto, S., & Andrews, A. (2007). *In the shadow of death: Restorative justice and death row families*. Oxford University Press.

ELECTRONIC VERSION OF A PRINT BOOK

Dewey, J. (1916). *Democracy and education: An introduction to the philosophy of education*.
<https://www.gutenberg.org/files/852/852-h/852-h.htm>

BOOK WITH A GROUP OR AN INSTITUTIONAL AUTHOR

National Association for the Advancement of Colored People.
(1994). *Beyond the Rodney King story: An investigation of police conduct in minority communities*. Northeastern University Press.

EDITED BOOK

Cobb, S., Federman, S., & Castel, A. (Eds.). (2019).
Introduction to conflict resolution: Discourses and dynamics. Rowman & Littlefield.

EDITION OTHER THAN THE FIRST

Leopold, Aldo. (1989). *A Sand County almanac and other sketches here and there* (commemorative ed.). Oxford University Press.

ARTICLE OR CHAPTER IN AN EDITED BOOK OR ANTHOLOGY

Lake-Liotta, R. (2011). Words save lives. In M. Andreas (Ed.), *Sweet fruit from the bitter tree: 61 stories of creative and compassionate ways out of conflict* (pp. 274 – 279). Real People Press.

ARTICLE IN A REFERENCE BOOK

Anagnost, G. T. (2005). Sandra Day O’ Connor. In *The Oxford Companion to the Supreme Court of the United States* (2nd ed., pp. 701 – 704). Oxford University Press.

ENTRY IN AN ONLINE REFERENCE BOOK

Peterson, M. (2019). The St. Petersburg paradox. In E. N. Zalta (Ed.), *The Stanford encyclopedia of philosophy* (Fall 2019 ed.). <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/paradox-stpetersburg/>

GOVERNMENT PUBLICATION, PRINT AND ONLINE

U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development. (2000). *Welfare to work: Reaching a new workforce*. Government Printing Office.

Child Welfare Information Gateway (2019). *Adopting as a single parent*. U. S. Department of Health and Human Services.
https://www.childwelfare.gov/pubPDFs/single_parent.pdf

ADVERTISEMENT, PRINT OR ONLINE

Google. (2019, November 12). [Advertisement]. *Washington Examiner*, 25(40), 5.

Ford Motor Company. (2020). 2020 Fusion [Advertisement].
<http://www.ford.com/cars/fusion/>

An Annotated Student APA-Style Research Paper

Laura DeVeau was free to choose her own topic when it came time to write a research paper for her English 002 class. After considering a number of possible topics and doing some research on several of them, she turned to a subject that interested her: the effects of religion and spirituality on the mental health of society.

DeVeau was particularly interested to learn that historically, psychology professionals saw little value in religion and spirituality and, in fact, viewed them as having a negative impact on the mental health of individuals and society in general. This jarred with her own experience, and

DeVeau set out in her first draft to document the psychological benefits and value of spiritual and religious beliefs. Once finished with the draft, she put it aside for a day before reading it carefully in an effort to see how she could strengthen it. DeVeau reworked her opening two paragraphs. In the first paragraph, she clearly described her research dilemma: the wide variety of opinions about the impact of religion on a person's life. In the second paragraph, she focused the scope of her project on her disagreement with professionals in the field of psychology who claim that religious feelings are not compatible with sound mental health. DeVeau then looked at all of her examples to make sure that they were well organized and persuasive. Finally, she scoured her sources to make sure that she was using the materials that best supported or illustrated the points she wanted to make about the value of spirituality and religion.

The final draft of DeVeau's research paper shows that she has learned how the parts of a well-researched and well-written paper fit together and how to make revisions that emulate some of the qualities of the model essays she has read and studied in class. On the following pages you will see the cover page (required for all APA-style research papers), first page, and list of references from DeVeau's paper.

**The Role of Spirituality and Religion
in Mental Health**

Laura DeVeau

Department of English, University of Vermont

ENG 002: Written Expression

Professor Gardner

April 12, 2010

The APA-
style cover
page gives
title, author,
and course
information

Description

"The text at the center of the page reads as follows. The Role of Spirituality and Religion in Mental Health. Laura DeVeau. Department of English, University of Vermont. E N G 002: Written expression. Professor Gardner. April 12, 2010. The corresponding annotation reads, The A P A style cover page gives title, author, and course information. "

The Role of Spirituality and Religion in Mental Health

It has been called “a vestige of the childhood of mankind,” “the feeling of something true, total and absolute,” “an otherworldly answer as regards the meaning of life” (Jones, 1991, p. 1; Amaro, 1998; Kristeva, 1987, p. 27). It has been compared to medicine, described as a psychological cure for mental illness, and also referred to as the cause of a dangerous fanaticism. With so many differing opinions on the impact of religion in people’s lives, where would one begin a search for the truth? Who has the answer: Christians, humanists, objectivists, atheists, psychoanalysts, Buddhists, philosophers, cults? This was my dilemma at the advent of my research into how religion and spirituality affect the mental health of society as a whole.

Citation
of multiple
works from
references

In this paper, I explore the claims, widely accepted by professionals in the field of psychology, that religious and spiritual practices have a negative impact on mental health. In addition, though, I cannot help but reflect on how this exploration has changed my beliefs as well. Religion is such a personal experience that one cannot be dispassionate in reporting it. One can, however, subject the evidence provided by those who have studied the issue to critical scrutiny. Having done so, I find myself in disagreement with those who claim religious feelings are incompatible with sound mental health. There is a nearly limitless number of beliefs regarding spirituality. Some are organized and involve rituals like mass or worship. Many are centered around the existence of a higher being, while others focus on the self. I have attempted to uncover the perfect set of values that lead to a better lifestyle, but my research has pointed me in an entirely different direction, where no single belief seems to be adequate but where spiritual belief in general should be valued more highly than it is currently in mental health circles.

Acknowledgment of
opposing
viewpoints

Thesis
explicitly
introduced

Description

"The title of the research paper reads, The role of spirituality and religion in mental health. The first paragraph reads: It has been called "a vestige of the childhood of mankind," "the feeling of something true, total and absolute," "an otherworldly answer as regards the meaning of life" (Jones, 1991, p. 1; Amaro, 1998; Kristeva, 1987, p. 27). It has been compared to medicine, described as a psychological cure for mental illness, and also referred to as the cause of a dangerous fanaticism. With so many differing opinions on the impact of religion in people's lives, where would one begin a search for the truth? Who has the answer: Christians, humanists, objectivists, atheists, psychoanalysts, Buddhists, philosophers, cults? This was my dilemma at the advent of my research into how religion and spirituality affect the mental health of society as a whole. The corresponding annotation reads, "Citation of multiple works from references." The second paragraph reads: In this paper, I explore the claims, widely accepted by professionals in the field of psychology, that religious and spiritual practices have a negative impact on mental health. In addition, though, I cannot help but reflect on how this exploration has changed my beliefs as well. Religion is such a personal experience that one cannot be dispassionate in reporting it. One can, however, subject the evidence provided by those who have studied the issue to critical scrutiny. Having done so, I find myself in disagreement with those who claim religious feelings are incompatible with sound mental health. There is a nearly limitless number of beliefs regarding spirituality. Some are organized and involve rituals like mass or worship. Many are centered around the existence of a higher being,

while others focus on the self. I have attempted to uncover the perfect set of values that lead to a better lifestyle, but my research has pointed me in an entirely different direction, where no single belief seems to be adequate but where spiritual belief in general should be valued more highly than it is currently in mental health circles.” An annotation corresponding to the first half of the second paragraph reads, “Acknowledgment of Opposing viewpoints.” Another annotation corresponding to the second half of the second paragraph reads, “Thesis explicitly introduced.” ”

References
begin on a
new page

An online
source

A book

An article or
a chapter in
a book

An article
in a journal

Anonymous
source alpha-
betized by
title

References

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- Pargament, K. I., Smith, B. W., Koenig, H. G., & Perez, L. (1998). Patterns of positive and negative religious coping with major life stressors. *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion*, 37(4), 710–724.
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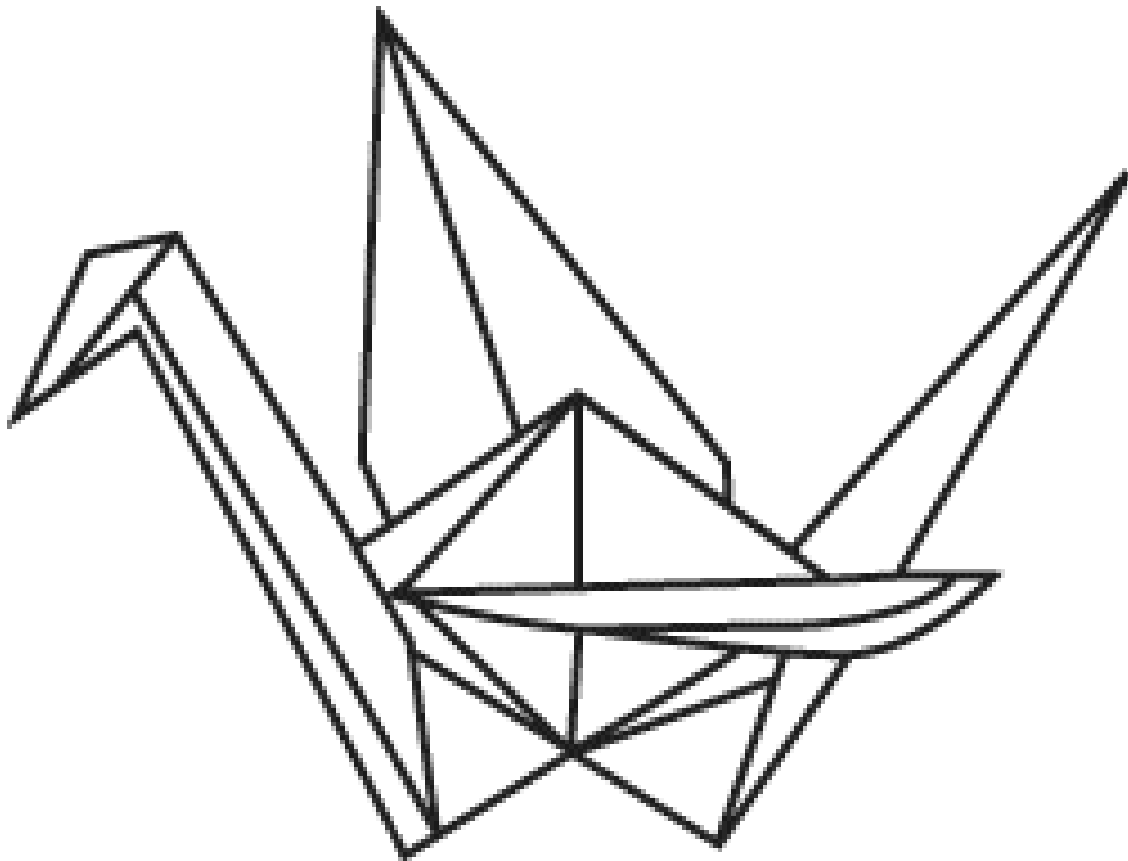
Description

"A header reads: References. A corresponding annotation reads, References begin on a new page. Page references read as follows. J. (1998). Psychology, psychoanalysis and religious faith. Nielsen's psychology of religion page. Retrieved from <http://www.psywww.com/psyrelig/amaro.htm>. A corresponding annotation reads, An online source. Beyerman A. K. (1989). The holistic health movement. Alabama University Press. A corresponding annotation reads, A book. Dein, S. (2010, January). Religion, spirituality, and mental health. *Psychiatric Times*, 20(1): 1 to 3. Retrieved from <http://www.psychiatrictimes.com/articles/religion-spirituality-and-mental-health>. Ellis, A. (1993). Dogmatic devotion doesn't help, it hurts. In B. Slife (Ed.), *Taking sides: Clashing views on controversial psychological issues* (pp. 297 to 301). New York, NY: Scribner. A corresponding annotation reads, An article or a chapter in a book. Jones, J. W. (1991). Contemporary psychoanalysis and religion: Transference and transcendence. Yale University Press. Kristeva, J. (1987). *In the beginning was love: Psychoanalysis and faith*. Columbia University Press. Larson, D. (1998). Does religious commitment improve mental health? In B. Slife (Ed.), *Taking sides: Clashing views on controversial psychological issues* (pp. 292 to 296). Scribner. Pargament, K. I., Smith, B. W., Koenig, H. G., & Perez, L. (1998). Patterns of positive and negative religious coping with major life stressors. *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion*, 37, 710 to 724. A corresponding annotation reads, An article in a journal. "Psychological benefits." (1999). *Walking the labyrinth*.

Retrieved April 3, 2000, from h t t p colon slash slash w w
w dot labyrinth way dot com slash h t m l slash benefits dot
h t m l. A corresponding annotation reads, Anonymous source
alphabetized by title. Verghese, A. (2008). Spirituality and
mental health. Indian Journal of Psychiatry, 50(4) colon 233
to 237. d o i: 10.4103 slash 0019-5545.44742. "



CHAPTER 24 Editing for Grammar, Punctuation, and Sentence Style



Once you have revised your essay and you are confident that you have said what you wanted to say, you are ready to begin editing your essay. Remember that when you are *revising*, you are (re)considering the most important elements of your essay: thesis, purpose, content, organization, and paragraph structure. If these pieces are not in place and clear to your reader, you will be adding and changing sentences to communicate your ideas, which might lead you to eliminate

editing errors or introduce new ones. Therefore, you typically move on to *editing* after revision (though it is important to note that you can — and should — return to revision often because the writing process does not always move easily from one step to another).

It is at the editing stage of the writing process that you identify and correct errors in grammar, punctuation, and sentence style. You don't want a series of small errors to detract from your paper. Such errors can also cause readers to have second thoughts about your credibility as an author, leading them to distrust *what* you are saying because of *how* you say or write it.

However, you may have difficulty identifying editing errors because they are not easy to spot and they take time to learn. To help you, this chapter addresses ten common writing problems that instructors from around the country told us trouble their students most. As you edit your essay, you can use this chapter as a guide, checking for these specific errors (see, especially, the Questions for Editing Sentences checklist on [p. 641](#)). Or, if you know you struggle with one or more of these errors — or if your instructor or peer has pointed out an error to you in their feedback — you can learn from the examples in this chapter how to identify the error and how to correct it. For more detailed guidance with

these and other editing concerns, be sure to refer to a writer' s handbook or ask your instructor for help.

☑ For more help with grammar, punctuation, and sentence style, visit Achieve for *Models for Writers* and navigate to LearningCurve, game-like quizzing activities that help you practice and improve your writing skills.

RUN-ONS: FUSED SENTENCES AND COMMA SPLICES

Writers can become so absorbed in getting their ideas down on paper that they often combine two independent clauses (complete sentences that can stand alone when punctuated with a period) incorrectly, creating a *run-on sentence*. A run-on sentence fails to show where one thought ends and where another begins and can confuse readers. There are two types of run-on sentences: the fused sentence and the comma splice.

A *fused sentence* occurs when a writer combines two independent clauses with no punctuation at all. To correct a fused sentence, divide the independent clauses into separate sentences, or join them by adding words, punctuation, or both.

INCORRECT	Jen loves Harry Potter she was the first in line to buy the latest book.
EDITED	Jen loves Harry Potter ^{. She} she was the first in line to buy the latest book. ^
EDITED	Jen loves Harry Potter ^{; in fact,} she was the first in line to buy the latest book. ^

"Incorrect: Jen loves Harry Potter she was the first in line to buy the latest book. Edited: The word "she" is replaced with a period followed by the "period She" where S is in uppercase. Edited: "Semicolon in fact," is inserted between the words "Potter" and "she." "

INCORRECT	The email looked like spam, Marty deleted it.
EDITED	The email looked like spam, ^o Marty deleted it. ^
EDITED	The email looked like spam, ^{so} Marty deleted it. ^

"Incorrect: The e-mail looked like spam, Marty deleted it.
 Edited: The comma after the word "spam" is replaced with a
 period. Edited: The word "so" is inserted before the word
 "Marty." "

SENTENCE FRAGMENTS

A *sentence fragment* is a word group that cannot stand alone as a complete sentence. Even if a word group begins with a capital letter and ends with punctuation, it is not a sentence unless it has a subject (the person, place, or thing the sentence is about) and a verb (a word that tells what the subject does) and expresses a complete thought. Word groups that do not express complete thoughts often begin with a subordinating conjunction such as *although*, *because*, *since*, or *unless*. To correct a fragment, add a subject or a verb, or integrate the fragment into a nearby sentence to complete the thought.

INCORRECT Divided my time between work and school last semester.

EDITED ^{*I divided*}
~~Divided~~ my time between work and school last semester.

INCORRECT Terry's essay was really interesting. Because it brought up good points about energy conservation.

EDITED ^{*because*}
Terry's essay was really interesting/ ~~Because~~ it brought up good points about energy conservation.

Description

"Incorrect: Divided my time between work and school last semester. Edited: The word "Divided" is replaced with the words "I divided." Incorrect: Terry's essay was really interesting. Because it brought up good points about energy conservation. Edited: The period after the word "interesting" is deleted. The uppercase "B" in the word "Because" is replaced with a lowercase "b." "

Creative use of intentional sentence fragments is occasionally acceptable — in narration essays, for example — when writers are trying to establish a particular mood or tone.

I asked him about his recent trip. He asked me about work.
Short questions. One-word answers. Then an awkward pause.

– David P. Bardeen, "LIVES; Not Close Enough for Comfort"

✓ LearningCurve > Fragments

SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT

Subjects and verbs must agree in number — that is, a singular subject (one person, place, or thing) must take a singular verb, and a plural subject (more than one person, place, or thing) must take a plural verb. Most native speakers of English use proper subject-verb agreement in their writing without conscious awareness. Even so, some sentence constructions can be troublesome.

When a prepositional phrase (a phrase that includes a preposition such as *on*, *of*, *in*, *at*, or *between*) falls between a subject and a verb, it can obscure their relationship. To make sure the subject agrees with its verb in a sentence with an intervening prepositional phrase, mentally cross out the phrase (*of basic training* in the following example) to isolate the subject and verb and determine if they agree.

INCORRECT The first three weeks of basic training is the worst.

EDITED The first three weeks of basic training^{*are*}~~is~~ the worst.
 ^

Description

”Incorrect: The first three weeks of basic training is the worst. Edited: The word “is” is replaced with the word “are.” ”

Writers often have difficulty with subject-verb agreement in sentences with compound subjects (two or more subjects joined together with the word *and*). As a general rule, compound subjects take plural verbs.

INCORRECT My mother, sister, and cousin is visiting me next month.

EDITED My mother, sister, and cousin^{are} ~~is~~[^] visiting me next month.

Description

“Incorrect: My mother, sister, and cousin is visiting me next month. Edited: The word “is” is replaced with the word “are.” ”

However, in sentences with subjects joined by *either ... or*, *neither ... nor*, or *not only ... but also*, the verb must agree with the subject closest to it.

INCORRECT Neither the mechanics nor the salesperson know
what's wrong with my car.

EDITED Neither the mechanics nor the salesperson ^{knows}~~know~~_^
what's wrong with my car.

Description

"Incorrect: Neither the mechanics nor the salesperson know what's wrong with my car. Edited: The word "know" is replaced with the word "knows." "

While editing your essay, be sure to identify the subjects and verbs in your sentences and to check their agreement.



LearningCurve > Subject-Verb Agreement

PRONOUN-ANTECEDENT AGREEMENT

A *pronoun* is a word that takes the place of a noun in a sentence. To avoid repeating nouns in our speech and writing, we use pronouns as noun substitutes. The noun to which a pronoun refers is called its *antecedent*. A pronoun and its antecedent are said to *agree* when the relationship between them is clear. Pronouns must agree with their antecedents in both *person* and *number*.

There are three types of pronouns: first person (*I* and *we*), second person (*you*), and third person (*he*, *she*, *they*, and *it*). First-person pronouns refer to first-person antecedents, second-person pronouns refer to second-person antecedents, and third-person pronouns refer to third-person antecedents.

INCORRECT House hunters should review their finances carefully before you make an offer.

EDITED House hunters should review their finances carefully
before ^{they}~~you~~ make an offer.

Description

"Incorrect: House hunters should review their finances carefully before you make an offer. Edited: The word "you" is replaced with the word "they." "

pronoun to refer to it or recast the sentence to eliminate the agreement problem.

INCORRECT	Each of the women submitted their résumé.
EDITED	Each of the women submitted ^{her} their résumé.
EDITED	^{Both} Each of the women submitted ^{résumés} their resume .

Description

"Incorrect: Each of the women submitted their résumé.

Edited: The word "their" is replaced with the word

"her." Edited: The word "Each" is replaced with the word

"Both." The word "resume" is replaced with the word

"résumés." "

✓ LearningCurve > Pronouns

VERB TENSE SHIFTS

A verb's tense indicates when an action takes place — sometime in the past, right now, or in the future. Using verb tense consistently helps your readers understand time changes in your writing. Inconsistent verb tenses, or *shifts*, within a sentence confuse readers and are especially noticeable in narration and process analysis writing, which are sequence and time oriented. Generally, you should write in the past or present tense and maintain that tense throughout your sentence.

INCORRECT The painter studied the scene and pulls a fan brush decisively from her cup.

EDITED The painter studied the scene and ^{pulled}~~pulls~~ a fan brush decisively from her cup.

Description

"Incorrect: The painter studied the scene and pulls a fan brush decisively from her cup. Edited: The word "pulls" is replaced with the word "pulled." "

MISPLACED AND DANGLING MODIFIERS

A *modifier* is a word or words that describe or give additional information about other words in a sentence. Always place modifiers as close as possible to the words they modify. An error in modifier placement could be unintentionally confusing (or amusing) to your readers. Two common problems arise with modifiers: the misplaced modifier and the dangling modifier.

A *misplaced modifier* unintentionally modifies the wrong word in a sentence because it is placed incorrectly.

INCORRECT The waiter brought a steak to the man covered with onions.

EDITED

The waiter brought a steak to the man ^{*covered with onions*} [⊙] ~~covered with onions.~~

^ ^

Description

”Incorrect: The waiter brought a steak to the man covered with onions. Edited: A period is inserted after the word “man.” The phrase “covered with onions” is deleted and inserted between the words “steak” and “to.” ”

FAULTY PARALLELISM

Parallelism means using similar grammatical forms to show that ideas in a sentence are of equal importance. Faulty parallelism can interrupt the flow of your writing and confuse your readers. Writers have trouble with parallelism in three kinds of sentence constructions.

In sentences that include items in a pair or series, make sure the elements of the pair or series are parallel in form. Delete any unnecessary or repeated words.

INCORRECT	Nina likes snowboarding, roller skating, and to hike.
EDITED	Nina likes snowboarding, roller skating, and ^{hiking.} to hike.

Description

"Incorrect: Nina likes snowboarding, roller skating, and to hike. Edited: The words "to hike" are replaced with the word "hiking." "

In sentences that include connecting words such as *both ... and*, *either ... or*, *neither ... nor*, *rather ... than*, and *not only ... but also*, make sure the elements being connected are parallel in form. Delete any unnecessary or repeated words.

INCORRECT The lecture was both enjoyable and it was a form of education.

EDITED

The lecture was both enjoyable and it^{educational.} ~~was a form of education.~~

Description

"Incorrect: The lecture was both enjoyable and it was a form of education. Edited: The words "it was a form of education" are replaced with the word "educational." "

In sentences that include the comparison word *as* or *than*, make sure the elements of the comparison are parallel in form. Delete any unnecessary or repeated words.

INCORRECT It would be better to study now than waiting until
the night before the exam.

[illegible]

Description

“Incorrect: It would be better to study now than waiting until the night before the exam. Edited: The word “waiting” is replaced with the words “to wait.” ”

WEAK NOUNS AND VERBS

Inexperienced writers often believe that adjectives and adverbs are the stuff of effective writing. They’ re right in one sense but not wholly so. Although strong adjectives and adverbs are crucial, good writing depends on strong, well-chosen nouns and verbs. The noun *vehicle* is not nearly as descriptive as *Jeep*, *snowmobile*, *pickup truck*, or *SUV*, for example. Why use the weak verb *look* when your meaning would be conveyed more precisely with *glance*, *stare*, *spy*, *gaze*, *peek*, *examine*, or *witness*? Instead of the weak verb *run*, use *fly*, *gallop*, *hustle*, *jog*, *race*, *rush*, *scamper*, *scoot*, *scramble*, or *trot*.

While editing your essay, look for instances of weak nouns and verbs. If you can’ t form a clear picture in your mind of what a noun looks like or what a verb’ s action is, your nouns and verbs are likely weak. The more specific and strong you make your nouns and verbs, the more lively and descriptive your writing will be.

WEAK	The flowers moved toward the bright light of the sun.
EDITED	^{tulips stretched} The flowers moved toward the bright light of the sun. ^

Description

"Weak: The flowers moved toward the bright light of the sun.
Edited: The tulips stretched toward the bright light of the sun. The weak noun and verb, "flowers moved" are replaced with the words "tulips stretched." "

When you have difficulty thinking of strong, specific nouns and verbs, reach for a thesaurus — but only if you are sure you can identify the best word for your purpose. Thesauruses are available free online and in inexpensive paperback editions; most word processing programs include a thesaurus as well. A thesaurus will help you avoid redundancy in your writing and find specific words with just the right meaning.

ACADEMIC DICTION AND TONE

The language that you use in your college courses, known as *American Standard English*, is formal in diction and objective in tone. American Standard English is the language used by educators, civic leaders, the media, and professionals in all fields. Although the standard is fairly narrow in scope, it allows for individual differences in expression and voice so that your writing can retain its personality and appeal.

Tone is the distance that you establish between yourself and your audience and is created by your *diction* (the particular words you choose) and the complexity of your sentences.

Formal writing creates a distance between yourself and your audience through the use of third-person pronouns (*he, she, it, they*) and provides the impression of objectivity. Formal writing values logic, evidence, and reason over opinion and bias. Informal writing, on the other hand, uses first-person pronouns (*I, we*); is usually found in narratives; and respects feelings, individual tastes, and personal preferences. Similarly, the second-person pronoun (*you*) is used to bring your reader close to you, as is done in this text, but it is too familiar for most academic writing and is best avoided if there is any question about its appropriateness.

INFORMAL	The experiment looked like it was going to be a bust.
FORMAL	After detecting a number of design flaws in the experiment, we concluded that it was going to be a failure.
SUBJECTIVE	The governor said that the shortfall in tax revenues was quite a bit bigger than anyone expected.
OBJECTIVE	The governor reported that tax revenues fell by 9 percent over last year.

When writing in a particular discipline, use discipline-specific language and conventions that reflect your understanding of the discipline. Key resources are your readings and the language you use with your instructors and classmates in each discipline. As you read, note how the writer uses technical language (for example, *point of view* and *denouement* in literature; *mean distribution* in statistics; *derivatives* in financial analysis; *pan*, *tilt*, and *track* in film study; *exogamy* and *endogamy* in anthropology; and *polyphony* and *atonality* in music) to communicate difficult concepts, recognized phenomena in the discipline, and characteristic nuances of the discipline.

Discipline-Specific Prose (Psychology)

How does information get “into” long-term memory? One very important function that takes place in short-term memory is *encoding*, or transforming the new information into a form that

can be retrieved later. As a student, you may have tried to memorize dates, facts, or definitions by simply repeating them to yourself over and over. This strategy reflects an attempt to use maintenance rehearsal to encode material into long-term memory. However, maintenance rehearsal is *not* a very effective strategy for encoding information into long-term memory.

A much more effective encoding strategy is *elaborative rehearsal*, which involves focusing on the *meaning* of information to help encode and transfer it to long-term memory. With elaborative rehearsal, you relate the information to other information you already know. That is, rather than simply repeating the information, you *elaborate* on the new information in some meaningful way.

—Don H. Hockenbury and Sandra E. Hockenbury, “Encoding Long-Term Memories,” from *Psychology*, Eighth Edition

If you listen carefully and read closely, you will be able to discern the discipline-specific language cues that make a writer sound more like, say, a historian or an anthropologist than a psychologist. In turn, you will be able to use the language of your own discipline with greater ease and accuracy and achieve the subtleties of language that will allow you to carry out your research, draw sound conclusions, and write effectively and with authority.

 LearningCurve > Appropriate Language

ESL CONCERNS (ARTICLES AND NOUNS)

Two areas of English grammar that can be especially problematic for nonnative speakers of English are articles and nouns. In English, correct use of articles and nouns is necessary for sentences to make sense.

There are two kinds of articles in English: *indefinite* (*a* and *an*) and *definite* (*the*). Use *a* before words beginning with a consonant sound and *an* before words beginning with a vowel sound. Note, too, that *a* is used before an *h* with a consonant sound (*happy*) and *an* is used before a silent *h* (*hour*).

There are two kinds of nouns in English: count and noncount. *Count nouns* name individual things or units that can be counted or separated out from a whole, such as *students* and *pencils*. *Noncount nouns* name things that cannot be counted because they are considered wholes in themselves and cannot be divided, such as *work* and *furniture*.

Use the indefinite article (*a* or *an*) before a singular count noun when you do not specify which one.

I would like to borrow *a* colored pencil.

Plural count nouns take *the*.

I would like to borrow *the* colored pencils.

If a plural count noun is used in a general sense, it does not take an article at all.

I brought colored pencils to class today.

Noncount nouns are always singular and never take an indefinite article.

We need new living room furniture.

The is sometimes used with noncount nouns to refer to a specific idea or thing.

The furniture will be delivered tomorrow.

When editing your essay, be sure you have used articles and nouns correctly.

INCORRECT	I love an aroma of freshly baked cookies.
-----------	---

EDITED	I love ^{<i>the</i>} an ^ aroma of freshly baked cookies.
--------	--

INCORRECT	I have never had the chicken pox.
-----------	-----------------------------------

EDITED	I have never had the chicken pox.
--------	--

Description

"Incorrect: I love an aroma of freshly baked cookies.

Edited: The article "an" is replaced with the article

"the." Incorrect: I have never had the chicken pox.

Edited: The article "the" is deleted."

✓ LearningCurve for Multilingual Writers > Articles and
Types of Nouns

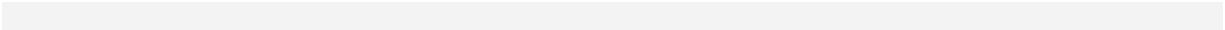
✓ LearningCurve for Multilingual Writers > Prepositions

✓ LearningCurve for Multilingual Writers > Sentence
Structure

✓ LearningCurve for Multilingual Writers > Verbs

Questions for Editing Sentences

1. Do I include any fused sentences or comma splices?
2. Do I include any unintentional sentence fragments?
3. Do my verbs agree with their subjects?
4. Do my pronouns agree with their antecedents?
5. Do I make any unnecessary shifts in verb tense?
6. Do I have any misplaced or dangling modifiers?
7. Are my sentences parallel?
8. Do I use strong nouns and verbs?
9. Do I pair articles and nouns correctly?



Glossary of Useful Terms

Abstract

See [*Concrete/Abstract*](#).

Allusion

A passing reference to a familiar person, place, or thing, often drawn from history, the Bible, mythology, or literature. An allusion is an economical way for a writer to capture the essence of an idea, atmosphere, emotion, or historical era, as in “The scandal was his Watergate” or “He saw himself as a modern Job.” An allusion should be familiar to the reader; if it is not, it will add nothing to the meaning.

Analogy

A special form of comparison in which the writer explains something unfamiliar by comparing it to something familiar: “A transmission line is simply a pipeline for electricity. In the case of a water pipeline, more water will flow through the pipe as water pressure increases. The same is true of electricity in a transmission line.”

Analysis

An examination of a reading or a source to understand the writer’s main point and to assess the piece of writing for its relevance, bias, overall argument, and reliability.

Anecdote

A short narrative about an amusing or interesting event. Writers often use anecdotes to begin essays as well as to illustrate certain points.

Argumentation

The art of arguing, or attempting to persuade the reader to agree with a point of view, to make a given decision, or to pursue a particular course of action. There are two basic types of argumentation: logical and persuasive. See [*the introduction to*](#)

[Chapter 22](#) (pp. 521 – 30) for a detailed discussion of argumentation.

Attitude

A reflection of the writer's opinion of a subject. The writer can think very positively or very negatively about a subject or have an attitude that falls somewhere in between. See also [Tone](#).

Audience

The intended readership for a piece of writing. For example, the readers of a national weekly news magazine come from all walks of life and have diverse interests, opinions, and educational backgrounds. In contrast, the readership of an organic chemistry journal is made up of people whose interests and education are quite similar. The essays in *Models for Writers* are intended for general readers, intelligent people who may lack specific information about the subject being discussed.

Beginnings and Endings

A beginning is the sentence, group of sentences, or section that introduces an essay. Good beginnings usually identify the thesis or controlling idea, attempt to interest readers, and establish a tone.

An ending is the sentence or group of sentences that brings an essay to a close. Good endings are purposeful and well planned. Endings satisfy readers when they are the natural outgrowths of the essays themselves and give readers a sense of finality or completion. Good essays do not simply stop; they conclude. See [the introduction to Chapter 6](#) (pp. 133 – 41) for a detailed discussion of beginnings and endings.

Cause and Effect

A type of analysis or writing strategy that explains the reasons for an occurrence or the consequences of an action. See [the](#)

[introduction to Chapter 21](#) (pp. 495 – 97) for a detailed discussion of cause and effect.

Citation

A reference to a published or unpublished work that indicates that the material being referenced is not original to the present author. A citation allows a reader to find and examine the referenced material to verify its authenticity, accuracy, and appropriateness.

Classification

See [Division and Classification](#).

Cliché

An expression that has become ineffective through overuse. Expressions such as *quick as a flash*, *jump for joy*, and *slow as molasses* are clichés. Good writers normally avoid such trite expressions and seek instead to express themselves in fresh and forceful language. See also [Diction](#).

Coherence

A quality of good writing that results when all sentences, paragraphs, and longer divisions of an essay are naturally connected. Coherent writing is achieved through (1) a logical sequence of ideas (arranged in chronological order, spatial order, order of importance, or some other appropriate order), (2) the purposeful repetition of key words and ideas, (3) a pace suitable for your topic and your reader, and (4) the use of transitional words and expressions. Coherence should not be confused with *Unity*. See also [Transition](#).

Colloquial Expression

An expression that is characteristic of or appropriate to spoken language or to writing that seeks the effect of spoken language. Colloquial expressions are informal, such as *chem*, *gym*, *come up with*, *be at wit's end*, *won't*, and *photo*. These types of

expressions are acceptable in formal writing only if they are used purposefully. See also [*Diction*](#).

Comparison and Contrast

A type of analysis or writing strategy used to point out the similarities and differences between two or more subjects in the same class or category. The function of any comparison and contrast is to clarify — to reach some conclusion about the items being compared and contrasted. See [the introduction to Chapter 20](#) (pp. 467–71) for a detailed discussion of comparison and contrast.

Conclusions

See [*Beginnings and Endings*](#).

Concrete/Abstract

A concrete word names a specific object, person, place, or action that can be directly perceived by the senses, such as *car*, *bread*, *building*, *book*, *John F. Kennedy*, *Chicago*, or *hiking*. An abstract word, in contrast, refers to general qualities, conditions, ideas, actions, or relationships that cannot be directly perceived by the senses, such as *bravery*, *dedication*, *excellence*, *anxiety*, *stress*, *thinking*, or *hatred*. See [the introduction to Chapter 12](#) (p. 289) for more on abstract and concrete words.

Connotation/Denotation

Both connotation and denotation refer to the meanings of words. Denotation is the dictionary meaning of a word, the literal meaning. Connotation, on the other hand, is the implied or suggested meaning of a word. For example, the denotation of *lamb* is “a young sheep.” The connotations of *lamb* are numerous: *gentle*, *docile*, *weak*, *peaceful*, *blessed*, *sacrificial*, *blood*, *spring*, *frisky*, *pure*, *innocent*, and so on. See [the introduction to Chapter 12](#) (p. 288) for more on connotation and denotation.

Controlling Idea

See [*Thesis*](#).

Coordination

The joining of grammatical constructions of the same rank (words, phrases, and clauses) to indicate that they are of equal importance. For example, “*They ate hot dogs, and we ate hamburgers.*” See [the introduction to Chapter 9](#) (pp. 205 – 06) for more on coordination. See also [Subordination](#).

Deduction

The process of reasoning from stated premises to a conclusion that necessarily follows. This form of reasoning moves from the general to the specific. See [the introduction to Chapter 22](#) (p. 524) for a discussion of deductive reasoning and its role in argumentation. See also [Syllogism](#).

Definition

The stated meaning of a word or concept. A definition may be either brief or extended, part of an essay, or an entire essay. See [the introduction to Chapter 18](#) (pp. 422 – 24) for a detailed discussion of definition.

Denotation

See [Connotation/Denotation](#).

Description

A rhetorical pattern that tells how a person, place, or thing is perceived by the five senses. See [the introduction to Chapter 16](#) (pp. 385 – 87) for a detailed discussion of description.

Details

The small elements that collectively contribute to the overall impression of a person, place, thing, or idea. For example, in the sentence “The *organic, whole-grain* dog biscuits were *reddish brown, beef-flavored*, and in the *shape of a bone*,” the italicized words are details.

Dialogue

The conversation between two or more people as represented in writing. Dialogue is what people say directly to one another.

Diction

A writer's choice and use of words. Good diction is precise and appropriate: the words mean exactly what the writer intends, and the words are well suited to the writer's subject, intended audience, and purpose in writing. The word-conscious writer knows that there are differences among *aged*, *old*, and *elderly*; *blue*, *navy*, and *azure*; and *disturbed*, *angry*, and *irritated*. Furthermore, that writer knows in which situation to use each word. See [the introduction to Chapter 12](#) (pp. 288–91) for a detailed discussion of diction. See also [Cliché](#), [Colloquial Expression](#), [Connotation/Denotation](#), [Jargon](#), and [Slang](#).

Direct Quotation

Material that has been borrowed word for word and must be placed within quotation marks and properly cited.

Division and Classification

Rhetorical patterns used by the writer to first establish categories and then to arrange or sort people, places, or things into these categories according to their different characteristics, thus making them more manageable for the writer and more understandable and meaningful for the reader. See [the introduction to Chapter 19](#) (pp. 443–46) for a detailed discussion of division and classification.

Documentation

The act or the instance of providing documents or references as to where documents or other material may be found.

Dominant Impression

The single mood, atmosphere, or quality a writer wishes to emphasize [per text] in a piece of descriptive writing. The dominant impression is created through the careful selection of details; it is influenced by the essay's subject, audience, and

purpose. See [the introduction to Chapter 16](#) (pp. 385 – 87) for more on dominant impression.

Emphasis

Placing important ideas and words in specific places within sentences and longer units of writing so that they have the greatest impact. In general, what comes at the end has the most impact, while that placed at the beginning has nearly as much; what comes in the middle gets the least emphasis.

Endings

See [Beginnings and Endings](#).

Ethos

One of the key components of argumentation, according to Aristotle. Ethos concerns the authority, credibility, and, to a certain extent, morals of the speaker/writer. See also [Logos](#) and [Pathos](#).

Evaluation

An assessment of the effectiveness or merit of a piece of writing. In evaluating a piece of writing, one should ask questions such as the following: What is the writer's purpose? Is it a worthwhile purpose? Does the writer achieve the purpose? Is the writer's information sufficient and accurate? What are the strengths of the essay? What are its weaknesses? Depending on the type of writing and the purpose, more specific questions can also be asked. For example, with an argument essay one could ask: Does the writer follow the principles of logical thinking? Is the writer's evidence sufficient and convincing?

Evidence

The information on which a judgment or argument is based or by which proof or probability is established. Evidence usually takes the form of statistics, facts, names, examples or illustrations, and opinions of authorities.

Example

Something that illustrates a larger idea or represents something of which it is a part. An example is one of the basic means of developing or clarifying an idea. Furthermore, examples enable writers to show rather than simply tell readers what they mean. See [the introduction to Chapter 14](#) (pp. 343 - 45) for more on example.

Facts

Pieces of information presented as having objective reality — that is, having actual existence. For example, water boils at 212° F, Katharine Hepburn died in 2003, and the USSR no longer exists — these are all facts.

Fallacy

See [Logical Fallacy](#).

Figure of Speech

A brief, imaginative comparison that highlights the similarities between things that are basically dissimilar. Figures of speech make writing vivid, interesting, and memorable. The most common figures of speech are:

Simile: An explicit comparison introduced by *like* or *as*. “The fighter’ s hands were like stone.”

Metaphor: An implied comparison that makes one thing the equivalent of another. “All the world’ s a stage.”

Personification: A special kind of figure of speech in which human traits are assigned to ideas or objects. “The engine coughed and then stopped.”

See [the introduction to Chapter 13](#) (pp. 320 - 21) for a detailed discussion of figurative language.

Focus

The limitation a writer gives to his or her subject. The writer’ s task is to select a manageable topic given the constraints of time, space, and purpose. For example, within the general subject of sports, a writer could focus on government support of amateur

athletes or narrow the focus even further to government support of Olympic athletes.

General

See [*Specific/General*](#).

Idiom

A word or phrase having a special meaning that is used habitually. The meaning of an idiom is not always readily apparent to nonnative speakers of a language. For example, *catch a cold*, *hold a job*, *make up your mind*, and *give them a hand* are all idioms in English.

Illustration

The use of examples to explain, elucidate, or corroborate. Writers rely heavily on illustration to make their ideas both clear and concrete. See [*the introduction to Chapter 14*](#) (pp. 343 – 45) for a detailed discussion of illustration.

Induction

The process of reasoning to a conclusion about all members of a class through an examination of only a few members of the class. This form of reasoning moves from the particular to the general. See [*the introduction to Chapter 22*](#) (p. 524) for a discussion of inductive reasoning and its role in argumentation.

Introduction

See [*Beginnings and Endings*](#).

Irony

The use of words to suggest something different from their literal meaning. For example, when Jonathan Swift suggested in “A Modest Proposal” that Ireland’s problems could be solved if the people of Ireland fattened their babies and sold them to the English landlords for food, he meant that almost any other solution would be preferable. A writer can use irony to establish a special relationship with the reader and to add an extra dimension or twist

to the meaning. See [the introduction to Chapter 12](#) (pp. 288 – 93) for more on irony.

Jargon

The special vocabulary, or technical language, of a trade, profession, or group. Doctors, construction workers, lawyers, and teachers, for example, all have a specialized vocabulary that they use on the job. See also [Diction](#).

Logical Fallacy

An error in reasoning that renders an argument invalid. See [the introduction to Chapter 22](#) (pp. 527 – 28) for a discussion of common logical fallacies.

Logos

One of the key components of argumentation, according to Aristotle. Logos concerns the presentation of an argument through the use of logic and reason. It requires that the thesis or claim is worthwhile, logical, consistent, and supported by evidence. See also [Ethos](#) and [Pathos](#).

Metaphor

See [Figure of Speech](#).

Narration

The writing strategy of telling a story to relate what happened. Although narration is most often used in fiction, it is also important in expository writing, either by itself or in conjunction with other types of prose. See [the introduction to Chapter 15](#) (pp. 365 – 68) for a detailed discussion of narration.

Opinion

A belief or conclusion that may or may not be substantiated by positive knowledge or proof. (If not substantiated, an opinion is a prejudice.) Even when based on evidence and sound reasoning, an opinion is personal and can be changed; it is therefore less persuasive than facts and arguments.

Organization

The pattern or order the writer imposes on his or her material. Some often-used patterns of organization include time order, space order, and order of importance. See [the introduction to Chapter 5](#) (pp. 110 – 14) for a detailed discussion of organization.

Paradox

A seemingly contradictory statement that is nonetheless true. For example, “We little know what we have until we lose it” is a paradoxical statement.

Paragraph

A unit of a series of closely related sentences. These sentences adequately develop the central or controlling idea of the paragraph. This central idea, usually stated in a topic sentence, is necessarily related to the purpose of the whole composition. A well-written paragraph has several distinguishing characteristics: a clearly stated or implied topic sentence, adequate development, unity, coherence, and an appropriate organizational strategy. See [the introduction to Chapter 7](#) (pp. 160 – 62) for a detailed discussion of paragraphs.

Parallelism

The repetition of word order or grammatical form either within a single sentence or in several sentences that develop the same central idea. As a rhetorical device, parallelism can aid coherence and add emphasis. Franklin Roosevelt’s statement “I see one-third of a nation ill-housed, ill-clad, and ill-nourished” illustrates effective parallelism. See [the introduction to Chapter 9](#) (p. 206) for more on parallelism.

Paraphrase

A restatement of the information a writer is borrowing. A paraphrase closely parallels the presentation of ideas in the original, but it does not use the same words or sentence structure. See also [Direct Quotation](#), [Plagiarism](#), and [Summary](#).

Pathos

One of the key elements of argumentation, according to Aristotle. Pathos is concerned with using artful, strategic, and well-crafted language and support that appeal to the emotions of the speaker/writer's audience. See also [Ethos](#) and [Logos](#).

Personification

See [Figure of Speech](#).

Persuasion

An attempt to convince readers to agree with a point of view, to make a particular decision, or to pursue a particular course of action.

Plagiarism

The use of someone else's ideas in their original form or in a slightly altered form without proper documentation. Writers avoid plagiarism by (1) putting direct quotations within quotation marks and properly citing them, and (2) documenting any idea, explanation, or argument that is borrowed and presented in a quotation, summary, or paraphrase, making it clear where the borrowed material begins and ends. See [the introduction to Chapter 10](#) (pp. 235 – 39) for a more thorough discussion of plagiarism and [Chapter 23](#) (pp. 602 – 609) for help documenting sources.

Point of View

The grammatical “person” in an essay. For example, the first-person point of view uses the pronoun *I* and is commonly found in autobiography and the personal essay; the third-person point of view uses the pronouns *he*, *she*, or *it* and is commonly found in objective writing. See [the introduction to Chapter 15](#) (pp. 365 – 68) for a discussion of point of view in narration.

Process Analysis

A rhetorical strategy used to explain how something works or to give step-by-step directions for doing something. See [the](#)

[introduction to Chapter 17](#) (pp. 403 – 405) for a detailed discussion of process analysis.

Purpose

What the writer wants to accomplish in a particular piece of writing. Purposeful writing seeks to *tell* (narration), to *describe* (description), to *explain* (process analysis, definition, division and classification, comparison and contrast, and cause and effect), or to *convince* (argument).

Rhetorical Modes

Spoken or written strategies for presenting ideas or information, the most common of which are argument, cause and effect, comparison and contrast, definition, description, division and classification, illustration, narration, and process analysis.

Rhetorical Question

A question asked for dramatic effect or to make a point but that does not require an answer from the reader. “When will nuclear proliferation end?” is such a question. Writers use rhetorical questions to introduce topics they plan to discuss or to emphasize important points. See [the introduction to Chapter 6](#) (p. 138) for another example.

Sentence

A grammatical unit that expresses a complete thought. It consists of at least a subject (a noun) and a predicate (a verb). See [the introduction to Chapter 9](#) (pp. 201 – 06) for a detailed discussion of effective sentences.

Signal Phrase

A phrase alerting the reader that borrowed information follows. A signal phrase usually consists of an author’s name and a verb (for example, “Coughlan argues” or “Yadav disagrees”) and helps integrate direct quotations, paraphrases, and summaries into the flow of a paper. A signal phrase tells the reader who is speaking

and indicates exactly where your ideas end and your source's begin.

Simile

See [*Figure of Speech*](#).

Slang

The unconventional, informal language of particular subgroups in our culture. Slang terms, such as *bummed*, *hot*, and *cool*, are acceptable in formal writing only if used selectively for specific purposes.

Specific/General

General words name groups or classes of objects, qualities, or actions. Specific words, on the other hand, name individual objects, qualities, or actions within a class or group. To some extent the terms *general* and *specific* are relative. For example, *clothing* is a class of things. *Shirt*, however, is more specific than *clothing* but more general than *T-shirt*. See also [*Diction*](#).

Strategy

A means by which a writer achieves his or her purpose. Strategy includes the many rhetorical decisions the writer makes about organization, paragraph structure, sentence structure, and diction. In terms of the whole essay, strategy refers to the principal rhetorical mode a writer uses. If, for example, a writer wishes to explain how to make chocolate chip cookies, the most effective strategy would be process analysis. If it is the writer's purpose to analyze why sales of American cars have declined in recent years, the most effective strategy would be cause-and-effect analysis.

Subordination

The use of grammatical constructions to make one part of a sentence dependent on, rather than equal to, another. For example, the italicized clause in the following sentence is subordinate: "They all cheered *when I finished the race*." See [*the introduction to*](#)

[Chapter 9](#) (p. 202) for more on subordination. See also [Coordination](#).

Summary

A condensed form of the essential idea of a passage, article, or entire chapter. A summary is always shorter than the original. See also [Paraphrase](#), [Plagiarism](#), and [Direct Quotation](#).

Supporting Evidence

See [Evidence](#).

Syllogism

An argument that uses deductive reasoning and consists of a major premise, a minor premise, and a conclusion:

All trees that lose leaves are deciduous. (*Major premise*)

Maple trees lose their leaves. (*Minor premise*)

Therefore, maple trees are deciduous. (*Conclusion*)

See [the introduction to Chapter 22](#) (p. 524) for more on syllogisms. See also [Deduction](#).

Symbol

A person, place, or thing that represents something beyond itself. For example, the bald eagle is a symbol of the United States, and the maple leaf is a symbol of Canada.

Syntax

The way in which words are arranged to form phrases, clauses, and sentences, as well as the grammatical relationship among the words themselves.

Synthesis

A written discussion that weaves together the ideas of one or more sources with your own. There are two types of synthesis: *informational/explanatory synthesis* and *persuasive/argument*

synthesis. See [the introduction to Chapter 10](#) (pp. 232 – 35) for more on synthesis.

Technical Language

See [Jargon](#).

Thesis

The main idea of an essay, also known as the controlling idea. The thesis may sometimes be implied rather than stated directly. See [the introduction to Chapter 3](#) (pp. 69 – 72) for more on the thesis statement.

Title

A word or phrase given to a text to identify the essay's subject, to state the essay's main idea, or to attract the reader's attention. A title may be explicit or suggestive. A subtitle, when used, explains or restricts the meaning of the main title.

Tone

The manner or “voice” in which a writer relates to an audience. Tone may be friendly, serious, distant, angry, humorous, cheerful, bitter, cynical, enthusiastic, morbid, resentful, warm, playful, and so forth. A particular tone results from a writer's diction, sentence structure, purpose, and attitude toward the subject. See [the introduction to Chapter 12](#) (pp. 291 – 93) for several examples of different tones.

Topic Sentence

States the central idea of a paragraph and thus limits the content of the paragraph. Although the topic sentence normally appears at the beginning of the paragraph, it may appear at any other point, particularly if the writer is trying to create a special effect. Not all paragraphs contain topic sentences. See also [Paragraph](#).

Transition

A word or phrase that links sentences, paragraphs, and larger units of a composition to achieve coherence. Transitions include

parallelism, pronoun references, conjunctions, and the repetition of key ideas, as well as many conventional transitional expressions: *moreover*, *on the other hand*, *in addition*, *in contrast*, *therefore*, and so on. See [the introduction to Chapter 8](#) (pp. 179 – 82) for a detailed discussion of transitions. See also [Coherence](#).

Unity

The quality of oneness in an essay that results when all the words, sentences, and paragraphs contribute to the thesis. The elements of a unified essay harmoniously support a single idea or purpose — they do not distract the reader. See [the introduction to Chapter 4](#) (pp. 89 – 92) for a detailed discussion of unity.

Verb

Verbs can be classified as either strong verbs (*scream*, *pierce*, *gush*, *ravage*, and *amble*) or weak verbs (*be*, *has*, *get*, and *do*). Good writers prefer to use strong verbs to make their writing more specific, more descriptive, and more action-filled.

Voice (style)

The individual manner in which a writer expresses his or her ideas. Voice is created by the author's particular choice of words, construction of sentences, and arrangement of ideas. See [the introduction to Chapter 11](#) (pp. 265 – 70) for a detailed discussion of voice.

Voice (grammar)

Verbs can be classified as being in either the active or the passive voice. In the *active voice*, the doer of the action is the grammatical subject. In the *passive voice*, the receiver of the action is the subject:

Active: Glenda questioned all of the children.

Passive: All the children were questioned by Glenda.

Writing Process

The sequence of activities that most writers usually follow when composing a written work. The process typically consists of four stages:

Prewriting: The stage in the writing process in which you select your subject and topic, gather ideas and information, and determine the thesis and organizational pattern or patterns of a written work.

Drafting: The process of creating the first version of your writing in which you lay out your ideas and information and, through subsequent revision, prepare more focused and polished versions, referred to as second and third drafts, and more if necessary.

Revising: The stage in the writing process in which you reconsider and possibly change the large elements of your writing, such as thesis, purpose, content, organization, and paragraph structure.

Editing: The stage in the writing process in which you reconsider and possibly change the small elements of your writing, such as grammar, punctuation, mechanics, and spelling.

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